Changing Tides

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Changing Tides

by SpotTheStriker

Summary

When the violence against merchant and civilian ships escalates, Phainon is tasked with hunting down the pirates responsible but there's more danger on the seas than roaming brigands and it may take a pirate to save the world. They just have to learn how to get along first.

Or, Phainon gets pulled out of the water by Captain Mydei and they decide to investigate the Black Tide together.

Notes

Please forgive any mischaracterization. I try really hard to adhere to canon but there's always gonna be some quirky things in an AU.
I will update tags as I go.

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1: Phainon

When Trianne popped up next to Phainon in the shipyard it very nearly caused an accident. To his credit, the reflex to swing wildly at the jump scare only made it about halfway to target before he managed to steady the heavy beam balanced on his shoulder. Smashing one of the messengers of Janus with a garboard plank wasn't the kind of thing that could be fixed with a heartfelt apology and baked goods. But it might be enough for the dock worker that had been knocked into the shallow water next to the drydock.

Phainon winced when he saw the poor guy flailing about with a look of bewilderment.

"Hey, you alright?" he called out, already setting down the beam before it could do anymore damage.

The man nodded but Phainon dropped down anyway to take his hand and help him to his feet. Salt water poured into his boots, soaking his pants and creeping up to where his chlamys was tied around his waist. It was too hot a day to wear anything but his bracers from the waist up.

He firmly held the man's arm until he got his footing in the shallow water, offering a reassuring (and apologetic) smile.

"It's really nothing," the dock worker insisted, and Phainon let go, making sure the man was able to climb to safety before he finally gave Trianne his attention.

"You really shouldn't be surprising people like that, Trianne." His voice was light, more playful than scolding.

"Maybe we did come up to too fast. We've been practicing our flying to be even faster!" she said with a happy bounce and her arms outstretched like wings from the dock above Phainon.

He waded up the gentle slope along the underside of the ship's skeleton and she followed with light steps along the walkway beside him. It was starting to take shape, but it would be a long time before this masterpiece was seaworthy.

"Did you want to show me? Maybe ask for a race?"

"You're fast, Snowy, but we are a lot faster! It wouldn't be much of a race."

A quick stomp on dry land only cleared away a little bit of the sea and Phainon took the time to lean his shoulder against the wall beside him so he could take each boot off in turn to dump the water back where it belonged.

"So, what is the hurry, Trianne?"

"Oh!" She bunny hopped in place and put both her hands on her hips. "We have a very important message!"

Phainon wringed salt water from his top and then shifted it back over his shoulder, pinning it in place with the fibula haphazardly. It didn't matter much to him if things looked perfect as long as it was functional.

"Agy wants to see you today."

It was like a shock through his system, surging along his spine and making him stand up straight with a newfound sense of directive. It only took one hand and a light leap to vault back up onto the walkway and then Phainon was hurrying to say goodbye to the shipyard's master. Even if he was working on a volunteer basis, it was rude to leave without saying anything at all.

Okhema was a shining beacon on the hill. One of the biggest and most beautiful port cities in Amphoreus. It was built under the watchful gaze of Kephale and the Dawn Device that kept the Black Tide as a distant and forgettable threat. Beautiful buildings climbed up the hills and mountains and stretched along the bay around bustling docks and shipyards. Dozens of big ships anchored on the water, waiting for the tide to go out to sea.

Phainon treasured the climb from the shore to the Marmoreal Palace. Where most would take the passages to travel swiftly, the steep road was an opportunity to work his calves, build more endurance, and challenge himself to sprint at the steepest stretches. He was only partly serious about racing, but Trianne zoomed alongside him anyway, cheering him on as she flew by until it turned less into a competition and more into coaching, pushing him along faster and faster. He had to take a second at the top of the hill to put his hands on his knees and catch his breath.

Eager or not, Phainon didn't dare meet with Aglaea in soggy clothes. He had stopped dripping sea water along the way but there was still a shipyard smell that clung to the fabric, the wonderful scent of hard work, good lumber, and tar. He didn't think she'd mind that part as much as the lingering fishy salty smell from the extra dip in the ocean.

He had a room here at the palace for his things. It wasn't extravagant but Phainon was cared for like the other Chrysos Heirs. Aglaea wasn't a Queen or the Ruler of Okhema, but she carried a weight as the leader of the Heirs and the Flame Chase journey as well as Okhema's Admiral, overseeing the city's protection from seafaring threats. Under her guidance a fair number of coreflames had been recovered over the centuries and the people respected her and her dutiful protection of the city and their surrounding territories. As the keeper of Mnestia's coreflame, her golden threads carried a beautiful and delicate power that kept the peace.

It was Aglaea that had found Phainon in the barracks, devoid of life, little more than a blade to be directed. She gave him new purpose, a better reason to fight, and he owed her everything for that alone.

"Tell Aglaea I'll be there soon," he requested of Trianne, who gave him a happy salute.

"You got it!" Her red hair flashed in the corner of his eye as she zipped away.

He pushed the door to his room open without ceremony, stripping as he went, leaving articles of clothing wherever they fell. One of his boots got kicked into his bookshelf, his chlamys

ended up on the kline. He ripped open drawers looking for something clean and, more importantly, appropriate. Phainon had learned the hard way that Aglaea felt very strongly about colors and appearance. The dressmaker knew her trade and took offense when he didn't at least try to understand the basics of color theory.

He pulled on pants and his high-collared v-neck tee, black, gold, and matching. The long white and gold coat went on over the top. Then his black boots, his bracers, the pauldron, his blue half cape over the shoulder… Phainon double checked himself in a mirror as he adjusted the straps over his chest. Heaven forbid the motifs and patterns didn't match. Most of his clothing was sun themed, but there were some stragglers in there somewhere with different patterns.

It was his usual look, so the quick check was enough to settle any brief anxiety. Confidence restored, he hurried to Aglaea's office.

"Aglaea!" Phainon called cheerfully from the doorway. He gave the frame a gentle tap with his knuckles for good measure. "You wanted to see me? Do you need some help?"

She was standing near the balcony, not far enough out to be seen by the public, but enough to bask in Kephale's eternal daylight. She sparkled in the light where it caught on shiny silk fabric, cream under gold, dancing with the thread and the natural curls that bounced under her chin. The laurels in her short hair perched as delicately as her manicured nails and the fine straps of her heels. She always dressed like one of her models, perfection among mortals, as guarded and picturesque as a marble masterpiece, and equally as unmoving.

"Phainon," she greeted without turning, rolling his name on her tongue with a natural and alluring grace.

He took the greeting as permission to approach, stepping deeper into her office workshop. Despite her best efforts, her workspace was naturally cluttered. It was an organized cluttered with hand written labels in cursive pinned to shelves, boxes, and collections of expensive thread and fabric. Her garmentmakers drifted in a neat line along the wall opposite her massive desk, piled high with papyrus scrolls, maps, and clay tablets pounded thin.

"Did something happen?" he asked, careful to keep the worry from his voice, even if he harbored it in his heart.

For as light as she seemed, there was a weight to her shoulders. When she turned and walked back to her desk it was with measured footsteps, as though she'd be crushed by that weight with a single misstep.

"Pirates," she said simply as though that explained everything and it kind of did. The distant Black Tide was less of a threat than piracy. Displaced people, separated from their homes and driven to desperation frequently turned to the seas and her bounty. Okhema relied less on foreign trade these days but no small amount of their food and supplies to fuel the city's wealth and comfort came in the bellies of big ships. "They have plagued Okhema as long as there has been a city, but my fleet needs a more skilled warrior at the helm."

His smile faded with the seriousness of the situation.

“I would not ask anything of you had I any other way,” she said softly, and he jumped at the chance to correct her.

“You don’t need to,” he promised with a hand over his heart, “tell me what you need me to do, and I’ll see it through.”

She matched his gesture and looked at him with clouded eyes. “I’m giving you a ship.”

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Phainon was good at most things but not all of it was natural talent. In his heart he was still the son of a farmer, most comfortable with two feet on solid ground or at most the loose of good, tilled soil. The sway of a ship took a lot of getting used to. He knew how they worked; he helped build them in his spare time and every soldier learned how to sail. He knew which ropes loosed the sails, when it was best to anchor, how to follow the tides, and anything he didn’t know he trusted to his crew.

And for now, that was enough.

Aglaea had given him a single task when his new crew disembarked: to hunt the most notorious of pirates. The Goldweaver was certain, whether by intuition or by gathered intelligence Phainon wasn’t sure, that most of their lost ships were the work of a single crew. A single very strong crew that left burning husks of ships in their wake and few if any survivors, so scarred by their encounters that they were rendered mute or unsound of mind. A crew that sailed under red and gold with blood painted on their hull. Rather than feed the beast, Aglaea wanted to send her best, and Phainon was unrivaled in Okhema.

It was a lot of pressure, but Phainon was eager to please and eager to prove himself, starting with his new command. He learned the name of every crewmate on day one, establishing a rapport with his new first mate.

Marcus was attentive and friendly, a skilled and seasoned sailor and warrior. Bolaris already had ideas brewing for how to upgrade the ship while he managed their supplies. Zeno had plotted several routes using the neighboring isles as waymarks. To name a few.

All of Phainon’s crew were the best of the best and he had taken a liking to the Speeding Sol from the moment he stepped onto her deck and very nearly got clotheslined by the rising main sail. Despite the risks involved with their mission, speed was just as important as firepower, so Phainon chose the smaller vessel. She still had a solid bronze battering ram on her bow and courage in her sails, but the smaller and more elite crew would be easier to care for and they could spend longer stretches at sea.

Phainon took his turn at the oars with the men on breezy days and helped them hold the sails on the windy ones. They shared their meals together and sparred on deck. He took watches in shifts, and he personally took responsibility for every failing, even when he was reassured that something was easily fixed and not worth fretting over.

It had taken them a week of sailing, pressing farther away from Okhema to find any sign of something sinister in the waters.

The wreckage of a merchant ship had drifted by on the currents and a close inspection of the waterlogged wood showed strain and tearing.

“What do you think?” Phainon asked Marcus.

The man was feeling the wood, pressing into it with his fingers. “It’s possible they ran aground and a reef tore the hull…”

“There aren’t any shoals or reefs near here,” Zeno insisted.

Phainon scratched his chin with the back of his pointer finger, an absentminded gesture as he contemplated. “We found enough of the ship but none of the cargo.”

“Unless they were shipping heavy ores, it’s unreasonable to assume we wouldn’t find ANY cargo,” Marcus agreed.

“Not unless it was liberated from the sea. The wreck can’t be more than a day old, let’s stay around these waters for a time and shout if you see canvas on the horizon.”

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The empty seas had taunted them for another few days, until a tired crewman had spotted a distant fire, beyond the reach of the dawn device. They took to their oars and chased the light to the horizon, crossing the threshold into the dark just before the entry hour but by the time they caught up…

The wreckage was slowly sinking, bright in the dark where it still burned above the water. There was blood everywhere, but no bodies, no cargo.

Phainon carded a hand through his hair, the other was on the railing. His crew lined up alongside him to lean over the edge of the Sol for a better look at the mess on the surface of the sea. Very slowly he let his hand fall over his face, stressed, before clenching a tight fist to drop onto the rail with a frustrated growl.

The men nearest him turned in surprise but he was already reining in the outburst. “Get the hooks and small boats. Let’s see if they left anyone,” he ordered softly. And then he turned on his heel and stalked to the bow to climb into the small boat himself.

He remembered the wreck in pieces. Each snapshot tugging at memories lurking under a thin but carefully crafted surface. The fire was too familiar; wood burned the same color as wheat. Streaks of blood in the water and on the sails, crimson in the firelight still glowed the same as when it was spattered across stone. The familiar smell of burning flesh clung to the air.

Every image accompanied by another from his youth that Phainon saw regularly in his nightmares. Death, destruction, and fire haunted him, providing kindling, motivation, and a deep desire under his duty for revenge. That flame flickered again inside him, but it was easily set aside for the more immediate concern and desperate hope for survivors.

Ash dusted their shoulders as they rowed quietly through the mess, using long fishing hooks to move debris, searching for life or even bodies that could be recovered and given a proper

burial. Phainon used one such hook to drag a length of sail closer until he could grab it with his hands and pull the scraps in, but there was nothing but tears.

“Captain,” Zeno said in a near whisper just over the crackle of the flames. He didn’t need to say anything more.

Phainon tsked and steeled his jaw, grinding his teeth with his lip curled back ever so slightly as righteous fury crawled inside him until he trembled with the tension. “We need to find them before they do this again.”

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It had been a very long time since Phainon had been outside of the reach of the Dawn Device but there wasn’t any time to appreciate the natural passage of time. Aquila had been vanquished several centuries past and had resumed the opening of their eyes. Day and night cycles resumed outside of Okhema but there was little time to appreciate it.

Phainon remained focused on the task at hand. Zeno was using stars and maps to chart their progress and there was undeniable energy in the crew. Even if there was no way to prove it, they were certain that they were catching up. There were little signs from birds to discarded ship waste, to yet more destruction. And through it all, Phainon remained driven but cheerful, checking on each of his men in turn at every junction in a gesture of responsible love.

“You should take some time for yourself,” Marcus told him in a whisper. He settled on the crate beside Phainon and offered him a waterskin.

“I do, I promise,” he whispered back with a muted chuckle. The waterskin nearly slipped from his hands when he reached for it. The ocean spray made it slick. Despite the choppy waters, most of the crew was sound asleep under the blanket of stars.

“I can take this watch. You should sleep.”

Phainon shook his head and his bangs swayed and bounced. “I couldn’t if I tried.”

“Still haven’t quite found your sea legs, Captain?”

“I’m sure they’re just around the corner,” he laughed, miming a curve with his hands as he did so. He took a long drink, tilting his head back and leaving it back even as the waterskin settled in his lap.

“I did miss the stars,” he admitted, and Marcus took a second to follow his gaze.

“Are you very familiar with them, Captain?”

“Marcus, you can stop with the Captain now.”

“…of course, Lord Phainon.”

Maybe it was a lost cause. Baby steps.

“Not very familiar,” he said instead, “but when I was a kid, my friend and I would watch the thief star just after curtain-fall hour and count the rest as they appeared in the sky.” Phainon had noted the thief star earlier that night. It had been a long time since he had seen it glow red. Perhaps it saved that color for the lands beyond Kephale. “And what of you, *Lord* Marcus.”

“I was born and raised in Okhema. This is my first time seeing the night sky.”

“And what think you of it?”

“It seems cold.”

Phainon mulled that over for a second, watching the sky and waiting for it to agree but then the wind carried the softest sound, and he was very suddenly on his feet striding towards the rail, staring straight ahead into the dark and waiting with a hand on one of the lines for balance.

“Lord-“

“Shh.” Phainon held out a hand towards Marcus without looking at him until he was silent and then he let the arm fall at glacial speed. As though the creak of his clothing would be too loud.

For a moment there was only the slap of choppy waves against the side of the Sol, the creak of the masts, the soft snores of his crew… and then the breeze tickled his ears and nose again with the faint sound of steel on steel, battle cries, and the smell of burning.

He turned his head like whip in the direction of the wind, squinting in the dark until the waves lifted them high enough to see the glow on the horizon.

“Found you,” he muttered to himself and then louder, “Marcus! Wake up the crew, to oars and arms!”

Marcus jumped and hurried to obey as Phainon hurried to the tiller. It was held in place with a rope when they were safe to drift. He kicked the heavy rope free and pushed his whole body against the beam. The ship groaned but began to turn as the crew started to rouse full of confused shouts and hurried scrambling.

The first mate was shouting orders; the oars were biting into the water. There was a rush of wind that grabbed at Phainon’s cape as the sail raised in a hurry and scooped the ocean breeze to lurch them forwards towards destiny.

The sounds got louder, the fire brighter and bigger as they raced and Phainon started praying, deep in his heart, that they would get there in time. It didn’t take them long to catch up enough to see the second ship, her red sails unfurled, ready to flee. She was a massive thing crowned in gold with a massive lion’s head carved into her bow. He could see ropes and men pulling supplies from the burning ship as they approached. There were shouts and the pirates turned to flee.

“To port!” Marcus shouted, “we must pursue!”

“No!” Phainon shouted over him and there was a pause in the rowers, as they waited. As much as Phainon wanted to give chase… “The burning ship, there’s still time to check for survivors.”

The sails were on fire, but the hull didn’t seem to have been broken. It floated aimlessly. “Ram the side at an angle,” he ordered.

Phainon gave the tiller to Zeno and was already hurrying to the bow in a zig zag, stepping around crewmates and grabbing onto the lines where he could until he was standing on the railing, waiting as the ship approached.

Too fast!

The Sol slammed into the burning merchant ship. Glancing enough to not tear the hull but hard enough for the bronze to grab onto her. Phainon leaped at the last second and for a long heartbeat he was airborne above the water.

He hit the deck hard. His knees buckled and the warrior rolled with the momentum until his side slammed into the base of the mast. Burning fabric was raining from above, filling his lungs with smoke and ash. There was no one on deck, not a single sign of life. A permeating sense of dread filled his chest as Phainon lurched to his feet with the roll of the ship. He could hear shouting from the Sol but couldn’t make out the words. As he looked back the main sail came undone and slammed onto the deck, cutting him off in a shower of burning splinters.

The fire licked at his boots and clothes as Phainon stumbled away with an arm held over his face to protect his eyes from the flickering embers.

“Lord Phainon!” Marcus shouted.

“I’m fine! Don’t let the fire spread to the Sol! I’m going to go look below!”

Phainon didn’t wait for a response before he was running and stumbling towards the stern, looking for stairs in the dark. It only took a moment. There was a lantern hanging beside the doorway, trying its best to be bright in the face of the raging fire beside it. He ripped the thing off the wall and half ran; half fell down the stairs into the belly of the ship.

“Is there anyone here!” he shouted, running the length of the hold, scanning the shadows for movement. All of the hammocks were empty, piles of intermittent dust kicked up as he ran through them and Phainon had to take a second to cough and clear his lungs before he could shout again. “Anyone!”

The ship creaked ominously. Water sloshed from below and when he looked down, Phainon saw water start to pool around his feet, leeching between the floorboards from the floor below, slowly filling the belly of the dying ship. The roar of the fire above was so loud, he worried that he wouldn’t be able to hear the survivors, but there weren’t even bodies.

Had they already been thrown overboard? Were they kidnapped? Phainon snarled and punched one of the columns. He let the pirates go and any survivors could be onboard, kept as cargo, prisoners!

He turned to run back to the stairs and then the whole world tilted at an impossible angle and Phainon was thrown sideways into a hammock. It softened the initial blow and then dumped him into empty space where time stilled for a breath and then he hit the side of the ship and flopped onto a puddle. The ripping of the hull was loud enough to make the fire seem distant as a second ship slammed into the side of the sinking vessel.

For a mercy, the impact settled, and the ship didn't capsize. It slammed back down, upright, and Phainon was jostled, the water that had pooled with the tilt raced back across the floor, dragging him along until he managed to grab another hammock and drag himself back to standing with a shake of his head. Salt and smoke stung his eyes and stiffened his joints. The ceiling above groaned and he could see the glow of fire above the flimsy flicker of his noble lantern.

But above it all, Phainon could hear the distant and unmistakable sounds of battle. His men were screaming, battle horns cried, steel met steel amid the snarls of war beasts; metallic and awful screeches that tore through Phainon's soul with a shiver, a familiar and horrible sound he couldn't quite place. The water beneath him bubbled, ankle deep now, the timer was ticking like sand in an hourglass and above him, his people, his friends were dying at the hands of murderers.

With an angry shout, Phainon scrambled towards the stairs, the lantern left behind to roll into the inky water where its meager flame was swallowed without mercy.

He was nearly there when the ceiling gave way and the main deck collapsed above him. Phainon recoiled from the burning mast and the shower of dust and embers. The burning sail billowed around movement in the smoke and when the ocean wind finally pushed that curtain aside, Phainon's eyes met that of another warrior.

He was fury and battle incarnate, a lion of a man, all muscle and power, with a thick mane of blonde hair that hung past his shoulders. The fire glinted off his golden gauntlets, embers and burning flesh clinging to the sharpness of his claws. Blood glinted where it splashed across his armored legs and disappeared in the crimson and black of his robes and the tattoos that danced on his exposed chest.

Blue flashed as Phainon drew his sword, fury rising in his chest when the pirate stood and flicked blackened flesh from his fingers. He snarled and surged forward but Phainon's first step was cut short as the ship lurched again with a tearing scream.

He hit the water and all sound stopped entirely.

It couldn't have been more than a minute that Phainon had been under the water. At least that's what he told himself. He distantly remembered feeling a rough hand on his collar, sharp tugs at his feet, an orange glow in the water, but then he was heaving and sputtering with his cheek pressed against waterlogged lumber.

He felt so heavy blinking away the salt as he tried to push himself up on the makeshift raft. Phainon shook his head rapidly to cast away some of the sea, to keep it from dripping further into his eyes as he searched for something familiar.

The Sol was on fire, sinking into the depths of the ocean just as the creeping light of dawn started to color the sky behind her. Phainon felt his heart go with it and as he scanned for more life, searched for any struggling in the water, any sign of his crew, that feeling sank deeper and deeper.

“No!” he shouted to no one and then the sea shifted behind him.

Phainon clung to the wood with white knuckles, careful to keep his balance, to not submit to the ocean, as he glared over his shoulder. The massive hull of the pirate ship crept up alongside him and someone dove into the water next to him. He instinctively kicked at the person, but a strong arm grabbed his leg and pulled him into the water, embracing him from behind and looping a rope around his chest. Phainon felt the squeeze as it tightened under his arms and for a moment that was all he could feel. The arm had let him go and he was drifting deep, watching his ship join the other in a slow-motion fall into the black.

Failure crept up his bones.

Not again.

The rope tugged. Water ripped by with the rest of the weight on his shoulders.

And then he was breathing again, up and up until he felt the smooth wood of a well-crafted deck against his back while that glorious light of dawn glittered on the red and gold sails above.

Chapter 2: Chryseus Leo

Chapter Summary

Phainon and Mydei meet

Chapter Notes

I've literally already ruined the pacing of my outline. This will be so much longer than 19 chapters I can tell. Why am I like this?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei's bare feet hit the deck with a soggy splash less than a minute before the body they pulled out of the water landed behind him with a squelching thud. He unwrapped the heavy rope from around his arm and waist and tossed it to the side, giving his men a grateful nod in the process. The water weight was pulling his pants low on his hips, but he at least had the common sense to take everything else off before he dove *back* into the water.

He walked away from where the others were starting to crowd, up the steps to the upper deck where his armor and the rest of his clothes were laid across a crate, still damp from when the capsizing ship had thrown him into the sea with the other guy. With the sun rising it wouldn't be too long he hoped with a sigh.

"Prince," an old man said to get his attention.

Mydei ran a hand through his bangs to brush them away from his eyes, the seawater dripping down his arms and chest as he squeezed the silken strands and turned to face his teacher. Krateros was offering him dry boots. Simple, but his size, and he gratefully took them with both hands to set them on the crate while he wrung the worst of the ocean from his pants.

"Is he alive?" Krateros asked, peering over the railing at the crowd.

"Alive enough to nearly kick me."

"Give him space!" Perdikkas shouted, no more than a voice in the pit of curious people. The men weren't listening.

From the upper deck it was easy enough to see them crowd the puddle near the railing, curiosity getting the better of them. They rarely took survivors onboard. There were rarely any survivors *to* bring aboard.

“I said give him space!” he heard Perdikkas shout once more and then there was a flash of blue light, and everyone was scattering with shouts and hurried gasps.

Mydei’s eyes narrowed as he pulled on the boots, watching the pack scramble to lower their spears and point their swords at the most beautiful and simultaneously pathetic looking person he had ever seen.

“Alive enough to think he can fight.”

“If he is a danger,” Krateros was saying, “we should kill him and give him to the ocean. It won’t do to have a rabid dog on board.”

Soaked to the bone and holding a great sword taller than he was, the warrior swung in wide, clumsy arcs, a demand for space more than a declaration of war. He stumbled to the railing, sword held out in response to the spears pointed his way while he coughed and heaved water from his lungs. Snow-white hair clung to his forehead and neck, plastered on his head with the water weight aside from two stubborn bits on the very top his head that stood upright. It dripped into his wild eyes that darted back and forth over his men who had expertly cornered him against the rail, an unmoving cage.

He was acting like a startled, injured animal. In a way, he was. He was displaced from his ship, removed from his people, and had just suffered through a traumatic encounter. Even bogged down by heavy clothes, the man had a solid stance and was potentially very dangerous.

“Hey, it’s okay!” Perdikkas was saying, one hand outstretched, the other resting on the hilt of his sword as he tried to approach.

Mydei started running the moment the second boot was on.

The warrior’s attention had latched onto Perdikkas and in a fraction of second he had turned from confused to enraged, lashing out with his sword in an expert, if somewhat slow strike.

In the middle of its horizontal arc, Mydei landed on the flat of the blade with both boots. He had run along the rail and leaped, forcing the tip of the weapon into the deck and the warrior to stumble as the unexpected weight ripped him forward. The sword clattered uselessly across the polished wood and half a dozen men rushed to contain him.

Mydei rolled as he fell, and his men hurried to catch him and help him to his feet. Perdikkas steadied him with a firm grip on his arm, and they waited for the whole five seconds that it took for his soldiers to pile the guy and wrestle him to his knees, both arms pulled out to the sides. Still, he struggled and Mydei had to admire his strength. It was taking four men to hold him down.

“Perdikkas!” Leonnius shoved through the masses to their sides. “Are you alright?”

“Yeah, Mydei stopped him.”

“How did you-?” he started to say but stopped when Mydei tilted his chin.

“Cornered hounds bite,” the Prince said and then he was walking towards the man.

“You have a funny way of thanking the people who saved your life,” he scolded as he stalked forward, snatching a spear from one of his men as he went. The brightest blue eyes glared at him, lip curled back.

“Where are the others?” he spat, voice rough, no doubt the salt from the sea had ravaged his throat.

Mydei tilted his head. “What others?”

“Your other captives, pirate!”

What was he talking about? Mydei drummed his fingers on the spear and firmly told him. “We have no captives.”

The struggle slowly came to a stop, and the warrior visibly slumped. Mydei could see his emotions cycle in his expressions: surprise, skepticism, and finally grief when he studied Mydei’s face and seemed to find the truth there. He also saw the exact moment that the man steeled himself, tucking away those emotions and hiding them behind a mask of defiance with gritted teeth and a sharp gaze.

“You killed them…” the survivor growled.

“Yes, we did. We had to.”

He turned his face to the side, glaring at Mydei’s men as he started to pull again, fighting to get free.

Up close and straining it was easier to appreciate him. In the hold of the broken ship, it had been hard to really *see* the man, but he had a pleasing outline and a solid build. His clothes were very fine but there were calluses on his hands from working ropes and swinging swords.

“Look at me, Okheman,” Mydei instructed but the man refused.

The Prince tapped the butt of the spear against the deck with a commanding thud, spun it in a circle and then slid his hand up the shaft to steady the point under the man’s chin, forcing that delicate face and sharp jawline to tilt back until their eyes met again.

There was hatred there, yes, but there was also grief, and Mydei got the feeling this pathetic, wet dog had been misinformed.

“What’s your name?” he asked.

White-hair refused to respond, his lips pressed into a tight, thin line. Mydei pressed with the spear, forcing his head to the side as his eyes flicked down.

“Did anyone check his collar for tags?” Mydei called out to the crew with slightest curl of a smile.

“I am no one’s dog!” the man snapped and Mydei pulled the spear back to crouch low in front of him instead, their noses nearly touched. He could see the way the man’s breath hitched, held tight while those sapphire eyes briefly dropped to study Mydei’s still bare chest and arms. They roamed around the gold ring around his bicep, the tightness of his still wet pants against his thighs and counted his tattoos before darting back to meet Mydei’s own judging gaze.

“Are you not?” Mydei asked as he reached for the man’s collar.

He recoiled, pressing back as far as his captors would allow, and Mydei paused until he stilled again. Bare fingertips traced along the leather collar on the man’s neck, over the sun marking beneath it, deceptively gentle, feeling along his fluttering, too fast pulse, until he found what he was looking for. The thread was barely thicker than hair when Mydei pulled it from the collar and held it between them so it could shimmer in the light of the spreading dawn like spun gold.

He must not have known. There was surprise in that blue-eyed stare when he saw it and utter bewilderment when Mydei snapped it in two, the length of it dissolving into dust.

Mydei reached out again to press his fingers into a cut across the man’s cheekbone. It was a scrape, undoubtedly caused by the chaos on the merchant ship and cleaned by the sea. No doubt it would sting later when the adrenaline faded, and this man had a chance to set aside his rage and take stock of his situation. He pressed hard enough to make it bleed again until the gold streaked across his fingertips.

“This is why you survived, Okheman,” Mydei told him. He showed the man the golden blood on the pads of his fingers. “Not because *we* chose to spare you, but because the Black Tide *couldn’t* take you.”

Mydei watched the recognition settle in his face and filed away every minute reaction.

“The Black Tide?” he repeated aloud, as though he didn’t quite hear him the first time and Mydei saw the fight drain from his shoulders with a shaky, long-held breath.

He looked up at the men holding him and gave them a reassuring nod. They let go and the man fell forward onto Mydei’s arm. He held him steadily for a second by the chest and then slowly pushed him back to sit on his own heels when it was clear he wouldn’t fall over without help.

They sat there for a moment, the Okheman processing what he had heard with his head down and his arms at his side and then he started to laugh. It was a rolling, wheezing sound, the hint of something melodic buried under a layer of weariness.

“Do you really expect me to believe the word of a murderer?” he asked when he finally calmed.

“Were you not there?”

The Ohkeman's brow furrowed, and his frown deepened, straining to recall. Mydei stood up straight and waited, looking down at the man who seemed to still be struggling with his memory.

One breath.

Two.

"Hephastion," the Prince said softly, and it took all of two seconds for the First Mate to take charge.

"Nothing left to see, let's get underway!" he ordered, and the men dispersed, returning to their duties.

"Perdikkas is going to get you dry clothes," Mydei told their guest firmly, "If you attack him again, I will snap your neck and feed you to the sea, Nameless Hero."

"Phainon," he mumbled and for a second Mydei almost didn't hear him, "my name is Phainon of Aedes Elysiae."

"Welcome aboard the Chryseus Leo, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae."

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"The Deliverer of Okhema?" Hephastion asked.

Ptolemy nodded. He had a scroll open on his lap. Tomes were hard to keep at sea, and the older ones were starting to fray along the edges, but it didn't stop their resident record keeper from doing his very best to maintain a collection worthy of the Crown Prince of Kremnos and his own curiosities. The book worm had managed to assemble a wide variety between the pieces he had taken from Castrum Kremnos, the books smuggled from the library at Garbaniphoro, and the mass of writings plucked from ships they had conquered at sea.

The scroll on his lap was one such piece, liberated from the private collection of a Captain of the Goldweaver's Navy. It seemed the hero that Mydei had plucked from the sea had the accolades to be worthy of song and poetry.

"…*that* guy? Are you certain?"

"Do you know any other Chrysos Heirs with blue eyes, white hair, and a golden sun on their neck?" Perdikkas asked.

"The thread proves it," Ptolemy reminded them.

Mydei lay on his bed while they talked. His room was small, but private. It served as his Captain's Office, full of maps, charting equipment, records, odds and ends, and personal supplies. His friends had piled in while he had finished changing and insisted on discussion while he tried to nap after another long night.

“I would have thought the Goldweaver’s golden hero would’ve been smarter. Sending himself and his men onto a corroded ship?” Hephastion wondered aloud.

“Arrogant.”

“Ignorance,” Mydei corrected. He could hear them twist in their chairs to look at him, but he kept watching the ceiling, looking past it as the hammock swayed with the ship. “It was on his face.”

“Why would the Goldweaver send the Deliverer away from Okhema without telling him about the Black Tide?” Ptolemy tried instead.

“Maybe she doesn’t know,” Leonnius finally chimed in.

Perdikkas shook his head. “She knows everything.”

“Even beyond the reach of the Dawn Device?” Ptolemy questioned.

Mydei sighed and sat up, effectively silencing the room. They watched him walk across the room to get his gauntlets from the desk and slide them on one by one. He flexed his hands and tightened the straps and then excused himself without saying another word.

Behind him the room continued to chatter, speculating wildly even when he closed the door and stepped out into the sunlight.

“Are you also here to waste my time with pointless speculations?” Mydei asked with crossed arms, “or perhaps you want to force my hand instead?”

Krateros shook his head. He was leaning beside the door. There was no need to keep guard, so he was likely there to eavesdrop and be readily available if he was called.

“It was your mother’s wish that I teach you, not make decisions on your behalf but if you would hear my advice, I would give it.”

Mydei twisted just enough to look over his shoulder at the old Kremnoan. “I would.”

“The Okheman is trouble. No good can come from having him on board.”

“Ptolemy claims he’s the Goldweaver’s Deliverer. They believe him to be a Chrysos Heir without equal. Surely, such a warrior is strong enough for my ship.”

“He is at most a prisoner of war, a prized agent of our ancient enemy. Mydeimos, you are not his Captain, not his King,” Krateros insisted.

“I am no one’s King,” Mydei growled and then he stomped away.

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The boots and exomis Phainon had been given were rough but dry, which for now was a blessing while he waited in the dark. Perdikkas, who seemed to be the ship’s medic, had been

kind and gentle helping him get free of his familiar clothing without destroying them. He hadn't said much, and Phainon hadn't asked much at the time, still reeling. When he was clothed and dry, the man had left him in a cell in the belly of the ship to be alone with his feelings.

The brig was cold and replete with shadow; one row of half a dozen cells made of steel bars and lit by dull, intermittent lanterns. Some daylight filtered in from above through the checker patterned grate in the ceiling, but the light had two floors to get through and there was something partially covering the grate on the top deck.

Phainon had hoped that the pirate was lying about the others, that there would be familiar faces in the dark, but while the cells were full to bursting, it was with treasures and supplies, not people. Even the cell Phainon was locked inside was nearly packed tight with spare rope and treasures taken from other ships. There almost wasn't any room for him and his guilt.

He sat on one of the crates with his knees pulled up and his back to the bars. If he listened, he could hear the crew moving above him, the steady beat of a drum as they rowed farther from home.

Phainon wanted to be angry, he wanted to be sad, but truthfully, he was mostly confused.

The Black Tide was a distant, familiar threat. When he was very young, Phainon saw his small isle of Aedes Elysiae swallowed by the Black Tide, a literal surge of putrid corruption that ate at the wheat and flesh, warping his friends and family into monsters that crumbled into dust when his shaky hands drove a sword through their tortured bodies. At the time he didn't know why he had been spared, and the grief had crushed him, turning him into a shell of himself that longed for vengeance against an impossible enemy.

Aglaea had given him answers but not closure, the motivation to always press on but with the weight of them on his back.

They were not buried memories that he had tried to forget, he kept them close, but a part of him must've still been afraid enough to overlook the signs as the Sol had sailed. There was the dust in the hold of the merchant ship, the horrible feeling in his chest when they couldn't find any corpses, the familiar sounds of newborn black tide monsters screeching for relief, and the realization that the corruption had probably doomed the Sol the moment she rammed into her side.

He had made excuses in the moment without realizing it, assigning the carnage to pirates and feeling validated when he recognized them as Kremnoan. Their reputation as warmongers made it easy to assume and he felt terrible for that condemnation when evidence proved otherwise. Marcus, Zeno, Bolaris, and all the others. He'd have to carry them now too.

Phainon hadn't seen evidence of the Black Tide this close to Okhema since Aglaea had sent him to Janusopolis to escort refugees. The monsters there had strayed from the Tide, still dangerous, but bearing no risk of corruption. In the couple years since, the Council had stopped worrying over the absent threat, focused instead on the keeping of Okhema's wealth and Aglaea had returned to focusing on the Flame Chase Journey.

He ran a hand along his bare throat. That man, the Captain of this ship… the heat from his fingertips still lingered where he had touched Phainon with unexpected gentleness, as though he was supremely aware of the roughness of his skin and was afraid to hurt him. The shock of it had sent shivers down his spine and a warmth in his belly that had Phainon questioning his mission entirely.

He hadn't known that Aglaea had left one of her threads on his person, but he wasn't surprised in retrospect. The way it had been so easily plucked and destroyed explained their missing intelligence. How else could Aglaea have not known that the ship roaming the seas, taking their goods was Kremnoan? How else could they not know how far the Black Tide now reached? If this ship was the one hunting the Black Tide across the water, and they were destroying Aglaea's threads and network along the way, there was no chance she would know these very critical pieces of information.

He needed to return to Okhema, but there was little hope of that now. Eurypon's Navy was the stuff of legends and had regularly clashed with Okhema in the past. Before the Black Tide they had battled over territories giving rise to heroic feats that were painted in mosaic on temple walls. Eurypon had been quiet for a time, but that bad blood surely lingered still.

Phainon tilted his head back to bang against the bars and took a deep breath before a tiny movement caught his eye. He turned to see the biggest red eyes just a little too close.

On reflex he yelped and fell off the crate in a surprised leap and crashed into the bars in the small space.

The chimera watched him with calm amusement where he lay on the crate next to Phainon's and while the man flailed for balance, it calmly picked itself up and hopped into the warm spot that was left behind to settle back down to watch the new toy.

It was such an unexpected crewmate that he took an extra few seconds to process that the little thing was here in his cell with him and then Phainon just had a dozen questions rapidly bouncing around his brain. It took a wide chimera yawn to shove them all aside and replace with them an overpowering need to pet and fawn over the perfect little guy.

"Hey," Phainon crooned as he reached out, "what's your name?"

The chimera was white on the bottom and orange on top, nearly red in the dim light of the hold. His ruff was dark brown with big tufty cheeks in soft cream. Phainon scratched the top of his head gently, tracing a triangle between both ears and the soft spot in the middle of his brow.

Pleased with Phainon's offering, the chimera very slowly closed his eyes and rolled onto his side to stretch his paws, all four adorned with orange socks and pink toe beans and for a happy minute there was peace. And then Phainon tried to rub the chimera's belly and then there were claws and teeth in his hand and they were back to a tentative standoff.

"I'm sorry!" Phainon apologized with his hands held up in a peaceful gesture and the chimera looked him up and down, contemplating forgiveness. "I won't pet your belly again, promise."

His tail swished back and forth, the tip of it curling ever so slightly on each pass, the chimera slowly relaxing again…

And then the door opened.

Phainon got to his feet and turned to face his captor with a guarded expression. The Captain was dressed the same way as he had been when first they met in the brief moment on the merchant ship, long flowing red robes, half his chest exposed, and armored legs. His arms were crossed, sharp claws tapping lightly on his arm as bright gold eyes studied Phainon in the limited light.

He felt like a caged animal, waiting for the predator to come along to consume him. This was a lion, content in his den, and Phainon was the defiant Oryx who wasn't going down without a fight.

The chimera stretched once more, peeped in greeting, and then jumped from the crate to pad up to the bars. It took the animal a moment to squeeze between them and when its face got stuck for a few long seconds, Phainon very nearly dropped to his knees to help it. But it managed with a long purr, bug eyes, and pawing at the air until it sprang free with a *pop!* He shook himself off as though that wasn't the greatest prison break of all time and trotted up to the pirate to rub against his legs and paw at his knees.

The Captain uncrossed his arms and very slowly dropped to one knee so he could scratch the chimera's back and sides. Once more, the fuzzy menace flopped over with a happy coo.

"W-Wait-!" Phainon cautioned when the pirate went to scratch and pet the animal's belly, but he was undeterred and to Phainon's surprise the warning was misplaced. The chimera happily accepted the belly scratches to become a satisfied and comfortable puddle on the floor.

"He bit you." It wasn't a question and there was no concern in the deep voice that rumbled in his chest.

Phainon instinctively reached to rub at the little bites and scratches on his hand. Gold smudged across the raised injuries. "…yeah."

"Only those that Fig Stew deems worthy may pet his belly."

So, the chimera's name was Fig Stew. Cute. "And a pirate like you is worthy?"

The scratching stopped and the man stood up straight again. "More worthy than you, *Deliverer*."

Phainon tsked and looked down at his hand, rubbing a little more firmly as though that would erase the sting of rejection. "He just hasn't given me a chance to prove myself yet."

"And you think you will get that chance?"

"Yes," Phainon said, assuredly.

The pirate tilted his head, the barest curl of a smile there, but it might have been a trick of the light. “My men are upstairs debating what to do with you, trying to determine your purpose in these waters.”

“And?”

“And I don’t waste time with speculation. Why were you on that merchant ship?”

“I was looking for survivors.”

“The ship was on fire,” he reminded his prisoner, “surely the chance of survivors was not worth the risk of your own life.”

“It’s always worth the risk,” Phainon fired back. There was a pause as those words hung in the air between them. “And I think you agree with me.”

A scoff. “What makes you think that?”

“Because you came back for me, a stranger.”

Another long pause, heavy with accusation. Neither man faltered, keeping their expressions schooled, unwilling to give the other any advantage as though this conversation was something to be won.

“Did you know that the Black Tide has infested these waters?” the Captain finally asked.

“…no,” Phainon admitted.

The pirate reached up to pinch the bridge of his nose and Phainon was impressed and amused that the action was so practiced he didn’t accidentally poke an eye out with those long claws.

“Why were you sailing here if not to fight the Black Tide? Is that not the Deliverer of Okhema’s duty?”

Phainon didn’t really want to be called that. If their situations were different, maybe he would’ve requested otherwise, but right now it didn’t seem wise to make demands of his host. “We were hunting you,” he admitted somewhat softly, expecting retribution, but it didn’t come.

Instead, the man was chuckling, “and how did that go for you?”

A lost ship, a lost crew, and now Phainon was in the lion’s belly. He didn’t answer.

“So, the Goldweaver doesn’t know as much as the bards would have the people believe,” the pirate went on, “destroying her threads works after all.”

“And maybe my crew would still be alive.”

“They died fighting the corruption and then in battle with my men, in service to their Captain, believing they were heroes rendering aid. Is this not an honorable death?” It was said so

plainly, as though the words should make Phainon completely forget them, move on in a moment. Kremnoan philosophy at its finest.

“I should expect such cruelty from one of Eurypon’s Captains,” Phainon said instead with a slight shake of his head and for the first time, the pirate seemed uncomfortable. He looked away, studying the floor at Phainon’s feet while he shifted his weight.

“Mourn them as you see fit, but there is no room for sulking on my ship.”

“What does it matter to you what I do in my cell?”

“Does my hold seem a dungeon to you?” he asked, looking up again. “You are the first to be behind bars since this vessel was liberated from Castrum Kremnos.”

Liberated? Phainon tilted his head at that implication. Weren’t they part of the Kremnoan Navy? He was tempted to pry, that tenacity making him itch like a dog eyeing a bone and trying to muster the willpower to resist, choosing instead to say with a playful tone, “Aw, I’m so honored to be your first, Captain.”

The man tensed and went wide-eyed for only a second and then found his composure again.

“I meant it when I told you before, there are no captives on my ship. You are here because your reputation proceeded you and I had to be sure you were no danger to my people.”

“And what do you think now?”

The pirate shrugged. “That you are no match for me and therefore not a danger that cannot be handled.”

Phainon twitched. “You could certainly *try* to handle me, pirate.”

Another scoff and a dismissive wave of his hand. “Perhaps you should stay in there then, until your hungry belly shakes the ship and my men decide to throw you to the sea so they can sleep without the growling.”

He shuffled behind the bars, grabbing them with both hands and leaning forward to give voice to the question left in the stagnant air. “Or?”

“Or you earn your meals and passage with work, until I decide what to do with you.”

Phainon mulled that over. These were still pirates. Not just pirates, they were *Kremnoan*, enemies of Okhema, followers of Strife. The damage that led the Sol to them may have been the Black Tide, but Phainon had seen ships ravaged by conflicts between men as well. There was blood on their hands but… there was blood on his hands too and his options were slim.

Phainon held a hand out through the bars, reaching for the pirate. “I’ll earn my keep for now,” he agreed. The man walked slowly up to the bars to take his hand, meeting his squeeze to shake, but Phainon held on, trying to crush the man’s hand as he pulled him in a little closer, until their foreheads nearly touched through the bars. He was breathtaking up close.

“But I won’t participate in piracy,” he growled, drawing the line. “Do we have a deal, Captain…?”

That little smirk was back in the corner of the pirate’s lips; the dim light made the red in his eyes glitter like wine spilled in blood. The hand holding his crushed back with equal force, measured carefully to match.

“Mydei,” he said and Phainon’s eyes flicked briefly to his lips when he did, “Captain Mydeimos. We have a deal, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

They let go and Mydei backed up out of reach before turning away. “I will send Hephastion with the key to release you. He will give you instructions.”

“This is just until I can return to Okhema!” Phainon called after him and Mydei paused at the door to look over his shoulder with a mischievous look in his eye.

“As you say, *Deliverer.”*

Chapter End Notes

Here's hoping I didn't lay it on too thick from the start. I want them to click but also grow into the flirting!

I can't believe Fig Stew doesn't have his own tag

Chapter 3: Gestures of Love and Respect

Chapter Summary

There are a lot of different kinds of love and lots of ways to express it.

"A dog," Mydei repeated, stating it as a matter of fact.

He was sitting on the railing of the upper deck, one leg up beside him so he could rest his elbow on his knee and his chin in his palm. The ocean churned against the side of the ship, waving at him on his precarious perch, threatening to knock him loose, but he paid no mind. His amber eyes glittered in the sunlight, boring a hole into the back of Phainon's head while he watched the man.

"Yep," Leonnius agreed from the floor beside him. He held a shield up to better catch the light and tsked to himself when he found another dirty spot. *Squeak, squeak, squeak,* sang the rag as he rubbed the metal with newfound determination.

Even from here, Mydei could see Phainon's lips moving, chattering away at his partner on the lines. He was smiling but he had been from the moment Hephaestion had released him with a to do list of daily tasks. Not once had Mydei felt like it was completely and truly genuine, nor did he expect it to be. Somehow the smile never quite reached his eyes. It strained under a weight that only Phainon could feel, but despite the trauma of the early morning he *was* smiling, making the most of his situation and stepping forward rather than wallowing in his grief. For now at least, that vengeful fire from earlier was contained, no longer pointing at Mydei and his crew.

They returned his clothes to him when they had finally dried but like most of the men, he had opted on the nice day to forego his top, wearing only that ridiculous collar and his bracers. Sweat glittered on his back, running the length of his spine as he worked the ropes. The man was very fit, exceptionally beautiful, with a few faded scars between his back and chest.

Less than a day, and the Deliverer had ingrained himself with the crew as though he belonged, either oblivious to the wary tension or choosing to ignore it. His natural charisma made him instantly likeable, and the crew weren't entirely sure how to handle it. They couldn't tell if he was a lost puppy begging for a home, or a fox smiling at hens. Even with that leash cut, there was no doubt, Phainon would report to his mistress as soon as he was able.

"A dog digging holes looking for bones," Hephaestion agreed from the little table beside the tiller. He absentmindedly fiddled with a compass. "He's been asking questions. How does a man talk so much but say so little?"

“He may not be Okheman by birth, but the Goldweaver has taught him to be one of them, duplicitous and silver-tongued,” Leonnius theorized but Mydei wasn’t so sure that was all it was. Phainon harbored secrets and had a quick wit, that much was obvious, but he was also honest when they spoke. When Mydei had faced him in the hold, even through bars, Phainon hadn’t lied to him. He really believed, watching the man now, that this was genuine curiosity and not malicious intent.

“Do you know if the men have told him anything?” Mydei asked.

Hephaestion shrugged. “If they have, I wouldn’t know. Only half of them even speak his language. All that matters to them is that he works hard, knows how to sail, and isn’t sharpening his sword behind their backs.”

It wouldn’t make a difference if they had answered his questions. Innocent or not, Mydei was realizing with each passing minute that he had lied to Phainon and to himself. Krateros had been right, as long as they were at odds with Okhema, Phainon was a prisoner of war. He could not be allowed to return to report their strength and numbers. If he already knew that much through observation, it didn’t matter if he knew more.

“If he asks,” Mydei told them, “you may answer at your own discretion.”

The squeaking stopped. “Are you sure, Mydeimos?”

“And what if he tells the Goldweaver?” Hephaestion asked.

A harp behind them twanged twice. Peucesta, who had been listening the whole time in his calm silence, broke it to ask, “You aren’t letting him go, are you, my Prince?”

“We don’t keep prisoners,” the first mate reminded them, “we agreed we wouldn’t when we took this ship.”

“No, we let him out of that awful little cell,” Leonnius pointed out, “so he’s not a prisoner…?”

“What else do you call a guest that isn’t allowed to leave?” Hephaestion huffed.

“Captive, hostage, convict,” Peucesta answered unhelpfully, with a lovely pluck of the harp at every word.

“He is most certainly not crew,” reminded Hephaestion and Mydei resisted the urge to sigh.

The corner of Mydei’s lip twitched with suspicion as he watched Phainon stumble when the ship swayed with a particularly strong gust of wind. The ship settled but Phainon overcorrected the recovery and collided with Ulixes, their drillmaster, who shoved him back. Hostility singed the air, but Mydei stayed seated and immediately held his hand out to stop Hephaestion from interfering when he saw his friend shift in the corner of his eye.

Phainon held both of his hands up, slowly backing away from the offended warrior. For a moment it seemed like peace would be maintained but another unexpected bump on the

ocean sent those raised hands right onto Ulixes' chest. Phainon's lips moved, he smiled, and then he was punched in the face.

The brawl broke out immediately after. Rather than roll over and take it, Phainon had stumbled with the hit and come right back to grab the Kremnoan around the middle, shoving him against the mast with a thud that Mydei felt in his bones from across the ship. He watched with guarded amusement, hand still outstretched even though Hephaestion was ignoring the unspoken command to walk to the rail to see what was going on.

A handful of the others on deck hurried to tie the lines, yelling and straining to hold the sail without the pair of squabblers helping them. Someone had to dive onto Phainon's abandoned rope to secure it to the railing before it became a hazard. A couple others were trying to get a hand on Phainon himself, to pull them apart, but a firm kick kept the boldest of them away while Ulixes kept trying to pry him off between punches and shouts.

"Captain-"

"No, let them finish." If there was any real risk, Mydei would personally intervene.

The fight only lasted another minute. Another few good blows each and then Phainon was dislodged by a knee to his chest, and he was stumbling back. A few of the others caught him by the shoulders but made no move to restrain him, just gave him a little nudge. The two of them panted, words were exchanged, and then Phainon shook his head, just a little shake with a smile.

Mydei watched them clasp arms, having found some mutual understanding in their altercation. Ulixes let go first and immediately returned to work, but Phainon stood still for a moment, processing what had happened with a nervous shuffle. He looked around while he rubbed his wrist, it must've twisted in the fight, and eventually noticed Mydei watching him. His eyes widened in shock. He must have been expecting some sort of punishment for causing trouble.

Would Phainon fight back if Mydei demanded retribution? Would he take responsibility and endure any punishment?

Mydei lazily let Phainon stew in his worries as they watched each other like a cat and a mouse, caught in their own suspended snapshot of time until Mydei showed mercy and looked away.

Out of the corner of his eye, he saw Phainon's shoulders drop as he started breathing again and then hurried to help with the sails once more, all awkward apologies, a bowed head, and awkward scratches at the back of his neck.

"He's been on the ship for a day, and he is already solving disputes like a Kremnoan," Hephaestion noted blandly, but Mydei could hear the compliment buried under his tone.

Hephaestion was one of Mydei's oldest friends and arguably the person he trusted the most. If he had not agreed to be Mydei's first mate, the Prince may not have taken on the role of Captain at all. Mydei had no desire to lead but had fallen into the responsibility at a young

age when his core friend group had found him on the shore of the Sea of Souls as a child and raised him on the sea, always sailing from one isle to the next in search of conquest and glory in the tradition of his heritage. Always treating him as the Crown Prince he was, the future King they wanted him to be.

At least that's how it started.

They kept sailing, kept searching for glory in combat, stealing what they needed and selling the rest, but Mydei wasn't sure he wanted to do that forever. He didn't *want* to be like his father. He didn't *want* to be King. He just wanted to protect his family.

How hard could that be?

His thoughts drifted back to the Black Tide, that ever-present threat, creeping in the depths.

"Phainon sleeps in the cell at night," Mydei decided, "for his protection as well as ours."

Leonnius held the shield up to the light again. "You think the men will try to slit his throat while he sleeps?"

"Until I make a decision about him, I don't want to find out." The Crown Prince finally got down from the rail. He had his own chores to do after all. Without another word he walked away, all focus and business.

A lovely refrain drifted from the harp as Peucesta kept playing.

"Yeah," Hephaestion sighed with a smile. He rolled his head to stretch his neck, long hair spilling over his shoulders. "It's been a while since our beloved Prince has shown so much interest in someone."

"Yep," Leonnius agreed.

"I suppose we should take the time to introduce ourselves."

The music swapped to a major key in agreement.

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Phainon had fully expected to get in trouble when he realized the Captain had seen them, especially after he had puzzled out who the man really was. Surely, the heir to Castrum Kremnos would favor a bloody punishment for such an outburst on his ship.

History was a hobby of Phainon's. If he wasn't building ships or training, he was reading or digging through local shops for antiques. Castrum Kremnos was a dream destination for those that wanted to train to fight. Before the fall of Aedes Elysiae it was something Phainon had talked about with his parents and friends and even started making a travel plan before his whole world collapsed, dragging his dreams into the depths with icy claws.

When he heard the name, Mydeimos, Phainon thought it seemed familiar and the barest of digging and one man's slip up confirmed it. Crown Prince Mydeimos the Undying wasn't just

a Captain in Eurypon's Navy, he was the King's only child. There had been rumors that he had lived in self-imposed exile with other Kremnoans, that the famous Kremnoan Detachment followed their immortal Prince into glorious battle.

The Chryseus Leo and her crew *were* that same Kremnoan Detachment.

Knowing as much it was hard not to feel the slightest trepidation when he saw the Prince descend from the upper deck but the intimidating man didn't continue towards Phainon and went below deck instead. He watched those broad shoulders and strong back disappear into the dark of the stairs and then let out his held breath to look around.

Most of the crew had decided to ignore him, moving through their tasks and loudly chatting in Kremnoan, correctly assuming that Phainon couldn't understand them. He thought about trying to chat with them again, as he had throughout the morning, but it hadn't worked then and it wasn't likely to work now. Mid-afternoon and sailing on favorable wind, there wasn't much left for him to do now that the ropes were secured, and his assigned tasks had already been completed. Left to his own devices, Phainon chose to be proactive, wandering and looking the ship over with an experienced eye. She was a remarkable masterpiece, a feat of engineering made by the master smiths and craftsmen of Kremnos.

She was built for luxurious war, massive, long, with three masts and that gorgeous roaring lion figurehead carved from red crystal for a ram. The detailing etched into the railings, doorways, the mast, and the aplustre told tales of Strife, images of war, and murals of victory. They were marred in places, and it was obvious where damage had been repaired with new wood, leaving stories unfinished or in pieces, changing their meanings in the process.

Phainon gave the crew space as he wandered and traced those carvings with his fingers, appreciating them from his own world, giving every relief the attention it deserved as though he was appraising a rare gem back home. It was behind the tiller, near the aplustre that he found a scene that surprised him into stopping his wandering entirely. In loving detail was pictured a feast between two Titans. Nikador's spear was raised in salute to Kephale, who gifted to Strife the Dawn. They were depicted as equals, as friends. It was the last thing Phainon would have expected to see carved into a warship by a hopeful hand.

"Oh, sing to me muse, of those halcyon days when Titans spoke of peace." Phainon nearly jumped out of his skin. His eyes shot up and his head twisted like a whip to look at Hephaestion. "Or so Peucesta would sing."

The first mate smiled and tilted his head, the same gesture as when he had turned the wrought iron key and let Phainon loose that morning. They had exchanged names then. He was all lean muscle and sinew, not the kind of figure Phainon would have expected from a Kremnoan warrior at a glance. He kept his hair long, very long, long and straight enough that when he pulled his locks over his shoulders it reached his waist. Sharp eyes full of experience glittered with cautious optimism and Phainon felt the connection there, seeing this interaction as the olive branch that it was.

He turned back to where his fingers were still resting on the sun behind Kephale. "They're beautiful."

“They’re worn and faded,” lamented the Kremnoan.

“And they’re more beautiful for it,” Phainon countered fondly, “I noticed many of these stories are incomplete, how old is the ship?”

For a careful second Hephaestion hesitated, but he answered clearly, “She was finished nearly twenty-five years ago, to be the flagship of King Eurypon’s royal navy. He commanded her for a few years during his campaigns in the North and maintained her glory when she was damaged, but there are none among us that can repair the carvings.”

That was a shame. Phainon moved the tip of his pointer finger along the back of a carved image of a lion. It was mid roar and bathing in golden sunlight. “I’m surprised King Eurypon does not command her himself still,” he mused, testing the waters. This was the first time someone had been so forthcoming when he had made inquiries, and he was very curious. The last time Okhema had seen an organized Kremnoan attack was more than five years ago. “The Captain suggested the ship had been stolen?”

Hephaestion smiled. “In a way it was.”

“In a way?” Phainon asked.

Hephaestion nodded and said, “That King… didn’t need it anymore.” There was an edge to the man’s voice, an underlying disdain when he referred to Eurypon.

“You harbor no love for your King,” he observed.

“I have nothing *but* love for my King,” Hephaestion corrected, “even if he has yet to pick the crown up from the ground.”

Phainon turned again to look at Hephaestion, letting his hand fall from the aplustre to his side. The man was watching Phainon with the same intensity that he had seen in Mydeimos’ gaze earlier, searching for a reaction, judging Phainon’s knowledge just as fervently as he was giving it. Not that there was much to find and Hephaestion knew it. The comment was lost on Phainon who puzzled over the man’s careful word choice.

“If you’re done admiring the décor,” Hephaestion continued, closing off any further discussion, “I do have a task for you.”

He gave the carvings one more lingering look and touch, rolled his shoulders and gestured politely to the first mate. “However, I may be of service.”

Pleased, he gestured for Phainon to follow and led the way towards the bow. The raised deck there had another set of stairs leading below. A shortcut to where the crew slept and kept their things. It was also host to some of their more readily accessible supplies and armory.

Hephaestion led Phainon to one such storage closet full of odds and ends generally used for patchwork repairs. The sort of things that seemed like junk until they were miraculously needed for weirdly specific reasons. Phainon’s father used to keep a small basket for such things under the kitchen washbasin, insisting that none of it could be thrown away or

repurposed ‘just in case.’ On a ship, space was a resource to be managed like any other, so it was important to only keep things that would be necessary and to budget the use of those supplies wisely. From what Phainon could tell of the organized mess, they had prepared for many months at sea and restocking had come from inconsistent sources, taking supplies from ships they had conquered, or, as Phainon now knew, ships that had already been lost to the Black Tide. Anything that was free of corrosion was fair game on the high seas.

Hephaestion handed Phainon a wooden bucket and started throwing things in there. He recognized all the items immediately. Scrap pieces of wood, a ceramic jar of pitch, a brush… these were all tools for patch repairs.

“Is this for the deck?” Phainon asked and the first mate stopped what he doing to look at him quizzically.

“Yeah, there are some small holes in the deck from this morning.” A pause. “Are you familiar with patching holes?”

“I help the ship builders in Okhema when I can. May I?” he asked and Hephaestion stepped out of the closet so that Phainon could step inside.

The longer Phainon studied the haphazard shelfing, awkward cases, jostled containers, clay jars, and loose trash the more a pattern started to emerge. At one point the closet had been organized. Rough seas shook everything together, but the collection of miscellany was trying to adhere to materials of like purposes. Plenty of oils, lots of tar… He unsealed a couple of amphorae and twisted them in turn towards the light until he found a wide-necked jar full of old beeswax.

“This is going to hold up better to the weather than the pitch for small scrapes on the deck,” he offered, holding the jar out to Hephaestion. The man balanced the ceramic precariously in the bucket and offered his hand to Phainon to help him to his feet. Despite his lean appearance, the Kremnoan had an iron grip and tugged Phainon to standing with ease.

“It’ll look better too. How big are the holes?”

Hephaestion moved the bucket under one arm and gestured with his hand to demonstrate a circle with his finger and thumb. “Not big, more scratches than anything. The worst of them may be buffed out by sharkskin.” He pointed to another jar. This one was at least labeled with what looked like a child’s drawing of a shark.

Phainon leaned over a pile of discarded lumber scraps to grab it. Strips of shark hide were neatly placed inside, some already worn. “This is high quality,” he praised as he ran his thumb over the rough hide.

“Leonnius caught and tanned them himself.”

With an impressed hum, Phainon added a few sheets of the skin to the bucket in Hephaestion’s hands and then took the supplies from him. He crouched on the ground and started sorting through the stock. They wouldn’t need the whole jar of wax. Phainon pointed into the closet again.

“Will you hand me that small adz?”

The tool was hanging on the wall by a string and a stubborn hook. It wasn’t very sharp, old and worn as it was, but the curved, wide, flat blade was exactly what he needed. For a brief but heavy pause, the First Mate hesitated to hand it over. The tool could easily be used as a weapon and Phainon was reminded how tenuous their partnership was for the day. They were enemies yesterday, it was only Kremnoan confidence and Phainon’s agreement with the Captain that kept him from being thrown right back into the brig.

“Oil lamp?”

Again, Hephaestion provided. The lamp and flint were added to the bucket while Phainon used the short end of the adz to scoop a generous amount of wax from the amphorae. He counted his supplies in turn and then finally stood with the tools of his trade.

“Did you want to supervise?” he cheerfully invited.

“Do you think I need to?”

“I wouldn’t mind the company.” But he didn’t have any expectations.

Hephaestion reached into the bucket in response and pulled out a piece of shark skin. “I’ll even help.”

The deck was well cared for as it was. Despite its age the Chryseus Leo was maintained as though it was waiting for a royal maiden voyage, the only nicks and problems in the deck were caused by the scuffle that morning. The biggest of which was caused by Phainon’s blade when the Prince had deflected the swing meant for Perdikkas and the heavy weapon had gouged into the wood.

Phainon squatted beside the spot and ran his hand over the sharp, raised edges caused by the splinters removed from their natural grain.

“A blade as heavy as yours, I’m grateful it only bit the deck and not my friend,” Hephaestion said over his shoulder but the nip of guilt in Phainon’s chest burned away as quickly as it appeared.

“I am too.” He meant it.

Phainon got to work using the adz to gently scrape away the bigger splinters and round out the cavity; shark skin smoothed the edges. There was peace in hard work, something so satisfying in being a part of the process of repair.

Hephaestion was only a spear’s length away, rubbing at much smaller wounds with the skin. Those nips in the ship were from enemy arrows that had embedded in the wood. Phainon recognized the marks from past experiences. Most crews and Captains would overlook those common scars as natural wear and tear, but the first mate was taking extraordinary care to make those tiny rough spots smooth, leaving the markings faded but not erasing them

entirely. He worked in slow circles, carefully running his free hand over every spot to check that it was exactly the right texture before he moved on to the next one.

Phainon slowed his own work as he watched to appreciate the meticulous attention.

“You love this ship,” he observed aloud in a soft voice.

And Hephaestion stopped to look up at him with surprise that melted into a genuine smile. “What sailor doesn’t love their home?” The first mate went right back to work, humming to himself in the lighter mood carried by such a lovely sentiment.

When Phainon filled the empty space he had carved with wood chips and heated the wax with the lamp to pour between the cracks, it was with extra care. When he used the flat of the adz’s heated blade to burn the wax in place, smoke curling briefly in the air until a damp rag soothed the aching lumber, it was with respectful concentration. And as he sanded down the wax to make it even, running his hand over his work just as Hephaestion had done, it was with love. Not because Phainon loved this ship himself, but because Hephaestion had convinced him with his actions that the vessel deserved nothing less.

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By the time they were done the sun was dipping low. That was yet another thing to get used to this far from the Dawn Device. Phainon liked the colors of the sky during parting hour, even if they felt a little colder now after a trying day of loss and discovery.

Hephaestion had left him to check on dinner midway through their work and Phainon had been left alone for the most part to clean up. As alone as one could be with a crew of Kremnoans frequently glancing his way and bumping his back while he sorted his supplies in a desperate attempt to tame the chaos of the closet. The endeavor already felt a lost cause before the smell of grilled fish wafted by on the breeze and his angry stomach decided that was a more worthy pursuit.

The galley below decks had long tables and benches but there wasn’t enough space for the entire crew to eat at once. Many of the men were fine with the arrangement and took their food to their private spaces in the crew’s living quarters, others made makeshift tables and chairs of crates and barrels to eat on the deck. Some took their food and ate as they worked, making up for any lost time that may have been wiled away throughout the day.

When Phainon wandered down the stairs to the galley below in search of the source of that wonderful smell, the happy chatter quieted. The elephant in the room had blue eyes and white hair and he nearly wilted under those piercing stares but Phainon returned them with a soft smile and a playful wave. A few of the crew laughed and returned to their conversations, chatting in Kremnoan while they waited.

The food was already prepared and waiting in baskets and half covered by cloth to keep it warm but no one made a move to take some. Standing beside the lineup with his head bowed, eyes closed, and his arms crossed was the Captain. He leaned against the countertop, keeping the line from advancing, infinitely patient and stoic,

“What are we waiting for?” Phainon asked a man next to him, but he only got a confused expression in response. More people shoved into the galley and took seats or found places to stand. Someone had already uncorked a barrel of wine and many were choosing to indulge there while they waited.

Phainon’s belly rumbled and his mouth watered. He still wasn’t sure if he’d be allowed to eat yet and he certainly wasn’t going to find out if no one was eating at all. The temptation to make a scene, to ask, was beginning to outweigh his curiosity until something bumped into his shin.

Fig Stew put both of his front paws on the top of Phainon’s boot, looked right up at him, and then rubbed those tufty cheeks against the leather. He blessed the man with a rub from both sides of his perfect, round face before moving to the next man in line, rubbing against everyone in turn and ending with the Prince. The chimera sat in front of the man, mewled, and then waited with his tail swishing back and forth.

Mydei and Fig Stew watched each other for a respectful moment and then the Captain reached into one of the baskets and pulled out a single pita pocket stuffed full of cooked fish. He offered it to the chimera, who took it happily in his mouth, waited for head pats, and then happily bounded out of the galley with his meal.

Only then did the Captain move from his place and the men descended on the meal with disciplined eagerness. Those close to the front of the line took their food straight from the baskets on the countertops, while the Prince brought one basket to the tables and then took another to the back of the line, serving those there himself. Every hand that took food muttered phrases in Kremnoan, giving thanks to Mydei directly, who muttered back to them in their native tongue.

There was no shoving, no jostling, no one took more than their share on a first pass, and Phainon was impressed. He also was hesitant. For as disorganized as it appeared, there was a definite system and he wasn’t sure where he fit, much less that persistent fear that he wouldn’t be allowed to eat at all.

“Did you not want any, Deliverer?” Mydei asked and Phainon only just realized that the man had come up beside him with a nearly empty basket. The Captain held it out to him, watching with that steady gaze as though he would pounce the moment Phainon failed this test.

“Is this you telling me that I earned it?”

“If you don’t want any…” the Kremnoan growled and started to turn away, but Phainon hurriedly caught the edge of the basket to stop him.

“No, I do! I thought maybe you would be upset with me for earlier.”

“Hephaestion said you worked hard today and Chryseus Leo is happy,” Mydeimos explained, somewhat dismissive, “if you believe your fight with Ulixes should be punished further than the bruises he already gave you, then go and ask him to hit you again, but do it on your own time and with a full stomach.”

Phainon didn't really want to get hit again. "…thank you." He reached in and took one of the pockets and was determined to leave it at that, but Mydei sighed and pushed a second one into his hands.

"I said a *full* stomach," he grumbled. The Prince muttered something to himself in Kremnoan looked Phainon up and down with a furrowed brow and narrowed eyes. He gave Phainon a third pocket with more mumbled Kremnoan musings and wandered off to feed more of his men.

Phainon waited in shock with his hands full, too tired to really process the interaction. He stayed standing there, doe-eyed and lost, until Hephaestion waved him over to one of the tables to sit and sip at pomegranate wine.

There were others there, one of them, the man he had fought with earlier, raised his wine in a gesture of respect and Phainon returned it with a half-smile and a bow of his head. But the weight of the day was heavy and though he still smiled, Phainon ate in silence while the others talked around him in a language he couldn't understand. They gave him space to enjoy his meal near others, not really one of them, but not entirely alone anymore either.

The fish was moist and delicious, well-seasoned and mixed with herbs and vegetables. The bread was soft and warm. It was exactly the comfort that Phainon needed after a long day, so much so that he didn't complain when he was escorted back to that cage in the dark. He still felt warm when Hephaestion reassured him with apologies and gave him a mat to sleep on and a heavy blanket to use. He was warm when they bade each other good night; when the locked clicked. And that comfort stayed with Phainon in the dark until the mercy of night wrapped him up tight in sleep.

Chapter 4: Shared Stories

Chapter Summary

Yay bonding!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It only took Phainon a couple days to find a rhythm. There was a routine on the ship and now that he was finding it, things were clicking a little bit better, a little bit faster. Hephaeston would unlock his cell in the mornings, he would get whatever quick breakfast was available in the galley and then join the men for morning drills.

The Drillmaster, Ulixes, was the man that Phainon had scuffled with on his first day. Apparently, fighting between the men wasn't a rare occurrence and the Captain only involved himself in those disputes if the violence escalated beyond problem solving and encroached into genuine rage. It made sense when Phainon realized it. These were warriors from a warring culture, it was only natural that they would get twitchy between fights and need an outlet. Sometimes all two men really needed was to beat the shit out of each other and then laugh about it later.

After morning drills were daily chores. Phainon was the bottom of the rung on this ship, so his tasks were important but demeaning. Tasks like dumping the overnight bedpans, swabbing both high traffic decks, laundry, washing dishes, and working the lines and oars when called upon. Fortunately, the rowing wasn't something he had to do yet. The Chryseus Leo was plenty fast if there was wind and there was no shortage of that.

As long as his list of chores was, Phainon was a hard worker and buckling down and knocking those tasks out quickly left him with more free time to explore the ship, nap, talk to the others, and just appreciate the ocean and the crew.

Phainon had always loved people. Only about half of the detachment understood him when he spoke and fewer than half could respond, but Phainon made every effort to not let that language barrier deter him and made use of universal hand signs and gestures to try and bond indiscriminately. Most everyone was receptive to his friendly teasing albeit from arm's length. Aside from Hephaeston, most of the crew remained guarded, but there were two people on the ship that seemed to have a real problem with him, a seasoned veteran named Krateros and the Captain, Mydeimos.

While the Captain was dismissive and short, he was at least willing to speak with Phainon whenever Phainon approached to ask simple questions, but Krateros wouldn't even look at him. It made sense, there was bad blood between their city-states. There had been years of a

tenuous silence between leadership, but their conflict spanned centuries, all the way back to the Titans. Anywhere Kremnoans and Okhemans met there was conflict. That hostility was what made Phainon realize that the cell wasn't because they were afraid of him, but worried *for* him.

Another mixed message from the Captain to let simmer on the back burner of Phainon's inner thoughts.

In any case, Phainon wanted to make the most of his free time with his chores completed and with nothing urgent to do, he wandered to the ship's library.

That had been a happy discovery in his exploring. What had once been a massive and lavish Captain's quarters had been divided into a few different rooms. Mydei still had his own private space, but they had filled the largest storage space with books, scrolls, and tablets that the Kremnoans had collected. It was small compared to a real library of course, but easily the largest collection he had personally seen on the sea.

Phainon let himself into the unlocked room with a soft click of the latch and poked his head in first to be sure he wasn't intruding on anyone. Almost immediately he was spotted.

"Perfect timing," a confident voice called from across the room. Against the far wall, more than half buried under a partially collapsed shelf and a massive collection of clay tablets and books was a man with short hair and a shrewd expression. Despite being very trapped he was holding a book open with his only free hand. "If you're not busy."

Phainon's eyes widened in the same breath that he was hurrying across the room to assess the situation. "Oh Titans, are you alright??"

The Kremnoan smiled with just the corners of his mouth, amused. He set the book down, holding it open with his arm so he could slowly reach for a scrap of paper to put between the pages of his book so he could close it without losing his place.

"'A man who has been through bitter experiences and travelled far enjoys even his sufferings after a time,'" he recited in the clear monotone of someone quoting a favorite passage from a book.

"…so you want me to leave you here?" Phainon asked, pointing at the pile.

"Of course not!"

The man had twisted at an angle and once trapped had almost no leverage to free himself. What books he could move one-handed had already been set aside, or in some cases tossed. Phainon managed to free his other arm where it had been pinned by a scroll jammed between the wall and a heavy tablet and then he was able to help, systematically moving treasured tomes and bound leather to reveal the crux of the problem.

"Ah wait," the Kremnoan said when Phainon reached for the stone tablet. "That's a load bearing record." He pointed at where the tablet and the bookshelf met, for now it was

preventing an even greater disaster as the haphazard shelf threatened to dump the other half of its charges onto the pinned man.

Phainon backed up to reassess the situation. There was still urgency churning deep in his belly, but the trapped man seemed unbothered, waiting patiently and calmly.

“Any ideas?” Phainon asked when he saw the man watching him.

“I haven’t the angle nor the means to see all the pieces. I fear I am entirely at your mercy, Deliverer,” he said with a small chuckle, laughing at his own joke under his breath.

Phainon bowed his head and shook it back and forth twice. “Should I fail, and you be crushed under these words, who will I mourn?” he asked, equally playful, channeling his inner poet in response to this book worms own eloquent musings.

The man laughed a proper laugh, a breathy sound louder than a true librarian or scholar of the Grove but softer than a soldier’s echoing boom in the barracks. “I am Ptolemy. I suppose it wasn’t fair of me to not offer that when I already knew who you were.”

“I guess I have caused a few ripples, enough to be known,” Phainon apologized. He started delicately removing books from the teetering shelf. They were held in place by a thin metal rod. The restraint was enough to keep them from dislodging when the ship tilted and twisted with the waves, but not enough to hold their weight at this angle. The nail holding the rod was wiggling loose. It wouldn’t hold if Phainon simply pushed the shelf upright without easing some of the weight.

“You have,” Ptolemy admitted, “but it’s a pleasure all the same. It has been some time since the ship has felt so alive.”

“Bold words from someone who may perish under these stories.”

“You seem studied.” The casual brushing off impending death must be a Kremnoan thing.

“I graduated from the Grove of Epiphany,” Phainon confirmed and then added proudly, “five-time debate champion.” He set the books on a neat pile as he removed them and then paced around the mess on the floor, to see how to best get at the books on the next shelf. There was plenty of light from the line of windows but not a lot of space between shelves to work with. It wouldn’t do to knock another one loose.

“A silver-tongue indeed.”

“I don’t know that I am all *that*.”

“You may even have the wit to compete with Mydeimos.”

Phainon paused. It was only for a moment, but he could feel Ptolemy’s eyes on him all the same. “Well, you don’t have to worry about that. The Captain barely seems willing to interact with me at all.”

Ptolemy tsked and mumbled under his breath in Kremnoan.

“Ah! Did I twist your leg?”

“No, no, I’m bemoaning our Prince.”

The tomes on the lower shelves were considerably thicker and at the awkward angle for retrieval Phainon found himself struggling not to drop the heavy books on Ptolemy. He held perfectly still holding one such book, waiting for the sway of the ship before stumbling backwards to set the book down on the floor with the others.

“…I’m not sure I understand the Captain,” Phainon admitted. He gave the shelf an experimental shove. It budged but barely and that struggling nail kept trying to make an escape. “I expected him to be more like his father.”

“’Few sons are like their fathers--most are worse, few better,’” Ptolemy quoted.

“And which is he?”

Ptolemy shifted his weight, testing his legs with a wince. They were still trapped. “If you are well-read, than you have heard of Eurypon, the mad king of Castrum Kremnos. Do you think a man worse than he would have pulled you from the sea?”

Phainon tentatively reached a leg over the pile, effectively straddling Ptolemy to widen his stance for better balance. It was the only way he had a chance of moving the stone tablets from the middle shelf without stepping on something breakable.

“Is that why the Prince exiled himself?” Phainon asked. He was interested in the story of course, but his attention was admittedly divided. He put one hand on the wall to brace himself while he delicately started pulling the thickest of the stone slabs off the threatening bookcase.

“Is that what the bards of Okhema sing?” Ptolemy scoffed, but for the first time the man’s words seemed to catch in his throat as he hesitated. “It is not my story to tell… but perhaps it’s best you know, if you are to walk the same ship as he does, for however long.”

“I wouldn’t want to put you in troubling situation…”

The stone slab slipped from his fingers and slammed into the floor next to Ptolemy’s leg with a sickening crunch and they both froze, wide-eyed, holding their breath.

“…Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, I already am.”

“I am so-“

“Please do not apologize for what, thankfully, did not happen.”

Phainon bent a knee and kicked to return to one side of the pile, flapping his arms to balance as he did so. That heavy slab wasn’t moving for awhile but it wasn’t on the shelf anymore. He gave it another shove and this time the shelf rocked more agreeably.

“I’ll not give you details, lest he not want you to know them, but there is enough that is common knowledge to tell. The Prince was not raised in Castrum Kremnos by King Eurypon’s hand.”

“I know he left in his youth…”

“Eurypon threw Mydei into the sea of souls when he was newly born to appease Nikador,” Ptolemy explained, “the tale is famous in Castrum Kremnos. I am surprised it has not made its way to Okhema.”

Phainon stood still for a moment to process his shock. It was hard to imagine a father’s cruelty when Phainon’s own family had been loving and wonderful. To grow up with no one… More than that, such an origin explained the Undying title. Older soldiers who had scuffled with Kremnoans talked about their strength and conditioning. When they spoke of Mydei who couldn’t be killed at all, Phainon had assumed those were embellishments, but perhaps he really was immortal, if he survived the sea of souls as an infant.

“My professor used to complain about war,” he said softly, “not because he abhorred violence but because animosity could prevent the exchange of information and he believed all knowledge should be shared.”

He bent down to clear more of the books and scrolls that were across Ptolemy’s lap. His smile had faded and the Kremnoan took notice, both of his solemnity and of his unwillingness to directly address this new tidbit about the Prince.

“Mydei is not without family,” Ptolemy told him firmly, even reaching out to put his hand on Phainon’s arm to stop him from working for a moment. Their eyes met and Phainon could see in those harsh eyes that this was immensely important to the man. His gaze glittered with desperate need to make Phainon understand, regardless of any prejudices.

He squeezed Phainon’s arm once, then let go and resumed digging. It was easier now that they had cleared the heavy scrolls from Ptolemy’s belly. Now that he could sit up, it was easier for him to be proactive in his own rescue.

“I was very young when I chose to leave Castrum Kremnos,” he started to say and Phainon twisted in place to better face him as they worked. “Training begins for Kremnoans from the moment our little hands are strong enough to hold a spear, by the time myself, Hephastion, and Leonnius realized we did not want to serve a corrupted King we were not yet men.” His expression grew distant, no longer sitting on the floor of a ship but back in his homeland, reliving difficult memories. “It is a long story, one that need not be recited in its entirety, what matters is that there were no small number of us that latched onto a rumor carried by wayward fishermen of a child that saved them from monsters in the sea, a child with red markings and an animal ferocity, blessed by the titans.

“We scoured the waters and found Mydei to raise him ourselves while we showed him the freedom of the open ocean. We are his family and we would follow our King without question because we know him to be an honorable man of the highest quality.”

Phainon grunted as he moved a scroll to get at the last heavy tome trapping Ptolemy's thighs. He stayed quiet, letting the story roll over his understanding of the man.

"Have I said too much? Perhaps not enough?"

"Ah, no, Ptolemy," he mumbled. Phainon stood again to push at the bookshelf. It was still holding onto the Kremnoan's ankles and would need to be moved if the man was to be free once more. "I am simply appreciating what you told me."

"The bards sing of you too, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," Ptolemy explained, "like Mydei, I assume your story has more layers than what is written in poetry."

Phainon chuckled sadly. "I wish they wouldn't hold me in such light."

"Are they not your deeds?"

"They are wildly embellished."

"Even those of the Nameless Hero who wandered from a burning village?" Phainon's mood darkened, and Ptolemy looked away. "I overstepped."

The silence stretched between them as they removed the last of the books and Phainon tried to puzzle out the best way to move the shelf without hurting Ptolemy's foot.

"The bards make it sound like I'm something special," Phainon finally said in a quiet voice, "but the truth is I'm just the son of a farmer who played hero with a wooden sword. A boy that lost everything, could do nothing, and became nothing. I don't know why Aglaea picked me, when I was covered in dust and salt, just a shell of a man."

Ptolemy mulled that over and then quoted with sincerity, "'Is he not sacred, even to the gods, the wandering man who comes in weariness?' I am glad that fate has crossed our paths Phainon of Aedes Elysiae and not just because you are about to free me from the result of my hubris."

Phainon smiled again. "Then I will not disappoint."

He pressed his shoulder to the heavy shelf, braced himself, and pushed. The shelf teetered unhappily and then groaned its way back to standing. Ptolemy hurried to pull his foot free and scooted backwards to safety.

"These bars will need to be replaced," Phainon muttered.

"Phainon," Ptolemy said as he slowly got to his feet, leaning heavily on the wall for support, "it was not my intention to cause you distress…"

But Phainon was already smiling again, feelings buried back where they belonged in the depths of his heart. He could see the skepticism on Ptolemy's face and did his best to convey reassurance in response. "All is well, Ptolemy. I'm just glad I could help, and especially glad for the insight. It seems my professor was right; knowledge should be shared freely."

“I can’t promise that I will answer all your questions,” Ptolemy admitted, “but that is more a matter of timing than an unwillingness.”

“I do appreciate it. How are your legs?”

Ptolemy tested his injured foot and tsked. “Nothing compared to how my arms will feel after reorganizing this mess.”

“May I help?” Phainon asked.

“I would be grateful for it.”

Ptolemy was less forthcoming when he started sorting. His concentration was focused on ensuring everything was put back exactly where he wanted it and it was good thing he knew because this library was not organized in any way that Phainon understood. To make matters worse, half of the collection was in Kremnoan and he had to pause to compare the letters, relying on symbol recognition more than actual understanding of what they said.

“Where did you get all these?” he asked.

“We liberated nearly all of it from other ships, a couple libraries.”

“That is the second time I have heard someone on this ship use that word to justify stealing,” Phainon grumbled.

“It’s not stealing,” Ptolemy insisted, indignant. Even punctuating the statement by smacking Phainon lightly on the head with one of the books, making him blink in surprise.

He may have loved his books and stories, but Ptolemy was still a Kremnoan warrior. All of them readily expressed themselves with physical gestures and disregarded personal space when they were comfortable, from the way Mydeimos had shamelessly reached for his neck to snap Aglaea’s thread on day one, to the way Ulixes had punched him for a too friendly comment, and now as a playful gesture with Ptolemy. It made him laugh.

Ptolemy gave him a funny look with pursed lips and one raised eyebrow before he smacked Phainon again with the book. He put it away on the shelf with a mumbled Kremnoan curse.

“I’ve also heard that word a lot too,” he chuckled. Phainon handed Ptolemy a scroll to put away.

“Good. It is an unflattering insult.”

“I suppose I may deserve it.”

“You sound so happy about that…”

The chuckles faded into giggles. “I don’t mean to be. …would you teach me?”

Ptolemy paused with a clay tablet in hand. Maybe Phainon shouldn’t have handed the man something so heavy to be weaponized if that question was inappropriate to ask but Ptolemy

seemed to have forgotten he was holding it when he tilted his head.

“Teach you what?”

Phainon pointed to the clay and the lettering there. “Teach me Kremnoan.”

He tsked as he put the tablet back on the shelf, the bottom shelf this time, and pushed it into place with his uninjured foot.

“Why?”

“Why not? For one, I’d like to know when people are calling me rude things,” Phainon explained, “but I also would like to be able to understand the crew. Understand and be understood.”

“…you are a fascinating person, Deliverer of Okhema,” Ptolemy deadpanned, “that is a lofty goal for someone that expects to return home before long.”

Phainon shrugged. “I have seen the ships supplies. I know the crew was not expecting to dock at any port for at least a few more weeks. Surely that is enough time to at least learn Kremnoan curses.”

Ptolemy gave Phainon a sad look, one that left Phainon confused and a little worried. Was the language that hard to learn that it warranted such pity?

“I will teach you, but it may take some time and if you aren’t giving it your all-“

“I will,” Phainon promised.

They were getting to the end of the pile and the incident in the library was a thing of the past, a secret between them that made Phainon happy to have shared in the moment.

“I assume you originally came here for something to read,” Ptolemy said. He brushed dust off his chiton and stepped over to another shelf, scanning the spines and occasionally pulling out a scroll to check its contents.

“Ah, I did,” Phainon admitted. “I wasn’t sure what you had in your collection and was curious. I guess I didn’t really consider that most of it would be in Kremnoan.” He brushed his hands over the shelf, noting with relief that at least some of it was in familiar tongues. They must’ve ‘liberated’ those stories and records from Okheman ships they had taken over. The reminder left a sour taste in Phainon’s mouth. They were still pirates. They were still enemies. When he returned to Okhema, it would be with important information to report, and then he would back to hunting them again as was his duty…

“If you’re earnest about learning Kremnoan,” Ptolemy was saying. He had wandered to the far side of the library while Phainon was browsing. “You can start here.”

Phainon would’ve willingly gone to him, but Ptolemy met him in the middle next to a small desk. He set two little books of near equal shape and size on its surface, extra mindful to not knock over the open inkwell and pen there.

“This is one of Mydei’s favorite stories.”

“Oh, it’s fiction?” Phainon asked.

“Yes, is that a problem?”

“It’s not what I usually read…” he cut himself off at the look on Ptolemy’s face and held a hand up apologetically, “I’m sure it’s an excellent tale.”

“What’s important is that we have two copies, one in Kremnoan…”

“And one in Okheman Common,” Phainon finished when he recognized the language scribbled on the spine. He picked up one of the books and flipped through it. The one in Kremnoan was older, more frayed, more loved. There were notes in the margins, scribbled quickly and barely legible. They might’ve been doodles if the scribbling wasn’t so frequent and so unrecognizable as anything resembling a picture.

“You can compare them to start building associations,” Ptolemy explained, “it won’t help you speak it or even understand it until I can teach you how to vocalize the words, but it’s a start so you can familiarize yourself with our letters.”

“Can we not start learning how to speak it now?” Phainon tried.

Ptolemy stared at him and then grumbled to himself in Kremnoan with a long-suffering sigh. “You must’ve been popular with your professor.”

Phainon laughed again, “I thought I’d ask, but I understand. Thank you for the start, Ptolemy.”

Ptolemy huffed and sat at the desk. He picked up the pen and tapped it on a scrap of paper. Little flecks of dried ink scattered in all directions. “I’ll try to prepare a teaching plan and we can practice at dinner, perhaps before bed. You don’t have any night shifts, do you?”

“Ah, no, I’m not sure they’ll let me,” he admitted sheepishly.

“That’s alright. I have my own duties on the ship too, but when I’m available I can come find you.”

“I appreciate that.”

Phainon scooped up the second book. They weren’t very big. Not quite pocket-sized but each book fit comfortably in his hand. He held them reverently. Not only were these entrusted to him with love, but they were a bridge to communication, and while this was a distant and unlikely dream, a better chance for a peaceful resolution between Kremnos and Okhema.

“Ptolemy,” Phainon asked now that it was on his mind, “if Mydeimos isn’t like his father, is better than him, do you think he’d be open to peace with Okhema?”

Ptolemy looked up at him thoughtfully, then down at the pen to fiddle with it with both hands. “Is there not already?”

“What do you mean?”

“Phainon, when was the last time Okhema and Kremnos clashed?” Ptolemy held up a hand to stop him from speaking just yet. “I don’t mean between isolated parties such as ours whom Okhema have labeled pirates, I mean a true act of aggression, of war.”

Phainon thought about that. “Six years ago,” he said, “the clash outside Ladon.”

Ptolemy studied him with a goading expression, waiting for him to think things through.

“King Eurypon doesn’t see Okhema as a priority anymore,” Phainon thought aloud, “Okhema hasn’t instigated any engagements in a long time to focus instead on our trade partners but why wouldn’t Eurypon still try to attack?” He held a hand to his chin and studied the floor intently while he thought. “Something else has his attention, something more important, or…” Something clicked. Phainon looked up at Ptolemy. “King Eurypon is dead.”

“As of five years ago, yes,” Ptolemy confirmed.

“This is-“ Phainon stumbled, “then Mydeimos is-“

“He should be, yes. The Kremnoan rite of succession dictates that the man or woman who kills the King be crowned in royal blood and take his place,” Ptolemy explained.

More clicking. “Mydeimos killed his father,” Phainon breathed.

Ptolemy nodded. “He exacted revenge on King Eurypon for himself and his mother who died at Eurypon’s hands the day Mydei was thrown into the sea. Then he rejected the crown, claimed this ship, and those of us that wanted to follow him left Castrum Kremnos.”

“We haven’t clashed with Castrum Kremnos in five years because-“

“There is no Castrum Kremnos with which to clash,” Ptolemy confirmed, “at least not as it was in the past. It still exists, the city is… lost, for now, but her people are still proud and there are a great many of us that still wait for our Prince to embrace his destiny and lead us home.”

Phainon felt like his head was spinning. “How does Okhema not know of this?”

Ptolemy shrugged. “Perhaps they simply do not care as long as there are no red sails on their horizon.”

There was a flicker of truth there. Many people in Okhema didn’t bother to study history, what mattered was that they were safe to focus on the next day, on enjoying the wealth that flowed from the harbor and from Kephale. What did it matter if their ancient rivalry simply faded away into the background? Especially with the Black Tide, the rise of piracy, and other allies to bicker with, something that seemed open and shut didn’t require answers.

That didn’t sit right with Phainon but the knot in his stomach would need to time to unravel the complexities of this new information. He felt like it should change everything, but realistically, to Okhema, it was unlikely to change anything.

“Speaking of history,” Ptolemy interrupted his thoughts, “I really should get back to work.” He pointed with his pen at the papers.

“And I should get to studying,” Phainon agreed. He held the books up with a smile, already tucking away that turmoil.

He started walking to the door reaching for the latch.

“Deliverer… Phainon,” Ptolemy called.

Phainon paused with his hand on the metal and turned to look at the Kremnoan over his shoulder with a questioning tilt of his head.

“’For a friend with an understanding heart is worth no less than a brother,’” he quoted, fiddling with the pen again, “Thank you for swapping stories with me.”

“It was my honor.”

-

Mydei’s claws glanced across Hephaestion’s small shield with a grating screech offensive enough to wake Fig Stew from his afternoon nap to glare daggers at the pair from his sunny spot on a crate. The spear that lashed out from beneath it kissed the Captain’s belt at the hip but he danced away before it could bite flesh.

Hephaestion grinned and pressed his advantage. He was light on his feet, not as fast as Leonnius, but agile enough to keep pace with Mydei and fierce enough to have earned his place by his Prince’s side. His spear swung in from the side, the blade of it whistling all the way up until it was stopped by shining gauntlets.

Mydei twisted his arm to grab the weapon and pulled Hephaestion in close, but that shield blocked his claws again when they reached for his first mate’s face.

“Have you decided then?” Krateros asked again from the side, continuing their conversation about Phainon. He was leaning against a barrel next to Fig Stew’s crate, arms crossed and one leg folded over the other at the ankle. The old teacher was only half paying attention to the spar as they danced across the upper deck.

“No,” Mydei said firmly and then dodged under another strike.

“The longer you delay the worse the outcome,” the teacher scowled, “this is the time for swift and decisive action.”

Mydei growled angrily and lashed out at Hephaestion with a kick right in the middle of that damned shield. The force of the blow drove the first mate back and bought them both time to take a breath.

“And what would you have me do, teacher? Snap his neck as a reward for his loyal service these past few days?”

“Yes,” Krateros returned, “do not call him loyal. You are already confusing his self-preservation for loyalty. He is playing you, Prince.”

Mydei cracked his knuckles by pressing his fist into his palm and repeating the action on the other side.

“For what it’s worth,” Hephaestion said, “I like Phainon. He offered respect to Chryseus Leo without demand and treats the crew as equals without judgement.”

That *did* matter to Mydei. He was more inclined to believe Krateros if Phainon simply went through the motions, following instruction and nothing more. But every time Mydei turned to watch the man, Phainon was doing something helpful unasked. He never tried to draw attention to his actions either, he simply did them because he could. Phainon genuinely wanted to help and he gave his all in everything he did.

“He is a manipulative, duplicitous Okheman,” Krateros reiterated, “there is nothing he does or says that can be trusted."

“Except he is not,” Mydei reminded, “he is from Aedes Elysiae.”

“An isle that no longer exists, Mydeimos. He serves the Goldweaver and has for long enough to have a reputation, to be called their *Deliverer*. From whom do think they believe him to deliver them from?”

“We have no conflict with Okhema.”

“Only the King may declare as such,” Krateros huffed. It was an obvious jab and Mydei very nearly took the bait, but Hephaestion saved him from that mistake by throwing his spear. The metal head glinted in sunlight, and he was easily able to dodge when he saw the light flash in the corner of his eye.

Hephaestion was already rushing in with his shield, keeping low to chase Mydei from the same side as his spear sticking into the deck.

The shield met Mydei’s gauntlets, and he threw Hephaestion back.

“Castrum Kremnos no longer exists, there can be no conflict with Okhema,” he growled instead, stomping his foot for emphasis.

“Have you forgotten our people still waiting in settlements beside the sea? Or your crew here on this ship? Are they not the spirit of Castrum Kremnos and Nikador's chosen?” Krateros paused but only for a second. He met Mydei’s glare with a steady gaze. “And do you believe Okhema feels the same? A pretty face and you already forgot that he was sent here to hunt us, to hunt *you.*”

Mydei scoffed and pulled the spear from the deck. He expertly spun it around his body until it settled across his shoulders with his wrists draped across the shaft.

“How long will you harbor this resentment, teacher?” he said with a softness to the edges, a genuine sadness.

“If you will not see him as the enemy he is, then I will deal with the Goldweaver’s spy myself,” Krateros threatened.

Mydei felt the twist in his heart, a burning anger as his hunch was validated. He was right to leave Phainon in the brig for his own protection. Krateros wasn’t the only old guard on the ship who ached for revenge against Okheman’s Navy for long past grievances. They would treat Phainon as a proxy for all of Okhema’s armies if Mydei let them.

It felt hypocritical to reject their desire for revenge when it was Mydei himself who ripped the heart from his father’s chest. That had been about vengeance too, no matter what he told himself, but Phainon had yet to hurt anyone, had yet to prove himself an enemy.

Mydei saw Phainon and saw hope for a future that he had yet to consider for his people.

“This is my order to you Krateros, you will leave him be,” Mydei growled, “the Deliverer is mine to do with as I see fit and I take full responsibility for his actions, even those he has yet to take. If he becomes a danger to our people, as you are so convinced he will be, then I will hang him from the mast myself.”

Chapter End Notes

10 points to anyone who can figure out what Ptolemy is quoting

Chapter 5: Fishing with the Competition

Chapter Summary

I wonder whose turn it is to bond with Phainon this time

I'm trying to update every other day or so while I still have steam. I really wanted to write this chapter yesterday but I ended up too busy. :')

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

All was fire and smoke. It burned Phainon's lungs, melted his flesh while he screamed. The agony that started in his toes spread until it consumed him entirely, and when he was certain this was the end of him, a blackness swallowed him up. The fire was replaced by ice but still his lungs burned. Every breath was devoid of air as water rushed inside him on every inhale.

He was about to drown and then Phainon was very suddenly awake, choking and gasping. He sat upright and tried to summon his sword, but it didn't come, still locked up tight from when it was confiscated on day one.

Those wide blue eyes darted around in the dark, from his empty hand to the steel bars, and finally to Leonnius. The Kremnoan was crouched down on one knee with a hand through the bar, hovering over the spot that Phainon's foot had occupied prior to waking. They watched each other while Phainon caught his breath and his eyes adjusted to the light.

It was so early in the morning that nothing but black trickled in from above, the only light was from the extra lantern on the floor where Leonnius had put it.

"Oh good, you're awake," he said softly, like he hadn't just woken Phainon up himself.

"Wha?" Phainon managed. His heart was still racing. Short hair, a playful smile, and scars under his right eye and over his nose made for a memorable face. He had met Leonnius before, but it had been a brief interaction at dinner and under the influence of a rough night of sleep Phainon struggled to remember his name. "Leonnius?"

"I got the key from Hephaestion last night." Leonnius held the cast iron key up on its ring.

"…It's the middle of the night, go back to *bed*," Phainon whined.

"We've got stuff to do."

"*We?*"

“Ptolemy said that you’re nice to a fault so you can’t so no,” Leonnius said as he stood up straight to unlock the door. It swung open with a soft squeak, but Phainon was already covering up with his blanket again, hiding his whole head under the covers.

“No,” he huffed, in defiance of Ptolemy.

Leonnius leaned against the bars and sighed dramatically, “Cold, but that’s fine, this is a pretty big chore, you probably couldn’t do it anyway.”

Phainon twitched.

“I’ll just have to ask Hephaestion or maybe even Mydeimos to give me a hand.”

Another twitch and Phainon sat up with a groan. He roughly reached for his boots and yanked them on. Leonnius handed him his shirt and helped him stand.

“You’re gonna want your bracers too.”

“What are we doing?” Phainon grumbled. He slipped his shirt on over his head but left his coat and cape behind.

“It’s cloudy, early, and chilly, which is the best time for fishing,” Leonnius explained. He was helping Phainon with the armguards, way too chipper for the early hour as he strapped them down and then fixed the high collar of Phainon’s v-neck for him.

Oh, well, that explained being awake so long before entry hour. Fishing was easiest right at dawn.

Leonnius recovered the lamp from the floor when he was sure Phainon was awake enough to stand on his own, which was generous considering the way he swayed with the ship. Phainon was still working on his sea legs, this tired it was a tall order asking him to walk in a straight line, but he at least managed to keep up and every step came with more lucidity. Until he slammed into Leonnius’ back on the stairs. The Kremnoan had paused briefly when they turned the corner and saw who was waiting for them at the top.

Fig Stew’s eyes reflected the lamp, glimmering in the dark and framed by dim lamplight. His tail stood straight up, vibrating for a few seconds.

“What’s he doing?” Phainon asked.

“Being impatient.”

Leonnius sighed and walked up to Fig Stew who happily led them both to the upper deck where a tired helmsman waved at them from the tiller. The sails were rolled up tight, but the ship still drifted on currents. The tiller had to be watched at every hour. Both newcomers gave him an acknowledging nod and then set up back by the aplustre.

“Okay so,” Leonnius started, “see this?” He kicked at a big, long storage box built along the side railing. “There’s one on the other side too.”

Phainon gave the side a kick and was rewarded with a hollow sounding thud. He hadn't realized these were containers. They looked more like benches or wide steps running along each side not quite the full length of the upper deck.

Leonnius leaned down and felt along the shallow lip, searching for the stiff hooks to undo it. "The latches stick a little sometimes." The same hooks that kept the storage space closed also hooked to the railing to hold the lid open. Leonnius walked the length of one side, opening each section in turn and securing the lid in place. Piled high inside was a collection of fishing equipment, everything from massive, weighted nets to harpoons to long pole fishing hooks, buckets, rope, and so on.

"The same stuff is on the other side," the Kremnoan was explaining, "have you ever fished with nets before?"

"No," Phainon said, "most of my fishing experience was your standard rod fishing from a dock back home."

"Well, this is nothing like that. You sure you'll be up for it?"

"Of course," Phainon insisted with determined expression.

"Great, cause trawling is pretty easy, and we can make a game of it."

Phainon was already interested.

Leonnius pulled out the net and started dumping it onto the deck. It was peculiarly shaped, conical with a wide mouth. One edge was lined with corks; the other was lined with bronze weights. Where they met at either end was a wooden plate fitted with bronze and attached to ropes. Phainon hurried to grab a handful of it, pulling it out to stretch across the deck and make more space for the rest.

"You've probably seen it done with two boats or two people on a shoreline," Leonnius was explaining, "but it's really easy off the back of one boat and we're going the right speed for it. All we do is throw the net over, wait for a bit, and then pull it back up full of fish."

"…that's it?"

"That's it." Leonnius started to point to parts of the net. "This line of corks helps this edge float, while this longer loop is weighted to sink, so it opens up like a mouth under the water." He pointed to where the net narrowed and became more fine with a tighter weave. "The fish get funneled back into the tighter part of the net where they get tangled up and trapped."

Phainon picked up one of the attached planks. "What's this for?"

"They're like wings. They catch the water as it moves past them and spread apart, pulling the net open from side to side under the water. Without them the net would just pinch closed."

Phainon followed the ropes from the planks to where they met, tying together into one rope that they would presumably use to pull the net up to the deck. "It's like flying a kite."

Leonnius beamed. “Yeah, underwater and full of fish, but yeah, it’s kind of like a kite.”

Fig Stew mewled from the crate and stomped a paw, demanding they both look at him before Leonnius patted Phainon’s arm. “The taskmaster has spoken. Do you think you can finish getting this net set up while I get the other one?”

“Yeah,” Phainon reassured him, now that he had a basic understanding of how this was going to work it didn’t seem too hard to get set up.

Leonnius patted him on the shoulder and then went to the starboard side to start pulling out the netting. Now that Phainon was pulling the net apart to check for tangles or detached corks and weights it was easier to tell how big it was. What seemed irrationally massive before was really a second layer. The inside of the conical part of the net was doubled up to make it sturdier and to more effectively trap thrashing fins. Spread out, each net was small enough to be cast at the same time as the other without tangling due to the width of the ship itself. He unwound the long ropes, making sure that when they went over the railing, they couldn’t tangle themselves. Lining the rope up without overlapping so that it moved back and forth in a line was safer than leaving it in a coil.

“Toss me that line,” Leonnius called while pointing to the single end rope. Phainon swung it a few times and then tossed it over. The Kremnoan tossed it over his shoulder along with his own and then jogged over to the shrouds. Of everyone that Phainon had met on the ship, Leonnius was hands down the most sure-footed. They hadn’t worked the lines side by side yet, but Phainon had seen Leonnius running the deck and racing up the shrouds to fix snagged ropes. Not once had he seen the man stumble. Even now as he carried the two heavy ropes across the yard, he was walking as though it were a sunny day on a stone road.

Leonnius straddled the yard beneath him for balance while he looped the ropes through pulleys on their respective sides of the aftermast. Then he tossed them both down to Phainon who properly split them up on their matching sides of the tiller. He started pulling his rope through the pulley, leaving himself a generous amount to eventually throw overboard with the net.

“Loop it through that pulley too,” Leonnius ordered. The man was as fast as he was sure-footed, already next to Phainon in a flash and pointing to where the aftermast met the upper deck. There were other smaller pulleys there. This one only had one groove, so it would need to be kept taut to avoid slipping. Phainon had made that mistake once. Never again. Once more, Leonnius matched him on the other side.

“Are you a gambling man, Phainon?” Leonnius called to him as he tied the end of the loose rope to a tie off near the railing.

“Depends,” Phainon answered with a grunt as he looped the rope one extra time for good measure.

“If you pull up more fish than I do,” Leonnius started to say as he gathered up his net, “I’ll give you a tip on how to win favor with Fig Stew.”

Phainon smiled, “and if you win?”

“You take my shift polishing shields in the armory.”

With how stingy that chimera’s heart was, that felt like a steal.

“Leonnius, you have yourself a deal,” Phainon said. And then they both shoved their nets into the ocean just as pink started to color the clouds. The ropes whirred and the pulleys spun as the organized coils disappeared over the railing. Phainon bounced away before the rope could snap taut with a *twang*. The knot held even when the pulleys groaned. The sea splashed around the ropes that dragged in the water and Phainon worried just a little bit as he peered over the railing into the inky black that he had missed a step and his net hadn’t properly opened.

Leonnius had confidently stepped away from his railing and taken up a spot next to Fig Stew to wait. The chimera was pacing along the top of the crate in even prancing circles.

“How long do we have to wait?” Phainon asked as he wandered over too. The impatience was contagious.

“How ever long you think you should,” Leonnius said with a smile.

The spirit of competition stirred in Phainon a bit. “I could just leave my net in all day.”

“And risk the line breaking? If you can’t pull the net up at all, then you’ll have to concede,” Leonnius said in a sing song voice and Phainon’s brows furrowed in thought.

The net had seemed sturdy, but the man was right, the net wouldn’t hold up if he scooped up something particularly big or strong and whatever he did get would need to be hauled up at all. The pulleys would offset most of the weight, but there was still the issue of pulling against the forward momentum of the ship and Phainon would still have to gauge what he could personally lift.

He reached out to offer his hand to Fig Stew who at least paused to consider it. The chimera sniffed Phainon’s fingers, gave him a little lick, and then mewled his disappointment and kept pacing.

“Is he feeling okay?” Phainon worried aloud.

“He’s waiting for his fish.” When Phainon tilted his head in an obvious question, Leonnius added, “any time we fish, Fig Stew gets first pick of the haul.”

“He’s really spoiled, huh?” he laughed.

“Oh, absolutely,” Leonnius agreed. He reached out to scratch Fig Stew’s sides and the chimera relented, rolling over to accept belly rubs from the Kremnoan.

Phainon thought he was being sneaky adding his hand to that soft belly fluff while Leonnius was keeping the critter distracted but not a second after the pads of his fingertips touched fur there were teeth in the meat of his thumb.

“Ow!” He recoiled and cradled his injured hand with a pout. Was Fig Stew *smiling* at him?

“Damn, still not worthy huh?”

“I thought the Captain made that up…”

Leonnius smiled sympathetically and turned his own hand over. There were two little scars across his palm, two thin lines. “I think everyone on the ship except Mydei have matching scars.”

Fig Stew resumed his eager, excited pacing with his tail straight up and vibrating the whole time.

Phainon very tentatively sat back down. “Does he belong to the Prince then?”

“I don’t think Fig Stew really belongs to anybody,” Leonnius admitted, “I know he favors the Prince but there’s history there.”

That was one of Phainon’s favorite words, history. “Is it the kind of history you could share with an Okheman?” He batted his eyelids for good measure.

“What do you think, Fig Stew? Do we tell the evil Okheman about you?” Leonnius asked as he leaned on the crate.

Fig Stew gave Leonnius an affectionate headbutt and then turned around to bless him with his butt in what seemed to be chimera approval.

“Fig Stew lived in the palace of Castrum Kremnos,” Leonnius said as he scratched that fluffy face, “and slept at the feet of Queen Gorgo.”

Phainon’s jaw dropped just a little bit. He recovered quickly enough not to be embarrassing. He knew that chimeras could live a very long time, but he didn’t know the ages of the chimeras that lived around Okhema. Meeting one that was older and from such a prestigious background felt special, perhaps a little humbling.

“A royal Kremnoan,” Phainon praised, “no wonder he’s so elegant and handsome.”

Fig Stew trotted across the crate to Phainon’s side and sat down with his chest puffed out, his head tilted back, and his eyes closed to bask in the praise.

“Surely, he is the fluffiest of all Chimeras.”

“A King among them, even,” Leonnius agreed, “Nikador envies his spirit.”

“I can see why, look at those perfect ears and mane. Even the hundred thieves of Dolos couldn’t hope to steal enough treasures to be worthy of him.”

The purrs were making the crate shake and Phainon had to put a hand on it to steady it.

“Supposedly, Fig Stew was there when the Prince was born,” Leonnius said, “instant friends. When we joined the detachment, Fig Stew was already there with Krateros, and when we

were getting close to finding Mydei, he was the one that leaped into the water to lead us to him. Oh, when he was a baby Mydei was-“

Phainon politely held a hand up, “ah, Ptolemy told me.”

“Oh, good, he’s a way better storyteller.” Leonnius scratched the base of Fig Stew’s tail and the chimera leaned happily into the scratches. “To Mydei, Fig Stew is what’s left of his mother, a way to be closer to her even though he barely got to know her. Well, he and Krateros’ stories.”

“Krateros is the old guy with the bad eye, right?” Phainon asked.

“Yeah. You… actually might not want to get to know him,” Leonnius admitted.

It was a puzzling piece of advice that made Phainon want to know the guy even more. “Why?”

“Krateros is old guard, like leader of the Godshield Brigade elite kind of old guard. He’s not a *bad* guy, he’s just very traditional and has a lot of combat experience.”

“Sounds like the best kind of guy to learn from.”

“Phainon,” Leonnius said with a shake of his head, “combat experience against Okhema.”

“Oh.”

“Yeah. There are actually a lot of people on the ship that aren’t really sure about you. There’s a lot of really bad blood here that comes from personal experience. You’re really friendly but maybe be a little more careful?”

It was unexpected advice. Phainon rarely met anyone that wasn’t receptive to his charms. Even the Council of Elders and his prickly professor had been swayed over time, but those were neutral parties, and Phainon was once again reminded of the animosity between Okhema and Castrum Kremnos. An animosity that made no sense to him anymore after his talk with Ptolemy.

“Are you one of those people, Leonnius?”

The man chuckled, “if I was, Hephaestion would never have given me the key to your cell. Honestly, what I’ve seen of you so far, I think you’re great.”

Phainon blushed and shyly reached up to scratch the back of his neck. “I don’t know about that.”

“Then prove me right.”

Leonnius got up and dashed over to his rope to give it a tug. “I don’t know about you, but I’m getting close.”

Phainon very suddenly remembered the competition and hurried to check his rope as well. The tight line was rough under his fingers when he gave it an experimental tug. With one hand it gave a little, but it was difficult to pull it very much. With two hands the rope started to lift with minimal effort. He could wait… it looked like Leonnius was debating as well. When Phainon peeked over, he saw Leonnius watching him with a small smirk.

It was urgent mewling that broke them out of their standoff. Even if they weren't ready, Fig Stew certainly was, which led to another internal debate. If Phainon pulled his net up first, he'd win favor with Fig Stew, but if he waited, he'd win his competition with Leonnius.

A splashing sound snapped him out of his thoughts. Leonnius was pulling his net up, those strong legs putting in the work as he walked backwards. The pulley creaked and squeaked as the net slowly but steadily lifted.

Phainon hurried to his own rope. In just the minute of deliberating it already felt heavier. They must've been sailing through a school. He wrapped the rope around his arm for leverage, very suddenly grateful for the advice to bring his armguards. The rough rope settled on the leather and spared his arms the chaffing as he pulled. The pulley stuttered for a second and then started to move. Phainon dug his heels in and held tight with both arms, feeling the tug of war as he fought the ocean and the fish to haul the net one inch at a time.

It was so much harder than he thought to pull those fish up. It would've been impossible without the pully system. The ship shifted in the water, and the swaying nearly knocked him over. Phainon's shoulder slammed into the railing, and he lost a bit of ground, but he got it all back with a determined growl and capitalized on the momentum to rip the top part of the net out of the water. The splashing of the struggling fish was a welcome sign of progress singing to his ears.

Leonnius was in a similar state, struggling with a wild grin that made Phainon realize the Kremnoan was approaching this the same way he would battle, with excited determination and tenacity. This was a demonstration of willpower and physical prowess as much as it was a task to be completed.

He didn't know exactly how long he struggled with the rope but by the time he managed to pull that net all the way out of the water, the clouds above were a lighter gray with the morning light hidden behind them and the crew starting to wake.

Phainon could see Leonnius out of the corner of his eye also struggling to get his net that last bit over the edge and then back up arrived. Right as Phainon slipped and almost lost the net entirely, another hand was on the rope.

Mydei had hurried to grab the rope just ahead of Phainon and was pulling with unfathomable strength. The muscles in his back were tense and defined, the flex of his biceps more than a little distracting as he pulled on the line. Ptolemy too was rushing to get a hand on the rough rope, coming in behind Phainon to grab the slack there, and the three of them easily pulled the fish up the rest of the way.

The net sloshed over the railing and hung from the pulley just over the deck, up close to the aftermast. The fish were still wiggling in the net, struggling against their bonds as they

gasped. As soon as the knot at the split in the rope stuck on the pulley and the net ceased to move farther, both Ptolemy and Mydei let go.

Phainon didn't realize that was the actual proper thing to do and most definitely did not do the same.

The net dropped to the deck, ripping Phainon forward. He slammed right into Mydei's back and the both of them were thrown under the mass of fish with a surprised shout and panicked scuffling.

Individually the fish and other collected odds and ends were not particularly heavy, the entire mass of them coming down were. Phainon immediately went down under them alongside the Captain where they both flailed for purchase. Someone thought fast and loosened the top of the net so the fish could spill across the top deck alleviating the weight and leaving the two of them waist deep in sea life.

"HKS!" Mydei snarled, "why didn't you let go??" He rolled over and sat up with seaweed in his hair and unhappy anchovies bouncing around in his lap. A handful of sardines were tangled in the loose fabric of his chiton and stuck in the metal of his pauldron.

Phainon's head was spinning. He was trapped on his belly, only the white of his hair sticking out of the sea of scales and fins. A swordfish was bouncing on his back, knocking the wind out of him with every landing until Mydei kicked it off with a heavy boot and then physically pulled Phainon up by the back of his shirt. Ptolemy was trying so hard not to laugh.

Across the deck, Hephaestion and Perdikkas had helped Leonnius lower his net without any casualties and all three of them were laughing so hard that Leonnius was having a hard time staying upright. They wandered over to where Mydei was physically shaking Phainon up and down, whether in punishment or to get the fish out of his clothing it was hard to tell. Probably a bit of both.

"Phainon," Leonnius was wheezing, "why didn't you let go?"

"I didn't know I was supposed to!"

And then everyone except Mydei and Phainon were laughing again.

Mydei let him go with an annoyed grumble and tried to wade to relative safety. He still nearly twisted his ankle slipping on a bream as he plowed through the mess of flopping fish.

"Leonnius," Hephaestion tried to say around a chuckle. He was holding it together better than most of them. "Did you not tell Phainon on purpose?"

"I swear, I really thought he knew!"

Phainon smiled and shook his head. He started stumbling out of the pile towards Leonnius, dropping to one knee briefly on the way. Phainon played it off like he fell, with one hand extended for balance, but the other scooped up a handful of sardines.

"Really I should have!" he laughed, "it's a silly thing that I didn't realize!"

He dashed at Leonnius and playfully shoved the fish inside his exomis, making the man jump and squeal in a manner that had everyone roaring with laughter again. Even Mydei was smiling with his arms crossed and his head slightly bowed.

“Now we’re even,” Phainon laughed.

“Not quite,” Leonnius said with a grin. He pulled the last of the sardines out of his clothing and tossed it back on the pile, then he gestured with his thumb over his shoulder to his net. It was keeping the fish contained even as it spread across the deck in a blob. “I pulled more in than you did.”

Phainon’s face fell.

“Did you bet on this?” Perdikkas asked.

“We certainly did,” Leonnius declared proudly, “have fun polishing shields, Phainon.”

Phainon tsked. “How can you possibly tell with my fish scattered across the deck?”

“What were the terms of your agreement?” Mydei asked from the railing.

“Whoever pulled up the most fish wins,” Leonnius told him.

Mydei kicked a fish out of the way to walk to the center of the deck so he could assess both piles. “Your nets are fairly even, not accounting for the sizes of each fish, I’d say you each pulled up the same weight.”

As if on cue, Fig Stew made his grand entrance. He jumped from his crate, ran up to Mydei to tackle the Captain’s legs affectionately, and then bounded through Phainon’s pile of fish. The happy chimera walked away with at least seven sardines crammed into his mouth.

“…Leonnius wins,” Mydei announced.

Phainon wanted to protest, surely counting the fish after Fig Stew had stolen his cut wasn’t fair! But the others were already laughing and Leonnius was offering his hand to shake.

“You put up a worthy fight,” he praised, “and it is an honor to be the one to have appeased Fig Stew.”

Phainon huffed a happy little huff and grasped Leonnius’ arm. “As did you. I’d like a rematch.”

“Anytime, Okheman.”

“You know you still have to gut and sort the fish,” Hephaestion offered.

“That’s true. Are you any good with a filet knife, Phainon?”

“Oh, I have some experience,” he said. They were still shaking hands and smiling at each other, gripping the other’s arm a little tighter and a little tighter the longer they held on.

“Whatever gets these fish cleaned up the fastest,” Mydei grumbled, “it would be nice to walk across my deck again.”

“Then let us help,” Perdikkas offered, “would you two be amenable to partners for your competition?”

Phainon considered that for a moment. “I don’t mind, as long as the teams are fair.”

“’Many hands make light work,’” Ptolemy said in the monotone recital voice he used for quotes.

“Then I will be on Phainon’s side,” Hephaestion offered and Leonnius whistled.

“What did we just say about fairness?” he complained.

“I suppose the only way to balance these teams would be if His Highness would help Leonnius,” Perdikkas mused out loud. Everyone turned to look at Mydei.

“Do you really think so little of yourself Perdikkas, to assume you are no match for this Deliverer?” he said with a dismissive wave of his hand.

Phainon’s eyes glittered playfully, and he shrugged, “It’s alright if the Captain doesn’t want to risk losing to an Okheman. Does His Highness even know how to clean a fish?”

Every other Kremnoan on deck hummed a soft ‘ohhhh’ under their breath as they looked between Mydei and Phainon. Phainon who was standing confidently with a teasing, cheeky grin, knowing full well that he was poking the beast and Mydei who had barely reacted aside from tightening his own grip on his crossed arms.

Mydei mumbled something under his breath in Kremnoan and Ptolemy, who was next to him, snickered. “If you need me to personally humble you, Deliverer, then so be it.”

The four of them waited near their piles of seafood, until Ptolemy and Perdikkas could secure a few empty barrels, a couple buckets, and a small table. By then, word had gotten around and the rest of the crew were procrastinating their duties to sneak peeks at the competition. Some of them were watching from the shrouds, others were sneaking around to watch from the aplustre, but everyone was excited. Even Fig Stew wandered back after finishing his treat.

Perdikkas stood in front of the four men. “The middle barrel is for sardines, anchovies, and the other small fish. Each team has a barrel for cleaned breams, swordfish, and any other big fish. That’s gutting, scaling, the works. The buckets are for the discarded parts. The team that completely sorts and preserves their pile first wins.”

“What if we fill the barrel before we finish the pile?” Phainon asked.

“We don’t have the space to save all of it,” Leonnius admitted, “anything that doesn’t fit in the barrels we’ll toss over the side.”

“Any other questions?” Perdikkas asked.

“Are there any stakes in this competition?” Mydei inquired, “or is this only for bragging rights?”

“Does the Captain need anything more than that?” Phainon teased.

The Prince twitched and turned his head to look at him. “Are you afraid of what I may ask for when you lose?”

“It didn’t even cross my mind that we would lose,” he returned, locking eyes.

“Funny, I assumed you were already used to it.”

Hephaestion coughed to stop them. “Perhaps we should get started?”

“Leonnius,” Mydei said without breaking eye contact, and the runner stepped right up, “I will do all the gutting and scaling. I’m trusting you to sort the fish.”

Leonnius saluted.

“Hephaestion,” Phainon called while he kept eying Mydei with a playful smirk, “we’ll do the same. I’ll clean the fish.”

Ptolemy set two filet knives on the table, cleared his throat, and said, “My triumph always be yours… Begin!”

They were off in a flash. Phainon immediately snatched a big fish from the pile before he went to the table to scoop up the knife. He cut off the fins in clean swipes, then one clean slit down its belly and he was pulling the guts free. If he wasn’t so focused on winning it might have been gross. He hadn’t done this since he was a boy when his father taught him how to clean and cook his catches from the dock.

Across from him, Mydei had already trimmed his first fish and was almost done scaling it. Phainon looked up in confusion when he saw that Mydei had skipped slitting its belly. He was about to flag a judge when he saw the man expertly cut the fish along the gill… and pull out all the insides in one go. The fish was tossed into Mydei’s barrel, and Leonnius, as fast as he was, already had the next one in front of him.

He may have underestimated Mydeimos.

The next hour was a flurry of scales, fish guts, and runners. Leonnius was easily the fastest man on the ship, but Hephaestion made up for the lack of speed with efficient tenacity. Mydei and Phainon always had their next fish lined up and ready, with no down time.

“You’re better with a knife than I thought,” Phainon complimented while they worked.

“You’re not so bad yourself. A month of working in the galley and you might compare to me,” Mydei teased, smirking while his eyes glittered. He tossed another fish into his barrel.

Phainon wanted to be mad, but the banter didn’t make him angry so much as light a fire in his blood. There was something so invigorating about the competition. Competing with Leonnius

had been fun but there was an energy that Mydeimos brought to the table that was so different. The playfulness was elevated into something so much fiercer and wild. More than anything else Phainon wanted to win, and he could see that Mydei did too.

The Captain was meeting Phainon's eagerness with his own at every step until they were pushing themselves faster and faster. Twice he had to slow down when he almost cut himself, and once he had to redo a fish because he forgot to scale the other side. And every time, Mydei would smirk with glee like a warrior that had found the chink in an enemy's armor on the battlefield. But for every mistake Phainon made, so did Mydei. That confidence led to tiny errors that needed to be fixed. Not every kind of fish could be gutted through the gills, not every fish cleaned easily, and while Mydei had the advantage in experience, Phainon matched him in fighting spirit and willpower.

It was the second quint of the action hour, clouds still covered the sky, a pale gray, plenty of light to see the last fish drop in each barrel just as both Mydei and Phainon declared simultaneously, "Done!"

Spectators cheered but both Mydei and Phainon were staring at Ptolemy and Perdikkas who leaned in close to whisper to each other. Hephaestion and Leonnius pressed in close with their respective teammates. As close as the race had been, this fell to the judges to decide.

"After discussing it amongst ourselves," Ptolemy started.

"We decided to call in an expert to determine the winner," Perdikkas finished. He waved his hand down at Fig Stew who happily hopped up onto the table to be more easily seen.

The chimera calmly strode across the table, head held high, steps regal, to peer into both barrels. He fished around with his paws and pulled a fish out of Mydei's barrel. The men started to cheer and Mydei crossed his arms, staring Phainon down with a smug look until Fig Stew went to Phainon's barrel and the smirk dropped. The cheering turned into confused mumbles before silence descended on everyone like a held breath.

More pawing.

Fig Stew pulled a fish out of Phainon's barrel and put it on top of the one he had grabbed from Mydei's. Both fish were the same size as the chimera. He struggled to hold both of them in his mouth at the same time, needing to hold them by what was left of their tails. He waddled with them both, stance wide to straddle his prize as the fish dragged between his legs. Everyone watched him go in stunned silence as he dropped the fish off the table, grabbed them again, and resumed his dignified waddle through the sea of spectators until he was out of sight.

Mydei and Phainon watched him go with loosened jaws and dumbfounded expressions.

"I guess that means it's a tie," Hephaestion laughed, and the silence broke into cheers.

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The only hint that Mydei was annoyed by the outcome was his insistent order that everyone finish cleaning up. Not even he could question Fig Stew's ruling. He had grumbled about the fish smell and then disappeared to do his own chores, whatever those may have been, while Phainon and Leonnius got to work packing the nets away. There was a special way to do it, Leonnius had insisted, to ensure that they would be easy to use the next time they needed to fish.

Hephaestion and Ptolemy handled the barrels with a couple others on the crew. The fish would be preserved in oil or salt at the discretion of the head cook, who would inevitably be the one to serve it to them eventually.

With things put away, Phainon followed Leonnius and the others below decks to follow Mydei's second and most important order. Fresh water was limited on the ship, but Mydei had expressly ordered that anyone who had participated in the morning escapade bathe, and not a single person argued with the demand. No matter how tired they were, all of them were eager to wipe themselves clean.

A communal bathing area was easy to set up in the crew's living quarters with a changing area and a place to dump their dirty clothes until someone (probably Phainon) could get around to washing them. Phainon helped them fill several washbasins while Leonnius passed out sponges and towels.

It wasn't the same as a bath at the Marmoreal Palace, but the water was warm from sitting in the barrels and it felt good running down his arms, his chest, and back. The sponge was soft and gentle; they even had sweet smelling soap and oil. Phainon didn't even mind sharing the space with his new friends.

"I am so glad that I woke you up this morning, Phainon," Leonnius said cheerfully.

"You know what, Leonnius," Phainon said with a smile, "so am I."

Even if it did mean the rest of his day would be spent polishing shields.

Chapter End Notes

I realized I've been using a lot of technical terms and not everyone wants to google things in the middle of reading, so I put some terms in here just in case!

Exomis – tunic that leaves one shoulder exposed
Aplustre – The curved part of the back of a Greek trireme
Bow – Front of a ship
Stern – Back of a ship
Aftermast/Aftmast – The third mast from the bow
Yard – the part of the mast that the sails are hung from, the beam that runs perpendicular to the mast

Chapter 6: Storms

Chapter Summary

Updating the tags with this chapter
New tags: PTSD, Minor Injuries

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Overcast skies that lured fish closer to hungry nets were also an opportunity to restock on fresh water. So Phainon wasn't even kind of surprised to see the crew tightening the ropes that held empty and half full water barrels against the railing to catch the expected drizzle. They were sealing up the belly of the ship as best they could too, covering the cargo hatch so the water couldn't get below and clearing out the scuppers to improve drainage.

Under the protection of the Dawn Device and the eternal day, storms and rain were a light affair in Okhema, welcome moisture for the plants along the coast but rarely anything of concern. In these farther seas, where night still shared the sky with the sun, it was harder to tell if this was a blessed raid, or the prelude to a harsher melody.

The seas themselves were choppy but not alarmingly so and the sails were already furled when Phainon finished polishing that last shield, handed it to the ship's Armorer to lock up in the Armory, and headed sleepily to bed. He had underestimated the sheer number of shields to polish and had to eat while he worked. Leonnius had at least brought him one of the grilled fish cooked on a stick to perfection and Ptolemy had sat with him to start working on Kremnoan phrases. Phainon could very proudly now say, "hello, my name is Phainon" with a very heavy accent.

It was dark when he flopped on his bed and Hephaestion locked him in. Someone had cleaned his fishy clothing and left them on a crate nearby, but he was too tired to change out of his borrowed exomis and instead spread out on his mat facedown like a starfish.

This had been one of those days that had Phainon questioning his mission. Despite the chaos of everything, a couple very key things stuck in the forefront of his mind.

The first was what Leonnius had said about being too friendly. As much as Phainon understood why he had been given that advice, it still hurt to hear. But maybe he needed the wake-up call. It was easy to forget that he was a fleeting person on this ship. Hell, Phainon was literally sitting in a cage in the brig because there were people that didn't trust him.

And they were right not to.

When they eventually made it to a port and Phainon left the ship, he'd return to Okhema with way more information than he had expected to have. Even if he wanted to protect the Kremnoan Detachment, Aglaea's threads would read his lies and know if he held back. Even if she could be swayed to understand, the Council would not. What Phainon saw as proof of peace, they would see as an opportunity.

For all he knew, they *did* know that Eurypon had been killed and were waiting for news about the state of Castrum Kremnos. Aglaea's fleet had been growing, maybe they were waiting for exactly the information Phainon would bring to them, that the Kremnoans were King-less, waiting on a young man that didn't seem interested in continuing their conflict. Would the Council of Elders seek them out? Destroy them once and for all while Mydei's people were scattered?

Aglaea had a vested interest too. She was still seeking coreflames. The prophecy that fueled her Flame-Chase Journey said that they were the key to the Black Tide. The only chance of long-term prosperity included retrieving the Coreflame of Strife, the last known whereabouts of which was Castrum Kremnos, supposedly in the care of Kremnoan priests. What better time to invade than when the city was leaderless?

The second thing that lingered in the forefront of Phainon's mind was admittedly less noble and more self-indulgent. The sheer relief and joy that he had felt when he thought that fishing net was going to win and Mydeimos' jumped on the line to help him.

Phainon felt his cheeks grow warm as he thought about Mydei's back and arms and the definition of his muscles and the strength of his spirit as they pulled together. There was something charming about how well they worked together, how easily they fell into that rhythm even when they stood on opposing sides, and Phainon really wanted to spend more time with him.

Mydei's friends were quick to share things about him, they had an eagerness for Phainon to understand their best friend, and the more he learned and the more he stood in the Prince's presence the more he wanted to. It was a budding curiosity, Phainon told himself, nothing more. A chance for peace between their nations. Others were certain he would become King someday, surely it was Phainon's duty to get to know the Crown Prince as a proper Ambassador, before they went their separate ways.

It was a happy bonus that the man was easy on the eyes.

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Creaking lumber and battle instincts saved Phainon's life. The ship listed violently to one side and the crates in his cell shifted as he jolted awake and sprang to his feet just as the supplies slammed against the bars, taking his sleeping mat with them.

It took him a very long second to process what was happening. Phainon hadn't remembered falling asleep and now he was very awake and very concerned.

The ship lurched the other direction and the crates slid again, this time taking him along too. His fingertips brushed the bars, but he fell down the slope of the tilting ship before he could

grab them and landed painfully against the edge of a box. Both of his boots followed, slamming into his stomach and face. The hanging lanterns were fighting for their lives. One of them broke free when the ship lurched back again. It crashed against the wall and sputtered out in the couple inches of water that was soaking the floor. Rainwater streamed from above, leaking through the cover over the grate.

Phainon hurried to pull his boots on and scrambled in the dark for his shirt and pants. He had been too tired to take off his bracers, which was a boon, when a barrel in his cell nearly rolled over him and he had to support its weight with his arms before he could wiggle free. Thunder shook the whole ship and Phainon felt his blood run cold. The ship shifted violently again, and he slammed into the bars of his cage. If the ship went down and he was trapped in here…

He waited until the ship was level for a few seconds and then tried to kick at the door to break the lock. Another lurch and he stumbled. Then tried again, then again, every kick the door clanged but held firm.

“Hephaestion!” Phainon yelled but there was predictably no response. It was almost impossible to hear anything over the sound of crashing waves, thunder, and rain. The roar of the sea was a battle cry against the Chryseus Leo, swallowing his pleas.

“Leonnius!” he tried. “Anybody!”

A box broke into splinters next to him when it crashed against the steel bars. He raised an arm to protect his eyes and fought to stay upright, so he could again slam his boot helplessly against the door of his prison, hard enough to feel the vibrations all the way up his spine.

“Mydeimos!” he yelled, desperate and praying.

A yowl responded. Clinging to the bottom most stair was Fig Stew. All his little claws were dug deep into the wood, holding tightly as those red eyes darted between Phainon and the floor covering puddle.

His heart and face fell seeing the chimera in distress. Phainon tried to kick the door again and snarled angrily when it didn’t give. He held tightly to the bars.

“You need to find somewhere safe, Fig!” he yelled, but the chimera was still trying to brave that final step. A peal of thunder rolled through them and Phainon worried it would startle him but the animal seemed to find courage in the sound. Unbothered by the crack and roll that hurt Phainon’s ears, Fig Stew was infinitely more upset with the rocking of the ship.

He waited until the ship leveled out and then dashed into the puddle, plowing through the water towards Phainon. Halfway between the bars and the stairs, the ship stuttered and tilted again, and Fig Stew traveled the rest of the way through the air.

The chimera popped right between the bars and into Phainon’s arms as the man hurried to catch the little guy. Phainon cradled the chimera to his chest, holding tightly and stroking his fur.

“It’s okay,” he muttered reassuringly, making a soothing shhh sound as he did. “I’ve got you, you’re okay.”

But Fig Stew was on a mission, and he wiggled his way loose enough of Phainon’s tight grip to slap him across the face without claws to make the man let go. He jumped from Phainon’s arms to the top of one of those sliding boxes and wiggled his tail back and forth to make the key jingle on its ring.

“You might have saved my life,” Phainon said with a sigh of relief. He nearly dove on the key as Fig Stew set it down and held on tight with the rocking of the ship to fumble through his freedom. Reaching around to feel for the keyhole was genuinely difficult to do while also dodging debris but he managed and Phainon left it in the lock while he raced out of the cell towards the stairs.

He turned back at the entrance to the stair well to wait for Fig Stew, but the chimera must’ve known something he didn’t. The animal mewled at him and then disappeared deeper into the hold, running for a safe spot.

The ship rumbled again and Phainon stumbled to the upper decks. Before he stepped out into the hurricane winds, he could hear shouting and yelling. There were people out on deck, even as the ship tilted at extreme angles, they were pointing and shouting, trying to communicate over the wind and rain, using the dim light of morning cloud cover and the lightning to see what they were doing.

A series of flashes ripped across the sky and Phainon saw red sails fluttering haphazardly in the wind. The storm must’ve knocked them free. Left unfurled, they could tear and be lost, or worse, capsize the ship. Loose and broken lines whipped in the wind. Phainon could see others trying to catch them, to tie them down or use them to close the sails. There were some people in the shrouds, fighting with the heavy canvas.

He ran out on deck, stumbling the whole way to grab a rope that was flailing nearby with both hands. It very nearly ripped him off his feet and Phainon reached with his boot to hold onto the railing with his foot for leverage. A shout ripped from his throat when the rope slipped in his hands, tearing the flesh there, still he held on while his body strained. The tiniest lull in the wind bought him reprieve enough to pull the rope down enough to loop it around one of the tie off spots along the railing.

The ship slammed into a tall wave and tilted just as Phainon was getting back to his feet. He slammed into the railing beside him, and looped his arms around the rail, holding tightly as the tilt threatened to spill him over the side. The water below was black and full of malice. He stared at it wide-eyed as primal fear washed over him with the rain. It felt like the ocean was reaching for him, desiring him. A horrible voice ripped through the back of his mind, speaking in layers, the language of the Titans. He couldn’t understand the words, but the intent squirmed under his skin to settle inside his bones with familiar terror.

Very suddenly, Phainon was no longer on a ship. He could still feel the rain, but the horrible memories of his burning village were all encompassing. The black of the ocean smelled like smoke and the creaking of the ship was replaced with the screaming of his parents and crackling of a hungry fire. He hyperventilated at the rail, desperate to find himself.

A rough hand on his shoulder pulled him back to waking. Leonnius was looking at him with wide eyes, shouting something he couldn't hear. The man tossed a noose over Phainon's head and the chill in his bones was back, but Leonnius wiggled it over his shoulders and tightened it around his waist instead.

Phainon gave the lifeline a tug. He was tied to the mast now, a safety net in case the ocean reached for him again.

Leonnius shouted again but thunder cut him off. He slapped Phainon's cheek hard enough to clear whatever fog the Kremnoan had seen there and Phainon bounced back to the present. Above them one of the sails started to tear and Leonnius was off in a flash, scrambling up the shrouds and leaving Phainon to find another way to help.

He squinted in the rain, trying to make sense of the movement as he hiked up the deck against the wind. For a second, Phainon thought he saw gold glitter in the flashing lightning and he ran towards it.

Mydei was holding two different lines, one in each hand. His feet were sliding on the deck as he struggled to hold them while men worked from the shrouds. Phainon paused when the deck tilted and then ran when it tilted back, taking advantage of the temporary downhill to dive on one of those lines.

Mydei's amber eyes locked onto his for a second. The Captain didn't bother trying to yell at him as Leonnius had. He happily let go of the line that Phainon had grabbed and turned to focus on his own. Phainon wrapped the rope around his arm for the better grip, supporting the worst of the biting, water-logged lines over the hard leather of his bracers just as he had when fishing. This was notably harder than that had been.

Side by side with Mydei, Phainon had a better understanding of what was happening. The torn topsail needed to come down to the deck. The sail couldn't be furled the way it was ripped. Blinking through the rain he could see others on the yard trying to untangle the ropes so it could be safely lowered to the deck and secured. He and Mydei were holding the sail mostly closed which explained how damn hard it was when the wind was working against them.

A gust of wind pulled Phainon off balance and the rope pulled him forward but a strong arm around his waist held him steady until he found his footing again. Mydei was still holding the bulk of the weight on his line with one arm, using the other to steady them both.

Phainon studied the way he was standing and tried to copy it, widening his stance and digging in his heels. It helped until the ship listed again and Phainon's foot slipped, but Mydei once more grabbed him, holding him by the arm until he found his footing.

It was easy to understand in those little touches exactly what to do and Mydei was so in sync with Phainon's sways that the moment he felt those gauntlets on his arm, Phainon was able to correct, to hold his stance, listening without his ears as his confidence grew and that crushing fear morphed into a distant worry. Standing next to Mydei, Phainon felt like they were at war, standing together under one banner against an impossible enemy, with no hope of winning,

and not a single shred of hesitation between them. The odds didn't matter as long as they had breath and strength to hold on tight.

They held like that until the sail was gathered. Phainon could feel the pressure on the line ease but then it was unexpectedly gone entirely. He turned to look at Mydei with confusion when he heard the shout.

Phainon reacted first. He tackled Mydei, pressing his shoulder into the man's muscular chest and sending them both to the deck. The top sail crashed into the spot that Mydei had been standing, tearing through the railings on both sides of the ship. Phainon felt pain lance through his leg and held still where he lay across Mydei's chest.

Mydei's gauntlets grabbed at his shirt and shoulders, Phainon thought he could hear yelling but the only thing he could process was the sudden warmth below his knee.

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When Phainon had come crashing out of the gloom, the first thing Mydei felt was relief. It was the kind of feeling that he would've liked to contemplate further if the urgency of the situation hadn't taken priority. He was genuinely happy to see the man had somehow freed himself, was in awe of how he had braved the elements to help, and was deeply honored to stand next to him as he struggled.

Phainon was utterly hopeless on a ship tossed by rough seas. Mydei had seen the way he stumbled every damn day on this ship when the slightest breeze made the vessel wiggle. No sea legs to speak of, but despite that Phainon was here, beside him, holding tightly to a rope and doing his absolute best.

There was no need to communicate with words, every time Mydei reached for Phainon to steady him, the man responded perfectly to the touch and corrected himself. He saw those brilliant blue eyes taking in his own stance, mimicking him, striving to learn to be better, to meet Mydei on equal ground.

Their backgrounds, their statuses, nothing mattered to the storm aside from their matching indomitable wills. And for a heartbeat in that freezing rain, Mydei smiled at the thrill of the fight, the joy of standing shoulder to shoulder with someone of merit, and the poeticism of fighting against nature.

And then the rope went slack and in the second it took Mydei to realize what was happening, Phainon had slammed into him, sending them both across the deck. The wind was knocked out of him as his back hit the polished wood and again when Phainon landed across his body with his shoulder in Mydei's belly.

He lay there with the rain beating on his face for one held breath and then tried to sit up, but Phainon was still laying on him. His white hair was sticking to Mydei's chest with the rain, and he was barely moving.

Propped up on his elbows, Mydei could see the deck in splinters. If Phainon hadn't have knocked him away… Mydei tsked. He was immortal. Crushed by the sail would certainly

have been an unpleasant way to go but he would've woken up, complained to Perdikkas about the ache, and gone on with his day.

For Phainon to throw himself in harm's way to save him, either he didn't know, or he was acting on instinct. This wannabe hero really threw himself into danger for someone he should see as an enemy, as his captor.

"Deliverer," Mydei shouted but it was swallowed in the din. He grabbed at Phainon's shoulders and tried to shake him, but the man didn't spring to his feet as he had hoped. Lightning flashed and Mydei's eyes caught on gold running across the deck. Another flash and he could see the jagged piece of wood sticking out of Phainon's pant leg near the meat below his knee. It was too dark and the rain too heavy to see how bad it was.

He tsked and then the ship started tilting again. The dislodged sail groaned and slid but it didn't roll. For better or worse it had trapped itself in the railing when it broke through it on impact. Tangled as it was, they were unlikely to lose it over the side either.

Mydei wrapped an arm around Phainon, reaching across his back to hold on to his side under his arm, the other grabbed a handful of his shirt while the ship threatened to throw them to the sea. He could feel the man's heartbeat racing under his fingers, feel him gasp as they slid a few feet until Mydei was able to get his heel pressed against something solid.

"Take a breath," he ordered, not convinced Phainon could hear him. The man reached up and grabbed onto the fabric of Mydei's chiton near his hips, holding on tightly. It was a good sign that he was conscious and coming back to himself.

Leonnius dropped onto the deck beside them, kneeling. He had been in the shrouds helping to drop the sail not a second prior.

"Are you okay?!" he yelled, only a few inches from Mydei's ear and Mydei still barely heard him over the rolling peal of thunder.

"He's hurt," Mydei shouted back. He pointed to Phainon's leg. Leonnius waited for the ship to list again and then crept on his hands and knees to Phainon's injury.

Mydei tightened his grip on Phainon when he saw Leonnius reaching and he was glad he did cause the man tried to buck and recoil when Leonnius pressed on it. He tensed and quivered under Mydei's grip, fists tight where he was holding onto Mydei's clothes, as Leonnius ripped the plank free.

Phainon cried out and panted, curling his good leg up as he tried to relax while Leonnius tore the base of his own exomis to tightly bind the wound.

"It's not nearly as bad at it looks," Leonnius reported as he crept back up to Mydei, screaming in the rain. "Perdikkas will need to stitch it up for sure, but it went clean through the meat. It'll hurt but he can probably still walk on it without making it worse."

Mydei nodded and yelled, "Go help the others with that last sail."

“May victory be ours, Mydeimos,” Leonnius yelled and then he was gone, running off in the rain.

Mydei took a deep breath, let the ship rock, and then he pulled Phainon further up his body so he could be close enough to yell at him.

“Listen to me, Deliverer,” he shouted, and he saw Phainon’s eyes move, “your injury is such that it would only stop a weak man.” Those blue eyes narrowed. “Are you a weak man?”

Phainon grunted and started shakily pushing himself up. The ship lunged to one side and Phainon crashed back into Mydei, chest to chest, but Mydei used it to get a better grip on him, wrapping one arm around his back again and using the other to pull them both up. He kept his hold on Phainon tight until the man was pushing Mydei off and holding himself upright without help. Even so, Mydei reached out to grab his forearm so he could lean in to yell again.

“If you would be a hindrance to my crew, crawl below decks now, but if you can yet stand, come help me.”

Phainon squeezed back. He looked a little pale but that could’ve been the dim light and the blue of lightning. Mydei trusted Phainon to know his own limits. He reached for Phainon’s waist to test that the lifeline was tight and then they were hurrying across the deck.

The last sail that needed to come down was the foresail on the foremast. It was the sail closest to the deck, and it wasn’t torn yet. They just needed to tie it closed and then everyone could get to safety below decks to ride out the rest of the storm. There were already men aloft and Mydei spotted Hephaestion and Krateros already on lines. He turned and grabbed Phainon’s arm, pointing him towards Hephaestion before Mydei hurried to help Krateros.

Phainon already had a hard time walking across the deck, the limp wasn’t doing him any favors, but Mydei saw him nearly throw himself on the rope, take it in both arms and start pulling with just as much ferocity as he had before.

Very slowly, the sail furled, Mydei’s body was barely starting to ache as the cold pelted his mostly bare chest. No doubt there were scratches on his back from when Phainon had tackled him too. He was ready to be below decks with the others, so as soon as the last sail was secured, Mydei began herding people to cover. He was unwilling to go down himself until every man was safe.

Unsurprisingly, Phainon and Hephaestion were lagging behind. Despite the injury, Phainon was helping his first mate double check the ties, both the ones for the sails and the lines holding the tiller. Mydei hurried to do the same and when all three men were satisfied, they stumbled towards the stairs at the bow.

Hephaestion ducked into safety and shed his lifeline as Mydei turned to wait for Phainon. He undid the knot of the rope around his waist as he waited, tossing the lifeline to the side. They would just be an unnecessary hassle below decks with the limited length of rope tangling on everything.

Lightning cracked again and the sea was illuminated; a massive wave was rolling their way. Mydei gestured for Phainon to hurry and held tightly to the doorway himself, but the warning came too late. The wave picked up the stern and the ship tilted again with a sharp jolt. Mydei watched Phainon's injured leg give and he was thrown to the side. He hit the railing with a crunch and then his scrambling body went overboard.

With an urgent shout Mydei was hurrying to grab onto Phainon's lifeline, a lifeline that should've already gone taut, but the loose end was whipping by, racing out to sea with the man. He would have surely been lost if Mydei hadn't started running when he did. The Kremnoan dove on the end of the rope and pulled with desperation, holding on with his claws to the mere foot of remaining cord. He snarled and put his foot against the railing for leverage and yelled at the sky when the ship again tilted, nearly ripping him overboard too. Maybe he had taken his own lifeline off a little prematurely.

Someone slammed into Mydei's back and wrapped their arms around his waist, helping him pull, then another until they finally made progress and a soaking wet Phainon was reachable from the rail.

Hephaestion and Mydei each grabbed onto him and pulled him over to drop him on the deck and Perdikkas slid to his knees to press on his chest with firm pumps until Phainon was coughing and vomiting seawater.

Perdikkas helped him sit up when the ship tilted in their favor, grabbing one of the man's arms to throw over his shoulder. Mydei hurried to grab the other one and they half carried, half dragged Phainon below decks.

It was a tight squeeze, loud with people talking and shouting. Most of the crew were in a line with buckets, passing water from the hold up the stairs to dump on the main deck where it could drain through the scuppers. They weren't at any risk of sinking due to water getting below decks, but they didn't want the water to get above a certain threshold, lest it ruin their food supply.

Mydei shoved past most of them, following Perdikkas to the other end of the ship, to the warmth and dry of the infirmary with Phainon in tow. He kicked the door open and then dropped him onto the bed there with a gentle roll. He was still dazed, pale, and coughing, barely conscious.

"What the hell is happening out there?" Hephaestion said, "this storm came out of nowhere."

Mydei shook his head. "No, it's…"

"Hephaestion," Perdikkas said, cutting them off with other priorities, "help me get him out of his wet clothes, I need to see how bad that leg is."

They got to work while Mydei ran a hand anxiously through his hair. It hadn't really clicked until now how terrifying that was. He shouldn't have run back into the rain without his own lifeline attached, they could've both been lost at sea. Hephaestion and Perdikkas too had not been secured when they rushed to help. One more bad wave and the three of them assuredly

would have drowned and Mydei would've lost more than a few lives waiting to be found and fished out again.

He took a shuddering breath and a step backwards to give the doctor some space and just about rolled his ankle stepping on Phainon's lifeline. It was still attached to his waist, the rope trailing behind him like a tail.

He let his arm fall to his side as he followed the rope with his eyes to the unattached end. Amber smoldered in the lantern light, thunder rolled above them, but Mydei's entire focus was on that splayed end of rope. He dropped to one knee to pick up the end, running his thumb over the even fibers. His whole body started to shake with barely restrained rage.

The rope had been cut.

Someone had tried to kill Phainon.

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Perdikkas really wanted to tell Mydei to leave. Mydei could see it all over his face as he stood in the infirmary waiting patiently for Phainon to wake.

"Your Highness," Perdikkas finally said with stress in his voice, "I gave him poppy in his water, he's not going to wake for awhile."

Mydei tapped his fingers on his arm and stayed put anyway.

"I'll make sure he eats what you brought."

Still no movement.

"Are you worried someone is going to try and kill him while he's in here?"

Mydei's grip on his arms tightened.

"Ah ha," Perdikkas sighed and dumped the supplies he had been trying to sort back into the helpless pile on the floor. The storm had shaken everything up so badly that everyone was going to be on clean up and repair duty for a while. Poor Ptolemy hadn't stopped sobbing in the library doorway since the storm had stopped around the Lucid Hour. Which was saying something as the light of the thief star had just barely passed by overhead not even a quint past. Mydei had brought food for both Perdikkas and Phainon and was notably upset that Phainon was still sleeping.

"How bad was his leg?"

"Not bad," Perdikkas walked over to where Phainon was covered to pull back the blanket and lift the bandages. It was stitched up tight in two places. "The fragment went through but close enough to the edge of his leg that it barely went through the muscle. It bled a lot, but it will heal quickly and with few issues." He covered the leg again and gave Phainon's chest a gentle pat. The man was snoring lightly with a stupid smile on his face as he slept.

“Mydei, do you know who cut his lifeline?” Perdikkas asked softly.

“No, I don’t.” Mydei’s brow furrowed ever so slightly as he watched Phainon sleep. “And I will probably never know. It would be a fool’s errand to hunt for the culprit on behalf of a prisoner. The distrust would upset the veterans on the crew.”

“What are you going to do?”

“…I don’t know,” Mydei admitted, “For now, he no longer sleeps in the brig. He will sleep in my quarters.”

Perdikkas raised one eyebrow and Mydei looked away, perhaps a little shy about the suggestion no matter how confidently he ordered it.

“I told Krateros that I would take responsibility for him. It makes sense that I keep him close! This way I will be able to monitor his actions and if necessary, protect him.”

“You don’t need to explain yourself, Mydei. I think it’s a great idea.”

Chapter End Notes

New term:

Scuppers – drain holes along the deck so water won’t pool around the railings

Chapter 7: The Strength and Kindness of Strife

Chapter Summary

Everybody needs healing after that storm.

New tags: Medicinal Drug Use

Chapter Notes

I’m glad we’re all in agreement that Fig Stew is the best and yes, he’s in this chapter too.

My husband sails and he came through to correct my terminology and I had to sit there like, man idek what these words mean, I’m not doing that to my readers too. Turns out sailors really have whole other languages on the water so if there are sailors reading this, I know I'm mixing it up a bit, bear with me. The coherency of the story takes priority over naval term accuracy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Thanks to the poppy that Perdikkas had given him for the pain, Phainon had slept heavily for a full day and a half, only rousing to half consciousness for water and bathroom breaks at the urging of his doctor, who never once left him unattended. They even barred the infirmary door at night to lock it as a precaution.

When Phainon was finally, properly awake, Perdikkas sent Leonnius to fetch Mydei.

“Well, you wanted me to tell you when he woke,” Perdikkas said with a grin.

Mydei stood in the doorway of the infirmary with his brows pinched together and a meal in hand. He couldn’t decide if he needed to be worried or if he wanted to laugh.

Phainon was sitting up lopsided in bed, leaning heavily against the wall with one leg over the side of his bed and the other stretched out on top of the blankets like he was trying to claim as much space as possible. He had the dumbest grin on his face, glassy eyes, and was babbling like a child at Fig Stew. The chimera was bouncing back and forth in Phainon’s lap, climbing all over those strong, bare thighs while Phainon giggled when it tickled. Aside from his undergarments and an assortment of bandages across his chest, legs, and hands, the man wasn’t wearing anything at all.

He absolutely did not mind, as high as he was, and it gave Perdikkas better access to the awful bruises on his side.

“I thought you only gave him poppy the once…”

“I did,” Perdikkas insisted, “I didn’t think I gave him very much but it’s taking a long time to wear off.”

Phainon spotted Mydei and beamed like the sun, that dazzling smile so bright despite the late afternoon light trying to get in through the dusty windows.

“Captain!” he slurred, “come here! I have to tell you something important!”

Perdikkas raised a hand to cover his mouth to hide his smile and Mydei flashed him a suspicious look.

“Do you know of what he speaks?”

“I really don’t, Mydei. It has been an adventurous quint to say the least.”

Mydei set the bowl of sweet porridge down on the desk and cautiously walked over to Phainon’s side, pulling over Perdikkas’ stool as he went so he could sit down next to him.

“You should be resting, Deliverer,” he ordered, “sleep off the fog.”

“Mydei, Mydei,” Phainon babbled and Mydei had to fight to keep the smile off his face when he heard that adorable voice saying his name. “This is important.”

“If I listen, will you swear to me that you will eat and then sleep?”

“I swear… swur… sweer.” Phainon rolled his head heavily while he played with that word and smacked his lips.

Mydei had poppy sometimes when he was recovering from death, only a little, enough to dull the pain but not enough to completely take his senses and wits. He didn’t like the way it made his body feel heavy and his tongue feel fuzzy, so he sympathized with Phainon. Of course, this out of it, Phainon might not have cared about the unpleasant side effects.

The man was staring intently into empty space, his eyes darting about to chase a fly that wasn’t there. Mydei sighed and reached out to take his face in both hands, cradling his cheeks and jaw, grounding him with his thumbs pressed to the soft skin in front of Phainon’s ears.

“Deliverer, focus!”

Those glittering blue eyes, even glassy and cloudy, were so beautiful looking at him like he was the only thing in the world that mattered. This close Mydei could see the gold flecks scattered in the cerulean. Phainon smiled despite his squished cheeks and when Mydei tried to pull back, Phainon held him loosely by his wrists, leaned forward, and chased his touch with his lips and cheek.

"…is this focusing?" Mydei asked firmly.

"Yes."

Perdikkas was trying so hard not to laugh behind Mydei. His little snorts and nasally squeaks were still escaping and Mydei finally had to look over his shoulder to give him a pointed glare.

"I'm sorry, it's just," Perdikkas started to say but he had to stop to suppress a giggle.

Mydei sighed and turned back to Phainon who was rubbing his cheek against Mydei's hand, and he kept doing it until Mydei used his thumb to firmly press along his cheekbone under his eye to soothe him.

"You're really strong," Phainon mumbled, "I saaaw you in the rain, being really strong."

"Is that what you needed to tell me?"

"No… Do you have tattoos on your legs too?"

Mydei sighed and very gently guided Phainon back against the wall so he could have his hand back.

"Did we not have a deal? Should I leave?"

Phainon pouted and Mydei felt his heart turn over. Something about a sad Phainon just didn't settle well in his belly, but he crossed his arms and held his ground.

"Oh, yeah, okay, listen," he slurred as he fumbled around in his lap. Phainon grabbed Fig Stew under his little arms and held the chimera up so Mydei could see. In the most serious voice he could muster, he said, "*he looks just like you."*

Fig Stew blinked at Mydei with a smug expression.

"…truly, it is as though I am peering into a mirror," Mydei grumbled with a deadpan tone.

"*Right??"* Phainon breathed. He set Fig Stew down in front of him and reached with both hands for Mydei, gently grabbing his face with both of his hands to squeeze the Prince's cheeks. "You have prettier eyes though, don't tell Fig, he might be upset."

The heat rushed to Mydei's cheeks and the tips of his ears at the praise. He very gently took hold of Phainon's wrists to pull his hands away and flashed Fig Stew a look. The chimera seemed very okay with Mydei having prettier eyes and was watching his Kremnoan best friend with half-lidded eyes and that same knowing smug smile from before, like he had figured out a secret.

"I won't tell him," Mydei promised, "now do as I ordered of you, Deliverer. Perdikkas will help you eat and then you will sleep. Do you understand?"

“Okay,” he agreed and leaned back again. His head hit the wall with a hollow thunk like he was already jumping ahead to the sleep part. It was as good a time as any to make his escape and Mydei stood up to leave before he could be grabbed again.

“He’s insufferable,” Mydei grumbled to Perdikkas.

“You are so much worse when you’re sick.”

The Prince pouted and Perdikkas playfully slapped his arm at the shoulder. “I’ll have him sobered up and back to work in three entry hours. Nothing strenuous mind.”

“There is work aplenty,” Mydei sighed, “I have no shortage of tasks he could handle.”

They both looked over at Phainon when he started mewling. He and Fig Stew were having a conversation with meows, growls, and the grumbling squeaks of chimera speak.

“…three entry hours. No earlier than that.”

“Of course,” Perdikkas agreed.

Mydei turned to leave, halfway out the door when he heard Perdikkas call to him again and turned to look at his friend over his shoulder.

“You have to admit, Phainon *is* cute.”

He slammed the door.

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By entry hour the next morning, Phainon was clear-headed and properly dressed in his exomis. He only vaguely remembered the prior day when Perdikkas asked him about it. He knew the Prince had to come to check on him and had a vague recollection of being held but it was hard to tell if that last part was a memory or a fading dream. In any case, Phainon was ready to be out of bed and frustrated that Perdikkas wouldn’t let him return to his duties right away. He knew that working out would be out of the question but after the storm there were lots of things to do, surely there was *something.*

“I’ve already wasted a whole day,” he insisted.

“Phainon, your leg is healing well but if I let you get back to work too fast, you’ll tear the stitches and waste my hard work.”

Phainon pouted. “I’ll be careful…”

“If you’re that bored, then help me in here for now.”

Even after a day of sorting and cleaning, Perdikkas only had half the infirmary put back together. Everything had been hastily stuffed into boxes to recover floor space but now nothing was organized, and it was taking him forever to find things he needed without dumping it all out onto the floor again.

The doctor was already going through a box on his table, pulling out jars and herbs that didn't belong and setting them aside. Phainon rocked in bed to get to a stand and limped over to look at what he was doing.

"If you want to take this box," Perdikkas was saying, "anything that's in a jar needs to come out and be put into this case." He pointed to a small chest on the table. "And anything that's in a packet needs to be piled up for me to sort. Bandages go in that box and if it was damaged, put it in this crate." He kicked the crate on the floor with his foot.

Phainon listened to the instructions intently, delighted to be able to help. He took Perdikkas' spot at the table and started rifling through the box. He was a little surprised to see that the war ship had a vast collection of state-of-the-art medical equipment, bandages, herbs for poultices, oils, salts, and so on.

"Perdikkas," Phainon started, "I thought Kremnoans *wanted* to die in battle."

"There is glory in dying in combat, yes."

Perdikkas grunted as he lifted another big box onto the table next to Phainon's. He took up a spot next to him to sort through those supplies.

"Why all this stuff then?"

"What do you mean?"

"All of these supplies are for preserving life, staving off death. Why keep so much if it's contrary to your creed?"

"'Valorous death before glorious return,'" Perdikkas quoted, "it's true, that is the Kremnoan way. Scars and wounds are symbols of honor and courage, to die on the battlefield is to send our souls and those of our respected enemies to fuel Nikador's blade, the ultimate sacrifice to serve alongside our Titan even in death." He tossed a roll of bandages over his shoulder into the correct container with one hand and set a jar of something that smelled strongly of flowers into the chest. "But if it was as simple as throwing our lives away, we wouldn't train, we wouldn't condition ourselves, nor learn how to efficiently draw blood from others just as we're willing to spill our own. Sacrifice isn't as simple as throwing yourself on the sword in ritual. It's fighting and dying with purpose, and one can't find and fall in love with a reason to die, if they don't first find and fall in love with a reason to live."

Phainon thought about that for a second and then asked, "have you found a reason to die, Perdikkas?"

"Of course," he said, cheerfully, "my reason to fight, my willingness to die, is my vow to serve my Prince. He would be furious to hear me say it, but I would gladly throw my life away in service to his ambitions."

"Isn't that rude of him?" Phainon asked, "for Mydei to be mad at you for your choice?"

Phainon pulled out pieces of a broken jar and gently put them and the spilled contents into the crate at his feet. The little round balls smelled funny and were greasy as he gathered them up alongside the shards of clay.

“Maybe a little bit, but he has his reasons. Mydei is uniquely blessed by the Titans. He thinks it’s ridiculous that people would throw away their lives if they don’t need to, to fulfill a sense of duty to a crown he won’t pick up.”

Phainon set a few packets of dried herbs on the pile that Perdikkas had started and dug around in the box for more. It felt more efficient to search for specific categories of supplies rather than pull things out at random.

“Ptolemy told me that he shared Mydei’s story with you,” the doctor continued, “so you know he spent his youth in the Sea of Souls while his father was fighting his campaigns. Mydei saw all those lives that were lost, he still appreciates their sacrifices, but I don’t think he likes it. I have never heard him say the creed, even before going into battle. I think he would rather his people live and find happiness than seek noble ends to satisfy our god’s recent bloodlust.

“But more than that I think Mydei is the purest embodiment of Strife, not as a war machine that marches endlessly hoarding souls, but Strife as it was in days long past, that followed the five tenets of Nikador. He wants to shield the people he loves, to pursue glory not through conquest but through protection, for Strife to be a motivator for growth and inspiration.”

That was not the picture of Kremnoan royalty that had been painted for Phainon in Okhema. The Council taught the people that Kremnoans were bloodthirsty and violent simply because they enjoyed it, because Nikador demanded it. He had been told that Strife was the antithesis of peace and that was why a nation of soldiers could never find happiness, why they marched into battle on the orders of their King and god with no fear of death.

“Five tenets?” he asked.

“The five parts of Nikador that together create Strife,” Perdikkas explained. His voice was a little strained as he tried to peel some leaves apart. A jar of oil had spilled on them, and they were drying stuck together. He gave up after a few tries and dumped them in the ‘damaged’ crate.

“Kremnoans uphold all five as virtues to embody: courage, honor, tenacity, sacrifice, and reason. Although, Eurypon seemed to have given up on those towards the end of his life,” grumbled Perdikkas.

“If honor is so important, why did you guys become pirates?” Phainon asked.

“What other choice was left for us? Okhema considers us pirates,” Perdikkas grumbled, “only because we’re breaking *their* laws, even though we aren’t citizens.”

“But you do steal from ships and fight against other nation’s navies?”

Perdikkas shifted his weight from side to side. “Yes, even if Mydeimos is not like his father, hungry for conquest, we’re still Kremnoan. Our hearts still sing for battle, we still need to get supplies to take care of ourselves and our people, but there is honor in how we choose to emulate Strife.”

“Honor-” Phainon mumbled.

“Yes, Phainon. Honor. We don’t attack and slaughter indiscriminately. When Mydei, Hephaestion, and Krateros choose our targets we are very careful to avoid collateral damage. Eurypon would raze whole cities to the ground, Nikador famously destroyed whole civilizations, we only target hostile military installations, other war ships, and mostly, the Black Tide.” He fixed the pile of paper packets on the table so they wouldn’t fall off. Each one of them was at least labeled. Phainon couldn’t read the Kremnoan just yet, but he could recognize the individual letters. “And Mydei is very careful to lead the way at every step so he can protect us and show mercy where need be. This lifestyle suits us.”

“The history we have in Okhema about Castrum Kremnos focuses mostly on Eurypon and Nikador as insatiable, they paint you all as less than men, bloodthirsty to a fault,” Phainon said.

“I’m not surprised, Eurypon may not have started that way, but he became it,” Perdikkas lamented, “it was before my time, but something changed when Eurypon came back from his campaign in the North. He started getting wild, becoming the mad king, even throwing his son away to appease an equally mad Titan on the hearsay of a soothsayer.”

“Are the stories about Mydei true?”

“Which ones?”

“The ones about him being immortal.”

“Oh, those are true.”

Phainon paused and flashed Perdikkas a skeptical look, his hands full of bandages. There were weirder things in Amphoreus but it still felt like a stretch, even with golden blood.

“They are. I have held my Prince’s body, marred beyond hope of repair, and watched it stitch back together as flawless as the day he was born. It’s unpleasant for him, but he cannot die.”

“…so when I pushed him out of the way of that falling sail.”

“He was upset with you, yes,” Perdikkas laughed, “he doesn’t like when people risk their lives for his, because he sees his own life as cheap compared to those of his people.”

Phainon pouted. “Does it hurt him? Does he feel it when he dies?”

“Yes.”

“Then I’d do it again,” Phainon said firmly with a soft smile, “immortal or not.”

Perdikkas puzzled over Phainon for a long moment, playing with a cracked jar of salts as he did so. “Phainon, when you jumped to save him, did you forget that he’s your enemy? I just told you as much.”

He looked down, white hair hiding his eyes, as he whispered, “Why do we have to be?”

Perdikkas didn’t really know how to respond to that, Phainon could see it on his face and maybe it was just a childish dream, but Phainon wanted to believe that they could be allies. When he returned to Okhema, he’d make them see that there didn’t need to be bad blood between them, that the Kremnoans would make incredible partners against shared enemies.

He still remembered that feeling in the rain, standing shoulder to shoulder with Mydei, the way it felt to stand as comrades. It made his spirit soar to think of that moment. He wondered if Mydei had felt it too.

They chattered about lighter topics after that. Any discussion of politics was chased away by questions about their supplies. Phainon’s curiosity had gotten the better of him while they were sorting medicines and Perdikkas happily told him about some of them. He taught Phainon about doses, what medicines could heal or harm, poisons that could cure illness when mixed correctly, and ways to care for injuries. Phainon even shared what he had learned from the grove regarding alchemical mixtures until they were exchanging knowledge in equal spades.

They talked until they finished repairing the infirmary and Leonnius visited with dinner and Phainon’s repaired clothing, neat little stitches fixed the tear in the leg. The crew had managed to keep most of their supplies safe from the rain, but a lot of the fresh products were wearing thin. The chef had managed to make the most of what they had, and dinner was a hearty stew and paximathia, a dried, hard bread.

All three of them let the bread soak up the stew to soften it while they talked. None of the sails had been lost but several needed to be fixed, the railing would need major repairs in places, but the biggest casualty was Ptolemy’s library which was taking four people to put back together. Leonnius reassured the two of them that the repairs were coming along nicely, but Mydei had made the decision to change their course. When Phainon asked where they were headed, he was met with a shrug in response and Perdikkas mumbled something about trusting the Captain and needing to get to bed.

Even though Phainon felt fine, Perdikkas insisted he spend another night in the infirmary and locked them both in when the sun set outside. Even though this was just another cell, Phainon was grateful to be away from the steel bars and Perdikkas’ soft breathing was a better soundtrack than the creak of the ship alone.

He studied the long shadows in the infirmary from his narrow bed, both hands folded over his chest. Every rock of the ship pressed one of his shoulders against either the wall or the little rail attached to the side to keep him from rolling onto the floor. Phainon’s leg and bruised chest ached but it was manageable and grounding, the subtle pain was a reminder that he was alive, and he almost wasn’t. Mydei had saved him twice now to his once. Not that it was a competition of course.

He remembered hitting the water, the way the waves muted the thunder above until all he could hear was the rumble of the deep. Before the ice filled his lungs and he was pulled back on board, Phainon remembered the voice of the Titan again, a malice wrapped in sweet melody, coaxing him to sink deeper into an endless abyss. He remembered even as he sank towards the depths the memory of fire licking his skin and the screech of monsters.

Deep in the core of that unnatural storm, the Black Tide beckoned.

-

If Mydei thought Phainon was insufferable before then there was no word to describe him now. Eager to please and with no sense of personal self-preservation, Phainon took every opportunity to escape the infirmary to be of use.

It had started early that morning when Perdikkas woke to find the wooden bar they used to lock the door tucked into Phainon's blankets and had to go find his patient who was helping pull the patched sail back up into place. The doctor literally dragged Phainon back to bed by the collar.

The second time, Phainon had slipped out when Perdikkas went to fetch them both water after his thirsty patient had drained their waterskins in the infirmary. He found Phainon helping move the now full water barrels below decks and dragged him back to bed by the ear.

The third time, Perdikkas had to check on another member on the crew who had twisted his ankle. When he got back, of course Phainon had left. That time Mydei found him helping carry spare lumber to replace the damaged railing. Phainon insisted that he was fine, nearly convincing Mydei he was okay to work, until a red-faced Perdikkas started yelling and swearing at him from across the deck in Kremnoan and then Mydei was throwing Phainon over his shoulder to drag him back to the infirmary himself.

That's when it turned into a game. Leonnius, Ptolemy, and Hephaestion started taking turns helping Phainon escape, creating opportunities for him by distracting Perdikkas, and helping to smuggle him to help with tasks and betting on how long they could keep the doctor and captain from finding him. It was easy on paper and much harder in practice once Mydei started to catch on and went on the offensive. The Captain was a motivated bloodhound on the hunt and their only advantage was in numbers.

Phainon understood that he didn't want to be caught, but he was none the wiser when it came to the betting. He was just happy that so many of his friends had things for him to do, even when they hurried him from one job to the next sometimes without finishing the task he had just been working on. The longest he spent on a single job was when Leonnius managed to get him up into the shrouds to reorganize the lines for the repaired sail, but then Mydei had shouted from the other end of the ship and Leonnius kicked him off the yard and into Hephaestion's arms on deck to be hurried off to his next job securing barrels and crates around the hold.

They were trying to hide Phainon under a hat, crossing the deck while he hunched to get him to the navigation room to organize maps, when Mydei finally slid in front of them with an annoyed expression. Immediately the three Kremnoans hid Phainon behind them.

“Heeey, Mydei,” Leonnius started.

“Don’t start,” he growled.

“Start what?” Hephaestion said coolly and Mydei rolled his fingers so the gauntlets would clack threateningly.

“That damn dog is supposed to be resting.”

“I’m not a dog!” Phainon called over their shoulders and all three of them immediately put their hands on his hat to pull it down to cover his face.

“Certainly a dog would be more obedient!”

“’Each man delights in the work that suits him best,’” Ptolemy quoted.

Hephaestion agreed, “yeah, Mydeimos, he just wants to help.”

“My leg doesn’t even hurt anymore!” Phainon insisted.

Mydei crossed his arms and zeroed in on those bright blue eyes peeking over the first mate’s shoulder. “Are you lying to me?”

“Surely, I’ve earned *some* trust after saving your life.”

Mydei’s eye twitched. “Bold words coming from the mouth that I have had to pull out of the ocean *twice*.”

“What if we give him easy jobs?” Leonnius offered, “nothing that would hurt his leg.”

“Perdikkas explicitly said three entry hours, not two,” Mydei insisted with an annoyed growl.

“I’ll take him,” said a soft but clear voice. All five of the men turned to look at Peucesta standing beside them with his lyre under his arm. “I’ve been watching,” he explained, “if he must work to not be a nuisance, then he can help me.”

Mydei turned back to look at Phainon with a pointed stare that Phainon immediately countered with a brilliant smile. “Fine. You’ll help Peucesta and then return to Perdikkas.” He held up a hand to silence any protests. “This is the only compromise you will get. The alternative is I tie all four of you to the mast until dinner.”

Leonnius, Hephaestion, and Ptolemy all agreed immediately and without protest, leaving Phainon with no choice but to accept his new fate as they scattered with the breeze… whatever that fate was.

Peucesta was a thoughtful looking man with elegant long hair that reached just past his shoulders. He didn’t have the same bookish sharpness that Ptolemy had but they shared some softness in the cheeks. Like all Kremnoans he was in shape, a warrior, but the calluses on his hands were more towards the tips of his fingers rather than on his palms.

They hadn't met properly but Phainon had heard him playing his lyre at mealtimes and in the mornings. His role on the ship was guarding morale and their spirits more than their bodies.

"Um," Phainon asked as he followed the man towards the bow, "Peucesta right? What are we doing? Do I need to get any tools?"

"No," Peucesta said assuredly, and then it was awkward silence until they got to the very front of the ship.

Nestled behind the crystal lion head ram was an old sculpture of a lion's face. Phainon had been up here before when he had been exploring and had been reminded of Verax Leo at the Marmoreal Palace, but this one was much, much older, a lot bigger, and more stylistic, cast in some sort of bronze rather than stone. While it had the same jaws and a similar ruff, this one had a glorious pair of horns that curved over its brow and met on its muzzle in a V-shape to frame its face. The carved tufts of its cheeks were full and regal, matching the strong and pointed jaw. It was mounted on a massive circular plate that was installed against the back of the ram so the lion could face inwards with its own private horseshoe shaped deck just a few steps lower than the forecastle deck.

This spot was quiet, reverent, not so isolated that Phainon felt alone, but set apart in a way that that the hustle and bustle of the ship felt distant.

Peucesta gently put his hand on the lion's nose.

"I know you went overboard during the storm," he said, "so you must have heard it too."

Phainon felt his blood go cold. He swallowed slowly but the lump in his throat held firm. "Heard what?"

"The language of the Titans and the Black Tide. It's easier to hear in the water."

"…if you don't have anything for me to do-"

Peucesta tossed him a sponge and Phainon fumbled to catch it. Water splashed against his chest and got his clothes wet. He blinked at it in surprise as the man sat down next to the lion head to play.

"We are here to clean and sing to the great lion."

"…we're doing what?"

"I know from Hephaestion that you respect the ship and take great care to show him that love when you help with repairs. That includes the ship's spirit, especially after encounters with the Black Tide." He started to pluck at the strings.

Phainon mulled that over for a second while he studied the silent lion. If the ship's figurehead was a living simulacrum like Verax Leo, then it would make a lot more sense why they treasured the ship like a living thing. This was a symbiotic relationship and sponging clean a statue wouldn't be too exertive.

He wrung out the sponge and stepped up to the bronze to put his hand on the lion's nose. It was warm, not the same as stone warmed in sunlight, more like it had a buzz to it that Phainon felt through his fingertips all the way down his arm, just the tiniest prickle of recognition.

"There are statues in Okhema that look a little like this one," Phainon said reverently, "albeit more like lions and much smaller."

"Verax Leo?"

"Yeah, they talk a *lot*."

"Chryseus Leo does not speak except on the rarest of occasions." Peucesta sounded very sad as he said it, the melody on the lyre turned to a minor key. "He is old and tired."

Oh, the ship was named for him.

"Oh, muse," Peucesta said clearly, melodically in time with his strumming, "speak through me of the lion of Tretos, whose roar shattered shields and whose claws were as spears. That most grand of beasts, with fur of gold and flame, the lord of the plains, Chryseus Leo, who one day met his fate. For many years he lay siege to the city, consuming of them their offered herds, lest he come for them in their beds.

'Behold the great lion,' they cried, 'from whom we will never be free, for none dare contend with the Titan's blessed beast.'"

Phainon listened, doing his best to use broad, slow, quiet strokes to wipe the salt and grime from the golden lion. He didn't want the sounds to interrupt the music.

"Then came fate, when the city could bear the beast no longer. He was clad in red and gold, a leader of legions on their eternal march for glory. Gorgo was his name, and when he heard tale of the lion he was moved to action. When thus they met it was without steel, for so inspired was Gorgo by the lion's might he cast aside his spear. And when Leo roared his final breath in that great battle, it shook the city for a hundred years."

"I think I've actually heard this story," Phainon admitted, quietly but with thinly veiled excitement.

Peucesta stopped playing. "You have?"

"When I was young, I dreamed of traveling to Castrum Kremnos, to learn how to fight. I read whatever I could about its history, what little there was. King Gorgo, the founder of Castrum Kremnos, was known as the Lion-Slayer King for his feat. Supposedly, Nikador flung the head so hard it stuck to the fortress wall. Was this lion head modeled after the original then?"

Peucesta shook his head. "This *is* Chryseus Leo, the lion of Tretos. There was always only one."

Suddenly Phainon felt a lot more humbled by this task. He paused before reverently continuing his work.

He swallowed around that nervous lump in his throat again. “How did he end up here?”

Peucesta started to play again, but he didn’t sing the story like before. “Chryseus Leo was given as a gift many Kings ago to a monarch of the northern kingdoms. When King Eurypon invaded, the lion was recovered, the only treasure that had not been corrupted by the Black Tide. Eurypon believed that the lion harbored special power that kept it clean of corruption, and instead of returning him to the fortress wall, had this ship built around him. The lion and the ship are synonymous now. He feels it as an extension of himself and as we care for him, he extends his protection to us.”

“… you asked me about the voice I heard in the water,” Phainon realized, “Peucesta, was King Eurypon right about the lion?”

He smiled and the music changed to a major key. “He was. This ship is not immune to the Black Tide, but it *is* highly resistant. Not even Chryseus Leo knows why he was spared the corruption, but it gives us a fighting chance against the deep that so desperately tries to reach for us. That storm was not natural, if it had not been for the lion, we may not have survived.” Peucesta leaned against the lion from where he was sitting, still playing, but offering physical contact with his shoulder as well.

“A few years ago, in a battle with the Black Tide, I nearly turned when I went overboard. The black had reached for me, and I heard it speak, beckoning in a sweet voice and enchanting melody. The others pulled me from the water and left me to rest here in front of the lion and we talked of Strife, of the future we wanted to see. Because of him I did not turn, my brothers did not need to slay me in my madness, and I have honored the lion with song ever since.”

This was the most Phainon had ever heard Peucesta speak. He respectfully held his silence and listened to those delicate notes while he polished the lion’s teeth until the man was done speaking. “Why share this with me?”

“The others speak of you fondly, and I thought it was important that you know. It seemed a good time since we now share that brush with death and that song that lingers still.”

Peucesta was right about that. The Black Tide was a haunting memory, both from his past and now the singing from the storm. It was sticky and staining like ink on the soul, crawling under his skin.

“Caring for Chryseus Leo,” Peucesta was saying, “even though he is mostly silent now, is a way to thank him for his protection, for his diligent duty to Strife. Golden blood would’ve spared you and Mydei, but that storm would’ve claimed the rest of us. Fixing what was broken is important and this may seem like a boring task, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, sitting and singing to the ship, but it is equally as valuable to him.”

Phainon ghosted his fingers over the lion’s cheeks, tracing the worn carvings. The bronze shimmered golden in the sunlight, warming his soul, shining light onto those stains. Now that he was holding still, listening only to the pluck of those strings and concentrating on the lion, it felt like there was a soft heartbeat there. Imagined, he reasoned but special all the same.

“I only know reverent harvest songs and noisy drinking songs,” Phainon admitted, “I’m not sure a lion of such renown would take interest in those.” He set the sponge down in the bucket to float on the surface of the water and sat down on the deck in front of Peucesta. It hurt to cross his legs, so he only folded the one, pulling his knee up to his chest so his injured leg could stay extended.

“I don’t think he would mind.”

“Then I will trade you,” Phainon offered, “show me how to play the lyre as you do, and I’ll teach you a few songs.”

Peucesta smiled gently. “I think he would love that.”

They didn’t move from the bow until the thief star crossed the sky and Perdikkas came for his patient and even then, Phainon whined and begged for more time. He really felt like he was getting the hang of strumming the strings and was eager to practice further. But Peucesta gently took the lyre from him, patted him on the shoulder, and told him that the rest would be best for both Phainon’s fingers and both their ears.

Pouty, but pliant, Perdikkas led him by the sleeve back to the infirmary.

Behind them, the lion purred.

Chapter End Notes

This chapter is 1000 words over my target word count per chapter because I couldn't bring myself to cut medically high Phainon. It was just too funny.

Chapter 8: If

Chapter Summary

New tags: Happy Ending

Chapter Notes

Soooo, my original outline had the contents of this chapter as the end of chapter 3. So, uh, there are going to be way more than 19 chapters unless I make them longer and post less frequently. Do readers prefer these shorter chapters (~5k-6k words) updated as I finish them every 1-2 days, or weekly updates where chapters are potentially longer? I'm pretty happy with lots of short chapters but I know that can be intimidating.

Also, I see and love you repeat commenters. The only way you guys could sustain me more, would be if I printed out your kind words and ate them.

As promised, Perdikkas let Phainon go after he ate breakfast the third entry hour after the storm. The doctor had applauded Phainon for his quick healing, mumbling about Chrysos Heirs before he kicked him out of the infirmary under the condition he still take it easy for at least a few days. No working the lines, no combat drills or training, and no fishing. No exceptions.

Phainon had happily promised to adhere to Perdikkas' rules and tried very hard to say so in Kremnoan to show he was serious. With all that extra time he had been reading his two books and felt like he was picking up the right words.

At least he felt that way until Perdikkas had very politely told him to keep practicing and to never say those words with that accent, in that order again. He refused to elaborate further.

As eager as Phainon was to utilize his freedom productively, he also needed to get his bearings. Now that he was headed back to his cell, he felt like it was worth checking on what was left of his outfit that he hadn't worn during the storm. With all the supplies being properly packed and inventoried, he was worried that his things had been misplaced.

Using the daylight filtering in from above and a lantern he took from the wall, Phainon dug around in his cell with increasing disappointment. None of his clothes, his greaves, not even his blanket was there anymore. Theft on a ship was almost unheard of, getting away with it was borderline impossible with the tight quarters so it was more likely that his things had been confused with spoils of war when supplies were being shuffled. Worst case scenario,

one of the old guard had thrown his clothes away out of spite, tossing them overboard. Phainon didn't want to think about how upset Aglaea would be if that was the case.

Still hopeful, Phainon went upstairs to the crew's living quarters to find someone who might know. He was halfway across the deck when he spotted Hephaestion and waved to the first mate who gave him a quizzical head tilt in response.

"Perdikkas set you loose?"

"Haha, yeah," Phainon smiled and scratched the back of his neck, "Hephaestion, do you know what happened to the rest of my clothes?" He gestured to what he was wearing. Phainon had his repaired pants, boots, and his high-collared, v-neck but his coat, cape, and armor were gone.

"Oh yeah-"

"I have them."

Phainon turned to look over his shoulder at Mydei. The Captain had said it so casually.

"…on purpose?" Phainon asked, more suspicious than surprised.

"Yes. I put them in my room where I expect you to sleep at night going forward."

The silence stretched long enough that Hephaestion shuffled uncomfortably away, mumbling an excuse about being called.

"Is there a problem?" Mydei prodded when Phainon seemed to have completely short-circuited.

"I must have misheard you," Phainon laughed as he snapped out of his stunned trance, "for a second I thought you said you wanted me to sleep in your room."

"That is what I said." Mydei turned and started walking towards the stern where his room was. The doors to his space, the library, the navigation room, and more were next to the stairs to the top deck.

Phainon followed him closely, struggling to find his words. He could feel his cheeks burning. "…*why?"*

"Would you rather sleep behind bars?" Mydei asked as he held the door open for Phainon.

"I might!"

Mydei scowled. Phainon couldn't *see* it through the back of Mydei's head, but he could almost hear it and could feel it as they stalked down the hallway.

"That's absurd. The hold is dark and miserable and it's a hassle for Hephaestion to unlock your door every morning."

Mydei stomped into his room with Phainon on his heels. The other person in the room looked up, starting to address the Captain, but Krateros held his tongue and frowned when he saw the other man. The old soldier gave Phainon pause too. Mydei was the only one that seemed unaffected by the sudden chill in the room, if he noticed it at all.

“Your things are here,” he was saying, crossing to the far wall where an ornate dresser was built into the space between windows. The drawers were held closed by twisting latches so as not to spill their contents in rough waters. He twisted the latch on the third drawer up from the floor and pulled it open so Phainon could see but Phainon was still waiting by the door.

He felt very uncomfortable, like he was intruding. Even though Mydei had been welcoming, Krateros’ obvious disapproval was suffocating.

The room was spacious, but not as big as it used to be. The furnishings built along the walls felt lopsided, only occupying the original three walls while the one that divided the room from the others felt much newer. Any furniture or trappings along that wall had been added and nailed into place rather than elegantly blended into the original construction under and around a line of thick paned windows. There was a place for a large bed but there was no mattress, instead, there was a hammock hung over the space and the surface was instead used for storage like the cluttered top of a desk. Books, stationary, maps, collected goods, and so on were littered about. In one corner was a small pile of weapons, a spear, an unstrung bow, several quivers of arrows, a shield, and Phainon’s greatsword.

Krateros stood over a long table in the middle of the room. There were chairs and stools scattered around along the walls, by Mydei’s mini arsenal, everywhere except beside the table. Phainon could see a massive map spread out across the surface. Heavy books and boxes of carved ships held it open at the corners. Figurines were meticulously placed across its surface. Krateros had his hand on one of them, but he left it where it was and slowly pulled his hand back when he saw Phainon.

“You may as well, reclaim that while you’re here,” Mydei was saying. He pointed with his gauntleted hand at Phainon’s sword.

When Phainon took a step towards it, Krateros straightened and crossed his arms. “Are you sure that’s wise, Prince Mydeimos?”

“I see no reason why he should not have it.”

“*See no reason*?” Krateros hissed. His fists clenched at his sides.

“It’s fine,” Phainon said. He put both of his hands up. “I don’t need it right now. Leave it where it is.”

“It should be locked in the armory,” Krateros insisted.

“Take the compromise, teacher,” Mydei ordered with a sigh, “the sword stays where it is. I would rather Phainon know where he can reclaim it and be able to wield it should the need arise.”

“And would he raise his sword in defense of your crew?”

“I believe he would.”

Phainon shuffled uncomfortably. Conflict like this bothered him. Leonnius’ warning about Krateros rang in his ears. This was Mydei’s oldest confidant, perhaps even a father figure, who had helped raise him after Mydei had been pulled from the Sea of Souls. Maybe this was a discussion he was best left out of. Stay quiet, keep to himself, better not to interject.

“I would,” Phainon said firmly, “if I could.”

The old man turned on him. “There is nothing you can say Okheman that would convince me that what you say is true.”

Mydei stepped forward but Phainon cut him off, stepping up to the table to look Krateros in the eye when he responded, “Then I will say no more to you. I’ll just have to show you … should the occasion arise.”

Krateros glared at him and for a heartbeat they watched each other until Mydei laughed, it was one laugh, almost a bark, short like a punctuation.

“What more can you ask for, Krateros,” the Prince said, “Deliverer, do you have need of any of your things?”

Phainon shook his head. “Not right now.”

“Then wait outside for me.”

Krateros never stopped glaring at Phainon. That one good eye was boring a hole through the back of his head the entire way from that table back to the door and Phainon even worried the old man could see *through* the door the way that weight lingered even when the latch clicked. He went down the hallway and waited on deck, leaning against the wall beside the door, using the stairs as shade from the morning sun.

It was shaping up to be a beautiful day. The sails were already unfurled, catching the wind, pulling them along. Driving them farther away from Okhema.

Phainon had seen the map when he was leaving. He had heard that after the storm, Mydei had ordered a change of course, and without knowing their route prior it was hard to tell how much that had changed, but now Phainon knew for sure; the Chryseus Leo was heading away from Okhema, away from any of his city-state’s allies. Even worse, it looked like they were traveling along the estimated line between free waters and the Black Tide, heading towards a distant isle that Phainon didn’t recognize. A home port perhaps? But why would they make berth so close to the reach of the Black Tide? Was Chryseus Leo’s protective nature strong enough to protect them even in harbor?

More importantly, was there any way for him to return home from there? And did he even want that anymore?

-

Krateros at least waited until the door closed to express his displeasure. “You should not be wasting your time with him. Kill him before we get to the settlement.”

Mydei sighed and stepped up to the map. He picked up the little carving of a lion, the Chryseus Leo, and moved it to a collection of isles. The Black Tide was infringing on their safe haven, it wasn’t moving as quickly as it had been five years ago, but it still marched steadily to eat the seas and islands.

“I told you already, teacher,” Mydei huffed, “I won’t unless he forces my hand.” He put both his hands on the side of the table, holding tightly to ground himself as the bubble of anger kindled in his belly. “But someone has already tried to take this needless task upon themselves.” Next to him he felt Krateros shift in place. Mydei turned just enough to glare at him with one eye. “You wouldn’t happen to know anything about that, would you, Krateros?”

The old warrior was a stone wall, giving nothing away. “I don’t, if any of my men had tried to take his life they would not have failed.”

They stood in tense silence until Mydei relented. Prince or not, he still respected Krateros’ authority and experience.

“We will finish the repairs at the Kremnoan Settlement, rest, and then resume our patrol,” Mydei ordered, “any other ships caught in that storm will have turned.”

Krateros nodded and turned back to the map. He pointed and ran his finger along the black line they had drawn on it. “If we are quick, we may be able to prevent the Black Tide’s territory from expanding further.”

“The men are tired. We will lose too many if we don’t let them rest.”

“Any longer than a day is too long of a delay.”

“A day then,” Mydei agreed, “let them properly bathe, see their families.”

“And what will you do with the Okheman? He will try to flee the moment his feet touch the shore.”

Mydei tapped his fingers on the desk. Phainon stood here and insisted he would fight for the ship if pressed, but he also refused to engage in piracy. He had a sense of duty that meant nothing when they were at sea but how *would* Phainon act given the choice between this crew and returning to Okhema.

“He cannot be allowed to see where your people have settled,” Krateros insisted, “he will tell the Goldweaver and they will seek us out to destroy us, until every Kremnoan is buried. You *must* end him before we make berth.”

It pained Mydei to consider, but Krateros was right. Phainon was not one of them.

“I know,” he admitted in a growl, “I will deal with Phainon personally, when the time comes.”

-

When Mydei left his room and spotted Phainon leaning against the door, he was surprised to see how puzzled the man looked. Those blue eyes were staring so intensely at the deck that he had stopped blinking. His brow was pinched tight in concentration; his normally jovial expression contorted into a tight frown. It was cute, if a little strange watching him think that hard.

“Something on your mind?” Mydei asked and Phainon had blinked himself back into his usual animated self, smiling wide enough to reach his eyes at last.

“Ah, no, nothing important.”

He was a bad liar, but Mydei let it go.

“Come,” he ordered, “you will be helping in the galley today.”

Phainon perked up immediately. “That sounds like fun.”

“It is very hard work,” cautioned Mydei.

“Aw, are you worried about me?”

“I am worried for my crew eating a subpar meal because you were unable to handle the task assigned to you.”

“How hard can it be?”

Mydei smiled to himself as he led the way down to the galley.

The kitchen was past the eating area, behind the long countertop that separated the spaces. It was an expansive kitchen built with royalty in mind. When Mydei and his detachment had fled Castrum Kremnos after killing the King, the galley was one of many reasons why they had stolen this ship. It had three stone and clay ovens, plenty of counter space, lots of light, storage for all their cooking equipment, several washbasins, two open cookfires with massive hung pots, lined with stone to protect the ship, and so much more. It was a dream come true.

Phainon whistled behind him.

“There are usually three people that work the galley,” Mydei explained as he walked over to a cubby to take off his gauntlets. “I have given two of them the day off to rest and handle personal tasks.” He put them in the cubby and then undid his pauldron so he could gather up the loose fabric of his chiton. “You will have to work hard to make up for the both of them. Will that be too much for you, Deliverer?”

Phainon scoffed behind him. “I can handle it.”

Mydei could hear the hesitation in his voice and feel eyes on his bare back. He folded up his chiton reverently, down to just his pants and tall, armored boots, and traded them in the cubby for a worn, loved apron that he slid over his head. Mydei ran his hands through his hair,

giving it a toss so the apron strap could settle comfortably on the back of his neck and shoulders. The little bronze buckle clinked against the clasp of the braid over his shoulder.

“Wait…” Phainon mumbled, “Are you helping in the kitchen today too?”

Mydei grabbed a spare apron and tossed it to him, the folded fabric slammed into Phainon’s chest, and he very nearly smiled at the way the Deliverer fumbled to catch it.

“It’s my kitchen,” Mydei explained as he tied the apron closed behind his back with practiced precision. “Of course I will be working here today, as I do every day.”

Phainon’s expression was priceless. That wide-eyed confusion and awe made Mydei’s heart flutter.

“You’re… the cook?”

Oh, he was so cute trying to put the pieces together. “I am the Chef, yes. Do you need help with your apron?”

Phainon startled and scrambled to get the apron on. “No, I don’t.”

“Good, then put your bracers in a basket,” he ordered, pointing over his shoulder, “and wash up, we have a lot to do today.”

Mydei was determined to give Phainon the benefit of the doubt about a lot of things. Even with Krateros’ warnings at the back of his mind, even with the weight of being from two distant worlds hovering over him like a blade waiting to fall, even knowing that something would need to be done about him at some point…

It was his friends holding that blade away, keeping it from falling. As Mydei watched Phainon tuck his armguards away, fumble with his apron, and wash his hands, he could hear the excited chatter of his friends from the last week. How excited they were to tell him about Phainon, how much they liked him, how much they wanted to trust him, and oh Mydei wanted so badly to trust him too.

“Aedes Elysiae,” Mydei said and Phainon’s head jerked up and looked over at him with those stunning, thoughtful eyes. The light glittered on the tattoo etched into his neck under that collar when he tilted his head. “It was a farming isle, known for it’s wheat was it not?”

“Yes, it was.” Phainon’s voice was small and Mydei worried briefly that he overstepped.

He cleared his throat. “Then you know how to process wheat, to turn it to flour?”

“It has been a long time,” Phainon admitted, “but I know how to work a millstone yes.”

“The moisture from the storm ruined my flour,” Mydei explained. He gestured for Phainon to follow him through the kitchen to the millstone.

The contraption was attached to a table in their big, walk-in pantry surrounded by barrels stacked along the walls and labeled in Kremnoan. The millstone itself was a rectangular

shape, almost square, with a deep v-shaped basin. A rod was attached to a pole on one end of the basin, stretching across the mill long ways to extend well past the length of the basin. It served as a handle, with the operator pushing and pulling the rod back and forth. Every pass dragged a heavy stone affixed to the rod along the inside of the basin to grind the wheat into flour. For a ship this size the mill was large, perhaps not as big as the millhouses Mydei had seen in his travels, but too large for a domestic, single-family's use.

Phainon confidently stepped up to it, checking the joint with a practiced eye. He gave the lever an experimental pull to test the weight and Mydei felt his cheeks warm at the sight of those biceps flexing.

"It's bigger than the one I used at home," Phainon admitted.

"We Kremnoans have hefty appetites," Mydei explained, "and we don't really do small."

Phainon snorted and flashed Mydei a sly smile. "Is that so, Prince Mydeimos?"

"HKS, think before you speak," he scolded and looked away, "can you handle it?"

Phainon chuckled, "It's not too big for me."

Mydei walked over to a barrel and opened the lid. He ran a hand through the grain there, checking it. "This is the barrel to be turned to flour."

Phainon stood next to him, in the close space they were nearly touching. "Zea."

"You know your wheat."

"Son of a farmer."

Mydei swallowed and stepped back. "There is a sieve on the wall, to filter out the sprouted wheat. We will grind it separately."

"Why?"

Mydei looked over at Phainon and was surprised to see genuine curiosity there. With how cheeky Phainon was on a good day, Mydei half expected a question like that to be a gesture of defiance, trying to annoy him. But the slight tilt of his head and clear eyes were genuine.

"Germinated wheat tastes different when it has been ground into flour," Mydei explained, "I would prefer such flour be used to make cakes mixed with honey rather than paximathia or pita."

Phainon nodded slowly and then reached for the sieve. "I better get started," he said playfully, "I have a lot to do. You're welcome to watch me if you'd like, Mydei, but I'm going to have to ask you to stay out of the way."

Mydei bristled at his nickname, especially with how sparkly Phainon said it, but he huffed and gave the man the room all the same.

It wasn't like there was a shortage of tasks to do. It wasn't even Action Hour yet but cooking good meals for his men always took the better part of the day. Krateros had once scolded him for it, emphasizing that his role as Captain and Prince needed to come first but Hephaestion was more than capable of handling disputes and Mydei liked how cooking made him feel. It was hard work, in a hot kitchen, a battle in its own way, but very little was as satisfying as creating a wonderful meal.

He left Phainon in the pantry and returned to the galley to start assessing what he could make. His original plan for the day was to use the rest of those cabbages that had started to wilt but the storm had hastened their demise and there weren't enough good leaves left to wrap any hearty filling.

The lentils were still good and thanks to Leonnius and Phainon there was plenty of fish. Fish and lentil stew then, with pomegranate on top.

Mydei rolled one of the big water barrels they kept in the kitchen over to the massive pot and started filling it with a separate bucket. He was strong, but he wasn't *that* strong. No sense risking injury on a shortcut by lifting the whole water barrel.

When it was about half full, he covered the pot with a lid. It would be a while yet until it was time to start the fires. He still prepared the wood, lining them on top of old coals. Mydei filled the ovens and the stove as well. He still wanted to make bread today so the loaves could properly dry for storage.

Mydei started pulling out ingredients next, moving efficiently and with purpose through the kitchen and setting things out on the biggest countertop. Olive oil, salt, pepper, garlic, onions, and a whole lot of pomegranates. He scowled at the onions and garlic. They were in better shape than some of their food, but he wouldn't be able to use all of them this time.

The pomegranates were easy but time consuming. Mydei spun the knife in his hand and expertly cut into each fruit, five cuts around the calyx to pull off the tops and then it was easy to pull them apart into sections from there. He used the back of a wooden spoon to smack the rinds to dislodge the seeds, letting them fall into a big bowl of water. The membrane would float to the top, saving him the trouble of having to pick the fibrous and tasteless part out by hand.

Although, it would be funny to make Phainon do that.

He tossed the spent rind away into a scraps bucket and peeked his head into the pantry. Phainon was still grinding away with the millstone. He had found a comfortable stance and every push and pull was careful and calculated, not a single wasted effort.

He didn't say anything and Phainon hadn't seen him so Mydei ducked back out. He thought there would be more chatter than this. The others made it seem like Phainon was endlessly nosy, verbose, and easy to converse with, but instead they had settled into a quiet and comfortable rhythm.

He set the pomegranate aside and went to one of the cabinets to find his jar of foamy wine yeast. It had a distinct smell so as he opened each lid it was only for a few seconds at a time

until he found what he was looking for and set it out on another countertop. From the same collection of clay jars he pulled out a wide brimmed amphorae full of honey and on a second thought grabbed a basket of dried figs.

Candies and sweet things were some of his favorite things to make but it was hard on a ship with limited resources. Candied figs and dates lasted a long time when he made them right. Mydei set them out to snack on them while they worked. He cut up the onions, minced the garlic, dug out what was left of his dried thyme, cleaned the pomegranate seeds and then he went to start warming up the oven and stove tops.

Mydei clicked the flint over the kindling, got the fire started, and then paused. With a long-suffering sigh, he opened the oven door and pulled a sleepy Fig Stew out by the tail.

“One day, I will forget to check, and the crew will enjoy roasted chimera.”

Fig Stew was immensely unbothered by the prospect of being consumed and far more annoyed with having lost his warm spot to sleep. He yawned and batted at Mydei’s hand until Mydei set him on the counter to stretch and find another warm spot up against the warming oven to fall back asleep.

“Are you still alive in there, Deliverer?” Mydei called. He scooped out the yeast and added a generous amount to some water and added honey.

“Did you need this flour now?” Phainon called.

“May as well bring me what you have.”

Phainon had found a handful of empty flour sacks and was systematically filling them. He brought a full, heavy bag out to Mydei slung over his shoulder.

His bare shoulder.

Mydei did a double take when Phainon set the bag down next to the countertop. He had taken his apron and shirt off to work. A light sheen of sweat glittered where dust hadn’t already clung to his skin.

“Will this be enough?” Phainon asked and Mydei had to tear his gaze away from those flexing muscles.

“…it will do for now.”

“Do you need me to grind more?”

Mydei really wanted to say yes but truthfully this was plenty. “You got through about a quarter of the barrel?”

“A little less?”

He nodded. Wheat almost doubled in bulk when it was ground to flour. “…put your shirt and apron back on and come help me make the dough.”

Phainon smiled and nodded, hurrying back to the pantry. “Should I have been grinding down the germinated wheat? Are we making cakes?” he called from there. It was muffled a little while he tugged on his shirt.

“No, we’re making pita,” Mydei told him.

The chef was already scooping up the freshly ground flour to add to the big bowl of bubbly yeast. Phainon knew his trade. The flour was exceptionally fine and excellent quality despite the relatively short amount of time he had spent grinding the wheat. He set it aside.

Phainon struggled to finish pulling his shirt down past his abs as he stumbled out of the pantry. Still no sea legs.

Mydei pointed at him with a spoon. “I would have expected Okhema’s Deliverer to have a firmer grasp of his stance on the sea.”

Phainon shyly looked away. “I thought we already established I’m the son of a farmer. I didn’t start sailing until after Aglaea took me in. I was already a young adult by then.”

That explained a lot.

“Come,” Mydei ordered. He set Phainon up at the countertop and pulled over the yeast to add the rest of the flour. They rolled out the massive ball of dough together, sprinkling more flour onto the countertop as needed to keep it from sticking.

“Do you know how to knead?”

“Have a little more faith in me,” Phainon protested lightly.

Mydei huffed and took half the dough himself. Next to him Phainon copied his actions, moving a little faster than Mydei who narrowed his eyes in suspicion and met his pace, until they were pushing each other faster and faster.

Flour was getting everywhere. It stuck to their hands and arms. Phainon let his dough hit the countertop hard enough to send flour across the kitchen and up onto their faces. He had flour across his cheeks and nose and Mydei was sure he matched.

“At least you aren’t totally hopeless,” Mydei praised when they started separating the dough, mess aside. It wasn’t lost on him that Phainon had somehow turned this into a race and he wasn’t about to let this novice beat him.

“I learned how to work dough so I could trade work for rest. Bakers tend to need the extra hands.”

“You traveled a lot.”

“I wandered for a long time after Aedes Elysiae…” he trailed off, but his hands kept pace, “I wandered for a long time. Took work where I could find it.”

Mydei thought about that for a second as he tossed another disc of dough to his pile. “Were you there when the Black Tide destroyed your home?”

“…yeah,” Phainon grumbled and Mydei felt a little guilty for bringing it up, “you fight the Black Tide a lot, you know what it’s like.”

Phainon reached over Mydei to get more flour to sprinkle on his side.

“But I wasn’t there when it took my home,” Mydei admitted. You have to give trust to get trust. He started to rub his readied dough with olive oil.

“…Castrum Kremnos is…?” Phainon asked and Mydei remembered his friends telling him that Phainon knew less than they had realized. He must not have known that the city had fallen.

“Yes.”

They both started tossing the dough into the oven. One of Phainon’s hit one of Mydei’s and pushed it out of the perfect cooking spot. He flashed Phainon a glare and was met with a cheeky smile, so Mydei made sure to aim his dough at Phainon’s, back and forth knocking the soon to be yummy bread into haphazard cooking places.

With the pita bread baking, Mydei moved them both over to fileting fish. They had a lot to get through. Already scaled from their fishing escapade it was just a matter of deboning and getting the fish into neat slices.

“Were you there?” Phainon asked.

“Hm?”

“When the Black Tide destroyed Castrum Kremnos.”

“No,” Mydei said simply, “we had left before that happened.” But not everyone had made it out. Mydei wasn’t sure how he felt about it. Had he been there, could he have saved more of the citizenry? Would it have mattered?

“Are you sad?” Phainon asked and Mydei was genuinely surprised by the question.

“Why would I be sad about that?”

“I’m not sure,” he admitted as he threw more bones into the waste bucket, “you just seem sad.”

“HKS, that’s ridiculous, focus on your fish, or I’ll beat you in this race too.”

Phainon dialed in fast at that comment. He still lost and Mydei smiled triumphantly as he set his knife down and went to get the lentils.

“Where did you learn to cook?” Phainon asked as Mydei started the fire in the pot and added the lentils to the warming water.

“Self-taught.”

“That’s amazing, Mydeimos,” Phainon praised and Mydei could hear how genuine he was. It made his heart sing.

He made Phainon turn the bread with a long wooden paddle while he seared the fish in a pan on the stovetop with oil, garlic, salt, and pepper. He added the filets, thyme and the chopped onions to the pot with the lentils and then covered it all to soak and cook.

“The bowls are stacked in the closet by the pantry, but it will be a bit yet,” Mydei told Phainon, but the Okheman took the initiative to fetch them while they waited.

“Deliverer,” Mydei started, to get his attention and Phainon turned to look at him, pausing with a stack of bowls in hand.

“Yes?”

Mydei hesitated. For someone that hated speculation, that hated wasting time, it was hard to get to the root of what he wanted to ask.

“If you return to Okhema,” Mydei finally managed, keeping his voice cool and level despite his racing heart, “what would you do?”

“*If?”* Phainon repeated. His demeanor was changing, hardening. He set the bowls down heavily on the countertop. “What do you mean *if*?”

Mydei felt his façade slip, eyes widening at his own mistake for a second before he gathered himself once more. “Answer the question, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

He could see the emotions cycle behind Phainon’s eyes, everything from pain and betrayal to resolute anger. It was taking him some time to process the implication.

“Answer me,” Mydei repeated, a little more gently this time.

Please, he begged inside his head, *please don’t make this harder than it needs to be.*

“What do you want me to say?” Phainon hissed, “that I’ll go home and retire, keep everything a secr-“ It was like everything was hitting Phainon at once. His eyes went wide, and he shook his head while raising a hand to his mouth. “You were never going to let me go, were you?”

Mydei’s eyes darted to the side involuntarily and Phainon must’ve seen it. The man put his hand on his face, slowly running his fingers through his hair as he cursed under his breath.

“Everyone answering my questions, telling me about the ship, about *you*… There’s no way you can let me go back to Aglaea,” he growled, voice suddenly strained.

“Deliverer-“

“Don’t call me that!” Phainon’s vitriol caught Mydei off guard and he was suddenly very aware of how naked he felt without his gauntlets.

“How the hell could I be so stupid? What the fuck happened to not keeping captives, *Captain*.”

Mydei frowned but stayed quiet. There was nothing he could say that wouldn’t upset Phainon further.

“Am I an ailing pet then?” Phainon growled. His eyes were wild and full of anger and hurt. “All of this kindness and camaraderie, was to put me at ease before you kill me in my sleep?”

Mydei met his anger with his own now. “*Absolutely not*. If I wanted you dead you would be.”

“Then what I am I? A pet? A slave?” Phainon demanded with his voice raised and Mydei sneered at those horrible words.

“You are neither of those things, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae,” Mydei insisted, but he couldn’t answer the first question. He didn’t know. He knew what he *wanted* but it didn’t feel right to propose that now.

“Kephale, how was I this *stupid?!”*

“The hell is going on down here?” Leonnius asked as he hurried through the galley to peer into the kitchen.

“Nothing,” Mydei insisted firmly.

Phainon was standing still with his head bowed, shaking. Without another word and with stiff movements, he started setting out bowls and checking the bread.

“Go back to work Leonnius,” Mydei ordered softly and then he did the same, preparing food in uncomfortable silence.

Every time Mydei looked over at Phainon, the man had his head down and his back turned, refusing to look his way.

Worlds apart as they had been from the beginning.

Worlds apart as it felt like they may always be.

Chapter 9: Knowing the Enemy

Chapter Summary

No new tags.

Mydei and Phainon have some things to work out

Chapter Notes

I have been excited for this chapter for so long. I wrote the first half last night crazy late and woke up early to finish it cause I was too excited to share it.

All the sweet comments about how wholesome the fic is and I'm hiding behind the door with the angst bat like, haha yeah, so wholesome :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

If you return to Okhema, Mydei had said. *IF.* Not when. *IF.*

Getting kicked by a dromas would have had the same effect the way the air had been punched from his chest. Phainon's entire fragile world had collapsed in that moment. Any hope he had for peace between their nations, shattered by the clarity that came from a two-lettered word.

If.

There was nothing that could immediately be done, reeling as he was, so Phainon had turned back to his assigned task, chores that now came with a rancid edge to them. Leonnius' voice had been like cold water on a wildfire, a moment to breathe, but not nearly enough.

As he retrieved finished pita from the oven and set them aside on the countertop to cool, he couldn't look at Mydeimos. As he lined bowls out, waiting to be filled with stew, he couldn't look at Mydeimos. As he got started on washing dishes, he would not look up at the Captain.

Phainon felt like an idiot. From day one, Mydei had insisted they didn't keep prisoners but still locked him in a cage to sleep. Like a fool, he had assumed it was for his own protection.

There was the pity in Ptolemy's eyes when Phainon had mentioned trying to learn Kremnoan in only a few weeks. Phainon had thought that maybe it was because the language was hard to learn, now he understood, it was because Ptolemy knew the truth and couldn't tell him that he would never see his home again.

Leonnius' warning about not bonding with older crewmates because they hated Okhemans, Perdikkas reminding him that they were enemies. Earlier that very day, Krateros insisting that Phainon not be allowed to have his sword.

Phainon really stood there and told that old man to his face that he would willingly raise that sword to protect his new friends, that he would prove it given the opportunity…

How fucking stupid was he?

From the beginning it was a constant string of reminders that he was not one of them. He was a prisoner of war. They could not send him back to Okhema. Phainon *knew* as much. He had even worried himself how the Council would act. He *knew* that Aglaea would see through any deception and order him to continue his task hunting pirates, especially if she now knew that he had been in the enemy's clutches. He had theorized himself that the Council of Elders would take all the things he had learned and exploit them, possibly try to finish the war between them.

If their roles had been reversed, if it was Aglaea who had been the Captain finding an enemy in a sinking wreckage, she would never have pulled Mydei from the sea in the first place. The strategic thing to do would've been to kill him as soon as they realized who he served.

Phainon put cooled pita bread in the serving basket, everything he did felt stiff and labored. Every movement weighed down with the sting of betrayal, of realizing that these people he had come to see as friends, who he had been proud to stand beside in the storm, had been leading him on, seeing him as a toy, a temporary plaything.

A plaything that they had welcomed. Now that Phainon knew Mydei was the cook he realized the comfort food that got him through that first night had been made by him. Mydei had pulled him out of the ocean twice now. The first could've been nothing more than an opportunistic gesture before the Prince knew who he was, but saving Phainon from the storm was another thing entirely. He could've let Phainon drown, saved himself the headache of keeping him around, but instead he had pulled Phainon to safety and personally seen to his well-being while he recovered.

He had let Phainon get close to his friends, his *family*, to learn about their history, their way of life, their religion …and sealed his fate in the process.

He could never go home again.

Would that be so bad? He wondered briefly to himself as he passed the bowls stiffly to Mydei to fill with lentils and fish.

Yes. It would be.

Phainon *had* a family back home. The other Chrysos Heirs needed him, loved him. Even now they probably mourn him, assuming he was lost at sea. How horrible did Aglaea feel, believing she had sent him to his death? What about the triplets or Castorice? Phainon had a purpose there, he had a *home* there. A history of standing shoulder to shoulder with purpose that lasted longer than a *week.* He couldn't accept that those things were just *gone* without his

choice, without a goodbye, because a Kremnoan Prince plucked him from the water and decided to keep him!

He fumed while he set the filled bowls on the countertop and sprinkled the pomegranate seeds on top, waiting as men started to file in. He seethed when he brought small barrels of wine to the galley tables so they could start drinking. He glared bitterly at Ptolemy who greeted him warmly with the Kremnoan greeting they were practicing and felt nothing when the librarian lowered his wave with a confused expression.

He ignored them when Hephaestion and Perdikkas started to mumble in hushed and worried tones, sending glances his way. He studied the floor when Fig Stew was given his offering of food and the men began to eat, refusing to take the bowl offered him by Peucesta. When Leonnius tried to speak to him, Phainon physically pushed him aside, shouldering his way through the kitchen to discard his apron and fetch his bracers from the cubby. When Mydei reached for him, Phainon smacked his hand away and fled, hurrying out of the galley and up to the deck for fresh air.

Even when the gentle sway of the ship threatened to take his feet out from under him, Phainon ran. He ran across the deck and upstairs, bursting into Mydei's empty room. He stomped up to take his greatsword, that familiar weight heavy with responsibility.

Chartonus had sold him this sword with the promise of another down the line when he had earned it. Phainon hadn't been able to afford to commission a better one back then. He still barely had any coin to his name. They had talked about him working off the debt, but he never found time. He might never get the chance now.

He saw his own twisted, outraged face looking back at him in the reflection of the blade. Phainon's eyes glittered with grief as much as anger. The fury was easy. It was the sorrow that was hard, that wanted him to slow down for even a moment so it could latch onto him and drag him away to drown him. The fury was what pushed away the soft memories of trying to stumble through a lyre lesson, of standing shoulder to shoulder with Mydei in the rain, of reading a book in two languages, of Fig Stew biting his hand. Fury was what buried the memories of a gentle hand binding his leg, of the smell of burning wax on the deck, of a rope burning his hands while fish tossed in a full net.

Grief was what made him fall to his knees with that sword in his hands, to just feel the weight of it for a moment, only a moment to mourn something that didn't feel real anymore.

And duty was what made him stand back up again. He owed it to Aglaea to get himself home, no matter the cost.

Phainon knew from his time on the Chryseus Leo that Mydeimos the Undying was a man of honor. While his trust in the words of the Kremnoans had been damaged, he had at least seen enough of the man's actions to believe that much to be true.

Sword in hand, Phainon strode out into the evening. He could still smell the food from below, hear the voices of the men as they gathered below in the galley. Above him the thief star glittered red across the sky, heralding the end of the day while the sun settled on the horizon in orange and purple hues.

He thought through his plan with every step back to the galley, sword held loosely in his hands as crew scattered before him, shouting, a couple followed him warily, looking for a chance to stop whatever he may be planning. Treating him openly as the wild dog they thought he was, finally showing him how they really felt. But any time one of them moved in close he glared at them with such poison they stepped away.

Phainon saw a couple of them turn to run to the armory, putting him on a clock, but this wouldn't take long.

"Mydeimos," he called from the bottom of the stairs to the galley. The whole crew had stilled, eyeing his sword, judging the threat. With a heavy heart he saw Hephaestion resting a hand on the sword at his side.

Mydei gently set the basket down and turned to face him with his same guarded expression.

"I challenge you. Fight me," Phainon said loudly, firmly, "for my freedom and my life."

-

When Phainon had run from the galley, Mydei hadn't had the time to pursue. Feeding his men was his top priority, but Phainon was a close second. He had wanted to breach the topic with tact, something that Mydei rarely cared for but had hoped the Okheman would appreciate but not only had things blown up in his face, they escalated out of control.

Phainon was standing in the galley, armed, angry, and out for blood. Mydei chanced a glance at Krateros. The old man was watching Phainon but there was a smugness about him, an air of 'I told you so' that hurt Mydei's heart. His promise to Krateros bounced around in his head and Mydei was trying to decide if Phainon's current actions needed to be answered with a noose. What excuse could he give to spare Phainon's life for this?

"If I had known the heat of the galley would muddle what brains you had, I'd have sent you to work somewhere else," Mydei said with a tilt of his head and softness in his voice to ease the tension. It didn't work.

The men muttered uneasily. Mydei could hear shouting on deck.

"Do you accept?" Phainon growled.

He glanced over at Hephaestion. His first mate was stone-faced, focused. The switch had flipped, and the man was in combat mode. If Mydei didn't do something soon…

At the top of the stairs, several of the crew had caught up, properly armed. Mydei could see their spears pointed at Phainon's back, hear the creak of a heavy war bow drawn tight. They would kill him if he didn't put his sword down.

At first it seemed to Mydei to be the desperate pleas of a cornered man, no more an animal than when they had pulled him aboard, but Phainon had proved himself to be more level-headed than that. He had controlled himself when his men had all died, been willing to set

aside his feelings when they shook hands, made every effort to keep the peace, even between Kremnoans.

It clicked when Mydei was studying the way Phainon held himself, driven, angry, but composed. The sword rested lightly in his hand, not held tightly the way someone completely out of control would have grasped it. His stance was professional, measured, the mark of an expert swordsman, still and poised. Mydei could see the way his eyes systematically darted around the room that he was marking potential threats, ready to retaliate if any of them made a move but he stayed relaxed at ready.

Phainon was giving them both an out.

It was clever really and Mydei felt a rush of relief when he realized it. If Phainon won, then on his own honor as the Crown Prince, Mydei would have to let him go, consequences be damned. Krateros couldn't do anything, none of them could. Any attempts on Phainon's life would belittle the word of their Prince and Captain. Strife would never allow them to infringe on their honor in such a way. Phainon would've won his freedom and absolved Mydei of any responsibility.

"You do realize that by your own demand, if I win, your life and freedom will belong to me?" Mydei asked.

"You won't win." Resolute courage hung so heavily in the air that Mydei almost believed him.

Mydei smiled, a one-sided smirk. "Alright, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," he said, "I accept. We will fight to first blood. If you win, I will honor your right to freedom and release you at a port of your choosing. Not my crew, nor I, will harm you from the moment of your victory until you have left Chryseus Leo in your wake." He crossed his arms. "But if I win, you will abandon any notion of returning to Okhema and join my crew, not as a slave, but as a man in chosen self-exile."

Phainon's grip tightened on his sword, only for a moment, flexing. Every passing second, Phainon felt colder, more distant, a sharp contrast to the fire in his eyes. He was trying to close himself off. "I accept."

The reaction from the crew was mixed. Mydei recognized the voices of older men shouting for him to reject the proposal, others were shouting words of encouragement, already caught up in the excitement of a fight, but most of them were just confused. They mumbled to themselves in harsh whispers, trying to understand what must have felt a dramatic change considering Phainon's good nature until this moment.

Hephastion relaxed but only enough to let go of the hilt of his sword. He still carried a tension in his shoulders as he stepped around the bench he had been sitting at and moved carefully to Phainon's side, gesturing without touching him to guide the man towards the deck.

"Mydeimos," Krateros growled as he stepped up to Mydei's side, "make the duel to the death, don't run the risk of an angry Okheman on the crew."

“That is hardly fair, Krateros,” Mydei sighed, “and I trust Phainon to honor his word, just as I will honor mine.”

“And what makes you think he will not harbor a grudge when he loses? When he’s forced to stay on a ship, he has no love of?”

“Are you so willingly blind, Krateros?” Mydei turned and went into the galley with Krateros on his heels. He took off his apron and folded it reverently, tucking it away in exchange for his chiton and pauldron. “He is torn and hurt. I heard it in his voice earlier and it’s plain on his face. This duel absolves him of guilt. He doesn’t know what he wants, so he’s letting fate decide and resolved himself to honor the outcome.”

“Then he is a fool.”

Mydei didn’t have the heart to tell Krateros that he was doing the same thing. The same difficult decision Mydei had been wrestling with was out of his hands now. As he pulled on his gauntlets and stretched his fingers, Mydei considered that Phainon was in the same position.

That puppy was too pure and innocent for his own good. It wasn’t a scheme falling in love with this ship and her people. It wasn’t manipulative acting that Mydei heard in Phainon’s voice as he cursed himself. There was a very real chance that Phainon was also torn between wanting his homeland, a sentiment that Mydei understood, and wanting to maintain these new bonds that he had formed. As betrayed as Phainon may have felt, that betrayal could only exist if those friendships had value to him.

They were equally trapped by the circumstances of their positions, their origins.

There was something freeing about the idea of solving it with brute force.

Mydei straightened himself, checked his jewelry with light touches, and double checked his pauldron and armor. He didn’t know what kind of a fighter Phainon was, but if the bard’s tales were true, then this would be as exciting as it was freeing.

He walked out of the galley with Krateros on his heels.

The crew had followed Phainon to the deck, creating a large circle. Hephaestion was standing next to him with a hand hovering over Phainon’s sword hand, not touching him, just making him wait, ready to catch him in case the man attacked before Mydei was ready. It felt entirely unnecessary to Mydei. Phainon was eerily calm, waiting patiently.

“Phainon of Aedes Elysiae,” Mydei called as he stood across the deck from him. He stretched his arms over his head and rolled his fingers. “I am obliged to offer you a chance to reconsider.”

“I will not.”

No banter. It hurt more than it should.

“Hephaestion, clear the deck.”

Reluctantly, the first mate stepped away from Phainon and started shouting at the men, making them retreat to higher decks to give the two warriors space. Mydei could see the glint of spears and shields mixed among his people. They didn't trust Phainon. Should he let the Okheman win to appease his crew?

"Peucesta, give us a count of three."

Clear notes sounded across the deck. Mydei saw Phainon adjust his stance, pointing his sword at Mydei. That damn thing was heavy and he was holding it so casually with the one arm fully extended. That alone was an impressive demonstration of strength.

A note. That was one.

Another. Two.

On the last chord, Phainon lunged. He was incredibly fast, closing the distance between them in three reaching steps, that sword building momentum as he swung.

Mydei responded by clawing the air in an uppercut. His tattoos flashed faintly in the dim light of dusk and crystal sprouted from the deck, sharp and reaching, cresting like a wave about to break on top of him. An opening attack like that, Mydei had timed it to not only block but to stab at Phainon, reaching for gold, but for once those horrible sea legs worked in Phainon's favor and Mydei missed.

Crystal broke as the blade of the sword crashed against it, the bright red dissolving as Mydei dispelled it so he could reach for a surprised Phainon with his fist. The swordmaster recovered quickly and when Mydei pressed in close, Phainon twisted the blade in his grip so he could pull it in close to his body to intercept those gauntlets with the wide blade.

The grating sound of metal on metal made Mydei smile. Not very many people could keep up with Mydei, even on his bad days. They had only clashed twice and Mydei was already feeling the excitement in his blood, the rush of adrenaline that came from recognizing a worthy opponent.

Phainon shouted and spun, his foot came up but Mydei blocked it with his arm. He twisted to grab the leg but before he could scrape along the flesh to seal his victory, the sword spun around dragging in a wide arc parallel with the deck enroute to disembowel and Mydei had to retreat.

Phainon let the arc finish and then stumbled to recover his stance. On stable footing, the man was probably a monster. Mydei used the shifting ship to budget his stamina, letting the subtle rock work for him rather than against, so when he surged forward again, he expected it to be game over, but Phainon was able to counter his claws.

Back and forth they traded blows with several close calls, but even with the uphill tilt, Phainon showed no signs of exhaustion and Mydei was feeling a little humbled. He was so impressed with Phainon's bladework as they chased each other across the deck that Mydei again considered letting him win. Let the man earn his freedom, and then he had to duck as that blade cut so close to his face he could've kissed it, and he knew more than anything he

could never allow that. Not because of the stakes, not because he really wanted Phainon to stay, but because Phainon *deserved* Mydei's best.

Mydei had a better grasp of naval combat. He used the railings, the lines, and the shrouds to his benefit, enjoying the verticality of their arena and the home field advantage, while Phainon had a better understanding of controlling his immediate space. The more Mydei tried to use his crystals, the faster Phainon learned the tells until it ceased to be a viable strategy entirely.

The only advantage Mydei had at all was Phainon's inexperience fighting on an unstable surface and the longer they dueled, the faster he learned how to compensate for his own weakness.

The sword came down towards Mydei's head and he reached up to grab it, pinching it tightly between both hands. Phainon was taller and Mydei was feeling that now as the man bared down on him, both hands on the hilt of his sword, leaning his weight behind the clash. Briefly Mydei considered letting the sword meet his shoulder, take the hit so he could land one of his own but then he remembered the win condition was first blood, and he lamented. How much better of a fight could this be if they were both allowed some recklessness?

The sword inched closer, Mydei's arms shook from the angle. He chanced a glance at Phainon's face and saw the glimmer of a smile that matched his own. Phainon was enjoying himself too. Under that resolve and desperation, the weight of high stakes, Phainon was having a good time.

"I understand now," Mydei crooned, "there is no one in Okhema that can challenge you."

Phainon's eyes narrowed but he didn't deny it.

This ship started to sway, Mydei felt the change in Phainon's leverage. He let go of the sword and dropped to the deck. The blade slammed into the railing behind him and Mydei was able to land a kick to Phainon's belly with both legs while he braced himself against the deck with his shoulder.

The Okheman went flying across the deck, slamming into the opposite railing with a crunch. He coughed and stumbled with the force of the blow but no blood. Phainon wiped some spit from his lips with the back of his hand.

Mydei used the sword lodged in the railing to pull himself up, appreciating the craftsmanship of the handle as he rose. It wasn't the best sword Mydei had seen but whomever had made this weapon had cared even for their cheaper creations. He wrenched the weapon free with one hand and tossed it across the deck. It skittered and bounced until Phainon stopped the slide with his boot, but he didn't bend down to pick it up right away.

Phainon was still watching him, waiting for the trap but Mydei held his hands out to the sides to show him he was waiting.

"If I am going to win, it will be because I am the better fighter," Mydei promised.

"*If* you win," Phainon repeated, jabbing at the unasked question there, the possibility that either of them could take this victory.

"If I win." It was as good of an acknowledgement of Phainon's skill as he was going to get right now.

Phainon tucked the toe of his boot under the blade right in front of the hilt and kicked it up to his hand, where he expertly swung it in a circle before he took his stance again. They watched each other carefully. Sweat dripped down Mydei's chest and back. He could see it beading on Phainon's brow.

The sun was setting; the lamps were being lit around the deck around them. Phainon waited for the glint of firelight to make Mydei blink and then he was leaping across the deck again.

Mydei's crystals reached for him, compensating for his inevitable stumble, but Phainon was sure-footed this time and the tip of the blade nearly caught his chest. If he hadn't have stepped backwards…

Phainon's assault was flawless and Mydei found himself retreating. He hit the railing and threw up more crystals in defense, using them to dive around Phainon so he had more space to maneuver, but the man was relentless, swooping in low and cleaving at unexpected angles. Mydei was still able to meet him at every clash, still kept his blade from licking his skin, but the advantage that Mydei had a moment ago was just gone.

He waited for the sway of the ship, waited for it like a cue to turn the tides but it didn't come and Phainon's fist collided with Mydei's chest, too close to the base of his neck for comfort. Mydei could see Phainon's eyes glitter when he huffed, still smiling. The man had aimed for Mydei's throat and missed but he was already moving on, thinking ahead with glittering eyes and an excited smirk, and if it wasn't one of the most attractive things Mydei had seen in a long time.

Phainon fit in with Mydei's crew so much more than he had realized. He *belonged* here, Mydei was so sure of that. He didn't want this synergy to ever end.

With renewed resolve, Mydei roared and leaped back into the fray, finally putting Phainon on the back foot. The whole world fell away from them. The cheers and jeers of the crowd were a distant rumble. All that mattered was the flow of the fight and the stupid grins on both their faces.

Again, they clashed, sword and gauntlets ringing against each other.

"We should have done this earlier," Phainon told him while they were in close. He sounded a little sad and for a second Mydei wondered if he meant sparring or meant dueling for his freedom.

"When we started, I didn't care which of us won," Mydei admitted, "but the longer we fight the more I need to."

Phainon's eyes widened and Mydei won the clash, pushing him back. He took a step towards Phainon but paused, waiting for the ship to sway so he could rush with Phainon's stumble, but it didn't come.

Mydei's smile faded, his brows furrowed, suddenly very serious, snapping out of his battle haze to look up at the sails. Phainon must've noticed something too. He tilted his head, puzzled.

The sheets above hung limp and heavy. No wind.

Around them the crew was uneasy. Krateros barked orders in Kremnoan, calling them to arms and many of them swarmed below, heading to the armory.

Phainon raised his sword again, but Mydei had abandoned the fight entirely. He raced to the railing and looked over the side. The ship wasn't moving *at all*. The water beneath them was still a dark blue, a good sign, but it was churning in a circle like an eddy.

An eddy on the ocean.

Mydei turned to face Phainon again. The man looked frustrated, coiled, ready to pounce, to finish this fight.

"Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," Mydei called, "I'm sorry, but we cannot finish this fight."

Phainon frowned. "Then you concede?"

"I do not."

"Then fight me!" he growled but the words fizzled when the sounds carried across the water, tearing screeches ripped through the darkness and then the whole ship lurched when another vessel collided with them.

-

Phainon had been torn the entire fight. He was torn when he proposed the fight, it was *why* he had proposed the fight to begin with. Faced with an impossible decision this just seemed the easier way to solve the problem. He had every intention of honoring the outcome of their clash. But the longer they fought, the more his blood cheered with every movement, the more Phainon started to beg and plead with the Titans that he could somehow have both.

Why couldn't this be the end of it? Why couldn't this clash be the end of the Okheman/Kremnoan conflict? Of course the answer was more complicated, but it angered Phainon to no end that it had to be.

He *loved* this. He *loved* the way Mydei fought. That same synergy they had fighting the storm surged and flowed in the combat against one another. He loved that Mydei didn't hold back, that he respected Phainon enough to want to win. The longer they danced around each other the more obvious it was how much of a compliment they were giving to the other to fight fairly and with their whole hearts. They both wanted to win, not because of the high stakes, but purely for the joy of victory against an incredible opponent.

Every gasp, every clash, every drop of sweat made Phainon *want.*

And that duty and desire fought inside him more bitterly and tumultuous than the fight happening before his eyes.

He was so angry when Mydei stopped, when the fight came to an anti-climatic end.

“Phainon of Aedes Elysiae,” Mydei called with genuine disappointment and urgency in his voice, “I’m sorry, but we cannot finish this fight.”

“Then you concede?”

“I do not.”

“Then fight me!” Phainon snarled, but then he felt it too. The weight on the air, the foul smell of bloody ashes and cooking flesh, and then the sounds curled in the shell of Phainon’s ear. The ripping screeches of Black Tide monsters.

The ship lurched and Phainon stabbed his blade into the deck to keep his balance. He dropped to one knee as he fell, leaning heavily against his weapon. The crew was springing into action. Monsters were spilling onto the deck. One of them raced at him, but Mydei’s fist crushed its head, and it crumpled into dust. The Kremnoan looked down at him with sharp but worried eyes. They darted towards the Black Tide, then back to Phainon, taunting him with guarded curiosity.

“Did you mean it?” Mydei asked him, “this morning. Did you mean it?”

‘And would he raise his sword in defense of your crew?’

‘I would, if I could. …I’ll just have to show you…should the occasion arise.’

Phainon saw a massive Black Tide monster lunge at the pair of them. Arrows from across the deck slammed into its side but it was undaunted, lumbering with a metallic roar, claws reaching for the Prince. Mydei turned to catch it, but Phainon was faster. His sword ran through the beast’s chest, and it collapsed in a gurgling mess at the Prince’s feet.

“Yes,” Phainon breathed and raised his sword, pointing it at the Black Tide as he twisted his stance, taking a step backwards to be in line with Mydei, his back turned towards the Kremnoan. The Prince grinned wider than before and cracked his knuckles. He too adjusted his stance, turning his back towards Phainon as well in a returned gesture of trust, eyes trained on the invaders, ready and excited to fight.

Okheman, Kremnoan, it didn’t matter anymore.

It was time to remember who the real enemy was.

Chapter End Notes

I can't even tell you guys how happy the comments make me. I wiggle in my chair every time I see them in my inbox.

Chapter 10: Trust Earned With Blood

Chapter Summary

> They have some stuff to work out but priorities priorities

Chapter Notes

> Thank you all again for your comments. I write for myself first but the excitement and energy to write quickly is 100% fueled by you guys and how badly I want to share what I have planned :3c

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Already warmed up from their original conflict, Phainon moved seamlessly into combat with the Black Tide. The ship that had rammed the Chryseus Leo had slammed into her at an angle, leaving them all shaken but not at any risk of sinking. The hull was too thick, too solid to be taken down so easily even by another war vessel. It was only enough contact to keep the ships together in the still water while monsters poured over the railing.

The Kremnoan Detachment was quick to respond, professionally engaging the monsters on deck with their shields and spears. Heavy bows twanged in time with Krateros' shouted orders, firing at enemies as they made the crossing. Several Kremnoans, protected by their archers, retrieved wide planks, creating bridges to ease the monster's crossing, luring them onto the Chryseus Leo.

They didn't know yet if the ship was infected, if crossing would turn the crew. The ship protected them on home turf, but until they were sure, it wasn't safe to cross themselves. Better to lure the monsters to their deaths than succumb to bloodlust and race into the Black Tide's trap.

Phainon's sword gleamed in the orange glow of monster parts and those pinpricks of lantern flames that tried to stave off the darkness of night in a battle of their own. The sun's last rays disappeared as he cleaved a monster in two and slid under another. Mydei's crystals destroyed that one, protecting Phainon's back as he surged to the next.

There was no time to entertain his fears, no time to listen to the terror in his memories, no time to heed the whispers of the Titan in the back of his mind. Every time Phainon started to struggle with the inherent fear of fighting the Tide, that impossible enemy that only knew how to consume, he would see the flash of red in the corner of his eye.

Against all reason, Mydei gave him courage.

While the others played defense, Phainon and Mydei were tenacity incarnate, two harbingers of Strife, tearing through the swarm back-to-back, meeting each other swing for swing, counting under their breath as though they had shared the battlefield their entire lives. A dance that they had created, a song that only they could harmonize. They were keenly aware of the other at all times, could sense when the other needed help, and when they needed to move on. When Phainon pressed a monster, Mydei dashed to the next, leap frogging to efficiently dispatch enemies until the spill onto the deck ceased to be enough to sate the lust for battle.

Mydei pinched Phainon's arm, just enough to get his attention and then wordlessly sprinted across the deck to jump to the other ship. If it had been anyone else, Phainon might've hesitated. He might have sat back and thought about the risk, may have reasoned it out properly and realized that only Chrysos Heirs *could* safely resist corruption, that it made sense for them to be the Vanguard. He may have still considered the sizes and strengths of the monsters waiting on that other deck, one of which lunged at Mydei the second the man's boots touched lumber.

But Phainon didn't take the chance to second guess himself. Mydei lit a fire in Phainon that no one else had before. His sword ripped through the neck of the monster as he crossed the gap on Mydei's heels. Crystal covered his weakness. His sword watched Mydei's back.

They fought until the deck was nearly cleared and then Mydei was shouting for Phainon from the stairs to the hold.

He paused then, as Mydei disappeared below decks to search for monsters there in the dark. Phainon was surrounded by dust. Monsters still screeched and raged against the Kremnoans on the Chryseus Leo, feeling far away now that he had a single moment to himself, to appreciate the lingering ache starting to creep in his muscles. Adrenaline still screamed along his veins, craving this battle, enjoying it deep in his gut, feeding his long-buried desire for revenge against the monsters that destroyed his beloved home and threatened his new one. The problems of a few quints ago seemed so pointless now in the face of their shared extinction.

"Phainon!" he heard Leonnius shout, and his head jerked up to see the man pointing from the shrouds of the Chryseus Leo. Phainon wasn't sure how to tell if it was safe or not for them to come aboard, he wanted to yell back, but Leonnius pointed again to the stairs.

Someone needed to watch Mydei's back. Phainon took off running again. He nearly leaped down the stairs, skipping four or five with every step.

There was almost no light in the belly of the war ship, just the fading glow of monsters as they dissolved, ripped apart by claws. Down here the sounds of battle were muted. He crept along slowly, listening for movement in the stillness.

"Deliverer."

Phainon nearly jumped out of his skin when the gauntlet came down on his shoulder.

“Mydeimos!” he yelped back, “I could’ve hurt you!”

Even now the sword shook in Phainon’s hands, resisting the instinct to swipe.

A faint red glow filled the space as Mydei summoned crystal to his palm. His tattoos pulsed with light that flowed to his hand, circling brightly as he kept the tool suspended.

“This is not a merchant vessel,” he mumbled as he walked through the space, noting supplies.

Phainon dispelled his sword for now in a glimmer of blue light. He gestured to a flag on the wall with his chin. “Okheman Navy…” he mumbled and that horrible pit in his gut returned.

“They must have been caught in the storm and turned,” Mydei mused. He was already digging through boxes one-handed, the other still holding their light.

Searching for me? Phainon worried with horrible dread.

Mydei was searching more deliberately now, digging through chests and speed walking through the hold until he found what he was looking for. His claws pulled a golden thread from the edge of a barrel, one of Aglaea’s. Before Phainon could stop him, Mydei crushed it and the broken thread dissolved.

“There are good weapons here,” Mydei reported, “and the ship is not infected. The water in the barrels is clean, it must have drifted away from its master’s reach for now.” He wandered back over to Phainon, who was standing still, staving off the guilt that was budding in his gut. “Deliverer, go back to the Leo and tell the others that it is safe to loot the ship.”

That snapped Phainon out of his trance, back to reality. “What?”

“When you return, help me mark what supplies are worth keeping.”

That’s right. Mydei was still a pirate.

Any joy and excitement that had come from teaming up against the Black Tide shattered like glass. They had literally been fighting for Phainon’s freedom a quint ago. The feelings of betrayal surged back up again with the bile in the back of his throat. He tried to swallow it back down, but everything stuck.

“You want me to steal from my own people?” he asked in a low whisper.

Mydei’s brow furrowed, and he shuffled uncomfortably in place, as though it just occurred to him what he had asked of Phainon.

He opened his mouth to respond, a command, Phainon assumed but it never came. A vicious squeal ripped through the dark. There was a flash of orange and then a blade erupted from Mydei’s belly.

The moment passed in an extended blink. The kind of moment that felt longer than it was, that lasted less than a second to everyone who wasn’t trapped in that bubble of time. The

annoyed shock on Mydei's face, the twist of the blade attached to the monster's arm, the way golden blood spattered across Phainon's chest and legs.

Phainon's sword was summoned and cleaving the monster in half from the head down before he really had time to process the weight of what happened. It screamed and collapsed in orange embers, gleaming in the dark, as the blade ripped free with a sickening squelch.

The light went out as Mydei stumbled forward, colliding with Phainon's chest. He hurried to wrap his arms around the man and felt the warmth of precious blood spilling across his belly where he slumped.

"Mydei!" he shouted.

"Try not to sound so upset," Mydei scolded, "we are enemies are we not?" The Kremnoan laughed a little bit at his attempt at a joke but he still sounded like he was in pain. "I have suffered worse."

Again, Phainon dispelled his sword so he could use both hands to hold him up. He knew, he *knew* that the Prince was immortal but experience in combat still screamed that Death was fast approaching. He could feel where the sword had entered at Mydei's side, slick and hot.

"You're shaking," Mydei noted in the dark, "you better not be crying. How shameful, Deliverer, stressing over someone who cannot die."

Phainon felt him shift and then strong arms were pushing him off, towards the dim glow of the stairs.

"Let me help you," he insisted but Mydei shoved him again.

"We still have work to do and my people are still fighting. I am behind you, go tell them it is safe to cross and that we have supplies to load."

Phainon shuffled uncomfortably in the black.

"I'll not make you help," Mydei promised, softer this time, "I promised you I would honor your desire to not engage in piracy."

"Let me help you back to the Leo-"

Mydei hissed, "this is nothing, Deliverer, stop wasting both our time with misplaced sympathy." The light returned to Mydei's hand. The shine of golden blood was everywhere but he was at least still standing, hunched but upright. "Until our duel meets an appropriate end our original agreement is still binding. If you really want to help, then do as I say!"

He stumbled after Phainon enough to shove him again and then Phainon relented.

Phainon ran up the stairs as fast as he had stumbled down them the first time, hurrying up to the deck where the only shouts were the calls of the Kremnoans, still waiting for word from their Prince. There were no monsters left, all of them dead, the crew waiting patiently.

More shouts when they saw him. A ripple of unease that Phainon disregarded in favor of finding his footing. The swaying ship made Phainon stumble, but he hurried to one of their bridges and scurried over to the Chryseus Leo where Hephaestion caught him and held his arms tight to steady him.

“The ship is safe,” Phainon reported, “Mydei is-“ He trailed off when he saw how the others were looking at him. He followed their eyes to where he was covered in blood.

“Perdikkas!” Hephaestion shouted. Others were crowding, getting in close to see what was happening.

The doctor shoved through and pressed a hand to Phainon’s chest and belly, demanding, “where are you hurt?”

“It’s not mine,” he hurried to say. The moment the words were out of his mouth, he regretted them.

The legion pulled him away from Perdikkas, rough and experienced hands were forcing him to his knees, pulling his hands behind his back, shouting in Kremnoan. He heard Krateros’ voice among them. Hephaestion was yelling, speaking so rapidly that he couldn’t even try to understand them.

“Mydei is still over there!” Phainon shouted but he was drowned out. The shafts of spears were crossed in front of him, someone had a firm grip on his hair, holding his head down so all he could see was the deck and Mydei’s blood soaking through his clothing. He felt sticky and uncomfortable. His muscles ached from fighting, from being held so tightly. Tiny, unshed tears pricked at the corners of his eyes, finally spilling over at the feeling of helplessness on top of everything else.

“Someone needs to go get him! He told me to send people over!” he shouted desperately but no one was listening.

-

Mydei felt embarrassed more than anything else. He stood still in the dark, wincing when he tried to move, mumbling ‘ow’ every time he shifted. The pain was whatever, compared to dying a stab wound was nothing, even if it did go through.

He actually let that puppy distract him. It had been a very long time since a monster had managed to slip under his radar like that.

He gently pressed on the exit wound and followed its path to his side where the blade had entered. Golden blood would save him from turning at least. The injury was already starting to knit back together from the inside out like always. It wouldn’t even scar when it was done healing. For now it was just annoying, but not half as annoying as Phainon’s worried shouts.

It was probably jarring for Phainon to see that, but he’d have to get over it if he was going to be around for a long time …he hoped Phainon would be around for a long time. That seemed

less likely after how Phainon had reacted earlier in the galley. They would need to finish their fight to settle that daunting loose end.

Mydei pouted to himself thinking about how incredible it was to fight alongside Phainon. The flow of that engagement had been electric, even before the Black Tide and fighting side by side had felt better than clashing against each other. He really hoped they could do it again.

He pressed a hand to his side and stumbled towards the stairs. If Perdikkas could get this wrapped up fast enough, Mydei could help move supplies. He was surprised his men weren't already over here helping, they were usually on standby and Phainon had run out of here so fast he might've been flying. There was no reason it should be taking this long to wrap up such a straightforward skirmish.

The fresh air on deck was still heavy with strife, not only were his men still on the Chryseus Leo, they were arguing and yelling at each other. Mydei frowned and stomped over to the bridge to cross to his own ship where he stayed on the railing, holding the lines for balance.

Hephaestion and Krateros were yelling at each other. He could see the old man standing over Phainon with his sword drawn and held at his side.

The Okheman was pinned down on his knees, held still by men of the old guard. They had crossed their spears in front of him and forced his neck over the spot where the shafts joined by his hair. Even from there Mydei could see him shaking, with fear or frustration he couldn't tell.

Hephaestion, Leonnius, Ptolemy, and Perdikkas were trying to get to him, demanding Krateros release the man while the old teacher insisted it was for everyone's safety.

"What the hell is going on over here?" he snarled in Kremnoan, and the crew silenced immediately, turning to look at Mydei.

Perdikkas moved first, instantly stepping towards the Prince and reaching into his pack at his side, presumably for bandages, Mydei didn't give him the chance. He held a hand out to stop him and dropped onto the deck, priorities had changed. His crew parted for him and he stalked towards where they had Phainon. Blood squelched in his footsteps, leaving shiny spots on the deck.

"Krateros," Mydei hissed, "what is the meaning of this?"

"This treacherous Okheman snake returns to us covered in *your* blood after demanding a duel with you and you question *my* actions?" Krateros asked. The teacher was fuming, shaking with anger Mydei hadn't seen in many years. "I knew he could not be trusted to honor his word."

"Phainon wouldn't do that," Hephaestion hissed, "he is truer to Strife than you are Krateros! Where is *your* honor and reason?"

“How dare you speak to me of honor and reason when you have also been enchanted by this siren in our midst!?”

Mydei watched Phainon who was holding still, defeated. They were arguing in a language he couldn’t understand. Was he afraid? Was he angry?

“’The sort of words a man says is the sort he hears in return,’” Ptolemy quoted from behind Hephaestion, “Phainon has done nothing wrong! You are making him the image of your own fears!”

“Then how do you explain our Prince’s blood?” Krateros countered.

“He saved me from a Black Tide creature,” Mydei said bluntly.

“You expect me to believe that a Black Tide creature could injure you so deeply?” Krateros raised the sword, pointing with it at Mydei’s injury before swinging it close to Phainon’s bowed head. Phainon flinched when the steel flashed close and Mydei tensed.

Mydei sighed and crossed his arms, fighting to stay level-headed, “Now you doubt *my* word, teacher?”

Krateros hesitated then, so did his men.

“Are you so determined to hate this Okheman that you would doubt *me? When he has proven your words of this morning wrong?”*

“I know you have a soft spot for this beast,” Krateros growled.

“And would you have killed him before I gave the order? Did I not tell you that I would tighten the noose around his neck myself if I deemed him a threat?”

Krateros wilted under Mydei’s growl. “You misunderstand, Prince,” he insisted, “it was only right that we hold him until we knew what happened.”

“And now that I have told you the truth, what will you do Krateros? Our fight is not yet concluded, I have a vow to him, would you shame me?”

They waited in silence while Krateros and Mydei glared at each other.

“Now, Krateros,” Mydei demanded, “there is yet a ship we must deal with before the winds and ocean resume their natural course.”

Krateros tsked and sheathed his sword. His men let go of Phainon who collapsed onto his hands and knees. Mydei had to resist the urge to drop beside him, to pull Phainon into his arms and make sure he was okay.

It was Leonnius that hurried to do what Mydei could not, rushing to Phainon’s side to help him sit back on his heels, to whisper softly to him with reassurances. Still Phainon held still with his hands resting in loose fists on his thighs and his head hung low. No doubt he was

trying to make sense of what was happening, lost in his own thoughts. They would have to clear things up later.

“Hephaestion,” Mydei said softly, and the first mate was hurrying to bark orders, sending men across to the Okheman war ship.

“Perdikkas,” he called next, and the doctor stepped up with bandages. Again, Mydei waved him off and asked for a report instead. He never stopped looking at Phainon as the doctor gave him the catalog of injuries. No one had died; injuries were minor aside from his own.

“We should get him somewhere safer,” Leonnius insisted. He had an arm around Phainon’s back. “He doesn’t look good.”

Mydei shook his head. There was a discussion that needed to happen. Krateros’ concerns needed to be addressed before they could be allowed to fester further than they already had.

“Deliverer,” Mydei called, changing his tongue to speak in a way he could understand.

Phainon tilted his head back to look at him. His eyes were dull, tired, overwhelmed but his face was guarded, carefully neutral, already gathering himself.

“Are you well enough to stay here on your knees for a time?” he asked, trying to be gentle despite the gravel in his voice.

Phainon nodded and bowed his head again.

Perdikkas grabbed Mydei’s shoulder and turned him so he could hiss low. “What are you doing?”

“Krateros holds the ear and hearts of half the crew,” Mydei explained, “I must make peace with him.”

The grip on Mydei’s shoulder tightened. “You cannot kill, Phainon.”

“I gave my word,” Mydei reassured him, “I will not kill him unless he gives me reason to need to.”

Perdikkas’ eyes darkened. “The way he confronted you in the galley-“

“Is not enough. Perdikkas, please, have faith in me.”

“…I do, Mydeimos,” Perdikkas insisted, “but please remember when you pass judgement, that Phainon isn’t just yours to do with as you please anymore. He’s one of us now too.”

Mydei’s eyes darted to Perdikkas but otherwise he didn’t react. He lazily watched the crew bringing supplies over, he noted the way Peucesta and Hephaestion kept glancing his way with worried expressions. The whole crew was uneasy, uncomfortable with the situation, with the way their Prince and a respected General had clashed.

He waited until they had rolled the goods to the hold and set the sails of the Okheman vessel alight with fire. Mydei waited until the ship began to sway, free of the Black Tide's eddy. The sails caught the wind as they kicked up again to gently pull the ship along on their lazy glide as though they had never ceased. The crew lingered on deck, curiosity keeping them close.

"Krateros," Mydei called, loud enough to command all their attention.

The old man shouldered through the crowd to stand where his Prince could see him.

"I would hear your thoughts."

Krateros was already a hardened man with a permanent scowl. A man of action, a man that Mydei knew to be reasonable and good. But he was also stubborn and heavy with grudges and experience that narrowed his vision.

He was confident when he spoke, keeping his voice loud enough to be heard, and keeping to Kremnoan so that everyone would understand. Everyone except Phainon.

"The Okheman is a problem," he said simply, "he cannot be trusted. I stand by my order to arrest him when he returned without you."

"You assumed me dead?" Mydei asked.

"No. Of course we know that you cannot die, Mydeimos, but I could not allow him to roam free while evidence suggested he attacked you. Not on the heels of an important duel with stakes of such value. How could I be sure that he would not raise his blade to any of the crew after behaving so dishonorably?"

That was a reasonable concern from a paranoid parent figure.

"Bullshit," someone coughed from the side and Mydei turned.

"Do you have something to say, Hephaestion?"

"I do."

"Speak."

"Krateros is so buried in the past he refuses to acknowledge the proof of Phainon's *actions."* Hephaestion turned to the crew, appealing to them directly. "Has he done *anything* to suggest that Krateros is right to be suspicious? That he is a spy sent by the Goldweaver? He has only served and now *protected* this crew and our Prince."

"My caution is not blindness," Krateros insisted, "you are too young to remember, Hephaestion, what the Okhemans did to your elders when we clashed in the waters outside of Styxia." Some of the older crew, people that had served Kremnos for decades, were nodding, shuffling at the memories. "You don't remember how much blood was spilled because of their spies when they came for us on home soil, or the way they infiltrated our ranks at the isles of Sabany. Trust is a luxury you enjoy paid for with Kremnoan blood."

“You would pin the sins of a nation on the shoulders of one man!”

“They call him *Deliverer*. From whom do you believe they want to be delivered from?”

Hephaestion growled. Tensions were high. Mydei could see his first mate and best friend fiddling with the hilt of his sword. Normally, he would welcome a fight, let them clash to resolve their feelings but Mydei knew it would escalate too far and there had been enough blood spilled for one night.

Krateros noticed too. He also reached for the sword at his side, drawing it and holding it to the side so it could catch the light. Others responded in kind until steel flashed in every hand. The deck was divided. Mydei saw Phainon shift in the corner of his eye, still on his knees but with his head raised, watching with a sour expression.

“I will not lose sleep over one more dead Okheman,” Krateros huffed.

“You will not harm him without spilling Kremnoan blood first,” Hephaestion snarled, and a few others shouted their agreement.

Mydei stepped forward so he was between them, gore from his own belly still prominently on display. Blood still dripped to the deck, spilling down his sides in rivulets. He wanted them to see it.

“I tire of bloodshed,” he admitted tiredly, arms crossed.

Mydei continued with a firmer voice, channeling the authority he despised to appeal to the traditionalists on the crew, “Krateros, I understand your fears. I know they are born of experience and grief. Hephaestion, I agree that Phainon has done nothing yet to prove himself a threat. His challenge to me was a gesture of respect and it is still binding. Our battle is not yet concluded and until it is, Phainon is not to be harmed, lest you who are my people bring shame upon me in the eyes of our Titan.”

The crew murmured but most of them lowered their weapons. Krateros was not one of them. Mydei could see fear and worry in his eyes. Not good enough. That was fine, Mydei had more to say.

“When I ripped out the old King’s heart it was with the promise of a new beginning for our people,” he huffed, “there is no beginning in nursing this hatred of Okhema, only chains that keep us bound to a bloody past with no absolution! Even now we bicker at each other’s throats, divided over an enemy that has not mattered since Eurypon’s head rolled. If a single man can tear us so completely, what hope have we against the Black Tide?”

Mydei looked over his shoulder at Phainon, at his expression. The Okheman's brow was creased with confusion, he still didn’t understand.

“Do we not all bleed?” Mydei asked while he looked at the warrior, “do we not all want freedom from the encroaching Tide?”

Phainon tilted his head, it was subtle, but it was there. Even if he didn't understand Mydei's words, the sentiment was getting through.

"This obsession stops right *now*," Mydei growled as he turned back to Krateros, "we move forward as a united Kremnos right *now.* And if you are not ready to accept that Krateros, then at least continue to uphold our traditions of Strife. Until such time as our duel concludes, Phainon is to this ship as he has been. He will earn his keep with his work, share our meals, and be left to his own peace."

Krateros slowly lowered his sword to sheathe it. He sighed and shook his head but he still respected Mydei. "For your sake and for my oath to your mother," he said, "I will honor your wishes."

Satisfied, Mydei nodded. "Then let us see to our wounded and rest."

The crew started to scatter until only Mydei, Phainon, and his five closest friends were left, only then did Hephaestion sheathe his own sword. There was still a feral glint to his eyes.

"You should have killed me," Phainon told them. Firm, cold, and resolute.

Peucesta slapped him across the back of the head beating at least three others who had raised their hands to do so. He startled and looked up at them with surprise coloring the edges of his fury.

"What do you think all of that was about?" Perdikkas scolded. The doctor was still trying to get close to Mydei with some sort of medicinal cream in his hands.

"We care about you, HKS," Leonnius growled. He put an arm around Phainon's neck and pulled him in tight to ruffle his hair, a playful salute, but Phainon pushed him away and scrambled backwards to his feet.

"Just stop," he insisted, "stop pretending."

"*Pretending*?" Hephaestion snarled, with such venom that even Mydei leaned away with wide eyes. "Is that what all of this is about? Your caustic mood today, challenging the Captain for your freedom? Because you think we're all messing with you?"

Phainon blinked away his surprise. All his fire was draining away under the assault.

"You are no different than Krateros!" the first mate panted. Peucesta put a hand on his shoulder to calm his friend down and Hephaestion took the hint, shrugging him off to pace in a tight circle instead.

"Phainon," Leonnius started, but he hesitated searching for the words, and Ptolemy stepped up instead.

"You have earned the truth," he admitted, "but not right now. It's late, everyone is tired. Exhaustion and battle high make for short tempers and this is a discussion that should be had with clear minds and open hearts. For all our sakes, please set aside your anger with us for tomorrow and we will do the same."

Phainon thought that over and then nodded, just a tiny back and forth tilt of his head.

“Good. Tomorrow we will speak with you of what just happened too,” Ptolemy promised, “I imagine you are confused. For now, know that we here are on your side, no matter what happens in the future, you have earned that much from us.” He looked to the others for approval and every one of them nodded in agreement.

Mydei held a hand out, gesturing towards the upper deck. “Leonnius, will you take him to my room? Help him set up his hammock and get him a wash basin.”

“Yeah, of course.”

Leonnius gently took Phainon by the wrist and led him away.

They watched in silence until he was gone and then the collective sigh settled on them all at once.

“I can’t believe you were jumped by a Black Tide monster,” Hephaestion teased and Mydei twitched irritably. “Were you distracted by something else? Maybe *someone* else?”

Mydei punched at him, but Hephaestion dropped under the fist, chuckling.

“Damn it, stop moving,” Perdikkas scolded, “I should really look at this after you bathe.”

“It will be healed before I could wet the sponge. Leave me be!” he grumbled.

“Will Krateros honor his vow?” Peucesta said solemnly from the railing and the air of joviality was gone again.

Mydei frowned but nodded. “They will not be friends, nor do they need to be, but Krateros is still a devotee of Nikador. He will not harm Phainon until we finish our fight.”

“He wouldn’t have killed Phainon on the deck either,” Perdikkas reminded them, “not until you returned. I know it was tense earlier, but we should give Krateros credit. Just as Phainon has earned our trust, he has long since done so.”

“Everything he does is for love,” Peucesta mused aloud, “love of his people and King.”

Mydei scowled at the word King.

“Phainon isn’t his people,” Hephaestion reminded with a spit in his tone.

“Then we’ll have to change that,” Mydei said firmly and then he walked away before they could tease him again.

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Leonnius was gentle with him, which Phainon appreciated. It was soothing, if confusing. He expected them to be rough. Maybe it would be easier if they were, but there was nothing but kindness in Leonnius’ callused hands helping him remove his bloody clothes.

The Kremnoan gently took Phainon's hand and turned it over to press the sponge into it and that's when he realized how tired he really was that even his body was struggling to respond to basic expectations. All the adrenaline had fled, taking with it the thrill of camaraderie and the simplicity of battle, leaving Phainon feeling empty and confused, trapped in the emotions that had been pushed aside in favor of something easier to understand.

It had hurt watching them fight. Even if he didn't speak the language, Phainon knew they were fighting about him, about what he represented. He had not been able to defend himself, stuck hiding behind Mydei and the others.

Phainon squeezed the excess water from the sponge into the basin, watching the water turn yellow already from the blood on his hands. It shimmered in the dim light and very suddenly, Phainon was aware of the filth, how deeply, deeply uncomfortable he was with Mydei's blood smeared across his arms and chest.

In a frantic fit he plunged both of his hands into the water to scrub them with his nails, scraping them clean until the skin was raw and red. He dragged the sponge over his body with more force than he needed as though he could rub away the ringing in his ears and those gnawing doubts alongside the blood. When that wasn't enough, he thrust his face into the water with half a mind to drown himself but rose with a start when his lungs screamed for air, leaving him gasping while bloody water streamed and dripped from his hair.

He watched his own reflection as it tried to clear but every time Phainon's eyes were almost able to glare back at him, water dripped and the ripples scattered his image into pieces. A more accurate reflection of how he felt than how he looked.

Phainon slowly sank down to his knees and rolled to sit on the floor with his back against the cupboard. At some point in his bathing Leonnius had left him alone.

At first Phainon was upset that he had been abandoned but the more he thought about it the more he was grateful for the solitude, and the more he appreciated the offered trust. They trusted him to be alone. The same way they promised to protect him, looking at him with such genuine faces that Phainon wasn't sure how else to describe it other than as love.

He sat there zoning out until he was too cold in just his undergarments. Shakily, Phainon got to his feet and went to his own drawer to fetch his exomis. He ran his fingers over the royal blue of his cape, folded nicely inside. Briefly he considered wearing his coat, even without his undershirt, just for the comfort of something familiar, to hide how naked he felt, but the gold lining shimmered and he was again reminded of blood dripping on the deck while Mydei had pleaded in defense of him.

He left it, settling for the simple clothing.

"Deliverer," a soft voice said behind him as he closed the clasp over his shoulder to pin the fabric in place.

Mydei had bathed elsewhere. He was clean and wearing nearly the same thing Phainon was, simple attire for tired men. In his hand was a plate with a small cup and a fork balanced around something warm and probably very tasty.

The Prince cleared his throat and set the plate down on the table. The map had been rolled up, tucked away somewhere unimportant.

“You didn’t eat,” he noted, “before we fought. I could barely concentrate on the fight with your stomach growling louder than the Tide.” The attempt at teasing was comforting.

Phainon stepped forward on shaky legs. He reached for the plate and pulled it closer with two fingers. “Did you make this special for me?”

Mydei blushed, the faintest color in his cheeks, maybe even a trick of the light.

“If I am going to defeat you in combat, it will be when you are at your best,” he said with a dismissive wave of his hand, “I won’t have you blaming weakness from malnutrition when you lose and join my crew.”

Phainon managed a small smile and would’ve bantered further, but Mydei had already turned away. Their hammocks were on opposite sides of the room and the Prince was already settling into his.

The food was perfect. A soft filet, warm bread, a sauce with a savory sweet flavor that Phainon couldn’t quite place. Pomegranate wine that made the tension turn drowsy.

He settled into his hammock full and warm, contemplating kindness. The faces of his worried friends, for undeniably he could call them friends, as they pledged to speak with him, pledged to protect him. The way Mydei literally bled for him.

Phainon wasn’t sure he deserved it if he really thought about what would happen if he won the duel and returned to Okhema, to the family he had made there. In a lot of ways, he agreed with the men who seemed ready to take his life. Even if he didn’t know their words, it wasn’t hard to piece together a hypothesis from what he already knew. They still saw him as their enemy, he still was… wasn’t he?

But as he fell asleep, the most important thing Phainon remembered, was fighting back-to-back against the one thing that didn’t care about the flag they sailed beneath.

And he laughed aloud to himself in tired gasps when he realized that was the answer to all of their problems.

Chapter End Notes

I have some work obligations coming up that I expect will eat my writing time for a few days. If you guys want any updates on delays on chapters you can follow me on Twitter. My name is the same there as it is here. Otherwise I should go back to regular updates by the end of the week.

Chapter 11: Clearing the Air

Chapter Summary

Oh thank goodness, Fig Stew is back

Chapter Notes

This might be the last update for a few days so I spared you all the cliffhanger

The hammock had seemed like a silly choice when Phainon had first seen them in the crew's living quarters but settled deep in the pocket and overcome with exhaustion, he slept better that night than any night prior on the Chryseus Leo. The rock of the ship was almost entirely negated by the natural sway of the hammock, and it was much easier to enjoy his rest when he wasn't rolling into crates or steel bars.

That weighing exhaustion is what kept him falling back to sleep even when things started to move around him. He dimly remembered the moment when Mydei woke up and had come to check on him. Phainon remembered soft hands on his forehead, brushing hair out of his eyes, checking his pulse with a gentle press of fingers under his choker. He remembered soft murmurs when Mydei turned away to address whoever had come into his room before they both had stepped outside, leaving him to drift away again, quietly mourning the loss of the prince's presence.

He vaguely recalled several voices, reviewing the map spread again across that big table. Mydei's voice low and deep as he talked to Krateros and Hephaestion in whispers so as not to disturb him. He could pick out a couple words in Kremnoan, words that he recognized from his limited study time. The most important of which was 'home.'

When he finally came around to full wakefulness, it was to the chime of soft laughter. There were a number of people in the room with him, talking in whispers and pouring juice. He held still to listen, and recognized their voices, even if he didn't know what they were saying.

Phainon rolled to his side so he could blink at them, bleary in the bright light shining through the windows. It was well past Entry Hour.

"'My poor unhappy man, why do you lie awake in this way?'" Ptolemy quoted with words that Phainon could understand and very suddenly the rest of them knew who he was talking to and turned to flash comforting expressions. He smiled at Phainon from where he was leaning on the table and raised a glass to him.

“What time is it?” Phainon managed.

“A few quints past the Lucid Hour,” answered Perdikkas. He was tightening the bandages around Mydei’s belly while the prince sat patiently on a stool. “You must have been very tired.”

“If you’re hungry, we brought you food.” Hephaestion gestured to a plate of purple and green grapes, soft cheese, olive oil, and hard bread.

Phainon blinked at them. His head felt fuzzy and his body felt heavy, too comfortable. He rolled again to try and get up, but his leg caught in the fabric of the hammock and he didn’t get up so much as fall out in an awkward flail of limbs that dumped him on the floor to the tune of intermittent chuckling.

He pouted at them from the floor until Perdikkas abandoned Mydei to offer a hand.

“Sorry, sorry,” he said around his own giggles, “we don’t mean to make fun.”

“I do!” Leonnius called and a few of them laughed again. Even Mydei was smiling warmly.

“Were you all just, waiting for me to wake up?” Phainon asked as he rubbed his head. Things still felt a little awkward for him, despite how things had shaken out late the prior night. He didn’t feel quite as emotionally charged anymore now that he was rested, but sleep didn’t make the problems go away.

“They are here to annoy me, as usual,” Mydei grumbled, feigning annoyance despite the smile still curling the corners of his lips.

“*And* wait for you to wake,” Hephaestion confirmed, “if you’re ready to talk, we can get started while you eat.”

“Let the man be awake for more than a minute, Hephaestion,” Leonnius sighed. He reached for one of the two amphorae on the table to top himself off, but Hephaestion leaned over to snatch his cup from him.

“Go be useful and fetch Peucesta.”

Leonnius whined and sighed but he did get to his feet.

“Leonnius,” Mydei called, “fetch Krateros too.”

The mood in the room instantly soured but no one argued with him. Phainon felt in his bones how badly Hephaestion especially didn’t like that idea. Leonnius looked like he might argue for a second but then he turned and left.

“Maybe I should escape back to bed,” Phainon wondered aloud, trying to sound playful, eager to lighten the mood again.

It must’ve worked because Ptolemy laughed a single bark and whipped out another quote, “’Sleep, delicious and profound, the very counterfeit of death.’”

Even if Phainon wanted to, the moment he turned back to his hammock it was already occupied. Fig Stew had happily jumped in and was settling down, cutting off any hope of escape with a relaxed sigh and happy chirp. His belly was up and inviting but Phainon had learned his lesson the first two times.

Hephaestion kicked a stool his direction. “Come sit. Eat.”

Phainon obeyed. Food did sound good; good enough that he didn’t question where they got the fresher food. He was pretty sure he knew already. Okhema produced the best cheeses. The grapes were round and full with a satisfying and flavorful pop when he bit down through the skin. The oil was smooth on the crisp bread and paired nicely with the mild cheese.

Perdikkas tapped Mydei’s bandages one last time, finally content with his work, and sat next to Phainon at the table.

“So, um,” Phainon started. He put one of the pieces of bread in the oil so it could start to soften. “How does the whole immortality thing work with injuries?”

“They just heal fast,” Mydei offered with a shrug and then it was quiet again while the Prince reached for his chlamys from his stool to dress himself more appropriately.

Phainon felt the heat rise in his cheeks as he chanced glances Mydei’s way. Without his gauntlets he could see just how far those tattoos reached down his arms.

“So, you usually fight bare-handed?”

“Is that really what you want to talk about?” One of Mydei’s eyebrows went up.

Phainon shrugged. “Just curious. Didn’t realize it was a secret.”

“I *can* use weapons. I just prefer not to.”

More silence.

The Kremnoans all looked between themselves before Hephaestion sighed, “Please don’t let it be this awkward the entire time…”

The door opened a second later and Leonnius returned to his seat, snatching his cup from Hephaestion as he did so. He leaned back in his chair until the back tapped against the wall and rested the cup on his chest between sips.

Peucesta, newly arrived, headed straight for the back of the room. He sat himself down on the top of one of Mydei’s dressers, against the window. He immediately started to play, just a soft soundtrack, the kind of thing that fades into the background and is easily forgotten until it stops and leaves behind a hollow feeling that something is missing.

It was Krateros that altered the mood the most with his presence. He glanced at the others there and then found a spot against an empty wall to lean, crossing his arms and bowing his head, eyes closed to listen.

“It is indeed going to be this awkward the entire time,” Ptolemy mumbled into his cup.

Hephaestion flashed Mydei a look, jaw locked, annoyed, but Mydei kept his cool.

“Krateros,” the Prince greeted, and the man looked up at him, “I don’t want your unsolicited input during this discussion.”

“Then why am here?”

“Because I want you to listen and council me when I ask it of you. You are still my teacher, I still value your advice, even if I decide not to follow it.”

The others didn’t seem nearly as welcoming towards the old veteran and Phainon was just trying not to draw attention to himself. It didn’t work. Krateros looked from Mydei to Phainon, watching him closely before he bowed his head again.

“I understand,” he said carefully. The respect that Mydei showed him was placating. Even if Krateros wasn’t invited to participate this was still an olive branch, and when Krateros closed his eyes and did his best to become one with the background, the edge in the room softened.

The silence lingered, no one knew where to start, so Mydei took the lead as he usually did.

“Deliverer- Phainon,” he said. Phainon looked up from his food.

“As promised, we owe you the truth.” He drummed his fingers on his leg. “Perhaps it is best if we start at the beginning. I did not lie to you when I told you this ship does not take prisoners. It was something we agreed to in our self-exile when we took the Chryseus Leo from Castrum Kremnos.”

Leonnius was nodding profusely. Hephaestion ran his finger along the edge of his cup.

“When I pulled you from the water the morning we met, it was not because I intended to put you in a difficult situation,” Mydei insisted, “we were simply surprised that were any survivors at all.”

Phainon swallowed. “Because of the Black Tide.”

Perdikkas spoke next, raising a hand in apology when he cut Mydei off. “We aren’t monsters. Any time we attack a ship, Black Tide or otherwise we look for innocent people to protect them. We’ve carried refugees before, freed would be slaves, but when the Black Tide is involved, there are *never* survivors… until Mydei saw you in the hold of that merchant ship.”

“Ptolemy looked you up,” Hephaestion picked up the story and Ptolemy nodded along, “we knew from how you were dressed and your sun mark that you had to be from Okhema and it wasn’t hard to piece together from there. Your notoriety made you dangerous, especially when you lashed out at Perdikkas, and with the crew’s …history, we figured the safest thing to do would be to kill you, as another casualty of war.”

“So why didn’t you?” Phainon asked. His appetite was gone. He just pushed grapes around his plate.

“It didn’t feel right,” Mydei said matter-of-factly, “we had just saved you from a mutual enemy. The way you talked with me on the deck and below, it was plain that you had come for us uninformed. You were as much a victim as the rest of your crew, regardless of our nations’ conflict.”

“And the rest of your crew was okay with that?” Phainon asked, suspicious. He looked over at Krateros, but the man didn’t react.

“I had promised Krateros that if you became a danger, I would kill you myself,” Mydei said simply.

Phainon drew in a breath and held it. That made a lot of sense.

“Even last night, when Krateros arrested you, your life wasn’t in danger,” Perdikkas told him, “because of Mydei’s vow to him, he would’ve left that judgement to the prince.”

“He even said so last night. You couldn’t understand the discussion,” Ptolemy acknowledged, “but he did.”

Ptolemy recounted the argument from the prior night, how Krateros and the old crew saw Phainon as a threat from Okhema, a spy, that arresting him until they got the whole story was the right thing to do when Phainon had returned alone. Then he shared what Mydei had said about how those grudges should not be directed to someone who had yet to do anything worthy of that hatred. That Mydei refused to continue the conflict with Okhema at all, that their war ended with Eurypon and they needed to move forward together.

All the feelings of being helpless came back and Phainon felt that lump in his throat. So that’s what they had been yelling about. As he had suspected, Mydei and the others had been his advocate, arguing for his innocence despite his allegiance.

“The Kremnoan Okheman conflict still lingers, especially for the older crew,” Mydei admitted, “but nothing has come of it since the King’s death. I was short-sighted and that first morning, I struck a deal with you as I have prior passengers.”

Phainon pulled his hands into his lap and looked down. “When you let me work the ship, all that bonding- “

Hephaestion kicked his stool from under the table, almost hard enough to knock him over and Phainon scrambled to grab the table for balance. “It was real, HKS.”

“When I realized the complexity of the situation left us with no choice but to feed you to the sea or hold you hostage, I told them they could answer your questions,” Mydei confirmed, “it was never my intention to lie to you about your status on the ship. By the time I realized I had, that I had lied even to myself, it was too late to change anything. You had barely begun on the ship and were already solving problems as a Kremnoan would, working hard, eager to please and obnoxiously curious. Even if you were a captive by circumstance, I saw no reason to make you suffer, and there was no need to keep our history and companionship from you when you were already trapped here. Not until I had another solution.”

That explained a lot. The hesitation in their voices before they told him stories, the pitying glances when he mentioned going home. They *did* know the situation but wanted to protect him from the truth for a time.

“The truth is,” Hephaestion told Phainon, “only half the crew consider you an enemy. Even locking you up at night, it wasn’t because we thought you were dangerous, it’s because we were worried someone on the crew might try to harm you. Even moving you here to the Captain’s room was so someone could be ready to protect you.”

“Not that it helped,” Leonnius grumbled.

Phainon tilted his head in confusion at Leonnius’ comment.

“During the storm,” Perdikkas said, taking a turn to speak, “someone cut your lifeline in the hope the storm would take care of you.”

The pieces were coming together. Phainon’s brow pinched deep in thought. “You were barring the infirmary door at night because you thought they might try to finish the job.”

Perdikkas nodded.

“We still don’t know who did it,” Ptolemy admitted.

“It doesn’t matter,” Mydei huffed, “the crew won’t harm you now, not while our battle is unfinished. To do so would dishonor the vow we made to honor the outcome.”

“But why go through all that effort to protect me? Wouldn’t my death have solved your problem?” Phainon asked. It wasn’t coming from a desire to die, when he asked it was with a genuine curiosity, a want to understand why a culture that treated death so casually would shy away from it, especially given it was the easy solution.

Mydei’s eyes were wide and thoughtful, he looked at Phainon like he had an answer stuck in his throat. Color rushed to the prince’s cheeks and he looked away. A gesture that left Phainon even more confused.

“You were innocent, but mostly because we like you,” Peucesta said from his corner, “because the more we got to know you, the more you got to know us, the more we wanted you to be one of us.”

Phainon huffed, feeling a little angry and once again torn. “That wasn’t your decision to make.”

All the Kremnoans looked down and away, ashamed.

“The situation was complicated,” Perdikkas tried.

“I get that but that doesn’t make it okay,” Phainon was saying, “you all made me believe that I would get to go home. Can you imagine how it felt to feel like one of you, to be happy here and then learn that it was covering a lie? That I didn’t have a choice? That you were all keeping things from me about my fate?

“Ptolemy you told me that you read those ridiculous songs the bards wrote about me, you knew that I was important to Okhema, to Aglaea. Even if my family-“ he stumbled a little, “even if the family I was born to is gone, I have friends and a new family at home. Did any of you even consider that?”

There was a shameful silence. Peucesta stopped playing. Perdikkas fiddled with the leftover bandages as though the answer was written on the cloth.

It was Mydei who broke the silence with the softest glimmer of hope in his whisper, “… you’re happy here?”

Phainon sighed and ran a hand through his hair, combing the white with his fingers until he looked as disheveled as he felt. “I was.”

The music started again, this time in a minor key, sad.

“But I owe you all some truth too.” Phainon pushed the plate away and leaned back on his stool. “I’m still angry and hurt because of how you lied to me, not because I was being held captive. I understood why you had to do that and if our situations were reversed, I would have done the same.”

They were all quiet while he talked, letting him gather his thoughts. Mydei loosely crossed his arms and tilted his head. The sunlight glittered on his earring. It was distracting so Phainon studied the table instead.

“I don’t like it, but the truth is, your fears were not unfounded. If I return to Okhema, I *will* have to tell them everything. Not because I want to, but because I wouldn’t have a choice. Even though I don’t agree with what you are doing, the piracy, the stealing, I don’t think you guys are evil like I was led to believe.” He clenched his fists on his thighs.

“But it wouldn’t matter how I felt, what I think, or what I’d try to keep to myself. Aglaea’s golden threads would keep me from lying or withholding anything I’ve learned, even if I could convince her to show mercy, I don’t know if I’d be able to convince the Council of Elders that Castrum Kremnos is no longer a militant threat. I’m not even sure they *know* about King Eurypon’s death, if they did… Krateros and your crew aren’t the only ones who believe this war between us is ongoing. I’m not sure what they would do if they knew about you and your people. They might even take up the banner of war in full force again, to try and end it on their terms.

“I’m not sure I could do it. It wouldn’t feel right, duty or not.”

Phainon looked up at Mydei specifically this time.

“When I realized in the galley that you also had an impossible decision to make like mine, I thought maybe the duel would be the best way for us both to put the decision in fate’s hands. Even if it was a coward’s idea, it felt like the best way for us to come to a resolution that we could both live with.”

Mydei nodded. “I suspected as much.”

The room was quiet as everyone mulled over the situation.

“So now what?” Perdikkas asked, breaking the silence with a soft voice. He was still fiddling with the bandages, wrapping his own fingers and then unwrapping them over and over.

“Easy,” chimed Leonnius, he finished his juice and then leaned forward to reach for more, but Ptolemy swiftly pulled the pitcher out of his reach until he finished speaking. “Phainon joins the crew.”

Phainon almost fell out of his chair. For a second, Mydei looked like he was going to agree but he retreated when Phainon cut in. “I can’t.”

“Why not?” Leonnius and Ptolemy asked at the same time. They smiled at each other when they realized they were on the same page.

“I’m not a pirate,” Phainon insisted, “I can’t-I can’t do the things you guys do. I’m sorry, I just can’t break the law like that. I still have a family and a purpose in Okhema. Aglaea saved my life, she finished raising me, I owe her a debt I’ll never be able to repay, a debt that I sealed with my oath to support the flame-chase journey. And that’s to say nothing of the other Chrysos Heirs that rely on me.” He moved one hand to his chest to rest over his heart.

Hephaestion sighed and reached for the amphorae. He handed it over to Leonnius who went to pour only to realize the pitcher was empty with a scowling frown.

“We’re back at the beginning of the problem,” the first mate lamented, ignoring the rude hand gesture from his thirsty friend, “you can’t join the crew because it conflicts with your oath, but we can’t let you go because, per your own admission, Okhema will use the things we told you to hunt us down and finish the war.”

“The war that really ended five years ago,” Leonnius reminded.

“That Okhema doesn’t realize because they don’t know Eurypon is dead,” Perdikkas sighed.

“Or they *do* know,” Ptolemy mused, “and are not telling their people because they don’t *want* the war to end.”

The whole room sighed.

“I don’t want to agree with Krateros,” Perdikkas grumbled, “but he might be right.”

In the corner, Krateros didn’t react. He didn’t smile or frown, just waited patiently, listening, as still as a statue.

“Not about the killing you part,” Perdikkas clarified with a slight wave towards Phainon, “about the treating you like a prisoner of war part.”

“’No man or woman born, coward or brave, can shun his destiny,’” Ptolemy quoted. He very sadly pushed a loose grape with a finger until it rolled off the table. “Okhema and Kremnos are doomed to hate until one of us is destroyed.”

Phainon saw Mydei out of the corner of his eye tense up tight. His relaxed expression had turned stressed, with a deep frown and his fingers pressing deep into his arms where he held them. His brow was pinched in thought, but he didn't share what he was thinking. He looked so much more human like that. It made Phainon's stomach flip, and his chest feel warm. That distressed face more than anything made Phainon want to fix everything so Mydei wouldn't have to look like that ever again.

"Let's just change our destiny," Phainon offered. The room turned to look at him, puzzled.

"The answer has been in front of us the whole time," he continued and stood up to emphasize what he was saying. "Ever since I got here, even last night, it's been Kremnos against Okhema with no hope of resolution between our nations, but we already felt and lived the answer."

The image of Nikador and Kephale united, carved in wood, sprang to Phainon's mind.

Mydei looked up at Phainon. "The Black Tide."

Hephaestion smiled, just a little twitch in the corner of his mouth, when Phainon pointed at Mydei. "You said as much yourself on the deck last night, your Highness."

"Yeah but uniting two halves of a disagreement between people of the same culture and background is *very* different from uniting two entirely different peoples," Leonnius pointed out. He was back to leaning in his chair, trying to get the last few drops of juice from his cup.

"That's where I come in," Phainon said with a reassuring smile, "when Aglaea and Tribbios started calling me the Deliverer, encouraging others to do the same, I was embarrassed. It didn't feel like she gave such an auspicious title to the right person." He put his hand back on the table but stayed standing, leaning his weight onto both his hands. "But maybe I can use this title she gave me, convince the people that our war with Castrum Kremnos is in the past and that the Black Tide should be our priority. They'll listen to me."

Ptolemy wrinkled his face as he worked through a few different expressions. His bookworm persona didn't take it well and every contortion looked extra sharp and exaggerated. "Did you not say that your Council of Elders couldn't be convinced?"

Phainon deflated. He hung his head and slumped down onto the stool again. "Yeah…"

"Phainon, does Okhema have to contend with the Black Tide at all?" Hephaestion asked. The question made Phainon tilt his head.

"When we talked in the brig," Mydei started to say, "you were unaware of how far the Tide had spread."

Phainon groaned as he realized the futility of his idea. Of course, the Council would reject the idea of setting aside an eons long war in favor of an Alliance to fight an enemy that they had all but forgotten about. They would consider it a problem for distant lands, not something to trouble the populace, especially with Kephale's Dawn Device to protect them.

“There’s no reason for Okhema to join forces with us to fight something that isn’t a threat to them,” Perdikkas pointed out, giving voice to Phainon’s thoughts.

“They will have to confront it eventually,” Mydei reminded the room, and everyone looked over at him. He was back to his composed, stoic expression complete with nonchalant hand gestures.

“Not with Kephale’s Dawn Device,” Ptolemy argued.

The Prince shook his head. “Is it not the Goldweaver’s life ambition to gather the twelve coreflames of the Titans?” Everyone brightened at once. “The Deliverer even said that his oath is to her flame-chase journey. Is that not what the journey entails?”

“Yeah, but what does that have to do with the Black Tide?” Phainon asked before he remembered a few things. They all let him work through it when they saw the realization on his face.

“I don’t know how many coreflames Aglaea has already,” Hephaestion said as he knocked his empty cup over on the table with a deliberate push, “but there’s at least one that we know of that she doesn’t have.”

“The coreflame of Strife,” Peucesta mumbled, distracted. The song changed to something more ominous and faster paced.

“You know where it is?” Phainon asked.

“In the heart of Nikador,” Mydei said with a dark tone, “buried in Castrum Kremnos where we trapped him, deep in the Black Tide.”

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Mydei watched Phainon’s face fall into a quiet but determined expression. It wasn’t the news he wanted but it was *something* and rather than slip into despair as he thought Phainon might, he seemed to be crunching numbers in his head. It was the exact crinkle of the eyebrows that Ptolemy had when he was calculating their earnings and expenses report every time they docked to trade.

“I could convince them,” Phainon said, confident, “Aglaea would take my side if I told them about the coreflame.”

“That might solve the whole Okhema Kremnos issue, but doesn’t that sign us up for something worse?” Leonnius pointed out.

“If we sell a truce on the promise of the coreflame of Strife…” Perdikkas mumbled, “we’d be expected to help retrieve it.”

The whole room grimaced. Mydei looked between each of them in turn. They were trying too hard to complicate a solution by creating another problem.

“Krateros,” Mydei invited, when he saw the old man watching them, a deviation from his prior position, “do you have any council that may benefit the room?”

“The Black Tide need not be a unifier,” Krateros said firmly, “*if* there is ever to be a truce between Kremnos and Okhema, only the King of Castrum Kremnos can broker such peace.”

Peucesta missed a note on the lyre, an ugly sound that was quickly glossed over when the melody resumed. Perdikkas also flinched, but the others held their silence, careful not to react. Mydei could see Phainon looking at him expectantly, confused but unsure if he should speak.

“Castrum Kremnos has no King,” Mydei said firmly, shutting that down.

“Then abandon any hope of change,” Krateros said, equally firm as he bowed his head again.

Fig Stew gave the room a sad awoo from Phainon’s hammock. His front paws were on the edge of the fabric so he could watch them with those big eyes, oblivious to how the tilting bed was about to dump the chimera in a replay of what had happened to Phainon.

“So, we’re back to the Black Tide?” Leonnius asked with a groan.

“Until we think of something else,” Hephaestion confirmed.

“I think we need more time,” Ptolemy offered, “we don’t need to solve everything right now.”

“That’s right,” chimed in Perdikkas. He crumpled up the bandages in his hand and stuffed them into the folds of his exomis. “We did what we intended to. Cleared the air, told Phainon the truth and got the truth, unless there’s something you forgot?”

They looked at Phainon whose eyes tilted towards the ceiling. He held a finger to his chin to think and fuck it was adorable. Mydei moved his hands to his thighs to dig his fingers in to keep his legs from bouncing.

“Not that I can think of,” he said, “but… nothing has changed yet, has it?”

“No,” Mydei confirmed, “you are still a prisoner of war, pending our fight’s conclusion.”

“Should we take care of that today?” Phainon asked.

Mydei shook his head. “My injury is nearly healed, but I will still need the rest. If we are to fight, I want us both at our best.”

He didn’t need to remind anyone that the pending rematch was also protecting Phainon’s life, buying them time until they could think of an acceptable alternative. The duel freed them of and social responsibility and guilt but it wouldn’t prevent the consequences that would come with either victor.

“For now, we act as we have been,” the first mate supplied, “Phainon still works the ship, we still watch his back. Until he leaves this ship, he’s one of us. Agreed?”

“Agreed,” the other four Kremnoans said.

Mydei saw Hephaestion’s eyes dart towards Krateros when they said it, but the old man was still and silent, waiting to be dismissed as though he were napping on guard duty.

“Agreed,” Mydei added after them.

Much softer and with awe, Phainon brought up the rear. “Agreed.”

Mydei leaned back to grab his half full cup from the shelf behind him. It was closer than the table. He held it out to his friends, and they repeated the gesture.

“To brothers in arms, bound by the blood we spill together, not the blood we share,” he said, looking squarely at Phainon as he spoke.

They all mimicked his gesture, waiting until Phainon joined them. Everyone else had empty glasses, so it was only he and Phainon who drank, but the sentiment was there.

Mydei felt his heart flutter looking at his family. It was still too much to hope that Phainon might be a part of it. There were insurmountable odds, laid plain and bare now, but something about the universal willingness in the room to climb that mountain gave him courage.

He raised his glass one more time and waited for the others to copy him before he said with a smirk, “to getting back to work.”

All the Kremnoans groaned aside from Krateros, who cracked his composure to laugh. “You heard the Crown Prince,” the old man said, chattering fondly in their native tongue.

Hephaestion helped herd them along, leaving Phainon and Mydei alone.

Phainon still looked bothered, conflicted, like he was holding the whole world squarely on his shoulders.

He didn’t know why, but Mydei wanted to share that weight with him.

“Deliverer,” he said as he stood and Phainon’s daze broke enough to look up, “if there is a way for me to return you to your home while still protecting my family and my people, then I will find it.”

Phainon’s face tilted, just enough to make his hair sway across his forehead and bounce around his ears.

“Why don’t you want to be King?” he asked softly, and the question stole his breath.

Mydei looked down at his now empty cup and slowly put it on the table next to the others. “It is hard to explain.”

“Try.”

Mydei looked up at Phainon and their eyes met. It felt like Phainon was looking straight into him. His eyes were like the sky, clear, pure, and infinite, held steady.

“Because the blood-soaked Crown of Strife cannot lead my people to the peace that I dream of for them.”

“Even if it’s a way to end this war and peaceably secure my freedom?”

“It is not the answer that Krateros thinks it is.”

Phainon went quiet then, back to his thoughts.

Mydei sighed. “Perhaps I *should* throw you back into the sea,” he growled and turned his nose up, arms crossed, eyes closed, “sleeping in, lazing about when the rest of my crew are hard at work!”

“Apologies, *Captain*,” Phainon said, and Mydei could hear the playful lilt in his words, “*someone* saw fit to keep me in his room for a time after my meeting. I could hardly refuse~”

Mydei felt his ears turn red, could hear Phainon pulling on his boots.

“If you are still here when I open my eyes, I’ll feed you to the waters beneath my ship,” Mydei threatened.

The scrambling got a little faster until he heard Phainon call from the door in a sing-song voice, “I’ll miss you too, Mydeimos. Don’t wait up for me.”

The door closed before Mydei could throw anything at him. He stood there in his room alone to catch his breath.

Well, mostly alone.

Fig Stew was still watching from Phainon’s hammock. The smug smile was back as he purred loudly enough to be heard from several paces away.

“If you have something to say, I would hear it,” he huffed at the chimera.

Fig Stew raised his tail and pressed it against the fabric to make the hammock swing, just a gentle sway. His expression never changed.

Mydei sighed and started gathering the dishes to take with him to the galley. A glimmer of guilt gnawed at his belly. In all that discussion he had thought of another solution, one that he had already been considering for a long time now.

‘No man or woman born, coward or brave, can shun his destiny.’

A thousand-year-old Kremnoan Dynasty. A crown he refused to pick up.

Mydei had already resolved himself to being the last prince of Castrum Kremnos, no matter how much his people wanted him to pick up the crown, to call himself King. They wanted

him to lead them home, to resume the mantle of Strife, to follow the mad Titan to glory and conquest, to die. There was no future in that doomed life.

'Okhema and Kremnos are doomed to hate until one of us is destroyed.'

Maybe that was the answer.

Why leave the crown there on the ground, waiting to be picked up, when Mydei could instead grind it to pieces forever?

Chapter 12: Homesick

Chapter Summary

New tag: Public Nudity

Home is where the heart is! ...right?

Chapter Notes

Thank you everyone for being patient while I tended to work obligations!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon left the meeting feeling better but not resolved. Nothing had really changed aside from having all the nasty on the table where everyone could see it. The only peace came from knowing that no one was happy about the predicament, and everyone was on the same page wanting to work together to find an outcome that made everyone happy. The unspoken tension was the universal understanding that this peace was fragile. A decision couldn't be avoided forever, and someone was going to get hurt when it was made.

Baby steps, Phainon had to remind himself as he stepped out into the light. Knowing that people on the ship wanted to kill him and how dismissive the others had been about it was the more immediate concern for him. But as he hurried to follow Hephaestion's orders, bringing water to the men working the lines, he didn't sense any animosity. Instead, the crew treated him with begrudging to open respect. Ulixes even hit him in the shoulder with an affectionate punch and praised him for his fight with Mydei the prior evening. Kremnoans really did respect strength. Even the older crewmen gave him a nod here and there, even if they looked like they had swallowed something sour while doing so.

Earned respect wasn't the only thing that buzzed in the air. The crew was antsy, a little too eager to tend to the sails, many of them waiting by the oars one level down. Phainon tried to ask one of them in Kremnoan what was so exciting but after a very awkward exchange, the man had burst out laughing at *something* Phainon had said and walked away shaking his head.

He went looking for someone he knew could understand him after that.

"Perdikkas," Phainon asked gently. The man was dumping waste over the rail.

"Someone giving you trouble?"

“The opposite. Is something supposed to happen today?”

“Oh, did no one tell you?” Perdikkas pointed to the horizon. They were following a shoreline. It was very far away, the kind of thing that was easy to miss if you weren’t looking for it. “We’re making berth soon. Good thing we put a rush on clearing the air before we got there. Ah, don’t get your hopes up.” Phainon’s face went from joyful surprise to cautious optimism. “It’s not an Okheman friendly place.”

Didn’t matter, it was still dry land, something solid. Phainon was excited until something else occurred to him.

“…will I be allowed off the ship?” he asked.

Perdikkas tried to keep the pity off his face. Emphasis on tried. “That’s-That’s something to figure out when we get there.”

And getting there didn’t take as long as Phainon had thought. Despite the delay from the Black Tide, the Chryseus Leo made good time, making it home with the late afternoon high tide. The wind was behind them, the current strong, the men pulled on the oars like their lives depended on it. The ship itself carried an air of urgency, that eager and powerful desire to curl up in a familiar bed after a long trip. It made Phainon homesick in equal measure with his sense of adventure.

The shoreline they were following was the same landmass that led to Okhema, albeit in a horrible zig-zag, spend-a-month-on-a-dromas, kind of way. Where the continent started to narrow was a collection of islands, perched on the biggest of which was a collection of buildings, too big to be considered a village but too small to be considered a city. Even from a distance Phainon could see the settlement was expanding, evidence of construction on the edges giving it away.

Phainon hurried to the bow, holding onto the shrouds so he could lean over the side to watch them come into port. Most of the crew were still on the oars, fine tuning their steering against the currents to avoid the islands’ reefs, a natural defense from seafaring invaders. Peucesta played music for them to give them instructions, relaying calls from Leonnius in the upper shrouds above to safely navigate.

Mydei was dressed finely, back in his usual regalia, looking every inch the King he should be as he watched from the upper deck. Phainon could feel his eyes on the back of his neck, gauging any reactions, but Phainon couldn’t be bothered to care. He was taking in the sights.

Up close it was easier to tell how much of this place was actually very old, especially near the docks. Newer buildings freckled here and there, but the core of the island home was many decades old at least, perhaps even pushing a hundred. He’d need to be up close to be sure, but he recognized familiar textbook examples of Kremnoan architecture. Older buildings had bronze fixings, both functional and decorative, making the old city into a recognizable fort with sprawling walls.

Mydei shouted orders to the men on the lines as they approached, turning to call to the men on the tiller as well. The sails were completely furled now, no need for the wind to carry them

any further. Krateros shouted orders below and they gently coasted in close using their lingering momentum and the oars to glide expertly into place. People shouted from the shore and the docks, pointing to the big ship. One of them blew into a horn to call for more hands.

Perdikkas and Hephaestion rolled massive ropes over the side of the ship for them to grab on long hooks. After a quint of fine tuning between the oars, and their comrades pulling the lines from the shore, the Chryseus Leo was safely tethered between two docks. The whole ship lurched a little as she settled, sails furled tight, oars being tucked away.

Mydei was already heading down from the upper deck, talking to Krateros on the stairs and waving over Hephaestion to join them as he went. A couple men were removing a section of the railing to allow for the wide, sturdy ramp from the dock. They caught the ropes tossed up to them, pulled the ramp into place and latched it tightly against the deck so it wouldn't slip. Within seconds men and women were pouring onboard to greet the crew with happy cheers and rough greetings.

"They're all Kremnoan," Phainon mused aloud.

"Yup," Leonnius confirmed. He dropped down from above to land next to Phainon with a heavy thud. The man definitely felt that landing all the way through his knees if the look on his face meant anything. "Welcome to the new Kremnos, sort of."

"Sort of?"

"Well, this is an outpost that Castrum Kremnos has had since our battle with Icatus like 70 years ago," he explained, "when the Black Tide took over Castrum Kremnos, this was the only territory left that was safe. This is what's left of our people."

Phainon's heart sank. "This is all that's left?"

"Don't look so sad. It's a miracle so many people made it to safety at all and those we lost died honorably."

"Then this is your home port?"

"For now, yeah, just until Mydeimos becomes King and then we'll go back to Castrum Kremnos."

Another sad tug pulled Phainon's heart. Surely Leonnius knew how Mydei felt about that prospect? If the prince had been willing to answer when Phainon asked, surely, he had answered his friends? Had he given them the same answer?

"Leonn-"

"Deliverer!" Mydei's voice cut him off.

Phainon turned to look at the captain who was gesturing for him to come with one finger pointed his way, curling and uncurling in an unmistakable summons. He gave Leonnius an apologetic smile and obeyed.

Mydei was standing next to the ramp talking to a tall and intimidating looking woman. She had two people beside her, another woman with long braided hair and a bald man who was already barking orders to the people down on the dock. Krateros and Hephaestion were standing there too, acting as liaisons between the crew and the dock workers. The entire exchange felt amicable and efficient. No small talk, only happy business.

“Yes, Mydeimos?” Phainon asked with as sweet a voice as he could muster.

Mydei reached out and grabbed Phainon’s chin, pinching his cheeks tightly to keep him from moving, making him blink in surprise at the sudden rough treatment. The woman looked him over. She was wearing armor, had a couple small scars on her jawline, and short hair. She also was not happy to see him.

She said something to Mydei in Kremnoan and Phainon caught a couple words. One of them was flattering, the other was not. Mydei responded somewhat flippantly, letting him go. They went back and forth like that, obviously discussing him with varying degrees of hostility. Inevitably, Phainon started to speak, eager to calm them, but Mydei’s gauntlet covered his mouth and grabbed his head so fast that he ended up floundering in place around the impromptu gag instead, clutching at Mydei’s unmoving wrist and tapping it like that would convince him to let go.

Mydei only released him when the woman sighed and turned to talk to the other lady, leaving behind a horrible, metallic taste on Phainon’s tongue. They must’ve settled on something because she barked another order and suddenly traffic was moving around them. The crew was already opening the hold to roll barrels and treasure onto unloading nets, eager to have the work out of the way so they could enjoy the short break.

“Your pretty face is already turning heads-” Mydei told him as he let go.

“You think I’m pretty?”

“You’d be prettier if you weren’t interrupting me.”

“I don’t think it works that way.”

“*Phainon*.” Something about the way Mydei growled out his name sent shivers up his spine and trapped his breath halfway down his throat. “This is a Kremnoan port. They have no love of Okhemans.”

“I have to stay on the ship…”

“I did not say that.” Mydei held a hand up to shut down any expected excitement and looked a little surprised when Phainon wasn’t ready with excitement to share. “I’m saying that when we go ashore, you must stay with someone from the detachment.”

“Someone like you?” Phainon teased.

“Yes.”

Oh. He didn’t expect that to be an option.

“Preferably me,” Mydei doubled down and Phainon felt weak in his knees, “I am the most qualified to protect you.”

“You know I don’t need protecting.”

“Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, you do here. This is not a matter of individual strength, it’s a matter of politics.”

Phainon could see the seriousness of Mydei’s words in the way he gestured with his hands, a finger sharply pointed his direction and a clenched fist.

“Alright,” he relented, “am I still a prisoner then?”

“Consider the port an extension of the ship. The same vow we made this morning applies there.”

Phainon chewed on the inside of his cheek for a second before asking, “what’s to stop me from running away?”

“Do you see any other way out of this port? There is only one other ship that makes berth here, a merchant vessel of ours that we use for trade and it is not here nor will it be in the time it will take us to make repairs and again disembark.”

Well, that would do it. Phainon wouldn’t get very far on a secluded island full of Kremnoans.

“You’re not going to want to run anyway, Phainon,” Hephaestion said with a gentle smile. He patted Phainon’s back with one very firm smack. “We’re going to drag you to the bath house and there’s always good food when we come back to port. The whole city wants to welcome back their prince!” He put an arm around Mydei’s shoulder and grinned.

“Go help unload,” Mydei snapped, but there was no irritation in his voice.

Hephaestion chuckled but obeyed.

“Should I help?” Phainon asked.

“No. We have a system; it will be better for you stay out of the way.” Mydei leaned forward over the railing to rest his weight on his forearms while he looked out over the town. He looked wistful, regal, but wistful. The breeze was nice here, it tugged at Mydei’s cape and earring and played with his hair like a comfortable friend.

Phainon watched him for a second, feeling his cheeks warm looking at that soft expression.

“Are you happy to be home?” Phainon asked. He stepped up to the rail beside Mydei.

“This isn’t home.”

“This is where your people are, isn’t that home?”

Mydei looked down to watch the people moving on the dock. A couple of kids were weaving underfoot, running to jump into a man's arms, excited to see their father home again. His expression was guarded but there was a slight smile threatening to break through that composure. It was there hiding in the corner of his eyes.

"I suppose," he mused softly.

"Hey, I meant to ask," Phainon said light-heartedly. He mimicked Mydei's pose so he could playfully nudge him with his shoulder. "Why aren't there any women on the crew?"

"Why? Looking for someone?" Mydei retorted a little snippier than Phainon expected.

"Nothing like that!" he insisted with a laugh, "I was just curious. I thought Kremnoan women were as strong as Kremnoan men."

"They are." Mydei's mood mellowed again. "I had a few on my crew for a time."

"Did something happen to them?"

"They left of their own volition. Said they would rather help rebuild Castrum Kremnos from the shore than waste time comforting insecure men on a ship."

Phainon laughed, "surely they weren't talking about-"

"The crew? Yes. They were stronger than most of them, but I am glad I honored their parting. This island is only a success because of their strength and wisdom."

"Then the lady from before…"

"Yes, her name is Empousa. She's the harbormaster now."

Phainon whistled. "She didn't seem all that happy to see me."

"No one will be," Mydei admitted. It was cold but honest. "But most will be focused on the bounty we brought."

"Right, why wouldn't everyone be excited for their share of the pirate treasure."

That was not the right thing to say. Even if Phainon meant it in jest, Mydei didn't take it that way. He tensed for a moment and then leaned back, resting only one hand on the railing while he turned to look down at where Phainon was leaning with a frown.

"Do you really believe that is all there is of us? That we are simply thieves cackling over hoarded gold before we bury it?"

"No, I-"

"This island used to be self-sustaining before the population more than tripled. My people are trying, but they will perish without the goods we retrieve. That is what we are doing

Deliverer. When we disembark we are looking for food, supplies, the means to survive. *That* is the treasure they are eager to receive."

"And is *that* sustainable, captain?" Phainon fired back as he stood up to meet him, "piracy may be the easy answer now, but what happens when that's not enough anymore?"

Mydei scowled irritably. "Go get your things," he ordered instead, "whatever you need for a night on shore."

Phainon let out a short and stiff huff of air to tell Mydeimos he wasn't happy with the deflection but stomped off without a word anyway.

At first Phainon wasn't sure what he needed to pack. It wasn't like he had much to his name to begin with. He unlatched his drawer and opened it to check. Would it be too much to wear his full armor? …if he was already turning heads.

Phainon took off his exomis and got dressed in the familiar clothing, this time wearing all of it. As he tugged on the strap across this chest to tighten the leather, he felt a little smug. The pauldron, the fine stitching on his sleeves, the gold and blue of his half cape, the medallion set into the leather guard at his shoulder, it was all designed by Aglaea, and it filled him with confidence. It was also extremely Okheman. He checked his bracers, his boots, the thigh strap, and even his collar, wanting to make the best (or worst) impression. If he was already going to be accepted as an Okheman first, let him at least look the part and be ready to play ambassador.

He grabbed his two books and tucked them inside his coat. His sword was still hidden away, waiting to be summoned. Phainon had been a little surprised Mydei hadn't tried to confiscate it again, but in light of everything that had happened maybe it was a calculated choice to let him keep it.

"What do you think?" he asked Fig Stew. The chimera was still in his hammock from earlier. He sleepily yawned in response and curled back up to nap.

"That's not reassuring."

"There you are!" Leonnius called from the door. The runner stopped and looked Phainon up and down.

"Too much?"

"You're gonna stand out."

"So, I should take it off?"

"Nah, I think it's very *you*."

Was that good or bad? Leonnius didn't give Phainon a chance to ask. He was already across the room and pulling Phainon along by the wrist. "The dock crew are going to finish unloading and start on repairs which means *we* finally get to relax."

“Don’t you do that all the time on the foretop?”

“This is not like those times,” he insisted, defensive, “how did you even know?”

“Everyone knows. You snore.”

Phainon was a little surprised to see the same happy group from this morning waiting on deck for him. They all seemed eager to be off with bags slung over their shoulders and wearing minimal armor.

“I am so ready for a real bath,” Perdikkas was saying as they approached.

“Shouldn’t we show Phainon the city first?” Hephaestion asked.

“Dressed like *that?*” Mydei asked. The prince’s eyes were unabashedly looking Phainon up and down, drinking him in.

“’When they had admired everything to their heart’s content, they went to the bath room and washed themselves,’” Ptolemy quoted. Everyone was giving him a deadpan look. “I’m just saying that in books they explore *first!*”

“He’ll see plenty of the town on the way,” Perdikkas groaned, “I want to be *clean*.”

“I’d like to see,” Phainon said happily. It might be his only chance, he realized.

“I’ll show him,” Leonnius offered, “and we’ll meet you guys at the bath house after.”

“Don’t take too long. Perdikkas might have boiled away into nothing by the time you catch up if do,” cautioned Hephaestion.

“Would you like to come too, Mydei?” Phainon invited. A couple of the guys flashed each other looks.

“Mydeimos knows the most about the city,” Peucesta finally weighed in. He made it sound so casual but there was insistence there.

Immediately, Perdikkas added on, “he knows about the history of the old town too.”

Mydei narrowed his eyes at the others. “What are you lot on about?”

“Phainon *does* love history, don’t you, Phainon?” Ptolemy said with a huge grin.

“Then it’s decided,” Hephaestion announced firmly, before Mydei could get a word in edgewise, “Mydeimos and Phainon will take the scenic route and the rest of us will head straight to the bath house.”

“Wait I was gonna-“ Leonnius didn’t get to finish before Perdikkas and Ptolemy each grabbed one of his arms, lifted him off his feet and all five of them sprinted off the deck and down the dock, laughing and stumbling and very nearly taking out at least twice as many people as themselves along the way. At some point between the ship and the shore Peucesta

had ended up on Hephaestion's back, playing a rapid melody that could be heard all the way until they vanished from sight in the crowd.

Mydei and Phainon both had to take a second to process.

"Do you know what that was about?" Phainon asked.

Mydei shrugged and sighed, "I have known them my whole life and they never cease to surprise me. Come along."

The city was *vibrant*. That was the best way Phainon could describe it. There was a life, an energy, that reminded him of Okhema but perhaps with a different flavor, different colors. While Okhema was frequently abuzz, it was more reserved, polite, the sort of noise that accompanies peddlers shouting in markets rather than the charged excitement of the Kremnoans. They were more open and honest in everything they did, even when it made them seem too rough or too forward, the people here embraced it. Just like on the ship, disputes were settled with brawls that ended amicably, men and women alike were more willing to express their feelings with physical contact and had little concern for personal space. Phainon saw people throwing their arms over each other's shoulders, playful punches, rough-housing children, impromptu arm-wrestling matches, and people standing close to each other when they talked or gestured.

And all of it was framed by a beautiful island town. Mydei led him on a winding route through the old city. Buildings crafted from stone and painted with old murals depicting glorious combat and Strife, were carefully placed to create chokepoints and strategic advantages should the city ever come under attack. They paused frequently so Phainon could ask questions that Mydei efficiently answered to keep them moving. They talked about the history of the town in between greetings with excited townsfolk and Phainon was pleased and surprised by how much Mydei knew of his people's wants, needs, and history despite what he knew of Mydei's past spent away from these traditions.

He also was made more keenly aware of Mydei's people. Proud as they were and as comfortable as they seemed to be, there was a sort of longing in the way they saluted their prince. They revered him but it never felt like they were seeing *Mydei* so much as they were seeing *Mydeimos the Undying, Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos, future King*. His presence was so radiant to them that Phainon was thankfully overlooked or spared little more than a wary glance. All it took was Mydei to wave them away from him and they gladly turned their attention back to him, to their hope, avoiding any conflicts and giving Phainon a chance to perceive him in this new light.

To his credit, Mydei took everything in stride, he was polite and loving towards his people, but always from the pedestal they put him upon. As Phainon watched Mydei carefully take the hand of an elderly man in both of his gauntleted hands with reverence, he realized that the prince was trying very hard to step off that figurative raised platform, to meet them at the same level, to be one of them. But no one aside from his crew ever gave him the chance. That same old man bowed his head and knees to be lower than Mydei and after a brief exchange they were again walking and talking about the murals as though Phainon weren't catching glimpses of the depths of Mydei's soul.

He understood now why Mydei was so eager to captain a ship than lead his people directly. For as much as he cared for them, there was also a detachment, as though his heart already belonged elsewhere, but chose to return for a time out of dutiful love.

When they finally got to the bathhouse, Mydei's demeanor changed. It was so subtle that Phainon almost missed it, but the second he heard his crew laughing loudly enough to be heard from the street, Mydei softened at the edges. The prince that his people wanted was happily put back inside the box and Mydei was able to just be himself again.

"You should avoid the bath we will be in," Mydei cautioned as they entered.

"Why is that?" Phainon puzzled.

"It will be too hot for you."

Phainon felt the twitch in his eye. "You don't think I can handle it?"

"I know you can't handle it. Did you not see the forges next door? This bath is resting on a natural hot spring but some of the pools still use the boiling water from our forges."

That sounded *awful*. Phainon squinted at Mydei's back as the prince led the way to the changing rooms. This part at least reminded Phainon of Okhema. While it wasn't as ornate, bath houses tended to follow the same basic layout. There were places to rest, cubbies to store one's clothing, stacks of folded towels, soaps, oils, the only thing Phainon couldn't find was…

"Do you not have chitons for bathing?" he asked, turning to Mydei.

Mydei who was already very naked and tucking his clothing and boots into a larger storage space. Phainon's cheeks and ears turned pink as he gave Mydei a once over before Phainon realized what he was doing and looked away entirely. Huh, those tattoos went a lot farther than he had previously speculated.

"No… are you *shy*, Deliverer?" Mydei jabbed. He had twisted enough to smirk over his shoulder at Phainon, eyes glittering.

Phainon was a soldier. There was no such thing as privacy in the barracks, and he had been to public bathhouses before. Nudity was not a big deal unless someone went out of their way to make it a big deal. That said, Okhema still expected some measure of modesty outside of smaller, private baths. He had simply expected the same.

"No," he said a little too quickly.

Mydei laughed and walked up to Phainon, locking eyes with him and holding them there with his gaze. He reached around Phainon while the Okheman tried to remember to breathe, to grab a towel from the stack behind him. Staying far too close, leaving no space for Kephale between them, Mydei slowly wrapped the short towel around his waist, never once breaking eye contact.

"Take a minute if you need it, Deliverer," he teased and then he was gone.

Phainon had no idea how long he was standing there short-circuiting. It was probably only a few seconds, but it felt like a full quint. He took a deep breath. Really, nudity was nothing, there were men coming and going around him and only about half were wearing towels and Phainon wasn't in the least effected.

But something about Mydei.

Maybe it was the way he had leaned in with that simmer in his eyes, like the gold of them was melting. Maybe it was the way he flexed when he turned to look over his shoulder at Phainon. There was that smirk curling his lips like Mydei knew *exactly* what he was doing. Or the flashing glow of those tattoos that went all the way down his-

Phainon slapped both his cheeks hard, hard enough to leave red handprints if the heat of the bath and his own embarrassment weren't already making him feel like a tomato. He was way too hot standing in the spillover steam of the baths, fully dressed, after *that.*

He shook his head and took his clothes off, feeling a little paranoid as he did, but every time he glanced at others changing, they weren't looking at him, everyone was too focused on getting clean and getting home.

Phainon tucked his neatly folded clothing away and reached for a towel. He was halfway done wrapping it around his waist when he remembered Mydei's jab about being shy and felt that spirit of competition curling in his belly. After taking the time to calm down while he undressed, Phainon didn't really have anything to *hide*…

He very happily strode to the baths with that very towel draped around the back of his neck instead.

It was not hard to find his friends. All six of them were in the back of the spacious room sitting around and inside a square-shaped pool. Steam rose in thick curls, weighing heavily in the air until disturbed by splashing, laughing, and rough housing. They saw Phainon walking towards them and a couple of them whistled.

"We thought you got lost!" Leonnius called.

"Starting to take bets on if you had slipped and died," Hephaestion weighed in. Despite how dark his words were, they all laughed, enjoying the mood.

"Mydei ran away so quickly," Phainon dramatically lamented as he stood behind the prince, "it took me some time to figure out where he went."

Mydei turned around in the bath to retort but it was his turn to catch his breath as his eyes traveled upwards to where Phainon smirked down at him. Mydei may have been aware of how he looked and the effect he could have on people, but Phainon could also play that game. The prince's lips parted just a little bit as his eyes traveled up and down.

Hephaestion came to the rescue, splashing them both with water with a firm slap across the surface. Mydei raised a hand and turned towards his first mate with a chuckle, but Phainon was far less dignified. The moment the boiling water splashed across his legs and feet,

Phainon squealed like a small child, recoiling with a leap from where he had been scalded until he was a safe distance away.

The others blinked at him for a long heartbeat and then all the Kremnoans were laughing so hard their roar could no doubt be heard from the ship all the way down at the dock.

“It’s his soft Okheman skin!” Perdikkas teased.

Hephaestion wheezed around tears, “I have never heard that sound from a grown man before!”

Ptolemy slapped them both. “Cut him some slack, what did we expect from the finest of the Okheman Navy!”

Even Mydei was cracking up at Phainon’s bruised pride.

He knew the teasing was all good fun, but it still gave him pause as he tip-toed back to the water, itching to prove them wrong, too competitive to listen to his body screaming for him to wait, that no one wanted boiled Okheman for dinner, least of all the Okheman!

“Deliverer, don’t force yourself,” Mydei said, a little more serious despite the chuckle in his voice and that was all Phainon needed to hear to firmly step into the bath.

It was absolutely the hottest thing he had felt in his life. This was what stew felt like. He was soup. This was soup. This was soup that needed to sit for twenty minutes to be safe to eat, that was what it was. But he managed to take a very painful seat in the bath, and everyone happily cheered for him, even if it felt a little condescending.

They were not in there long before Peucesta complained about wanting something cooler. Phainon suspected it was for his sake, but he was grateful for the excuse to y’know, live. Even so, he fought the urge to spring out of the water, waiting not so patiently until he was the last one out as though he had something to prove and then he was hurrying to the cold bath. The others laughed at him but followed Phainon all the same, trying different baths, different temperatures, until finally everyone felt clean, relaxed, and smelled nicely of soaps.

Phainon worked a floral smelling oil through his hair as everyone changed. He was already back in his pants and undershirt, checking himself in the mirror.

“You’re plenty pretty, Phainon,” Leonnius reassured him, “let someone else use the mirror.”

“’And he looked like a god as he came from the bath,’” Ptolemy agreed in quotes.

“I don’t know about all *that*, Ptolemy,” Phainon laughed.

“Relax, he’s said that about Mydei before too,” Hephaestion teased, and it was Mydei’s turn to blush scarlet. He had dried and dressed quickly but was taking his time with his hair like Phainon was, gently rubbing in a nice, sweet-smelling scent and braiding it carefully. For all their gruff, they took cleanliness very seriously when they had the opportunity to do so.

Clean, content, and feeling refreshed, Phainon followed them out of the bath house. They looped him in close, fussing with his hair, putting their arms around him, letting Mydei take up the rear to follow the pack in the dimming evening light. And as they walked, they pointed out landmarks and taught him more Kremnoan phrases while Peucesta played his lyre in the lead like an enchanted piper.

“Home sweet home!” Leonnius announced when they finally reached a building on the hill, nestled amongst other dwellings. It was an older home, had been there for a long time, sporting bronze fixtures and big stone pillars. Not quite the size of a palace but built for the general or dignitary that was expected to lead the city. Mydei’s home, Phainon realized.

“Wait do you all…?”

They nodded enthusiastically.

“There is too much space for any one man,” Mydei explained, “why would I not share it with people I trust?”

Leonnius took his wrist and dragged him inside, showing Phainon all the hallways but getting distracted when they got to a large, open receiving room connected to the balcony. Piles of cushions were shoved in two different corners. There were folded up screens set aside against a bookshelf along one wall. A big desk sat empty, pushed out of the way against the opposing wall. There were people there Phainon didn’t recognize, setting up food on a big, oval table surrounded by chairs and a pair of klines.

“Just in time,” Peucesta noted gratefully, and the music stopped so he could sit.

The others poured in behind them, shoving Phainon along until he was sat in the middle of a kline with Mydei sitting beside him on his left. Without ceremony, the Kremnoans started passing around plates full of fruits, roasted vegetables, fresh cheeses, herbed meats on delicate skewers, warm, fluffy bread, and of course fresh juices and creamy milk.

Phainon curled his nose a little when Mydei added milk to his pomegranate juice but after asking to try it and getting to sample a sip from Mydei’s own chalice, he was equally convinced of the merit of something that would seem otherwise strange.

They laughed, they joked, they told simple stories, and Phainon felt whole, so he was surprised by the aching in his heart when he stood on the balcony after dinner, changed into sleepwear that Mydei had loaned him, listening to Leonnius snoring, the quiet turn of pages while Ptolemy read, and the soft breath of the ocean breeze. The sky was dark, out of range of the Dawn Device he could see stars in the night sky, they twinkled as a reminder of days long past, and of how far away he was from his own home. A home he desperately wanted to share with the people resting quietly behind him.

This felt so *safe*. He felt so *happy* here with these men that he considered friends. Even felt privileged to have seen Mydei without his public-facing mask, to be able to jest with them, be vulnerable around them.

Phainon wanted so badly to introduce them to his family, to show them his city as they had done for him. He could imagine Ptolemy and Professor Anaxa arguing about a tome they had both studied while Perdikkas and Hyacine chattered about healing poultices. Leonnius might be able to stand a chance in a race against the triplets with those swift feet of his. Would Castorice love listening to Peucesta's songs, wiling away the time in peace, humming along while she worked on her handicrafts? If anyone could smooth talk Cipher into parting with her goods for a fair price it would be Hephaestion.

What would Aglaea think of Mydei? Would she also catch her breath, appreciating his beauty, that quiet confidence, the way he cares about his people so much that he fights the destiny they want for him?

His heart twisted, feeling so far away. No matter how much he wanted to just magically fix things, build the perfect bridge between everyone, he was still a prisoner from that distant place.

And he was unbearably homesick.

Chapter End Notes

Is it really a phaidei fic without a bath house scene? :3c

Chapter 13: Building Bridges

Chapter Summary

Mydei not putting a name to it yet but he is feeling something~

Chapter Notes

I keep telling myself the fluff is over and I focus on the plot now and then I think of something new and I can't help myself

They weren't the usual nightmares, Mydei was used to those. Usually, the back of his mind would dredge up old memories of drowning, whispers from the Sea of Souls as he fought upriver again. No these were different because there was light this time.

It started very much the same, Mydei was drowning, but when he broke the surface of the water the dream changed, everything was bathed in red light, the glimmer of a gold sun breaking through smoke. He could feel Nikador's battle cry rattling his bones, hear the titan's voice in his head, beckoning to him between screams and when they fought it was with violence that cracked the world.

Mydei expected to be jolted awake when Nikador's lance punctured his chest but there were hands on his back supporting him, pushing him forward, and when he turned to look over his shoulder: there was Phainon.

And in him was the courage to fight on.

Mydei woke up with Phainon's name on the tip of his tongue, unspoken only because of the weight of sleep. Sunlight was pouring in from the balcony, barely missing his face but warming his chest and legs. He felt groggy and heavy, still flopped across the kline. Someone had covered him with a blanket which he promptly kicked off to spill onto the floor. It was well past Entry Hour and it was too hot to be covered.

With a soft groan he sat up and ran his fingers through his hair. Mydei was very rarely the last one awake, but… where was everyone?

He looked around the room, puzzled.

Where was Phainon?

Surely, the puppy was not dumb enough to go into town alone?

Mydei waited for that thought to comfort him and when it didn't work, he was springing up off the kline and searching for his boots. Someone must've hidden them, determined to make him rest. Perdikkas did that sometimes when he felt like Mydei was overworking himself.

Instead, the prince hurried to the balcony, hoping to see one of his friends returning that he could call to but instead he found Phainon.

Not *on* the balcony of course, but down on the street. For the sake of space, Mydei's home was surrounded by others, not nearly the same size, but what use did he have for an expansive property when he was barely even there? The people who lived around him were mostly families, older men and women of the Godshield Brigade that had been commanded to retired and settle down.

Phainon was playing with a ball in the middle of the wide path, surrounded by children.

Mydei couldn't hear what they were saying from where he was on the balcony, but they were laughing and pointing at the ball in his hands that he was keeping above them, trying to balance it on one finger until two of the young boys jumped up and grabbed his arm, knocking the ball loose and then everyone, even Phainon, were chasing it. If Phainon slipped and fell (something he must've been doing on purpose) they tackled him while he laughed. Whenever he managed to steal the ball back, the kids teamed up to try and recover it. Anytime Phainon shouted at them in play, they laughed and had to stop to teach him how to say the Kremnoan words right while they pulled on his cape and coat tails.

It was shockingly domestic and Mydei found himself watching, no longer out of concern but out of curious amusement. Phainon getting along with kids shouldn't have been a surprise considering he was just like them at heart, but it wasn't something Mydei had considered until he saw it himself. Most of what they knew about Phainon was from embellished stories, he had been surprisingly reserved about himself on the ship, asking questions more than offering answers. Was Phainon so good with kids because he had his own?

Mydei's gaze sharpened at the thought, remembering what Phainon had said yesterday about not looking for a woman. Did he already have one? Was that why Phainon was so eager to return home to Okhema? Mydei could have sworn that Phainon was interested in men, the way Mydei had caught him studying his body at the bath. If he did have a family waiting for him, it would make sense to keep it a secret, to protect them from people he only thought of as pirates.

For some reason it really bothered Mydei to consider that Phainon may have a wife and child waiting for him back in Okhema. A knot twisted in his stomach, clawing through his insides towards his heart, but Mydei shoved it back down with practiced force. He frowned as he watched them now, deciding his time was better spent away from the self-indulgent speculation that he despised so much.

He sighed and leaned away from the rail but turned back when something caught his eye. Left on the wide stone railing were a pair of books, nearly identical.

Mydei recognized them almost immediately. He reached out to scoop up the book on top. It was his favorite tale, printed in Kremnoan, a rare find stolen from Queen Gorgo's personal collection when Krateros fled Eurypon. Sure enough, when Mydei flipped through the pages he could see his own scribbles in the margins, marking his favorite parts. His handwriting was instantly recognizable because it was barely legible; something Ptolemy had long mocked him for.

The book told the story of a warrior returning from a long war. Mnestia had spared him in combat because his wife had prayed to her for his safe return, but as the hero traveled home, he offended Strife by mistake. Thus, he was trapped, doomed to wander the world to atone until his family sought him out to return in glory together, saving him. Ptolemy quoted the book constantly, knowing that Mydei enjoyed it.

He jumped ahead to his favorite part, when the hero is finally found by his family. As a kid, Mydei resonated the most with that scene. It reminded him of the moment he had been pulled out of the sea. The detachment certainly weren't his *children,* but they were his family, and the joy he had felt when the hero was *found* filled him with such familiar love that Mydei had underlined and labeled the passage multiple times. He paused over the words. Underneath his own scribbles were neat letters, elegant handwriting in Okheman Common.

'This is my favorite part too.'

Mydei blinked. Maybe Phainon's Kremnoan was better than they realized, but more impressive was how Phainon had been able to interpret Mydei's atrocious handwriting.

He looked back over at Phainon, still having the time of his life playing with the kids. One of them had brought snacks, a melon that a parent must've cut into manageable slices. They were all taking turns trying to force feed the Deliverer while he sat on the ground, desperately trying to please the hoard despite his full mouth and the juice running down his chin.

Mydei turned back to the book. His favorite part too… Drastically different backgrounds, different cultures, and yet the human experience of wanting to be *found* by family, connected them. It was endearing.

And then Mydei remembered Phainon had a family in Okhema, and he closed the book with a pained, door-closing sigh and set it right back where he found it.

"Oh good, you're awake," Hephaestion said. The first mate tossed him a pomegranate from all the way across the room and Mydei had to step forward to catch it. It had already been cut so it was easy for Mydei to pull open the rind to start snacking while his best friend spread a couple of maps out across his desk.

"Has Phainon ever mentioned a wife?"

The desk screeched as it was pushed across the stone floor when Hephaestion tripped and stumbled into it. With a very careful, measured voice, Hephaestion over-enunciated, "*What brought this up, Mydeimos?"*

Mydei watched Hephaestion struggle to fix the desk, utterly unbothered by the reaction. “He had asked me about women on the deck yesterday and mentioned a family in Okhema when we were discussing his status as a prisoner of war. Do you think he has fathered any children?”

“*I think that’s the kind of speculation you abhor, and you should ask him directly.”*

That wasn’t going to happen. It was such a non-issue that didn’t change anything or directly affect anyone in the Detachment. Mydei was determined to see Phainon home regardless, so it didn’t matter.

Mydei responded with a non-committal hum.

“I have the reports from the dock crew,” his first mate said instead with a cough. He slapped a bunch of folded up papers onto the desk. “As well as the reports from the local scouts.” More folded papers landed with a *whap!* “And I have the inventory report from Ptolemy.”

“You have all been busy this morning.”

“Yeah, well, we had stuff to get done before we could leave, and you and Phainon needed the sleep.”

Mydei raised an eyebrow. “He slept in too?”

“Yeah, but I saw him playing outside on my way back. Leonnius was a little worried he’d wander into town if we left before he awoke.”

“I thought the same.”

“I know we joke about him being a dog, but he’s incredible, Mydei,” Hephaestion said with a smile, “we’d be very lucky if he joined the crew.”

The prince waved a hand dismissively, but he didn’t comment. Getting Phainon home in a way that didn’t jeopardize his people was the priority, nothing else mattered regarding the Deliverer of Okhema. He brought his breakfast over to the maps so he could look.

The situation was bleak.

The Black Tide claimed territory two different ways. The first was the horror that Phainon had experienced in his youth, the revulsion that claimed Castrum Kremnos, when the wave itself spreads like smoke or ink in the water. That’s the wave that they had felt in the storm, when the ocean turns black and corrupts ships that sail through it, turning whole crews into monstrous minions. When that wave hits land, it spreads like a mist, engulfing islands and turning their residents to those same monsters. At least when islands are taken, the monsters are generally landlocked, the mist retreats, and the monsters are left behind to hold the new territory.

The second way was via monster and bloodshed. Those roaming corrupted ships and monsters could persist away from the Tide itself, acting as any other army, expanding the Tide’s reach by conquest. Weak people, soft people, could be turned clashing with Black Tide

creatures, but warriors like those in the detachment were safe from transformation during those clashes.

In their sailing, the Chryseus Leo had seen the aftermath of battles with the Black Tide monsters. They were brutal and bloody warzones, with no captives and no survivors. Sometimes it was hard to tell which method was worse. Written in blood or ash, it was all the same story of suffering.

The map had been updated by the scouts. They used multi-colored dots and lines to indicate sightings, skirmishes, and other notable encounters with the Tide and other city-states. For now, the rest of the world still didn't know about them hiding here on this island, and Mydei was fine with that. When Phainon had told them that Castrum Kremnos' recent history was all but unknown to Okhema, Mydei had been relieved. The last thing they needed was a war on two sides.

The Black Tide had expanded to the isle north of them, taking it over entirely. If the Tide continued to push from that direction, their island would fall within a month, finishing what it started in Castrum Kremnos.

The roaming monsters hadn't found the island yet. For all their lack of humanity, they still harbored some leftover intelligence, enough to sail and to choose targets according to their master. One of the Detachment's self-imposed tasks was hunting down these ships, killing the monsters, and burning the vessels to push back the arm of the Tide. Another task was to be, as Phainon was so fond of calling them, pirates. They were discouraging trading vessels from routes that crossed into Black Tide waters by assaulting and robbing them, convincing those routes to change out of necessity.

Mydei followed the line of one of those routes with his finger. As of the storm, that route was now in danger, anyone traveling that line would be turned and then they'd have more enemies to deal with.

He sighed.

"It gets worse," Hephaestion told him, "we don't have the ore to repair or make weapons. The forges are reusing what we can but…"

"It won't be enough," Mydei finished.

He started looking over the map, combing through it with a practiced eye, eventually resting his finger on an island to the northwest. "This fort."

It was an Okheman fort. It was also the closest fort to the Black Tide line, in immediate danger. Mydei could go anywhere as a Chrysos Heir. He had that protection from the Tide due to his golden blood, but he was not going to bring his men into a place that may be underwater with the Tide. This fort was next, but there was still time. "They'll have an armory."

"It's Okheman…"

“It’s a military outpost far away from Okhema, soldiers not civilians.”

“You’re the one that said we aren’t at war with Okhema anymore…”

Mydei pulled his finger back and sighed yet again, this time softly through his nose. He was gripping that pomegranate way too hard. Hephaestion was right but they didn’t have a lot of choice. It would take too long to get to any of the other outposts to restock.

“All the more reason to go,” Mydei said, “the Tide will take that fort within the week. If we get to it, not only will we be able to take the supplies, but we may be able to save the men by chasing them to safety.”

“Never beating the pirate allegations,” Hephaestion sighed.

“Good.”

They had done this a lot. It didn’t bear repeating out loud. Whenever they did don the pirate persona, it was in its entirety. They covered the lion figurehead, changed their flag, wore ragged clothing over their armor, Mydei even had a horrible tricorn hat that at least distracted their enemies enough to forget any distinguishing features. Because at the end of the day, it was better for them to see pirates than Kremnoans. Pirates were isolated trouble, Kremnoans might encourage Okhema to mobilize against their ancient enemy. It was safer for his people if Mydei played the part of a brigand.

“And after the fort?” Hephaestion asked.

Mydei leaned over and pulled out drawers in succession until he found an inkwell and his pen. He put his mostly abandoned snack down so he could open the little jar of ink and wet the end of the pen with his tongue. Then he delicately marked a line in dashes.

“The fort and the trade route.”

“Yes,” Mydei confirmed, “we will take the north passage to travel the edge of the Black Tide. Once we have taken the fort and claimed their armory, we will chase the Okhemans back to the trade route and then follow it back here.” He followed the line with the back of the pen as he spoke.

“Taking out any ships we find along the way.” Hephaestion nodded, “short trip.”

“Tell Ptolemy to plan for three weeks.”

“Mydeimos, this is barely a two-week trip. We should save space for any cargo we take.”

Mydei shook his head. “Plan for the worst, Hephaestion.”

-

Phainon never wanted melon again. He had no idea what kind of melon it was, but he had eaten so much of it at the hands of a gaggle of children that he was sure that he was going to be sweating sugar for a week. Kremnoan were *relentless* at any age, and it was hard to say no

when they weaponized those huge, adorable eyes, and physically shoved sweet treats into his mouth before he could squeak out any words.

Eventually, the herd thinned, called away to do chores or training by their parents. Not every parent was happy to discover that their children were playing with an Okheman and Phainon had to scurry away from sharp insults and suspiciously accurate stones thrown at his head. He hadn't expected the first one and it had slammed into the space just behind his ear. It had hit hard enough for him to take the warning seriously, but not enough to bleed. The rest he was able to dodge but it was hard to explain the hostility to the kids, so he opted for a lame excuse about his own parents calling him and removed himself to head back inside.

"Oh Phainon," Hephaestion greeted, "done entertaining the whelps?"

"Ah, yeah, it seems their parents weren't pleased with an adult stranger eating their snacks," he laughed softly to himself, "it sounds worse when I say it out loud. Were you here to see Mydei? He was still sleeping last I checked."

"The prince is awake," Hephaestion confirmed with a grin, "we were just talking strategy."

"Anything I should know about?"

"Maybe not this, Phainon."

Phainon's smile wavered only a little. If Hephaestion noticed he didn't react. "I understand."

"We will be leaving this evening with the tide, though. Best be back on the ship before then."

"I will… Is there anything I can do to help until then?"

The Kremnoan tilted his head, a little puzzled with the request. "You know this is a break, right?"

"Heh, I know, it's just hard to sit still when there's so much to do!"

"The dock crew are working on the last repairs right now," Hephaestion thought aloud, his voice dropped nearly to a mumble like he was working through the list for his own benefit, not Phainon's. "There are still a lot of barnacles to scrape off the hull, if you really want to do that… oh, you said once that you dreamed of training at Castrum Kremnos as a child. The city may be lost for now, but the old masters are still here."

Phainon brightened at that prospect. "Would they be willing to train with an Okheman?"

"I'm sure with your obnoxious tenacity you could win them over," he laughed, "I'll take you there myself, put in a good word."

"I would appreciate that. Let me get my things, just in case I don't get a chance to return here before we leave." Phainon hurried down the hall but paused when Hephaestion called his name.

The Kremnoan's eyebrows were pinched, mulling over his words carefully before he asked, "Phainon, are you married?"

The question caught him so off guard that Phainon almost fell over when he tilted his head to a full 45 degrees. "No? Why?"

"Maybe I have a crush on you," Hephaestion teased.

"Aw, do you really?"

"Fuck no, go get your stuff before I leave you here."

Phainon laughed and jogged through the house to get his books, pleased to find them exactly where he left them.

-

Mydei trusted Empousa, really, he did, but it was routine for him to personally check the supplies that were restocking his kitchen on the Chryseus Leo. It wasn't that he needed a *lot* of ingredients, he just needed the *right* ones. This was when he started formulating recipes in his head and deciding if he needed to request anything last minute to round out the menu. It was very important to Mydei that everything his men ate was nutritious first and foremost, but a little variety and good *tasting* food boosted morale better than any other idea he had tried in the past.

He was reviewing their supply when the commotion started. Like a tsunami the disaster began with silence, an absence of people. It was that silence that made him curiously leave the galley to search the empty deck. The dock below was barely manned by a skeleton crew despite the pending voyage. Not a single crewmate was trying to sneak something extra on board. No one was fussing over the barrels still left on deck that needed to be secured. Honestly the only reminder that he wasn't completely alone was the soft *shuck, shuck* of someone scraping off the rest of the barnacles from the hull.

This was the only reasonable time to do it. As the tide retreated, the ship settled onto stilts placed on the beach, keeping her from becoming stranded in the sand and resting upright. It also allowed access to her belly which is how they quickly replaced the damaged outer layer of the hull and removed aquatic pests.

Mydei puzzled over the quiet, searching the shore, but even the shoreline was devoid of people. The city could've been empty for all he knew. That's when he heard the roar on the breeze, the collective shouting of many, many people. A little switch went off in the back of his mind, putting Mydei into combat mode, alert, ready for anything.

"Mydeimos!" Leonnius yelled. The runner came flying around the wall, sprinting towards the ship. He was panting, sweat dripped down his nose and splashed onto the dock when he paused to catch his breath. "Mydei!"

He leaned over the railing to look at Leonnius with a serious expression.

“You need to come quick!” he said, worried, “it’s Phainon!”

Mydei didn’t even use the ramp. He vaulted over the railing and hit the dock in a runner’s stance, already springing after Leonnius in a sprint. They rushed through the empty streets, panic and bile rising in Mydei’s throat. He pushed it back down, readying his crystals, prepared for anything as the sounds got louder.

The sounds of gathered people shouting and the noise of combat were not very different, the energy was very similar, and the smell of sweat was about the same. Mydei shoved through the crowd. Many of them parted willingly given enough time to recognize that it was him brushing against their shoulders, but he was in a hurry and most stumbled on contact.

They shoved through narrow, packed alleys until Leonnius and Mydei finally burst into the training grounds. Set up to emulate the coliseum of Castrum Kremnos in miniature, there was plenty of seating surrounding the hard packed dirt of the arena. All the seating was packed, overflowing to where people were watching from the tops of neighboring buildings and children were perched on their parents’ shoulders to conserve space. Every eye was watching two men circle each other.

Leonnius pushed further, closer to the edge of the arena with Mydei pressed in tightly behind him, until they finally could breathe. It was still packed tight but along the rail they could at least see what was happening.

Phainon was pacing, shirtless, wearing only that damn collar and his bracers above his belt. His hair stuck to the back of his neck with sweat and there were bruises forming across his ribs, right on top of the old yellow ones from the storm. A Kremnoan round shield was strapped to his left arm and he held a spear tightly in his right hand. Across from him was Herklas, one of the warriors that Mydei had tasked with defending the island, a seasoned warrior with a healthy bloodlust. The Kremnoan was dressed similarly but wearing a helmet where Phainon had chosen to go without. He was hitting his shield with the spear to draw Phainon’s attention before lunging and the battle continued in earnest while the crowd roared their approval.

On the sidelines, six other Kremnoans were waiting on a bench. One of them he recognized as Daidalos, former chief engineer of the Kremnos Arena turned General and Trainer. The others were warriors from the island. Three of them were tending to wounds or laying on the ground, already defeated, presumably by Phainon.

“Why is he shirtless again?” Mydei wondered aloud.

“You, of all people, did not seriously ask that,” Leonnius countered.

Mydei ducked under the railing, fully intending to stop the fight, to get to the bottom of this, when he noticed gold flashing in the corner of his eye and shot a glance in that direction. Perdikkas, Peucesta, and Ptolemy were working the crowd, taking gold coins and gathering them into a helmet.

His frown deepened and he stalked along the railing towards them while Leonnius followed.

“Round four!” Ptolemy called while Peucesta played an exciting chime on his lyre, barely even audible over the cheering and shouting.

“He IS just an Okheman,” Perdikkas was telling a man in the front row, “you really think he’d get lucky four times in a row? And against Herklas? It’s a safe bet that this is where the Okheman meets his maker.”

Gold coins changed hands.

“Okhemans train their bodies to be pretty more than strong,” Ptolemy was arguing with a lady a little farther down. “You can see it in his eyes and hair, he might have muscles, but does he really know how to use them?”

Yet more gold changed hands.

Behind them in the arena, Phainon and Herklas clashed again. Phainon’s spear glanced off the shield and he narrowly avoided the bite of a spear across his belly. Phainon slid under the shield this time, swinging the butt of his spear around to smash it against the back of Herklas’ head. The bigger guy stumbled but still twisted, lashing out to smash his shield against Phainon’s face. Golden blood streamed from his nose and Phainon had to retreat to brush it away with his thumb. It still flowed and he lapped at it absentmindedly with his tongue across his grin while those sunny eyes tracked his opponent.

Mydei stomped up behind Perdikkas who was still happily cheering to the crowd. Peucesta noticed the prince first, grabbing his lyre with an ugly twang to stop the strings from vibrating further while he wide-eyed flinched away.

“What?” Perdikkas asked and then he turned around.

Mydei must’ve looked like Nikador come to take them the way Perdikkas recoiled and hid the jingling helmet behind his back. Ptolemy slowly leaned forward, presumably to take it from him.

“Mydeimos! My prince! Are you not taking inventory?”

“What the hell is going on?”

“Mydei, it is not as it seems,” Ptolemy insisted over Perdikkas’ shoulder while Peucesta nodded furiously.

“It *seems* you are exploiting Phainon.”

All three of them started protesting at once, a combination of “we would never!” and “it was his idea!” and “it just kind of happened!” while they pointed fingers in every direction so Mydei wouldn’t noticed the helmet of coins being slowly tucked behind Peucesta’s boots. Of course he noticed. They were not subtle.

“Is this a *hustle?”* Mydei growled and the protests continued, impossible to follow.

“Mydei!”

Any anger immediately unraveled at the sound of that cheerful voice. Phainon had run over to them all smiles, blood still dripping from his nose, making a mess of his face while he licked his lips. Behind him Herklas was being dragged to the sidelines, barely conscious and groaning.

“Why are you here? Perdikkas said you usually check the ship inventory.”

Phainon was completely oblivious to the noise around them. Too excited to see Mydei. All of that adrenaline from the fight must’ve still been singing in his veins with the energy he had bouncing around, spear still in hand.

It made Mydei happier than he realized that this puppy had eyes only for him. His heart did a little confusing dance and then Mydei felt *jealous*. There were others fighting with Phainon? Having a good time about it? This wasn’t a more serious affair?

“Are you fighting for *fun?”* Mydei asked, incredulously.

“Daidalos thought it would be useful for me to spar to apply the techniques he was teaching me and Hephaestion had to go. I guess a few different people thought it sounded fun and agreed to help!” Phainon laughed. He was smiling so wide it was burning Mydei’s eyes in the best possible way.

He also knew that *helping* probably wasn’t the right word. This may have always been a fun and silly thing for Phainon, but Mydei was damn sure that it didn’t start fun for any Kremnoans that volunteered for a chance to stab an Okheman captive on home turf.

That said… it certainly took a ‘fun’ turn if the crowd was anything to go by. Mydei hadn’t seen this much life on the island in a very long time. There were still some upset people. He could hear curses thrown Phainon’s way, but the man was undaunted, just happy to be there; overjoyed with the prospect of learning something new and getting the opportunity to apply it.

“Mydei, would you like to spar with me?” Phainon invited and Mydei’s face cracked. His eyes widened, his lips parted, and it took him a while to find his composure.

He cleared his throat, coughing into a closed fist, and looked down, “Deliverer, this is not the best place for our rematch…”

“Then it doesn’t count.”

His golden eyes darted up again, to that warm and welcome smile.

Phainon repeated, “Then it won’t count. What do you say, Mydei? Show me how to use a spear properly.”

Mydei’s lips curled up into a smile and he shook his head with a wave of his hand. “HKS, I have been using a spear since I was a child.”

“I know,” Phainon teased, “we met with your spear under my chin, remember? It won’t happen again.”

"…very well, I'll show you a few things, but tend to your nose first," he said pointing to Phainon's bloody face, "while I tend to some business of my own."

Phainon smiled and trotted over to his trainer, who gave him a hearty slap on his back and handed him a cloth. They talked amicably, too far away for Mydei to hear but it still made him happy to see Phainon getting along with more Kremnoans. This man was single-handedly building a bridge between himself and these people who struggled to see past his affiliation.

If he wasn't already Okhema's Deliverer, he could almost be for the Kremnoans…

Mydei shook his head to chase away that hope and focused instead on retrieving those coins, but while the three of his men were still standing there feigning innocence, the helmet behind Peucesta's boots had disappeared. He pushed past them to follow the tracks in the dust with his eyes, tracking where the helmet had been dragged and barely saw the heavy thing, laden with riches, disappearing around the corner in a flurry of fluffy orange and white fur.

They *really* were never going to beat the pirate allegations.

With a sigh, he turned on the trio again. "Does he know?"

They all shook their heads.

"The hustle is over," Mydei ordered.

"Of course!" Perdikkas agreed with a not so innocent smile.

"Mydeimos!" Phainon called and the prince turned to see that dazzling smile again, pointing a spear his way, sun shining on his shield. "Will you keep me waiting, your Highness?" There was a laugh in the way he tossed his challenge, and Mydei grinned back, wide and unrestrained.

"You're going to wish I had!" he hurled back.

"Then show me!"

-

Phainon missed watching the launch. Not that he hadn't seen ships launch before, it was just fun to feel the breeze in his hair and watch the sails unfurl. It was usually an all-hands-on deck kind of moment, but Perdikkas had dragged him to the infirmary immediately upon boarding, leaving Mydei to take his things to his drawer.

The doctor was slapping salve on Phainon's bruises with a big grin on his face.

"It's not that funny," Phainon whined, "it wasn't even kind of fair."

"You did last longer than we all thought you would," Perdikkas tried to reassure him while he wrapped Phainon's outstretched arm.

“If I was using my sword…” he grumbled under his breath.

The door creaked as it opened and in strode the proudest chimera. Fig Stew jumped up onto the bed where Phainon was sitting, put his front paws on Phainon’s thigh, and very carefully dropped a single gold coin into his lap.

Perdikkas choked on his own spit laughing while Phainon picked it up and bounced it in his palm.

“What’s this?” he asked suspiciously.

“*It’s your cut*,” Perdikkas wheezed.

Fig Stew gave Phainon a proud, tiny, “rawr!” and then bounded away.

Chapter 14: Crossroad

Chapter Summary

> No new tags but bear in mind the archive warning "graphic depictions of violence" for this one.
>
> I like to think Mydei can act when he wants to as long as he has a good reason

Chapter Notes

> This one got away from me a bit. I have a sticky note on my monitor that says "keep it simple, stupid" and never read it when it matters.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei liked to think they did a pretty good job of keeping Phainon in the dark. They were careful to only talk strategy when he wasn't around, they avoided all his questions, kept him occupied with tasks, but Phainon wasn't stupid. He was graciously looking the other way. Mydei could see it in the tight press of his lips when he was told this information wasn't for him. He could see it when Phainon's smile wavered as they grew quiet in his presence.

But Phainon didn't push the topic. He held his tongue every time he caught small groups of men meeting with their unit leads in the galley to talk about the plan. He looked away when he saw them reviewing the armory, gearing the men despite no visible threat on the horizon. Phainon even hid himself in their room when they pulled the longboat up onto the deck to start packing it for the operation.

It was by Phainon's own desire that Mydei had given the order to exclude him. Piracy was something Phainon wanted no part of, and the captain was determined to respect that request.

By the fourth day, it became impossible to keep Phainon completely out of the loop. They had beaten the Black Tide to the island, approaching from the far side just as the thief star dashed across the evening sky, burning red, and weighed anchor out of sight of the fort. With the operation beginning, it was no longer feasible to work around Phainon without locking him away entirely and Mydei wanted to trust him enough to not resort to that.

They had taken forts like this before. Most of them followed similar layouts but Mydei was always careful to have many layers of planning and protection, and good strategies required intelligence. War wasn't just hack and slash like common folk believed. All five of Mydei's

closest friends commanded their own units during operations such as these, taking a handful of men to fulfill specific tasks best suited to their talents.

Leonnius was their best scout. Supported by his own hand-picked runners, they would go ahead first, taking a few hours to gather what information they could, and then they'd return to report and last-minute adjustments, if any, would be made.

Mydei saw them off, personally helping lower the ship's longboat into the water with the four of them tucked inside. Each runner was wearing a small pack of supplies, including the means to communicate with the ship from the shore.

That's when Phainon couldn't take it anymore.

"Mydeimos," he demanded, after Leonnius had departed. He cornered Mydei on the deck, stopping him by the rail where the prince was waiting to spot a signal in the dark with his arms crossed.

"I told you-"

"I know what you told me and that's not good enough anymore."

Mydei drummed his fingers on his forearms. "Deliverer, you don't want to know."

"Yes. I do."

"Piracy," he answered flippantly.

"I understand that. What *specifically* are you doing here? I know this island; I restocked here when I was hunting you."

"Then you already know why we have come."

Phainon was fuming, his voice strained. "I thought you said we weren't at war with Okhema anymore."

"We?" Mydei countered and Phainon's face fell.

"As long as I'm on this ship, I'm one of you, we agreed."

Mydei turned on him. "Are you offering to raise your sword against your own people? Steal from them?"

Phainon looked away with an annoyed tsk.

"Go to bed, Phainon. We will be moving on by morning."

For a long second, Mydei thought Phainon would argue with him, maybe try to stop them entirely. In the dim light of the evening his defiant eyes glittered darker, somehow a richer blue, but he didn't say anything else. Phainon scoffed to himself and stomped away with his shoulders tight and his footfalls heavy enough to speak to his displeasure.

It took two quints for Leonnius to respond. A fire lit on shore, a pinprick of orange glow that flashed green after a moment. Mydei smiled as the fire in his belly roared in response. He turned and shouted to the crew to make ready.

Slapping on disguises was something so practiced that by the time Leonnius and his scouts rowed back to the ship with their report, the Chryseus Leo was a different ship. The red flag emblazoned with the gold symbol of Strife had been replaced with a solid black square, the lions at the bow had been covered in a massive black sheet, and everyone had dressed the part. They were wearing dirty leather coats, using swords and spears without shields, and tying their hair back with cloth and worn hats. They used animal fat and ash to dirty their clothing and faces, hiding any identifying markers.

Leonnius climbed up the side of the ship first, followed by two scouts. The runners peeled off to brief Hephaestion and Krateros, while Leonnius followed Mydei to the captain's quarters. Mydei was undressing down to his pants as he went.

"It is as we thought. They have a dock for merchant vessels waiting for inspection and another hidden in a cove on the other side of the island near where we are now," Leonnius was telling him, "Only two triremes, both belonging to the fort, one is waiting in the cove, the other is at their public facing dock."

Phainon stood up from his chair when they entered but Mydei physically pushed him back down as he strode past, motioning for his runner to continue with the other hand.

"The wall is tall but thin and there is a locked wooden gate on the side, reachable via island path."

Mydei pulled open drawers and cabinets, throwing articles of clothing on as he went, moving swiftly with no wasted energy. Black leather boots replaced his golden armor, light gloves instead of gauntlets, rather than going bare-chested as he preferred, he pulled on a dirty, fraying tunic with an old cord around the waist for a belt. Over the top of that was a knee-length heavy leather coat, dark and covered in patches from prior battles. He strapped a sword around his waist by a thick belt that kept his coat from flapping and ran ashes from an amphora through his hair to darken it. Another dash of ash brushed under his eye with a thumb covered the red mark under his eye.

And the whole time Phainon watched with a deep, disapproving frown.

"No matter what you hear or feel, you will stay here," Mydei instructed, commanding and firm. He studied Phainon for any sign of rebellion while he pressed his tricorn hat to his head, and finding none, he left.

"Leonnius, your unit will be with me, bring me Hephaestion," he instructed and then Leonnius was gone, zooming ahead while Mydei paced the deck checking his troops for any last-minute adjustments. There was no need for a rousing speech, this was routine, nothing special, no one needed any more than that.

"Mydeimos," Hephaestion announced his presence.

“Your unit will accompany me to the shore via longboat; we will be approaching the fort from the island. Krateros!” the old man jogged over, “there is a trireme docked, use it to breach the wall. We will meet you inside.” The old man nodded, and they clasped forearms.

“May victory be yours, Mydeimos.”

There was another flurry of last-minute orders as each of his friends addressed their men, reminding them to show mercy to those that flee. Ptolemy was reviewing with his men what supplies to look for and how to mark their locations with charcoal on the walls. Peucesta was organizing his archers. He had a horn at his side, a means to relay orders in the chaos of combat.

“Mydeimos,” Hephaestion called. They were already piling into the longboat, via the rope ladder thrown over the side, waiting for him.

The prince flashed Krateros a look from the railing. The old man was already on the upper deck, ready to take over command. They nodded once and then Mydei was vaulting over the side of the ship.

The longboat dropped nine ‘pirates’ on the shore before returning to the Chryseus Leo. The crew would secure the longboat and then meet them around the side of the island. They wouldn’t have time when they fled the scene to recover it otherwise.

Leonnius whistled once, sharp and short, and they all fell in line behind him, keeping low along the edge of the foliage. To run through it would provide cover but the movement would be more easily spotted from a distance, even in the cover of night they were too many to convince a good lookout that they were animals. Keeping close but staying on the beach allowed them to move quickly and quietly.

The island itself was not big. It was not meant to be sustaining, only strategically placed. This fort was little more than a storehouse and inspection point, entirely at the mercy of their own Navy’s traffic through the area bringing supplies and providing equipment and food as needed in turn. Mydei didn’t expect a full garrison of troops, but he didn’t expect a walk in the park either. Two triremes meant two crews which meant a couple hundred Okheman soldiers. Maybe enough to challenge the Kremnoan Detachment.

Maybe.

Not likely. This would be over fast.

Leonnius led them through the trees to a narrow dirt path and then to a dense patch of foliage for them to hide in while they waited. Mydei could see the wall ahead. The gate was little more than a pair of wooden doors, locked in the middle.

Mydei closed his eyes to wait, taking deep breaths in his low crouch. On every inhale he could smell the warmth of sunbaked loam and humidity and hear the distant chirp of insects. Hephaestion’s heartbeat was steady, right behind him, Leonnius’ in front. They too waited in reverence, contemplating the battle ahead, holding back that excited rush at the prospect of a proper battle. The adrenaline lurked under their skin like hounds waiting for the-

Peucesta's horn cut through the night like a knife. Two seconds later the whole island shook, erupting with the sounds of shouting and tearing lumber; the creak and snap of twigs magnified a hundred-fold, barely audible over the crunch of collapsing stone.

Before the dust had even begun to drift their way, Mydei had already started running. Crystal erupted from the ground to rip the doors from their hinges and toss them aside, still locked tight but now utterly useless. His crystals burst into glimmering dust as the Kremnoans surged through the gate and into the keep.

Leonnius claimed first blood from their group.

Mydei was fast but no one could beat Leonnius for speed. The runner had dashed ahead to clash with the first of the Okhemans that wanted a fight, swords clashed twice before Leonnius had dragged his blade across the man's throat, already moving on to the next clash. Hephaestion was on his tail, cutting off the Okheman troops from the side as they tried to race to the courtyard, yelling all the while in desperate attempts to organize under the assault.

The courtyard was the pirate's primary entry point so naturally the bulk of the fighting was happening there. Using their position as a pinch, Mydei and his small group were able to confront and pick off the Okheman reinforcements before they could join the main host, more importantly, they were running into individuals as they raced through the fort's hallways and open courtyards between checking rooms.

Individual soldiers were easier to scare than those running with a pack. It was human nature to draw comfort and courage from your companions. Lone soldiers that saw Mydei and the others roaming showed more of a willingness to run, and that's when the pirates showed restraint. The same training and control that made them efficient killers also made them compelling actors.

Hephaestion raced down a hallway after a young Okheman. The soldier was trying his best but the feral look in Hephaestion's eyes made the point of his sword drop, easy pickings in true combat where only blood mattered, but the first mate's sword glanced off the man's cheek instead of slitting his throat. He kicked the sword from the Okheman's hand and swung in painfully slow arcs, giving the man telegraphed swings to dodge until the fear finally bit at his heels.

"It takes so much more effort to let them go," Hephaestion complained, while they watched the man run away.

Mydei patted him on the back. "Few Okhemans fight as well as our Deliverer."

Leonnius ran ahead, back and forth, luring in enemies that saw him as easy prey only for Mydei and Hephaestion to chase them away when the Okhemans realized how out of their depth they were. Any soldiers that stayed and fought were granted swift glorious deaths. It was respect for them to honor the choice of those men who wished to be courageous in the face of death. Better to die by the blade than to become food for the Black Tide.

"The storehouse is up ahead," Leonnius confirmed when he returned to them again. He had already mapped the place in his head. Mydei could see it in the gleam of his grin. "There is a

long hallway that leads to island caves up a couple hallways down. That's how they're escaping to the cove."

"Hephastion, secure the storehouse and armory with your men," Mydei ordered, "Leonnius go to our main force and lead them there. If the way is clear tell them to begin loading supplies starting with the armory."

They both saluted and hurried to their tasks without question while Mydei raced deeper into the fort, searching for anyone that may be left behind. True cowards would abandon their own if they believed them to be dead. If the ship left prematurely… It was important that the Okhemans sounded an official retreat.

Navigation rooms were in high places on ships, usually attached to the upper decks, but that was not necessarily the case for forts. As they did not move there was little need to check the maps to distant shorelines or glittering stars. Mydei found it next to their commander's quarters and was only mildly disappointed to see that the commander was not there. Whether fled or gone to fight it was hard to tell but he left behind a very angry looking older man.

The Okheman reached for his sword, drawing it and throwing it at Mydei with admirable precision. He barely stepped to the side in time, and the blade embedded itself into the doorframe with a few of Mydei's hairs.

"Pirate," the man hissed.

Mydei held his arms out to the side and grinned a wild grin. "So I am."

The Okheman reached for a spear leaning against the table beside him, but Mydei was faster. He dashed across the room and kicked the old guy in the gut, sending him against the wall. Experience gave him recovery unsuited for his age, and he reached for the hilt of another sword hung on the wall nearby, even as he slouched.

Mydei grabbed the spear before it could clatter to the floor and threw it like a javelin. The cold, impartial bronze cut through the Okheman's hand, pinning him to the wall with a short, startled, and pained scream.

The prince drew his sword, spinning it in slow, measured circles, meant to intimidate. He was a lion playing with his food, drinking in the pain and fear as he stalked towards the guy. To his credit, the man was masking his fear well.

"Kill me then, make it quick," he spat.

"Kill you?" Mydei crooned. He stabbed the sword into the wall beside the man's head, slowly dragging it closer and closer to his neck with a screech that he felt in his teeth as it dragged through the wall. "I wasn't going to kill you."

Suspicion cut through the pain on the man's face. This close it was easy to see he was terrified, but brave, using anger to bury any doubts that may shatter his defiance.

"You are not the commander of this fort," Mydei observed allowed.

“The commander is dead,” he snarled.

“Oh? Then congratulations on your promotion.” The spear and sword ripped free. Mydei braced himself against the wall with a foot for the leverage to wrench them both from the wall at the same time, to let the man stumble. The new captain cradled his injured hand to his chest as blood flowed freely down his palm and wrist.

“Sound the retreat,” Mydei ordered, “sound the retreat and my men will let you go.”

“You will hunt us at sea, pirate.”

Again, the prince grinned, a wild and feral thing. He was a rabid animal, a bloodthirsty pirate, eager to leave bodies in their wake. Or so he wanted this man to believe.

“Do you not want the head start?” he crooned.

The man’s eyes darted about and then he slowly started to walk around Mydei, keeping his body turned to face him, expecting to be stabbed in the back, but the pirate didn’t move. The Okheman violently snatched a horn from the table as he fled and before Mydei could count to five he heard that crisp clear sound of a war horn, bleating out a code into the night air.

Mydei held still as he listened, still counting. When he got to ten, he turned and continued to chase. He needed to be that specter in pursuit, that was his role; he couldn’t let them regroup at their dock and try to take the fort back. It was so important that they finished chasing the Okhemans away.

He turned a corner into a long hallway, the one that led to the escape route to the trireme in the cove and scrambled backwards when he heard people rapidly approaching. Mydei hid behind the wall with his hand on the hilt of his sword, listening to the rapid patter of footsteps and shouts, waiting for them to thin so he could take up the rear, to chase them properly.

The horn sounded again, close. That guy should have been promoted earlier. It sounded like he was taking up the rear himself, making sure his people were retreating. That made things easier.

Mydei waited for the horn to pass and nearly stepped out, but one last straggler was trying to catch up. With a purr and a grin, Mydei listened to those footsteps until they had barely passed his hiding spot and then his sword was swinging at that last Okheman’s heels.

He had expected a squeal, a shout, maybe a stumble before the man scurried away. Mydei did not expect it to be countered. His blade clashed with another much larger one as they sprang away from each other, down either ends of the hallway.

Mydei’s heart dropped. Standing between himself and the waiting Okheman captain was Phainon.

-

He really tried.

Phainon *knew*. He *knew* on day one that they were planning something he wouldn't like, something that would force him to confront his sense of morality, to balance it with what these men were like versus the things they chose to do. The kind of thing that tested the benefit of the doubt he gave them, the trust they had earned from him, that whatever horrible task they saw fit to exclude him from was for the *right* reasons.

They got quiet when he came near, dodged all his questions, and when he played along and let the subject change to small talk, he could see their relief as they believed they were playing him. But Phainon was no fool. If this was a campaign against the Black Tide then they would have told him the plan. No, whatever their plot, it was against *people*. *Living*, people. And when he had the chance to peek at the maps that they thought were so cleverly hidden, he knew that the Chryseus Leo was heading for the northernmost Okheman fort.

Phainon had been there before. He remembered it from when the Sol had resupplied there. It was not a well-manned fort and the people there were brave, soldiers true, but unpracticed. It would be a slaughter.

So, when Mydei shoved Phainon down, changed into wildly different attire to hide his identity, and then left, he didn't know what to do.

Phainon really tried not to think about what was happening.

He stayed in that chair with his fists on his thighs, trying not to look at the stitching on his sleeves, the suns stitched into his leather armguards, or feel the weight of the shining cape over his shoulder. He tried not to think about the title hung around his neck like a noose. Even when the ship picked up speed and he braced himself for the impact he *knew* was coming, Phainon did his very best to stay in that chair. He closed his eyes tightly and covered his ears with his palms pressed tight to drown out the sounds of shouting and yelling. He kept them covered even when he was thrown to the floor when the ship collided with something big, pushing and shoving forward before it finally stopped.

He really tried.

He really tried to behave.

Phainon scrambled to his feet and ran out of the door before he could stop himself. He didn't bother with a disguise; he didn't consider anything except how that noose labeled 'Deliverer' could just as easily be used as a lifeline as long as he pulled the rope away from his own neck and tossed the rope to someone who needed to be saved.

The Chyrseus Leo was bigger than the trireme that they had rammed. At their speed and angle, they hadn't plowed through the thing so much as just took its place at the dock by forcibly relocating the whole damn ship. It had been forced up the bank and into the fort wall, causing both the wall and the ship to tear in twain. The crew were already using the crashed ship as a bridge to run through the gap and begin fighting.

Phainon listened to the clash from the railing, scanning for his own entry point. A flash of light to his left and fine red dust on the breeze told him that Mydei had found an alternate way in. They were pinching the Okhema soldiers.

He swore to himself and instead followed the main host. He ran up the trireme and used it to vault up onto what was left the standing wall, crouching there to watch, to search for an opening, some way he could help.

The pirates did not hesitate to cut down those Okhemans that raised their voices with battle cries. He watched Perdikkas cut one such man down before moving to the next, his sword clashing with a man wearing a leader's colors. Mityphon was a young commander but kind. Phainon recognized him immediately from the one time they had met.

Arrows whistled past his ear and for a heartbeat Phainon worried that they saw his clothing and the crew were targeting him by mistake, but then Ptolemy's arrow lodged in Mityphon's eye while he was locked in combat with Perdikkas and he stopped caring if they targeted him too.

Phainon cried out but it was buried under others to mesh with the cacophony of death.

An older soldier turned when Mityphon crumpled, calling to his men, ordering them continue to defend with all their lives while he ran in the direction of the commander's quarters. That's where Aglaea's nymph would be, where any hope of rescue would come from.

Phainon saw Krateros advance on a young man, probably the kid's first tour. The boy was shaking, taking a step backwards. He was about to intervene, maybe save *someone, anyone,* when Krateros pulled his swipe short, barely clipping the boy's shoulder. It was enough to make him run, courage spent, and Krateros let him go.

Any Okheman that tried to retreat was allowed to, Phainon realized, but there was no mercy for those that chose to stand their ground. That was still too high of a price for Phainon. He had no tears for men he barely knew, but he had blood aplenty to shed on their behalf instead.

He dropped into the courtyard and summoned his blade, surging forward next to Perdikkas to expertly deflect a spear that was meant for his pirate friend. Adrenaline starting to flow, Phainon pushed his opening to shoulder charge the Okheman back and away from the others.

For a second nothing moved. Perdikkas was looking at Phainon with seriousness and worry, shaking his head and watching him with unblinking, burning eyes without saying anything. Phainon glanced away, turning from him to his own people instead.

They were caught between horror and awe. Phainon was framed by starlight and the glow of braziers, gold and silver outlining their Deliverer as he stood over them with his sword drawn, clean and gleaming. They recognized him and several of them smiled, cheering as they rallied, ready to fight once more, so their shocked faces cut him deep when he raised his sword towards them instead and yelled, "*Flee! Leave this place! Now!"*

Stunned, they made no attempt to move until the pirates again advanced and then they were clashing again as though Phainon had said nothing. A few even puzzled and murmured over whether they should be raising their swords towards *him* as well. Or at least they did until Phainon swung his blade to deflect an arrow meant for an Okheman and spun on his heel to face the invaders.

"*Move*!" he called to them.

One of the men, excited to stand shoulder to shoulder with their Deliverer, raised his sword to attack, but Phainon physically blocked him and the sword glanced off his pauldron with a clang. He put a hand on the man's chest and shoved him back. "*Run!"*

This time two of them obeyed, turning to flee.

Krateros swung at a persistent Okheman archer, but Phainon was there to intercept that fury. The old Kremnoan scowled under his disguise, rage burning deep as his sword was forced away, but it softened almost imperceptibly, when the archer tried to retaliate, and Phainon shielded Krateros with his own body. The bolt sunk into his shoulder just under the protection of his pauldron and he hissed but did not cry out. Sweat dripped from his nose as he spun, ripping that great sword through the air to cleave the bow in two. He chased the arc to put his hand on the archer's chest, to shove him back towards safety.

It was an uphill battle, Phainon lamented, one he was ready to climb, when he heard the horn. One long bleat and two short calls sounded a tactical retreat. The Okhemans responded immediately. Those in the back turned and fled, while the more experienced warriors on the front moved more slowly, covering their escape until Phainon physically got between the two forces again and then they were running too.

The vice commander, the old man that Phainon hadn't recognized at first, was crossing the courtyard with the horn, still sounding the retreat as he scanned for his men. The pirates were still pushing forward, slowing to a crawl as the battle faded into recent memory, and whooped victory cheers.

Leonnius raced around a corner, stumbling when he saw Phainon. He shook his head and ran to Krateros, talking to him swiftly. Orders were barked and they surged into the complex to loot it, any desire to chase was gone as they moved with purpose instead.

Phainon saw Perdikkas reach for him out of the corner of his eye, but he ran before the Kremnoan could stop him, chasing after the Okheman horn, eager to obey, to retreat, to flee, to *go home.* The vice commander paused when he met Phainon's eyes, the shock of seeing a ghost turning quickly to joy as they clasped arms.

"You live," he said.

"Yes," Phainon told him firmly. He let go to push the man along and he obliged, still sounding the horn as they ran into the hallway together. The pirates had peeled off, headed towards the main gate, the armory, and the storehouse. They were nearly at the exit, where the walls met the caves, when Phainon faltered and he almost paid for it with his ankles.

The flash of a sword reaching through the shadows barely registered in time for his instincts to respond. The clash lasted less than a second and then Phainon was bouncing back, putting himself between the Okheman vice-captain and their attacker.

Mydei's eyes were wide and confused. He lowered his sword at the same time Phainon raised his own.

“Deliverer!” the vice-commander called from down the hallway, urging him to come.

And Phainon really considered it.

They would flee to Okhema, to report to Aglaea. To be safe under the Dawn Device. It was a straight shot home to return a hero. The way he had been greeted, Okhema must have thought he had perished in the waters, it would overjoy them to know he was alive and well, to hear him speak to the Goldweaver of the tale of his survival and triumphant return.

And it would condemn those Okhemans to do so.

If Phainon went with them, Mydei would have no choice but to pursue with purpose to destroy. As far as these soldiers knew, they were attacked by pirates; an isolated incident, something to report, lament, and then forget. But if Phainon ran with them, then the truth went too. They would know that these were not simple seafaring brigands, they were Kremnoans, the Crown Prince himself among them and even if their reasons could be justified, Okhema would never be able to look past the flag they sailed beneath.

Mydei’s expression changed as Phainon stood there at the crossroad. The surprise had melted into a frown. His grip on the sword tightened, the creak of leather giving him away. He was doing the same math as Phainon was, coming to the same conclusions.

The sword in Phainon’s hand disappeared and he bowed his head, turning away from the vice-commander to walk towards Mydei instead. He didn’t look at the man, didn’t want to see his expression. There was too much to explain so Phainon didn’t try. He stood a few paces away from the pirate and waited until he heard the footsteps behind him vanish into the night.

“…you did not go with them,” Mydei observed aloud. His voice was softer than Phainon had expected, no edge at all.

“How could I?” he asked. When Phainon looked up it was with a genuine smile and tired eyes with his hands held out to his sides. As much as he wanted to go home, he still wanted to do it the right way. He owed them both that much. “We haven’t finished our fight.”

Mydei studied him in the dark, his eyes flicking between Phainon’s own and the spreading gold on his sleeve. The captain closed the last few steps between them and reached for him. Phainon expected a soft touch, but Mydei forced him to turn around with a shove instead so he could break the arrow sticking out of his back, making Phainon yelp as the head moved in the tender flesh.

“Go back to the ship,” he ordered gently, “I think that’s enough piracy from you today.”

Phainon grimaced and nodded. Mydei left him standing in the hallway, trusting him to return on his own.

He walked slowly, eyes straight ahead. Phainon didn’t want to look down, didn’t want to see the bodies. There were some in the hallways with their throats slit and he wondered how

many of them had been killed by his close friends. He puzzled over why that didn't upset him more.

A few pirates were moving the bodies in the courtyard before they could finish cooling, setting them neatly to the side, more respectful of the dead than Phainon might have expected. Against orders, he stopped to help them.

He was supposed to be these peoples' Deliverer, but even as he set his hands on each of their chests, sending them to Thanatos with a mumbled blessing, Phainon felt… fine, relieved even to not find any Kremnoans among the dead. Of course he grieved, of course he felt guilty and hurt to see his countrymen dead, but there was also an acceptance. He couldn't save them all against their centuries long feud, but he *had* managed to sway a great many of them to escape unharmed. Perhaps it was Phainon's newfound understanding of Strife, or maybe he simply did not know them well enough to mourn them as one might a close friend, but as he stood again and left the fort to climb back onto the Chryseus Leo it was with a sense of curious peace blanketed over his grief and unease.

There was no way he could choose to be like this all the time. But wasn't this lifestyle of violence the same as the one he had already been living as a warrior for Okhema? How was this any different? Both sides were fighting for duty and for love; as Perdikkas had once described it: a reason worth living for.

Phainon watched from the railing of the upper deck as the crew loaded stolen goods from food to weapons to precious resources, everything except wealth. They were loading survival onto the ship, hope for the future of their displaced people.

It made him feel like he was still standing at that crossroad again, the same one that he had been trapped at from the moment fate put him under red sails in the mouth of a lion. The same crossroad that fate was going to decide in the purest way through combat. Phainon had told Mydei that he stayed to honor their duel, and he meant it with his whole being.

So why did it feel like he had already made his choice without it?

Chapter End Notes

https://x.com/lilikeaven/status/1967324783928086587 <-- Please, please look at this wonderful Pirate!Mydei art!!

Chapter 15: The Fine Line of Piracy

Chapter Summary

No new tags!

Chapter Notes

My friend pointed out that I keep taking Phainon's shirt off. I'm not sorry. Consider it a call back to almost every trailer he's featured in.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei was worried when he got back to the Chryseus Leo. It didn't show on his face of course but Hephaestion could tell, and it wasn't hard to figure out why.

Phainon was acting normal.

They were still anchored at the fort's dock, the last of the supplies trickling in, getting ready to leave, and Phainon was on deck helping Perdikkas tend to the injured with that same soft smile as though they hadn't just killed a bunch of his countrymen and robbed them.

"If Perdikkas isn't worried…" Hephaestion tried but Mydei's frown deepened.

Phainon was talking softly to calm one of the men who he knew could not understand him while he pressed gauze to a wound. Phainon's right arm was in a sling, tied tightly to his chest to keep his own injury from worsening so he only had his left hand to work with. He had left his coat and cape in their room, but gold still soaked his shirt making it stick to his back over the bandages that had been swiftly slapped on. Crimson blood colored his palm and fingers, but he was still steady, unbothered by the way the soldier held tightly to Phainon's wrist for grounding. He just… kept talking in soft whispers to put the man at ease until Perdikkas could get to him.

When the doctor took Phainon's place, he moved to the next guy, fetching water, gauze, applying pastes, whatever was asked of him that he could do with one arm. He just wanted to help.

"He could have run," Mydei wondered aloud.

"We would have had to hunt him, you know that."

Yes, and Phainon would've also known that. He wasn't stupid, but… "why didn't he try?" Phainon was too hopeful, too positive, too determined to give up without a fight. It was in his nature to *try.*

Hephaestion turned around to lean his back against the railing, looking over the aplustre instead of studying Mydei as he had been since they got back. His hair was in a long ponytail, tied at the nape of his neck. He pulled it over his shoulder and ran his fingers through it.

"Did you want him to?"

Mydei's brows pinched. His immediate response was 'no', but it was more complicated than that, so he kept his silence.

Hephaestion sighed through his nose and rolled his head, leaning on his elbows so he could stare straight up into the sky to say, "You better beat him, Mydei." They both twisted in place, just subtly enough to catch the other out of the corners of their eyes. "When you settle his challenge. You better fucking win."

-

Phainon was tired. It had been a long and miserable night, but his hurts could wait, people needed help, and he couldn't sit still knowing there was something he could do for them. There were too many injuries for the infirmary, so Perdikkas had any man that needed medical attention stay on deck towards the bow, out of the way of where able-bodied Kremnoan pirates were moving goods.

It was an efficient system, practiced, but slower than Phainon had expected it to be. Everything they brought on board had to be inspected before it could be sent to the hold to be packed away for the journey. Peucesta and Fig Stew had final approval over every piece that crossed that ramp. It had seemed utterly ridiculous to Phainon that the chimera's stamp of approval was required. Surely this was not the best time to entertain the animal's antics.

And then he saw Fig Stew pull one of Aglaea's golden threads out of a crate and everything made more sense. Even the pet on board had a job. The chimera had a nose for finding them and if he couldn't reach one, he'd just scratch until Peucesta came to offer opposable thumb assistance. Fig even found, and ate, one of Aglaea's nymphs, and finished sniffing the rest of the cargo with part of a wing stuck to the fur next to his mouth.

"Phainon," Perdikkas called gently. He reached out to gently touch Phainon's bicep with his still clean forearm as he stepped in close. "You've done enough. It's late, please rest."

"I'm okay, Perdikkas."

"You fought twice as hard as any of us, playing both sides like you did."

Phainon shyly reached to scratch the back of his neck and barely stopped himself in time to avoid bloodying his hair. "It was nothing."

“No. It was a lot. You saved people, Okheman *and* Kremnoan. Maybe there’s something to that title you keep trying to ignore.” Phainon’s eyes went wide for a moment and then he looked away, but Perdikkas lightly kicked his shin to keep his attention. “Something to die for, yeah?”

“A reason to fight, to live,” Phainon corrected, “…I think I will go lay down.”

Perdikkas nodded and gently nudged him along, pushing Phainon towards the stairs. The crew still milled about, barely recognizable in their costumes as they unfurled the sails and raised the anchor.

He went to his room and closed the door with his foot. The wash basin water hadn’t been replaced yet, so it was still a little dirty, but it wasn’t egregiously murky. It darkened immediately when Phainon gently put his hand under the water to try and wash away the gore. Phainon had avoided the mirrors in the room. He knew there was red blood spattered across his clothes, his face, his hair, never mind what he had personally shed in gold.

One-handed it was almost impossible to get the blood off, no matter how much he splashed. He sighed and nearly gave up until a hand reached around to rest on his arm. Phainon flinched away and the hand retreated.

“M-Mydeimos! I didn’t hear you come in.”

“My apologies, I didn’t mean to startle you,” he said gently, like he was trying to soothe an upset chimera. Mydei looked different, but kind of attractive as a pirate. The hat suit him. It held his bangs just right to frame his eyes and drew attention to his signature braid that rested just over his right clavicle.

Phainon felt the heat rise to his cheeks. “I wasn’t startled,” he insisted with a cough, but Mydei didn’t push the issue.

Instead, he pointed to Phainon’s hand on the edge of the bowl. “May I help you?”

Dirty water slowly ran down the side of the basin while Phainon considered that question. Matching Mydei’s softness of voice, he said, “Yes… please.”

Mydeimos took off his hat, coat, and gloves and left them on the table. Then he lifted the washbasin to cradle in both arms, muscles flexed but not struggling. Water sloshed as he lowered himself to sit on the floor with his legs folded beneath him to cradle the basin in his lap. He gestured for Phainon to sit across from him.

Carefully, because of his bound arm, Phainon stumbled his way into a cross-legged position to match and offered Mydei his hand.

Gently, almost reverent, the prince took Phainon’s hand in both of his and guided it into the water. It made sense, because of his gauntlets, but Phainon was still surprised by how *soft* Mydei’s hands were without them. Where his were callused from swinging a sword, Mydei’s were not. The prince took very good care of himself.

Strong thumbs massaged Phainon's palm in slow circles and long, firm strokes, then rolled his hand to do the same for the back, for each knuckle. He held Phainon still, palm up, with one hand cradled beneath while the other gave every individual finger attention, rubbing them each in turn to clean them. He guided Phainon to curl his fingers, to trace along his nailbeds to find the stubborn, offensive sanguine there, until it was only healthy pink skin beneath the swipe of his careful touch. Mydei cupped water with his hand to scoop it over Phainon's wrist, to brush away the stray speckles that had tried to escape down his arm.

It was impossible to tell which drop of blood was Kremnoan and which was Okheman. It was all the same red. It all smelled like copper and dried dark. It all turned pale in water and it all washed away the same, leaving cloudy streaks in something that was otherwise pure and untarnished.

Even when Phainon was certain he was clean, Mydei didn't stop taking his time to trace the lines on Phainon's palm as though he was searching for the future there in the dim light, reading a book that no one else dared tried to understand but that he desperately wanted to.

And Phainon didn't once try to take his hand back. He felt respected, maybe even a little worshipped. He was *definitely* blushing all the way to his ears at the quiet intimacy, but every touch carried relief and gratitude in equal measure.

"Why didn't you go with them?" Mydei asked in a whisper while he massaged the soft flesh below Phainon's thumb.

Phainon looked up at him, but Mydei was avoiding eye contact, focused entirely on Phainon's hand in the basin while he waited. His expression was relaxed aside from the subtle arch of his brow, a curve of concentration and concern.

"You would have had to chase after me, to bring me back if I had," Phainon answered in the same whisper.

"Is that the only reason?"

Phainon tensed but Mydei assuaged those feelings by twisting the Okheman's hand to cradle his fingers as though he may raise them to his lips for a kiss. His thumb rubbed across Phainon's knuckles.

"I told you," the Deliverer mumbled, "we have to finish our fight."

Mydei lifted Phainon's hand from the water, holding it just above the surface. The little drips plinked in the water below.

"Are you angry with me?" the captain asked, while he used his other hand to scoop water over the both of theirs, to rinse them. "At the crew?"

"…I was at first," Phainon admitted when he had a moment to consider it. He lowered his gaze from Mydei's downturned face to watch the basin. "But I think you've earned my trust. I saw that you had ordered the crew to let them escape if they ran. And I saw the map; I knew the Black Tide was going to reach this fort soon. They would *all* be dead if you hadn't picked

this spot." Phainon experimentally flexed his fingers and Mydei stopped what he was doing in case Phainon wanted to reclaim his hand, but he didn't. He left it there for Mydei to hold. "In a way, I suppose I should be thanking you, for saving who you could."

"Leave your hand right like this," Mydei ordered. He tapped Phainon's outstretched hand with one finger, leaving it palm up in the air so he could move the washbasin to his side, setting it on the floor and leaning over to reach for a cabinet drawer. Mydei fished around, body tilting at a funny angle as he strained to reach for a towel. Then he set the soft fabric in his lap, recovered Phainon's hand, and the care began again.

"I expected you to be full of fury," the pirate admitted as he delicately pressed the towel against Phainon's skin. "So eager to be home that you would have taken any chance to be free of the shackles that I put around your wrists." He pressed his thumb to the side of Phainon's wrist as he said it. "When I saw you standing there between myself and your freedom…"

"I think… I think we should still let the fight decide," Phainon admitted, "we swore an oath when we stood across from each other, to face each other fairly. What kind of man, what kind of Deliverer would I be if I could not honor my own word? Besides, I think I have done more good here, serving you, than I ever have playing court in Okhema."

Mydei snorted, a light puff of air through his nose, perhaps a laugh in disguise. "Silver-tongued as you are, Okheman, I'd expect you to enjoy such boring endeavors."

"And where were your boorish mannerisms tonight, Kremnoan brute?" Phainon teased, "when you let my people escape, saving them in ways they will never know?"

Mydei rolled his eyes and rubbed at Phainon's hand a little more roughly while Phainon chuckled.

"Mydeimos," Phainon said more seriously, "I'm not a pirate. I can't do everything you do, even if it's for the right reasons, but I still want to help. I want to fight."

Mydei met his eyes for the first time sitting down, his face still guarded, but there was a tremor to his gaze when they looked at each other, when Phainon smiled with genuine warmth.

"HKS," Mydei grumbled. He looked back down to continue drying Phainon's hand. He gave it back when he was satisfied that it was clean. "Then perhaps you should be more careful. You have nearly doubled the number of injuries my ship sees per every three entry hours, and I cannot trust you by my side if you are leaving gold all over my ship every time I look away!"

Phainon laughed, "Perhaps you are not protecting me well enough, hm?"

"Are you a child? Do I need to be your keeper?"

"You *could* keep me," Phainon joked but the look of shock on Mydei's face had Phainon back pedaling. He took his hand back so he could cough into his fist. "I'm sorry, that joke

was in poor taste."

Mydei rolled his eyes and folded the towel so he could dip the corner of it into the washbasin to wet it. Roughly, he took hold of Phainon's chin and held him still while he wiped his face. That grip loosened with every stroke until it was just the warm pads of Mydei's fingers pressed under the bone of Phainon's jaw, guiding more than demanding.

"You are a strong fighter Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," Mydei praised, "not many can keep pace with me, and I like how it feels to fight with you, both at your side and against you. If we want to ensure our pending battle for your fate is fair, I think it best that we study the way the other fights."

"Makes sense."

Mydei set the towel aside and motioned for Phainon to turn around with a slow spin of his finger. He obeyed but still jumped and twitched at the cold of those gentle hands when Mydei slid them under the hem of Phainon's shirt. He pressed a little more firmly in response, so that it wouldn't tickle so much as they worked together to get the filthy fabric off his chest around his sling.

Water dripped and splashed behind him and then the cool of the towel turned washcloth wiped away the evidence of his willingness. The scarlet of life spilled by men, the same between nations, was starkly set apart from the two men. Did Mydei feel isolated from his people because he did not bleed the same as them? Did he perhaps see in Phainon a kindred spirit? Gold sparkled in the water, refusing to blend with the hematic price shed by common men until Mydei stirred the water with the cloth.

"When you are well, I would like to begin sparring with you regularly," Mydei invited as he resumed his task.

Phainon's smile widened. He knew Mydei could hear it in his voice. "I would be honored."

"So eager to collect bruises."

"Oh *Captain*, this won't be anything like the arena."

"Good," Mydei purred, with an audible smile of his own, "I'm counting on it."

-

The Chryseus Leo stopped chasing the Okheman trireme by Lucid Hour. The crew was too tired after the late-night prior and with how quickly their prey had fled on favorable winds, Mydei decided their goal had been achieved. Those soldiers would be safe in Okhema, and they had other plans to attend to.

True to his words, Phainon began to spar with Mydei daily, something they both looked forward to. Mydei found comfort in sparring with his old friends, but Phainon was always a *challenge*. They were there to learn from each other, sure, but Mydei learned day one that Phainon *hated* losing and their spars almost always escalated into fights that rattled the ship.

It got so bad that they lost the privilege of using the upper deck, where Mydei usually sparred, after Mydei kicked the tiller on purpose to make the ship turn unexpectedly tight. Phainon had predictably lost his footing when the ship caught on a wave and lost most of its momentum, but before Mydei could take advantage of the stumble and claim victory, a very angry Fig Stew came flying up the stairs. Displeased with the whiplash that had interrupted his nap, the chimera sank his teeth into Mydei's elbow, just above his gauntlets, and then gave Phainon the same treatment with teeth in his hand when the Deliverer laughed.

They were more careful after that.

Every time they clashed, Mydei felt himself getting stronger, properly growing, where before he had felt like he had hit a plateau. He could see Phainon improving too. His sea legs were getting better and somehow his disposition was even sunnier. It was easy to forget that one day they'd have to do this for real, for higher stakes, a topic that didn't even come up when they bantered, finding a good give and take that carried into real fights too.

And there was no shortage of those.

Mydei had been right to plan for three weeks at sea. The storm had pushed the Black Tide into more of the trade route than they had predicted and the Chryseus Leo had to burn four ships in two weeks. Only half of those ships had been safe to loot after being corrupted.

Phainon was invaluable in every fight against the Tide due to his golden blood and righteous tenacity, but his true value came from what he meant to Okhema and her allies. As the Deliverer, he was instantly recognizable and as they had seen at the fort, his presence and a few carefully chosen words were all it took to end a fight quickly, to chase away those who may otherwise stand their ground and fall to the sword and spear when they did. It was Phainon's own idea to weaponize his reputation for good.

Mydei had nearly sent him away when Phainon had strode confidently into his meeting with Hephaestion and Krateros. They were discussing plans, budgeting resources, and calculating their route with every intention of returning home at the end of the second week. *Krateros* had been the one to offer to hear him out and Mydei was so surprised and a little impressed that he agreed.

Which was why at the beginning of the third week since leaving the Kremnos outpost, they were already targeting another Okheman fort. Phainon had pointed it out on the map, not too far out of the way. He provided explicit details of its layout, its size, number of soldiers on duty, and even an estimate of supplies worth taking. He helped with every single step of the plan, something that Mydei considered very pirate. He kept that observation to himself.

It was a plan that only Phainon could've scripted, and it was something only he could pull off. When they pulled into that enemy port dressed as pirates and waiting for the signal from Phainon, the Deliverer walked right up to the gate to call his people. Regal and beautiful, fully on display in the Goldweaver's handiwork, he shone like the sun under starlight. Phainon knew exactly what to say, exactly how to be himself, to get them to willingly open the gates. When the Kremnoans surged inside like a hurricane, ready to fight, Phainon was beside them, weaponizing the pirates' reputation with his own. He never once summoned his

sword because he knew exactly what words would make the Okhemans drop their weapons and flee.

To the mild disappointment of the crew, it was the first time they had won a military engagement without bloodshed, and the payoff had been substantial. Despite planning it, Phainon still refused to help steal, and excused himself to wait in the library, keeping to himself to study, away from the piracy that he felt he could avoid.

He only did what he absolutely had to do to ensure the fewest number of casualties. But for all his efforts to preserve peace, Phainon was still a savage warrior when he needed to be and was not shy of bloodshed. When they clashed with the Black Tide, Phainon and Mydei would race to leap to the corrupted ships, to steal each other's kills, and pretend they didn't see money change hands between their friends whenever they announced their totals.

They were in familiar waters, heading home under clear blue skies and warm sunlight, talking about the bath house and leaning against the rail side by side to watch the white caps when Phainon had another crazy idea.

"Have you ever considered going on the offensive?" he asked, cheerful, natural. Phainon had said it with the same casual cadence as asking what they were having for dinner.

Mydei turned his head to look at him. "Against?"

"The Black Tide."

"Is that not what we have been doing?"

"Patrolling the line and burning ships that have already turned slows it down, but it isn't the same as pushing back."

"Deliverer, there is no way to 'push back', the Black Tide," Mydei reminded him.

"What if there was?" Phainon's eyes always glittered a brighter blue when he latched onto an idea. Like a dog with a bone, Mydei often thought when they gleamed with such resolution.

"Don't waste your time dreaming." Mydei turned around to lean backwards against the ship instead. He crossed his legs at the ankles and rested his elbows on the railing.

"I'm serious. If there was a way, would you take it?"

"Of course I would."

Phainon turned to rest his weight heavily on one elbow so he could face Mydei completely. The sea spray clung to his bangs in tiny droplets that shimmered in the wind. "What happens to the Tide line if we reclaim its islands?"

Mydei frowned as he considered that.

"It already retreats," Phainon pointed out, "after turning what it can."

“Not for all of them.”

“But when it does... If we kill all the Black Tide monsters, would the Tide line retreat further?” Phainon was looking at him with excitement. Oh, if determination and sheer willpower could make it true…

“What if the Black Tide itself isn’t expanding?” Phainon asked, “what if it is just moving forward and trusting it’s monsters to hold its new territory? What if there is a limit to how far it can reach without its army?”

“We would not be able to verify that without sailing around it,” Mydei mumbled. He held his own chin between his thumb and curled pointer finger while he studied the deck in thought.

“But if I’m right, then it could be forced to retreat.”

“What is to stop it from surging forward again? When it realizes what is happening?”

“Then we don’t invite people to go to those islands yet. We clear them and just-“ Phainon shrugged his shoulders, “-see what happens.”

“It’s a curious idea, Deliverer,” Mydei agreed, “if the others see fit to gamble on your idea, then when we restock, we may test your theory.”

Phainon beamed but that smile faltered. He was looking past Mydei, out towards the horizon, suddenly very serious. The scout on duty noticed it at the same time and shouted from the topsail in Kremnoan, “sails ho!”

Mydei turned to look as the shout went out, squinting at the ship. The Chryseus Leo was moving quickly, less than a day away from home and a good night’s rest on dry land. They would easily outpace this ship but…

“Mydeimos, could that be one of yours?” Phainon asked, breathy and rushed.

“No.”

“They’ll find the isle-“

Mydei was already crossing the deck to shout, “Hard to starboard! Battle stations!”

Krateros and Hephaestion took up the call and started shouting more specific orders as the men hurried to obey. The ship twisted and the sails groaned as they started to turn. Mydei bent his knees just a little to brace himself as the deck tilted ever so slightly and was secretly proud that Phainon did the same *without* holding onto the railing. His sea legs were getting better.

“Mydei, we don’t know if it’s an enemy ship,” Phainon tried.

“Wait in the room, Deliverer,” Mydei ordered stiffly.

“I can help-“

“Not if they are Okheman Navy! Those sails are white and blue, you know there is a chance.”

“Then I can talk to them!”

Mydei stomped his foot and light rippled along his tattoos to intimidate, but Phainon met him with his own growl and a shine in his eyes.

“We don’t have to fight!” Phainon snarled in broken Kremnoan.

“Look at the ship, Deliverer! We are not playing pirate. We are a Kremnoan war ship nearly home! This is not only about *us* but the remainder of *all* my people… and you are the only exception I will make.”

No prisoners. His people needed to stay safe.

Phainon’s eyes burned, his closed fist was shaking, but Mydei was right and Phainon knew it. With an angry yell, the Okheman turned on his heel, cape flapping happily and as oblivious as an inanimate object could be at the tension in the air. He stomped out of sight to sulk, presumably waiting to crash the party anyway.

Mydei stretched his hands and shoulders by rolling his fingers and reaching across his own body to pull each arm in turn until he felt loose and ready to fight. The two ships were rapidly gaining on each other now that they were moving to intercept and not following the same path. With every passing second the ship on the horizon got bigger until Mydei could see her flag proudly on display in the swift wind.

Okheman Navy.

And then a black and orange bolt narrowly missed his cheek.

Well, they used to be Okheman Navy.

“Black Tide,” Mydei snarled over his shoulder and Krateros relayed the call to the crew.

Phainon would probably come out of hiding then. There wasn’t time to worry about him right now and if he wanted to stay sulking, fine. More for the prince and another win to hold over Phainon’s head.

Moving in broad daylight like this was abnormal and the sea was still a sparkling blue, rather than the ink of the Tide. There was no reason for this ship to move with such haste and energy.

Mydei climbed up onto the railing and held onto a line for balance as they approached. Another Black Tide arrow zipped his way, close enough to pull his half cape in its wake with the wind but he didn’t flinch, he didn’t move at all until the sides of their ships ground together and then Mydei was throwing himself onto the opposing deck in a spray of red crystal.

The monsters near him evaporated as he clawed through the air and jagged crimson materialized in a wave before him. Aside from the monsters, there was no other evidence of

the Tide.

Mydei twisted enough to yell across, “Hephaestion!” They made eye contact. “Free to board!”

The first mate saluted and started shouting orders, and Mydei was turning back to the monsters with a feral smirk. He started running at a Black Tide archer but moments before his claws could connect, Phainon’s great sword tore through its chest. The steel stuck in the deck point first while the monster dissolved into ash.

Mydei spun on his heel in time to see Phainon land on the deck beside him.

“For the record,” he said, as he ripped his sword free and spun it in a circle, “I’m not happy about this either.”

“Then you concede?”

“I didn’t say *that*,” Phainon growled, and then they were both dashing different directions.

The entire fight was over in five minutes.

Mydei would have loved to personally take credit for the swift victory, but favorable circumstances were on their side this time. Phainon and Mydei could have single-handedly cleared the ship but having the rest of the crew on board to help was a boon, not a hindrance.

“23!” Phainon shouted from the ship’s bow.

24, Mydei thought but he lied when he shouted back with a scowl, “21!”

It was worth it to see Phainon fist bump the sky and dance to his own music the whole way back to the Chryseus Leo. Let the man be happy while he avoided the piracy he so abhorred.

“Let’s make this quick!” Hephaestion was yelling, “only grab what Perdikkas and Leonnius mark!”

The crew were pouring below decks to the cargo hold. There wasn’t enough room to take all the supplies, but they could get the valuables for now.

Mydei walked up to the upper deck first to bind the tiller and drop the anchor. He raised his hand towards the Leo as well and waited for one of his men to respond with the same gesture. The hand shot up a moment later, followed by the splash of the Chryseus Leo also weighing anchor so the ships wouldn’t drift too far apart while they searched for goodies. It looked like only the crew had been corrupted, so they could leave this one anchored here and return when they had more space for stolen goods to burn it then. This close to home they could probably just send their merchant ship to loot it on the way to market.

The maps spread across the table by the tiller were useless. Nothing they didn’t already have so he went to check the captain’s quarters instead. Unsurprisingly, Ptolemy had beat him to it and was perusing the two-shelf library there.

“Anything of interest?”

“The captain was a lover of romance,” Ptolemy acknowledged with a tone that screamed *yes.* His finger traveled along the spines in turn before he made a happy *oo!* sound and plucked one out to thumb through its pages.

Mydei grunted and started going over the man’s desk looking for orders. There wasn’t anything readily available to give their purpose away. His desk was neat and tidy, just another Naval war ship caught in the Black Tide’s net.

Mydei was about to leave when he saw the corner of fine parchment sticking out of a half-opened drawer and reached to retrieve it. The glitter of the broken wax seal was what caught his eye. The image pressed into the wax featured a pair of scissors crossed with a needle, the two bound loosely by a swirling thread and framed by laurels. It was Aglaea’s personal seal.

He turned the folded paper over a couple times before opening it to read.

Mydei’s eyes widened, and his head jerked up to check that Ptolemy hadn’t seen. The man was still engrossed in whatever book he had found. He turned so the bookworm wouldn’t notice him and then he read it again. Then he read it a third time.

His heart twisted twice, first with relief, and then with worry.

That fine script that curled effortlessly over the page in neat and simple lines were orders to the late captain from the Goldweaver herself. Orders of the utmost importance, a singular task to bring a particular pirate to justice.

Mydei folded the paper up carefully and tucked it inside his gauntlet, wedged in tight so he could keep it close, already feeling the weight of it. He’d have to tell them all eventually but first he wanted to get out from underneath the ink, to process this news himself.

“Let’s go Ptolemy,” he ordered.

“But I’m right in the midd-“

“Now!”

So much for their fight.

-

From the desk of the Admiral Goldweaver of Okhema,

Herein I officially commission the esteemed Captain Theophis of Okhema with the singular task of bringing the pirate, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, Deliverer of Okhema, to justice.

All expenses for any additional supplies that may be acquired at sea will be compensated, to be paid from the Goldweaver's private treasury.

Allies of Okhema must provide any and all resources as needed at the discretion of Captain Theophis until this criminal is apprehended and returned to Okhema to stand trial.

Refusal will be considered an act of treason.

Aglaea, Goldweaver

Chapter End Notes

I've said it before but I'll say it again: I treasure you guys. I love my readers and especially my commenters. You guys bring me such joy and relief to know that my silly idea was worth sharing! Even if I do get a little carried away and write way too much. Someday I will master the art of one shots, but it is not this day.

Chapter 16: Deliverer

Chapter Summary

No new tags
Phainon has a really good idea
Mydei also has a really good... well, it's an idea

Chapter Notes

Posting this one late cause it was actually a little tricky and it was running long. I was very adamant about putting specific things in this chapter so a couple scenes got a trim so the important parts could shine

I don't like swapping perspectives too many times per chapter but this felt right

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“HKS,” Ptolemy said slowly. He was leaning against one of the balcony pillars, enunciating the word for their poor puppy. Phainon was sitting on a stool in front of him, trying to navigate petting Fig Stew while they practiced.

“High kas,” Phainon responded, equally slowly.

“HKS.”

“Hick ass.”

“HKS.”

Phainon’s eyebrows were pinched so tightly together while he concentrated that he was almost squinting. He licked his lips and tried again. “Hic is.”

Mydei was trying so hard not to laugh, but the smile slipped out anyway. Even though their last voyage was only a few weeks, he had ordered more than one day of rest back home. The ship was fine; she was resting at harbor. Mydei just wanted the time for… personal reasons.

Even as he lazed about on the kline on his balcony, watching his best friends desperately try to teach Phainon how to pronounce Kremnoan syllables correctly, that letter was burning a hole in his desk. The same desk that was in this room shoved against the wall. He had put it there when they got home and hadn’t had a chance to move it from where it was hidden under a stack of blank stationery.

Mydei wanted to show it to Phainon, needed to hand it to him, to let the man read it and understand how much had changed, this new gravity to the situation. He wanted to be ready on the heels of heartbreaking news with an invitation to his own family, to let Phainon know that he was wanted and loved, even if it was from pirates. Everyone in this room from Peucesta playing the lyre half upside down on a cushion, to Perdikkas who was slowly losing his patience with all the swear words flying around, to Hephaestion who was trying and failing to nap, wanted Phainon to stay. At some point since they pulled him on board, every single one of them had come to Mydei in private to ask if they could keep him somehow.

But not like this.

Please not like this.

Mydei wanted Phainon to choose them because he had that choice, not because it was taken from him in ink or because of the results of a fight that Mydei kept finding excuses to avoid.

"HKS," Ptolemy tried again and Phainon groaned and flopped backwards off the stool to starfish on the cool floor with a *whump*. He tried to use the new angle to pet Fig Stew's belly but the chimera bit him and then Phainon shouted his worst attempt at the expletive yet.

"For Nikador's *sake*," Perdikkas finally cracked, "that's enough cussing for now!"

"This is important," Ptolemy insisted.

"*How* is *that* important?"

"Do you not want him to be able to pronounce your name correctly?"

Perdikkas was across the room in an instant, tackling Ptolemy around the waist and scooping him up enough to throw him over the balcony and into the bushes below to the soundtrack of raucous laughter. He at least leaned over the edge to make sure Ptolemy was okay. The scholar-warrior must've been fine because Perdikkas snorted, clapped his hands together to rid them of dust, and returned to his lunch with a satisfied expression.

It wasn't the first time someone had been thrown off this balcony. There was a reason Mydei had personally planted bushes down there. He chuckled lightly and raised his cup to Perdikkas in an approving salute who flashed a toothy grin his way.

The only one who was really alarmed was Phainon who scrambled to his feet to charge the railing, barely avoiding going over himself to call out, "*Are you okay?"*

"'Be strong, saith my heart; I am a soldier; I have seen worse sights than this,'" Ptolemy quoted back and Phainon relaxed.

Phainon who was too nice for his own good. Phainon who had weathered so much more than any one man of high moral standing should have to endure. Truly, he was the hero from the book, the one who Ptolemy most quoted.

"'Much have I suffered, labored long and hard by now in the waves and wars. Add this to the total - bring the trial on,'" Mydei mumbled under his breath, to himself, for himself, as he

studied Phainon. The man was strong, physically and emotionally. Intelligent too. It would take him time to adjust to the news but there was no need to baby him, to protect him, and the longer Mydei waited to break the news the worse it would be.

“Did you say something, Mydeimos?” Phainon asked, twisting his head to look his way.

“Yes.”

“I didn’t catch it.”

“Because it was not for you,” he grumbled and hid behind his juice.

Phainon laughed, “keep your secrets then.”

Mydei’s heart twisted uncomfortably. “…Phainon, there’s something-“

“I got the new maps!” Leonnius announced. He jogged into the room with his arms full of giant scrolls. Ptolemy was a few steps behind still picking leaves and debris out of his hair and clothes.

“Well played, Perdikkas,” he said in a low tone, flicking one of the leaves in the doctor’s direction. It obviously didn’t get very far before it fluttered uselessly to the ground to be crushed under Leonnius’ hurried steps.

The runner took the maps to the desk and set them down before dragging the furniture away from the wall about a foot. That’s when Hephaestion got up to pick up the other end, so they didn’t have to endure the screeching protests of an inanimate object dragged across marble. They set it down near the middle of the room where the light was best and where everyone could gather around.

Mydei’s eyes flicked back to Phainon. The man was watching with increasing concern, head tilted, the sky of his eyes alight with curiosity. “Mydei?”

“Another time.” The knot in his chest twisted farther, almost unbearable. He got up to avoid Phainon’s persistence, to focus on this new curiosity. It helped for now, but avoidance wasn’t a long-term solution.

Perdikkas pulled the extra maps to the edge of the desk and held them with one hand to keep them from rolling. Leonnius had found the specific one he felt was most urgent and needed the space. The map smelled like fresh ink just barely dried, and it held itself open without help in the corners.

“This is just around the isle,” Leonnius said as everyone gathered to see, “what the island scouts could confirm and… it’s not good.”

“Fuck…” Perdikkas breathed, and no one called him out for his language. There was no better word for how they were all feeling.

There were two lines dotted on the map to mark the ebb and flow of the Black Tide as it fluctuated around the ocean. At ‘low tide’, it was quite far away, harassing islands too far to

be of concern, but at ‘’high tide’… It was reaching the northern part of their isle.

“We have to start evacuating,” Hephaestion said in a whisper.

“That’s not possible. We’re too established here,” Ptolemy argued.

“We did it before when we left Castrum Kremnos,” Perdikkas reminded them.

“No, Perdikkas, we do not have the means to do so. There’s not enough food, not enough ships. We physically do not have the ability to get everyone off this island fast enough.”

“You shouldn’t have to, Ptolemy,” Phainon insisted.

“It was an inevitability,” Mydei said casually, but it did hurt. Moving his people again so soon… where would they even go? How would they even get there? The only place safe from the Black Tide was Okhema.

His thoughts drifted once more to the possibility of dissolving the Kremnoan Dynasty. Perhaps Okhema would accept them then, as refugees. If he personally went before the Goldweaver to negotiate… but after their adventures in piracy, they were more likely to be arrested. If Okhema was willing to arrest their golden boy and put him on trial, what hope was there for the Kremnoan people?

“What about my theory?” Phainon asked.

The Kremnoans looked at each other, puzzled.

“What theory?” Leonnius prodded.

Phainon told them what he had theorized about the nature of the Black Tide. Everything that he had told Mydei the day before on deck.

“Look,” he said as he pointed, “there’s a town right here on this island.” He pointed to a dot on the map, between the two Black Tide lines. The dot was marked in purple, indicating that it belonged to the Black Tide. It fell a little over a year prior, the whole town swallowed up and turned. For a long time, it had been unreachable, and with the way the Tide fluctuated it was rarely free of the black and it still might have been trapped under that corrupting fog. These maps were as accurate as possible but with something so malleable as the Black Tide, there was a chance that only Phainon and Mydei would be able to do anything to quell the swell.

“If we follow the Tide when it retreats and reclaim this island, I think it won’t be able to surge as far when it comes back again.”

“I don’t think that’s how the Black Tide works,” Perdikkas said bluntly.

“We don’t know anything about how the Black Tide works,” Ptolemy huffed.

“We know that every time it comes back it pushes farther,” Leonnius added unhelpfully.

“If it’s just an unstoppable force of nature,” Phainon started, “then why has it slowed down in recent years?”

Perdikkas shook his head, “what are you talking about?”

“I’ve been through all your old maps in the library,” the Deliverer said, “about five years ago the Black Tide’s expansion slowed down.”

Ptolemy stroked his chin. “Leonnius, down the hall-“

“I’m on it.”

Leonnius turned and jogged out of the room.

“I’m not saying you’re wrong, Phainon,” Perdikkas started to say, “I just don’t think it’s as simple as taking a sword to a hurricane.”

“…I better go help him,” Ptolemy grumbled, and he left too.

When they returned it was with way too many maps of various ages. A few were so old they almost crumpled when Mydei reached out to help take them. The paper was yellowed and faded with dark edges from years of handling.

“Careful!” Ptolemy hissed.

They very, very carefully sorted Ptolemy’s hoard by age and started to unroll and lay them on top of each other with the oldest maps on the bottom of the stack. It took all of them (except Peucesta who was still happily adding a suspenseful soundtrack to the room) to delicately layer each sheet and pin down the corners. The curl factor varied based on age so while the newer maps still remembered how to lay flat, the oldest one kept desperately trying to snap back into the scroll shape it was used to.

“Good grief, Ptolemy,” Perdikkas mumbled, “more than half of these are older than you!”

“Don’t start, my collection is about to prove a point.”

“…yeah, Phainon’s point,” Hephaestion observed. He was already flipping through the maps by one corner and just the little bit he could see was making a difference.

“There are more maps here than just what I had on the ship,” Phainon noted. He was preening under the praise, Mydei could tell from the way he carried his shoulders, but he was too focused to gloat.

“I can’t bring my whole collection on board.”

“Not that it hasn’t stopped you from trying,” Leonnius coughed into his hand.

Mydei reached out to gently take the edges of the stack. With Phainon’s help they pulled the layers back and then relayered them one at a time to watch how the Tide had spread throughout the years.

It was daunting to say the least. Stories claimed that the Tide was at least a thousand years old, but their records on the desk only went back about four hundred years. By that point the Tide had spread all throughout the North and was creeping through the ocean, eating civilizations that had almost been entirely forgotten. Even calculating how hard it was to track the Tide accurately, the pattern that emerged was consistently easy to follow.

The Black Tide had spread like a plague unhindered, getting bigger every jump, every new layer showed it spreading until around 80 years prior when it started to slow. The next map after showed stagnation, it wasn't growing, but it wasn't retreating either. Mydei went to drop the next map on top when Ptolemy stopped him.

"Wait."

He reached into one of the drawers and pulled out a few sheets of paper and Mydei tensed. Aglaea's letter was just underneath that stack, but Ptolemy didn't see it. He closed the drawer, and the prince was able to breathe again.

Ptolemy tore a strip off the paper and folded it around the edge of that map to mark it and then he gestured for the next one.

The next map was a seven-year jump showing another surge of Black Tide activity. Again, it steadily spread through their rough simulation of the years, until it stopped for a time. Ptolemy marked that map and the next three maps that showed the Tide fluctuating, before they moved on. Anything that seemed out of the ordinary was marked until they again reached the present day.

"A force of nature would not have slowed down," Leonnius pointed out.

"Or retreated…" Ptolemy mused as he flicked through his tabs and finally settled on the one, he wanted to look at first. Mydei helped him peel back the layers to get to the map from around 40 years back. There were three of them, all penned within a couple years of each other.

Ptolemy flicked between them rapidly to watch the Tide retreat in massive strides. "Do you guys know what this is?" he breathed, quiet, almost disbelieving.

Phainon sucked air in through his teeth. His eyes got wide.

"Kremnoans," Ptolemy continued with disappointment, "you cannot tell me that the Okheman realized before the rest of you did."

Mydei took a breath, realizing at the same time as the others as he reached out to run two fingers over a red and gold dotted line. There were notes in the margins, scribbled orders marked by arrows, circled isles, all in familiar handwriting. The air felt heavy.

"The Northern Campaign of King Eurypon," Mydei said, breathy and tense.

"Krateros blamed the campaign for Eurypon's corruption," Hephaestion mused, "but he must have been doing something right."

Ptolemy pointed to key locations on the map. “This is the isle where Chryseus Leo was recovered.” He flicked between maps to show the isle changing hands between the Black Tide and the Kremnoan army.

“Krateros would remember that campaign,” Perdikkas pointed out, barely above a whisper.

“He wasn’t on that front,” Hephaestion reminded them, “Eurypon had him running the campaign against Okhema at the same time.” The first mate leaned over to point at blue marks on the map, Okheman conflicts towards the South.

Mydei made a mental note to consult with his teacher later. The prince reached out to another tab and flipped through the maps to five years back. The time skips between each flip were not as long so it was easy to watch the Black Tide slowly engulf Castrum Kremnos. Just prior to the death of King Eurypon, the Black Tide was almost entirely stopped. It had been holding constant for several years and then it slowly started to creep forward again, not as fast as it had hundreds of years in the past, but dauntingly consistent.

“Did we do this?” Mydei asked the room in a hushed tone. Two of his fingers rested over the Castrum Kremnos of six years ago, waiting on the line of the Black Tide. Eurypon’s notes were everywhere in increasingly frantic script. Words were misspelled, the ink was thick and spattered where he had broken pens pressing too hard. Most of it was total nonsense. He had been trying to fight the Tide, Okhema, and three other nations at the same time, craving war anywhere he could find it.

“When I killed the old King,” Mydei continued, “did I take away our defense against the Black Tide? Am I the reason Castrum Kremnos was lost?”

It was quiet. No one knew how to answer that.

“Doesn’t matter. Take it back,” Phainon said, “there’s proof right here. Fighting the Black Tide works.” He flipped rapidly through the last five years with his thumb. Before anyone could argue with him, he asked, “When did you guys become pirates and start patrolling?”

“About five years ago, not long after Eurypon’s death,” Ptolemy said.

“Then it’s still working.” Phainon flipped through the sheets again so they could see. “Your patrols are keeping the Black Tide from spreading faster.”

“It’s not enough-“

“Then we make it enough!” Phainon’s energy was infectious. He was firm but excited, eager to make them see that there was hope. “It’s right here! The story of the Tide is *right here!* No other military force has tried to fight the Black Tide aside from the Kremnoan Dynasty and it was *working*. The island I mentioned earlier, we can start there, stop trying to slow it and start pushing it back.”

“Phainon, Eurypon went *mad* fighting the Black Tide,” Perdikkas reminded him, “mad enough to start infighting. He famously came home from the Northern Campaign a changed man. He became obsessed with his role as the inheritor of Strife, started trying to experiment

on the Titan, demanding more violence. Mad enough to-“ he cut himself off with a glance towards Mydei.

“To feed his only son to the Sea of Souls,” Mydei finished for him with a nonchalant wave of his hand, “the Black Tide poisoned his mind.”

“Eurypon wasn’t a Chrysos Heir,” Phainon reminded them. Mydei shifted uncomfortably.

“You really think you two are enough to make up for the entire Kremnoan Navy?” Leonnius laughed, “the Kremnoan Navy at the height of its glory?”

“No, but it’s a start, and there are more Chrysos Heirs in Okhema. If we can contact Agla-“

“No,” Mydei cut Phainon off with an urgent growl that had Phainon blinking in surprise.

Hephaestion looked between them with narrowed eyes and then broke the silence himself. “For now, we should test the theory. We take a few islands from the Tide, clear out the monsters and see what happens.”

“We will have to time it right,” Perdikkas pointed out, “for when the Tide is focused elsewhere.”

“Better not feed it more people to turn,” Ptolemy agreed.

Behind them Peucesta twanged his support in a major key.

“It will work,” Phainon reassured them, and it was hard not to believe him, “we’ll save everyone.”

“Who better to try than us?” Leonnius sighed, “only Kremnoans would be this stupid to think we could win against the Black Tide.”

“Well, Kremnoans and one Deliverer,” Peucesta reminded them. Everyone looked over at the musician where he still lay, hair splayed in all directions while he strummed out a melody. “Who better to pick up a mad king’s broken torch, than a collection of fools that bleed red and gold, Kremnoan *and* Okheman?”

Mydei watched them scatter, invigorated by Peucesta’s words, to begin preparations for their fool’s errand, leaving him alone in the room. He flicked through the map tabs and pushed the layers off until he found the map from around 20 years prior. His father’s handwriting was legible and lacking any signs of physical strain, but his words were radical drivel focused on his reign. He scribbled poems in the margins praising Nikador, begging for the coreflame, for the strength to finish the enemies of Strife while the Black Tide consumed their Northern territories.

He brushed his thumb over the date in the corner. A month after this map was drawn, King Eurypon threw his newborn into the Sea of Souls to appease the Titan of Strife.

With a long sigh through his nose, Mydei covered the map and pulled out the letter that held Phainon’s fate. Phainon, who so desperately wanted to go home, who so desperately wanted

to save everyone. The Deliverer of Okhema…

Mydei tossed the letter onto the desk as though it would burn him to hold it any longer. It settled on top, covering part of the Black Tide on the map. Aglaea's seal glittered like golden blood and Mydei realized something important.

'They call him Deliverer. From whom do you believe they want to be delivered from?'

Mydei had once selfishly believed Phainon could be *their* Deliverer, not Okhema's, but what if that clever lady, ancient as she was, had considered the same.

But then why did the Goldweaver call for the arrest of the person she believed could deliver the world from the Black Tide?

-

Phainon absolutely felt like he had the advantage on land. Something about the predictability of where his feet were landing without the need for micro adjustments to keep his balance. All that training on the ship was paying off at least. It felt like he had so much more stamina as they raced through the town, scouring for Black Tide monsters.

Mydei and Phainon were leading the charge. The Tide had retreated just before action hour and wasn't expected for another entry hour, so it was safe for the entire detachment to swarm the island. They left behind a few men to protect the ship and everyone else was given orders to raze the place.

This was the third island that they were trying to clear. The other two had felt like a warmup, little more than small villages with only a handful of monsters guarding their shores. They were on the way. This town was much bigger with a population near a thousand. The island had been rich in natural resources and was home to a small mine that would need to be checked before they left.

Phainon had every intention of taking on that task… if he could find it. They didn't have any maps of the town's layout so there was some learning on the fly, but Phainon had a good sense of direction and understood how to navigate difficult terrain. Aglaea very frequently chose him for difficult missions in dilapidated places for that exact reason. Who better to handle it then?

The sword in his hand flashed in the afternoon light, blinding a daemon before he leaped through the air with a shout to slice cleanly through its arm. A spin, a slash, and gold and ash gushed from its chest before it crumbled.

246.

In the distance, Mydei's crystals surged tall enough to be seen over the tops of the buildings. The crimson shattered into dust just as quickly as it had appeared. Phainon whistled. From this far away he didn't mind openly admiring Mydei's handiwork.

The captain had been distant the last few days. Embracing the opportunity to unleash everything against the monsters would do him good. When they had leaped off the boat together and raced to get a head start on the other, they had both been grinning.

Phainon was still worried. If he had stayed by Mydei's side like he wanted to, the captain would've undoubtedly scolded him for it. He'd scoff and say something about not needing an Okheman's help, but there would be mirth in his expression and a lightness to his tone and he'd be right. Even distracted Mydei in combat was wildfire, all-consuming and untamable.

But something about him lately was… off.

They were both in great shape, healed from their injuries, but Mydei kept finding reasons to postpone their duel. Ever since the end of their last voyage, Mydei kept looking at Phainon like he was in pain and then denying it when Phainon tried to point it out and ask what was wrong. All their conversations now were short and professional, keeping only to the topic of the Tide except for one.

Before they fell asleep the night prior, Mydei had called to Phainon from his hammock across the room and told him in all seriousness that he was very happy to stand shoulder to shoulder with him, that he hoped they could continue to fight under the same banner. It had been so soft and so strange that Phainon had to ask Mydei to repeat it.

He had refused and Phainon had laughed and returned the sentiment.

But he still remembered the fear in Mydei's voice, so subtle in that moment of vulnerability. He remembered the way Mydei had washed his hand, his face, and his back more than a couple weeks prior, the way Mydei had looked in that fort, like he was relieved when Phainon had chosen to stay.

It was a curious thing to feel that *want* from Mydei. Even if he didn't say it, Phainon could tell that Mydei wanted more than anything to ask Phainon to stay, to join the crew. This awkward distance that Mydei was keeping felt like he was gathering courage to ask, delaying their fight to buy time, and Phainon was trying to decide how he would answer. It had been a joke at the time, but Phainon meant it when he said Mydei could keep him.

But… he still needed to go home. Okhema needed him, Aglaea needed him, but as Phainon rushed forward and slashed through the heart of a Black Tide blade creature (247), he felt genuinely sad. Out here, Phainon felt like he was saving the world and helping people as he had always dreamed of doing. If this plan to push back the Tide worked, he had every intention of winning the duel, stomping up to Aglaea's desk and demanding her Navy come to Mydei's aid.

But that meant convincing Mydei to finish their fight.

Phainon ripped through a pack of three more monsters. That was 250. He wondered how many Mydei was up to and then he was surging forward again.

In the end, Mydei had found and cleared the mine. The monster in there had taken him the better part of several quints to kill which gave Phainon more time to kill the small fry. After a

heated argument about how many points the champion was worth, Mydei finally threw his hands up in defeat and let Phainon claim victory this time. A victory that Phainon happily celebrated at dinner with a deep bow and a victory fanfare provided by Peucesta.

With three islands cleared of the Tide, the Kremnoan Detachment plus Phainon retreated to safety at their home port and then it was just a matter of waiting.

A lot of waiting. After failing *again* to convince Mydei that it was time to finish their fight, Phainon had fallen asleep on a kline with his book over his face. Leonnius sliding around the corner so fast he slammed into the wall was what woke him up.

“Phainon!” Leonnius greeted excitedly. “Where is everybody?”

“Uh, bath house, I think.”

“Phainon, it *worked*!” the runner said. He was waving a scroll in his hand so animatedly that the poor thing was getting wrinkled and squished where his hand was squeezing it around the middle.

“What worked?”

“Your plan!” Leonnius eagerly unrolled the map across the desk to show Phainon the new Tide line. “It didn’t come back as far. It isn’t much but… Oh wait, there are some lines missing.”

Phainon got up and set his book down on the kline behind him so he could see the map. Leonnius had a spot marked with his finger. “Will you get a pen from the drawer?”

“Which one?” Phainon asked as he started opening them.

“I don’t remember.”

There were three drawers on the desk, all shallow, meant for office supplies. The first drawer was mostly empty aside from some sticks of sealing wax and a seal with the symbol of Strife on it. The second drawer was full of blank stationery. Phainon ran his hand along the back in case the pen and ink had rolled. No luck but the stationery wasn’t laying flat. He lifted the stack to check underneath and froze in place.

Hiding underneath was a folded letter with a broken seal in gold wax. He recognized Aglaea’s emblem immediately. Why did Mydei have a letter from Aglaea?

Phainon felt sick. His stomach had started twisting in loops. He felt dizzy. He didn’t even know what it said, and he already felt like he was going to throw up.

“Phainon? Pen?” Leonnius asked.

“…yeah, right.”

Phainon covered the letter and closed the drawer to fetch the pen from the third. The drawer slid open with a soft squeak and closed with the same sound. He handed Leonnius the pen

and tried to focus on the good news as the Kremnoan finished drawing in the line.

“It’s not much, but it’s some,” he said with a grin.

Phainon gave him a strained smile. “I’m glad.”

Leonnius punched him in the shoulder. “Be more excited! You were *right*! With the right battles and enough people, the Black Tide *can be pushed back*!”

“I am excited! I’m just tired,” Phainon admitted, “but we should tell the others for sure.”

“Mydei especially will want to know,” Leonnius agreed, “you said they’re at the bathhouse?”

“Yeah.”

“Let’s go tell them!”

Phainon waved him off. “I’ll never be able to keep up with you, go on ahead.”

Leonnius squinted at him, but excitement won in the end and the Kremnoan was zipping out the door before Phainon could change his mind.

Phainon waited until the footsteps faded into the dusk and then the good news morphed again into dread. He took several deep breaths that didn’t work and reached for the drawer again, pausing when his fingertips brushed the knob.

Whatever was in that letter was probably what Mydei wanted to talk about the other day. Where did he even get it? Was it addressed to Mydei himself? Did Aglaea *know* what was going on this far from the Dawn Device? Why didn’t he share it with Phainon?

Phainon pulled the letter out and put it on the desk. He shakily ran a finger over the seal and then stopped without unfolding it. Breathing was hard. Every inhale felt like someone was sitting on his chest. It felt like he was sinking, spiraling out of control.

No, he trusted Mydei. If this was important, Mydei would have told him about it. He still might. Phainon didn’t know anything about this letter. Speculating would make things worse.

He left the letter there and stepped away from it, walking backwards like it might attack him until he felt the edge of the kline against his legs. Phainon sat down, bowed his head, put one hand on his chest, and just focused on breathing for now.

-

The Kremnoans were in fantastic spirits when they got back to the house, clean, refreshed, and ecstatic. It reminded Mydei of stories of the energy to be had at massive victory feasts of wartime. His boys were tackling each other, punching each other, shouting to everyone that they saw on the street that there was once again hope.

Hope that the Deliverer had brought to them.

Mydei grinned at the thought. Surely the man was losing his mind, happy to be living up to his title, but the house was eerily quiet and Phainon did not get up to greet them. When they came around the corner and saw him on the kline, Mydei's first thought was that Phainon might be catching ill, and then he saw those blues look up at him above a frown, exhausted and guarded. It was the same expression that Phainon had when he had been made to kneel on the deck while men argued about his fate.

Then he saw the letter on the desk.

"Everyone out," Mydei said firmly, and the partying stopped.

"Wait, what?" Hephaestion asked.

Perdikkas was looking between Mydei and Phainon with concern.

Leonnius whined, "I just brought you the best news in five years and you-"

"Now."

Hephaestion threw Leonnius over his shoulder and grabbed Ptolemy's arm, pulling him along and ushering the others away to leave Mydei and Phainon alone. The protests carried down the hallway until the front door slammed closed and then it was quiet again.

"Did you read it?" Mydei asked softly.

"No."

His brow furrowed. "Why not?"

"Were you going to tell me?" Phainon asked instead.

They watched each other for a long breath and then Mydei walked to the desk. He picked up the letter and brought it to Phainon, standing over him and offering it. "Yes. I needed to know how I felt first."

Phainon took it and Mydei could see the nervous tremor in his hands. "And? How do you feel about it?"

Mydei took a deep breath through his nose and then sat down next to Phainon on the kline. "That it doesn't matter how I feel. It isn't about me."

Phainon gave him a puzzled look and then anxiously opened the letter to read it. He kept quiet, reading every line several times before he folded it back up and held the damned thing out to Mydei again. He slouched forward, resting his weight on his elbows on his knees, looking down, his face hidden by his hair.

He wanted to say something, to comfort Phainon, but he wasn't sure what he *could* say as he took the paper and set it on the kline between them.

“I’m sorry, Mydei,” Phainon said carefully. It was so quiet, as though speaking any louder might shatter him. “I must retract my challenge to you.”

Mydei’s heart hurt listening to him. Phainon was starting to shake. He covered his face with his hands to hide his soft sobs.

“Deliv- Phainon,” Mydei offered gently, “I wanted-I wanted to extend this invitation to you under better circumstances…”

Was this really the best time? To ask Phainon to join the crew? When he was hurting, reeling from the loss of his homeland, something that Mydei understood all too well? Was it even something that Phainon wanted?

“Would you like to be left alone?” he asked instead.

Phainon was curling in on himself, wrapping his arms tightly around his knees and hiding his face in them to cry.

Mydei extended his hand to touch him but stopped just above his back. It just… didn’t seem right. “Will you promise me that you will still be here in the morning?” he asked.

Phainon nodded without looking up and Mydei respected his privacy and let him be to process his changed reality.

-

Phainon wasn’t sure when he fell asleep, but he woke with tears dried on his lashes and sunlight on his face. He still felt sick and utterly, horribly betrayed.

To read those words in Aglaea’s handwriting…

The letter was scrunched up in his hand, not that he needed it anymore, those words were stitched into the fabric his soul. He sat up, head heavy, and took a couple deep breaths. There was still so much pain, but he started pushing it down as he always had.

There is no room for sulking on my ship.

And, hey, Phainon had wanted fate to intervene to make the decision for him. What was this but fate? Had he not wanted to be of use? To be in the best possible spot to do the most good? Surely this was still okay? Even-Even if he wasn’t their Deliverer anymore, that title had always felt like too much for someone like him. Somehow in all this pain there was a sense of freedom too. Those high expectations were gone, and he could focus on saving the people who needed him most.

So why did Phainon still feel like his heart had been ripped from his chest?

He sighed and got to his feet. None of the others were within eyeshot. The house felt quiet, thoughtful. Phainon wiped his face with his sleeve and wandered the house to find them.

All six of his Kremnoan family were sitting in the dining room that they rarely used, sat around a big table made for too many people. Even Fig Stew was sitting at the head of the table, watching the Okheman with bright eyes. They looked at Phainon expectantly when they noticed him, and Leonnius sprang up to pull out a chair for him.

“Please,” he whispered when Phainon hesitated and he slowly sat down.

“Mydei told us about the letter,” Hephaestion started, “and we talked about it.”

“You guys don’t have to-“ Phainon started but Mydei held up his hand and shook his head.

“We talked it through and even if you do not accept, we consider you a part of the crew,” Mydei said, “and we look out for our own. One’s home is important, and we want you to be able to return to yours.”

“That’s not possib-“

Again, Phainon was cut off. This time by Ptolemy, “I looked it up. We are going to buy you a pardon.”

Phainon felt dumbfounded by the idea. There was nothing that the Council of Elders, that Aglaea, would accept in exchange for something so valuable except-

“We decided we’re going to Castrum Kremnos,” Hephaestion told him.

“When we send you back to Okhema,” Mydei said with a wild look in his eye and a reassuring smile, “it will be with the Coreflame of Strife in your hands.”

Chapter End Notes

Just so you guys know. My original outline planned for 19 chapters. The events of THIS chapter were originally the end of Chapter 5.
Two things we learn from this:
1. I grossly underestimated my ability to yap.
2. This is going to be a long fic. I am so, so sorry.

Chapter 17: Heading Home

Chapter Summary

New Character Tag: Cipher

Chapter Notes

Should I put gambling in the tags? With all these silly boys making bets I'm wondering if I should xD

See the end of the chapter for more notes

This was a dream. It had to be. Phainon genuinely could not think of another explanation for what he was hearing. The Coreflame of Strife aside, they were just… adopting him? On the spot? And what was this about a pardon? Did Okhema even give those?

Phainon reached up with one hand to rub his temple. The room was quiet while he processed. The other men ranged from nervous to resolute, even Mydei looked anxious at the silence.

Mydei who was so much more expressive than people realized. Who wore his feelings just underneath that thin, guarded layer, so that people who loved him enough to look could read him as easily as he seemed to do for others. Phainon could see that worry in the curve of his brow, the way he was second guessing his announcement in the twitch of his eye, the way he was watching Phainon, unblinking like a wild animal that he desperately wanted to befriend.

This was a lot to process on top of everything he had learned last night. Phainon's whole world had flipped upside down with a single crumpled page and now these people were jumping to try and fix it for him. It felt so surreal.

"Phainon?" Perdikkas tried. The doctor was looking at Phainon with a soft, reassuring smile. "Maybe we should have waited until you were more awake."

"No… no this is okay. It's just a lot," Phainon admitted.

"We think the soldiers from the fort must have reported what they saw," Hephaestion theorized, "when you defended us and stayed behind, they didn't know you were with us against your will."

That made sense. It hurt, but it made sense. Phainon hadn't thought to send a message with his countrymen. In retrospect, that seemed like a silly oversight. Why didn't he send a

message the second time either? All that planning and he was so focused on making sure everyone was safe, Phainon didn't once consider what it looked like to see him, their hero, helping pirates.

"I did some digging through the library," Ptolemy said, taking the floor. His eyes were a little too wide and dark, like he had yet to sleep. "And there is historical precedent for pardons as decided by the Goldweaver and the Council of Elders. Usually because of some heroic deed or a big donation. Bribe," he coughed into his hand and mumbled around that last word, "We don't have any treasure we can send with you, but it would be hard to say no to one of her missing coreflames and slaying a Titan is a heroic feat."

Phainon shook his head, "Fighting a Titan is… and Castrum Kremnos is in the middle of the Black Tide."

"Yes, but we proved your theory which means it's *possible*," Hephaestion reminded him.

"Taking back Castrum Kremnos would be a major victory in the war against the Tide," Mydei pointed out, "it would be forced to retreat farther than it has since the time of Eurypon."

"There's also a chance that the Tide has corrupted the Titan," Perdikkas theorized, "maybe even as far back as when Eurypon first returned from the North. Imagine how deep of a blow that would be to fell such a major piece."

Phainon shook his head. "It's so dangerous, that's too much effort to go through for me."

"We'd be doing it for all of us," Leonnius insisted.

"Deliverer," Mydei called and Phainon flinched at the name, "what do *you* want?"

The room was quiet as Phainon bowed his head to think. The wood grain on the table was lovely.

"…I don't know," he admitted, "I think I just want to help everyone, however I can."

"Well, we want you to have the option to go home," Perdikkas announced. The others nodded. "So you get to help us, help you."

"Not to be the messenger of bad news but since that is my job, how the hell *are* we supposed to get the coreflame?" Leonnius asked, "Castrum Kremnos isn't a small town on an island."

"No *human* navy has ever been able to lay siege to Castrum Kremnos," Hephaestion mused.

"Even if we got every single remaining Kremnoan to go with us, there's no way we could clear the city. That deep in the Black Tide, we couldn't even step off the ship," Leonnius reminded them.

"Pushing back the Tide is working," Perdikkas suggested, "we just keep pushing it back until we get home."

“We’d all be in our sixties by the time we get there,” Hephaestion groaned, “that’s not an option.”

“I will go alone,” Mydei offered.

“No,” Phainon said too quickly, “I can’t ask you to do that.”

“Deliverer, this is happening,” the prince snapped, “do not reject our efforts to care for you, lest you offend us.”

“I’ll go with you.” There was a long silence before Phainon continued, “we both have golden blood, and we are both admirable warriors and… you shouldn’t have to face a Titan alone.”

“Assuming you *get* that far,” Leonnius bummed them all out once more, “population turned monsters aside, Nikador’s Titankin fill the inner city. Two people cannot do it alone, gold blood or not. I’m just saying, are we *sure* a strongly worded endorsement from the Crown Prince explaining that Phainon isn’t a pirate won’t work?”

“I’m sure the Goldweaver would *love* that,” Ptolemy mocked, “Don’t worry Miss Goldweaver, we promise he’s still a good person, you can trust the *Kremnoan pirates*.”

Phainon still felt heavy, grief still lingered, but the little ray of hope that they were trying to give him was thawing the ice in his veins. That they were here and even *trying* spoke volumes. Mydei was willing to go *alone* for Phainon.

How could he even begin to be worthy of such a gesture? Even his own people rejected their Deliverer. What could he hope to be for these people?

“You know, you never actually asked,” Phainon realized out loud, and the room quieted to look at him. Peucesta wasn’t even playing the lyre, they were so focused on him.

Phainon looked up at Mydei specifically, “you never actually asked me if I wanted to join your crew.”

Mydei’s eyes widened by a fraction and then he looked down and away. His hand was on Fig Stew’s belly, scratching with new purpose now to distract himself while the chimera purred loud enough to feel through the table. The others were doing some variation of the same, avoiding eye contact. Peucesta’s lyre plucked nervously, switching to a minor key while Leonnius picked at his chiton. Hephaestion crossed his arms and drummed his fingers, Perdikkas was trying to sink in his chair, and Ptolemy was suddenly very into artwork, studying the painting across the room from himself.

“Were you afraid I would say no?” Phainon asked.

“Would you have?” Mydei asked.

“No.”

The relief in the room was instant. Everyone was trying to hide their smiles. Ptolemy whispered something under his breath in Kremnoan that was too obscure for Phainon to

recognize. Leonnius leaned back in his chair with both his hands behind his head.

“It hurts,” Phainon admitted, “knowing that I can’t go home. It’s not even the first time this has happened, but I woke up already accepting it. The last time I lost everything it took too long for me to find myself; it took Aglaea to make me a *person* again and I owe her my life for that. It would dishonor her for me to step backwards into that shell that I once was. But-“ he started to cry again. The tears beaded in the corners of his eyes, threatening to spill over as he held his chest, twisting his fingers in the fabric of his shirt as though he could claw out his own aching heart. “-I didn’t expect to feel like I was already home *here*. I don’t want people to sacrifice themselves for me, trying to restore something that I don’t-that I don’t need anymore.”

Tears weren’t a foreign concept to Kremnoans but emotional vulnerability like that was close. No one moved or said anything except for Leonnius who flailed a little awkwardly trying to decide what to do with his hands. What could they possibly say? Call him a bad name, punch his shoulder, and scold him? That did seem to be the popular Kremnoan response but they kept their silence this time in silent processing.

It was Fig Stew who decided to take charge. The chimera got up, grabbed Mydei’s finger gently in his teeth, and pulled until the prince had to stand up as he was dragged around the table, awkwardly climbing over other Kremnoans on his way to Phainon. Fig put his front paws on Phainon’s bicep so he could reach up and place Mydei’s hand right on top of that ahoge.

Both men shared the same alarmed expression, frozen. They didn’t know what to do until Fig Stew sat in front of Phainon on the table and put his paw on his own head to teach them the proper comforting etiquette here. Unwilling to argue with the chimera, Mydei relented and Phainon felt the tears spill over as that warm hand gently pet his head, eventually getting bold enough to run his fingers deeper through snowy hair, to massage gently at his scalp with comforting presses.

Mydei eased into it, half leaning, half sitting against the table so he wouldn’t be hiding in the Okheman’s blind spot while he provided that physical comfort. Fig Stew scooted forward and leaned in close to lick those shed tears from Phainon’s face with a rough tongue until Phainon’s hands gently wrapped around the animal to hug him. He melted into that touch, relaxing with half-lidded eyes into Fig’s fur.

It bought enough time for Hephaestion to find his words. “Phainon, our home was taken from us too. We *chose* to leave, but it was only easy to do so because that choice to return was still there. Even when we swore ourselves to self-exile and thought that door was closed, we didn’t understand the true loss until that choice was completely *gone.”* He drummed his fingers on the table and then crossed his arms. “We want you to stay, I think every single one of us wants that and we had planned to ask, we just wanted to invite you join us when you *could* make that choice for yourself. So no, none of us are asking yet, not officially, not until you get the chance you deserve. We want to take this risk for you *and* for us. So put that crazy optimistic brain of yours to work and help us figure out how to do the impossible.”

The hand in his hair didn’t let up until Phainon pulled away from Fig Stew to look up at Mydei. The Prince was looking down with wide eyes, curious, concerned, and a little bit

afraid. He pulled his hand back when it looked like Phainon was feeling a little better and let out a breath through his nose. Pink had crept into his cheeks and chest and Phainon felt the heat rush to his own cheeks and ears at the closeness.

Rather than go back to his own seat, Mydei took the empty chair on the other side of Phainon, settling with a soft *hrumph* and crossed arms. Fig Stew stayed where he was, loafing comfortably with his eyes closed and Phainon's hand resting on his back to give scritches between his shoulder blades.

A way to do the impossible… The biggest hurdle wasn't Nikador. It was the Black Tide corruption. Leonnius was right, the biggest navy in the world wouldn't be able to take Castrum Kremnos because it was entirely under the black. The only people that could safely get through *that* would be Chrysos Heirs. Phainon had a lot of faith in himself and Mydei. The Kremnoan was even immortal which could only work in their favor, but two of them against an entire city? Even if they tried to sneak in, they would need someone skilled in stealth or someone who could pacify any hoards that they couldn't handle themselves… people like…

"I have an idea," Phainon said.

Peucesta held his hand out across the table and Ptolemy angrily slapped a pair of coins into his open palm.

"But I don't think you guys are going to like it."

Peucesta slowly slid one of the two coins back towards Ptolemy.

"I'm not worried about being outnumbered," Phainon admitted, "you guys are experienced Kremnoans after all. I've studied Kremnos fighting styles and I've seen Krateros with the crew. The crew could handle Titankin and monsters in any number given the right strategy and positioning."

"Black Tide," Leonnius coughed into his fist.

"Yeah, we need more Chrysos Heirs."

Ptolemy laughed, "sure! We'll just go to the market and pick up a few, Phainon be serious."

"Our options are recruit Chrysos Heirs and go after Nikador with a small strike team," Phainon said, "or we recruit a big enough Navy to push back the tideline. The *only* navy left in Amphoreus big enough to do that is the Okheman Fleet."

"Either way, Okhema is involved," Perdikkas lamented, "the only known Chrysos Heirs are under the Goldweaver's care. She'd have our prince too if she had her way."

"This is good news," Phainon proclaimed. His cheer was coming back. He still ached, it would take time for that to go away completely, but having a purpose was helping. Having a purpose that helped the people he cared about was helping a lot. Mydei's leg was pressed

against Phainon's under the table, anchoring him, giving him courage and comfort. Difficult didn't mean impossible, and that was Phainon's favorite kind of challenge.

He pressed back against Mydei and said, "I *know* all the Okheman Chrysos Heirs they're still family. Given the chance, I could convince them to help."

"Convince them to team up with Kremnoan pirates? While you have an active warrant for your arrest?" Ptolemy was still skeptical.

"Castorice and Hyacine would help for sure. Cipher can be paid off."

"Paid off with *what?*" Lack of sleep was catching up to Ptolemy for sure the way his voice rasped and his eloquence fled.

"The treasury at Castrum Kremnos is untouched," Mydei thought aloud, "this Cipher would be welcome to it if they offered their services."

"But can we trust them? Wouldn't they have the same oath to the Goldweaver that you have, Phainon?" Hephaestion asked.

"That's why they'll agree," Phainon argued. Fig Stew gave a warning growl when his excitement led to a particularly rough squeeze. He apologetically patted the chimera. "Because we're going after a coreflame."

"Why can't we ask the Goldweaver directly then?" Leonnius asked, "the whole goal is to buy Phainon's pardon with the coreflame, so why not just tell her that and get her help first?"

"We'd be arrested before we even get the chance," sighed Perdikkas, "and intention, actionable or not, isn't the same as having the coreflame in hand ready to trade."

"Even with her golden threads that know every truth," Pecuesta agreed, finally weighing in, "she is no Queen."

"Even if Aglaea-" Phainon cut himself off thinking about her. The woman that he trusted, the woman that was demanding his arrest in the first place, who first called him Deliverer now considered him a pirate. "-um, even if Aglaea supported our mission, she would have to arrest us and take us to the Council. She can't know what we're doing."

"You don't think the other Heirs would tell her?" Perdikkas asked.

"I don't and we need them. Castorice is the Demigod of Death, just her presence makes Black Tide monsters and Titankin sluggish, she's a one-person army, and Hyacine is a healer. When I left, she was researching the Black Tide corruption and how to resist or even reverse it. She could be the key to letting all of you fight beside us without golden blood."

Hephaestion uncrossed his arms to point at Phainon, wagging that finger up and down. "*That* would be worth it. Even if we couldn't help you fell the Titan, we could keep the city busy if we didn't need to fear the corruption."

“*Listen* to yourselves for a moment,” Ptolemy whined. Bro needed to go to *bed.* “We would have to *go to Okhema*, sneak into the holy city, find these Chrysos Heirs, convince them to join our *Kremnoan pirate crew*, take them to Castrum Kremnos, our *homeland* that is *drowning* in Black Tide creatures and *our own fallen Titankin army,* so that we can sneak our Crown Prince and our former prisoner of war to the arena where they are going to fight and kill our *god* so we can then go *back* to Okhema to buy a pardon so Phainon can just have the *option* to go home? An option that we all want him to reject? Because we think it will make him feel better?”

“Yes.”

“Yep.”

“*Mrreow!”*

A single happy twang from a lyre.

“Absolutely.”

“Correct.”

Phainon shyly resumed petting Fig Stew.

They made it sound like Phainon’s feelings; his autonomy was the most important part of this scheme. It was humbling. It wasn’t like that was the *only* reason why they were braving such a feat. As they had pointed out, defeating Nikador could potentially push the Black Tide farther back than it had been in six years. Reclaiming Castrum Kremnos was not only an emotional and symbolic action, but a strategic one as well. If they did their job well enough, maybe Mydei’s people could also go home.

It wasn’t just Phainon’s choice that was the prize here. Everyone could win and the Coreflame of Strife was the ultimate bargaining chip not just for Phainon’s pardon, but for peace. It was a gift in good faith that could demand a place at the table, an audience with the Council and Aglaea, to officially end the war between their peoples. While they planned to press that coreflame into Phainon’s hands, Phainon was plotting on his own, to hand it to Mydei, to personally escort him to Aglaea, not as a pirate to be imprisoned, but as the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos, representative of his people. That coreflame would pardon them all and usher in a new era of collaboration against the Tide.

Ptolemy pressed his hands together like he was praying, both elbows stretched across the table as he leaned over it. He breathed in sharply through his nose and pressed his hands to his lips before letting it all out in a long exhale. With a voice bordering on unhinged ferality he asked, “What are we waiting for?”

-

Mydei didn’t realize how much he enjoyed nighttime until there was no longer any nighttime. Honestly, only Phainon seemed unbothered by the unchanging sky under the influence of the Dawn Device. He was the only one on the whole ship that was able to sleep comfortably after

the bright thief star would dash across the blue to announce the curtain-fall hour. The man saw the star, yawned, wished everyone good night and crashed, just like that.

How the hell did he do that?

Even Fig Stew was having a hard time getting comfortable. He constantly protested by making laps around Mydei's hammock, leaving little scratches on his chest and belly in the process. Every time the chimera started to settle, he'd growl, mewl, and reposition, which might've woken Mydei up if he hadn't already been awake the whole damn time because of that sunlight directly on his eyelids.

Inheriting the wealth of a nation via royal birth had *nothing* on the riches a *curtain* salesman must have from peddling his wares in Okhema. This was horrible and everyone was feeling it.

By day three, Mydei found members of the crew cannibalizing old clothes to make blindfolds for sleeping and nailing scrap sail canvas to the windows and portholes. Everyone had matching bags under their eyes. Hephaestion had passed out in the galley at one point, narrowly avoiding wearing his meal. Ptolemy was found willingly buried from the waist up in the library, finally sleeping in the shade of many suspiciously stacked books. Mydei knew they were in trouble when Krateros nodded off at the tiller and had to catch himself with the most frayed and head empty expression he had ever seen.

And all the while, the crew dog was as cheerful as ever.

Phainon was covering *all* the sleepy slack by himself. The lunatic was up early, rushing to help deliver breakfast, work the lines, clean the deck, cook dinner, even offering to cover other tasks so folks could take longer breaks. He never stopped moving and he never stopped smiling.

Mydei could tell he was suffering. He could hear it at 'night' when Phainon slept. Those tearless sobs and broken whines kept soft, even in sleep not wanting to disturb anyone that may hear him and be bothered by the noise. He was no stranger to nightmares himself so, sometimes, Mydei would get up and pet him to soothe those troubled thoughts, running his fingers through Phainon's hair as Fig Stew had suggested and it would ease his sleep. Phainon was so responsive to gentle touches, just subtle reminders that he wasn't alone.

And it wasn't like Mydei was sleeping anyway with that fucking light turned on all the fucking time. Surely the Dawn Device had a lever or a wheel that could switch the thing off for a few hours?

Even when Phainon was awake and bouncing between people, chattering about how beautiful Okhema was and how you could see Kephale from so far away, and all those other fun facts that he had ready to go at the drop of a hat, there was misery there. Mydei could see it. Maybe it was because he was looking for it, but he could feel it most when they sparred. That pain was buried deep in the way Phainon's banter felt flat and his swings were stiff. When Mydei's claws cut a little too close and he didn't take advantage of a stumble, the prince knew for sure. For all his outward excitement, Phainon was still trying to cope with the changes.

The closer they got to Okhema the more Mydei worried how Phainon would react. It couldn't be easy to face this wound so soon after the knife had cut and twisted, but he seemed calm and focused when they finally weighed anchor in a sheltered cove a short walk from the holy city.

The bow was covered with the black sheet, and they took down their Kremnoan flag, choosing to fly no colors at all rather than go all in on the pirate costume that would give them away. They were far enough away to buy themselves time before discovery, out of immediate eyeshot and hopefully away from all but the most thorough of patrols.

Phainon had insisted that years of relative peace had made Okhema lazy and lax. This close to the city they were unlikely to find anyone particularly attentive as long as they didn't draw attention to themselves. Which meant everyone, even around the deck, was dressed as plainly as possible. No visible armor, no obvious weapons, if anyone asked, they were a merchant ship waiting for orders from their captain and they would not allow any inspections until said captain returned from the market.

Mydei thought Phainon looked cute in disguise, standing by the railing, excitedly searching for the best path to get to the road once they made it ashore. Even with the hood of the heavy cloak pulled up his white bangs and brilliant blue eyes still showed brightly. He was a man meant for the spotlight, even hiding under rough dark linen.

"You cannot all go," Mydei huffed. He and Phainon were matching looks standing there, waiting for the longboat. Mydei wasn't comfortable going without his gauntlets and familiar wear, so he also slapped the cloak on top and called it a day, the same way Phainon was hiding his own armor.

The exact same cloaks that all five of his fellow Kremnoans were wearing as they fanned around him expectantly.

"What happens if you need back up?" Hephaestion asked and Mydei pointed right at him.

"*You* must stay because if Krateros is left in charge he will have declared war by morning."

"Aw, sorry Hephaestion," Leonnius said, "we'll bring you back something from the market." The other four shuffled forward and Mydei had to hold his hands out, spread wide to stop them.

"No. Only two of you may come with us," he huffed, "a large group will be harder to hide."

"Obviously I need to go in case one of them gets hurt," Perdikkas argued.

"Don't even start, you're too slow," Leonnius huffed.

Peucesta raised his lyre, itchy to argue with music but realized very quickly that the instrument likely would not help his case. He tucked it back under his cloak and tried creeping past Mydei instead, but Ptolemy yanked him back.

“We do this fairly, by chance,” he growled, and then Ptolemy was fishing around in his pockets. He pulled out a crumpled piece of paper, double checked that it wasn’t anything important and tore it into four strips that he then rolled into tight straws. Two of them he tore short and two he left long, then he mixed them together between his hands and hid their lengths behind his palm.

“Short stays, long goes, agreed?” he asked while offering just the tops of the straws to them. The other three nodded and all reached to grab one, snatching them up quickly and holding out the results.

Perdikkas grabbed a short slip, he would have to stay. He seemed more resigned than disappointed. It was hard to argue with chance after all.

Leonnius pulled long. He hissed a soft, “yessss” to celebrate and crumpled the paper in his fist.

Peucesta frowned and flicked the short slip back at Ptolemy. No field trip for the bard. His lyre twanged uselessly from under his cloak, muffled and pathetic at best.

But Ptolemy’s slip had been plucked from his hands at the same time as the others’. He stood there puzzled, trying to determine who had accidently grabbed two slips, stealing what he now knew was the second long slip.

“Oh my~ Does this mean I get tag a long?” purred a feminine voice. Standing beside them in the circle as relaxed as though she was meant to be there was a lean woman with a long tail. She waved the last slip of paper between them all, pinched between long nails painted gold. “That *is* what the long one means, right~?”

The ship erupted at once as Kremnoans fumbled to find weapons and turned on the woman on deck. Trying to stay under the radar left most of them with nothing bigger than a combat knife. Mydei reached to contain her on instinct, but Phainon dashed between them all, putting himself squarely in front of her with his hands held out wide and a shout on his lips.

“Must be my lucky day,” she crooned around a bouncy giggle, “a whole ship of wound springs and one missing puppy.”

“This is Cipher, she’s one of the Chrysos Heirs,” Phainon hurriedly told everyone, but the Kremnoans didn’t relax. Mydei rolled his fingers, trying to assess the threat.

Cipher was the Heir that Phainon had mentioned before. The one that could be paid to help them. She… wasn’t what he expected.

Cipher was dressed like a thief, wearing a hood that left space to cover her cat ears and a skintight body suit and thigh highs with just enough ribbons and flair to advertise the Goldweaver’s handiwork. She had gray hair that was barely long enough to extend past her hood and blue-green eyes that rivaled Phainon’s for clarity. Her tail was dark brown at the tip, fading into the gray of her fur that predictably matched the fur around her ears. It lazily swayed back and forth, held in an elegant curve to keep it from dragging across the deck. The tip of it kept twisting in tight curls like a question mark.

How in Nikador's name did she get on board?

"Geez, brat, if you're going to name drop at least do it with some pizzaz." Her voice had a permanent roll to it, like a purr under the playful lilt of her words. It made every word sound like a tease, like a piece of cheese dangling in front of a mouse, both tantalizing and suspicious.

"Try something like Cipher the *magnificent*, or Cipher, the greatest of all thieves~!" She held her hands out to the side and slowly turned to show off her curves. "Or there's the obvious, Cipher, the Demigod of Trickery!"

Nobody moved.

"Tough crowd, and after I won fair and square!" she purred as she waved the little strip of paper back and forth.

The tension was thick enough to cut with a knife and Cipher was swimming in it like a fish. She was the only one that didn't seem even slightly bothered to be at the pointy end of a nervous Kremnoan Detachment.

"I *really* hit the jackpot finding *you*, Deliverer boy," Cipher went on, ignoring the boring Kremnoans, even as they pushed in a little closer to try and corner her. Mydei could see Hephaestion trying to slowly shift towards the rail, watching the flank in case she tried to bolt. Ptolemy was trying to match him on the other side.

She put a hand on Phainon's shoulder and spun in a circle around his arm as though she were dancing to swoon and drop in front of him. He predictably hurried to catch her. "Seamstress has been looking *allll* over for you." The cat walked two fingers up his chest and booped his nose and Mydei instantly felt angry. "She misses her favorite."

"Miss Cipher-" Phainon started to say but Mydei cut him off.

The prince surged forward to grab her, but she saw him coming from the corner of her eye and sprang over Phainon, vaulting over his shoulders to hide behind her fellow Okheman. Mydei barely stopped himself from hitting his friend.

"Easy, gold-hair, I'm not here for you~"

"You can't be here for me either, Cipher," Phainon told her. He turned around and stepped back to be beside Mydei.

The prince fought not to show how much the action filled him with joy and pride. Having Phainon beside him felt right, no matter who they were facing, friend or foe, this was how it should be.

She blinked, genuinely surprised by his serious tone.

"Because we actually came here for you," he said with a grin, that playful tone was back.

Cipher tilted her head back and *laughed*, at least, it kind of sounded like a laugh. She *looked* like she was laughing but that sound was closer to the dying cackle of a starving animal.

“Color me intrigued, golden boy,” she purred again, “how about we put down the prickly pieces and you can try to convince me why I shouldn’t take you back to our favorite motherly control freak.”

Phainon turned in place to look at Mydei with a soft, begging look. Those eyes glittered in the light, imploring, trust me.’ And he did.

Mydei turned enough to raise his hand and slowly lowered it, signaling to the crew to put their weapons down. They reluctantly did so, everyone still watching this cat woman carefully.

“Because I know you, master of mischief,” Phainon said with a playful tilt of his head and lilt in his voice, “and you of all people wouldn’t want to miss out on this.”

Chapter End Notes

I have been so excited to play Cipher. I know she shows up in HSR when Phainon is already crashing out, but I like to believe that in a world where she is more around, that they have a good rapport.

Chapter 18: The Protective and Perceptive Nature of Big Sisters

Chapter Summary

New character tag: Castorice

Phainon is a good boy with a big destiny but he's still the family baby and Mydei's about to learn what love means to one of them

Chapter Notes

Now that we're 100k words in I can really get started on the plot! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“What’s your plan to sneak past the seamstress?” Cipher asked.

“She should be asleep,” Phainon said as he stepped off the longboat and onto soft sand.

“You really think she’s been able to sleep worrying so much about you?”

Getting Cipher to agree to their crazy plan was easy. Phainon knew that all he’d have to say was ‘treasure,’ ‘Kremnos,’ and ‘this might be crazy but…’ and the cat was in. He didn’t even have to give her all the details of his awkward imprisonment and the experiments he had been doing on the Black Tide with their city’s mortal enemies. She was shockingly chill with those last two words, not even blinking when he introduced Mydei to her.

Cipher was a complex person in that she kept enough secrets to maintain a layered persona. There was a depth to her that Phainon knew was there but had never personally uncovered. The light-hearted and jovial prankster that had stood by Aglaea’s side every second that he had known the two of them was the only version she had ever shared with Phainon. And that side was predictable and agreeable as long as one knew what buttons to push.

The only hiccup he had anticipated was Cipher’s closeness to Aglaea. Cipher was *old*. Not quite Aglaea old but old enough and traveled enough to have built an airtight relationship with the Goldweaver. Aglaea had taken them both in when they were young, finished raising them, and gave them purposes on her flame chase journey. It made Cipher like Phainon’s much older sister where Aglaea was like their aunt that stepped up to mother them when things went south.

Phainon thought that ‘behind Aglaea’s back’ would be the phrase that made her walk away, but Cipher had purred at the idea instead and readily agreed. She was even leading their small group of four down the path towards Okhema herself, with her hips swinging back and forth with every step like she hadn’t just cracked Phainon’s resolve in sing-song a quint prior.

Aglaea was worried about him? Enough to lose sleep?

It was crushing to consider, especially with her written words still bouncing around in his head. Yeah, Aglaea was so worried she *wants him arrested?* He had a hard time reconciling both statements. If Phainon had a child out there committing crimes he’d be worried too but the image of Aglaea worrying *at all* was the hard part to picture. She wasn’t very expressive. But if anyone would know how Aglaea was feeling, it would be Cipher, who could read hearts and intentions at a glance and who was very near and dear to their Admiral.

The only other Chrysos Heir that was close enough to Aglaea to know how she really felt about something was Tribbie and *hopefully* all three triplets were also asleep at this late hour. If one of the triplets caught them sneaking into the city, no one would be sleeping anymore.

“Cipher,” Phainon asked as they walked up a hill to join the dromas road, empty at this late hour, “has Aglaea not been sleeping?”

“That’s still bothering you?” she cackled, “afraid of getting caught? Even if she *is* asleep her threads are all over the city, you’d have to be a chimera to get past them.”

Phainon could feel the Kremnoans behind him tensing up. Sweat started to bead at Phainon’s brow, and he pulled the hood down a little lower over his eyes. That wasn’t why he had asked, but perhaps Cipher wasn’t the best person to talk to about his worries. Aglaea was strong, she didn’t need Phainon fussing over an off-handed comment from a known trickster.

“Is there no way to sneak into the city unseen?” he asked instead.

“Oh, there are *lots* of ways,” she crooned. Cipher leapt onto the top of the waist-high wall along the road to walk along that narrow edge. Even in her heels she had perfect balance.

“Even from Tribbie?” Phainon asked.

“Oh, the big sis trio aren’t even in the city.”

“What?”

She paused to look back at Phainon. Every time he stopped the Kremnoans did too, bunching in close behind him to peek over each other’s shoulders in a line.

“All three of them have been flying allll over Amphoreus looking for your silly ass. They’ll owe me big for finding you first.”

Phainon’s heart twisted. Even the triplets were looking for him? He should have tried to send a message to them sooner, to reassure them. Maybe he could find a chance to write a letter while they were here, to try and *start* explaining things.

They started walking again.

“Not to be the voice of reason when Ptolemy is here,” Leonnius said from the end of the line, “but how *are* we getting into the city around the threads?”

“We can destroy them as we go,” Mydei suggested, “as we do at sea.”

“No news is still news,” Ptolemy sighed, “she will notice their absence will she not?”

“Phainon, how did you plan on getting around them in the first place?” asked Leonnius.

“Um…”

Cipher lost it, she was barely able to breathe, she was wheezing so hard. Disproportionately hard. No one else was laughing. “You *weren’t,* were you?”

“Deliverer.” Mydei grabbed Phainon’s shoulder, hard enough to stop him from walking, to make him turn to see the truth of it in his eyes.

Phainon held both his hands up in a gesture of surrender. With the hood pushing his bangs so much farther down his face, any reassuring smiles were coming out awkward and unconvincing. “I don’t think it’s possible to get around them entirely,” he admitted, “but if we move fast enough-“

“And what if the Goldweaver is awake?” Ptolemy asked, “we should go back to the ship for now, make a new plan.”

“We don’t have time for that,” Leonnius pointed out, “not that we’d even be able to tell with the sky barely changing.”

“Leonnius is right,” Mydei agreed, “Okheman patrols will find the Chryseus Leo before we have time to formulate an effective plan with the time to execute it. We must determine a route now.”

It felt really bad knowing he had put them in a tricky situation. Phainon could hear the trepidation in Mydei’s voice. It was so, so subtle, but it was there. This was Phainon’s home, surely, he could think of something?

“How badly do you want that silly piece of candy buried deep in Castrum Kremnos?” Cipher crooned. She stepped off the wall to sit on it instead, swinging her leg up in a wide arc to cross her knees, both of her paws resting over them in a misleadingly demure posture.

“The what?” Leonnius asked.

“She’s talking about the coreflame,” Ptolemy hissed.

Phainon immediately thought of the crew and the people of Castrum Kremnos, of peace within reach. He stepped towards her to answer but she yawned loudly and held her hand up.

“I already heard your pitch back at the deck, Deliverer brat. I wanna hear from mister royal lion here.”

Phainon stepped back to look at Mydei. Shining amber eyes were narrowed at Cipher from under his hood, but he answered, “I have already promised you the treasury of Kremnos. Is that not enough?”

She got up and sauntered up to him. “He must not have told you very much about me and my *bottomless* greed.” Cipher stretched, catlike, both of her arms outstretched to reach past Mydei’s shoulders before she relaxed, letting her forearms fall on either side of his neck to smoothly pull in closer to him. “I want the truth too.”

“I would pay as many of my lives as it takes to retrieve that coreflame,” Mydei said firmly. He made no move to push her away. Even when she ran a hand down his chest and shifted her weight against him, he was stoic, controlled, and unintimidated.

Phainon instantly was annoyed and his smile faltered. Her eyes darted in his direction, and their gazes met for half a second. That’s when she pushed herself away, keeping a hair’s width between herself and Mydei so she could still judge the Kremnoan up close.

“That’s a lofty price for something you’re just giving away.”

“It’s worth it. I want my crew to be happy.”

Cipher must have seen something surprising because the smile faded for a few seconds before she stepped away with a knowing cackle. “That’s gross. I’ll help you get in, buy you time, I’ll even keep the Goldweaver busy until your horribly disguised ship can get underway. But if anyone ever asks-” she chuckled, “I’m the one who found you first.”

And then she disappeared.

-

Mydei’s opinion of Cipher kept bouncing back and forth. He didn’t particularly care if she was overly friendly, she wasn’t *really* threatening, and Phainon seemed to like her. But she was snarky, sneaky, and her teasing felt like it was teetering on the edge of being malicious. She hadn’t *done* anything aside from randomly appear in the first place so it would be unfair to draw any lines, but he didn’t care all that much when Cipher vanished.

His gut reaction was*, good riddance*, until Mydei counted their posse a man short. Phainon was missing now too.

All three Kremnoans went wide-eyed, looking at the spot where he had been a moment ago. Nothing was left of him aside from a pair of footprints in the dust.

“What just happened?” Leonnius asked, breathy and tense.

“That’s a fantastic question~!” Cipher purred from behind him, “let’s find out together!”

Before Mydei could throw crystals in her direction, his fastest runner vanished at the same time as Cipher, once again leaving behind only footprints and a deepening sense of unease.

“Ptolemy.”

They immediately took up positions, back-to-back, the scholar holding his combat knife, blade twisted backwards, to rest along his forearm. Mydei let his gauntlets click as he rolled his fingers.

“She must be *taking* them somehow,” the scholar theorized, swapping to Kremnoan for some privacy.

“Well, I’m not *evaporating them*,” she crooned from where she was sitting on the wall, speaking in a perfect, albeit very old, dialect of Kremnoan. “That sounds like effort.”

Hearing those words from her mouth stalled both men long enough for her to dash to Ptolemy’s side and then he was gone too, leaving Mydei alone at the edge of the road. He lowered his hood so it would be easier to hear and crouched, just a tiny bend in his knees, arms outstretched like a coiled spring, a lion ready to pounce. Mydei closed his eyes and waited.

It was so soft, the gentle crunch of gravel underfoot as the cat reappeared. His crystals erupted from the ground, narrowly missing as he swiped at her.

Cipher squealed like a startled chimera and leaped backwards in a perfect back handspring over the wall to hide behind it.

“Good grief,” she whined, speaking Okheman again, “you know if you kill me, I can’t take you to your friends.”

She was right. He slowly lowered his hands and stood up straight, watching her tail swishing back and forth over the wall until she finally poked her head out, ears twitching and twisting.

“Where did you take them?” he demanded in a level voice.

“Relax, I took them past the guards to the Marmoreal Palace. You were never going to make it without my help.”

Mydei’s eyes narrowed at her.

“This is where you say, thank you, Cipher the Great.”

He did not say that. “Take me to them and I will.”

“Maybe in a minute.” Cipher vaulted back over the wall and stretched her arms up over her head with a soft mewl. “This is probably the last chance we’ll get to talk just the two of us for a while and I have to do my due diligence.”

“You already agreed to help.”

“And I already am! Have faith little gold lion,” she purred. Her arms fell back to her sides with a slap and then she entwined her fingers behind her back while she paced around him, wisely keeping just barely out of reach. He crossed his arms, refusing to dance with her.

“That Deliverer brat is like a younger brother to me,” she explained, “even if he never developed the right sense of humor, I still care about him.” Pacing turned into stretching after she made a full loop around Mydei, everything she did felt like it was meant to draw the eye, to distract. “He also was quick to skip over details back on your boat.”

“Ship.”

She laughed and waved her hand dismissively. “’We’re going to Castrum Kremnos to get the coreflame!’” Cipher purred in a creepily accurate impression, sounding *exactly* like Phainon, “’there’s treasure there if you help us!’ I get why *he* wants the damned thing, the man is too goody goody for his own sake, desperate to fulfil that ridiculous vow to Aglaea, but why *is the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos* helping him?” She leaned against the wall and started rolling a gold coin between her fingers. Mydei had no idea where or when she got it, it was just there, and for some reason it felt… threatening.

“I told you-“

“Yeah, yeah, you want your crew to be happy,” she repeated, “but that brat isn’t on your crew.”

The way she was looking at him… This was a test. Mydei held her gaze a little too hard, searching for the right words but she read his silence.

“Zagreus’ purple balls, you stole my puppy,” she hissed, “you really did make him a pirate.”

Mydei’s frown deepened, and he hissed back, “No. Aglaea did. And he belongs to no one. You would do well to not speak of him as though he is a pet to be collared.”

He expected Cipher to react poorly but to his surprise she smiled and sighed, “Fine fine. I don’t believe for a second that he woke up one day and simply stopped being himself. You were keeping him against his will, right?”

Mydei shuffled. “It’s complicated.”

“And the coreflame will fix it?”

“It’s a start.”

The coin in her hand disappeared and she walked up close to Mydei again. He resisted the urge to reach out to grab her, to demand she take him to his friends. They were wasting time with this useless interrogation.

“And what’s stopping you from keeping that coreflame? It belongs to Strife, your god, you could finish Okhema with that power.”

“I have no interest in continuing our war with Okhema.”

“Easy to say *now*,” she crooned, “before you know what it *feels* like to have that power in your chest. You haven’t felt that *heat* that *pressure* deep inside your ribcage like a part of you that you never realized was missing.” Her voice was almost manic as she described it from personal experience, losing herself in the moment at the memory with wheezing breaths before she found her composure again. “The brat is so easy to use too, he’d do *anything* to make the people around him happy.”

Mydei’s eye twitched. He so badly wanted to grab her by the neck and shake her out for even implying that he could *use* Phainon like that.

“So long as he is on my ship, Phainon is a part of my crew,” Mydei said. He over enunciated every word, emphasizing how he felt with a low voice. “Nothing good will come of that coreflame except for the value it has to the Goldweaver. Value enough to buy that Deliverer’s pardon so that he can come home… where he belongs.”

Cipher’s eyes were darting back and forth like she was literally reading text behind Mydei’s eyes, delving into his soul and dancing there with emotions Mydei wasn’t even sure he understood. She was gleaning meaning from his tone; from the way he paused when he spoke of Phainon’s home. Her tail flicked twice and then the tip of it curled tightly when she mewled her way into a rolling laugh.

“Oh, I see, you love him,” she observed and Mydei deflated like a popped balloon.

“What nonsense,” he sputtered.

“He’s easy to love. I won’t tell him,” Cipher promised.

“There is nothing to tell! I am caring for him as I would anyone else on my crew!” Mydei insisted. His heart was racing at the implication; he could feel the heat in his ears, in his cheeks, behind his eyes. What the hell was she on about?

“Men really are so damn stupid,” she cackled, “you’ll figure it out eventually, I’m *sure*.”

Hrumph. Mydei crossed his arms.

“Or don’t,” she said noncommittally, her voice dropped low, “but when you get that coreflame and hold the ultimate temptation in your hands… if you betray him, if he gets hurt, I will bury you alive.”

The idea of suffocating over and over again was unappealing. Mydei had been there, done that, it wasn’t an experience he wanted to repeat but even without the threat, the potential for heartache alone was a deterrent.

Power had never appealed to Mydei. If it did, he’d have a crown on his head, a Kingdom to rule, people to order about, but even considering that option in passing made the bile creep up his throat. That wasn’t a future he wanted for his people. There was nothing left for them in Castrum Kremnos but bloodshed. Plenty of Mydei’s culture was worth preserving, the legacy of a corrupted, bloody king was not one of them.

“There is no power in this life that I could want aside from that which could protect my people. The Coreflame of Strife has more value in Phainon’s hands as a means to the happiness he denies himself, then it ever would to me or my kin, who would see it at the extension of a crown I have long rejected. Make your threats, I can feel in them the love you have for him, but rest assured, if that man is ever made to suffer by my hands again, I would sooner bury myself.”

They studied each other until Cipher started to laugh again. “Alright, alright, I believe you little lion. Just… make him happy, okay? My little brother deserves the world.”

Mydei blinked and then slowly nodded. He agreed completely, even if she was giving him horrible whiplash.

“Shall we go to him then?” Cipher offered. The threatening aura was gone, the rolling purr was back, and she waited patiently with one hand extended and the other behind her back.

Mydei skeptically reached for her hand. She snatched it and then the world blended into streaks of light and a rush of wind.

“You’re not gonna be sick, are you?” she asked when it stopped. The whole ordeal had taken maybe a second. Mydei had been on the road, blinked, and now he was… where was he?

The room was small but elegant, reminding him a bit of his home back on the island but with more frivolity in the architectural decorations. Kremnoan and Okheman architecture came from similar roots and shared a lot of their structural hallmarks such as balconies, columns, and love of open space. This room was no exception, with its own private balcony, a kline, a dresser, full-length mirror, a small desk and bookshelf. It even had its own private bath, though the water had long been drained. There was a light layer of dust on every surface except for the growing pile of discarded clothing behind the kline and perfect circles where amphorae and vases had been hastily shoved against the wall to make space for unexpected guests.

Phainon was frantically cleaning while Ptolemy perused the bookshelf and Leonnius was trying to calm the Okheman.

“It’s really okay, Phainon! We don’t mind!”

“I don’t usually leave a mess like this!” he insisted.

“You’re cute when you try to lie,” Cipher purred.

“Mydei!” Phainon called, brightening immediately. He kicked the pile of clothes under the kline. “What took so long?”

“Geez kid, not even a thank you?”

“I’m sorry, Cipher. Thank you for your help.”

“Good boy. I just got lost on the way,” she explained, “you know how big the palace is.”

Mydei caught her wink as she spun in a circle and watched her stumble when her spinning almost caused an accident. Her acrobatics saved her ankle and the amphorae that she almost tripped over. Phainon was already hurrying to scoop the thing up to carefully move it to a corner with the rest of his bizarre collection.

“Ugh, I’m realizing a little too late the missed opportunity to get rid of your trash while you were away,” she mused, “now, before I go~” She scooted in close to Mydei again with mischief sparkling in her smile. “What are you supposed to say, little lion?”

He sighed and rolled his eyes before mumbling, “Thank you, Cipher the Great.”

She squealed with glee and saluted the room, “Duty calls~ Better hurry.” Cipher was gone before anyone could blink, leaving silence and exhaustion in her wake.

“Okay but for real,” Leonnius said, “how does she…?”

“She flips a coin and can move really fast,” Phainon explained.

Mydei was already moving on. He wanted to focus on their mission, to trust that Cipher was doing her part to keep them safe from discovery. They didn’t have a lot of time to spare, and it was hard to tell with the permanent daylight how much of that precious resource they had left. But it was hard not to think about what Cipher had said. Love was a very loaded word. Now was probably not the time to open that basket of snakes.

Phainon’s room was still cluttered despite his rushed attempts to correct it, but it was honestly very nice. Phainon wasn’t a *dirty* person, he kept himself clean and was organized. It was refreshing to see that he was also very human. In the comfort of his own home surrounded by the fingerprints of a life lived, he was somewhat scatterbrained.

“I’m not usually here,” he was still trying to explain.

“Are you hoarding jars?” Leonnius was asking.

“No, no, I’m appraising them… Ptolemy did you just put one of my books in your pocket?”

“…*it would go so well with my collection on the ship!”*

Mydei tuned them out to look over Phainon’s walls. He had sketches and paintings and old advertisements hung up somewhat haphazardly. Anything that appealed to him he had purchased and kept as reminders of time well spent. That play he saw as a matinee, the announcement of a new sweet at his favorite bakery, a child’s drawing gifted to him, even a hastily scribbled receipt for a commission for a new sword with the start date left blank, payment pending, to name only a few. These were snapshots into the life of a man that wanted to *experience* everything, who wanted to remember all the joys in his life worth fighting for.

Maybe Mydei was feeling a little in love.

“We’re wasting time,” he said, quiet but forceful. They needed to get Phainon back to this life.

Ptolemy hurriedly grabbed two more books and shoved them under his cloak and then the four of them were peeking out of the doorway, heads stacked on top of each other and twisting to check both directions.

“The hall is clear,” Phainon observed.

Moving quietly in armor was a fool’s errand but Mydei made it work and there weren’t a lot of people around to hear them. …they hadn’t seen another soul at all.

“Shouldn’t there be guards?” Leonnius whispered.

“This is where the Chrysos Heirs live,” Phainon whispered back, “there isn’t any need to guard up here.”

“…Does the Goldweaver live here?” Mydei asked when he realized.

“Yeah.”

“So maybe we stop whispering,” Ptolemy hissed.

They moved in silence down the hall until Phainon stopped them in front of a closed door and motioned for them all to come in close. “Castorice can be touchy, so just, don’t be surprised.”

Mydei started to ask what that meant when a shadow moved down the hallway. The prince immediately shoulder-checked the group to shove all four of them into the bedroom and closed the door behind them with a soft click.

“Someone is coming,” he hissed.

The room itself was dark. Castorice had heavy curtains to block her balcony, leaving just enough light to see to not trample her things. Where Phainon’s clutter had been in laundry and antiques, Castorice had a thing for stuffed animals and handicrafts. Her desk was covered in fabrics and cotton stuffing, needles and thread, and projects that were missing their heads. Finished stuffed animals were piled in the corners, brightly colored and friendly looking.

Ptolemy had already moved to her bookshelf. It was smaller and mostly consisted of amateur bound manuscripts, packed with notes. He pulled one out to start reading but Phainon smacked his hand and swiped the book to put it back.

Mydei expected to find this Castorice sleeping, but the kline was empty.

“Does she sleep somewhere else?” Leonnius whispered.

“I have never actually seen her slee-“ Phainon cut himself off and dove into the pile of stuffed animals when the door handle started to turn.

Mydei almost followed him, but Leonnius beat the prince to it, wiggling into hiding and leaving no space for the other two. Ptolemy managed to get behind the curtain to hide on the

balcony, but Mydei was left awkwardly behind the door, trusting the shadows and his hood to hide him from view.

The woman who let herself into the room was ethereally beautiful in the same way moonlight on bone was beautiful. The way flowers bloomed on decay in defiance of death or the sense of peace that comes from visiting the grave of a loved one long since mourned. She was pale enough to nearly glow in the limited light, wearing white clothing adorned with handmade ornaments in the shapes of butterflies and flowers to match the ornaments in her lavender hair.

Castorice paused when she closed the door behind her with her foot, listening to the 'empty' room with her arms crossed tightly over a pair of tomes pressed to her chest.

Mydei was holding his breath, trying so hard not to breathe. She was so close, close enough that he could reach his hand out and take her shoulder.

And it was a very good thing he didn't. The feeling that crept over Mydei was so *gentle* that he couldn't remember when it started. Had he always felt this relaxed? This tired? It was a little cold, the creeping sensation in his veins, a squirming that made his mind recoil, screaming for him to move, that this feeling was too familiar and wholly unwelcome, but his body felt so light and unresponsive. If not for his shoulder against the wall, he would have collapsed.

They had time for a nap, right?

Mydei barely processed that her rich purple eyes were looking right at him. Oh, there was some pink in there too. It was lovely, like someone had taken the oranges from a sunset and left only the purple hues of dusk.

"Castorice," Phainon called. His voice was so far away, muted like he was calling from underwater.

Those beautiful purple eyes widened, and she turned, taking the hand of death, for surely that was what it was, with her. Mydei felt the clarity come back in a surge of warmth and put a hand against the wall for more support while he came to terms with how close that was.

Phainon was kicking himself free of her stuffed animals and stumbling to the center of the room. He lowered his hood and smiled at her.

"Lord Phainon?" her voice was gentle as a long rest, soft as the velvet of petals.

He nodded and held his arms open, and she dropped her books to the floor, utterly forgotten, to run to give him a hug.

It occurred to Mydei far too late exactly who Castorice was. Until he had felt it himself, he hadn't put the pieces together nor remembered the tales of Aidonia's Priestess of Death, a woman that could not touch nor be touched without taking life. She who lived without color, who knew not warmth, who danced with the dead, and conversed with spirits. The executioner of a culture that worshipped the grave.

Phainon's Castorice was that very same Hand of Thanatos. So, when Mydei saw her run to him, he panicked and reached to grab her with no regard for his own life. He was too late.

Her arms wrapped around Phainon's waist, and she pressed her cheek to his chest, holding him tightly with the happiest coo sound Mydei had heard. Phainon's own arms wrapped around her shoulders, curling around her to be all-encompassing. He rocked them back and forth a few times before they finally pulled apart and she was quick to grab his sleeve as though she would perish without the contact.

"Lord Phainon… how are you here?" she asked. Her eyes darted back to Mydei who was still trying to figure out how Phainon was *alive.*

"It's a long story and one I hope to tell you under less rushed circumstances," he said softly, "but first, please, I want to introduce you."

Phainon took her hand in his and pulled her towards Mydei, just a step. He held her hand firmly, offering comfort with a squeeze, and then motioned to Mydei with his other hand. Cautiously, the Kremnoan stepped out of the shadows and lowered his hood.

"Castorice, this is Mydeimos, Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos, and my very best friend."

Best friend. That was the first time Mydei had heard Phainon refer to him as his *friend* using words. So much of what was between them was unspoken, shared through exchanged blows and hard work. To hear it said aloud felt different.

"Castrum Kremnos," Castorice mumbled, she was also reeling from shock, Mydei could tell. "Lord Phainon, what an adventure you must have been on." She gathered her wits and stepped up to Mydei to curtsy. "It is an honor to meet you, Prince Mydeimos. Do I have you to thank for returning Lord Phainon?"

"It is… more complicated than that, Miss Castorice," Mydei responded. He bowed his head in a gesture of respect.

"If you are a friend of Lord Phainon," she said, "then you must be a fine person. With your permission, may I touch you?"

Mydei was genuinely taken aback. "A moment ago, I could have been certain that you were Aidonia's Hand of Death…"

"I was, Prince Mydeimos, until no more than few years past," she confirmed, "my touch no longer brings death against my will, not since my ascension to divinity, but if it would make you more comfortable, I will refrain."

Mydei looked between her and Phainon. The man was smiling reassuringly, still holding Castorice's hand as proof that it was safe. This person, like Cipher, was very important to him.

He extended his hand to her. "Mydei is fine."

She still hesitated. “With respect, Prince Mydei, I would like your spoken consent before I touch you.”

“You may touch me,” he said and then she was taking his hand. There was no ominous presence, no creeping dread.

“May I hug you, Prince Mydei?” she asked.

“You may,” he invited and then her arms were wrapped around his waist. She was warm, warmer than he had expected from a woman of her origins. His fingertips gently pressed between her shoulder blades when he raised his hand to reciprocate her gesture, and she must have understood his hesitation because she did not overstay her welcome. When Castorice pulled back, she took his hand again and then reached for Phainon’s, desperate to maintain contact.

“Lord Phainon, we must go wake Lady Aglaea, she will be so happy to see you!”

“Miss Castorice…” Phainon started, and she heard it in his voice and felt it when he let her go.

“…you are not staying, are you?”

Leonnius stuck his head out of the pile of stuffed animals to say, “Lady, have we got a story for you.”

Chapter End Notes

My twist on Castorice and coreflames is gonna be a little more original. This was something I decided on a long time ago, because half the joy of fanfiction is getting to provide happy endings and new twists wherein to explore a character. I love Castorice a lot in the game and her touch has defined a lot about her, she retains that history in this fic, but I'm so excited to explore how that history would effect her actions and perceptions of human connection when she is finally able to touch

Chapter 19: Bedtime Stories

Chapter Summary

> The best stories, the stories that hurt the most, the ones we need to hear, are the ones that ring with truth.

Chapter Notes

> I was looking for Phaidei fic recs on Twitter via threads of folks asking the same, and while I was looking through replies I found my own fic recommended and I lost my shit and called my mom freaking out excited telling her I officially made it! Idk which one of you it was but I am so honored. Thank you so much for enjoying my story enough to recommend it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The sudden appearance of not one, but *two* additional Kremnoan men in Castorice's room was enough of a jump scare to land Castorice in Phainon's arms. Which was admittedly a funny reaction considering between the two of them, he was confident she was the stronger warrior. Castorice was a proper demigod with a coreflame in her chest, Phainon was just… well, he was just himself.

He very gently set her down and the other two greeted her warmly.

"My name is Leonnius, this is Ptolemy."

"'But tell me, are you a goddess or are you a mortal woman?'" Ptolemy quoted when he bowed politely and pressed his lips to the back of her hand. Castorice turned a light shade of pink but before she could respond Leonnius was dragging his friend to the other side of the room while he protested, "I'm being polite!"

"Why is your polite always so *weird*!" Leonnius grumbled back.

"It may be best if you start at the beginning, Lord Phainon," Castorice said, as she gathered the books she dropped earlier and set them on the bookshelf. Elegantly, and perhaps still a bit flustered with that dusting of blush still in her cheeks, she settled on a stool, hands in her lap while she waited to be regaled.

"Forgive me, but there isn't time for the whole story." Instead, Phainon told her the short version, like the one he told Cipher but minus the emphasis on treasure. He told her that he

had been traveling with the Kremnoan Detachment, that they did not want to continue fighting with Okhema and had instead been fighting the Black Tide. He told her that they knew where the Strife coreflame was and were making plans to retrieve it, plans that needed her help to achieve success. He emphasized that he believed it was the first step towards defeating the Black Tide, the right step towards lasting peace for all Amphoreus.

"…this feels like something Lady Aglaea should know about," Castorice mumbled when Phainon finished.

He shook his head. "Not until we have the coreflame in hand. I can't risk any of us being arrested before then."

It was Leonnius who leaned in to add, "if nothing else, help us get it for Phainon. We believe it will be enough to buy him a pardon and let him come home."

Phainon bit his tongue to keep himself from adding that he wanted it to end their war. The way Mydei and the others had talked before, he didn't believe they'd go through with it if they knew that Phainon intended to reject it as payment for just himself.

Castorice folded her hands in her lap, flat, one on top of the other. She looked down. "Lord Phainon, are you really a pirate?"

Out of the corner of his eye, Phainon saw Mydei step forward to say something but… this was something Phainon had thought about since he had read Aglaea's words. He held his hand out to stop Mydei and was relieved when the prince honored his request and stepped back. The Deliverer knelt in front of her and took Castorice's hand in his to look her in the eyes.

"Yes. I am."

The three Kremnoans tensed in tandem, taken aback but he ignored them to focus on one of his oldest friends.

Castorice had arrived in Okhema not long after he had with a longer story to tell and a crushing curse. Despite her many years, she willingly accompanied Phainon to the Grove to study alongside him and they had grown very close to each other in that time. It was via study and research that Phainon and Castorice had been able to track and retrieve the Coreflame of Death together, answering questions that had haunted her as long as she had memory.

When Castorice ascended to divinity and had first learned to control her touch, Phainon was the first person who had reached for her. When no one else wanted to take the risk, he took her hand and held it to his face for her to feel. He had been her first hug, one that had lasted so long that she had cried herself into a stupor and had to be carried to her room, where she clung to him as though she was making up for hundreds of years of missed human contact.

There was a connection between them that he treasured. She had earned his complete honesty.

“And I want to show you why,” he continued with a tender squeeze, “please, come with us. I want you to meet all of them, to see what I have seen.”

She curled her fingers around one of his. Phainon had always had big hands, especially compared to her delicate ones. The other tenderly touched his cheek, holding him still with the palm of her hand so that she could study him and his smile.

“I trust you, Lord Phainon,” she agreed, “I will go with you to retrieve the coreflame.”

“That’s two,” Leonnius said cheerfully.

“Were you here for others, Lord Phainon?”

“Yeah, I was going to ask Hyacine to come. Her research into the Black Tide could save lives and Cipher already agreed to help us.”

Castorice pulled her hand away from his face and tilted her head. “Lady Cipher agreed?”

“Yeah.”

“Lord Phainon, I saw Lady Cipher and Lady Aglaea walking to the baths when I left the library.”

All four men went tense, winding even tighter than they already had been.

“If the Goldweaver is awake…” Ptolemy mumbled.

“Fuck,” Leonnius swore in Kremnoan and then he remembered there was a lady present, “sorry, sorry.”

“Time is short,” Mydei agreed.

“No that’s good,” Phainon told them, “She’s keeping Aglaea busy. Castorice, pack your things, only a small bag of essentials, while I go talk to Hyacine.”

He got up to move to the door, but Castorice caught his sleeve. “Lord Phainon, you should know, Lady Hyacine moved into the city to help rebuild the Twilight Courtyard. She does not sleep in the Marmoreal Palace.”

He groaned.

“Then we go into the city,” Mydei offered, “the Goldweaver is the only real threat, Okheman patrols are inattentive, they will be easy to get past.”

Phainon bit his lip.

“You do not like this plan,” the prince observed.

“No, it’s not that. I have some things to grab here at the Palace but if we go into the city…”

“We don’t have time for both,” Leonnius supplied.

“Castorice, could you take them?” Phainon asked.

“No need,” Mydei insisted, “tell us where to go and we will go. Give us a message or a token for this Hyacine and we will meet you at the Northeast dromas road.”

“Prince Mydei, it is no trouble. I can guide you.”

To Phainon’s surprise, Mydei took his place on his knees in front of Castorice, offering his hand to her for her to take. It was unexpectedly considerate of him to defer to her and her comfort. Phainon felt the heat rise to his cheeks as he watched Mydei gently hold her hand, ever conscious of his gauntlets and their sharp claws. Mydeimos must’ve been observing the way they interacted, noted their body language, probably took into account their closeness, and still decided to copy Phainon to put weight behind his words in the exact way he had, that he knew would reach her because of his exampled.

“I don’t know you very well, Lady Castorice, but we are taking you from your home, and in this I have experience,” he said gently, “I request that you take the time you need to gather your things and say goodbye in a manner that will bring you the most peace. It is easy now in the excitement of the decision to believe you will not need it, but I insist.”

Castorice was genuinely taken aback, so was Phainon. He tilted his head at Mydei, looking at the back of his head and that messy mane with genuine appreciation and a bit of a flutter in his stomach.

“Prince Mydei,” she said.

“Please, just Mydei,” he gently corrected.

“Lord Mydei,” Castorice said instead and Phainon smiled a little imagining the face Mydei must be making, with those subtle twitches in the corners of his mouth and eyes when he was trying to stay polite when he *really* wanted to say something. “That is… unexpectedly considerate. Thank you.”

Mydei patted her hand once more and then got up to face Phainon. “You will do the same, Deliverer.”

“Mydei, I don’t need-“

“You do. We will have you home soon, but until then, do what you need to do.” He put his hand on Phainon’s shoulder when he said it, holding them close, those golden eyes almost glowing in the dim light from the cracked curtain. That simmer in the dark made Phainon’s heart sing, that concern in Mydei’s voice, *just* for him!

What else could he do but nod?

“We’ll meet at the arches,” Phainon promised. He punched Mydei’s shoulder and the Kremnoan’s lip curled in a lopsided smirk.

“If you are late-“

“If I’m late, you better come and get me,” Phainon teased with his own sparkling grin.

“I will throw you over my shoulder and drag you back to the ship myself,” Mydei promised.

“You can flirt when we’re safe!” Leonnius scolded.

Mydei and Phainon broke eye contact at the same time, flustered at the accusation.

“You better hurry, Mydeimos.”

“My victory always be yours, Deliverer.”

Phainon left the room before Ptolemy or Leonnius could try cat calling and before Mydei could see his face adopting a deeper shade of red. Th-They weren’t flirting? That wasn’t flirting! That was just banter between friends!

The cloak almost tangled in Phainon’s legs as he shuffled down the hallway. Mydei had been right about his homesickness, Phainon really did miss these halls, but his longing to return was more complicated than he was willing to admit to Mydei just yet. It wasn’t that Phainon wanted to be back here, it’s that he wanted to *show his new friends the beauty of Okhema.* He so badly wanted to take Mydei’s hand and pull him through the market and show him good food and good music. He wanted everyone else to meet these wonderful, rough, rowdy, incredible men that Phainon had grown to adore. Kephale’s love was for all who walked across Amphoreus, not just Okhemans, and Phainon wanted so badly for Okhema to see and appreciate them.

That wasn’t the kind of homesickness that could be sated with a temporary goodbye, so he didn’t try. Instead, Phainon abandoned the idea of goodbye at all. As far as he was concerned the light promise to return in glory that he had given to Aglaea still held, even if he was returning in a very different manner than he, or anyone, had intended.

He paused to listen for movement in the hallways before he dipped inside Aglaea’s office. True to her words, Cipher was keeping the Goldweaver busy, and her office was empty. Her garmentmakers were hovering against the wall. If they noticed him enter, they didn’t care that he was there.

Phainon immediately noticed the subtle signs of Aglaea’s stress. Her office was *visibly organized* and immaculately clean. The kind of space that people might expect from a major political player in the largest standing city on Amphoreus. Which is how Phainon knew she was upset.

A happy Aglaea was *inspired*, constantly working on new projects, eager to *create*. It was only when she had too much on her mind that she cared about the organized clutter and sought to tidy her space in a manner befitting the desires of others. Her mannequins were empty, tools put neatly in their drawers, shelves dusted, letters organized, and so on.

It hurt to see.

“Oh Aglaea,” he mumbled to himself with his head bowed and a hand held to his chest, “I promise, I’ll make it right.”

Phainon hurried to her desk and started opening drawers. He knew where she kept things so despite the dozens of knobs, he only needed two. Her stationery was embossed along the edges long before she took pen to paper for that extra level of refinement. She applied it herself to set her words apart, something Aglaea felt was important when the Council of Elders had so much to say.

He dipped the pen in her gold ink and sat down to write. Phainon’s penmanship was neat and practiced, something he picked up from Aglaea. In his haste, Phainon left little speckles and tiny drips that made his perfectionism unhappy, but this was already more than he had expected to be able to say. He folded the letter but didn’t seal it.

Phainon tapped the paper as he looked for a spot to hide it, somewhere that Aglaea would find that Caenis or her goons wouldn’t think to look should the Council send spies.

He crossed the room in three long strides to one of her shelves and pulled a wide amphora down from the top shelf. It was decorated with scenes of lounging chimeras, snacking on cookies and sweets. It was on theme.

Phainon set it on the desk and started stuffing his pockets with the chimera biscuits that were stored inside. The crunchy treats were of the finest make, only the best possible ingredients. Aglaea traded high quality clothing for them as a long-standing deal with the oldest bakery in Okhema. These treats were especially made for Vigethos, (affectionally called Beagle Coconut by the children in town) Aglaea’s gray and white chimera, and Phainon knew the adorable monster went *crazy* for the things.

It was a good spot to hide the letter and if the daily treats were the best way to Vigethos’ heart, maybe they’d work on Fig Stew. Phainon was not above bribery to earn those belly rubs.

He had managed to cram more than half the jar into his pockets and tucked the letter inside when he went to put the amphora back. The second he lifted it; two bright blue eyes were looking right up at him from behind the jar.

“Fuck!” Phainon cussed in Kremnoan as he almost fumbled the pottery, “Cipher has been teaching you how to magically appear, hasn’t she?”

The chimera didn’t move. He was plain by chimera standards, all white belly and gray on top with a spade on the end of his tail and two uneven horns on the top his head by his ears. Aglaea had owned him since before Phainon had come to Okhema for the first time. He was a deceptively old creature with a spry demeanor and knowing look who had learned how to weaponize his cuteness against everyone except Aglaea. That’s why he was a little on the chubby side, because Trinnon kept giving him treats. The same treats nearly spilling from Phainon’s pockets.

He was also a little snitch.

“Hey, Beag,” Phainon crooned. He gently gave the chimera scratches under his chin. They were accepted but those eyes narrowed at him a little more with every pet. “Aren’t you so handsome?” The chimera had a lovely golden collar, just a delicate band barely visible under his fluffy white ruff. Phainon ran his fingers underneath it to scratch at the fur. “Did you miss me?”

The chimera purred and got up to sniff at his pockets, but Phainon quickly covered them. “You’re on a diet remember?”

Beagle sat down, his front paws neatly pressed together and opened his mouth for cookies.

Phainon gave him a pat on his head instead and put the jar back up on the top shelf, out of reach of the small terror.

“Sorry Viggie,” he whispered with an apologetic scratch behind the ears.

The chimera stomped his paw, but Phainon was already getting up to leave. So, Beagle escalated to plan B.

He screamed.

Phainon jumped on the chimera and jammed three cookies into his open mouth, silencing the animal in a heartbeat. There was a tense second of Phainon waiting to see if it worked and Beagle realizing he had a mouth full of delicious goodness before the chimera’s little mouth curled into a wide smile and his eyelids drooped in the most mischievous expression anyone had seen since Cipher had convinced the local fishing chapter that goldfish were made of actual gold. That was the face of a gluttonous animal that knew he had *won*.

And Phainon hated to lose. If he wasn't on a time crunch...

“This isn’t over,” he hissed to the smug animal as he stacked a little pile of cookies on the floor to keep the monster busy.

Phainon slipped out into the city via balcony to avoid Verax Leo and the only few guards that he knew would be at attention. They weren’t looking for people with active warrants, they were more like bouncers to keep sleepy drunks from wandering into restricted housing, but it wasn’t worth the risk that he’d be recognized under the hood.

He landed lightly on all fours and waited, listening, but nothing moved, nothing cared that he was there while the city slept.

Phainon wove through back alleys and hopped a couple walls, startling the occasional bird until he stood outside the door of a small home in a serene residential district. It felt like there was cotton in his throat and pressure behind his eyes. Now that he was here, Phainon felt very strongly that he needed to *feel*. He needed to remember and carry this weight, the same one that he had been holding onto for over a month, keeping close, buried deep as a new permanent part of him.

The longer he stood on the stoop the more risk there was that he would be seen, but it still took him a long time, nearly a quint, to gather himself to knock on the door.

It was late. No response.

Another knock, more waiting. Phainon checked down the path, hoping that none of the neighbors were up late.

Finally, the door opened a crack and Phainon shoved his way inside.

“Wha-! What in Kephale’s name are you doing?! Who are you!?” the lady yelled. She slapped his chest and tried to shove him, but Phainon barely noticed the physical protests. As soon as the door was closed, he lowered the hood and the assault abruptly stopped.

“Phainon?” she whispered.

“Xenia,” he greeted. Phainon tried to smile softly, but it was forced and weak.

She stared at him, pale and uncomfortable, and he wasn’t even slightly surprised when she slapped his face. It stung. He deserved it.

“You shouldn’t be here,” Xenia hissed, low, full of venom, and wavering with grief. Tears were flowing down her face.

“I know,” he managed.

“Mom?”

Both adults stilled when a little boy, maybe six years old, called out to them. The knocking must have woken him too. He was rubbing his eyes and covering his yawn, hair standing up on one side from sleeping too heavily on one side. The same side Phainon’s fallen first mate, Marcus, had slept on. The same dark brown hair, even the way the boy scratched at his belly was his father in miniature.

“Wha’sh goin’ on?” he mumbled, and she hurried to hug him.

“Nothing, just an unwelcome visitor,” she told him. Xenia gently pet her son’s head to fix his hair. It sprang right back up in defiance. “Go back to sleep, you have school in the morning.”

“Who’s that?” he asked instead.

“No one.”

“I was a friend of your father’s,” Phainon greeted, “what’s your name?”

“Don’t answer,” Xenia ordered with a shake and Phainon’s heart clenched, “go back to sleep, I’ll tell you more in the morning.”

The little boy looked suspiciously between the two of them, but he nodded and obeyed.

“He looks like his father,” Phainon observed softly, “Xenia, I-“

“Why did *you* get to come back?” she sobbed, “and not him? What happened, Phainon? What won’t the Goldweaver tell us?” Shaking hands covered her face as though it could stop the dam, hold back the grief that Xenia had probably been holding onto for a long time, that she had hidden away until now.

He reached for her but paused before his hand could touch her arm. Grieving people didn’t always liked to be touched but when Xenia stumbled, sobbing too hard to keep her balance, he stepped forward to catch her and held her tightly. Even when she slapped him again and pounded on his chest with her fists, he held her close until she finally accepted that she was not the only one in mourning. Her arms wrapped around his neck, and she sobbed into his shoulder while he held her, trying to convey in every firm rub across her back and shoulders the comfort that he knew she needed.

“The truth will not bring you comfort,” he told her, “but I owe it to you. Will you tell the others? The rest of the crew’s families?”

“Are you that much of a coward?” she growled but there was no bite in her tone, “that you will not tell them yourself?”

His hug tightened around her shoulders. Phainon felt that shame like a noose. “If there were not a people that still needed me, I would turn myself in to the Council in exchange for the time to tell them. Please, Xenia, meet me here in this middle ground, it is as far as I am currently able to go.”

She took a shuddering breath against his shoulder and slowly pushed away. Phainon kept his arms extended towards her, to catch her if she fell again but she found her footing.

“Then speak, Deliverer. Tell me the story of how you failed my husband.”

-

“Are they always like that?” Castorice asked just after Phainon left.

“It’s gotten worse since Phainon moved into Mydei’s room,” Leonnius noted blandly.

Castorice’s arm shot out and grabbed his wrist, making the man jump, slowly she turned to look at him with mischief and surprise painted in broad strokes across her face. “*You must tell me everything.”*

“There is nothing to tell,” Mydei grumbled.

I got you, Leonnius mouthed, gesturing to her and then back to himself with a few rapid nods.

“How do we get to the Twilight Courtyard?” Ptolemy asked and Castorice rose gracefully from her chair to walk to the balcony. Offensive daylight streamed into the room as she pushed aside the curtain and motioned for them to come see. All three of them piled in behind her to follow the line where she was pointing.

“Follow the road down the hill to the market,” she instructed, “when the path splits, go left until you see a forge to your right, then it’s another left and then your second right.”

All three of them nodded but she still studied them skeptically.

“…were my instructions clear enough, my lords?”

“We got it,” Leonnius reassured her. He was already walking up to the balcony railing to vault over it.

“When you are packing,” Ptolemy started to say, “will you bring a couple of those manuscripts? One of them looked interes-!” Mydei interrupted him to bodily throw him over the balcony.

Castorice jumped just a little bit in shock but when neither of the remaining men seemed alarmed she sheepishly held a hand to her mouth to say, “Does he truly want me to bring my works?”

“Please don’t listen to him Miss Castorice,” Leonnius reassured her, “he is simply a lover of literature and a hoarder of books, mostly harmless.” The runner saluted her and then jumped off the balcony.

“Miss Castorice,” Mydei gently cleared his throat to get her attention, “have you anything that I may show to Miss Hyacine? A token or a phrase?”

“Of course, Lord Mydei.” Castorice walked over to her shelf and pulled out a box of handmade charms. She fished around for a very specific one, a fat horse with tiny wings, lopsided and colored white, stitched from pieces of scrap fabrics of different textures. “Give this to her and she will know that I have sent you.”

He took it reverently and tucked it inside his cloak. “Will you be able to meet us at the gate? Or should I send Leonnius to escort you?”

“Respectfully, Lord Mydei, it is safer for me to move about the city than it is for you. I will be there.”

He walked back to the balcony and put a hand on it.

“Lord Mydei?” She was looking at him with awe and wonder that he didn’t expect from a demigod. “I hope we have more time to talk in the future. When Lord Phainon told his story, he mentioned you the most. I am looking forward to learning why.”

Mydei felt light-headed. He hadn’t even noticed. “I am sure it is nothing, Miss Castorice.”

She smiled knowingly and turned away to pack, leaving him to drop into the bushes beside his two friends with a whole new confusing feeling to push down on his list of priorities.

“Let us move quickly,” he whispered to them and then they were dashing down the street.

Okhema was very different from their Kremnoan settlement. While it had its share of twists and turns, stairways and covered roads, none of it was built with combat in mind. There was no strategy to it, no regard for defense, only a desperate need to make every empty space a monument to art. Every wall was covered in mosaics, every pillar sported colored fabrics, when stairs created awkward spaces between buildings, the people created water features full of colorful fish and bright flowers. Ivy was allowed to creep up the walls to add splashes of green to cream colored stone and pale marble. There were statues under each archway, colorful paintings and tapestries hung beside windows and doorways. This was a city for the wealthy, for those who had never known the horrors of combat, who had the luxury of wiling away the days dancing with spirits of creation and inspiration to enrich their lives.

It made Mydei a little envious. He couldn't see his people indulging to this degree, but what could *his* people create, given the opportunity to express themselves without the constant threat of war. Would they embrace it? Or would they reject it in favor of the path they had always known, following Nikador's footsteps to bloody ends?

"She said left at the fork, right?" Leonnius asked.

"Right."

"Right?"

"No, left."

"You said right."

"Because you were right."

"Oh."

Mydei rolled his eyes.

"Did we miss the turn?" Leonnius asked, "how far down the road were we supposed to go?"

They were almost at the bottom of the hill and hadn't seen a market, nor a fork in the road. Were they already lost? Mydei stopped to look around. This felt like a commercial district, but not a market. He sniffed the air. Forges could have distinct smells if they were close but all he could smell was fish and salty sea air.

"We must have missed the turn," he said.

"Let's try this way," Leonnius offered and then they were running again, trying to guess the layout of a city that none of them had ever seen, following signs that kept leading them through confusing paths up and down stairs, through tight alleys, and almost into a pond.

"We don't have time to keep guessing," Ptolemy hissed.

"Quiet! Someone is coming!" Leonnius hissed. The three of them crammed into a doorway down a shallow alley.

Mydei peeked, careful to keep his hood low over his head. It was a single guard, half asleep, not even armed. If not for his armor, Mydei may have thought he was a normal guy just out for a late-night stroll.

“Even with the Black Tide,” Ptolemy huffed, “how did Eurypon fail to bring this city to heel? Their security is so unserious.”

Very slowly the man wandered away, continuing his rounds. They gave it another quint for good measure and then spread out into the alley for space to breathe.

“We agree we are lost, yes?” Mydei whispered.

“Yeah.”

“’But cease your sighing and lamentation- we have no time to lose,’” Ptolemy said in his deadpan voice that he saved for quotes.

“But you have time to recite literature?” Leonnius scolded.

“You could ask for directions.”

All three of them froze at the new voice. It was a rumbling growl, deep and gravely with a purr embedded in the sound. Mydei spun, claws ready but it was no guard at the end of the alley, just a stone statue. He scanned the walls, looking for a place where a trickster or thief might hide. Who else would be out at this hour aside from pirates and criminals?

Leonnius peeked around Mydei. “Uh, and who might you be, mysterious empty dead end?”

“Hahaha! How curious that you do not know of me…” mused the statue. Its eyes lit up when it talked but no part of it moved.

“Anyone else getting an uncomfortable sense of familiarity?” Ptolemy asked.

The statue was round and mounted to the wall, a simple relief of a lion’s head with its fanged mouth open wide, jovial eyes, round ears, and a fluffy mane. From base to top it was slightly shorter than Mydei was tall but for something that was all head it still made for an impressive display. Chryseus Leo was a special case but in a world as wide and magical as Amphoreus, Mydei wasn’t surprised to see that there were more like their beloved ship.

“Distant cousin,” Leonnius mumbled. He pointed between the statue and Mydei.

“And you will help us find our way, lion?” Mydei asked.

“Not for free~”

“Then we will find our own way.”

“Wait! Wait! I need to at least know *where* you are trying to go,” the lion insisted. He had the same mistrustful playfulness that Cipher had minus Phainon’s seal of approval.

“The Twilight Courtyard,” Mydei told him.

“Of course, I know where that is.”

“Then speak, lion.”

“Not without something in return.”

Ptolemy scoffed and waved his hand back and forth. The sleeve of his cloak swished dramatically as he did. “And what could a statue want?”

“Tell me why three cloaked figures are hiding from the guards,” the lion crooned, “and I will consider it payment.”

Leonnius tugged on Mydei’s shoulder to turn him around and the three of them locked their arms around each other in a huddle to talk with some privacy.

“We don’t trust this thing, right?” Leonnius asked. The other two nodded.

“If it’s like Chryseus Leo, then it may adhere to a code,” Ptolemy guessed.

“We don’t have the time to wander; the risk is great but what choice do we have?” Mydei pointed out. He broke away to confront the lion head again, peering at it from under his hood.

“I will answer, lion, and you will give us directions. Should you fail to honor your agreement or send us the wrong way, we will return and crush you into dust, is this agreeable?”

The lion head sputtered, fumbling for words, “th-there is no need for such violence, Lord.”

“Then we are agreed?”

“Y-Yes, we are!”

“We are hiding from the guards because we are Kremnoan pirates,” Mydei said with a smirk, “on a mission to steal away the Chrysos Heirs of this city that we may fight the Black Tide in Castrum Kremnos and slay the Titan Nikador that resides there.”

The lion was silent. Its eye would glow and then turn off, as though it were starting to speak and then lost the words.

“My lord, you must jest…” the Lion tried but Mydei waved his hand.

“I have kept my word. Now tell us where to go.”

“Th-The road, take a left from here and then another two staircases down. That hallway leads to the market, from there-“

“Forge, two streets over, got it!” Leonnius said. He grabbed at Ptolemy and Mydei to start pulling them along. A couple steps later he was letting go to run ahead.

“My thanks lion,” Mydei crooned and then he was running along.

“Mydeimos,” Ptolemy hissed as they jogged to catch up, “why did you tell him the truth?”

“Who could he possibly tell that would believe him?” Mydei laughed.

Leonnius slid around the final corner and slowed to a walk. The market was several blocks and a few streets and there nestled in the corner by a fountain was the important shop. The forge they were meant to use as a landmark was closed for the night of course, but Mydei still had to resist the urge to browse the wares. He recognized the name of the forge from the receipt slip that Phainon had attached to his wall. If the Deliverer trusted this shop, then it must be high quality.

Leonnius tugged on his sleeve, and they reluctantly moved on past multi-colored signs with bold advertisements for everything from fresh fruit to antiques, to books.

The Twilight Courtyard was poorly named. It was never twilight in Okhema and their ‘courtyard’ was a very small part of the alley where space between buildings widened by an extra foot. Multicolored awnings connected the two roofs, filtering the light onto a small water feature and far too many potted plants.

Mydei checked both ways down the path and lowered his hood when he was certain they were alone. The sign was brand new, no more than a week old. This was either a new establishment, or something had happened to the prior sign.

He checked the door handle first to see if it was unlocked, expecting a shop and not a residence, but it didn’t budge. There was no bell or knocker, so he gently tapped twice with the knuckles of his gauntlet and then pressed his ear to the door to listen. Someone was moving inside, but no one was coming to the door.

“Maybe they’re asleep,” Leonnius offered.

“No, someone is awake.”

Ptolemy leaned over and knocked instead, loud, booming bangs that almost knocked over a plant, and made him the center of attention.

“If we had time to be polite, we would’ve brought cake,” he grumbled.

It worked at least, the door opened a crack and a sleepy voice called from the dark, tiny and light, a woman’s voice. “Hello? Are you having a medical emergency?”

“Not yet,” Leonnius joked.

Mydei pushed him away from the door. “Are you Miss Hyacine?”

The door opened just a little more. The young woman was wearing a loose chiton, sleepwear, and rubbing her eyes. Long pink hair rested over her shoulders in big curls, the ends tipped teal the same color as her big, wide eyes. She was a tiny thing with a lovely, if currently sleepy demeanor.

“I am. May I help you?”

“Phainon sent us,” Ptolemy hurried to say.

The door pushed open, and she stepped aside, very suddenly awake. “I’ll make tea.”

Chapter End Notes

No Fig Stew cameo for a couple chapters. Hopefully the other gremlin will suffice! :3c

Also, I'm sure most of you forgot the super background characters who perished for the plot in Chapter one, but Phainon sure as hell didn't. ;w;

Chapter 20: An Answer to All Things

Chapter Summary

New character tag: Hyacine

This is the first and hopefully only time, that the perspective jumps to someone other than Phainon or Mydei. I really want them to be the center of this story but I also felt like this was the best way to speak to Phainon's state of mind.

Chapter Notes

I'll still try to post every 1-2 days this week but UH GENSHIN UPDATE AND THE HSR STREAM SOOOO I MEAN, PRIORITIES

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei had expected a little more resistance or at minimum some wariness from this Hyacine. She was a small thing, smaller than Castorice was, with a bubbly personality. Even just barely awake she was cheerfully welcoming them inside, seating the three of them down at a table and getting tea started at a kitchenette in the same room.

No questions, no concerns, just three very large Kremnoan men dressed like they were there to rob the place, and this tiny young lady alone in her sleepwear had let them inside, sat them down, and was treating them like honored guests.

“Is Phainon alright?” she asked.

“He could be better,” Leonnius answered, meeting her cheerfulness with his own.

“Is he hurt?” Hyacine prodded.

“Nothing like that,” Mydei corrected, “As a Chrysos Heir are you aware of his status?”

“I know the Council of Elders demanded Aglaea brand him as a pirate and write a warrant for his arrest.”

Ptolemy snorted through his nose, a chuckle in another time and place cut short by the urgency of the situation. “You know more than we do.”

“If you would allow us,” Mydei offered, “we have a plan to rectify that order, but we need your help.”

Hyacine carried four little ceramic mugs over to the table and passed them out, one for each of them. “Please, I want to know what I can do, but first, what should I call you?”

“I’m Leonnius, this is Ptolemy, and that’s Mydeimos.” He pointed at each of them in turn to match their faces with their proper names.

She blinked. The rapid response was not what she had expected.

“Sorry, introductions are for people with more time,” Ptolemy explained.

“Then, please, do not delay,” Hyacine requested.

The three of them tag teamed the story while she poured them a herbal tea. Ptolemy was the better storyteller, but he was more dramatic, including vignettes that were nice but probably not necessary for the more recent, pressing concern. Hyacine didn’t need every detail of Phainon’s stay and Leonnius and Mydei kept having to cut their bookworm off mid-sentence to hurry him along. Mydei especially didn’t want some details to make it to the surface until after they had convinced this woman to join their quest.

‘We want you to join our pirate crew! It’s okay, one of your friends and colleagues has been our prisoner for a month and he loves it! He’s only almost been killed twice!’ Honesty was the best policy and Mydei had no issues coming clean later, but this was not the best time.

Unfortunately, the result was a disjointed retelling of the last month that left Miss Hyacine visibly distraught and further confused. Phainon would’ve done a much better job explaining all of this.

When they were done fumbling over their explanation of the situation to her, Mydei took the little charm out of his pocket and put it on the table. She very carefully set her mug down to hold it while she thought.

The silence was deafening. Mydei was questioning everything they had said to her, wondering if a crucial detail had been omitted or if they had said too much and frightened her. Simply admitting that they were *Kremnoans* in Okhema would make the average young lady politely excuse herself to run for help, but Hyacine was surprisingly patient.

She handled everything in stride with the same composure that Castorice had, contemplating every word without jumping to conclusions.

“This was the very first charm that I made,” Hyacine said gently, “I wasn’t very good at it, but Cassie was so patient talking me through it.” Her fingers ghosted over the stitching. “I gave it to her when I was finished because I was so embarrassed and she wouldn’t let me throw it away.”

Leonnius shuffled awkwardly.

“If Cassie and Phainon trust you, then I do too,” she finally said after another pregnant pause. After how horribly they butchered their pitch, Mydei was impressed that Phainon and

Castorice's trust was enough to sway her, but then again, Phainon did sort of have that way about him.

"Just like that?"

"Would you prefer if I said no?"

"'You are the most admirable woman in the whole world both as regards personal beauty and strength of understanding,'" Ptolemy quoted. Immediately after speaking he ducked under Leonnius' punch but collapsed when Mydei kicked his chair out from under him.

Hyacine very calmly looked Mydei in the eye and scolded him, "Lord Mydeimos, please don't do that again."

Brazenness aside, he hadn't had anyone talk to him like that in a long time. He blinked through his surprise while Ptolemy laughed.

"Those chairs are expensive," Hyacine finished with a playful grin, "I wouldn't want them to break."

Ptolemy's laugh turned into a choked, "huh?" while Leonnius' spat tea through his nose when his laughing and drinking disagreed on whose turn it was. She would definitely get along with the crew. Mydei made a note to introduce her to Perdikkas.

"Hyacine, we are pressed for time," Mydei managed.

"I know, we mustn't keep Cassie and Phainon waiting for long. I only need a moment." She got up and hurried to another room.

"Why do you insist on flirting with everyone?" Leonnius coughed.

Ptolemy was using the table to recover his footing. He put the chair back upright and pushed it in without himself in it. It was safer to stand. "It's not flirting, it's being polite. Flirting is whenever Mydeimos talks to Phainon." A hair's breadth before Mydei could throw his mug at Ptolemy, the bookworm scooped it up from the table and held it out of reach.

"I do not flirt with him."

Leonnius and Ptolemy shared a look.

"There's nothing *wrong* with flirting, prince," Ptolemy insisted.

Leonnius covered his mouth with his mug to whisper through gritted teeth, "except when you do it, Ptolemy."

"There is no more elegant way to greet a *Lady* than with the words of fine poetry!"

"Just compliment them or punch them like a normal person!"

"Punching is *not* normal outside of Kremnos!"

Mydei huffed and crossed his arms to wait, eyes closed, determined to ignore their bickering. He did *not* flirt with Phainon. Banter was different than flirting. It was only flirting if there was intent, if there was love.

Oh, I see, you love him.

Mydei stood up fast enough to stop both of his friends mid-sentence. They gave him funny looks as he sulked around the table, gathering the mugs and taking them to the washbasin to clean them for Miss Hyacine.

He really hoped Phainon was okay. If he had been caught… The mug in his hand creaked in protest, nearly cracking when he squeezed too hard. Mydei tempered himself quickly and added a little soap to the water.

The lion did not concern himself with matters of the heart. That was a luxury for peacetime, perhaps when they retrieved the coreflame, when Mydei was able to set right this horrible situation that he had trapped the Deliverer in, *then* he could assess his feelings. Even if he *was* in love, and he was not admitting to himself that he was, none of that love mattered if it wasn't reciprocated.

More speculation. He should just ask Phainon explicitly what they meant to each other and be happy with the outcome. They had already proven to each other that they were rivals and crewmates, Mydei didn't need more than that. And if he were to ask, it needed to be at a better time, when Phainon didn't have the weight of the world on his shoulders. It would not do to put either of them in a position where their trust in each other needed to be questioned, on the eve of a major operation.

He set the mugs aside to dry while Ptolemy and Leonnius continued to argue behind him until Hyacine finally emerged again.

She had changed into a red, white, and pink dress that covered her body and arms but stopped short mid-thigh. Stockings covered her legs, bows adorned her ankles over black shoes, and her hair was pulled into pigtails just behind and above each ear. She had a little hat perched like a tiara, away from her forehead, a pink cape as long as her dress, and a very full messenger bag slung over her shoulder. The charm he had given to her was clipped onto her belt.

"Are we to meet them here?" she asked.

"No, they are expecting us at the Northwest dromas road."

"Many of the early risers will be beginning their days soon," Hyacine cautioned, "and that is on the other side of town."

"Then I guess we better run," Leonnius mused with a stretch.

"I can carry you," Mydei offered.

"Thank you, but there is no need," she promised.

The door opened on oiled hinges as she held it wide for them, beckoning them out into the alley where they pulled their hoods over their heads once more. Hyacine closed the door behind her but left it unlocked and then she hurriedly led the way.

She didn't run as fast as Leonnius or Mydei could, but her little legs carried her fast enough to make them jog to stay caught up as she dipped through back paths through hidden alcoves to stay hidden from any curious eyes. Hyacine didn't take the scenic route, she didn't slow down, and she focused entirely on the mission. Mydei respected that.

They popped out between two buildings on the edge of the road, the only soul in sight was Castorice who was standing next to one of the arches that marked the edge of the city. She was wearing a long shawl bunched around her shoulders and holding a big bag in both hands in front of her.

Hyacine waved at her, and she smiled back, a cute open mouthed, eyes closed kind of smile. They hugged the moment they were close enough to do so.

"They found you," Castorice observed, "I am glad you were willing to come as well." She playfully reached to pet the charm at Hyacine's waist.

"They said that Phainon requested the both of us himself."

"Where *is* the Deliverer?" Mydei asked.

Castorice shook her head.

"You didn't say he returned to Okhema!" Hyacine noted with alarm.

"Ah, we must've forgot…" Leonnius apologized but now she was looking back at the city with concern. So was Mydei.

"We still have some time before the Entry Hour," Castorice tried to reassure them, but Mydei was not reassured.

"Maybe he got lost?" Leonnius asked.

Ptolemy smacked the back of Leonnius' head and said, "in his own city?" Leonnius came back up with a growl to tackle Ptolemy and they both went down wrestling on the road, completely ignored by the other three. Oh yes, these two Chrysos Heirs would fit right in.

"If the Goldweaver caught him," Mydei said, and the pair stilled to listen, "where would she have him taken?"

"Does Aglaea not know that Phainon returned to the city?" Hyacine asked.

"…we may have been told two different stories, Miss Hyacine."

Mydei scanned Okhema systematically, eyes darting back and forth to track *any* movement from birds, to a stray cat, to the rustle of leaves on distant trees. He trusted Phainon, but he also respected the Goldweaver's diligence. It was already very likely that they had stepped on

a golden thread, that she knew they were there or would know very soon. Mydei didn't know how long Cipher could keep an omnipotent demigod distracted.

His brow wrinkled, only a little and only for a moment. "Where is Cipher?"

"Oh, Lady Cipher told me to give Lord Phainon a message," Castorice reported.

"Is she not coming?" Leonnius asked from the road. Ptolemy was sitting on his chest with a foot on one of his wrists to keep him pinned.

Castorice shook her head.

So only two of the three Chrysos Heirs would be accompanying them. Four heirs were better than two but… Mydei had counted on more for their assault on Castrum Kremnos. That was a logistical problem for later. He shoved that down next to other problems that didn't matter any time soon, like his feelings for Phainon and the old cookware on the ship he wanted to eventually replace.

Mydei crossed his arms, still watching the city and counting in his head. Searching for Phainon in a city he didn't know how to navigate was not a *wise* strategic decision. The crew would undoubtedly fall to infighting between Krateros and Hephaestion if Mydei was caught and imprisoned alongside Phainon in a foolish attempt to free him, but perhaps Castorice could guide him through the city. Hyacine seemed to share Phainon's eagerness to help, with a good plan to ensure the safety of his men and the populace at large, it wouldn't be too hard to lay siege to Okhema with only the crew of the Chryseus Leo.

The plan was starting to come together in the back of his mind when Phainon stumbled out of an alleyway and jogged up to them, panting.

"Sorry," he managed, "that took longer than I thought it would."

Mydei scoffed to bury his own relief, "you're too sentimental, Deliverer."

Phainon laughed and rubbed the back of his neck. He was smiling but Mydei could see the hollowness of his eyes. Something had happened. Phainon looked *tired*, there were little dark spots on his shoulder and a redness to his cheek. That smile was shallow and forced, meant to reassure and conceal. It was too much like the smile Phainon had shared with him the first time they really spoke, when they shook hands and agreed to Phainon's servitude on the ship, no more than a mask.

"Lord Phainon!" Hyacine greeted, and she rushed to hug him. He scooped her up and hoisted her off her feet to twirl her in a circle.

Mydei was jealous for the second time that night.

"When Aglaea told us-"

Phainon shook his head and let her go. "It's fine, Hyacine. I can explain more later when we're safe but… I'm glad it happened. Where's Cipher?"

“Lady Cipher told me to tell you, Lord Phainon, that she will not be going with us,” Castorice relayed with a slight tremor in her voice, “she came to tell me that someone would need to hide our absences, lest the Council assume we were kidnapped and try to pursue, or worse, assume we were traitors and try to harm Lady Aglaea. She also told me to tell you: ‘leave the treasury door unlocked’ and that you would understand what she means.”

If Phainon didn’t, Mydei certainly did. With that superpower speed of hers, she could empty the Kremnos Treasury at her leisure once Nikador was dead and the coreflame retrieved if the vault door were unlocked.

“We should go,” Mydei urged, “Leonnius, run ahead, tell Hephaestion and Krateros to make ready to sail. This city will be awake soon.”

Castorice reached for one of Phainon’s hands, but Mydei grabbed his sleeve, holding him back. Both heirs looked at the prince with puzzled expressions and Hyacine’s eyebrows shot *straight* up.

He cleared his throat. “Deliverer, a moment.”

Ptolemy offered both girls one of his hands each and they giggled and ignored him to hold hands with each other instead. They skipped ahead, heads leaning close to each other as they whispered among themselves.

“Alas, I feel I may have deserved that,” he mumbled, clearly unbothered as he followed them down the road.

“Mydei?”

“Phainon, are you well?” Mydei asked.

He laughed, “Should I not be?”

“You’re leaving your home again; you have every right to be upset.”

“What do you mean, Mydei?” Phainon teased as he started walking, “we’re going home right now.”

-

Phainon hadn’t expected Mydei to be so stunned by what he had said, but he did mean every word. Okhema was home in the same way Aedes Elysiae was still Phainon’s home. It was a place where a part of his heart belonged, but Phainon had always carried the bulk of that belonging wherever he happened to be at the time so long as it was with good friends. Writing his letter to Aglaea, explaining how he felt he realized that homesickness had shifted, and he found himself longing for the Chryseus Leo, her crew, and especially her captain.

Fortunately, Mydei was easy to break out of stunned silences. Phainon punched him hard in the shoulder, challenged him to a race, and then they were nearly overtaking Leonnius and burying the girls in dust as they ran past.

Mydei did win that one. Phainon was only a little upset.

“Just you know,” Phainon started to say while the Kremnoans got the longboat ready, “only about half the crew are going to be happy to see us.”

Neither of the girls seemed upset so much as a little confused.

“Aren’t they expecting us? Is it because we’re Chrysos Heirs?” Hyacine asked.

“No, Mydei bleeds gold actually,” Phainon said, gesturing to him.

“It is because we are from Okhema,” Castorice observed, “and they don’t trust us.”

“Yeah. It took me a long time to earn my place here with them and some of them still don’t trust me,” Phainon admitted, “but the whole crew knows the plan and why you’re here.”

It had been a very stressful meeting and subsequent announcement. Krateros especially had not appreciated being kept out of the loop, especially when that loop involved retrieving Chrysos Heirs from Okhema. Having one Okheman warrior on board was enough as far as Krateros was concerned. Mydei and Krateros had argued about it up until Hephaestion yelled over them both to tell the old man *why*, that this wasn’t an Okheman infiltration, it was recruitment to reclaim Castrum Kremnos. Krateros had shut up after that and listened intently. He still wasn’t happy, and they didn’t tell him about their intentions for the coreflame, but he at least agreed to continue to follow Mydei’s command.

Even better, Krateros responded well to Phainon’s warrant. Perdikkas had worried that Krateros would try to kill Phainon as soon he learned that their duel was cancelled, but the old warrior had simply shrugged. He still refused to accept Phainon as crew, but he promised to speak to the others and assured them that there was no longer a risk to Phainon’s life from within.

“Don’t worry, Phainon,” Hyacine beamed at him, “we’re here to help, whether they like us or not.”

Castorice smiled and nodded.

“Your chariot awaits, ladies,” Ptolemy called. Leonnius slapped his shoulder, but they still held the boat steadily.

Both Phainon and Mydei held out their hands to the girls, offering strong support as they stepped into the longboat with their things. They waited until the girls were settled and then clambered in beside them to take up the oars.

The anchor was already coming up when they pulled up alongside the Chryseus Leo. Two pulleys were tossed down for Phainon and Leonnius to catch. They hooked them onto matching clasps at either end of the boat and, once secured, Mydei whistled.

“Hold on,” he cautioned and then the longboat lifted out of the water. It was not smooth. It never was being pulled up out of the water like that, but it got the job done and spared them a climb.

Hephaestion and Perdikkas were there to greet them at the rail and pull the longboat in close. They held the edges of both watercrafts tightly together while Mydei and Phainon jumped to the deck. Like before, they held their hands out to the ladies.

“Watch your step,” Phainon advised, cheerful.
The crew were torn between pausing to curiously peek at the guests and hurrying to get underway, only deciding when Krateros came along barking orders and making the decision for them. They were still in enemy waters and there would be plenty of time for gawking later.

“Phainon,” Mydei instructed, “will you take them to our room for now? We need to take advantage of this favorable wind.”

The girls pinched their lips tightly, fighting grins as they elbowed each other at Mydei’s instruction.

“With respect, Prince Mydeimos,” Krateros growled, “I want to meet them before we leave.”

The underlying threat took the shine from Phainon’s eyes. His smile stayed but he was ready to call his sword if anything went sideways. Mydei was ready to fight too, the shine of his gauntlets toyed with the light when he rolled his fingers.

But neither woman minded the hostility. Hyacine stepped forward first with an adorable curtsy. “Thank you for having us!” she greeted, “My name is Hyacine. I’m a Chrysos Heir from the Grove of Epiphany, living in Okhema to help establish The Twilight Courtyard there.”

Krateros blinked. His harsh expression had already dropped in the face of such a friendly greeting.

“And I am Castorice, the Demigod of Death and Chrysos Heir from Aidonia.” She matched Hyacine’s curtsy. “If I may, would it be alright if I greeted you with a hug?”

Phainon tried and failed to keep his smile contained but his pride shone through anyway. His clever friends had managed to circumvent the Okheman issue entirely, were charming, and most importantly, disarming.

Krateros had no idea how to react. But Peucesta beside him did.

“I would like a hug,” he requested in his usual clear but soft voice. Castorice happily set her bag aside and stepped forward to hug him, brief but warm.

“I am Peucesta,” he told her when they separated.

“I’m Hephaestion,” the first mate greeted. He stepped up on Krateros’ other side to sandwich the old man in. “I would also enjoy a hug.”

She smiled ardently and embraced Hephaestion. He squeezed her shoulders appropriately and then let her go to look at Krateros with a smug expression until the old man caved.

"…I suppose that would be alright," he grumbled, that old man bravado crumbling under so many eyes and gentle expectations.

Castorice's hug melted the man's heart so fast that Phainon wondered how much of his own heartache in the last month could've been avoided if he had requested the same on his first day. Probably none of it actually. Phainon might've been executed if he tried that. He was a different kind of cute and Castorice was simply special in a way that he was not. Phainon loved everything about her.

Krateros' tiny smile was *priceless* as he tentatively hugged her back, until he broke it off and she stepped away. He cleared his throat. "I'm Krateros," he finally introduced, "if you need anything while you two are on board, let me know." And then the old man was stomping away, barking orders as though he wasn't an old grandpa at heart with a new favorite.

"Peer pressure always works," Hephaestion said with a grin, "it's an honor to meet you both. Anyone that can sway Krateros so completely is a someone that I'd like to toast."

"After we are away from this place," Mydei reminded him.

"Any trouble in Okhema?" Perdikkas was asking Leonnius.

"Homer over here wouldn't stop flirting."

Ptolemy almost dropped the line he was holding as they pulled the longboat inside the ship so they could set sail. "It's not flirting!"

"'Oh, Miss Castorice!'" Leonnius impersonated in a voice much too high to be Ptolemy. He pressed his hands together and turned his eyes to the sky. "'Are you a goddess or a woman? May I steal your books?'"

"I don't sound anything like that!"

Hephaestion was cracking up. "How many books did you steal, Ptolemy?"

Absolute silence. Ptolemy's jaw slammed shut with a click of clashing teeth and his face turned red.

"I let him take a few of mine," Phainon laughed.

"Yeah, they were offered, not stolen!"

"Oh, Mister Ptolemy," Castorice picked her bag up again and opened it to show him several of her handwritten manuscripts, cheeks matching his shade of red.

Hyacine covered her mouth to giggle, "I think they're going to be friends."

"Phainon," Mydei reminded.

"Of course, captain," he crooned with a mock salute, "I'll get them settled in."

-

Aglaea –

Someday, I hope to be able to tell you all of this in person but hopefully this letter brings you comfort until that time when we are reunited.

I am alive and well and the last person who deserves your worry. When we last spoke, I swore an oath to you to sail into the world hunting the evil that threatened our people, that I would return in glory, worthy of the name you gave me. That oath still holds true for the greater part.

I am still sailing and hunting the worst threats to humanity, but I have failed you in one regard: my loyalty is no longer solely to Okhema and her beauty. Rather I have sailed beyond Kephale's reach and met people as vibrant and lively as our own and equally worthy of protection. They are led by a man that reminds me of you.

I am no hero, but you taught me with words and by example how to be selfless, that our golden blood is a noble calling to set ourselves aside out of love for others. It is because of this that I must apologize for failing the responsibility you gave me. I cannot be Okhema's Deliverer. That title is not meant for me.

When I first read your words and realized that I had been branded a pirate I was hurt, but the fall from captain to pirate wasn't as far as I first thought. I am still me. More than that, I am a version of myself that is somehow more 'free.'

I suspect that it was not your decision. Caenis and the Council have ever opposed the Flame Chase and they likely leapt at the chance to weaponize the law against you. Even so, did you know when you wrote those words, that I would feel that way?

You have always read my heart in a manner that I never could. Have you always known that I have harbored doubts? That I was afraid of letting you down? Did you know that when you made me a pirate that you were giving me the freedom to pursue a noble course? A course that has filled me with such passion that it has redefined for me what it means to be 'home.'

If you did, thank you, Aglaea.

There is a man who I have found out here among the waves. He is the one I mentioned, a pirate captain, and the most honorable, noble soul I have ever met. Like you, he cares deeply, leads fairly, and keeps himself apart in quiet confidence so that he may best serve those under his command. I have found in him a kindred spirit, one that sings in combat and competition, but finds joy in peace.

You taught me to judge a man by how he treats others and Mydei elevates and inspires those around him, he serves them, loves them, and risks his life for their happiness. He is kingly, handsome, and he loves his countrymen so completely that he fights the destiny they want for him with an ardor that exemplifies the Titans of old. I have spoken to his crew, and not only would they die for him, but they LIVE for him, and he has proven to me time and again that he is worthy of that love.

I want you to meet him, Aglaea. Please be patient with me, as you always have been. When the two of us return to Okhema again it will be wreathed in glory, and I will present him to you as the hero he is. More than anything I want you to see what I see in him, this man who deserves the world, who is far more worthy than I of the title, Deliverer.

I believe that you will see into his heart as you have mine, feel the depth of his spirit, and fall for his charms as I have.

My vow to you is still binding and I will give all of me to the flame-chase journey, but I know now that it is at Mydei's side that I may best achieve this purpose that you cultivated within me.

I will earn your pride and be worthy of you. Please continue to wait for me.

Phainon

-

Aglaea read the cookie jar letter three more times, her smile never wavering, never changing, with every pass, as she reclined on her kline with Vigethos curled up in her lap. Her perfectly manicured nails scratched under his collar and around his ruff while he snoozed happily in the peace just before Entry Hour.

Cipher's distraction finally ran its course after bathing almost the entire night. Aglaea knew how much the cat hated the bath and had taken advantage of the opportunity in a heartbeat. And the entire time they soaked, and Cipher chattered to her of halcyon days long past, golden threads wove a symphony. It was a verse in vibrations, singing the tale of four intruders sneaking through her city and leaving with two of her own.

She had waited until they left along the dromas road to tell Cipher that she was tired and wanted to rest, freeing the cat from her soggy fate, believing her mission a success. In a way, Aglaea supposed it was.

"Agy," Tribbie said by her side, "we changed the winds as you requested. Are you sure about this?"

"I am, teacher. Thank you for indulging me. I know it is not easy to command the winds in such a way."

"We are the Demigod of Passages," Tribbie confirmed, "it is our job… Is Snowy okay?"

The little demigod had her hands clasped to her chest; brows pinched with concern. Keeping them in the dark had been the hardest part of this plan. Aglaea felt so blessed to be worthy of the trust from her seniors.

"More than okay, teacher," Agy said, barely above a whisper. She curled her finger in the air and the golden threads that bound the room made themselves visible. They wavered as they moved, glitter in motion, lining every letter on the paper so that she could 'see' every emotion that Phainon had left on the page in ink made of those very same threads.

Mnestia’s coreflame, buried deep in her chest, purred as she read the letter again to herself. The threads quivered vibrantly in their joy, allowing themselves this indulgence in a complicated web of Aglaea’s weaving.

“He is in love.”

Chapter End Notes

Technically Tribbie AND Trianne have made appearances now but I'm not going to add them to the character tags since those have been isolated to cameo style appearances. Aglaea gets one because she's been much more involved with many more appearances in the story than a lot of people realize :3c

Chapter 21: Coreflame Confessions

Chapter Summary

We should probably talk about coreflames...

Chapter Notes

Not a tag update but a chapter total update.
My original outline is in sobbing shambles, the revised one was too optimistic for its own good, and I'm too determined to guess to just leave it as a question mark. No worries though, I'd rather move the goal posts than make cuts or ruin the pacing

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They made it to the room *eventually*. Phainon had gotten distracted halfway there and left the girls by the rail to help with the launch. He was still a part of the crew, and he did apologize profusely for leaving them there while they got the sails unfurled but every time Phainon glanced over they seemed to be enjoying themselves. Neither of them were regular sailors but they had been passengers enough to know how to manage expectations. The two of them were shoulder to shoulder at the railing, pointing at eye-catching features on the horizon as the southern wind gathered them up and sent them soaring away from the holy city.

Castorice was gathering her shawl about her shoulders more tightly to combat the sea breeze when Phainon finally came for them again.

“I’m sorry about that,” he apologized with a grin, “all hands-on deck for the launch.”

“You’re really a part of the crew,” Hyacine observed aloud. She was thoughtful but mildly dismissive, clearly not wanting to start any kind of altercation.

“I’m glad you’re happy, Lord Phainon,” Castorice added to cover for her friend’s misgivings, “I have not seen you so eager to tackle a task since we were all students at the Grove.”

Memories begat smiles and lightened any lingering tensions.

“I want to give you the tour,” Phainon explained, “but I know the others will want to talk to you.”

“I think,” Hyacine started to say as she took Castorice’s hand and they exchanged a brief look, “I think we want to know everything first.”

“That’s fair,” he agreed. He motioned for them to follow and led them to the captain’s quarters, well, his quarters too. Now that Phainon wasn’t in any danger, would he have to move out to sleep with the crew? He hadn’t really considered it until now. Maybe if he didn’t say anything, Mydei wouldn’t consider it either and he could stay.

“This is where Mydei and I sleep,” he said with a broad, sweeping gesture across the room, “and where all the meetings happen, navigation… it’s an all-purpose room.”

The two girls spread out to explore, being polite and resisting the urge to touch anything.

“Do you two share a hammock?” Castorice asked. She blinked her eyes innocently at him.

“No, mine’s over here. The ship isn’t *that* small that we have to share.” Phainon moved to the far side of his room to his own hammock and put a hand on the edge of it. It peeped once and a sleepy Fig Stew stuck his head out, wiggling it under Phainon’s hand with a groggy sigh.

Both girls *squealed*.

The chimera squinted at them and leaned back but the assault he was expecting didn’t come. Castorice and Hyacine approached very slowly, very carefully, and they both offered their hands for Fig Stew to sniff before they tried to touch him, which he appreciated. Phainon scratched gently behind his ears.

“What’s their name?” Castorice asked in an awed whisper.

“This is Fig Stew. He is the ship’s chimera.”

“He’s so beautiful.” Hyacine had little tears budding in the corners of her eyes.

“Just don’t pet his belly. Only people he really likes can pet his belly.”

“Can you pet his belly, Lord Phainon? All the chimeras in Okhema like your belly rubs.”

Phainon sighed sadly, “I’m working on it.” He looked down at Fig Stew. “*All* the Okheman chimeras!”

Fig Stew sniffed each of them in turn, skeptical but curious, and then he sniffed the air, steadily picking up speed until his nose was moving a mile minute and he was standing up in the hammock, awake and on the hunt. He deliberated for about ten seconds and settled on staring at Phainon’s pockets.

“Oh, I stole these from Aglaea’s office,” Phainon remembered. He pulled a couple cookies free and held them up, watching Fig’s big red eyes widen.

“Lord Phainon…”

“I’m a pirate now, remember,” he teased. It still stung a little to say, but joking about it helped. Phainon had willingly embraced it even if it went against the grain he had been raised to follow for so long. Those little aches would probably linger for a while yet.

He handed each of them a cookie so that Fig Stew could consider his choice of offerings. All of them stood shoulder to shoulder, crowded around Phainon's hammock, cookies held out on open palms, holding perfectly still.

With a connoisseurial flair, Fig Stew studied all three cookies. They each got a sniff, a tiny poke of a claw, and a lick. That little brain turned like a windmill until he concluded that they were the same and delicately took all three of them one at a time, beginning with Castorice and ending with Phainon. He dumped the biscuits onto Phainon's bed and messily devoured all three at once, scattering crumbs *everywhere* while the girls fawned over his cookie conquest.

"He looks a little like Lord Mydei," Castorice observed as she reached over to scratch between his shoulder blades with two fingers.

"I thought that too!" Phainon returned.

"Speaking of Lord Mydei," Hyacine invited with a cough, "he isn't what I picture when I think of Kremnoan pirates."

"Really? It's because of the cloak. He has the exact build you'd expect, and he has all the Kremnoan tattoos and that regal bearing from being their Crown Prince. How do I describe it," he fumbled, "almost like if a lion was a person."

"…do you like him, Lord Phainon?" Castorice prodded gently.

"Yeah, he's a good captain. The crew loves him, and he takes care of everyone," Phainon explained, "Mydei is also the ship's cook, so he works just as hard as any of us, maybe even more so. I help him sometimes grinding the wheat for fresh flour and he checks on me a lot to make sure I'm okay. He's strong too. As strong as we are. I know he bleeds gold so he's technically a Chrysos Heir like us, but I believe he could stand up to you in a fight, Castorice."

"You said he's the Crown Prince?" Hyacine asked.

"Did they not tell you when they talked to you?" Phainon asked, genuinely surprised. He sat back on his hammock, nearly sending Fig Stew flying, but the chimera didn't protest and instead scooted up close to Phainon's side.

She shook her head.

"Lord Phainon, I think the stories we were told may have been different…"

"They tried to all tell me things at once," Hyacine explained, "it was cute, but not very helpful."

"And you agreed to come anyway?"

"Of course, Phainon. All I needed to know was that you were the one asking." She smiled at him with sincerity that he had missed more than he realized and his heart melted.

“Well, let me tell you then, everything, the good, the bad, and how amazing this crew really is.”

-

Mydei, Krateros, and Hephaestion got the Chryseus Leo comfortably on course for home. It was the next logical step as it was a good halfway point between Okhema and Castrum Kremnos, they needed to assess supplies, and while there was an impending, unknown deadline with the Black Tide’s steady creeping, rest was also an important resource that needed managing. Mydei was not taking his men into the heart of the Tide unless they were rested and had chosen to go with full knowledge of the plan.

There also needed to be a plan.

And Mydei was not interested in a plan that was cooked up half-assed on exhaustion, which is why he really just wanted to sleep. But every time he paused outside his own door, he could hear three excited voices quietly chittering and giggling away. Phainon hadn’t seen his two friends in over a month. Until recently he wasn’t sure he’d see them ever again *at all*. It would be unfair for Mydei to interrupt a reunion when he himself knew how important those moments of reconnection were.

He pressed his ear to the door, trying to hear just enough to determine how long they’d be and all he could make out was Phainon’s polished voice in unintelligible murmurs. Mydei narrowed his eyes when he thought he heard his own name, but it could’ve also been the exhaustion.

“You know it’s *your* room,” Hephaestion whispered from *directly* behind Mydei. The prince swung a punch on reflex, but Hephaestion ducked in time. “Why are you sulking out here?”

Mydei skulked away from the door and walked all the way out to the rail. They would be away from the Dawn Device soon, not that they’d be able to easily tell with the new day already upon them. With this wind they were making amazing time.

“I’m giving them time to catch up,” Mydei explained.

“You know you could be in there catching up *with* them.”

The lion shook his head. “No, I want Phainon to feel as though he can tell them everything. He may not feel that way if I am there listening.”

Hephaestion leaned on the rail next to him. “Mydei, Phainon is the most understanding person on the ship. You’re still holding onto guilt that he’s forgiven you for.”

“Until I hear him say it-“

Hephaestion groaned loud enough to cut him off. “Mydeimos, my brother, I love you, but you are surprisingly dense when you get in your own way.”

Mydei frowned.

“If it wasn’t Phainon, would you be sitting out here?”

No. Mydei would’ve given anyone else the boot. He shook his head.

“Then why is Phainon different?” Hephaestion asked, poking at the heart of the matter, trying to drag that back burner thought back to the front. Did Hephaestion know? Could his first mate also see whatever Cipher had pulled from the depths of his soul?

“He’s not,” Mydei huffed, pushing it back down. He turned around and strode back to his own room with Hephaestion right behind him. The three Okhemans quieted when the door opened and the two Kremnoans stepped in.

“Mydei!” Phainon greeted and Mydei’s heart started doing jumping jacks. That smile was extra obnoxiously dazzling. All three of them had crammed onto Phainon’s hammock, the nature of the seating pressing them all tight against each other with Phainon in the middle. Mydei had to take a second to remind himself that close proximity was a *friendly* thing, that he was also very physical with his own friends.

“Hephaestion!” Phainon added when he spotted the first mate too.

“Heya, Okhemans,” he teased when Mydei said nothing, “I know this is a reunion you’ve been looking forward to, Phainon, but…”

“I know, it’s late,” Phainon finished with an apologetic furrowing of his brows.

Mydei looked between the three of them and sighed, “Deliverer, you and I will sleep in the crew’s quarters-“

“NO!” Castorice stood up and shouted and the whole room froze, wide-eyed at the outburst. Mydei stood still with his lips parted, he had no idea how to react to that. His fight-or-flight was holding the moment right in the middle of the two options in the space reserved for ‘what the fuck’ happenings and ill-conceived competitive challenges.

The only one that moved was Fig Stew, who rolled into the space she had just vacated from where he had been squished behind them. The chimera had a smug grin slapped on his face looking at everyone with a much too round belly and some kind of crumbs all over his fur.

“I-I just mean,” she fell right back into her soft, demure voice, gentle but insistent, “Hyacine and I don’t need our own room. We couldn’t possibly, when this is already your space…”

“Miss Castorice, I insist,” Mydei tried, tentative, like he was reasoning with a tsunami, “what kind of host would I be if I made you sleep with my men?”

Hyacine stood up next, a little too quickly, the balance in the hammock shifted and Phainon flailed to stay upright.

“Actually, Captain Mydeimos,” she said with that self-assured manner of speaking that Perdikkas used when he was taking charge of a room during a medical emergency, “as a doctor, I think it’s best that I immediately begin adapting to the atmosphere of your ship’s infirmary.”

“As her assistant, I should do the same,” Castorice insisted.

Phainon tilted his head. He was still trying to get out of the hammock. It was genuinely cute and simultaneously stressful. Part of Mydei wanted to hurry to his aid, the much larger part was enjoying watching his struggle knowing he wasn’t in any real danger. He’d figure it out someday, just like the sea legs he had finally developed.

“Since when?” the Deliverer asked.

“It happened while you were gone,” Hyacine said sweetly, and much too quickly.

“There are several beds in the infirmary,” Hephaestion offered, “I can take them so you two can get some rest.”

Hyacine and Castorice immediately locked eyes with Hephaestion and Mydei felt like they were up to something. Somehow. Already. With someone they had barely met. There was too much instant understanding for it not to be the most suspicious non-verbal exchange since Peucesta and Leonnius had set up that betting ring around Mydei and Phainon’s spars.

Mydei sighed, deep and full, defeated and open about it. He was way too tired for this right now.

“Alright, alright,” he relented, “make sure you speak to Perdikkas when he wakes so he knows you are staying there.”

Both the girls curtsied and gathered their things.

“We’ll talk more tomorrow, Lord Phainon,” Castorice reassured him. Not that he needed it. Phainon looked fine, just happy to have spent any time with them at all.

“Sleep well, Lord Phainon, Lord Mydeimos,” Hyacine said with a smile. It *almost* sounded like an order coming from her, the kind you wanted to obey without realizing it. Anything to make her happy.

Hephaestion closed the door behind them, leaving Mydei and Phainon alone.

Phainon groaned as he got up. The exhaustion was hitting him all at once now that the girls were gone and Mydei felt a little special to see him unwind. That public facing mask that Phainon wore was coming off in the comfort of his own space, a space he shared willingly with Mydei. Now that Phainon was no longer in danger, he probably could move to the crew’s quarters… Or Mydei could forget that he realized as much and never bring it up. They were comfortable, it would be a hassle to move all his stuff. Far more convenient if Phainon stayed where he was.

“I am glad to see them,” Phainon admitted, “but I am so tired.”

Mydei grunted and took his cloak off, starting the evening routine. “We are fortunate that we were able to retrieve them safely.”

“Yeah, Cipher must’ve pulled out all the stops to keep Aglaea from finding out.”

"…they're cute," Mydei mentioned quietly.

"Who? Hyacine and Castorice?"

"Yes."

Phainon laughed, "do you have a crush already, Mydei? What *happened* when you went to find Hyacine?"

Mydei turned away to hide his blush. He did have a crush, it just wasn't Hyacine. "HKS! Suggest as much again and I'll toss you in my cookpot."

Phainon's chuckle was music to his ears. He could hear the man undressing, setting aside his armor pieces and putting them away in his drawer. "It's okay if you do. Both of them are amazing, Cipher too. All three of them are like sisters to me."

That was a relief. Phainon wasn't dating any of them.

"I don't," Mydei insisted, "I have… other tastes."

Phainon gasped like Mydei had said something scandalous. "Oh, Mydeimos, could it be that your crystal heart belongs to someone already?"

Mydei ignored him and shrugged out of his armor. Each gauntlet had their own space in an easy to access drawer so he knew where they were at all times.

"Oh, Mnestia, it *does*." Phainon came up behind him and put an arm around his shoulders so Mydei couldn't escape. He was only half dressed when he pressed in close. "Is it Hephaestion?"

"Persistent dog," Mydei snarled. He punched at Phainon, but the man was learning, he dipped to the side to spare his gut the hit and swapped sides.

"Why won't you tell me?" Phainon pouted, "who won the affections of our prince? Do I know him?"

"You will not live long enough to know if you do not go to bed this instant!" Mydei felt like he was on fire. He absolutely refused to look at his friend and rival, just in case he was as easy to read as he feared. If a stranger like *Cipher* could pluck truths from the depths of him, what could he hope to hide from Phainon?

Phainon gasped, "I *do* know him!"

"HKS! What did I just say!?" Mydei growled but Phainon took the hint and backed away to kick off his own boots and wiggle out of his trousers.

"Fine, fine, I'm sure I'll find out eventually."

"Phainon," Mydei said, mostly under his breath, too much like a confession to his own burning ears.

“Hm?”

“…I’ll tell you who it is after we get the coreflame,” he promised. Mydei busied himself with folding his shed clothes as an excuse to keep his back turned.

“I’ll hold you to that.” Phainon’s grin was audible. “AW MAN.”

Mydei spun around, alarmed. Phainon was in his small clothes, holding his pants with the pockets inside out. They were completely empty but lined with toasty golden crumbs.

“How did you eat all of those already?!”

Fig Stew was smiling from Phainon’s hammock, eyelids heavy in the ultimate expression of full contentment, knowing he was the real winner of the night.

-

The tradition of waking Phainon up for meetings continued the following Action Hour when the chatter of several people woke him up. Perdikkas, Hephaestion, Krateros, Hyacine, and Castorice were there, sitting around the table with fruit, cheese, and juice. No yummy, captain cooked meals which made sense considering the captain was not awake.

For once, Phainon wasn’t the last one to the party. Mydei was.

He yawned, stretched, and very carefully swung a leg over his hammock to start the arduous process of sitting up in a sleeping arrangement that wiggled excessively every time he moved.

“Good morning, Lord Phainon,” Castorice whispered. She waved to him using Fig Stew’s paw. The chimera was sitting in her lap, partially on his back with her arm wrapped loosely around his chest so he could make biscuits in the air with all four of his paws. His big red eyes were watching her every move with very slow blinks, and he wagged his tail whenever she smiled back at him. Absolutely smitten.

Phainon managed a lopsided smile and another yawn. “Breakfast?” Hephaestion pushed one of the plates his way.

“It’s more like a late lunch,” Hyacine teased.

“We were up late,” he pouted. Phainon’s chiton had fallen off one shoulder while he slept and he didn’t bother fixing it. Modesty had long gone out the window with the Kremnoans and both Castorice and Hyacine had seen all of him before after a college prank went a little too right. Professor Anaxa had been far more embarrassed and upset than Phainon had been after that one.

He plucked a handful of grapes from their vine to keep in hand while he ate them one at a time. “You two met?” Phainon asked as he pointed between Hyacine and Perdikkas.

“I met them both this morning,” Perdikkas responded, “I didn’t expect them in my infirmary.”

“He thought we were patients,” Hyacine giggled.

“And I am relieved that you are not,” he added, “the two of you are welcome to stay there as long as I don’t have need of those beds for injured people.”

“Perdikkas was the one who stitched up my leg,” Phainon reminded them.

“Phainon showed us his scar last night,” Hyacine said excitedly, “your technique is incredible.”

“It’s just practice, Miss Hyacine.”

“Where’re everyone else?” Phainon asked.

Krateros answered, “sleeping or busy. Ptolemy is in the library reading, Leonnius is sleeping, and Peucesta is covering for the prince in the galley.”

Speaking of the prince… Phainon tip-toed over to his hammock to peek. The Kremnoan was *out*, wearing only a pair of shorts since he tended to run hot when he slept. He was curled up tightly on his side to face away from the room, leaning more heavily to one end of the hammock so he wouldn’t ruin his back with that position. The man was also crying, tiny tears beaded like pearls in the corners of his eyes. Phainon might’ve assumed they were just the usual sleep that gets rubbed away in the morning with a hearty yawn but there were tear tracks on his nose and cheeks and anxious tension in his brow.

He frowned, worried, and a little confused. Mydei was usually up before Phainon, rarely sleeping in, choosing small cat naps throughout the day instead. Those few times that Phainon was awake while Mydei slept, the man was like a rock. He didn’t thrash, he didn’t move, if he had bad dreams, he never physically expressed it… until now.

Phainon reached out to brush his thumb across Mydei’s eyes, to maybe provide some comfort if he could but he didn’t get that far.

“Leave him be,” Krateros scolded, “Mydeimos rarely gets the chance to sleep so heavily.”

He pulled his hand back and went to pick a seat instead, thoughts still drifting to his troubled friend.

“Okay,” Hephaestion started, to get everyone’s attention, “there are a few things we need to discuss before we can start making any real plans and that process needs to be moving. Perdikkas and I are doing inventory today so we can hand the list of things we still need to Empousa. So, what do you three need for the campaign?”

Perdikkas leaned on the table a little. He had a pen there, a small inkwell, and some loose paper ready to record.

“I suppose that will depend on what is requested of us,” Hyacine thought aloud, “Lord Phainon told us last night about his adventures here and about you all, but we didn’t have time to discuss what role you need us to play.”

“Do you need us to fight?” Castorice asked.

“Let’s start with the main problem,” Phainon suggested. He held his hand up to cover his mouth while he spoke, trying to multitask eating and contributing with at least a little bit of decorum. “Castrum Kremnos is very deep inside the Black Tide and it has been for five years.”

“So only Chrysos Heirs can go there,” Hyacine supplied.

“Not exactly,” Perdikkas said, “Phainon told you that we’ve been fighting the Black Tide?”

“He said that you had made strides and were able to push it back somehow,” she clarified.

“We can’t interact with the Black Tide itself,” the doctor continued. He used the pen to point between the three Kremnoans in the room. “But the *ship* can. Chryseus Leo is resilient to the Tide and as long as we stay on it, we’re safe. We *can* get a full crew to Castrum Kremnos.”

“The problem is we can’t leave the ship,” Hephaestion finished, “that’s where you two come in.”

“We have four Chrysos Heirs,” Phainon picked up what was now a practiced discussion, “the three of us and Mydei and Mydei is basically a one-man army. He is incredibly strong, and I told you last night about his immortality.”

“You told us a lot about Lord Mydei, yes,” Castorice confirmed, gently. She was slowly tracing little circles on Fig Stew’s belly, something that Phainon would be very, very jealous about later.

“He and I can fight Nikador,” Phainon said confidently.

“Just the two of you?” Hyacine asked, worry coloring her voice.

“Trust me, we’ve been sparring every day, and we are evenly matched. Mydei could probably take the Titan alone,” he praised, “there is no contest with the both of us.”

It was a fight that Phainon was genuinely looking forward to; one for which he had been preparing. He had some history with Strife, nothing as prominent as his deep-seated hatred and fears with the Black Tide, but Phainon had studied Nikador at length. It was one of his many side interests at the Grove when he still wanted to study combat at Castrum Kremnos, before duty and life had sent him in another direction.

“What we can’t handle, is Nikador *and* the armies of Castrum Kremnos,” Phainon admitted.

“You need me to use my touch…” Castorice mumbled. She hugged Fig Stew a little tighter and the chimera purred to reassure her.

“As the Demigod of Death, you could keep most of the city from interfering,” he told her.

“Hold on.” Hephaestion waved a hand in front of himself. “Aren’t all of you demigods?”

“Only Cassie,” Hyacine confirmed.

“I thought that was what the gold blood meant. That you were Chrysos Heirs and thus, demigods.”

Phainon shook his head. “Chrysos Heirs are people with gold blood, yes, but only Chrysos Heirs that have a coreflame in their chests are demigods. All demigods are Chrysos Heirs, but not all Chrysos Heirs are demigods.”

“Mydei isn’t a demigod,” Perdikkas reminded Hephaestion.

“Right, but I thought Phainon was.”

“Phainon and I haven’t been given coreflames,” Hyacine told them gently, “Lady Aglaea has unclaimed coreflames, but she said we weren’t ready to see them yet.”

Castorice put a hand over her chest. “Coreflames are alive in a way,” she explained reverently, “they aren’t power that can be wielded safely by anyone, like the Council believes, they have chosen their bearers across time. When Lord Phainon and I recovered the Coreflame of Death from Thanatos, it felt like nothing to him, but for me…” Her voice warmed at the thought. “It was like a part of my heart that I didn’t know was missing was restored. It was warmth and comfort and responsibility so great that I thought I would burst with the joy of it.”

“Aglaea told me that when she first held her coreflame, she knew it was hers,” Phainon recounted, “but it wouldn’t accept her right away. She said that knowing that the coreflame was a part of her but that she wasn’t ready for it was so heartbreaking that she almost gave up. She doesn’t want that for us, so Hyacine and I aren’t allowed to see the coreflames until Aglaea knows we’re ready and that we are paired correctly to the coreflame we’re meant to inherit.”

“Do you know which coreflames she has?” Perdikkas asked.

“Sky and Worldbearing,” Phainon said, unsure. He looked to Castorice and Hyacine for confirmation and they nodded.

“We used to guess which ones would be ours,” Hyacine shyly told them, “But not all Chrysos Heirs will get one, and that’s okay. We just want to help, and we can do that without coreflames.”

“Which one do you think is yours, Deliverer?” Mydei asked. The room jumped at his voice. It was hard to tell how long he had been awake. The tears had been brushed away and he looked groggy with wild bed head, but his eyes were alert as he sat up in the hammock and sluggishly twisted to look at them.

“It really doesn’t matter if I get one at all,” Phainon assured them, “I’m plenty strong without one, but I… I always thought Strife might be mine.”

Krateros inhaled sharply through his nose, but he held his tongue. His mood darkened and they could all feel the weight of it in the room, the sudden realization that Phainon had ulterior motives.

Mydei was undeterred. “That suits you. All the more reason to retrieve it,” he said.

Krateros leaned forward to snap, “Mydeimos!”

The prince held his hand up to stop the protesting they all knew was coming. “The greatest challenge will not be Nikador, it will be the armies between us and the Titan. Miss Hyacine, the Deliverer has spoken highly of your research. He claims you can heal Black Tide corruption; would you be able to find the means to allow my people to fight inside the city?”

Undeterred, Krateros stepped in again to shout, “No, you will not have a crew to fight for you if we do not discuss the coreflame!”

The threat lingered uncomfortably in the air. Mydei ran a hand through his hair and Phainon immediately wanted to do the same. Was it as soft as it looked?

“What use have we for it?” Mydei asked very seriously.

“I was led to believe that we were retrieving the coreflame for the glory of Castrum Kremnos,” the old man insisted.

Mydei sighed at the inevitability, “Krateros, that is not entirely true.”

The old man’s eyes widened as he looked between everyone seated there. Only the girls met his gaze, equally confused, the rest… “Was this the plan from the start? To give the essence of our Titan to the Goldweaver? So, your new favorite can play god?”

“This was always about Phainon’s pardon,” Mydei confirmed, “but we are not without benefit, Krateros, reclaiming the city and felling the Titan will silence the Tide and protect our people for many years to come. Is that not worth it?”

“This is the Crown all over again, Mydeimos! Will you reject the divine authority that should be your birthright too?”

“Did you not hear them? The coreflame chooses. For all we know that is what drove my father to madness, trying to force the coreflame’s decision.”

“This is not the future Queen Gorgo would have wanted for you!”

Mydei stood then with a growl. “My mother is dead!” he reminded his teacher, “do not use her to further *your* wants.”

Fig Stew cooed sadly, watching Mydei intently. Phainon looked over at the sound and saw the chimera’s eyes alight. Castorice was studying the chimera with a frightening intensity. He needed to stop this fighting, whatever it took.

“I won’t accept it,” Phainon said firmly, and the room went quiet, “if it is mine, I will reject it.”

“Lord Phainon-!” Hyacine started to say.

“Please believe me, Lord Krateros,” he said with a hand over his heart, “this endeavor is not to further my own ambitions. But I did keep my intentions from you and the captain and you are owed the full truth.” Mydei’s eyes narrowed, Hephaestion leaned forward with suspicion. “I know it was the plan for me to take the Coreflame to Okhema to exchange it for my own pardon, that is what Mydei, and the others wanted, but it was my intention from the start to petition not for myself but for the entire crew and for peace between Okhema and Kremnos. Even if the Coreflame of Strife is meant for me, I will reject it, to prove to you that this mission is not for me alone but for all our peoples.”

There was silence. Krateros was still shaking in fury, Mydei looked annoyed. Maybe that was a truth best kept to himself, but Phainon held his ground all the same.

“Do you really believe that I *need* the power of a Titan to lead our people, Krateros?” Mydei growled, backing Phainon up from another angle.

“With that power we could *win* our war with Okhema,” Krateros grumbled, but he sounded unconvinced.

“We have no war with Okhema!” the prince hissed, “our war is with the Tide!”

Krateros faltered under the reminder.

“Lord Krateros,” Castorice said and she commanded his attention, “I may understand more than most how you feel. Would it be alright, if we spoke in private?”

He looked at her and then down to where she was petting Fig Stew’s belly. The tension in the room remained but it plateaued. “So long as you know my mind will not change.”

She smiled and Phainon knew Krateros had no idea the kind of challenge he had just thrown to her. “I only wish to understand you, Lord Krateros.”

“…very well,” he agreed.

Castorice stood up on the spot, unwilling to wait. She delicately set Fig Stew down on the floor and then reached to take Krateros’ hand. Caught off guard by her gentle demeanor he took it, and they excused themselves to speak.

“Someday,” Hephaestion sighed, “he’s going to die in his sleep of old age, and we won’t have to worry about him anymore.”

Perdikkas smacked Hephaestion across the side of his head, hard, beating Mydei to it.

“That’s rude,” the doctor scolded.

“I stand by it,” the first mate grumbled.

“To answer your question, Lord Mydei,” Hyacine said. Her hands were in her lap as she fiddled with her thumbs. “I *can* heal corruption from the Tide, but I cannot prevent it. That was not my topic of study. A place as saturated as Castrum Kremnos… I don’t think I would be able to heal your men fast enough to allow them to fight and I know I wouldn’t be able to prevent the corruption.”

The Kremnoans tried not to show their disappointment, but Phainon saw it in their changed postures. Even Fig Stew slowly star-fished on the floor in chimerical grief.

“But I know someone who can,” she said, “and he’s a Chrysos Heir too.”

Phainon immediately brightened when he realized who she was talking about.

“Do we need to return to Okhema for him?” Mydei asked.

“No, he’s right where we saw him last,” she announced, smiling at her fellow graduate.

Mydei flashed him a puzzled look and Phainon grinned back to say, “we’re going to the Grove of Epiphany.”

Chapter End Notes

Krateros is not a bad guy. I LOVE him in the game but he's also a stubborn old man and stubborn old men need a lot of convincing to abandon the only course of action they've ever known

Also, Castorice and Hyacine aren't ENTIRELY self-inserts but they are certainly relatable

Chapter 22: The Grove of Epiphany

Chapter Summary

New character tag: Anaxagoras

The crew arrives in the Grove of Epiphany! Well, most of the crew.

The Grove of Epiphany had fallen to the Black Tide a couple years prior. Long enough ago to have already decayed into a shell of its former self with no hope of any population remaining but recent enough that Phainon had been at its downfall. He had helped with the evacuation and had even argued with the man they were going to collect, trying to convince him to leave with the rest of the scholars. A man that all three Okhemans insisted was alive, well, and probably very happy to have been alone for the last two years.

Mydei was having a hard time envisioning a man like that as someone respectable. All he could picture was a crankier version of Krateros, perhaps with a hunch, and thinner… with glasses, yes, there were definitely glasses involved somehow. Was this man eating? Bathing? Isolation without the Black Tide could drive a man mad, with the monsters and the mist…

“You wanted to speak with me?” Krateros asked from behind him. Mydei was on the top deck, leaning over the railing to keep watch over the rest of the ship. Lazy days meant more free time for the whole crew so only about half of his men were actively working on their chores.

On deck, Mydei could spot Hephaestion taking a nap with a book on his face, hear Peucesta writing a new song, and see Perdikkas buffing some dents out of his shield. Most of his attention was on Phainon and Leonnius who were playing games with the girls, some sort of team tag that involved running around the foremast and main mast.

“To apologize,” Mydei confirmed without turning around.

“There is no need.”

“Yes, there is.”

Krateros stepped up next to him. The old man had mellowed out considerably after talking to Castorice, neither of them were willing to divulge any details about the exchange and Mydei didn’t really care what was said. What mattered was that Krateros was calmer, more receptive, like he was at least *trying* to set aside himself for a bit to consider the bigger picture. He was still stubborn and grumpy, but at least he wasn’t egregiously obstinate anymore.

“You have been advising me my whole life,” Mydei said as he turned around to face his mentor, “since Phainon, I have been pushing you aside, kept you in the dark, for *that* I apologize.”

“I accept your apology, Mydeimos,” he said, still a little cold, but Mydei smiled at him and leaned back to hit his arm playfully anyway.

“What do you think of the two of them?”

“Miss Castorice and Miss Hyacine?” Krateros asked for clarification. He stepped up to the railing to watch them play too. Mydei nodded and rested his hand on the rail.

“I wonder how the Goldweaver managed to ensnare them. They are too honest and good for Okhema,” he said after a moment to think about it, “…perhaps Phainon is as well.”

“I did not expect you to change your opinion of him.”

“And I have not. Not yet,” Krateros reiterated, “but he keeps good company. Present company included and that is the mark of a wise man.”

“I am glad that Castorice has tamed your fire even a little.”

“Fig Stew has deemed her worthy.”

“A chimera’s word treated as law,” Mydei laughed once, a sharp bark like he couldn’t quite believe it even if such had been the case as long as he could remember.

“He was your mother’s,” Krateros reminded him, “for all I know, Queen Gorgo is still with us through him. And *she* trusted his judgement. How can I not do the same?”

It was silly but comforting to think about.

“Krateros… about the coreflame.”

“You don’t need to explain, Mydeimos,” the old man sighed, “I don’t believe that Phainon is worth this effort and I can’t be sure he will keep his word until I see the two of you return with the coreflame in hand, but that he is willing to set himself aside for the Kremnoan people… it speaks volumes.”

“After everything he has *already* done, he still hasn’t earned your trust?”

“Someone needs to be wary of the Goldweaver and her influence, if no one else will be.”

Mydei sighed and ran his fingers through his hair, eventually letting the hand fall to the railing next to the other. At least Krateros’ problem wasn’t with *Phainon* as much as it was the person that once trained him and held his leash. He leaned forward to rest his weight on his forearms to ask, “What will it take?”

“I suppose I will know when the time comes,” Krateros mused.

“Then I hope it comes soon,” Mydei admitted, “when we win and seize the coreflame, when we are sure that he has his free agency again, I intend to ask him to join the crew.”

The old man sucked a deep breath in through his nose, a sure sign that he was not surprised but still displeased and trying to control himself. “He is not Kremnoan.”

“He is the embodiment of Strife, Krateros,” Mydei praised, smiling at Phainon. How could he not with the pure joy that the man brought with him wherever he went? Leonnius had tackled him, and they were play wrestling. Both the girls were cheering them on like they had picked champions in a noble scuffle.

“He is Okheman.”

“Will you keep pretending he is then? His own introduction claims another homeland entirely and the Goldweaver rejected him as their Deliverer. Even if we restore his status, do you really believe a den of distrustful snakes would embrace him as such again?” Mydei asked, “he is as free as we are, and he is Strife as Nikador should be, strength, honor, reason, tenacity, and sacrifice used not for conquest but as a shield. The coreflame would be foolish to reject him.”

Krateros crossed his arms. “I know I can’t change your mind, but I urge you to consider what it means to your people, what *they* see when this creature of Aglaea walks away with a relic that is at the heart of our people. It is bad enough that we must wait for you to take up the crown, must we surrender our Titan’s spirit? Or do you expect us to follow it to seek solace in the arms of our once ancient enemy?”

Mydei pulled away from the rail and slowly walked to the apulstre where his favorite carving was. Fig Stew was on his usual midday napping crate there too, close enough to the carvings to see the resemblance with the faded lions beside him. He could hear Krateros following across the deck, staying close to keep their conversation but giving him space to be respectful of their stations.

Mydei put his hand on the carving of Nikador and Kephale. “In far more ancient times our Titans were allies,” he reminded Krateros, “of all the traditions and legacies we keep, let us not forget that most important one.”

“If Gorgo could see you now,” Krateros mumbled but his tone was measured, caught between disappointment and praise, like even he wasn’t sure which to feel.

Mydei scratched Fig Stew’s belly and the chimera purred and woke up enough to check who it was. Content, the critter rolled himself over to give his favorite person and those perfect tummy scratching gauntlets better access.

“I wish she could,” he dreamed aloud, “I would want to tell her about Phainon.”

Krateros huffed, angrily admitting, “I am sure she would be charmed by him and then would demand he stop distracting the crew from their duties.”

“Duties I must attend to as well,” Mydei agreed. He gave Fig Stew one last pat and then took a deep breath in through his nose and out through his mouth. “I trust you to keep her sailing smoothly while I am below.”

“As always, Mydeimos.”

Mydei walked quickly with purpose but not hurried towards the stairs that led down to the galley, stopping at them to yell at the squabbling crew.

“Deliverer!” They all froze and looked over at him. The tangle of limbs on the deck had at some point absorbed Peucesta as well. “If you have time to play then you have time to help me in the galley.”

“This is hardly play, captain!” Phainon called back.

“Yeah, he promised to teach us a lesson!” Leonnius yelled from the top of the pile.

“How are they going to learn if I am pretending at chef?”

“Give yourself more credit,” Mydei huffed, “but fine, stay the lines, Deliverer. Miss Castorice, Miss Hyacine, passengers earn their keep on my ship. If you are willing, I would be grateful for more hands, and perhaps you can teach me the trick to commanding this troublesome dog on my crew.”

Castorice looked down at Phainon who was still very stuck and trying to yell back but Peucesta’s foot somehow ended up under his chin and he was struggling to wheeze out any banter.

“We do know a few things we could share, Lord Mydei,” she called mischievously.

“Good luck, Phainon,” Hyacine teased and then she was trotting with Castorice across the deck to catch up.

The confused, playful panic on Phainon’s face was cuter than Mydei would ever admit out loud.

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The Grove of Epiphany was several days away in the middle of the Black Tide’s massive tide lines but even without the added ick, it was an overgrown mess to sail through. They had to wait for the natural ocean’s high tide to even approach the island because of the mass of roots and growth that were hiding under the water. In the two years of abandonment the forest had overgrown beyond the natural pruning and care of her gardeners. Now she was a trap for any watercraft that did not plan accordingly.

The myth claimed that the forest that surrounded and covered the island was all part of a single tree. Its expansion even into the ocean to blend with the seaweed forests was regarded as a metaphor for the adaptive pursuit of learning even beyond natural limitations. Looking at the island from afar, Mydei believed the rumor. The Tree of Cerces was impossible to mistake. She stood above all other vegetation, a mountain among them with the great crown

of foliage perched atop her face on the curling trunk, massive enough to cradle this small city of learning and her universities.

The crew were quiet when they first approached the island, observing with reverence this place of pilgrimage now fallen to ruin. Kremnoans may not have valued research and study as highly as other cultures, but they recognized a temple when they saw one. And it was always humbling to see the gem of a nation brought low.

“To oars!” Krateros called when they approached and the men hurried from the rail, even Phainon ran below, leaving the two ladies to watch with bated breath. Leonnius scrambled up the shrouds, taking position at the topmast to scan for shallow surprises.

The ship rumbled, it was very brief, but Mydei felt it through his boots. They were already brushing against underwater debris, and they hadn’t sailed into the tree line yet. Silently he dropped into a crouch to put his hand on the deck, eyes closed. It was so subtle, but it was there, the brush of roots against the hull.

Mydei immediately walked to the tiller, snapping once to get the helmsman to step away and he took the tiller himself. It wasn’t that he didn’t trust the helmsman, the man was an experienced sailor but there were some situations that called for a different hand.

The crew universally agreed that Mydei had the strongest connection to Chryseus Leo, more so than most captains may develop with their ships. Mysticism wasn’t the right word for that relationship, but no one really knew how deep that bond went to describe it, not even Mydei, and it didn’t matter most of the time. When situations called for a steady hand, the prince was quick to take control of their home.

The only sounds were relayed calls, the oars dipping shallowly in the water, and the creak of the hull. No animal sounds, no insects, not even monster calls. Mydei stared at Leonnius unblinking, noting the turn of his head, when he paused, to anticipate each shout and make micro adjustments as needed. He mapped the forest in his head as branches caressed the hull, slowly weaving them between trees, until *finally* they found the pier and came to a stop.

Mydei let out the breath he was holding and nodded at the helmsman when the man looped ropes around the tiller to secure it. The bay was at least cleared of debris, or perhaps it simply hadn’t grown this far in yet. There was room to maneuver around the long pier with their pick of moorings. Krateros suggested one towards the end of the long dock and Mydei agreed. It was safer to stay at the depth they knew was safe, than try to save time and run aground in their hubris.

It only took a few minutes for practiced pirates to secure the ship and lower the ramp. Mydei met Phainon and the girls at the rail, a pace away from their exit.

“Do you know where he will be?” Mydei asked.

“He had a lab up at the university,” Hyacine explained, “I was his teaching assistant, so I know how to get there quickly.”

“You don’t think he would’ve moved to Professor Socrippe’s lab?” Phainon asked.

“He likes when things are consistent.”

“Yeah, but he *hated* Socippe because he got extra funding to expand his workspace.”

“Lord Phainon, do you really think Professor Anaxa is that petty to steal his rival’s laboratory at the first opportunity?” Castorice asked. The three of them thought about that for a second and then they all nodded at once. “Saying it out loud, it does make sense…”

“We can check both places,” Mydei reassured them.

“Splitting up would be faster,” Hephaestion suggested. He had very suddenly appeared in their circle, fully geared, holding a spear with his shield strapped to his back.

“Yeah, we can take Miss Castorice and Phainon,” Perdikkas recommended. They were already starting to herd the two of them towards the ramp, Phainon excitedly taking the hint to skip ahead before Mydei realized what was happening. The vaguely hedgehog shaped hoard of Kremnoans were trying to sneak off the ship in a phalanx formation as though their shields were enough to hide them from his ire.

“No,” he said firmly.

“Oh, come on!” Ptolemy shouted from somewhere inside that collection of spears and feet.

“We only need a small group.”

“Welp, you heard him,” Hephaestion ordered as he started down the ramp after them, “everyone back on the ship.”

“Hephaestion, you too.”

“Mydeimos,” he whined, “I had to stay behind last time.”

“Someone needs to be in charge.”

“Krateros can do it! Who is he going to declare war on this time?” the first mate argued as he gestured to the empty shipyard.

Mydei sighed and turned back to the deck to call out, “Krateros!”

The old man’s head poked out of the formation that was already on the ramp. He was wide-eyed, trying to appear very small in the hopes that their commander in chief would forget that he had just asked for him.

Surprise stunned Mydei for half a second. “You too, teacher?”

“Your Highness, it *has* been a long time since the men have had a proper battle and the Tide’s mist has receded, how does this differ from our campaigns to push back the Tide?”

Mydei crossed his arms. This was a losing battle. The men were just going to swarm off the ship the second he left anyways. Almost the *entire* crew were trying to give him puppy dog

eyes through the gaps in their formation. It was jarring, obnoxious, and it made Mydei want to say no but they were all dressed up as proper Kremnoan warriors, itching for a fight, and the distraction could help thin the monsters at the school.

“Fine, under one condition.” Everyone leaned in. “Ptolemy is confined to the ship.”

“*What?!”* Ptolemy cried. His head poked out next to Krateros’. “*It’s a giant library, Mydei! Think of all the books that need rescuing!”*

Ptolemy outing himself had the formation immediately turning on the man like a body rejecting a transplant. They scooped him up, passed him up the line, and tossed him back onto the ship into the waiting arms of Hephaestion and Leonnius. They were trying really hard not to laugh at their friend as they hurried to catch him before the book hoarder could leap off the ship against orders.

“It’s okay, Ptolemy!” Perdikkas snickered, “we’ll bring one back for you.”

“You heard him, Ptolemy!” Leonnius was trying to say around his wheezing, “this is for the greater good!”

“We appreciate your sacrifice, Ptolemy!” someone else called.

Another yelled, “You have plenty to read already!”

One man tossed them a rope.

“You’ll sink the ship with paper if you had your way!” yet another playful taunt.

The librarian kicked as he was dragged backwards towards the crew’s quarters by his arms, heels squeaking across the deck as he went, still yelling and pleading, “*They’re sitting there UNREAD! They’re drowning in dust! They need meeeee!”* Half the crew saluted, the other half roared with laughter and cheers.

“Lord Mydei, will he be alright?” Castorice asked, nervous. She was watching the door where the three men had disappeared and furrowed her brow when Hephaestion and Leonnius emerged without Ptolemy.

“We will untie him when we get back,” Mydei casually reassured her. “We would lose him to the shelves if he went.”

The crew were excitedly swarming off the ship, all spears and shields and excited war cries. Peucesta had already started playing an anthem at double speed. Phainon was in that hoard somewhere. What a lively mess. He followed them more slowly, offering a hand to each lady so they wouldn’t trip over the step onto the ramp.

“Only one rescue per day,” he joked with a serious expression.

“I’m not sure Professor Anaxa will see it that way…” Hyacine sighed.

Castorice matched her vocal expression with a gentle exhale of her own. “We can hope.”

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Phainon's memories of the Grove were complicated, just like they were for Castorice and Hyacine. There were good memories of falling asleep studying, the debate championships, finding exciting new reading material, college pranks, that time he tried out for an exclusive club and ended up getting caught by faculty while streaking across campus at night. Almost all of those memories featured his best friends. But those recollections had bittersweet edges when those same study halls, dorm rooms, and courtyards had been touched by the Tide, shadowing any fond feelings with frightened screams and flashing images of destruction.

The monsters had landed ahead of the roiling mist, giving many of the scholars a chance to escape. Phainon remembered a rushed and bloody day of racing through lecture halls searching for survivors and escorting them to the harbor. He was a more experienced hero then, but it had still been an emotional experience. Tearful and angry begging had not swayed every stubborn soul and Phainon's hopelessness at the time had mirrored how he felt in Aedes Elysiae.

Okhema had welcomed everyone who had been displaced but many still regularly petitioned Aglaea for permission and protection to return for the Grove's wealth. No other library in the world rivaled this library's collection of knowledge, research, and readables.

Poor Ptolemy.

Phainon had felt bad watching his friend get pulled away from what was probably the man's ultimate vacation hotspot, but he understood why Mydei made the decision. Ptolemy would've had them dragging whole shelves back to the ship, possibly sinking it in the process. As it was now, they had their hands full without having to babysit their own librarian.

The Kremnoans had descended on the Grove with excited voracity. Everyone had battle buddies that they stuck to, keeping in small groups or pairs as they roamed, slaying monsters as they came upon them. While the crew didn't have *all* day to explore, they weren't in a rush either. The Black Tide wasn't expected to roll back over the Grove for a few Entry Hours, and low tide wasn't until Curtain-Fall Hour.

Hopefully, it didn't take that long to find the Professor but there was time to be thorough.

While most of the crew had spread to systematically clear the lower levels of the city, Phainon had paired with Perdikkas and Castorice to run directly to the school. Mydei, Hyacine, and Hephaestion had done the same but taken a different route to check other classrooms, leaving Phainon's group to head directly to Professor Anaxa's office. An unspoken fear lingered between the three of them as they ran along cracked walkways and collapsed pillars: was Anaxagoras still alive? Was he still himself?

Chrysos Heirs were not *immune* to the Black Tide's corruption. Highly resilient yes, immune to small doses, maybe, but *living* in the Tide? Even if the mist pulled away for days at a time, it still returned and blanketed the Grove for just as long as it had been in remission with each surge. That's to say nothing of the roaming monsters.

Castorice was more than capable of placating the monsters with her powers, but Phainon and Perdikkas still slew them as they found them. It was a mercy to do so as quickly as they could, when they could to free the tortured souls.

“How many *stairs* are in this Titan’s damned place?” Perdikkas huffed.

“It is not much farther,” Castorice insisted.

“Those scholars must have looked like warriors by the time they graduated with all this up and down!”

Phainon grinned at him, “Does the Kremnoan need a break?”

“Keep talking, Phainon, there are plenty of places around here for you to ‘trip.’”

It was a good warning as well as a threat. Phainon very nearly lost his footing on a raised root, but he rolled with his ankle and avoided lasting injury.

“Perhaps we should take it slower this close to the canopy,” Castorice suggested.

“We can’t,” Perdikkas insisted. He was still power walking around the growth, pulling ahead towards a door that was hanging off its hinges. Nature had ripped this one free as it grew unchecked. Phainon considered it a humbling reminder as they squeezed through the gap at how small humanity really was compared to the raw power of the Titans and the natural world.

“We can’t let Mydeimos find the Professor first,” Phainon explained.

“…men,” she sighed, but her pace quickened all the same.

Anaxa’s office was deep in a wing set aside for the Nousporist’s school. Even if each school of thought was embraced equally on paper, the Grove had gone out of their way to set this one apart from the others. Cerces valued all forms of academic pursuit, even blasphemous ones, but men were only begrudgingly tolerant of the blasphemy taught by Anaxa. The Professor found the entire situation humorous and embraced the solitude provided by the physical exclusion.

As one of the seven sages of the Grove, Anaxa still had a sizeable budget to fill his office with equipment, books, research materials, and even a small living space. Phainon remembered accidentally stumbling upon their professor late one night while he was heading back to the dorm after a late study session. The man had been dressed in a dromas themed onesie shuffling between the cafeteria and his office with murderous exhaustion in his eyebags and a mug of something that smelled suspicious in his hands.

“Well,” Phainon said as he walked slowly around the room. “It still looks lived in.”

“A Black Tide monster wouldn’t keep a human routine,” Perdikkas confirmed, “he may yet be himself.”

“That is wonderful news, Lord Perdikkas.” Castorice was speaking softly, her hands gently roaming over the spines of books and scrolls that were left in arbitrary piles. Phainon could see her out of the corner of his eye weighing a couple that were covered in dust, which did remind him to pick one out for Ptolemy before they left.

Phainon wandered over to the unmade bed and touched it, sliding his hand under the blankets. “Cold,” he reported and then he checked the chair at the desk as well. No dust but no warmth either. “He hasn’t been here recently.”

“Where else might he be?” Perdikkas asked. He was slipping a small tome into his pocket and trying to be sneaky about it.

“His lab. This way.” Phainon took the lead this time. The hallways were narrower, curved, with lower ceilings this deep inside the school. Monsters were around every corner, so they kept their silence to more quickly dispatch them.

Phainon paused around one such corner. This was a crossroads he knew, Anaxa’s lab was not far ahead but there was a lurking presence he couldn’t see down the other forks. He held his hand out to signal to the others to wait while he listened.

Black Tide monsters varied in size and strength. There were a few types that could be genuinely threatening, nothing that Phainon couldn’t handle of course but he was worried in close quarters about Castorice and Perdikkas. As a demigod, Castorice could assuredly deal with anything they ran into swiftly, but she couldn’t use her touch in these tight hallways without negatively impacting her comrades around her. Perdikkas was a solid fighter, but his shield and spear were designed for teamwork and practiced formations. In a hallway he was severely limited to what he could do.

Phainon squeezed the handle of his sword, doing the math in his head when footsteps from another direction caught his attention. One elite roaming monster he could handle but two at once? The angle of the hallway did not allow him to easily peek to see what they were dealing with, but it was glaringly obvious from the subtle breaths and shifting weight of presence that two of the other three hallways were occupied by something incredibly dangerous.

He turned to point, communicating with gestures that Castorice and Perdikkas needed to take the monster in the tight corner while he surged ahead to the farther hallway. When they both nodded their understanding, Phainon pulled his sword in closer to his side. He took a deep breath in through his mouth, nice and slow, no sound. Every muscle was coiled, ready. The air was charged but still. Each monster sounded like they too were waiting.

No time like the present.

Phainon slid around the corner with a battle cry, swinging his greatsword in a grand arc to clash right onto the back of Mydei’s gauntlet with a shower of sparks. It took all of two seconds for everyone’s shouts to turn into awkward echoes while they processed each other.

“Mydei!” Phainon broke the stunned silence with a cheerful greeting. This was a welcome surprise. “I thought you were a Black Tide monster.”

“HKS,” Mydei huffed. He slapped Phainon’s sword away.

“We almost skewered the both of you!” Leonnius growled. He pulled his spear up and tapped the floor with the butt of it. Peucesta and Leonnius had come pouring out of the third hallway. No monsters at all.

“Why aren’t you helping clear the city?” Hephaestion asked the pair.

Hyacine waved at Castorice and skipped up to her to trade information while the three groups mingled. Perdikkas was scanning everyone for injury, Peucesta was doing a head count with his fingers, and Mydei had crossed his arms to hide his embarrassment at mistaking his own people for enemies in the moment. Phainon could see the little bit of color in his cheeks and his ears.

“It’s done already,” Leonnius reported and Peucesta nodded, “there weren’t as many monsters as the other islands.”

“That makes sense,” Phainon added. His sword burst into bright blue dust as he tucked it away. “When we helped evacuate, the only people who were left to turn were particularly stubborn scholars.”

“Like your Anaxa,” Hephaestion confirmed.

“You didn’t completely wipe out the Tide before the mist came through, right?” Perdikkas asked. Phainon shook his head. “Then the army we are fighting is likely the leftover soldiers, abandoned by the Tide to keep control of this territory.”

“Did you find your man?” Mydei asked as he scanned the group.

“No, he wasn’t in his office,” Phainon noted with the barest hint of disappointment.

“We checked Professor Socippe’s lab,” Hyacine confirmed, “it had been picked clean but was covered in dust.”

“Leonnius?” Mydei asked, “have you seen any signs of life?”

“Non-Tide life? Yeah, lots of it. Your man is definitely here.”

Phainon grinned, “Professor Anaxa is the smartest person I know. If anyone could live among the Tide, it’s him.”

“The Professor’s lab is up ahead,” Hyacine confirmed. She pointed down the fourth hallway. It was one of the many paths carved from the tree herself, poorly lit and imposing in the wake of the Tide. Peucesta’s lyre twanged, only a few haunting notes to express displeasure but Mydei and Phainon were already stalking forwards, trusting the others to follow.

“I’m at 17,” Phainon purred in Mydei’s direction as they each fought for the lead with long strides.

“19,” Mydei coolly returned with a sideways smirk. He was slowly picking up speed, urging Phainon to match his pace.

“Hephaestion and Hyacine’s kills don’t count.”

Mydei scoffed, “I know that Deliverer! Or are you perhaps counting your companions kills for yourself?”

“Of course not, Mydeimos. You know I would never dishonor our competitions in such a way!”

“Perhaps you should if you are to stand any chance.” The Kremnoan started jogging, barely shy of a run.

“I can let you win this if you need the confidence boost.”

Mydei’s leg shot out to trip Phainon, but he neatly vaulted over the limb and turned around to run backwards, still keeping pace with Mydei’s jog. Was it showing off? Absolutely. But it was still nice to get to look Mydei in his beautiful eyes while he taunted his best friend. “We’re supposed to be hurting the *monsters*, your Highness, not *each other*~”

Phainon yelped when his heel caught on a raised root, and he tripped. All of his momentum shifted into flailing his arms like a drunken bird as he spun about in exaggerated steps to keep his balance. To his credit, he didn’t fall all the way to the floor and only lost a few steps as Mydei surged past him.

The prince was laughing as he broke into a run, “It seems you do not need help taking care of that yourself!”

Wounded pride pushed Phainon red-faced into a sprint to catch up and he finally overtook Mydei at the corner where the hallway split and the home field advantage swung in his favor. He took the left turn a little too fast and they both crashed together into the wall in a shower of tree bark before Phainon was able to slide into Anaxa’s lab ahead of Mydei with a gleeful, “I win!”

Immediately a bolt of green light shot in front of Phainon’s face, barely missing his nose and leaving behind the smell of burning hair. He yelped and jumped backwards into the hallway where Mydei slapped at his forehead to put out the simmering flames at the ends of his bangs before they could become a genuine problem. Phainon slapped back and they smacked at each other for a few seconds before Mydei eased up so Phainon could peek into the room.

“Professor Anaxa?” he called.

The man was standing on the far side of the room with a gleam in his eye. His custom-made weapon, a firearm, was aimed at the ceiling, smoke still curling from the barrel. He miraculously didn’t look any different from the last time Phainon had seen him. He still had the same sartorial preferences, the same pallid skin and hair that bordered on the unhealthy, and that same expression caught halfway between bored and annoyed.

Phainon slowly stepped into the doorway with his hands held up and a reassuring smile plastered on his face.

“Phainon of Aedes Elysiae,” Anaxa growled before he could say anything.

The man brightened at the recognition and then yelped when Mydei wrenched him back into the safety of the hallway by his cape, just in time to save Phainon from another green bolt that bounced past them down the hallway. The two of them pressed their backs against the wall for cover.

“*Rule number one!*” Anaxa yelled, "*It's Anaxagoras*!"

Mydei barked a single laugh from beside Phainon. “I like him already.”

Chapter 23: The Grove's Last Debate

Chapter Summary

Words are a good start but pirate debater, Phainon has a couple tricks up his sleeve.

Chapter Notes

If anyone was part of debate club in HS or at the collegiate level I apologize for my extremely shallow use of debate terms as I hide behind my "creative liberties" sign.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When instinct told Mydei to grab Phainon, he didn't even question it. Mydei's instincts had been honed by repeated deaths, at this point they had earned any and all benefit of the doubt. It was a damn good thing he did because some sort of glowing projectile ripped through the air where Phainon had been standing less than a second prior and proceeded to ricochet down the hallway.

"*Whoa!*" he heard Leonnius shout with unreserved surprise and then the runner's head peeked around the corner where the hallway split …then Hephaestion's, then Perdikkas', then Peucestas', and finally Castorice and Hyacine.

Mydei threw his hand up, gesturing for them to wait.

"*Phainon of Aedes Elysiae,"* the Professor was calling from inside the room. The man had a surprisingly smooth voice, not as deep as Mydei's but not quite as gentle and jovial as Phainon's.

"If I recall correctly," he was saying, "you were an exceptional student."

Mydei's eyes darted to Phainon. The man was still pressed with his back tightly against the wall, nervous sweat beading on his forehead. The fear that flickered across his face was exactly the kind of thing Mydei wanted to poke fun of on good days but the way this Anaxa's voice purred like poisoned honey, maybe Phainon was in the right to harbor that healthy wariness.

"So, what does it say about me, your teacher, that you cannot even remember the *first rule of my class only four years after your graduation?"*

Phainon very slowly leaned forward to peek back into the room. In the most apologetic tone, he could muster he called out, “Professor Anaxa, it’s not-“

Instinct saved Phainon again as Mydei grabbed him by one of the straps on the back of his outfit and once again pulled him behind cover. The shot pinged down the hallway, chasing after the last two. Mydei very carefully pinched out the budding flame at the top of Phainon’s ahoge. This guy was not pulling punches.

“How lamentable!” Anaxa mourned dramatically, “my former student retained nothing of my lessons!”

The follow-up shot bounced by before either of them had a chance to peek at all. Mydei admired the aggression, and was maybe a little afraid, but this was getting them nowhere.

“Professor Anaxagoras!” the Kremnoan called and there was silence from the room. It was impossible to tell if that was a good sign or not. Worst case scenario, his immortal body would take a painful hit from whatever that projectile was, so, Mydei confidently stepped into the doorway to get a good look at the guy who was trying to light his crush on fire.

Anaxa was… delicate, short, and visually young, especially from the far side of the room. He was wearing a cropped in the front, long in the back topcoat over long robes that made his shoulders wider, but the thick belt around his waist, tight sleeves, and formfitting vest gave the scholar away. The man was thin under the loose parts of his clothing. Everything he wore was intricate and fine with gold and red baubles tied in places too specific to be purely decorative. His left eye was covered with a wide patch that covered most of his cheek and almost the entirety of whatever parts of his forehead weren’t already hiding behind his too long bangs. Most of his seafoam green hair was cut at the chin but it was uneven, and a much longer section had gone untrimmed, left to hang over his right shoulder in a ponytail. No glasses, no hunch, no elderly persona.

Most important was the way the man was standing. His body language was open, confident, with his shoulders relaxed and his arm extended, holding the device that was presumably launching these high-heat projectiles pointed directly at Mydei. The other hand was raised to his eyepatch, hovering over it as though he would rip the thing off in a feral fit. His one eye was narrowed with suspicion and thinly veiled curiosity like Mydei had potential to be interesting if he didn’t prove himself a threat first.

“I am Mydeimos, Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos and Captain of the Chryseus Leo,” he introduced. No shooting yet, he must be doing something right.

“Oh?” The weapon drooped to point at the floor, but he kept his hand over his eye. “For what scheme could a Kremnoan possibly need *my* help?”

How the hell did this guy know they were here to ask for help? Was Mydei that easy to read? Did he tip his hand with his introduction?

“Professor!” Hyacine called. She stepped up next to Mydei so Anaxa could see her, but the scholar barely reacted to his former assistant.

Castorice came into the room next, taking up Mydei's other side with a gentle, "It's a pleasure to see you again, Professor Anaxagoras."

He looked between the two of them, drinking them in with the careful assessment of a sommelier sipping fine wine before growling loudly, "see, Phainon? It's not so hard to follow the rules. It's a shame your potential is still so stunted by your glib tongue."

Phainon peeked around the doorframe. "It isn't *that* bad, Professor!"

Anaxa's frown deepened. "If I had known there would be a class reunion I would have cleaned my lab." The sarcasm in his voice had Mydei doubting that statement.

The lab itself was organized chaos, maybe three times the size of Mydei's quarters on the ship and many times taller. Evidence of failed experiments peppered the entire space with burn marks, discoloration, broken shelves that never got fixed, scribbled out notes in heavy ink, and half destroyed cages. He had body parts in jars, suspiciously labeled baskets, books with pages ripped out and stuffed back in, and even half a Black Tide monster that he had somehow managed to preserve slumped in a corner. Arcane imagery was drawn on the floor and even on the back of the man's own hand. The table he was standing beside had massive chunks missing from the corners and was completely covered in layers of notes scribbled on anything even vaguely paper in nature.

Behind him Hephaestion whistled. The entirety of their group was now piling in, driven by curiosity to roam around the lab, looking at everything from behind the safety of their shields.

"…you even provided the rest of the party," Anaxa huffed irritably, "how kind."

"Please don't mind them, Professor," Hyacine said, "they helped us find you."

"You were not easy to find," Hephaestion admitted.

"Consider that was intentional." Anaxa's scowl was bordering on murderous.

"Professor Anaxa…goras," Phainon said as he took a few steps forward. He had one hand on his chest like he usually did when he was trying to put emotion into his next words. "We need your help."

"Naturally," Anaxa agreed without knowing any details or even any basics, "that does not entitle you to my input, nor give you the right to invade my home."

"Respectfully, the Grove is a public university," Phainon argued, "and the biggest standing library on Amphoreus. Would you deny us the pursuit of knowledge?"

Anaxa's expression remained guarded, but Mydei was getting the sense he liked the pushback even if the man was still annoyed with the invasion of his privacy.

"Of course not, I encourage higher learning, especially for those who desperately need it," Anaxa agreed, "but even if the university were still a functioning entity, this is my *private* lab."

Phainon put on his more charming smile, “But Professor, three quints into the Lucid Hour *is* the first of your two office hours when you are available to answer your student’s questions.”

Anaxa’s head jerked to a circular timepiece mounted on the wall to confirm. He very slowly holstered his weapon and turned back to study Phainon with his arms crossed. It felt like an invitation to continue, as though the humor of a silly argument was entertainment enough to be worth the effort.

The rest of the room was quiet as everyone watched these two debate. Mydei saw Peucesta and Perdikkas quickly pull each other close to whisper between themselves before they turned back to watch with significantly more interest than before.

“I don’t see any students in my lab,” Anaxa countered, playing along, “only three alumni who should be out in the world conducting their own research not cowering behind their former teacher’s skirt.”

“But we are, Professor! Was it not you who instilled in us the desire to always be learning? What kind of a student would I be to not follow my professor’s teachings to pursue higher education and seek guidance from the most intelligent sources, especially when it pertains to my current area of study?”

“Really, Phainon? Flattery?”

“It’s not flattery, Professor,” Phainon insisted, “it’s an assessment of available resources to deduce the best logical choice of whom to request advice.”

“Flowery language and an appeal to ego may work on the Council of Elders but I am not so easily cowed.”

“You misunderstand, Professor, it is an appeal to ethos.”

“…I’m listening.”

“Not my own, but yours,” Phainon explained, “there is no other expert qualified to advise us on the nature of the Black Tide.”

Anaxa drummed his fingers on his arm as he contemplated Phainon’s words. Mydei found himself at a genuine loss as well. He had heard that Phainon was a debate champion, and the man was very well-spoken and self-assured around the ship, but to see him excel in yet another element... Mydei was a little turned on. Phainon was incredible on all kinds of battlefields.

Next to him both the girls were smiling, delighted to see Phainon shine again, and his men were still watching intently. The prince narrowed his eyes at them and slowly meandered close to lean into where Perdikkas and Peucesta were keeping personal council to whisper, “five on Phainon.”

“And what interest do you have in the Black Tide?” Anaxa finally answered, betraying his enthusiasm for the topic.

“We want your help preventing Black Tide corruption,” he admitted.

Anaxa scoffed, “start smaller, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, your ambition has led you to unattainable goals and it will crush your spirit to pursue this line of inquiry. A mind such as yours is best spent on other, more achievable things.”

“Don’t doubt yourself, Professor,” Phainon responded cheekily and Anaxa’s eye narrowed, “this is why we came for you.”

“Blind faith in my own work. It has been two years Phainon, what makes you think I have continued my study when it was little more than a pet project, a means to bring variety to my lab?”

“Necessity. You remain here in the Tide line and have managed to avoid corruption, even as a Chrysos Heir, no one can live within the Tide without eventually succumbing. That you are here and yourself is proof that you have been continuing your research on the topic.”

“An appeal to kairos.” Anaxa sounded mildly impressed. “That’s a difficult angle, Phainon, are you sure that’s the method of persuasion you want to play?”

“If anyone can appreciate the quid pro quo of this particular opportunity, it is you, Professor.”

“Then sway me.”

“We have made some discoveries of our own that contribute directly to your research,” Phainon explained, “through experimentation fighting the Black Tide and mapping its expansion over the years.”

“You are not the first researcher to map the Black Tide’s movements,” Anaxa pointed out, “a great many here at the Grove with our vast collection of records have noted the Black Tide’s movements.”

“Then you are aware of the effect that the Northern Campaign of King Eurypon had on the Tide?”

“I am. The Tide’s retreat has yet to be replicated, a single piece of uncorroborated proof is not enough to draw a conclusion.”

Phainon gestured to Mydei and his crewmates, “we have, on a small scale, managed to replicate the results. We have been able to prove King Eurypon’s hypothesis and have been keeping diligent records to prove it.”

For the first time since they arrived, Anaxa started to smile, like a cat that cornered a mouse. “Then you have no need of my research. If the Tide can be made to retreat by force, then you don’t require a means to resist the corruption.”

Phainon shifted his weight, “Not so. Proving that the Tide can be made to retreat is a valuable conclusion, but it is only a driving factor for the specific endeavor we have resolved to pursue.”

“For someone who once told me their lifelong pursuit was to be a hero, should it not be the end goal?” Anaxa asked.

“It is, but our specific task of great magnitude requires bolder, more foolhardy steps. A good scholar must never be overly cautious, right Professor?”

“And what is this endeavor that you have thus far refused to speak of in plain terms?”

“We are going to Castrum Kremnos to retrieve the Coreflame of Strife from the corrupted Titan Nikador.”

The man paused, properly surprised and then he laughed. It started small and then slowly turned maniacal, until Anaxa had to draw a deep gasp for breath. “You need my research to allow an army to lay siege to a fortress city that is drowning in the Black Tide, and you believe that I will eagerly join your efforts because it provides me the opportunity to run experiments that otherwise would be unavailable to me here at the Grove.”

“I do,” Phainon said confidently.

The Professor started to clap, slow and deliberate applause. “Congratulations on another win, Phainon.”

Perdikkas and Peucesta shoved five gold coins each into Mydei’s outstretched palm.

“Then you will come with us?” Phainon asked, a little too eager, too excited.

“No.”

The coins were quickly retrieved and Mydei frowned at both the loss of the gold and the loss of a valuable resource they were here to collect. This trip could not be for nothing.

“Now what?” Hephaestion asked Mydei, but the prince didn’t have an immediate answer.

“Are you not even a little bit interested?” Phainon pushed, even stepping forward a little closer to the Professor in his surprise.

“Naturally, I am, but I have already pursued that research as far as I intended to and have already turned my attention back to my truest passion,” Anaxa explained, “a good opportunity means nothing to me if I have no interest in the initial inquiry.”

Hyacine stepped forward into the space between the two debating men. “Professor Anaxagoras, have you already solved the issue of Black Tide corruption?” He didn’t answer, so she pressed harder. “It is not in your nature to stop researching until you are satisfied with an answer. Are you not interested because you already found that answer?”

The whole room turned to look at Anaxa. His face was as stone, frustratingly blank. He uncrossed his arms and set one hand down on the desk beside him. “I have.”

“Will you give it to us?” Phainon asked.

“No.”

Mydei tsked. An answer to Black Tide corruption would make their nearly impossible task of retrieving the coreflame into something difficult but feasible. Mydei was still willing to go and fight with just the Chrysos Heirs they had already assembled, but a means to minimize the risk to even themselves was not an opportunity that they could pass up.

He crossed his arms and tucked his head to think. Perhaps Anaxa could be swayed in other ways. Phainon may have other angles of debate that he could employ but the Professor had admitted defeat on that front and *still* refused. He didn’t seem like the kind of guy that could be swayed by an emotional appeal, otherwise Phainon might have tried that already. Time wasn’t on their side for an extended stay either, there was no way to win through a battle of attrition. The only other easy option was…

“Miss Hyacine,” Perdikkas said to get her attention, “do you think you could come up with a solution without the professor?”

Anaxa turned to look at them warily. His former assistant was looking between them, face wrinkled with thought before her shoulders slumped and she admitted, “not in a time frame that would help.”

“He is our only chance of fighting beside Mydei and Phainon in Castrum Kremnos,” Peucesta observed, breaking his silence with a mournful tone. His words hovered in the air for a heartbeat before sorrow quickly morphed into resolve.

“Well,” Hephaestion said beside Mydei. He tapped the butt of his spear on the ground, calling the other Kremnoans to attention. “I guess we have to do this the hard way.”

Anaxa scowled, irritably, “brutes always turn so quickly to violence. Torturing me will not give you the answers you want.”

“We’re not going to torture you,” the first mate reassured him, “we’re going to rescue you.”

The other pirates immediately caught on and started spreading around the room, Phainon too. They were strategically cutting off any means of escape.

Mydei sighed. He didn’t like this, but there weren’t any other, better options that could be considered in the time they had left. And they were, after all, still pirates.

“Rescue…?” Anaxa was too surprised by the suggestion and focused on the men surrounding him to be upset when Leonnius interrupted his curious musings.

“Oh no! Do you guys hear that?” the runner shouted through the lab.

“I don’t hear-“ Castorice started but Perdikkas cut her off.

“It sounds like the Black Tide has already returned!” he called as he reached for a discarded rope on the floor.

Anaxa unholstered his weapon but Peucesta had already pounced, tackling the professor to the ground. Less than a second later the other four men were on him in a flurry of protests, dust, limbs, and rope. When the Kremnoans plus Phainon pulled away, Anaxa was bound to a pair of spears with his arms at his sides and the bindings wrapped around his torso from his shoulders to his waist. His weapon was tucked under Peucesta's arm. Phainon and Hephaestion each grabbed an end and hoisted the man up like a prized hunted animal strung up between them with his poor legs dangling uselessly above the ground and the most annoyed expression on his face.

At least the protesting stopped. Professor Anaxa didn't waste his time on people who wouldn't listen, regardless of the circumstances. Instead, he let out the most irritated, long-suffering sigh, accepting his fate and not happy about it.

"Is this really necessary?" Castorice asked, judging by Hyacine's expression, she had similar concerns.

"Don't worry, Miss Castorice, it's a pirate thing," Leonnius explained.

"We practice catch and release," Perdikkas reassured them, "we'll put him right back where we found him after we get the coreflame."

Mydei joined the caravan of people hurrying from the office with their prize, with a pointed, "What happened to no prisoners?" Not that he had any intention of stopping them, but considering the last month, it felt responsible to at least acknowledge the line that they were crossing.

"He's not a prisoner," Leonnius insisted, "besides we already broke that rule with Phainon."

"I'm not still a prisoner," Phainon said, aiming his words at Anaxa as though that would be comforting while he carried his old teacher down the hall. "It's a long story."

"This is still a kidnapping," Castorice calmly observed.

"It's not a kidnapping, it's a rescue!" Perdikkas clarified.

"It does look like a kidnapping," Hyacine added. Her voice was laced with concern but the spring in her step was playful.

"Kidnapping is only for kids, it's in the name," Hephaestion explained, "and besides we're just borrowing him. Kidnapping is when you keep the child."

Anaxa sighed and corrected, "the word you're looking for is abduction. I am being abducted."

"Wow, you fancy scholar types pronounce the word 'rescued' funny," Leonnius teased.

Mydei made a mental note to properly apologize to Anaxagoras later.

-

Phainon really did feel bad about abducting the Professor. He genuinely thought that Anaxa would come willingly after a little bit of buttering up and the presentation of what would've been an incredible opportunity for experimentation. In retrospect, he should've skipped the subtle praise that Anaxa generally hated and gone straight to appealing to the man's insatiable curiosity.

It was Hyacine forcing the Professor to admit that he had completed his research and refusing to elaborate at all that made Phainon jump on board the 'rescue' plan without hesitation.

Completed research didn't guarantee a positive outcome. That lesson was learned after a very frustrating assignment had saddled Phainon with repeated failed results. After losing sleep every night, spending hours redoing the experiment, begging for help from Castorice and Hyacine, even talking to students from the other schools, Phainon almost took the zero, not wanting to submit something that had so completely fallen apart.

He turned it in anyway with a heartfelt cover letter on his assignment insisting he had tried everything and would benefit from an extension to try again. Anaxa had given him full marks and pulled the struggling student aside to remind him that failure *was* a result and that all knowledge was useful. Phainon had carried that sentiment into every aspect of his life, treating failures as opportunities.

So why was Anaxa so reluctant to share his findings? Why not simply say that all his attempts to resist the corruption had failed? If there was ample evidence that it could not be done then they would know for sure, and they could try to find another way to infiltrate the city.

Except that Anaxa *was* proof that the corruption could be resisted. Even Chrysos Heirs would show signs of the Black Tide's influence after consistent exposure for so long, but as Phainon carried his professor back through the university down to the shipyard and up the ramp to the Chryseus Leo, there was no sign of it on his body. Hyacine would know for sure after an examination, but Phainon couldn't feel any trace of the Black Tide on the man, so he *must* have found a way and simply did not want to share it.

They took Anaxa to the infirmary, still bound for now, while Peucesta used a horn to call for the rest of the crew to return to the Leo. An experienced crew, there were no casualties and only minor injuries, not including the general disappointment of how unorganized and infrequent the Black Tide monsters had been. They had been hoping for a more exciting skirmish.

Krateros stood at the top of the ramp taking a head count but the collection of stolen readables could've also sufficed. Every single member of the crew had grabbed a tome or scroll for Ptolemy as an apology for leaving him behind. Although, looking at the list, Phainon worried that the substantial offering was a double-edged sword. Many of the books retrieved had volume numbers printed on their spines. The bookworm was unlikely to be happy to start a series on book three with no hope of seeing the first two.

They only cut Ptolemy and Anaxa loose when the ship left the Grove of Epiphany and cleared the submerged forest. Mydei handed command over to Krateros once the bow was pointed towards home and then the captain met Phainon at the rail.

“Deliverer,” he greeted and Phainon flashed him a smile.

“Sorry we broke the no prisoner rule, again.”

Mydei sighed and rolled his head forward, defeated. “He is your professor. If there were another way, I am sure you would have stopped them rather than helped.”

“I genuinely believed I could sway him with words,” he lamented.

“You did. It was a pleasure to watch.”

“A *pleasure*? Really, Mydeimos? You liked watching my silver tongue wag?” Phainon teased.

Mydei scoffed and shrugged. “It looked like another battlefield to me.”

“It’s not as fun of one as your regular battlefields.”

“You shine on those too.”

Phainon slowly turned to look at his friend with a coy smile. There was pink in Mydei’s cheeks and ears, and the man was avoiding eye contact. “Careful, Mydeimos, too many compliments and you’re like to perish.”

“I am no stranger to giving praise!” he protested, “but if you would prefer that I nag you for your faults we may discuss how your kill count lost to mine *again* and you nearly snapped your neck trying to show off.”

“That is barely a fault! On flat and even ground I can run backwards as fast as you run can forwards!” Phainon insisted, ignoring the indisputable win that was added to Mydei’s tally.

“Prove it.”

“The deck is not flat and even ground!”

“It is devoid of roots!”

“The ship rocks, Mydei!”

Leonnius popped up beside them to say, “if you two are done flirting-“

“*Not* flirting,” they emphasized in tandem.

“…yeah, okay, so Hyacine says that the guy we rescued doesn’t have any corruption, but, uh, there *is* something you two should know.”

Phainon felt his chest tighten up. A thousand worries lanced through his bones all at once and he hoped it didn’t show on his face. Mydei was a picture of composure. How did he manage to do that? The man was always so in control of himself. Phainon knew that Mydei had strong feelings about things, but he schooled his control with such enviable ease.

“They are down in the infirmary, waiting for you two.”

“Thank you, Leonnius,” Mydei said sincerely and started heading that way immediately. Phainon nodded politely to his friend and lightly punched him back when Leonnius tapped Phainon’s chest with his knuckles.

“Phainon, that was pretty damn awesome today.”

He chuckled and shook his head to chase away the blush from the praise, “I had a good teacher.”

“Yeah, well, talk him into spilling his secrets, yeah? We want to be there for you too.”

“I’ll do what I can,” Phainon promised, sincere, before he chased after Mydei.

Anaxa was sitting in a chair in the middle of the infirmary floor when Phainon arrived. His coat was sitting on the bed, set aside for the examination that he undoubtedly tried to decline. He had his arms crossed, one finger tapping furiously at his arm while he tucked his chin. Once, a long time ago, Anaxa had admitted to reciting equations and proofs in his head when he was particularly bored. With his eye closed and his legs crossed at the knee, those equations were almost visible dancing around his ears.

“Hyacine,” Phainon greeted. Castorice was there too, seated beside the first mate behind Anaxa. He nodded in her direction then repeated the gesture for Hephaestion. Aside from Mydei, no one else was present.

The healer offered him a little half wave and then hurried to close the door which immediately put Phainon on edge.

“What is it?” he prodded.

“Professor,” Hyacine invited, “would you like to tell them, or shall I?”

He sighed and rolled his head back to look directly at the ceiling like this was the most obnoxious moment of his life.

“Does this have to do with your research…?” Phainon asked.

“I told you at the Grove that you would not get answers from me that you want,” Anaxa repeated as his head rolled forward again, “because I *did* find an answer and the solution to your problem is not accessible to this crew.” He paused in case someone tried to interrupt. The Professor hated when people didn’t let him finish speaking. That was rule number two. “My golden blood *did* prevent the Black Tide from corrupting me for a time but after only a month I had to try something a little more extreme to protect myself. I was able to reverse the early stages and prevent further corruption to my own body and soul by taking the Coreflame of Reason and embedding it within my own chest.”

There was a pause while that information sunk in. Phainon saw the defeat on Hephaestion face and the subtle downturn of Mydei’s gaze. For someone so vocally opposed to Aglaea

and Titans as a whole, Phainon was more surprised that Anaxa, the blasphemer, had even considered the option.

The coreflame itself was supposed to be given to Okhema when the Grove was lost but in the rush during the evacuation, they had failed to retrieve it. Aglaea had yet to send anyone for it, deeming it a loss as long as the Tide extended too far to risk anyone but her Chrysos Heirs.

“It has been theorized that Titans are corruptible,” Anaxa continued with a wave of his hand, gesturing to the side as he tilted his head, “but as a Demigod I have seen no such evidence in the short time that I have had this coreflame in my chest.”

“Professor,” Phainon managed to say after the shock processed in his own heart, “I thought you hated the Titans, why would you have taken the coreflame?”

“The Coreflame of Reason has long been held in the Grove as a focal point of the Grove’s founding; a curiosity wrapped in myth. Regardless of how I feel about Cerces and my colleagues’ love for the Titan, the coreflame is still a proven source of power. There is no mysticism there. It was *that* woman’s lapse in judgement to not have it retrieved sooner for her collection. Perhaps she believed it was safe until she was ready to claim it, in any case, it was left behind and I had no reason not to use it for personal experimentation.” He spat his contempt for Aglaea but otherwise spoke candidly about his blasphemy.

Castorice tucked her hair behind her ears and leaned forward when she asked, “Professor, did the Coreflame accept you?”

“You’re worried that I may have forced it to attain divinity. No, I did not, nor did I take it into myself with the desire to achieve godhood. It was a successful experiment to determine the nature of corruption on my golden blood, nothing more. Anything I may have gleaned about the coreflame itself was an unintended byproduct.”

“But we’re still back to square one,” Hephaestion sighed.

“In your research, have you found any proof that an individual could be shielded from corruption without a coreflame?” Mydei asked.

“I have not,” Anaxa admitted.

“Have you found definitive proof that it cannot be?” Phainon tried.

The professor’s lip curled ever so slightly. “I have not. I ceased my research into the possibility when I found the solution that worked for my own body and then I resumed my preferred topic of research.”

“Maybe we can formulate a strategy that lets us help you from the ship, Mydei,” Hephaestion offered, trying to keep their hope afloat.

“Castrum Kremnos is inside the Black Tide,” Anaxa corrected, “your crew will turn long before you make it to the fortress.”

Mydei shook his head. “No, this ship is able to sail through the Tide. My men are protected so long as they are on it. What we need is a way to ward them individually so they can come ashore.”

Anaxa froze. His finger was still raised, mid-tap, trapped in time as he considered that. “You have tested this?”

Phainon nodded, “they found me inside the Tide. I lost my own ship and crew, but the Chryseus Leo and her crew were unaffected.”

“We sail through Tide waters all the time,” Hephaestion confirmed, “it’s how we have been able to pursue her ships and push back the Tide line.”

Anaxa’s finger started tapping again, double his original speed, and he tossed his head back again as he started to laugh that same maniacal laugh as before.

“Professor?” Hyacine asked, “Are you okay?”

He stopped laughing and leaned forward with a terrifying gleam in his eye that Phainon recognized from his school days. Either they were all about to have to write a ten-page essay, or Anaxa had figured something out.

With a happy, low purr, he said, *“I have some follow-up questions.”*

Chapter End Notes

Ethos is an appeal to credibility
Kairos is an appeal to context or opportunity. It is not an official form of persuasion but I figure, fictional world, they probably have a bunch that we've never heard of

Chapter 24: Song of Recollection

Chapter Summary

Mydei and Phainon both reflect and Castorice has a very important question for Mydei.

Chapter Notes

I almost posted this last night but I'm glad I let it cook cause this was a very important one and we had a minor family 'emergency.' My spouse took the sailboat out yesterday and our search and rescue drone, Eous, went overboard. Fortunately, my husband recovered it this morning with his dive gear and we learned a very important lesson about naming inanimate objects and getting attached to them. My kitchen is full of big bowls of rice and buried electronics. RIP Eous.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei's proper apology had been promptly rejected, and the prince still had no idea if Anaxa was still angry about the abduction or if it simply didn't matter anymore. The professor's attention had shifted so rapidly after their discussion in the infirmary that it was hard to follow his thought process at all. The man refused to elaborate on what he was doing or what he was looking for and the only hints Mydei could glean came entirely from the questions he asked as the man wandered the ship.

He asked about her history, about Chryseus Leo, about the figurehead, the type of wood, the nature of the markings, until Mydei couldn't keep up and Krateros took over. The old man had been a part of the ship's history for its entire life and was eager to help when he overheard one of Anaxa's snide comments about the Goldweaver. It was a bonding moment that no one expected but everyone appreciated.

Anaxagoras took samples, he raided Ptolemy's library, and he didn't sleep. Maybe it was a demigod thing, but he declined a hammock of his own and refused the meal that Mydei made, taking interest in the food just long enough to recognize the level of sophistication of his kitchen onboard. A kitchen that had been promptly co-opted into being Anaxa's new lab.

Overnight Anaxa had completely reorganized everything, created a massive mess, started three fires, laughed loud enough to wake everyone up several times, and somehow deeply offended Fig Stew. And that was *with* Hyacine and Phainon's supervision. Mydei had checked on the man in the morning, saw the state of his beloved kitchen and had to be held back by four people, an exhausted Phainon included. Very, very few things could challenge Mydei's restraint, the abhorrent assault on his kitchen was one of those things.

Winning his morning spar with Phainon calmed him down and Mydei reluctantly agreed to hand over control of his galley in pursuit of the bigger picture. It was only for the few days between the Grove and the Kremnoan settlement. What could go wrong?

He stood at his favorite spot at the railing, flopped over it at the waist like a wet towel, watching smoke curl out of the galley with a deep frown. Hyacine and Phainon were busy assisting with an experiment of some sort, leaving Mydei without his favorite combat partner and he was too worried about what was happening down there to find another one, leaving him to sulk irritably.

“Lord Mydei?”

He twisted his head and slowly pulled himself up to rest on his forearms. “Miss Castorice, did the professor not need you?”

“No, he seems to be doing just fine on his own. Professor Anaxa is brilliant but eccentric, the best way for me to help is to stay out of his way.”

Mydei hummed in agreement and turned back again to pout at the smoke. The way it curled out of the vent in varied colors was unnatural and unsettling.

“I’m sorry that he has taken your kitchen from you.”

“It’s in service to our mission,” Mydei huffed but the slight whine under his voice must’ve come through because Castorice stepped up beside him and put her hand on his forearm to comfort him.

“Lord Mydei, if you have a moment, may we talk?”

Puzzled, he looked up at her from where he was leaning. Castorice was a master of keeping a measured voice, even better than he was. It was hard to determine from just her words and expression what kind of discussion this would be. “Is something wrong? Is it an issue with the crew?”

“Not at all.” She squeezed his arm. “But I would like to speak in private, if that is alright?”

Extra puzzled, Mydei set aside any speculation and instead put his hand on hers with a soft squeeze. Always mindful of the sharp claws on his gauntlets, he delicately scooped her hand up to hold her fingers over his own so he could guide her as the Lady she was. While he had never been one for stuffy royal etiquette, nor had the need to use it, Krateros had still taught Mydei in his youth how to act as a Crown Prince and eventual King.

“Will my room suffice?” he asked, “or would you prefer the library?”

“Ptolemy is still in the library,” she reported and then added sheepishly, “that may partially be my fault. I enlisted his help as a reader to find any errors in my latest manuscript.”

“My room then.” He got the doors for her along the way and closed the final one behind them. This close to home he didn’t expect anyone to be in here. Any remaining navigation could be done without maps while they followed the familiar coastline.

Mydei let her go to pull out a chair for her and invited her to sit, taking a seat across from her for himself. He settled in with his knees slightly spread and his arms folded across his chest while she took a second to delicately settle with her hands clasped in her lap.

Castorice still harbored habits from her time as a cursed woman. Her body language was tight with her legs tucked under the chair and to the side, eliminating the risk of someone accidently tripping over them or bumping into her foot. She kept her shoulders down but not relaxed, rolled in to make herself narrower, with her arms pressed in close and her hands folded so neatly on top of each other it was as though she only had one. Very slowly she settled in, carefully unwinding one thread at a time, keeping her posture but any remaining rigidity had softened.

Mydei extended one of his legs in her direction, leaving it there as an invitation without forcing any contact. She noticed immediately and curbed her surprise with a soft exhale; her own legs extended to cross at the ankle so she could lean them against his boot without sacrificing any modesty.

“Lord Mydei, I know from my limited time here that you do not care for small talk,” she started, “so I will start with the first of two things I wanted to ask you about. Have you recently lost a loved one?”

Mydei was taken aback by the question because it felt like the answer should be obvious. “I’ve lost many. I am Kremnoan, my people live for battle and fight with the intent to perish in glorious combat.”

Castorice reached up with both hands to play with a strand of hair. It was clearly a nervous gesture, a reason to look away from him directly while she fumbled with her words. “Someone closer, such as a sibling or a parent?”

He frowned and admitted, “both of my parents are deceased. My mother died when I was an infant.” Castorice already knew about Eurypon. Phainon had admitted to telling both the girls the whole story their first time on the ship to catch them up to speed on the world news that had been denied them in Okhema.

“Any siblings? Perhaps a sister?”

Mydei shook his head, “not by blood. I have lost crewmates before but those closest to me, that I would consider my brothers are yet alive.”

Castorice was braiding her hair and then deftly undoing it while she chewed on the inside of her cheek.

“Why do you ask?”

She tucked the hair behind her ear. “As the Demigod of Death, sometimes I can sense lingering spirits that resist the natural current of the Sea of Souls. Strong souls can sometimes project themselves, appearing in dreams or through relics or mediums. You simply seemed haunted, Lord Mydei, and I was curious.”

“In dreams?” Mydei wondered and he raised a hand to his chin, resting his finger there to think. “There are only two people that appear regularly in my dreams and one of them is alive. The other is my mo-“ He cut himself off when the pieces clicked in place.

“Your mother passed away when you were young, yes?”

“She was killed by King Eurypon, I barely knew her… but sometimes I dream of what could have been had I not been cast away and she had not been murdered,” he admitted.

Those dreams were less frequent now, but when he was a child in the Sea of Souls it was almost as though Queen Gorgo were there with him, helping him, raising him in spirit. Each one was sunshine and fresh air in an ocean that collected his lives, full of warmth and arms that held him tightly and wiped away his tears. She instilled in him courage before he even knew what that meant, to keep fighting, to always press on through pain. Her voice was the lifeline of his foundation, the reason for his resolve. Her example was one of strength and love, unsure of their own destinies as Kremnoans, joyously contemplating something more for her son.

The dreams had become more transparent over time, and he had even talked to her as clearly as though they were memories of another life. The woman he could not remember in life had become his everything in death. Whenever he woke with tears in his eyes, they were not from pain or fear, but from the emotional well of peace that speaking to his mother brought to his storming heart.

Get up, my son!

“Lord Mydei?”

He jerked a little when Castorice put her hand on his knee. “I’m sorry, I did not mean to get so lost in my thoughts.”

“Do you know very much about her?”

“Krateros raised me on stories of her adventures.”

She nodded gently and took her hand back. “Was she very strong?”

“The strongest.”

“I know this is cliché to say, but I believe she may be watching over you.”

It was the kind of thing that Mydei had heard from old Kremnoans his entire life. Hollow words that are said at funerals that people cling to for comfort alongside other such anecdotes as ‘she fights beside Nikador now’ or ‘her soul has strengthened Nikador’s blade more than any who has come before.’ Mydei had lived in the Sea of Souls, he knew that it was foolish to believe that spirits could so casually linger to watch from a higher plane. Once they crossed into the Netherealm, they were gone.

It was different to hear it from Castorice, the Demigod of Death, the Hand of Shadow, the Executioner, because if anyone, *anyone*, would know the truth of such a statement, it would

be she who guides the river and keeps the souls of the dead. Which is why when Castorice said those loaded words, Mydei genuinely felt moved.

It was a dizzy sort of feeling, full of love and warmth that spread to his toes and fingers, the kind that cradled rather than strangled his heart making it feel so full that he worried it may burst. The threat of tears lingered behind his eyes as his throat felt tight. Instinctually, he raised a hand to his chest, pressing over his sternum to hold all those feelings back around ragged breaths.

“I’m sorry, if I said something inappropriate,” Castorice whispered, and he shook his head.

“No, it is good to hear. You’ve brought me a comfort I did not know I wanted,” he told her in a whisper.

She smiled warmly and clasped her hands before herself as though to pray. “I am glad. If I may, I had one other thing I wanted to discuss with you.”

He took a breath to center himself and blink away that pressure behind his eyes. What remained was a warm comfort, the eternal reassurance of a mother’s love.

“It can wait until another time, Lord Mydei, if you would like time to contemplate what I have already said.”

Mydei shook his head and gestured to her. “What is it, Castorice?”

“Are you in love with Lord Phainon?”

Mydei’s entire body went into fight or flight mode and got trapped in the middle of the decision-making process. Half of him wanted to jump out the window into the ocean and the other half was trying to evaporate on the spot. The blood was rapidly rushing to his face against his will making sitting uncomfortable and his face and chest turn red which probably answered her question better than his silent, opening and closing mouth was now that words had stopped working entirely.

Bless her heart, Castorice waited patiently for him to calm down enough for him to wheeze, “Love is a strong word.”

“Lord Mydei, I see the way you look at him.”

He looked away, embarrassed. “It cannot be so obvious.”

“I think he likes you too,” she said gently.

That warm feeling came back and he brightened, wide-eyed as he looked back at her. “Did he say…?”

“No, but I know Lord Phainon very well and he is not good at vocalizing his own desires. He simply doesn’t consider himself,” Castorice explained.

Castorice was right, Phainon never looked inwards. Mydei was reminded of a man that risked his own life to fight two sides in an Okheman fort, a man that was nearly lost to the sea fighting a storm to save a crew he was just barely coming to know, a man that saw an opportunity to have his freedom and honor back and wanted to reject it in favor of the means to save them all. Phainon was too perfect for a flawed man like Mydei, who willingly carried the pirate mantle and fought for a people that he could only disappoint.

“But I see the way he looks at you and the way he talks about you,” she giggled and put her hands back in her lap, “he is not a shy man. I think he mentioned your body and strength *three* separate times in the first quint of his storytelling.”

Mydei tsked but the blush stayed. “HKS, has he no shame at all?”

“He’s a catch,” Castorice admitted.

“…is there no one in Okhema waiting for him?”

“A lover you mean?”

Mydei shyly nodded.

“Not that I know of,” she reassured him, “Phainon is friendly and open, but I’ve never seen him take such interest in another person before.”

“Not even during your time in the Grove?”

Castorice considered her next words very carefully. “Lord Mydei, did Phainon tell you about his past?”

“He has in small doses, and I have heard pieces from my friends who have discussed it with him. I know that his home was destroyed by the Black Tide and that he was left, the only survivor, to wander until Aglaea found him and gave him purpose.” Mydei paused for a moment to consider aloud in a quiet voice, “And I have seen for myself what he will not say, that he is still angry and fearful to the point of breaking at the Tide. I have seen the same embers of vengeance in the bones of my own men, in Krateros especially.”

“Then you have seen the walls he has built inside himself.”

Mydei knew *exactly* what she was talking about. He saw them on the day they met and wondered now as he replayed their time together if they had ever completely come down. Perhaps that day in the galley, just before Phainon had thrown his challenge, and again when he had read the letter, but he was skilled in hiding himself again.

Castorice continued, “most people don’t see it. They see how friendly he is and assume that he is a trusting fool, but his friends know how deep his soul is and the sorrow and rage he keeps in those depths. He loves, he does, very deeply, but Hyacine and I worried that he would not be able to pursue a *romantic* love until that fire was tamed, so you see why we were excited to learn of you.”

That was a humbling thought, and he was glad for the distinction. There were many types of love and Phainon had demonstrated no shortage of familial and brotherly love towards the crew. Perhaps it was a love that he gave more freely, a natural byproduct of being a friendly person, of a Deliverer destined to save the world. But a man who had shunned romantic love, falling for Mydei?

“If you have feelings for him, will you tell him?” Castorice asked.

Mydei had never bothered trying to describe himself but pressed to do so he may have once said fearless, confident, or composed, but confronted with such a simple question it was hard to feel any of those things. The thought of taking Phainon’s hand in his own and admitting an all-encompassing attraction to the man filled Mydei with a fear that he had never known before, because admitting such a thing was opening the floodgates to change. Even knowing that Phainon may return his sentiments, Mydei was worried about what he may say.

“He suspects already,” Mydei admitted, “I told him that once we had the coreflame I would confide in him the secret of who held my affections.”

“You want him to have every choice available to him, before you ask.” Castorice was very good at seeing into the heart of things.

“Yes,” he said gently, “I would want the chance to court him properly as he deserves. I want him to join my crew because he wants to, not because I bound him to this fate. I would want the chance to win his love as he has already won mine.” Mydei sighed and reached up to rub his face. “I had hoped that he would see the Coreflame of Strife as a courting gift, the first of many, as a gesture of desire not only from myself but from my family that also want him to be one of us.”

“But Lord Phainon does not see it that way,” Castorice supplied, lamenting with Mydei over the confusion, “he sees it as a means to save you and your crew. Can this not also be a gesture of love in the same way?”

Mydei hummed, “It will not matter until we retrieve it. What matters the most is that Phainon is happy and if he is too busy taking care of others to care for himself, then I will simply have to take up that task.”

Castorice smiled and started to speak but the door slammed open, jumping on its hinges, slamming loud enough to have Mydei on his feet with his body between this new threat and his new friend.

It was just Phainon.

“HKS!” Mydei scolded, “have you no manners! I was ready to attack you!”

“Mydei!” Phainon panted. He paused when he saw Castorice in there too and tilted his head in confusion, brows furrowed like he was processing complex emotions all at once before he remembered why he had come. “Professor Anaxa has a prototype. He’s ready to test.”

-

Finding an island that was inside the Tide line wasn't difficult. In the time it had taken the crew to go to Okhema and the Grove, the progress they had originally made had been lost. It was still a slow creep without the monsters that the Tide desperately needed to hold the line, but it was dauntingly consistent. The last town they had cleared was eerie, devoid of life and movement but swimming in the Tide's fog.

Phainon was having a harder time facing it directly than he thought he would. Facing monsters was easier than facing the surrealism of the fog. It was so different at sea when the ocean turned black around corrupted ships and it was different fighting in places where the Tide had retreated entirely. The aftermath of destruction was different than standing in the presence of the master behind the madness.

He blinked and his breath stuck as images of Aedes Elysiae flashed. Instead of stone buildings and a grand pier he could see farms and storehouses on fire. In the distance, someone screamed and he gasped.

"Deliverer?" Mydei's voice snapped him back to reality with a harsh jerk and Phainon twisted his neck to face him sharply enough to hurt.

"Mydei!" he greeted cheerfully with a wide smile.

The captain's eyes drifted towards Phainon's hands on the railing. He was gripping the wood so tightly that it had splintered and gold was pooling around one of his nails. Phainon hadn't even noticed.

At the concerned look in those pinched Kremnoan brows, Phainon laughed and let go of the rail to wrap his arm around Mydei's neck, affectionately pulling the man in close to tussle his hair. Of course, his best friend roughly shoved him off and followed up with a punch that would bruise his shoulder.

"We're about to see Professor Anaxa change the world," he laughed while rubbing the budding sore spot.

Mydei still studied him, reading so deeply into his being that Phainon was starting to feel naked but if the captain found something worth addressing, Mydei didn't say. That courtesy was one of the many things Phainon liked about Mydei. He turned back to the rail to look at the city, this time putting his forearms on the ship so he wouldn't give away his misgivings so readily.

"Do you trust him?" Mydei asked. As guarded as he tried to be, Phainon could see the subtle tells of cautious concern. His braid was ever so slightly uneven from when he wove the strands this morning, his chiton was tied tighter at the shoulder, his necklace was unpolished. They were little things that most people wouldn't notice, but Phainon did. Phainon always noticed when Mydei was upset.

"Well," Phainon managed to squeak out and Mydei's fiery eyes started to bore into the side of his head at the hesitation, "I trust that he is brilliant… but I also know he's not shy of failure."

“Are my men in danger?”

Should he lie? No, not to Mydei, but the truth was always yes. There were absolutely risks. “I trust Professor Anaxa to take every step that he can to ensure the safety of his subjects.”

Mydei was still unconvinced. It was written in the tension of his shoulders and how tightly he held his crossed arms to his chest.

The crew was mostly gathered on deck now. They were hesitant to lower the ramp and were relying instead on the anchors to keep them close to the dock. Black mist clung to the wooden planks like a dense fog, pouring over in places to drip to the water below, ink black and devoid of light.

Anaxa and Hyacine were standing next to the removed section of the rail, waiting impatiently. The Professor was holding a hastily carved, plain wooden pocket, no bigger than a small book in his hand with a slot carved into one end and sealed with wax. Beside him, Hyacine waited with her staff under her arm and her familiar, Ica, beside her. The miniature Pegasus was more marshmallow than flying unicorn these days, but he was cute and comforting with his trills and doots. Something about fat, brightly colored animal sidekicks tended to put people at ease.

“I need a volunteer,” the professor yelled to the Kremnoans, “before I choose a man at random.”

Mydei tapped his foot twice and then called to the crew in Kremnoan, “This man is going to test a means to repel the Tide, but he needs someone who is not of golden blood to take this talisman to the dock. I will not force any of you, regardless of what this scholar says.”

Hephaestion immediately stepped forward, “Mydeimos, I will do it.”

Phainon could see the worry and the pride flash across Mydei’s face as the first mate stepped up. It was worry that he shared with Mydei. These were his friends too, *family* to Mydei, and if this didn’t work…

“No, Hephaestion.” Peucesta stepped forward, his soft-spoken voice resolved. “I am the better pick.”

“Peucesta-“

“Please, I have touched the Tide before,” he reminded them all, “ever since, I have craved the means to hear it again. I *want* this.”

For a very brief moment, it looked to Phainon like the man would decline, pull rank, and force Peucesta to cede this risk to himself but instead Hephaestion clasped arms with Peucesta. They leaned in to press their foreheads together, holding each other there for several seconds with Hephaestion’s hand on the back of Peucesta’s neck and their eyes closed. It wasn’t a common practice in Okhema and even on the ship, Phainon had only seen it a couple times among the older crew, but he knew it as a deeply intimate Kremnoan farewell reserved for family members or lovers.

They broke apart and Peucesta repeated the gesture with Mydei and that second goodbye caused the truth of how dangerous this was to settle in his belly. Phainon's proposition, this risky experiment… they were sending Peucesta to his death and not a kind one either. Peucesta was potentially sacrificing his free will to painfully transform into a monster that would need to be killed by his family on this ship. For a Kremnoan, to be denied the opportunity to die a glorious death as himself…

Phainon clenched his fists tightly at his sides and looked away before he could step in and ask them to find another way. But he knew, he *knew* that this was still the best option. Success would grant the wish of the crew to fight beside their beloved Prince on their homeland again. This was about all of them and Peucesta knew it.

The bard broke away from Mydei but leaned close to whisper something in the prince's ear and then he stepped back. Peucesta smiled at Phainon from where he was and nodded his head, a gesture Phainon returned in a quiet and solemn salute.

"Take heart, my friends," Peucesta told them, "When I return as myself it will be with a greater understanding of the sweetest songs."

Despite his impatience, Anaxa was surprisingly respectful. Phainon recalled the tenderness with which he treated his past test subjects, the only exception being students as they were rarely exposed to his more dangerous ideas. Famously, Anaxa preferred himself for testing but that wasn't an option this time.

"My theory is sound," Anaxa explained as he handed the wooden block to Peucesta, "you should not need it, but Hyacinthia will be sending her familiar with you."

"Little Ica helps me heal," she explained, "if the corruption begins to harm you, he will do his best to slow it before you turn, to buy us time to get you back to the ship."

"You understand that per the nature of this experiment, that Ica is a distant safety net, not a crutch," Anaxa cautioned, "He will not help you unless the situation is dire. It's possible that you will turn before we can get to you."

Peucesta nodded and tucked the wooden block inside his chiton, pressed against his belly.

"We will lower you by rope," Mydei explained.

Another nod.

"May victory be yours, Peucesta," Hephaestion said firmly with his hand over his heart.

There was a pause so that everyone could breathe through the weight and then Mydei waved his hand for the rope. They looped it around Peucesta's waist and a second loop under his thighs. He slowly lowered himself to sit with his lyre in his lap while the crew held his weight.

After a testing bounce, he gave them a thumbs up, and the crew moved the pulley arm out over the dock. Peucesta didn't wait for a push or any help, he kicked off the deck and out into

open air, floating there over the mist while the crew very slowly lowered him. Ica fluttered around his descent in excited circles, eager to work and oblivious to the tension.

Phainon leaned over the railing, with sharp wire around his heart. He wasn't sure he could watch and turned away to look at Mydei instead. Perhaps he shouldn't have. Mydei was holding his hand out to Ptolemy, who reluctantly handed their prince a war bow and three bolts. He waited to ready them, leaving each arrow leaning against the deck wall, bow unstrung unless there was no other choice.

Their beloved bard twanged his lyre as he was lowered, playing something sweet and cheerful, a reassurance in a major key that made Ica twirl and dance in the air. And he kept playing when his feet touched the dock, ankle deep in corrupting mist.

"*Oh*!" he exclaimed in soft surprise, only audible because no one on the crew could bring themselves to breathe. His song stuttered as the Black Tide licked at his knees, swirling around him, trying to engulf his body, but he regarded it all with fascination rather than fear, as though greeting an old friend.

Peucesta paused his playing and crouched to touch the mist with his hands. It swirled all the fiercer like sharks thrashing through chum at the surface of the ocean, but he was yet undaunted, calm and composed. Instead of calling for help or screaming in pain, he closed his eyes and rhythmically twisted his head back and forth, listening to something that only he could hear.

And then he began to play again.

The song was hauntingly beautiful. It was a lonely lullaby sung in sorrow, a prayer of ancient grief longing for peace long past. Mournful regret and hope in tandem sang harmonies beside the deepest longing of ages. And when Peucesta hummed the melody over the careful glide of his fingers, Phainon felt tears spill unbidden over his cheeks.

Overwhelming *loss* robbed Phainon of his strength and he slowly dropped to his knees with one hand clinging to the rail for support and the other covering his mouth, afraid to make any sound that may mar the beauty of the enchanting melody.

Someone put a hand on his shoulder, but it only barely registered before it drowned in the rush behind his eyes. All he could see was his home burning to ash while warm blood coated his hands. His mother's dim eyes were watching him, face contorted in agony while behind her body, Phainon's father was morphing before his eyes. Still that melody played over all other sounds, and while Peucesta was only humming, Phainon could hear the whispering words of the song in his head in a language he could never hope to understand. He remembered every lyric desperately singing from the black depths of the sea in a raging storm. Longing with such force that nothing else remained but infinite heartbreak and suffering, pleading for something known and lost.

Phainon came back to himself when pain stung across his cheek and the flashback faded away into the cheers of the crew on deck. Mydei's ember eyes were watching him, he had dropped to his knees beside Phainon and was holding his face in one hand. The other was slightly raised after the slap but hurried to cradle the other cheek, to keep him steady.

Around them the cheering continued, directed at the dock where Peucesta's song had changed. He was playing a drinking shanty to show everyone that the experiment was a success. They were already pulling him back onboard, blissfully unaware of Mydei and Phainon in their own bubble.

Phainon grabbed onto Mydei's wrists for support, and he felt the thumbs of Mydei's gauntlets stroking his cheeks.

"Breathe," the pirate ordered and Phainon realized he hadn't been, not properly. He was panting so shallowly that his lungs were starving for air and he felt dizzy. Mydei took one of his hands away from Phainon's face to grab his wrist, to press his shaking hand against Mydei's warm chest, just over his sternum. He kept it there in an abiding grip and took slow, deep breaths, giving Phainon a tactile example to follow.

He closed his eyes and leaned his face into Mydei's hand, letting his friend help hold Phainon's weight while he focused on that strong, fast heartbeat under his hands. Slowly he matched the pace of every inhale and exhale until the ache in his heart was distant and he could open his eyes again.

Mydei was watching him, face as stone, unblinking, until Phainon gave him a few weak nods. Only after Mydei was sure that Phainon was himself did he stand and pull him up to shaky feet.

Peucesta landed delicately in the crowd of his comrades with his lyre raised in one hand and the wooden block in the other. He had a big grin on his face but when he flashed a look at Phainon, he saw the shine on the Kremnoan's cheeks and the hollow look in his eyes.

Whatever that was, Peucesta had felt it too.

Chapter End Notes

I actually have a specific song in mind but I can't share it here cause it will IMMEDIATELY give away the plot LMAO. That said, by this point, some people may have some semi-accurate theories about the Black Tide. I will not confirm them in the comments but you're welcome to share them with me if you theory crafters want your ideas on the record in case you end up being right~ :3c

A moment of silence for my original outline that says the events of this chapter were supposed to be the end of chapter 7.

Chapter 25: Truth Hiding in the Harmony

Chapter Summary

Anaxa theorizes and Mydei confronts Phainon

No new tags but mind the existing ones

Chapter Notes

I feel very strongly about mental health. PTSD and treatments are different for different people. My fic is not meant to be an example of good coping habits or what therapy should look like. Please bear that in mind as we continue to follow Phainon and Mydei on this journey!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Even if it didn't show on his face, Mydei was trying to balance a wide array of emotions standing on that deck. The cheers and excitement of the crew had replaced his anxious trepidation and solemn resolve. He wanted to celebrate this success alongside them but Phainon…

Phainon looked like he was going to be sick. He was pale as a sheet, eyes wide and glassy, and shaking like a leaf in a summer breeze. The way he was staring ahead and fighting for every breath as though it may be his last reminded Mydei of old Kremnoan soldiers returning from campaigns they weren't ready for. Those men were haunted and changed, as though their minds or souls were injured. Most of them healed with rest and returned to the front lines, but some of them did not and were unable to fight again.

Mydei reached out to grab Phainon's arm just above the wrist and the man flinched, but he at least looked him in the eye and offered a weak and broken smile.

"Sorry, I don't know what happened there," he laughed and reached up to scratch the back of his head apologetically. "Peucesta is really moving when he plays, yeah?"

Mydei didn't know what to say, not all men liked having attention brought to their weaknesses, but injuries to the soul needed care and attention as much as injuries to the body.

"Deliverer-"

“Anaxa’s experiment worked!” Phainon exclaimed. He was trying to turn the conversation away from himself.

Not this time. Mydei tightened his grip on Phainon like a vice.

“M-Mydeimos!”

All protesting was ignored. He half-led, half-dragged Phainon across the deck, detouring only briefly to catch Perdikkas’ confused expression to beckon for the man to join them. Then he pulled Phainon down the stairs through the belly of the ship and to the infirmary where he finally let go.

“Sit,” Mydei ordered.

“Mydei, I-“

“*Sit.*”

Phainon rolled his eyes but kept his smile as he dramatically pulled up one of the chairs and took a seat. “Mydei, I don’t feel sick.”

Mydei crossed his arms and stood between Phainon and the door until Perdikkas finally caught up.

“Mydei, what’s going on?” he asked, “everyone else is looking for you and the professor wants to talk to Phainon.”

“Shouldn’t keep the professor waiting,” Phainon announced brightly. He stood up but Mydei roughly pushed him back down into the chair.

“Where were you back there, Deliverer?” Mydei asked.

“Hm? I was on deck.”

“Where were you up here?” he asked again this time pressing the tip of a claw to Phainon’s forehead.

Phainon’s eyes glittered and his jaw tightened. Mydei saw his throat bob as he swallowed. The man was angry and trying to hide it, but he answered in a deep, dark voice, “Aedes Elysiae.”

Perdikkas’ mood shifted to something more serious, and he stepped back enough to close the door. “Has this happened before?”

“There’s nothing wrong with me,” Phainon insisted, already back to being cheerful.

“I’m not saying there is,” Perdikkas said gently as he walked in closer to take a seat on the bed next to Phainon, “this happens to a lot of people.”

Phainon leaned back in his chair with his arms crossed and one of his legs bouncing up and down. “It only happens sometimes. There is nothing to worry about.”

“How often is sometimes,” the doctor prodded, “does something trigger it?”

The leg stopped bouncing as Phainon thought. “It happens sometimes around the Black Tide.”

“Have you known about this for awhile?”

He sighed and admitted, “Aglaea knows. It was worse when she found me, when I was more… angry and hollow. It hasn’t happened like *this* since before Aglaea took me in.”

“You were tense on deck when we got here and mostly fine until Peucesta started playing,” Mydei noted.

Phainon leaned forward and put his hand on his face to cover one eye. “That song was just… so familiar, it sounded just like the song I heard in the ocean when I went overboard during the storm.”

“Did you have the same visions during the storm?”

“Not as clear but, yeah.”

“And before then?”

Phainon thought aloud, “I felt it briefly a couple years ago when we were evacuating the Grove and a couple times before when fighting the Tide.”

Mydei nodded and said, “if you are seeing visions of your home then that is the source of the injury, and the Black Tide is ripping it open.”

“We fight the Tide all the time without incident,” Phainon pointed out, “and I’m not injured.”

“Not on the outside,” Perdikkas agreed, “Phainon, there’s nothing shameful about lingering trauma like this and it may come and go. You went through something awful as a kid, that can take a lifetime to recover from, especially if you’ve never had the chance to face that trauma or work through it.”

“I don’t think that really applies to Chrysos Heirs,” he laughed.

“It does,” Mydei corrected, “it happened to me.” Phainon went quiet at that, looking at Mydei with concern and perhaps a little bit of awe. “I spent my childhood drowning,” he reminded them casually, “it took many years of working with Perdikkas and Krateros for me to let that go. The nightmares still linger and there are times when I feel fear looking into the heart of the black ocean, but I have embraced that part of me and learned how to let it go.”

“We’re not saying you have to fix it right this moment,” Perdikkas told Phainon, “nor can you. It’s not the kind of thing that can be magically corrected but if you’re willing, will you

let me teach you some techniques? So, if those flashbacks return you can come back to yourself more quickly?"

Phainon still seemed a little upset at the implication that he needed any kind of care as he let his hand fall back to his lap.

"Do it because I want it," Mydei said quickly, and both the other men looked up at him in flabbergasted shock.

If he is too busy taking care of others to care for himself, then I will simply have to take up that task. What better way to get Phainon to take care of himself than to convince him he is doing it for someone else?

"HKS, what use are you to me if you break down at the sight of the mist?" Mydei growled dismissively, "if you are going to watch my back in the battle against Nikador, then I must know you can handle yourself. Or must I always be there to show you how to breathe?"

Phainon blinked and then exhaled into a half chuckle. "Alright, alright. I will do my best."

"We can meet after your Kremnoan lessons in the evenings," Perdikkas invited.

"I'll be there," Phainon promised.

-

Phainon still felt uneasy when he left the infirmary with Mydei and Perdikkas. As much as he wanted to push everything back down and focus entirely on the task at hand, he was still very shaken. But mostly, he was ashamed. The reassurances from his friends that what he was experiencing was normal, that Mydei had also endured similar stress, was comforting but it didn't eliminate the worry that somehow this made him less of a person. What if someone got really hurt because he broke down?

Years ago, when he was still barely himself, Aglaea had taught him how to manage his rage and fear to control himself in the face of the Tide. These episodes had stopped with her care over the years and Phainon had been able to successfully lead many expeditions against the Tide. He really believed they were behind him but the closer they got to the Tide the more those old wounds were reopening. Lessons from Perdikkas seemed more like a good idea the longer he thought about it.

His stomach was still churning when he walked down the steps into the galley. Anaxa was furiously taking notes as he studied the wooden block that Peucesta had taken to the dock while Hyacine checked Peucesta for any lasting damage or corruption.

Little Ica trilled happily at Phainon and zoomed up to collect his nose boop which Phainon happily bestowed with a wide smile and a single pointer finger.

"Is my man well?" Mydei asked as he stepped past Phainon. The pirate was tense. He still wasn't happy about losing his kitchen to this endeavor. His expression matched Fig Stew's glare who supervised Anaxa irritably from the open, cold oven door.

The bard was sitting on one of the preparation tables, lyre set aside by the cubbies. Phainon could see the exhausted hollow of his eyes still but the tear tracks had since been wiped away. Hyacine was standing in front of him with a gentle blue-green glow coming from her palm.

“He is perfect,” she announced, “no corruption at all.”

“That is not entirely accurate,” Anaxa mumbled from the opposite countertop. He held up the wooden block without turning around. The wax seal had been pulled free and something inside the pocket clunked about as he waved it. “He *was* corrupted but *this* removed it as quickly as the stain was accrued.”

“Then it worked?” Phainon asked. His heart fluttered at the good news.

“It will need some adjustments, but yes.”

“What kind of adjustments?” Mydei prodded.

“Ideally, the talisman would absorb the corruption *before* it can touch the man but drawing it out is an excellent start.” Anaxa dumped the contents of the pocket out into his hand and held it up to the light.

The red crystal was polished but cut unevenly into an irregular polygon. What mattered was that it was flat enough to fit in the wooden sleeve. Phainon had removed it from the crystal lion figurehead himself with a hammer, chisel, and a dozen apologies to the Chryseus Leo. The piece had come free like broken obsidian, clean, thin, and sharp. Now as it shined red in the light everyone could see the fine black staining the edges.

“…where did you get that?” Mydei asked.

“Ah, don’t be mad at the professor, Mydei,” Phainon hurried to say, “I broke it off the figurehead.”

Mydei twitched irritably and his hands clenched into tight fists, but he kept to himself with an annoyed huff.

“This ship has developed a means to absorb the energy of the Black Tide,” Anaxa explained as he set the crystal down. “Corruption happens when living beings absorb this energy and fail to purge it before they transform, but this ship is neither living nor wholly inanimate. The lion that has become one with this vessel is alive enough to absorb the effects of the Tide, but stone cannot turn into a monster. This is what protects you when you sail through tainted waters.”

“Absorb not reflect?” Perdikkas asked.

“Correct.”

“Does the ship have a limit to how much it can hold?” Phainon asked.

“Yes.”

“But it doesn’t matter does it?” Pecuesta realized softly, “because the corruption can be washed away.”

The corner of Anaxa’s mouth curled up, pleased with this new astute student. “Correct.”

Phainon inhaled sharply when it all came back to him, an afternoon spent caring for the lion, singing songs to him to heal his spirit, and the tender respect of a dutiful first mate repairing even the smallest dents. “All those times you went to sing to the ship…?”

“We knew the ship was resistant,” Mydei explained, “we didn’t realize it was absorbing the corruption.”

“This ship is in remarkably good shape,” Anaxa praised, “that care and love that you spend keeping it clean and in good repair may not have been intentionally meant to purge the Tide, but it did so all the same. Okhema has known for hundreds of years that minor corruption can be removed. Phainon, when *that* woman first brought you to Okhema, what was the first thing she requested of you?”

“She made me bathe. Twice.”

“The bathhouse in the Chrysos Heir’s bath glimmers gold with Mnestia’s power. It cleanses Black Tide corruption. Your golden blood may have kept you from turning, but it does not make you immune to the stain.”

Phainon searched through his memories. “I knew that the Black Tide could linger on a person. Every time Castorice, Hyacine, or I returned from missions where we fought the Tide, Aglaea would have us bathe. It was routine.”

Anaxa picked up the crystal and took it over to the washbasin. He dropped it in the water unceremoniously with a plop and droplets scattered across the countertop. When he took the crystal out of the water, the corruption remained but then Anaxa picked up a washcloth and reverently began to wipe it dry. Slowly, the black faded back to red.

“Care,” he announced, “it is not so simple as a bath. It is not the magic of clean water and soap. The answer is care.”

Peucesta had a soft smile on his face and Phainon could feel the warmth of those memories. His very first lessons on the ship had been to love and care for one’s home. The Chryseus Leo was a part of the crew as much as any other man onboard. Even if they didn’t realize what they were doing, even if they didn’t know that their love and respect for the ship was making a meaningful difference, it was that reverence that protected them.

“Even if it didn’t help, I would sing for this ship all the same,” Peucesta said proudly.

Perdikkas grinned. Mydei cracked a small smile.

“It means that this talisman is reusable,” Anaxa announced. He held the crystal aloft, pinched between his thumb and forefinger. “Acting as an extension of the ship, they will act as a

sponge to absorb corruption until they are at capacity. This is not a permanent solution. At most it buys time until the crystal can be cleaned."

"It is still something," Mydei praised.

"Thank you, professor," Phainon added with his hand over his heart, "but if they are already working as intended, why do you need to make the adjustments you mentioned."

"I want to extend the time and prevent the corruption from passing through the individual before it is allocated to this crystal, or they will be exposed to the Tide's song."

Phainon felt his blood run cold and Peucesta looked down. Anaxa's eye narrowed in on Phainon but he didn't look surprised.

"What song?" Perdikkas asked, "the one Peucesta played on the dock?"

"Have you heard it too, Professor?" Phainon asked softly.

"Yes."

"So have I," Hyacine admitted quietly, "I-I recognized it when you played it."

Anaxa tapped his fingers on the countertop. "Hyacinthia, you were exposed during a research trip if I recall."

"Yes, I was a young healer at the time and didn't know how to dispel the corruption," her voice wavered as she remembered. She raised a hand up to her chest as she bowed her head. "I took it into myself instead, but it wasn't enough, and my patient turned. As he was transforming, I heard distant singing, but it went away when I returned to the Grove, rested and bathed."

"And you, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," Anaxa invited, "you were exposed as a child."

"Yeah, but I don't remember singing," he said very slowly. Phainon had to really think about it, had to force himself to recall the details of the destruction that altered the course of his humble life. Revisiting it now, he was starting to shake but a hand on his shoulder immediately grounded him.

Mydei's hand squeezed firmly and when their eyes met, the pirate gave Phainon a genuine smile and subtle nod. Reassured, Phainon closed his eyes to think and as he relived that awful moment he realized that there *had* been a voice that day, buried under the screams and sorrow. The Black Tide had sung to him in the background of his dazed mind the entire time he had fought his turned family and friends, adding soundtrack to the numbness as he buried them and dragged himself away from fields of gold turned black.

"There *was* a song," he whispered, "and I heard it again during the storm. Peucesta and I talked about it while we cleaned Chryseus Leo."

"Then you have heard it as well? I suspected as much when you volunteered on deck," Anaxa noted when he turned to Peucesta.

“Several years ago, I was nearly lost to the Tide,” he recounted, “I slept beside Chryseus Leo and spoke with the lion daily until the song was gone. I have tried ever since to revisit the melody, to understand that voice, but I could not recreate it until today when I heard the song again, more clearly than I ever have before.”

“And I heard it in the Grove,” Anaxa confirmed, “before I realized the song was a symptom of the corruption, I entertained it as a curiosity to study. Only after I took the coreflame into myself and the song ceased did I realize the truth of it.”

Mydei took his hand back, brows furrowed. “I have waded through the Tide before, and I have not heard a song.”

“I didn’t hear it until after… after the danger had passed,” Phainon admitted.

“The corruption would have needed time to take root in a Chrysos Heir,” Anaxa explained, “far longer than a brief military conflict at sea. The extended exposure as a child likely made you more sensitive to it, Phainon, creating a stronger association that allows you to hear it at the slightest contact with the Tide and solidifying the association you have between the song and your childhood trauma.” The drumming on the countertop quickened. “Extenuating circumstances aside, Chrysos Heirs are more resilient to its allure it would seem. You said on deck that you wanted to hear the song again, that you have been longing to recreate it.”

“I would say it is my love of music that drives my desire,” Peucesta said, “but that would be a lie. It is enchanting, a melody of temptation.”

“Like you *need* to go to whomever is singing it,” Phainon whispered, and the room quieted.

“I know the feeling,” Hyacine added, equally soft, “I remember crying when I heard it. All I could feel was…” she trailed off like it was too hard to say the words.

“Loss,” Phainon supplied and she nodded. Shakily, he admitted, “Earlier, when you were playing on the dock, Peucesta, I collapsed hearing it again. I could hear the words in my head even though you weren’t singing them… and see my home burning. All I could feel was overwhelming grief, fear, and loss like I felt back then.”

“I have long theorized that the Black Tide is a form of energy,” Anaxa offered, “perhaps it is one weaponized by emotion.”

“But… belonging to what?” Perdikkas wondered aloud.

“Or who?” Phainon asked instead.

No one had an answer.

-

The nature of the Black Tide was an engrossing mystery but one best left for another day. Mydei’s list of concerns was growing with every new discovery but the priority was still the upcoming battle at Castrum Kremnos. As long as they knew enough about this eldritch enemy to protect themselves during the fight on the horizon, everything else could wait.

Gossip amongst the crew agreed. Word of the discussion and subsequent hypothesis about the Tide had spread like jam on bread, but Mydei got the vibe from the others that most of them considered the information above their paygrade and only cared about the impending battle. The battle and how tired everyone was after all the detours.

Only so much could be done on the ship and Perdikkas and Hyacine both agreed in their professional medical opinions that everyone needed rest and prescribed relaxation, which Anaxa promptly ignored. The eccentric professor kept working until he was satisfied with the tests and by the time they turned around to sail back to the Kremnoan settlement, he had a shopping list and a step-by-step process for making the protective charms. It would take time to gather the materials, but having a plan was already a huge step in the right direction.

Until then, the anticipation of a major battle made the air onboard buzz with excitement that overflowed to the rest of the settlement when they finally made berth again in the form of a classic Kremnoan celebration. It was tradition to party and spend time with family before a major campaign to allow the people to bid farewell to their warriors. There were feasts, fights, drinking, singing, and as long as they didn't hurt themselves, Mydei didn't mind.

He preferred the men get the partying out of their system now. More than a week at sea would sober them up with plenty of time to prepare and be ready to fight.

Most of his immediate family were happy to engage in the festivities, eating their fill and drinking sweet wines. Under the protective care of Hephaestion and Perdikkas, even Hyacine and Castorice were scooped up into the excitement. It was getting dark when the house finally settled. Most of the crew had gone dancing after dinner with the promise of a visit to the bathhouse afterwards. The only ones left behind were Mydei, Phainon, Anaxa, and Peucesta.

The Professor had excused himself to the library, disappearing among the tomes, determined to keep to himself. Mydei had expected nothing less, his worried attention was instead on his remaining wayward friends. The two who had taken the discovery the hardest, who still wrestled with their inner demons

Peucesta and Phainon were at the balcony railing facing opposite directions. Phainon was looking out over the city with his book in hand, reading it with one thumb pressed between the pages to keep it open while he leaned on his other arm. Peucesta was sitting on a stool with his back against the rail to strum his lyre. He was playing the song of the Tide, humming it quietly and striving for something more nostalgic than haunting. Carefully lending the same melody his own voice, to turn it from something sad into something hopeful.

"This one," Phainon mumbled to Peucesta as Mydei approached. He was holding the book up to the bard, pointing at one of the words. They were reading from the Kremnoan tome, Mydei realized.

Peucesta pronounced the word twice for him and added, "it means 'recoup'."

"Thank you, oh, Mydei."

“Deliverer. Peucesta.” Mydei kept his voice quiet to match the mood. “Do you not want to go into town?”

They both shook their heads and Peucesta changed the song to something sleepier and less emotionally charged by way of an answer. Phainon folded the corner of the page in his book to mark his spot and set it aside.

“Are you both well?” Mydei asked instead.

“Yeah, it just,” Phainon mumbled. He struggled to find the words. It hurt to see Phainon of all people struggle to speak.

“The song still bothers you?”

“It doesn’t *bother* me,” Phainon assured him, “it just changes things.”

Mydei frowned. “Do you no longer want your pardon?”

“I *do*! I still think retrieving the Coreflame of Strife is the right step.” His words trailed off again. Phainon’s hands were slowly clenching into fists on the railing. “This pointless rivalry between Okhema and Kremnos feels so *small* when I think of the Black Tide,” he explained, “the more we learn about it, the more I want to go farther than Castrum Kremnos. When we get the coreflame and take it to Okhema, I’m going to tell Aglaea everything and ask for the Okheman Navy to help us fight the Tide.”

“That is a very ambitious plan, Deliverer,” Mydei observed aloud.

Phainon sighed at the name and with a waver in his voice said, “No other choice but forward.”

Mydei could see the doubt that Phainon tried to hide, the struggle of worrying that he wasn’t enough. That something inside him was broken. Even after a few days at sea, days that felt normal and relaxed, Mydei suspected that Phainon was still thinking about the way he had collapsed on deck.

“Come,” Mydei ordered.

“What?”

“Come!” he repeated and then Mydei jumped over the railing. He landed beside the bushes and then jumped over the small wall around his yard to get to the street. Above him, Phainon was still standing on the balcony, confused. Mydei flashed him a smirk, gestured again and then took off running.

Mydei didn’t turn around, he didn’t need to. He could hear Phainon’s boots on the stones on the road behind him. He ran faster.

The hills on this island were steep, but Mydei had found natural paths through the foliage and hidden places that provided ample escape. Leonnius and Hephaestion knew of them too, had even helped Mydei map routes to some of the prettier places. Mydei led Phainon down one

such path, behind a waterfall, along a small cliff, under trees with leaves the same size as they were, until they reached the beach.

He stopped running when they broke free of the trees to the sound of crashing waves. The waterline on this side of the island didn't break on sand, instead it crashed across wide, massive rocks, smooth and flattened by the tide. The waves lapped at the sides of the stone at low tide, slowly eating away at rounded gaps and occasionally spraying the surface with salty droplets.

Mydei walked out onto the plateau, stepping around puddles that were left in the shallow basins in the uneven surface. They glowed like mirrors holding the moonlight. He took a deep breath in through his nose and held the sea air tightly in his chest until it hurt to keep. The breeze picked up and a misty sea spray left tiny droplets like diamonds in his hair and on his clothes and chest.

"Deliverer," Mydei called, turning enough to see his friend still hiding in the tree line.

"Why do you keep calling me that, Mydeimos?" Phainon asked as he slowly stepped out onto the stone, keeping several paces between them. He sounded tired, maybe even a little annoyed, like the weight of the world was starting to get to him.

"Because that is what you are."

Phainon snorted. "I haven't been since Aglaea labeled me a pirate."

"Are you so sure?" Mydei asked.

"Yes. Especially now."

"Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, you do not get to decide," he said.

Phainon's face twisted in surprise, "Huh? What does that mean?"

"It means you are still the Deliverer, and you have no say otherwise."

"I don't think that's how it works, Mydei."

Mydei's tattoos started to glow, just a ripple from his base through his back and chest up his arms to summon several shards of crimson crystal. "It is, and as the stronger fighter, what I say goes."

Phainon twitched. "You are not the stronger fighter."

"Prove it."

Blue flashed in Phainon's hand as he summoned his sword, a serious look on his face. He paced further out onto the stone to stand down the shore from Mydeimos.

They waited in silence until a particularly strong wave bashed against the stone sending a column of water up in the air beside them and then they were racing to close the distance.

This far away from the settlement, Mydei let loose. He opened with a massive wave of crystals aimed at Phainon's left side. Phainon predictably dodged to the right, towards the ocean, but when Mydei rushed to meet him, his claws tore at empty space. He barely managed to raise his gauntlets in time to catch the sword that dropped from above.

They clashed, Phainon's sword weighed heavily in the cross of Mydei's gauntlets with all of Phainon's body behind it as he dropped from his leap. The force pushed Mydei back on the smooth stone. Sparks bounced through puddles, disturbing the water's peace.

Mydei broke the stalemate. He dropped one arm and pushed with the other to cast the sword aside, creating an opening for him to reach for Phainon's chest, but Phainon had spun with the momentum, bringing his sword around in an arc to force Mydei's retreat. The tip of the blade narrowly missed Mydei's nose.

Phainon let the sword finish its swing and neatly spun it into another sweep, following Mydei's backstep with that blade gliding along the ground. He slowed its assault with crystal but couldn't stop it entirely, instead using the opportunity to leap over the blade, towards Phainon with his claws extended.

They broke apart, bouncing away from each other when Mydei landed. He flashed Phainon a toothy grin and licked the gold from his claws. A drop of blood slowly rolled down Phainon's cheek.

"Apologies Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, it looks like you will need to stay our Deliverer after all," he taunted.

Phainon shouted and surged forward, moving faster than Mydei had expected. He raised an arm to intercept the sword, but Phainon was *strong* and the force still launched him towards the tree line. Mydei slid on one knee. Gold shimmered dark in the moonlight as it ran over his gauntlet and the tip of Phainon's sword. The blade had bitten him on his bicep, just above the armor.

"That's more like it," Mydei growled with glee.

Mydei and Phainon exchanged blows with increasing fervor until their roars echoed around the stone arches and sparks from their clashes fell on moonlight in equal measure as the splashing sea. They were evenly matched in every way, pushing each other to heights that Mydei could have only dreamed of before Phainon.

It was the same feeling as the first time they had fought but cultivated into something far more intimate. Mydei didn't need to waste time trying to read his friend, because he already knew. He knew that Phainon was ambidextrous, that he favored movements in threes, that he preferred to lead with his right foot but was willing to use his left if he thought there was an advantage to be seized. And Phainon knew things about Mydei that he couldn't hope to understand. Mydei knew this to be true because when they fought it felt like dancing, like they were a single being relishing in the true joy of Strife and inspiration through challenge.

And the longer they fought the more Phainon relaxed and let himself meet Mydei at every step. Mydei could see the confidence coming back, feel it when that blade reached for his

flesh, and when he was sure that Phainon was more himself than he had been in days, he finally spoke again.

“You should be more honest with yourself,” he told Phainon, “as you are right now.”

Steel screeched against the rocks as Mydei kicked the sword away, but it sang on the return as it swiped from above.

“You think this is me at my most honest?” Phainon laughed.

Mydei grabbed the blade, pinching it between both of his hands to stop it above his head. “I know it is.”

“Will you still be saying that when I win?”

Mydei scoffed, “If you win.” Mydei’s foot connected with Phainon’s stomach, and the Deliverer was sent flying, disconnected from his weapon. Mydei tossed the sword to the side and ran at Phainon to tackle him. They went down in a flurry of limbs, rolling until a rock stopped them.

Phainon panted beneath Mydei, his wrists pinned beside his head, hair spread across the rock and shining with the water from the puddle beneath him. The moonlight caught in the water, making his white hair glow and stealing Mydei’s breath away.

The Kremnoan wiggled a little to settle over Phainon’s lap, boxing him in with his knees and weight while he looked down at that surprised smile that made his heart leap into his throat.

“Phainon, I-“ Mydei caught himself mid-confession, instead saying the last thing Phainon wanted to hear, the last thing he wanted to say, “I want you to stay here.”

“What?” he breathed, disbelieving.

They were still for several heartbeats and then Phainon surged beneath him and they rolled again, this time Phainon had Mydei pinned with a hand on his chest. Seawater dripped from his hair onto Mydei’s face. The moonlight caught the shine of the droplets, casting colors across the white before they fell.

“Do you think me that weak, Mydeimos? That I will break when it matters most?” Phainon asked, with hurt in his words.

It’s because I love you.

“Don’t be absurd.”

“Then why would you request that of me?!” he snarled.

Mydei rolled his hips to buck Phainon forward so he could pull his legs up for the leverage to roll them again. He looped his thumb through Phainon’s collar and pressed his hand to the stone beside his neck, holding him there by the accessory and a hand splayed on that strong

chest. Phainon's hand came up to grab him by the chiton's fabric across his chest. The other held tightly to Mydei's bicep, just below the metal band there.

"Will you not let me do this for you?" Mydei asked with a strain in his voice that made Phainon's eyes go wide and his heart race below Mydei's palm.

"No, we should do it together," Phainon breathed.

"And what if something happens to you?"

Phainon scoffed. "To *me?* What about *you?*"

"I am immortal."

Phainon's hands let go to fall to either side, entirely at Mydei's mercy, completely surrendering to him with a cheeky smile. "I have to go. It's my duty as the Deliverer."

"Then you concede?"

"Just this once, Mydeimos."

"A shame, I would have liked to pummel you unconscious." They had never needed to fight all the way to such a drastic win condition. Someone usually came by to stop them before they could.

Phainon chuckled softly and Mydei felt the butterflies in his stomach take flight. He wanted so badly to kiss this man who glittered like starlight, whose eyes were the sunny sky and whose heart beat out a rhythm of confidence with which Mydei longed to harmonize.

"You are not weak, *Deliverer*," Mydei crooned, "your inner demons do not scare me."

"They scare me," Phainon admitted and Mydei tilted his head with how easily Phainon admitted such a weakness. Phainon brought a hand up to gently push Mydei off so he could get to his feet and brush the dust and sand from his pants. He offered Mydei a hand and pulled him up so they could stand together. "But I'm ready to fight them now, because you have my back."

"HKS," Mydei huffed. He punched Phainon in the shoulder, hard, and that damn man laughed his perfect laugh that made Mydei's knees feel weak. "Together then."

Chapter End Notes

Okay, I cave. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NvumxmsD24o&list=RDNvumxmsD24o&start_radio=1 <-- this is the song. Click at your own risk. I don't feel like it's a spoiler for the game but it IS from HSR, so please bear that in mind if you haven't played Amphoreus. Also please bear in mind that it

MAY spoil some of the fic for you. I don't personally feel like this clue is big enough to tip the entire hand but it is very telling. If you want to find out WITH the characters, don't click on it! If you don't mind having a little reader's privilege, then know that I listened to the song the entire time I wrote the last chapter. :')

Chapter 26: Best Laid Plans

Chapter Summary

I'm looking ahead at my outline here and uh, need new tags: Suggestive Themes, Character Death, Implied/Referenced Character Death
Honestly they should've already been on there cause of Eurypon and Gorgo

With Castrum Kremnos on the horizon, the last of their plans are set in stone

Chapter Notes

This was almost the longest I've gone without updating and it's all Anaxa's fault. I have no idea why he was so hard to write this chapter.

Even after drafting the help of the craftsmen from the settlement, creating enough charms for the entire crew took two days of focused labor. Anaxa concluded that the solution to both of his problems was in the size and shape of the crystal removed from the figurehead. Mydei offered to provide his own crystals instead of chipping away at the lion, but Anaxa refused. Crucially, the crystal had to come from the ship itself, as an extension of Chryseus Leo.

Unfortunately, the wood also had to come from the same source and whole sections of railing were removed and cut into cubes instead of flat sleeves to accommodate the larger sections of crystal. The crew insisted on handling that part, while their Kremnoan friends from the shipyard installed new railings. The smooth new rails were a lighter color than the worn wood and far less interesting without the unique carvings running the length.

“I can’t tell if it’s poetic or weird to be going into battle with a cross section of a story tied to my belt,” Leonnius mused aloud. Phainon was next to him holding a cubical rough section himself. They were sitting on the deck in groups of four each responsible for various stages of the process. Phainon’s group was finishing up the last of the hollowing out process.

“It’s tragic,” Ptolemy grumbled, too upset to even think of a quote, “these designs were carved by shipbuilders and artists that fell to the Tide. Some of them may still be roaming Castrum Kremnos as monsters.”

That was not a pleasant thought. Phainon gently brushed shavings from the inside of his cube with two fingers. They were not small considering the width of the railing. Twine would be wrapped around them so they could be carried like oversized pendants or too full coin sacks at the belt. The twine would hold the crystal inside too with the right wrapping technique.

The girls were in that group. They were happily chatting between themselves as they expertly wrapped the cubes and checked that the crystal chunks were secure. High-stakes arts and crafts somehow fit perfectly in Castorice's element.

Phainon turned back to the cube in his hand. The goal was to leave the remaining walls the same width as a pinky. Hollowed out too thin and the wood may not be sturdy enough to survive a battle. This one was almost done. On three sides it had carvings of men carrying shields and spears, marching towards the cutoff. He held it up to see the faded images a little better and Hephaestion, sitting next to him, held his up too so those marching figures had somewhere to go. They did not match and somehow those warring soldiers ended up marching into a bathhouse.

"It isn't the worst place to end a march," Phainon chuckled.

"It's definitely where I'm going after dinner," Hephaestion agreed.

Leonnius leaned over to see what they were talking about and then held his own cube up between theirs. He had part of a feast on his. The front half of the roast pig had ended up on another cube somewhere, but he still had the curled tail carved just under a group of men raising their glasses in a toast.

"There we go," he added, "the perfect itinerary."

"It's awful that we must do this. It is like losing Castrum Kremnos all over again," Ptolemy lamented. He was still very focused, unwilling to be there any longer than they had to be. Every time he pressed the knife into the wood he winced like he was carving up his own flesh.

"Kremnos' history is us," the first mate reminded him, "it doesn't end because some faded carvings are repurposed."

"Isn't this an ideal situation for them?" Phainon offered. Ptolemy flashed him a glare. "I mean it. Broaden your perspective, Ptolemy. We will be carrying snapshots of history, a part of the ship with us into battle to reclaim your homeland. What better place for Chryseus Leo than protecting his crew even when ashore? If the lion had a choice, wouldn't he want to fight too? In this way he, and the legacy of your people, can be a part of one of the greatest battles since you were last at Castrum Kremnos."

"Well said, Deliverer," Mydei praised as he passed by. The man was coming from the bow with a basket of crystals that he had carved from the lion himself. It was a solemn duty, but Mydei refused to let anyone else chip away at that regal mane, not after he begrudgingly forgave Phainon for doing so once before.

Phainon watched Mydei walk by and his eyes traced the tattoos that spanned his back, his huggable waist, the way his muscles flexed carrying that heavy basket. He wondered what it would feel like to trace those lines with just the press of his fingers, with his tongue…

Leonnius smacked Phainon upside the head. "Ogle on your own time."

“Damn it, Leonnius,” Hephaestion growled, “you are ruining my strategy.”

“If you’re gonna compete, at least keep it fair.”

Apologetically, and blushing profusely, Phainon got back to work, and in the end, he still won. By the time they finished hollowing out their pile of cross-sections, Phainon’s tally was twelve and Hephaestion had finished eleven. Leonnius came in third at eight, proving his hands weren’t as fast as his feet. And Ptolemy was last with only four. He had spent too much time mourning and wincing to be efficient. It was a closer race than Phainon had intended as he had been easily distracted by Mydei and the bittersweet of repurposing these old carvings.

“Perdikkas!” Ptolemy shouted from where they were still sitting.

Across the deck Perdikkas leaned back to see around his own pod of workers. He was on sanding duty.

Ptolemy raised his arm to point dramatically down at Phainon, Perdikkas scowled and ten seconds later a gold coin slammed into Ptolemy’s face with suspicious accuracy. It fell in his lap, leaving behind an imprint but the book worm still chuckled under his breath as he scooped the coin up and rolled it between his fingers.

“’Let heaven give victory to whom it will,’” he quoted as he pocketed the coin, already feeling better now that victory was soothing his emotional wounds.

Phainon knew better than to ask for details. He figured out awhile ago that people were gambling on their competitions. It didn’t stop him from doing his very best at every opportunity.

“Have you finished your assignment?” Anaxa asked as he came to stand over them. The professor had been supervising the entire process, pacing as though he were searching for cheaters in the middle of a test. All four of them held one of the hollowed out cubes up for his approval but he didn’t linger long enough for full inspections and walked on.

Leonnius leaned in and Phainon and the others instinctively mimicked him, getting in close to huddle. “Is he always like this, Phainon?”

“I think the isolation made him nicer.”

All four of them broke the huddle to look at Anaxa’s back, watching the man closely until he paused and quickly spun around to glare at them and then they were hurrying to reconvene.

“That man would snap in a strong breeze and has a literal blind spot,” Hephaestion confided, “so why is he so damn scary?”

“If you have time to gossip like children, then you have time to help others with their tasks,” Anaxa called from above. He had slightly closed the distance to lean over their huddle, making them all flinch in place.

“We were just about to, Professor Anaxa!” Phainon reassured him.

“Anaxagoras.”

“That’s what I said.”

The angry Demigod stalked off to check on the others.

“I need to check with Empousa about our cargo allotment,” Hephaestion said as he got to his feet.

“I’ll find her.”

“Thank you, Leonnius. Ptolemy?” He helped the bookworm to his feet.

“I’ll help the girls. Phainon- Phainon?” Ptolemy turned in time to see Phainon already carrying the big basket of their hollowed-out cubes over to the next station to help with the sanding.

He set them down right in front of Perdikkas and squeezed in between the doctor and Krateros. The former handed him a sheet of sharkskin, already worn but with enough life left to be effective.

“Did you really bet against me?” Phainon teased and Perdikkas groaned.

“Hephaestion dabbled in whittling,” he explained, “got good at it. I thought maybe that gave him an advantage.”

“He did?” Phainon asked. He looked up in time to see Hephaestion leave the ship, presumably to find Empousa as he had previously declared.

“Yeah, Krateros taught him.”

The old man could clearly hear them but refused to engage in the conversation while he sanded away, careful not to damage the images. Every once in awhile he would stop and Phainon thought he may say something unprompted, but each pause was meant for Fig Stew who was dozing on his back in the warm sun. The temptation to reach for Fig’s belly was *right there* but Phainon had learned from that morning that his worthiness to scratch the royal fur was still in question and they didn’t need blood smudges messing with Anaxa’s perfect formula.

“Krateros, you whittle?” Phainon asked.

“Woodworking was a hobby of mine when I was younger.” Gruff words landed flatly between them and Phainon took the hint.

“I wouldn’t have expected that,” he offered politely but didn’t push the topic, instead they fell into a comfortable and drowsy rhythm with the *shushush* of sharkskin on splintery edges.

Phainon made a point to work at every station. When they were done sanding, he helped with the waxing, then on to polishing and shaping the crystals to fit them neatly inside each box, ending next to Castorice and Hyacine who showed him how to properly tie the twine. The

rough cord wrapped around all sides of the cube multiple times to cover the missing side and hold the crystal in place. The light coat of wax along the inside hollow helped keep each piece from clattering around but there was still some give to them, and they rattled with muted thuds when shaken.

Phainon put the last charm in the shallow crate just as the thief star dashed across the sky, brilliant white and twinkling good night.

“How did we do, Professor Anaxa?” Phainon asked.

“…”

“…Professor Anaxagoras.”

“Passable.”

In a world that was mostly pass or fail, Phainon took that as praise.

Anaxa took one off the top and ran his hand over each side. He shook it violently for a few seconds and then bounced it gently between his hands, letting the talisman roll as naturally as possible. Satisfied with their durability he put the piece back where he got it and pulled the lid over the top. The box would be stored safely in Mydei and Phainon’s room until it was time. They didn’t want to risk losing any on the journey through hostile waters.

Most of the crew had left the ship as the number of tasks to complete decreased to tend to last-minute plans and packing. The partying had not persisted past their first night on shore, but the town was still very alive and bright. Streetlamps were staving off the dark of dusk, glowing gold under navy blue and dying orange. The hum of people talking carried across the dock like the distant buzz of a beehive, indiscernible as words but thrumming with life.

Castorice and Hyacine had already excitedly left to find food, leaving Phainon and Anaxa alone on the deck. Mydei was around there somewhere too and Phainon was eager to meet up with him, but thinking of Mydei also brought up memories of their fight on the beach and the things that Mydei had said.

Even if Phainon had swayed the Kremnoan in the end, it still stung to recall that Mydei had wanted to leave Phainon behind, even after insisting that Phainon retain the symbolic title, ‘Deliverer.’ A name that Phainon still wasn’t so sure about after Aglaea’s warrant and his own willingness to reject it.

“Will you be coming with us to Castrum Kremnos, professor?” Phainon asked.

Anaxa was using both of his hands and little bunny hops to push the lid down. He was a strong man but too small to benefit from the same leverage literally any other full-grown man on the ship had. Phainon stepped up to help, pressing down until the lid wedged shut.

“Of course. I want to see this success with my own eyes.” He waved a hand down at the box, indicating that said ‘success’ was not the retrieval of the coreflame, but rather that his design

performed to his personal high standard. “But that’s not really what you want to talk about, is it?”

“…nothing ever escapes you.”

“I didn’t spend all those years teaching you for nothing.”

“Lately, I’ve been thinking about the name Aglaea gave me, that’s all. I’ve been wondering why she chose me to carry it,” Phainon explained.

“And you think *I’d* have some perfect answer to lay your concerns to rest, *Deliverer* of Okhema?” Anaxa sounded more annoyed than bored, but Phainon knew that of the two, bored was worse.

“Do you?”

“No, I don’t.”

He sighed and looked down, “I thought so.”

“Because it’s a ridiculous question to be concerned about in the first place,” Anaxa scoffed, “Why are you fretting over *that* woman’s choice on her behalf? Or is it that you are afraid that you cannot live up to the expectations that have been attributed to a single word? Are you only *you* because Aglaea gave you a fancy title? Listen up, I’ll say this once. There is value in rising to expectations but not because others have challenged you to meet them, but rather because you have chosen to accept that challenge, to match those expectations with those you have for yourself. If you truly want to be worthy of being the *Deliverer*, then stop wasting time wondering why she chose you, and prove to yourself that she was right to.”

Phainon considered that thoughtfully. He didn’t tell Anaxa that Aglaea had rejected him as their Deliverer, that his concerns stemmed from *Mydei* refusing to let Phainon throw the mantle away. But the advice was still sound regardless, and Phainon *did* want to be worthy of the title for Mydei’s sake. It was the Kremnoan that was throwing the challenge to encourage Phainon to be the best possible version of himself, and who was Phainon to deny Mydei?

“Thank you, Prof. I’ll keep that in mind.”

“See that you do.” Anaxa didn’t wait around for Phainon to keep asking questions. The professor already seemed annoyed at the one so Phainon didn’t try to stop him when the man walked away to leave the ship.

Choosing the title himself… Phainon had a hard time with stuff like that. It wasn’t something he ever really considered and something as grand as the “Deliverer”? He was just Phainon, the son of a farmer, turned warrior by circumstance. A fancy title didn’t magically make him amazing, but it didn’t take away from who he already was either. Rejecting the title, or embracing it, Phainon still wanted to defend people, to fight for them and their dreams.

“Deliverer,” Mydei called and Phainon looked up as his thoughts stalled. The captain was on the forecastle deck, looking at Phainon with his head tilted. “I thought you had already left.”

“I was about to,” Phainon shouted back, “come with me?”

Mydei shrugged and leaped over the railing, skipping the stairs to save time as he walked up to Phainon. “Food and then bath.”

“Aye aye, Captain,” Phainon teased.

Challenge accepted. He would be the Deliverer, because Mydei believed in him and that was enough.

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Chryseus Leo’s sendoff was no grander than any other departure. They left early with the tide, pointed the bow North, and made great time with a favorable wind. Free time was spent preparing, polishing shields, sharpening swords, and quiet moments of meditation. But even though the crew went through the motions of a stereotypical journey the air was charged with anticipation.

Mydei could feel it on every single one of his men. It practically dripped like condensation from the sails and clung to every word in every exchange as they crossed into the Tide line. The days still turned and stars still glittered at night, but at all hours the ocean was black as the shadow in the hearts of evil men. A lesser crew may have turned and run, abandoning any notion of success, but Mydei’s pride was in the resolve of every single crewmate, not one of which decided to stay behind.

This crew had not set out on a more personal endeavor since they sailed for Castrum Kremnos nearly six years prior to kill Eurypon. Homecomings were not supposed to be met with steel and blood but what other choice could there be for Kremnoans? It was poetic in a twisted way.

Mydei watched the men work from where he was sitting on the railing. The Black Tide kept reaching for him in splashes, but it fell short every time. Some of these men would not survive this fight, he knew that. That held true every time they donned their armor and leapt into battle with eager roars and what better way to say goodbye than embracing what they loved, what they genuinely believed in?

He wasn’t so sure. Krateros saw this campaign as the first step towards a renewed Kremnoan Dynasty, that they were following their *King* into battle to reclaim their homeland so that the Kremnoan people could return in glory and begin anew in the ways of Strife. Exactly what Mydei *didn’t* want.

“You look like you swallowed a bug.”

Mydei huffed and slowly turned towards Hephaestion.

“The protein is good for you,” the first mate added, “…Mydei, you don’t have to worry about us.”

“I never have.”

“Not out loud.”

Mydei grunted.

“…we wanted this too,” Hephaestion reassured him.

The prince turned his head back to look over the ship again, not ignoring his first mate, but not exactly eager to discuss it either.

Undaunted, Hephaestion leaned against the railing, hanging on the shrouds with one hand. “It is not lost on the crew how important this campaign is. For many of them it is returning home and to fight what may be the hardest and glorious fight of our entire lives.”

“We will not be able to purge the Tide from the city,” Mydei cautioned, “routing the enemy is not the goal of this campaign.”

“Mydeimos, we know.”

“This is not a permanent return.”

“Not this time.”

“Not ever,” Mydei growled and Hephaestion let go of the shroud so his arm could fall to his side.

“You still won’t pick up the crown.”

Mydei looked down. “Does that bother you?”

Disappointment was all over Hephaestion’s face and his heart burned to feel like he was letting his people down, but long hair waved back and forth across his shoulders as Hephaestion shook his head. His features softened and he smiled to say, “Maybe a little. It was always our hope that you’d lead us back someday as King, but we trust you, Mydeimos, and still follow you even unto death with or without your crown.”

“It is a comfort to hear you say that, my friend.”

“I would continue to tell Krateros that you are still deciding though,” he joked.

Mydei didn’t laugh.

“Have you given anymore thought to how you will propose to Phainon?” Hephaestion asked instead.

Mydei lost his balance and fell off the ship. He caught the railing with one hand as he fell and scrambled his way back on board to flop on the deck with Hephaestion’s help.

“Titan’s, Mydei, I was kidding!” Hephaestion laughed.

Mydei punched his shin and the first mate dropped to the deck beside him, still chuckling but now within strangling reach. Just before Mydei could get his hand around Hephaestion's neck, the first mate wrapped his arm around Mydei's and the two of them rolled, wrestling all the way across the top deck to slam into the side of the tiller to get yelled at by the helmsman. Mydei growled low in his throat when he finally got Hephaestion in a chokehold.

"Alright, alright, bad joke!" Hephaestion wheezed. He frantically tapped Mydei's arm until he was released to chuckle through his coughing.

They sat on the deck just enjoying each other's company for long moment while Hephaestion ran his fingers through his hair to try and fix it after the brawl.

"Don't die, Hephaestion," Mydei ordered in a soft voice that completely caught the man off guard.

Hephaestion snickered a little, "I don't think you have a say in that, Mydeimos."

"I am your Prince and Captain; you have to do as I say."

"Don't be a child, Mydei. It would be an incredible honor to die fighting for Castrum Kremnos."

"You self-exiled," Mydei reminded him.

"And you never lived there," Hephaestion turned it around, "the heart still longs for our homeland."

"Reminiscing about the past doesn't change anything," Mydei grumbled, but Hephaestion was right on all accounts, especially that it was disrespectful to worry. He trusted his men as his family. There were no stronger fighters in Amphoreus than those that belonged to this crew.

"If I *should* die," Hephaestion told him, "do not mourn."

"All weakness, grief, and grudges will be settled on the battlefield," Mydei agreed.

"And promise me you will make Phainon your first mate."

"If he accepts the invitation to join the crew," he promised.

"Oh, Mydei," Hephaestion laughed, "he will. The moment he has that pardon in his hand, ask him, and he will say yes."

"And you will be there to see it."

Before Hephaestion could snap at Mydei for his stubbornness, a low rumble across the water brought them back to standing. It was still Action Hour but had been overcast since they crossed into Black Tide waters, softening the light with gray clouds. But the way ahead was darker, navy blue and black like the sky was bruised and the distant thunder rolled without rain or lightning.

“The Lance of Fury,” Hephaestion mumbled in airy awe.

Mydei’s eyes narrowed as he scanned the horizon. The wind was changing, the sails fluttered and popped as the canvas was teased and there in the black was a glimmer of gold light.

“We will be there by the next Entry Hour,” Mydei observed, “gather the others for the war council.”

Hephaestion took a long second to obey, too focused on that same distant point. Most of the crew felt the ripple of Nikador’s call to arms and were getting antsy. It was unlikely anyone would be able to sleep tonight.

Mydei slapped his arm to get him moving and then followed him down the stairs where they went separate directions. In anticipation of everyone meeting, Mydei wanted to be mentally prepared. Krateros had already helped him determine a strategy over the course of the past several days, so the maps were already spread across the table in his room.

Fig Stew was waiting there, grooming himself on the map when Mydei entered the room and walked over to offer the chimera scratches.

“Now that I am here,” Mydei confided in the animal, “I worry I may have been too ambitious.”

Fig Stew cooed at him and stopped his grooming to lean into Mydei’s hand, accepting the scratches to his face, his back, and finally his sensitive belly.

“Perhaps I should I have done the normal thing and started my courting by gifting him a shield or perhaps flowers as Okhemans do,” he sighed.

It was more than that of course. What may have started as fetching a gift for Phainon meant much, much more now. This wasn’t just about Mydei’s personal future, it was also a resolution for the older crew, finishing what they started when they were last here. It was a military step towards safety for their island under siege. A chance to lay to rest their broken Titan in a manner befitting Strife. And it was those and a hundred other reasons that made this campaign important enough to weigh like the world and be worth the blood they would undoubtedly pay.

The door opened and the first of Mydei’s friends entered. They offered him warm smiles and firm nods as everyone picked their favorite chairs and squabbled over the less squeaky stools. The Chrysos Heirs arrived together. The girls were giggling about something under their breath while Phainon protested in flustered whispers.

He was cute when he was flustered. The pink in his cheeks and ears was just a shade darker than rosy and the way Phainon danced in place made Mydei want to pounce on him, hold him down and feel the heat of Phainon’s face with his lips. Krateros closing the door behind him snapped Mydei from the early stages of an inappropriate longing.

The captain’s quarters were not small, but it was struggling a bit with this capacity. All five of his Kremnoan unit leaders (and best friends), all four Chrysos Heirs, Krateros, and of course

himself and Fig Stew.

“Krateros,” Mydei invited and the quiet chattering in the room stopped.

The old man stepped up to the table. Anaxa hung back, so did Peucesta for now, but the others crowded around the map. Displayed on the table was a detailed layout of Castrum Kremnos. The map on top was of the outer city, the map below was the inner city, but Mydei didn’t need to review the latter, as he would be personally escorting the small group that was delving that deep into the city.

“Krateros and I have discussed the best strategy for this campaign,” Mydei announced, “as a reminder, the purpose of this mission is to slay Nikador and retrieve the Coreflame of Strife. The city is too vast and too populated to rout with a small crew and the Black Tide’s constant presence, but the fall of the Titan should weaken the Tide’s hold in this corner of the world all the same.” Mydei opened a couple of shallow drawers to fetch a few generic figurines that he placed on the table. “To this end, we have decided that it is best if only Chrysos Heirs breach the inner city, while the crew remains behind to hold the bay. Phainon, Castorice, and I will take the first opportunity to sneak into the city while the crew holds the attention of the Tide’s forces and the corrupted Titankin.”

“Lord Mydei,” Hyacine called softly, “do you not want me to accompany you?”

“No. I have faith in Professor Anaxagoras’ creation protecting my men, but we cannot be sure of our timeline nor ignore the risk that they may be parted with that protection,” Mydei explained, “I would rather you stay with Peucesta’s unit to administer aid as needed.”

“Not Perdikkas?”

“I lead my own unit in combat,” Perdikkas explained, “we do not have dedicated medical personnel on simple campaigns like this.”

“What do you do if someone gets hurt?” she asked.

“Everyone is trained in basic field medicine,” Hephaestion explained, “a friend binds the wound so the man can continue fighting.”

“We do not fear death by the sword or spear, Miss Hyacine,” Leonnius explained, “we fear the shameful death of succumbing to wounds or illness.”

Phainon put a hand on her shoulder to stop her protests. The two heirs looked at each other in silence, Phainon reassuring, Hyacine questioning, until she relented and nodded her understanding. “I will do my very best to ensure that you are all able to keep fighting then.”

“If any man is parted from his talisman, then they are to be rushed to Miss Hyacine,” Krateros ordered and was met with a wave of mumbled agreement.

“Miss Castorice,” Mydei said next, and she stepped forward, happily squeezing between Phainon and Hyacine so she could see the map. “Phainon and I will have no trouble safely

navigating the inner city on our own, but I worry about our escape. I have been told that you are an army unto yourself."

"I will hold the line, Lord Mydei," she promised, "wherever you tell me to draw it."

He nodded and then gestured to Krateros.

The old man leaned forward and gathered several of the figurines to set them in places across the map. "We will be assuming a formation for defense, not an assault," he instructed, "with the Chryseus Leo as our designated target to defend at all costs." The veteran pointed to a few roads on the map, addressing the Kremnoans. "If you recall, when we last led an assault on this city we left behind barricades in these three places to manage our escape. It is possible that those barriers were removed but if they remain it would be in our best interest to reinforce them and if they are not, then they need to be replaced using the surrounding structures here and here.

"Hephaestion and Leonnius will take the West roads, Ptolemy and Perdikkas, the East. That leaves my unit and Peucesta to manage the North and command."

Krateros used his hand and the pieces to clearly indicate the areas that each unit would be responsible for keeping. Both the West and East zones contained four roads each with instructions to limit that access to two chokepoints at most and, if it was safe and reasonable to do so, narrow that down to one. The largest road to the shipyards and bay was from the North. There was no hope of blocking that route, which was why the bulk of their forces would be stationed there under Krateros.

Their primary goal was the protection of the ship; their secondary goal was to make noise to attract the Tide. The distraction would clear the way for Mydei and Phainon. If Castorice's prowess as a Demigod of Death was not understated, then the forces they had to worry about would only be a problem at the start when they were on fresh legs and arms. By the time the crew would start to feel fatigued, Castorice would begin fighting from deeper within the city, creating a war for the Tide on two fronts.

"Changes in plans will be communicated to both fronts through Peucesta's horn," Krateros reminded them, "if your side needs reinforcements, communicate in kind. Leonnius, will you choose runners for all three groups?"

"I already have three in mind."

"You are drawing the line far enough into the city to allow room to fallback, so take advantage if you need to," Mydei reminded them, emphasizing the line that Krateros had already marked, "when we return with the coreflame, Peucesta will sound the retreat. Emphasize to your men the importance of heeding that call, the Leo cannot wait for those that may fall behind whether it be to death or bloodlust. Krateros, if something changes and the hour grows late, retreat without us and move the Leo away from the dock to rest and care for the charms."

"As you command, Prince Mydeimos. Valorous death before glorious return," Krateros said firmly to the table.

The Kremnoans nodded their agreement, caught up in the excitement of the moment.

“May victory be yours, Mydeimos,” Hephaestion added with a closed fist over his heart in salute. The others did the same, repeating the words and bowing their heads ever so slightly in respect. Even Phainon held his hand over his heart, smiling at Mydei in such a way as to fill him with courage.

Mydei resisted the urge to correct them. It was right to wish victory towards their commander as a representation of all of them. In honoring him, they were wishing for success for the mission as a whole, so he accepted the gesture with grace, returning their salute, but he did not repeat Krateros’ words as he was expected to.

Instead, he muttered an order, “Get some rest.”

Chapter 27: The Assault on Castrum Kremnos

Chapter Summary

No new tags, but I did have to push the chapter count back again... Forgive me for my inability to self-assess my yapping. @.@

Everyone says goodbye and the operation begins!

Chapter Notes

Edit: If this chapter reads funny it's cause it was funny to write and rereading it I was like... why does this feel off? And then I posted it and was organizing my notes and it explicitly says "Phainon's POV through CK" so, uh, oops? I'll leave it up for now but uh, I might spend tomorrow rewriting the last half and sneaky replacing it with Phainon's internal dialogue instead cause I feel like that will fix the funny feeling in my head.
If you read it NOW, the plot and dialogue won't change, the story is still the same, you just get the little bonus of Mydei's POV for now and there's no need to revisit after I fix it unless you really want to.

Edit 2: I FIXED IT. IT WAS A FAST FIX. Goodness that feels so much better.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

No one slept. How could they when the Chryseus Leo was anchored within spitting distance of Castrum Kremnos, listening to the rolling thunder of Strife who waited in the city for them? Phainon had laid in his hammock listening to Mydei's breathing, knowing that he was also awake and contemplating the day in their silence. Part of him wanted to spring out of bed with his excitement and encourage the crew to leave early! If no one was sleeping then what were they waiting for?

But still he lay until the Entry Hour and that feeling of beginning that dawn so frequently carried in its wake. All the good poems and stories spoke of noble deeds beginning at dawn, and what else could this be but a noble, heroic pursuit?

So, they waited in the dark quiet until neither of them could bear it any longer and even then the silence followed them to breakfast where the crew drifted in and out like ghosts. They were quiet as they walked back to the room, and it was quiet while they got dressed in their most iconic signature looks.

"Mydei," Phainon softly said, testing that first break of their comfortable silence

Mydei grunted.

“Don’t forget when we get the coreflame,” he paused, lingering for dramatic effect, “you have to tell me which pirate stole your heart.” Phainon flashed him a cheeky smile and the consequential blush in Mydei’s cheeks was worth the ice breaker.

“HKS,” the man huffed but he chased it with a sigh to say, “I will. Deliverer, will you be alright?”

“Of course, Mydei.” Phainon flinched just a hair when Mydei grabbed his wrist.

“Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, are you *sure*?” he asked again with burning in his eyes and a steeliness to the way he clenched his jaw.

It would be an easy thing to play and tease but Phainon and Mydei knew each other better than that by now. Mydei would see through the deflection, keep his quiet, but close himself off to be upset at the dishonesty. Even if Phainon did it to reassure, it was still hiding, and he didn’t want to hide from Mydei at this critical juncture.

“No,” Phainon said instead, his own anxiety laid bare for Mydei’s inspection, “but I have been working with Peucesta and the song no longer calls to mind those horrible visions and Perdikkas has taught me more techniques alongside the ones I learned from Aglaea.” He twisted his wrist in Mydei’s grip so he could hold the prince’s hand. “Most of all, I have you, and you give me courage.”

Mydei broke eye contact and pulled away. “Don’t be so sentimental, Deliverer. There will be enough of that today without your honeyed words.”

“Of course, Captain.”

“Finish getting dressed,” Mydei ordered, “I’ll meet you on the top deck when you have finished preparing.”

“Of course, Captain,” Phainon repeated with the same playful, reassuring lilt in his voice.

Mydei gave him another once over, punched Phainon lightly in the shoulder, and then excused himself.

Alone, Phainon let his smile fall to gather himself under the weight of emotion. He really wasn’t afraid. Even with those lingering flashbacks that haunted him at the worst times, he wasn’t worried. Thinking of Mydeimos was enough to stave off all his fears, leaving behind excitement, the thrill of the battle lurking under his skin. Today, they would end the war between their nations with the death of a Titan. Today, they removed Strife from the world and pushed back the Tide from this corner of the ocean, saving the last of the Kremnoan people from the same fate as Aedes Elysiae.

The chill that ran up and down Phainon’s spine jumpstarted his movements and he ceased his delay, getting dressed carefully but with confidence. Then he left to find Mydeimos.

Phainon found Mydei on the top deck as promised but he wasn't alone. He was meeting with his unit leaders, the five friends that had welcomed Phainon into their family on the crew. They stood beside and around their Crown Prince, each taking turns meeting with him. Phainon hung back, waiting on the stairs to not intrude.

One at a time they exchanged quiet words with Mydei, grasped forearms and touched foreheads in intimate Kremnoan farewell. For each one of them, the captain held them close with his free hand around the back of their necks, resting firmly to decide himself how long each embrace should last as they silently conferred blessings without words.

When the last man, Hephaestion, pulled away, Perdikkas called softly to Phainon.

He jumped and hesitantly approached the group. "I did not intend to intrude," he apologized.

"Intrude?" Perdikkas questioned.

"If anything, you are late," Hephaestion told him. The first mate extended his hand to Phainon.

It took him a second to realize what Hephaestion was doing and then he held both hands up, palms out to say, "Oh, no I really couldn't, this is sacred to Kremnoans…"

Hephaestion's hand lashed out to grab Phainon's raised arm, clasping him tightly below the elbow before stepping forward into his space. His other hand hooked around the back of Phainon's neck, and he pulled the man forward until their foreheads bashed together. Phainon stared at Hephaestion's closed eyes, feeling a little awkward at the closeness.

"I know, Phainon," the first mate whispered, "and you have more than earned it."

He held on until Phainon gripped him back and closed his eyes, basking in the moment of shared respect, the well wishes for the battle ahead, the understanding that this could be the last time they see each other alive, and that was okay.

"May victory always be yours, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, my brother," the first mate said firmly, leaving Phainon at a loss for words.

Hephaestion let him go and Perdikkas took his place, holding Phainon's arm and leaning forward to press his forehead to Phainon's.

"Take care of him," the doctor whispered, "and yourself. You both are precious to us."

Humbled, Phainon squeezed Perdikkas' arm and said, "I will."

Leonnius was next with a playful, "When we win, you'll show us Okhema proper, yeah?"

Phainon laughed and their foreheads bumped together. Neither of them closed their eyes like they were supposed to, too mischievous for that. "I promise, Leonnius."

The runner pulled away but took a second to wrap his arm around Phainon's neck to pull the man down for a solid hair ruffle, neatly undoing all of Phainon's hard work trying to comb it

this morning! Phainon still laughed and shoved the man playfully away.

“I told you once that ‘a friend with an understanding heart is worth no less than a brother,’” Ptolemy told Phainon as he stepped up and took the man’s arm. They leaned in and touched foreheads, and Ptolemy squeezed a little harder. “I meant every word then. I mean it even more now.”

“I have no words to express how honored I am, Ptolemy,” Phainon told him.

“Then show me with actions, as you have been, Deliverer.” Ptolemy smiled at him when they pulled away and stepped aside with one last pat to Phainon’s back.

Peucesta twanged three notes, the first three of the Tide song, before he tucked the lyre under his arm and offered his hand to Phainon, inviting rather than grabbing as the others had. Phainon didn’t hesitate to reach for it and even moved to hold Peucesta’s neck as Hephaestion had to him, holding them close for a second before he let his hand fall between them.

“Give me something more to sing of, Phainon,” Peucesta said in his soft whisper, “let me sing of the heroes that brought Nikador low.”

“For no other reason, than to give you your epic,” Phainon promised, and then the bard stepped back to join the others, leaving Phainon feeling full. These were *goodbyes*, he should feel sorrow, knowing this was a Kremnoan parting, a salute with the expectation of death, but instead Phainon felt sustained, like he was no longer a lone hero but a part of something bigger. They had willingly offered up a part of themselves and graciously accepted a part of him, a reminder that he would not be fighting this battle alone, even if they should fall, he carried them in every swing of his sword.

Phainon looked for Mydei next, half-expecting the captain to want to exchange the gesture as well, but he was set apart, standing several paces away to say goodbye to Krateros in the same manner.

“Well, duty calls,” Leonnius said to the small group.

“And we will answer,” Hephaestion added before herding his companions away, leaving Phainon to wait.

Krateros and Mydei whispered for a couple minutes and then the old man bowed and hurried to tend to his last-minute duties, giving Phainon a window to approach. When Mydei turned back to him, Phainon already had his hand extended.

Mydei looked at it, then up at Phainon’s face, then back to his hand. He slapped it away.

“M-Mydei!” Phainon felt genuinely hurt.

“HKS, what did I say about sentimentality? That is a *farewell*,” Mydei scolded, “and you will be fine and by my side the entire time.”

He walked to the railing and Phainon followed, the both of them studying the giant blade over the city. The sky was dark with rolling black clouds but the light from Nikador's sword made the city feel as day.

"Phainon, when I called you Deliverer," Mydei started but Phainon put his hand on Mydei's shoulder to stop him.

"I know."

"…do you?" Mydei prodded, "Do you presume to know what I wanted to say?"

"That you call me Deliverer, because you believe in me, not as an omnipotent savior but as an ally in battle that you can trust to do right by you and your people?"

Mydei's eyes widened by a fraction, eyebrows raised, and his jaw dropped just enough to part his lips. He scowled to hide his surprise and turned away from Phainon entirely with his arms crossed. "A lucky guess."

Phainon chuckled and put his arm around Mydei's shoulders to pull him back around. "Or maybe I just know you better than you think I do."

Mydei's demeanor softened. This close Phainon could smell the sweet scents that Mydei liked to comb into his hair and add to the washbasin before wiping himself clean of the day, could feel the way Mydei leaned into him, the way Mydei's eyelids drooped even though he was still trying to pretend to be mad. Mydei's foot bumped into Phainon's as he stepped in closer to keep his balance and it took genuine strength to not kiss Mydei right there.

The feeling caught Phainon by surprise and he let go to lean on the railing instead. His imagination thought Mydei seemed disappointed but that couldn't be, not when Mydei was already in love with someone. It had to be Hephaestion, *maybe* Perdikkas? Phainon tucked those thoughts away when the curiosity was outweighed by the churning sickness in his stomach and he realized that imagining Mydei with someone didn't make him as happy as he thought he would be. He cared about Mydei, they were best friends, it felt *wrong* not being happy for him.

"My Prince," Krateros called. They both turned around enough to look over their shoulders at the veteran. "It's time."

Mydei nodded and pushed away from the side of the ship to walk to the top of the stairs to stand beside Fig Stew who was perched, waiting on the railing. The whole crew was on deck, armed to the teeth with shining steel and bronze. Even the Chrysos Heirs stood near the back, Anaxa reunited with his firearm, Hyacine holding her staff. Phainon stood just behind Mydei, not wanting to be in the way, feeling out of place standing beside Krateros as though he were someone of importance.

"Sons and Daughters of Strife!" Mydei called them and Phainon's heart swelled when he realized that included himself and his friends. "Words have already been said of the importance of this campaign and the weight of that which we now shoulder, not only for our own glory but for that of all Kremnoans, Okhemans, and Chrysos Heirs. What we do here,

what we accomplish today, will set in motion the course of the future for all of Amphoreus, a brighter future free of the threat of the Black Tide." Mydei bowed his head for a moment and reached one hand out to rest on Fig Stew's head. He pet the chimera reverently before lifting his gaze again with fire in his eyes and roaring in his growl. "I know I need not ask of you to give your all in the coming conflict, so instead I swear on my own golden blood that I will give a thousand of my own lives to celebrate this triumph beside you all. Fight for that future, and when fate's inescapable grasp comes for you, resist it with the strength of your mighty will that we may raise our glasses over the Coreflame of Strife and toast this most valorous victory!"

Fig Stew roared his tiny roar and the crew followed suit, cheering with renewed vigor and an eagerness that carried in their chant, "The son of Gorgo will be crowned in blood!"

Mydei let them cheer for him three times before he raised his hand to silence them and then he nodded at Krateros who took command, shouting in Kremnoan, "To oars! To lines! Raise anchor!"

The crew hurried to get the ship moving, to close the final gap between the open ocean and the dock. Phainon stepped up beside Fig Stew and Mydei with a pat on the chimera's butt. He tried to sneak a scratch at the animal's belly, one last try for luck but the low growl stopped that idea in its tracks and Phainon turned to Mydei instead.

"And they say I'm a wordsmith," Phainon teased.

"Deliverer," Mydei said very seriously, "do you have my back?"

"Always, Mydeimos."

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It wasn't lost on Phainon as they raced through the back streets of Castrum Kremnos that this was a dream come true in the weirdest possible way. He had longed to visit the city of warriors his whole life, but he had imagined bright skies and a brighter people, the full glory of the Kremnoans he had come to love on display under crimson banners and guarded by the glittering bronze, blue, and white of the fabled Titankin.

But this… this was the wrong kind of life. Crumpled stone and long shadows of near eternal night painted the backdrop for the twisted orange glow of the black Tide. The only other light was from the Blade of Fury that glinted from the bronze fixtures above doorways and capping columns. Grass and vines desperately tried to grow from tears in the stone beneath their feet, choking on the smooth Black Tide that whispered its sweet song with every step.

Phainon could hear the whispers under the distant sounds of battle that they left behind as he and Castorice followed Mydei into the depths of dilapidation. Every monster they came across crumpled in seconds as they raced, too focused to even keep score, too worried about removing another monster that would otherwise be racing to the noise to slam into the barricades to attack their friends. The moment they had made berth, the three had left the others behind, war horns and the cacophony of battle the only hint they had that everyone was okay, embracing the battle, and fighting to their hearts content. And there was plenty to

fight. Phainon could feel the vibrations of rumbling footsteps on the main road not far from where they were running.

They didn't slow down until the Black Tide thinned and a massive wall rose in front of them and then Mydei switched to a brisk walk. This far from the fighting and the noise, Phainon could hear the song louder in the back of his mind, threatening to pull him back to darker days but every step made it easier to ignore, not only because he had Mydei's back to watch, but because of the city he wanted to see.

This path that they had run had taken them through courtyards, around dry fountains, under massive arches, and glorious atriums. Everything was built to last with thick columns and dense walls that could endure the mightiest armies and navies. Only the Black Tide could've felled this mighty city, no work of man could've brought her low. Even as they trampled through the fog, making the Tide curl and churn around their boots, Phainon wondered how such a mighty dynasty could have fallen.

"Lord Mydei," Castorice spoke softly, lest they be discovered once more. "Is this where you lived?"

"I was not raised in Castrum Kremnos," he told her, "If I had, I would have lived in the inner city."

"Are you sure you know where we're going?" Phainon asked.

"Five years ago, this is the path I took to meet my father. I will not soon forget the way."

Phainon could hear the pain in Mydei's voice. It was subtle but there. Even though he wasn't raised here, Mydei still respected and loved his culture and heritage. This city was still a part of him and the last time he was here it was still vibrant and alive. He couldn't imagine that pain, couldn't imagine what it would be like to see Aedes Elysiae again after all this time.

"Be wary as we near the acropolis," Mydei cautioned, "we will also have to contend with Nikador's Titankin."

"Have they also turned?" Phainon asked.

"No, but they will have still succumbed to depravity like their Titan. Smashing them to pieces would be the greatest mercy."

Phainon almost slammed into Mydei's back when the man came to a sudden stop. Was their path taking them over rooftops? Or perhaps much of the city was built underground, either way the way was lost, one of the footbridges collapsed, hanging limply on the far side of a sizeable drop and within eyeshot of a distant, massive gate.

"I had higher hopes for the master masons of Castrum Kremnos," Phainon teased as he stepped up beside his friend. "Seems even Kremnoan craftsmanship can be unreliable sometimes."

"The outer city was built by convicts," Mydei explained.

“Maybe they were taking their grievances out on you.”

“Doesn’t matter. There’s no shame in resistance here.”

“Is there a way around?” Castorice asked.

“Undoubtedly,” Mydei confirmed, “but it may take time to find a safe route, and I am unfamiliar with the surrounding streets.”

“We could split up,” Phainon thought aloud, but it would be hard to find each other again to communicate a discovery.

Castorice shuffled and then quietly offered, “I will ask Pollux for help. It is nearly time for them to join the fight anyway.”

“Pollux?” Mydei started to ask but Phainon was already grabbing his arm and pulling him out of the way. Phainon had met Pollux twice before and learned both times the importance of distance.

The air around Castorice grew heavy and dark, wind spiraled around her, chasing away the mist of the Tide like fog against the rising sun. She gathered herself and stretched her hand into the empty space before her; petals condensed in the air and gathered rapidly at the Demigod’s command forming a scythe in a flash of light. The elegant curve sliced the air as she spun, tearing into space itself.

“So, this is the might of the Demigod of Death,” Mydei mumbled beside him. Phainon’s hand pulled at his chiton again, pulling him further down the road to make space as massive claws reached from within the void to pry the gash open into a gaping wound. The dragon burst free in a shower of butterflies and flower petals that somehow worked with Pollux’s natural grace. Castorice had told Phainon once that the petals were from the land of the dead, that there grew the most beautiful blue flowers that the dragon slept beside.

It was quiet like its counterpart, Castorice, with scales the same purple hues ranging from the sky at night to the lavender of fresh flowers and a surprisingly soft appearance bordering on cute. Castorice patted the beast’s nose and whispered to it softly while Mydei and Phainon returned to her side.

“To think you command such a creature…” Mydei praised.

“I do not command Pollux,” she corrected gently, “they are my companion in death, the other half of the Coreflame in my chest, and the keeper of the Netherealm in my absence.”

The dragon rumbled, content to be called upon. Castorice very rarely called upon Pollux, it was hard for it to keep form away from the Netherealm and it frequently had to retreat to rest so they were only for emergencies, or the occasional treat. Phainon knew that nose could happily pierce the veil for nuzzles and cookies whenever Pollux wanted them.

Its wings fluttered in the breeze when it craned that mighty head over the trio to see the bridge that had collapsed under the passage of time.

“Can Pollux not fly us all the way to Nikador?” Phainon asked.

“I do not think Pollux would mind,” Castorice offered but Mydei shook his head.

“Nikador’s lance is especially deadly when thrown. Any approach from the sky is doomed to fail.”

Phainon frowned to himself as he remembered stories of Nikador’s thrown spears. They were said to appear like rain, thrown from such a distance and with such accuracy that many that fell beneath those golden blades never knew that Nikador approached. But then why didn’t…

Pollux shifted and Phainon was pulled from his thoughts. One massive leathery wing laid flat across the gap, creating a means for them to cross and both he and Mydei were able to reach the far side safely.

Castorice was the last, but she paused before taking a step. The sounds of screeching were getting louder, the drag of flesh on stone no longer a distant murmur. Pollux twisted its head to track the sounds with curiosity and the low rumble of a warning growl.

“Lord Mydei, is this far enough?” she asked.

Phainon looked to the Kremnoan. He wasn’t sure what lay beyond, how much farther they had to go. The sounds of angry screams, metallic and ugly, doubled in number and volume as the first of many monsters ripped down the hallway and into Pollux’s fire.

“Yes,” he confirmed as the heat of those flames blasted past them.

“Then I will make my stand and cover your advance,” she promised.

“Castorice!” Phainon called across the gap, “please be safe!”

“And you, Lord Phainon.”

Mydei grabbed Phainon’s sleeve and pulled him along and together they raced to the broken gate, the sounds of combat fading behind them as they ran. It was there that Phainon slowed to a reverent stop and Mydei let go of him to stumble a few paces ahead along the platform.

High above the city, no longer blocked by tall walls here beside a cliff, was the Blade of Fury, pointing straight down at the arena ahead and oh did it take Phainon’s breath away. The weapon that felled a hundred nations, no longer descriptive words on a page.

“I always wanted to see it,” he mumbled.

“Even if the world lay shattered, it would still hang high above everyone’s heads,” Mydei agreed.

“It’s magnificent.”

“You haven’t seen it at its most magnificent. It’s not just a weapon, it’s the faith of the Kremnoan people and where heroic souls that died on the battlefield go to temper the blade,

becoming a part of the god-king's power. Even in death, they embrace eternal glory."

Phainon's thoughts drifted to the detachment. He couldn't hear them from here, just the soft melody of the Tide and an unsettling thought.

"Mydei, I have been thinking," Phainon said quietly.

"Don't hurt yourself."

Phainon punched him in the arm. "Are you sure that Nikador is here?"

"I am. When we killed the old king, Nikador was here in Castrum Kremnos, standing at the ready beneath Kremnos Arena. We had no reason to confront them, and they had no reason to pursue. The Titan has not been seen in five years. There is nowhere else that they could be."

That didn't seem right… but he followed Mydei to the Janus Passage without saying another word and they crossed the first canyon to push deeper into the city, slaying Titankin as they went with disappointing ease. Every time Phainon closed the gap to cleave a monster that unsettled feeling got worse. Every pile of dust that made his heart want to shout victory only twisted in his gut.

A hulking Titankin stood up ahead, shifting its weight as though on guard and even though it looked *right at them*, the monster made no move to defend itself. So, he missed. Phainon pulled his strike to the left, far enough to drop from above all the way to the stone in a shower of sparks.

Mydei's footsteps quickened behind him and Phainon hurriedly stretched out his arm to stop him, relieved when the prince skidded to a stop with Phainon's arm across his chest. Together they studied the creature, waiting side by side for …nothing.

"Mydei, none of these Titankin have put up a fight," Phainon said seriously.

"Of course they wouldn't, we have been killing them too quickly."

"No, I think they won't." The sword vanished into blue light, still the kin did not attack. "Something isn't right."

"What are you thinking, Deliverer?" Mydei's frown was audible.

"I'm thinking that there are no Black Tide creatures in the inner city, and the Titankin have made no effort to stop us or attack. The stories of Nikador tell of a Titan with the strength to level city-states in a single blow, that the Blade of Fury was great enough to strike even Aquila from the sky. You said yourself that the lance of Nikador is deadly when thrown, so why did they not strike the Chryseus Leo while we slept at anchor? Were we not within reach of his mighty blows?" Phainon paused to shift uncomfortably under the weight of his new theory. "If the Tide had claimed such a powerful minion, why has it not used it to further its ambitions? Why has Nikador stayed here all this time?"

"Eurypon was corrupted by the Black Tide," Mydei insisted, "this we know to be true. He brought this corruption home and passed it on to an already crumbling Strife itself."

“Professor Anaxa said that becoming a Demigod stopped the corruption inside him at the Grove, that it even healed what he had already taken in. Mydei, was Eurypon a Chrysos Heir?”

“Yes,” Mydei said softly with the weight of someone wrapped in uncomfortable nostalgia.

Phainon took a shuddering breath and started walking, advancing forward as they talked, no longer bothering to kill the Titankin that waited unmoving, covered in the dust of neglect beside extinguished forges.

“Eurypon was exposed to the Tide for years, like Professor Anaxa was, but without a coreflame,” Phainon thought aloud.

“Perhaps he reasoned that claiming the Coreflame of Strife would heal him and give him the strength to continue his bloody campaign,” Mydei added.

“So, he lured, or trapped, or somehow brought Nikador here and started his famous experiments.”

“While the Empire crumpled to ruin around him from the infighting.”

“Mydei…” Phainon said as another thought occurred to him, “What if Nikador hasn’t been corrupted by the Black Tide?”

“Our mission has not changed,” Mydei reassured him, “Even if Nikador is not corrupted by the Tide, they are still a mad god in the wake of Eurypon’s tampering. Even before the old King brought his violence against his own Titan, Nikador craved bloodshed with equal fervor to Eurypon. Now, with their divine body hollowed by the hands of madness and their dignity as a warrior forsaken… there is no place in a peaceful world for a Titan of Strife that has abandoned their reason.”

“It’s sad really,” Phainon mourned aloud as he paused before a mural. Kremnos was not known for its artists, but Nikador was lovingly depicted in tile leading troops in a story told in pictures, their glittering spear catching the light in artistically embellished rays. He reached out to touch it, to feel the grit of age and wear under his fingertips, trying to see this exact picture in unfaded colors, feel the message behind the artisans longing for triumph. “I wish I could have seen this place before Eurypon, when it still had its glory.”

Mydei stopped behind Phainon. He could hear the softness of his breath that kept Phainon grounded in the present, bleak and broken as it was. What would it have been like to have been here? To have been raised alongside the other Kremnoans? Would he too have left at the rumors of their beloved prince, alive and waiting to be found?

“To survive, my people have migrated, and our traditions have faded. But glory? Even crumbling beneath the mist of the Tide, Castrum Kremnos has never forsaken the glory of its warriors.”

The ground beneath them shook, the tiniest tremor, the barest reminder of those very same warriors fighting towards an end. They were relying on Mydei and Phainon.

“Deliverer,” Mydei started.

“I know.” And then they were running again.

Phainon followed Mydei down narrow hallways and chambers, out into the open air once more, and across giant chains, spanning the chasm that separated the Kremnos Arena from the city. The Blade of Fury was close enough now to charge the air with the smell of ozone and storms, of iron and blood, and a brutal desire for violence. The feeling permeated Phainon’s skin, making him feel more alive than he ever had as the adrenaline rushed with electricity to every corner of his being, keeping him on the knife’s edge until a bolt of lighting pulled a gasp from his lips. Still, they ran, even when Phainon chanced a look back at the city below, searching for his friends in the dark.

He saw nothing and did not slow.

They raced past Titankin standing at eternal attention, slid past armories of untouched masterpieces and treasuries full of gold and precious stones. It wasn’t until they crossed through a cold forge that Phainon realized where they were. Mydei was taking him beneath the arena, under the Blade of Fury itself and Phainon could feel that power turning his breaths ragged as he realized how close they were to a fight he had thought about since his vow to Aglaea to join the flame-chase.

“We’re so close to the death of a Titan,” Phainon breathed when they slowed to a jog, “it feels surreal.”

“Don’t think of them as a god. It’s just you, me, and them – warriors in a fight to the death,” Mydei growled.

Phainon felt the pressure the moment they crossed the threshold, stepping from a staircase into a massive, open atrium. It was a brutal call to arms, chanted in the voice of a Titan with weight so great that the air felt oppressive. It warped and rumbled, loud like a battlefield, filling Phainon with bloodlust and a battle high that clawed at his buried rage so carefully put away and forced it to the surface with the taste of blood. It was *excitement* and adrenaline and *hatred* that overwhelmed the song of the Tide until Phainon felt like he was about to lose control.

And that scared him more than anything. More even than the Titan itself waiting in the center of the room.

Nikador was a creature of long limbs, animated bone and armor, gilded in gold and blue. They were an elegant figure clad in a flowing cape that dragged on the ground behind them as they hunched forwards to lean on a golden spear many times longer than Phainon was tall. Even as the Chrysos Heirs stepped into their territory, the Titan did not move.

Neither did Phainon. Every step was too heavy, too fearful. The next step would strip him of his will, he could tell, remove from him all that made Phainon himself, and leave behind the shell of his youth that longed for nothing else but revenge against the mist. He slowly raised a hand to his face to hold himself, pinching his eyes shut to try and block that voice in his head.

“This feeling… it smells of blood and the cries of lost souls,” Phainon struggled to say. His breath kept getting stuck in his throat and chest but to his credit, he stayed upright. This was no ordinary battle, and he could not pretend it was.

“Show me your resolve, Deliverer.”

Phainon looked up at Mydei with agony, all the fear of inadequacy of failure, rising with the terror of losing himself as he realized he was not ready for this. They had misplaced their faith.

“How can you stand there with such confidence?” he asked with a shaky voice, “can you not hear it? The voices of suffering and your corroded homeland?”

“Of course I can,” Mydei told him with a low growl, “All the anger and regret I feel right now, I have learned to control them, hone them into a razor-sharp weapon for my use. Come, Deliverer. I need you in this fight. Let us be as beasts, give in to that primal desire, the purest form of Strife and fight with intent to kill. And if you cannot do that for yourself, then do it for those that stayed behind to give us this noble opportunity.”

Phainon fought to picture the faces of their friends, remembered the way they held him on the ship and took a deep breath, then another, and finally stood straight once more as he found his resolve. Their confidence in him weighed more than his own doubts. Even if it was borrowed strength, it was enough to know that he was not alone, that he was more than his past.

“I would trust no other in this fight,” Mydei reminded him with a soft smile and Phainon let out his held breath. That wonderful, beautiful face and strong voice returned to him his wavering agency and Phainon instead embraced this gift the Titan was giving them. Let him feel it all and keep himself.

“Then let us end this, Mydeimos.”

Mydei grinned a wild grin and the excitement returned in waves. His best friend started walking towards the Titan, towards the deity of his people with confidence and command in his footsteps. And Phainon followed, watching Mydei’s back.

“Hear me, broken god!” he called as he walked towards the Titan. The figure on the platform twisted as it awoke. Phainon watched it move with suspicion. There was no fine layer of dust, no creak in its joints as though it had been at rest for years as he had anticipated.

“We are sons of Kremnos, inheritors of the Coreflame of Strife, and have come to meet you in glorious combat worthy of your name and mantle!”

The Titan unfolded, leaning forward to scream in a language that Phainon couldn’t understand, that mighty spear resting lightly in its spindly fingers. He raised his sword beside Mydei, pointing it at their foe while his blood sing with joy at this legacy that Mydei was sharing with him.

“Are you still afraid?” Mydei asked Phainon with a playful growl as he took up a battle stance, turning his back to Phainon to protect.

He smiled at that feeling of ferality rising to the surface, blue eyes glittering as the Titan roared at them again at a pitch that rattled the entire room and rippled through the Tide that pooled around their feet.

“No.”

Chapter End Notes

I originally considered letting them be competitive as they were in 3.0, fighting titankin on the way but the mood didn’t seem right. In the game they didn't go after Nikador with a crew of friends at their backs.

Chapter 28: The Inheritor of Strife

Chapter Summary

No new tags but please mind the ones that are already there!

:)

Chapter Notes

If my original outline is to be believed, this was supposed to be the beginning of chapter 9 out of 19... So wooo halfway point~!

:)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Mydei read grand epics and studied historical conquests in his youth, battles were always embellished to make them seem desirable. He had learned through experience that there was joy in combat that his Kremnoan blood knew every violent dance and song but before Phainon, the challenge was minimal. His friends were noble and powerful, more experienced, classically trained, but there were limitations to their growth and Mydei always felt like he could be more, like something was missing.

Realizing that Phainon filled that empty space with his presence, his sword and understanding was a revelation for the ages. It was a feeling that Mydei had felt budding inside him, but it wasn't until Castrum Kremnos that he knew for sure. Phainon was the harmony to his melody, or perhaps it was the other way around, it didn't matter. The solo that Mydei's heart had been singing in every conflict, every battle, every sea breeze, every journey, was meant to be a duet.

And their song was one of struggle and victory, singing over the Titan's battle's cries.

Nikador's pressure, that which warped the air and twisted all intentions into a desperate need for bloody carnage was no more than a lion's roar, formidable but conquerable. It was adrenaline and desire fueling both he and Phainon as they clashed against this mighty foe. There would be no need to embellish this tale, it was the grandest of conflicts in truth.

Mydei felt in Phainon's presence, in every swing of his sword, an extension of himself and in turn, he felt like an extension of Phainon. They needed no call, no shout to know where the other was or how they would move. All their training together, fighting the Tide beside each

other, was building an understanding that Mydei could not have fully appreciated until they were facing a true challenge and there was no greater challenge than Nikador.

To compare Nikador to an army would be a disservice to their strength. They were a hurricane blotting out the sun, a force of nature that could not be overwhelmed, only weathered. Every time that lance struck, lightning shook the atrium and rattled Mydei's bones. Every step that clattered across the stone was the crashing of towering waves. They were fools to assume they could win against this god-king of Strife.

And Mydei had never felt so alive.

Phainon dashed in from the right and Mydei immediately followed, giving his partner room to move to swing his sword. At the last moment, Phainon feinted to the left, swiping his sword at Nikador's ankle in a shower of sparks and giving Mydei the window to hold course. Mydei's fist, wrapped in crystal, slammed into Nikador's shoulder and the Titan lurched, still Mydei held on. His feet against that massive bicep, scrambled to hold for just a second more while Mydei used both hands to force his crystals to sprout from that divine shoulder.

Nikador's swung around to face Mydei, that long horn that extended well past their head sliced through the air, but Mydei held his ground, full of faith. That horn glanced off the flat of Phainon's blade, deflected when the warrior sprang between them. The lance spun in Nikador's hand and both Phainon and Mydei bounced away.

Mydei skidded across one of the bridges, a little too close to the edge for comfort, coming to a stop in a runner's stance. He glanced across the room to where Phainon had come to rest in the same pose, different bridge. They briefly exchanged looks, taking note of the next verse.

Phainon dashed first and Mydei paused, letting him lead in this arpeggio. Phainon's sword flashed blue and orange flickers every time the blade met the unbreakable bronze of Nikador's spear. The god was fast, jabbing and slicing, advancing on Phainon whose every effort was in deflecting, dodging. If they clashed, Nikador's superior strength would win, and Phainon knew it.

Mydei waited until the tempo increased at Strife's bidding, even the chanting in his head quickened with every jab. He waited and trusted Phainon's abilities, until the Lance of Fury chipped the edge of Phainon's sword and gold blood dripped to the floor. A wave of crystal slammed into Nikador's side, sharpened edges stabbed up into the Titan's chest, taking advantage of the gaps to pin the god to the lattice.

Phainon rushed in, gold blood turning his hair yellow where it streamed from his ear and cheek. His blade whistled in the air as he dropped from above to slice at the Titan's joints. The steel dragged across the god, leaving behind a shallow scratch.

He was mid-leap when Nikador shattered Mydei's crystal, throwing the prince back with the force. The Titan screeched and jumped onto the statue in the back of the atrium. They clung there like an insect, long limbs gripping the statue's sword as they readied their lance to throw.

Mydei and Phainon rushed in close so they would be harder to hit, and the instinct saved one of Mydei's lives. The lance cut by his shoulder like light, too fast to track with mortal eyes.

Phainon leaped after the Titan and Mydei sent crystals ahead. The crimson shards grabbed at Nikador's feet while the god summoned another lance, pinning them in place so Phainon's sword could swipe again at that scratch. This time, the crack was audible. It was punctuation at the end of a long sentence, a staccato note in a legato refrain.

Mydei hurried to follow up, taking Phainon's place when the swordsman bounced back to jab his claws into the opening Phainon had created. The war armor splintered and Nikador screeched loud enough to shatter the statue. Long cracks ripped across the atrium's ceiling and plaster and dust rained down upon their shoulders.

Long fingers wrapped around Mydei's leg as he was falling but Phainon's sword cleaved through one of the digits and they both fell to the platform.

Nikador pressed their advantage.

A broad swipe of the lance thrummed in the air above them, nearly claiming their heads before the two warriors were able to drop beneath it. The ground underneath them was vibrating with the intensity of the fight. Mydei could feel it through his gauntlets when he crouched.

Phainon was moving again, shouting in a wordless snarl that betrayed the man's excitement. He was feeling the bloodlust, that vicious desire to fight and kill, with no concern for his own injuries. Mydei briefly realized that Phainon probably didn't know he was bleeding at all.

More dirt rained around them. There was a platform here, a way to raise this battle into the arena above but Mydei had a better idea. He turned on his heel and raced to the wall, leaving Phainon to contend with the Titan alone for a short time, to hold that divine gaze. Ledges and statues facilitated his climb as Mydei hurried, as close to the ceiling as he could get before crystal erupted above them.

The ceiling exploded.

Mydei fell alongside the dust and cacophony of his own attack and the massive blocks of the collapsing atrium. Through the debris he could see the flash of blue and white as Phainon pushed away from Nikador to dodge the environmental hazard and Mydei lost him in the chaos. The roar of the cave in drowned out all other noise, any attempts to shout for Phainon were lost until stone settled and the dust began to clear.

"Mydeimos!"

"Here!" he called, and relief washed over him. Cracked open to the world, the atrium was flooded with light from the Blade of Fury above and it was infinitely easier to see the destruction. The Titan was buried under the rubble, but Mydei could still hear chanting in that ancient tongue, reverberating in the back of his mind. Nikador was still alive.

Mydei sprang backwards to the edge of the arena. The collapse had filled the space below, leaving them in a crater of debris, the once grand colosseum no more than a bowl in the ground now. Phainon bounced across the arena and landed beside Mydei, sword still ready, eyes searching for movement.

This pause, this rest in the melody was unbearable. The tension was winding tighter with every passing second as they waited.

It was Phainon who sensed it first. Energy gathered above them and Mydei might not have moved in time, but Phainon's shoulder slammed into his chest, and they both rolled. For a brief second, Mydei remembered the storm and a falling beam. He immediately reached for Phainon, eyes searching his leg for injury, but the man was okay, nothing damaged aside from a new tear in his cape. The torn fabric was pinned beneath a golden spear, an acceptable substitute for flesh.

The ground ripped open and Nikador pulled themself free with a jerky jitter.

Mydei's resourcefulness paid off. Nikador's armor was cracked and golden blood streamed over those lanky limbs in rivulets to pool beneath those gangly feet. The Titan twisted and screamed.

"This isn't over," Mydei cautioned with a happy purr as he and Phainon got back to their feet, dirty, bruised, and still very eager to fight.

The hollow crack of Nikador's back was different than the rolling peal of thunder above. It was wetter. With a squelch that made Mydei's stomach turn, a golden figure ripped free of Nikador's back. The bloody heart of the unarmored Titan was missing its face, and sections of its arms and shoulders. Long blades stood out of their hunched back, all that remained of grand wings. They squealed and chanted as their upper body stretched, free of the confining armor. The pale body of Nikador still moved, still attached below the waist of the bloody, aurum god, but the spear in its hand was guided now by the detached arm of the exposed flesh.

One golden hand reached for them, gesturing in mirror with the white armor beneath it to grab at Mydei and Phainon. The tug on his soul was immediate. Mydei felt a piece of himself ripping away, saw it in a white shimmer as his vitality was drawn in towards the god and left speared in the ground.

Beside him, Phainon panted, holding his chest. Their ghosts, pieces of their souls were side by side, lifeless and shimmering pearlescent. Mydei and Phainon exchanged glances of shared confusion and then lightning cracked the sky and this four-armed Nikador was upon them.

They could have been fighting for days or minutes, Mydei genuinely didn't know. The world was moving in a blur. Everything was flashes of red, gold, and blue, give and take, dance and song. Three times the god pulled from them their spirits to weaken them. Three times Phainon and Mydei hurried to smash those spears and reclaim that vitality and three times Mydei felt his endurance wane.

This fight could not last forever.

Mydei was tossed aside when the flat of the spear slammed into his chest, leaving a long cut across his belly as the weapon finished its arc. He paused to catch his breath, but Nikador surged after him, the tip of the spear reaching for his chest.

It stopped when Phainon dashed between them and the divine weapon slammed into the flat of Phainon's sword, locking them both in a clash above Mydei. Phainon's legs were shaking, his arms straining to hold back the Titan and then the unthinkable happened, Phainon's sword shattered. Pieces of the blade rained across them both and the spear tore through Phainon's pauldron, sinking deep into his shoulder with a pained cry and a hot gush of golden blood.

The sound of angry pain cut through Mydei like a knife, filling him with a newfound rage. Phainon was holding tightly to the weapon, shouting Kremnoan swear words at the golden god in a voice that cracked and rasped, broken and tired.

Crystal erupted around Nikador's feet and the spear ripped free, Phainon's blood dripped across Mydei and spattered on the ground. It burned hot and horrible like the surging hatred that uncoiled in Mydei's gut. He turned on the Titan with ferocity unbridled. Thunder rolled as Mydei fought the Titan alone, faster and faster, until he stopped processing every action, surrendering entirely to the beast within him that wanted to kill this creature that hurt what was his.

The Blade of Fury shimmered above them, bearing witness to this final Kremnos Festival, as Mydei ripped Nikador's head free in a shower of glittering gold and the Titan of Strife lay still. The pressure in the air stilled, the chanting ceased, and all that was left was a regretful silence.

Mydei panted. His heart was still racing, the battle high still lingered. Even without the Titan's living presence pumping it into his veins, that bloodlust still fluttered in every breath. It took a conscious effort to rein in that rage to find himself buried in the violence and as soon as he did, Mydei was hurrying to Phainon's side.

"Deliverer!"

Phainon was sitting up, eyes wide, breathing heavy. There was gold on his lips and pouring over his fingers where they pressed into the wound at his shoulder. His injured arm hung limp, the hilt of his broken sword still half resting against his palm.

For a fearful moment, Mydei thought his mind was gone. Phainon's eyes were so haunted, so deep in that trance that it looked like Phainon was lost, but then he took a shuddering, wet breath and said, "that was amazing."

"HKS," Mydei scolded but he could not hide his relief nor his agreement and smiled his way to tired laugh.

He reached for Phainon's wound to check it himself, but Phainon hissed and flinched away. "Leave it, please. We need to get back to the others. The coreflame?"

Mydei tilted his head towards the body where it lay and then helped Phainon to his feet. The sword clattered away spent and useless, and the broken shards crunched underfoot as Phainon found his footing and walked with reverent purpose towards Nikador's corpse.

Was this something that they should do together? Mydei stayed back. Where before he was eager to retrieve the cursed thing to present to Phainon as a gesture of promise, now he wasn't so sure. In the aftermath of combat, actually *here* beneath the symbol of their faith, standing across from their dead Titan, Mydei felt a sort of fulfillment, like he had passed some test that he didn't know he was taking. It felt like he was being watched, when he would've preferred that feeling shift to Phainon.

Phainon who was kneeling beside the body, shoving his good arm down the god-king's severed neck to pull the coreflame from their heart and in doing so achieve a destiny that he had been groomed for. Aglaea must have intended for their Deliverer to become a Demigod and what better coreflame than Strife? Phainon could save the world with that coreflame, be what Strife was always meant to be, a protector, a defender, not a tyrant.

Mydei humbly watched from a distance as Phainon pulled away from the corpse, hands dripping gold around the relic. It looked small in Phainon's hand. Purple and bright with shimmering white glitter that looked like the night sky and the crest of Strife prominent within, etched the same color as their blood. Even from several paces away, Mydei could feel its warmth and call beckoning him to come closer.

"Mydei…" Phainon said, so small, so full of wonder that quelled all the residual bloodlust inside them, "It's not mine…"

Those words hit Mydei with the weight of a mountain and the dread of staring into the unknown. It was the way Phainon looked at him, with awe and worship. The way Phainon held the coreflame out to him as he stumbled over uneven ground, trying to hand the coreflame to Mydei.

And something inside of the prince desperately wanted it. His heart *ached* for it and when Phainon very, very gently tried to put it in Mydei's hand, Mydei heard Cipher's words crooning from memory.

…like a part of you that you never realized was missing.

"It's yours," Phainon said so gently, so pure, and with the most genuine, happy smile that little tears were beading in those perfect blue eyes.

…they have chosen their bearers across time.

The coreflame was so warm in his hands, so small and seemingly so fragile. This tiny thing that could save them, save all of them. This was the strength to conquer, to ensure victory in every battle.

It was warmth and comfort and responsibility so great that I thought I would burst with the joy of it.

Mydei took a deep breath through his nose and slowly grabbed Phainon's wrist. He pulled it up and cradled the man's hand in his own so that he could give the coreflame back, making Phainon take it so he could step away from that power.

"Mydei?" Phainon's confusion dripped from him like blood. "What are you doing? This is yours. It belongs to *you*."

"No."

Phainon took a step forward and Mydei recoiled. "It *chose you*."

"I don't want it."

"No one else can take it!"

"You can, Phainon!" Mydei insisted. He closed Phainon's fingers around the coreflame with both of his hands. "As we planned. You can take it back to Aglaea to buy your pardon."

Phainon shook with frustration, exhaustion, it was all the same now as he tried to push the coreflame to Mydei's chest. "This is a *part of your heart*, Mydei! You need it!"

"I don't!" Mydei held tightly to Phainon's fist with both hands so his best friend could not let go of the coreflame.

"How can you *say that?* Now that you know, now that you've felt it, you'll never feel whole again without it!"

He closed his eyes and looked down, away from Phainon's begging lest that pleading face make him relent and accept this horrid gift, heavier than any crown. "That's not true!"

"It is!"

"It's not, because I have you!" Mydei shouted.

The silence was deafening. Beneath his fingers, Phainon was still quivering. Mydei looked up at him, at those wide searching eyes. The tears that had beaded there were spilling over, leaving trails through the grime and blood on Phainon's cheeks.

"What?" Phainon whispered.

"I don't need the coreflame to feel whole," Mydei repeated and then he smiled to say, "because I have you. And if you make me take it, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, I will tear it from my chest and drag you and that damned thing to Okhema to see you free."

"Mydei-"

The ground rumbled hard enough to nearly send them to their knees. Something thick and horrible dropped from the sky beside them, a heavy goo that dripped like rain around the Titan's body. A tearing laugh, otherworldly and bone chillingly shrill rolled over Castrum Kremnos. In the distance, Mydei thought he heard a horn, Peucesta calling for a retreat. The

mist started to pool and rise around them again, where the Titan's screams had dispelled it before, in Nikador's absence it swelled and thickened.

Phainon stumbled and Mydei hurried to steady him as they started putting together the pieces. Nikador wasn't corrupted. They were not an agent of the Tide.

They were the dam.

The pooling mist surged to the body of Nikador, filling the bones of the Titan, until the husk started to twitch and move. Mydei saw Phainon widen his stance preparing to fight and knew that he would not survive another round.

None of them would.

Except maybe Mydei.

This was no longer Nikador, this was the Black Tide unleashed and if someone did not hold it back, then Phainon, the crew, and his distant people would die.

"Deliverer!" Mydei snapped, "You're the captain now."

"What-?!"

"Listen to me!" he growled, grabbing Phainon by the front of his armor to capture his attention, to make the man meet his eyes, "take the coreflame, earn your freedom, but first please, save my family. I trust you. I trust you more than anyone to lead them. Get them to safety and I will cover your escape."

"I won't leave you!" Phainon snarled.

Mydei ignored the declaration and dragged him close, one hand holding Phainon's arm that clutched the coreflame, the other hooked around the back of Phainon's neck to pull him in until their foreheads were pressed tightly together.

"It was you, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae!" he shouted as though to announce it to the world and then softer, only for them, "it was always you. The pirate that stole my heart."

"Why are you saying this now?!" Phainon cried. He was trying to pull away, to get out of this Kremnoan farewell but Mydei held him tightly so he couldn't escape.

"I promised." He squeezed Phainon's arm, reminding him of the coreflame still held tightly in his fist. "Save them, Deliverer. I beg you."

The Tide churned behind them. Mydei could hear the song now, it was soft and peaceful, a stark contrast to the twisted, headless form of the Titan it was nearly done assimilating.

Phainon was sobbing but he nodded and Mydei took that as a promise. He rubbed the back of Phainon's neck, squeezing reassurances before he closed the last of that space between them.

Their lips met, rushed and desperate. Mydei could feel Phainon reaching for him with his injured arm, taste the blood on his lips as the man reciprocated, longing for Mydei, begging him without words to stay with him, to return to the ship together.

Mydei's instincts screamed. The spear glittered in the corner of his eye. He grabbed Phainon by his armor and threw him.

-

Phainon's heart was racing. He was dizzy, light-headed, and not from his injuries. To hear Mydei's confession was everything, but it crumpled away as that love was replaced with loss so much worse than that which the Tide had sung.

He screamed Mydei's name as he was tossed down a long path and tried to find his footing faster, to run back to that fight so that Mydei didn't have to struggle alone. The Tide was sticky and boiling under his feet as he ran but a massive wall of crystal blocked his path and Phainon slammed into it with reckless abandon. Again and again with helpless screams and sobs he rammed his body uselessly against the barricade, refusing to abandon his best friend, refusing to accept that intimate goodbye, angry to collapsing that Mydei had been so selfish as to deny Phainon the chance to *say the words back*.

The words that Phainon didn't even know he needed to say. The words that sprang to mind along with the singular, overwhelming desire to be selfish, to *want* for himself.

I love you. I love you!

He could still feel that goodbye on his lips, the hope that Mydei had left with him, knowing that this horrible, cursed fire in his hands was *Mydei*. This was a part of Mydei's heart, given *willingly* with complete, implicit trust and love to be casually sold for what? For freedom? For something Phainon already had standing at Mydei's side?

The ache in his arm was getting worse, the Tide was surging, building. This was not a gentle Tide that took in its own time. It would overwhelm the crew, push its way across the ocean and take take take.

What the hell had they done?

Phainon screamed and pounded on the crystal until his voice broke. He could hear the combat beyond, knew that Mydei was fighting. How long could he keep it up? Immortal as he was, Mydei could fight for days, weeks even, but with the weight of this corruption…

It was a tug on his cape that cut his next harrowing plea short. Phainon twisted, tears and blood flying with the sharpness of the action.

Standing in the mist, tugging with all his might, was Fig Stew.

The chimera was in bad shape. His paws were muddy and scratched, splotches of bloody fur were nearly black in the dim light, red eyes were glassy and tired. Purple goo clung to his tail

and ears, the corruption trying to wear away at the beast, eager to recruit such a noble soul to its legions of monsters.

Even when Phainon just sat and watched, unmoving, Fig Stew tugged and tugged. His nails left marks on the stone as he fought to move the mountain, an impossible task without Phainon's consent, but the effort was everything, an ultimate example of resolve. The chimera was already tired from his trek through the city, ready to collapse, but like his master his spirit exceeded the limitations of his body, and he pulled and pulled until his legs gave out and then he shakily got back up to pull again.

And Phainon cried.

Fig Stew needed him. The crew needed him. Mydei needed him. Phainon made a promise to protect, to save Mydei's family, *his* family now too.

Following Fig's example, fighting the exhaustion, Phainon shakily crawled to Fig Stew to scoop the suffering chimera up to cradle in his arm. The tired animal clung to him with his paws, tail resting loose over Phainon's wrist beside the coreflame. He got to his feet and caught his breath, almost choking on the heavy Tide. He turned back to glare at the wall that Mydei had made, at the Sword of Fury beyond it, and growled low under his breath, "Don't die too many times."

And then he ran.

Getting back to the ship was harder than anything Phainon had ever done. The city was almost empty now between the efforts of Castorice and the crew, but it wasn't the monsters that made the sprint difficult. It was moving farther away from where Mydei was fighting and dying. It was knowing that they did this, they messed up. It was the aching desire in his chest that *loved* to the point of pain. It was Fig Stew's quiet whimpers as they ran from the dense might of the Tide on their heels.

He tripped over the Kremnoan barricades, abandoned along with their dead… and there *were* dead. Phainon recognized Ulixes, the taskmaster, as he fell on the street beside the man's lifeless body, gutted with his sword in his hand, and the flashing rush of memories threatened to trap him here, to die beside them.

The coreflame in Phainon's hand burned, bright enough to keep the mist at bay as it tried to roll over him where he curled around Fig Stew on the ground. He held it tight and thought of Mydei and the coreflame flickered brighter, reassuring, reminding him that Mydei was alive, strong, and counting on him. It was courage in the darkness and Phainon took deep breaths, letting that courage give him the strength to stand again, to limp the rest of the way to the dock, where the crew watched from the railing.

The ramp had been pulled up to keep the fog from chasing the crew in their retreat, but as Phainon hurried down the wooden dock he heard shouts and saw them throw him a rope. He looped it around Fig Stew first, letting the chimera be carried to safety while he watched the city slowly disappear in inky smoke.

He looped the rope around his chest when it was thrown again and tried to hold on as he was pulled up roughly over the rail.

Phainon let the rope go, tossing it aside when his feet touched the deck. It was a struggle to stand, and he leaned heavily on the railing as chaos erupted around him. Perdikkas was by his side immediately, pressing a warm, wet cloth to his shoulder. Hyacine too was trying to get to him and Phainon felt some strength return with a quiet 'doot.'
"Where is Mydeimos?" Krateros shouted and Phainon felt like collapsing all over again. The crew was shouting, crowding him.

"Give him space!" Perdikkas demanded and Ptolemy was there to help them push the crowd back. Both of them were hurt, he could see it in the way they limped, the bandages on their bodies.

Where was Hephaestion? Phainon dimly wondered after the first mate and then Krateros was in his space, sword drawn. He had bandages wrapped around his chest and leg, dried blood clinging to his jaw, the man's eyes were wild, still crazed from battle and eager for answers.

Phainon slowly opened his hand showing the coreflame of Strife to a round of gasps from the crew. A couple of them shouted, the start of a victory cheer, but those few were quickly silenced.

"He told me," Phainon started, and his words cracked. He had to pause to swallow, still his voice was raw and broken as he fought to yell loud enough to be heard by all, "he told me to take his place as the captain." Gasps and whispers moved like ripples through the men.

Krateros' hand lashed out to grab Phainon's coat, pulling him close, holding him still while that still bloody blade pressed cold against Phainon's throat. The deck erupted into chaos and tears rolled down Phainon's cheeks again, not for fear of death, but for fear of failing in this critical task assigned to him and sealed with a parting kiss.

"You left him," Krateros accused with a tremor in his voice. Rage and anger could not hide the grief in the old man's expression. The steel bit into Phainon's neck and he felt warmth run over his collar, but he did not plead for his life, even as the crew turned on each other. This old veteran was a mirror, Phainon's own grief reflected in those watery eyes as Krateros lashed out the only way he knew how.

"I'm sorry," Phainon whispered and waited for the end.

A hushed silence settled on the deck. It startled even the old man who relaxed his grip to look with curiosity at the chimera. The crew parted for Fig Stew, lowering their weapons to watch the chimera struggle with determined purpose, limping to Krateros' and Phainon's feet. He howled, low and mournful until Krateros stepped back and lowered his weapon, leaving Phainon to Fig Stew's judgement. The chimera mewled and then slowly lay down to roll over, presenting his belly to Phainon.

The crew held their breath as Phainon slowly knelt, resting on both knees. His injured arm still hung uselessly and the other still clutched the coreflame like a lifeline, still Fig Stew waited. With a shaky sigh, Phainon let go of the coreflame, setting it reverently in the space

between himself and the chimera. Phainon’s bloody hand felt too dirty, too stained to gently scratch that perfect white belly fur, but Fig Stew didn’t mind. Even in pain, even in mourning, Fig Stew still purred.

Krateros dropped his sword. The steel clattered on the deck, shattering the silence. With humility and exhaustion in every movement, the old man slowly knelt beside Phainon, head bowed and his fists tight over his knees.

“What should we do, Captain?” he asked, genuine.

Phainon didn't have the strength to marvel at the change of heart, at the power that Fig Stew had over the faith of the crew. Everyone was looking at him for guidance, anxious and afraid. They needed him to be the Deliverer, the person that Mydei believed in, that Mydei *loved.*

The coreflame pulsed, encouraging, filling Phainon with confidence to give his first order, “We need to go home.”

The crew scattered in silence to obey, to get underway before the rolling Tide could catch up to them. With Krateros and Perdikkas to help, Phainon got back to his feet, cradling the coreflame like it was the only thing that mattered. Ptolemy scooped up Fig Stew, holding him within reach so they could still hear his purring.

He turned to look at the city falling away behind them, all but that mocking Blade of Fury hidden in the Tide’s polluted grasp, pointing at the still fighting Mydeimos the Undying, Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos, Inheritor of Strife.

“We’re coming back,” Phainon hissed, low and angry so only those beside him could hear, “we’re coming back for him.”

Chapter End Notes

Phaidei nation, how we feelin'? :)

As a heads up, this is a very busy week for me! I will probably not be able to post at all this week. :)

Chapter 29: Aftermath

Chapter Summary

No new tags!
In the wake of unexpected loss, the captain has some decisions to make

Chapter Notes

Thank you all for your patience! I had a wonderful week attending my first con! I spent way too much money but I am content if a little tired. Hopefully, I'll be back to regular updates now!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon tried to help the others the moment Chryseus Leo got underway. A cursory glance at the injured on deck and basic math told him that only a skeleton crew would be left to sail the ship. Three rows of men lay in various stages of dying, from the eerily still to those howling and writhing in pain. They needed everyone that could stand working the lines.

But the second he stepped away from the rail Phainon collapsed heavily into Perdikkas and Krateros' arms. All of his remaining strength was in keeping Mydei's coreflame held tightly to his chest with nothing left to keep his shaking body upright.

"Stay with me, Phainon." Perdikkas sounded so far away.

The deck twisted and blurred, his vision failing as the adrenaline finally settled, leaving him feeling cold and numb.

"'m fine… where's Hephaestion?" he asked but he didn't even recognize his own voice with the slur of the syllables.

If they answered, he didn't hear it. Instead, they pulled him along, half dragging, half carrying him across the deck to an open pad to lay him down beside the other injured Kremnoans. Every sensation was muted as his body started shutting down to rest, focused entirely on the warmth in his arms and the flowering pain in his shoulder where the Lance of Fury had pinned him to the stone.

Someone was talking to him, but he couldn't see who it was with the black creeping along the edges of his vision. Hands were pulling on his clothes, undoing the straps and buckles of

his armor. A sharp pain ripped through Phainon a moment later, and that was enough to crush what was left of his consciousness.

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Phainon woke to the pitter-patter of rain on canvas and opened his eyes to a gray and solemn world. The ship wasn't listing like it might during a heavy storm, just the gentle sway of a ship at rest, likely moored in a protected cove. Above him was stretched the fabric of one of the top sails, angled to dump the rainwater over the railing to keep the deck dry. The red of it looked like drying blood, dark and cold, wrapped in the same gloomy filter that blanketed the rest of the world in soothing mourning.

It was you! It was always you.

Time passed differently laying there, listening to the distant roll of thunder while the petrichor tickled his nose. Phainon felt too numb to think, too tired to *feel* beyond the voice of memory, a mercy perhaps considering the emotions that he knew were waiting for him. Emotions that still manifested in watery eyes and quiet tears that spilled over his cheeks while he stared blankly ahead and slowly tried to process.

Save them, Deliverer. I beg you.

The ache in his shoulder was still there, a brutal reminder that the nightmare was real. The corresponding arm was strapped tightly across his bare chest to keep it from moving. Just below, over his belly, was a foreign warmth, one that breathed in tandem with himself. Fig Stew's little heartbeat was slow, at rest. He too had endured and lost.

Men moved around the deck, keeping quiet, tending to their companions when one of them moaned or whimpered in their pain, until the rain was once more the only soundtrack.

What should we do, Captain?

A shadow passed beside him and then a small hand was pressing on his chest, just below his collarbone. Her fingers were warm, even through the bandages.

"Lord Phainon?" Hyacine whispered, "Are you awake?" Without moving his head, Phainon's eyes slowly shifted to meet hers. "Can you speak?"

He swallowed and opened his mouth to try but all he could manage was an exhausted croak. She reached up to press the pads of her fingers to the side of his throat. A soothing, cooling sensation spread from her touch and he shivered.

"It's okay if you can't right now," she reassured him gently.

Phainon still tried, testing his jaw with a couple stretches before he managed to whisper, "what happened?"

"Krateros took over after you passed out," Hyacine told him, "We got as far as we could before the rain started but he didn't want to risk being on open water during a storm. We spent the night anchored in a cove while we tend to the wounded and assess our situation."

He pulled at his bound arm and a sharp pain twisted in his shoulder, ripping a gasp from his lips. Hyacine rested her hand over the wrap with a concerned expression, but he nodded at her reassuringly and used his other arm instead to feel around for the coreflame.

The doctor pushed down on him more urgently when he started to panic, unable to find the only part of Mydei he had left. Phainon shoved her off, fighting to sit up, sending Fig Stew into an alarmed roll when he bucked and kicked at the heavy blanket that was holding him down.

Where was it?

Where was the coreflame? Where was Mydei's heart?

Hyacine threw herself across his chest to hold him down, but even exhausted, his thrashing was not so easily tamed. She failed to subdue his recklessness until Perdikkas joined her, jumping onto Phainon to straddle his lap with both hands on the man's chest to push him back down, panting.

"Phainon, what the hell?" he snapped, "do you know how long it took Hyacine and I to get you stitched up?"

"*Where is it? Where is Mydei?"*

Perdikkas drew in a sharp breath. "Mydei is gone, Phainon. He's still at Castrum Kremnos, remember?"

Phainon's hiss made Perdikkas and Hyacine flinch, "*How can I forget?"* He still tossed, trying to get Perdikkas off but the doctor held firm and even managed to pin Phainon's remaining good wrist across his chest next to the other. "*Where is the coreflame?"*

"Relax and I'll tell you." It took effort but Phainon took a couple deep breaths and slowly resumed his supine position. "Peucesta has it, he is keeping it safe beside Chryseus Leo."

Something about that didn't sit right. There was a possessive feeling lurking cold inside his belly, that hated the idea of someone else holding onto it, of keeping it *safe*. That was *Phainon's* job, but the longer he lay there with his two friends watching him with wary, fearful expressions the more he realized how silly that was. They had every right to worry and care just like he did, and Phainon needed to be the captain, to take care of them until such time as he ceased to embody that role.

Slowly, Perdikkas let go and eased off Phainon's lap to kneel at his side opposite Hyacine. There were questions in those tired eyes, worry and loss eating away at them all. Exhaustion weighed heavily over the deck.

"Perdikkas," Phainon started, he swallowed and whispered, "back there-"

"Not right now," Perdikkas scolded. He looked down, shaking but dry eyed, "I-I want to know, really, I do, but you need to heal first. Are you in pain?" Phainon shook his head but

gasped and cussed when Perdikkas lightly touched his shoulder. “Let me get you some poppy.” He started to get up, but Phainon caught his sleeve to stop him.

“Not this time,” he whispered.

“You don’t need to punish yourself,” Perdikkas reassured him, “if you’re in pain…”

No, it wasn’t that, Phainon thought to himself. He just wanted to remain clear-headed, to be able to make important decisions without the influence of the drugs, but… pain was already clouding his mind. Grief was already driving his actions. Perhaps, in a way, Perdikkas was right, reading the depths of Phainon’s soul.

“Please,” he still whispered.

“Water at least?”

Phainon nodded, already feeling the fuzzy of exhaustion creeping behind his eyes. Before Perdikkas returned with a waterskin, Phainon had already fallen asleep.

-

It took Phainon one Entry Hour to recover enough energy to get to his feet, against the advice of his physicians. His arm was still tightly bound to his chest to ease the strain on his shoulder, but he had strength enough to help furl the sails and get them moving towards home. They were falling behind in a race with the Tide to get to the settlement, cursed to sail on inky water until they made up the sea that that they lost.

Krateros sat beside Phainon as soon as the new captain felt clear-headed enough to take in the report and had patiently walked him through the bleakness of their situation.

They had lost seven men in Castrum Kremnos, the names of which were recorded on paper and handed to Phainon to read, along with reassurances that Kremnoans had no need to grieve. But it didn’t stop Phainon from tucking that piece of paper under his chlamys to keep close to his heart. He would respect their culturally held desire not to be openly mourned but the weight of their sacrifice was something he wanted to appreciate in private.

Nearly every man had sustained injuries during the battle, but only a few were confined to their beds or the infirmary with wounds that prevented them from working. Hyacine had been a miracle on the field, saving the lives of nearly a dozen men that would have undoubtedly perished, something that several of them grumbled about. Only Kremnoans would so openly regret surviving a major battle.

The worst part of the report was news of the Tide. Even with fair winds to carry them, the Tide line had kept pace with the ship and any advantage they had was lost when the rain forced them to moor for an Entry Hour. According to their maps and predetermined timeline, the Tide should’ve been in retreat, but it had changed course unexpectedly and was surging with renewed vigor.

Phainon, Krateros, and Ptolemy equally agreed that the surging Tide would take the settlement within fourteen Entry Hours and had begun discussing the possibility of an evacuation. A topic that Phainon felt was best decided when everyone would be able to listen and contribute.

That moment came five Entry Hours after they had left Castrum Kremnos and finally started to overtake the Tide line. The promise of beating the spread filled the crew with new life even as they focused on nursing their wounds.

Phainon had ordered Ptolemy to fetch the others and meet at the infirmary, leaving him alone in his room with Fig Stew to get ready. The chimera had healed quickly, shrugging off the corruption like a champ, but he was still emotionally distant. He had the same brave façade that Phainon had been wearing, pretending that everything was alright, but Fig was clingy, refusing to leave Phainon's side for even a second, and in that action Phainon saw through him.

"Would you like to nap with him today?" Phainon offered, referring to the piece of Mydei they still held onto so tightly, and Fig Stew tilted his head.

The Coreflame of Strife was a revered treasure amongst the crew. Phainon insisted on keeping it at night ever since he was able to return to his own bed, cradling it and Fig Stew together in a tight curl to sleep, the warmth of it a comfort in the lonely gloom. He frequently would wake when it flickered and caught himself looking over at Mydei's hammock, expecting the Kremnoan to be there, sleeping as though nothing had happened. That was the miracle of this coreflame, so willingly given to Phainon. Keeping it close… it felt like Mydei was still there.

Which was why, during the day, Phainon made sure to share.

It hurt every morning, handing it to members of the crew with reverence, but Mydei's family needed their Prince and the comfort that the coreflame brought, even if they didn't know yet why it felt that way. Phainon had not revealed the truth of the coreflame's nature. Something he intended to do at the meeting today.

He fixed his hair in the mirror and then crouched down to one knee to hold his arm out to Fig Stew. Carefully, the chimera climbed onto Phainon, paws clinging to his chlamys with his chin on Phainon's shoulder. That strong arm scooped under Fig's bum and tail, holding him secure while they walked to the infirmary.

Most everyone was there already, waiting in solemn silence. Krateros was leaning against a wall, arms crossed. He nodded politely to Phainon when the captain entered, a gesture mimicked by Perdikkas, Ptolemy, and Peucesta all sitting on chairs.

"Hello, Lord Phainon," Hyacine greeted from the desk beside Perdikkas. Behind her, Anaxa was ignoring them, reading a book and sitting on a bed beside Leonnius. The runner had twisted his ankle during the battle and was on bedrest until Perdikkas said otherwise, but he had the strength to sit up, with his legs thrown over the side of his resting place.

Castorice raised her hand in a small wave from where she sat beside one of the beds and Phainon moved towards her. He set Fig Stew down at the edge of the sheet that covered most of Hephaestion's body.

"Thank you everyone for being here," Phainon addressed the room, careful to sound at ease, "It makes me happy to see everyone looking better."

"*Everyone?*" Ptolemy grumbled.

"I do miss Hephaestion," Leonnius lamented dramatically.

"Me too," Hephaestion agreed in a tired but playful voice from his bed.

"Not everyone can pull off the corpse look with such vitality," Perdikkas praised.

Leonnius whistled, "That's not what you want to hear from your doctor."

Phainon looked down at Hephaestion and offered the first mate a small smile. Hephaestion really did look horrible even when he tried to smile back. Better than before even with a pale countenance and too weak to sit up.

Fig Stew crept up across the bed with delicate steps to curl against Hephaestion's side, purring gently.

"He'll be fine," Ptolemy huffed as he waved a hand back and forth, "Hephaestion is not fool enough to perish in his bed, succumbing to injury. The embarrassment of such a thought alone will sustain him."

Hephaestion tried to laugh but it came out as a whimpering bark. "Surely, I am immortal now," he mused, "if ever there was a fight in which to give my life, that would have been the one."

"I am sorry you missed your shot at glory," Phainon apologized.

"No, you're not."

Phainon tilted his head with a wide grin, "no, I'm not, because I need you. All of you."

He slowly sat down on the edge of the bed beside Hephaestion, and Castorice reached out her hand to take his own with a reassuring squeeze.

"I know you all want to know what happened-"

"Phainon, wait," Hephaestion wheezed, "where is Mydei?"

The question felt like a punch to his gut. Hephaestion had been in and out of consciousness since his emergency surgery, no one had the chance to tell him yet.

"Perhaps, captain," Krateros said, and Hephaestion stiffened, "you should start at the moment you and the Prince entered the city."

Phainon took a deep breath and then he told them a story of valor and loss.

He told them almost everything, from their sprint through the city to when he and Mydei left Castorice behind. He described their climb surrounded by lightning and what it was like to hear the voice of the Titan. Phainon told them how he faltered under that crushing weight, that bloodlust that Nikador demanded with their presence, but how Mydei spoke to him in earnest, giving him courage to persist.

The battle was harder to describe in detail, as most of it faded into a blurred memory, so he stuck to the highlights and absentmindedly reached to touch the new nick in his ear as he recounted the blood they spilled. He told them about the ceiling collapsing, their near deaths and the breaking of Nikador's armor, revealing the true spirit of the god-king that crawled from their shell like a cicada. Phainon recounted in detail how Mydei rose to the challenge and killed the Titan when he was too injured to continue the fight himself.

Then he told them about the coreflame, about their discovery of its nature. That piece of Mydei's heart was resting in Peucesta's lap where he sat across the countertop. The bard curled more tightly around it when Phainon told them the truth of what it was, to whom it belonged, and the weight of it being apart from their Prince.

Phainon started to tell them about how he fought to give it to Mydei, but the words caught, and he changed the story only slightly to keep that world-shattering confession to himself. Instead, he told them that there had been no time for Mydei to ascend to divinity, as the Tide surged. He revealed to them the truth that they had discovered, that Nikador's 'corruption' was not of the Tide but of necessity and Eurypon's madness, that the god was a dam, slowing the flow of this mighty swell. Mydei's continued sacrifice was the only thing keeping the Tide from surging faster than they could sail.

Then he shared with them Mydei's last orders to Phainon, to assume the role of captain, exchange the coreflame for Phainon's pardon, and get his family to safety. He told them about Mydei throwing him aside and blocking his return in crystal, to cover their retreat. His fingers carded through Fig's fur as he recounted aloud the chimera's bravery in coming to find them, to retrieve Phainon from his own desperation that would have destroyed him.

"I know I am not Kremnoan," Phainon said, "and if it is the will of those here, I will gladly give the title of Captain to another."

Ptolemy stood up, walked over, and punched him square on the jaw. The whole room jumped. Phainon blinked, stunned as he slowly reached up to rub at the warm spot spreading across his cheek.

The bookworm shook his hand out and said casually, "I had to since Hephaestion can't right now."

"Thank you, Ptolemy," the first mate managed after a loud swallow.

"The young Prince chose you," Krateros said firmly. If there was anyone on board that should be the captain, it was Krateros. "It would betray our love for him, to not honor his wishes."

“Do you not want to be captain, Deliverer?” Peucesta asked in his soft, attention commanding voice. He was still holding the coreflame delicately, his lyre set aside, within reach but less important than the heavy burden he cradled in both hands.

Phainon’s eyes drifted down to that fragment of Mydei’s heart, heavy with the weight of that name on his shoulders. “I want to do what I promised,” he said after a long moment of thought, “to take care of his family.”

“Then believe in yourself the way he does,” Perdikkas offered with a smile.

“You are more than enough,” Hephaestion offered from behind him.

“If we have finally established the chain of command onboard the ship, there are more urgent matters that need discussion,” Anaxa huffed, ever condescending.

“But I didn’t get a turn to kiss the new captain’s ass yet,” Leonnius crooned.

Anaxa’s painfully loud sigh was met with chuckles.

“’If he were to return and look after my affairs I should be both more respected and should show a better presence to the world,’” Ptolemy quoted absentmindedly before asking, “Alright, *captain*, what is the plan?”

Phainon took a breath to steel himself and the coreflame flickered encouragingly. The regret that he felt for trying to reject this responsibility handed to him, died in the embers of hopeful support and Mydei’s love, leaving behind only a stubborn, renewed resolve to be the Deliverer that they needed.

Krateros’ report played on a loop in the back of his head, taking precedence. Hephaestion will have not heard the report, it was worth reviewing.

“Hyacine, how many more men need bedrest?” he asked. The energy was returning to his voice.

“Five, they have been moved from the deck this morning and are settled comfortably in the crew’s quarters and these two wonderful patients here.”

Phainon looked down at Hephaestion. “How long will Hephaestion be bedridden?”

She glanced over at Perdikkas who wrinkled his nose.

“It’s hard to say,” she admitted, “if he is to fight again, perhaps a couple weeks?”

Hephaestion made an annoyed snorting sound.

“For now, I want Krateros to be my first mate,” he announced.

“Captain,” Krateros protested, “I served his highness as an advisor.”

“Excellent, I expect the same from my first mate.”

The old man's eyebrows shot up as he studied Phainon, but he slowly nodded.

"I saw the list of people who died, is there a funeral ceremony that needs to be performed on their behalf."

"No," Ptolemy answered, "I have already recorded their names for the histories."

"I know one of them used to assist Mydei in the galley… Who has been covering the kitchen?" Phainon asked.

"I have, Lord Phainon," Castorice offered, "myself and the Professor."

That was a genuine surprise. "Professor…?"

"Wipe that dumbfounded look off your face, *captain*," he grumbled with a dismissive wave of his hand. The other was keeping his spot in his book; thumb stuck between the pages. "It is a small price to pay to retain some control over my lab and I have yet to hear any complaints."

"Would you two be willing to continue serving in the ship's galley?"

"Anything I can do to help, Lord Phainon," Castorice agreed immediately. When Anaxa didn't respond, she added, "I am sure Professor Anaxa will help."

"Not if you keep calling me that," he hissed.

"We are two days from the settlement," Krateros said, to get them back on track, "and the Tide is on our heels like wild dogs."

Ptolemy raised his hand but didn't wait to be called upon to say, "Krateros, Phainon, and I checked the maps. It's impossible to say for sure but it is highly likely that the settlement will be under the Tide well before we can push it back."

"We discussed it among the three of us, but… how long would it take to evacuate?" Phainon asked and the question hung in the air for a long breath as everyone processed the grief of losing their home *again*.

"A couple days?" Perdikkas offered with a heavy swallow.

"If I gave the order to evacuate the city, would the Kremnoan people listen?"

Again, silence hung in the air. Ptolemy and Krateros had already had the time to process the inevitability of this decision and even they were hesitant to answer. The bookworm drummed his fingers on his knee.

"We will make them listen," Hephaestion said firmly when no one else dared to speak.

"Lord Phainon," Hyacine offered, "if anyone can get them to listen, it's you."

"A silver-tongued Okheman, what could go wrong?" Leonnius chirped.

Krateros tsked and said assuredly, “they will listen.”

“But where can we even go?” the runner added. He shifted uncomfortably on the bed and Anaxa nearly smacked him with his book for bouncing the thin mattress up and down.

“There is only one place safe from the Tide,” Castorice reminded them all.

“The Dawn Device extends well past Okhema,” said Phainon, “there are lots of places that we can lead them for now that will keep Okhema and Kremnos apart.”

“Can we not take them to the Holy City?” Hyacine asked, “was that not the purpose of this bloody campaign? To end the war between us? Aglaea would accept the Kremnoan people as refugees…”

The coreflame flickered under darting gazes and Phainon’s shoulders slumped.

“That…that is the one thing Mydei told me to do that I hesitate to obey,” he admitted.

Immediately five Kremnoans started protesting at once, a combination of accusations, reminders of the blood spilled for this specific purpose, words reminding of Mydei’s desires, of *their* desires for him. Words that turned into arguing with each other when calls of support clashed with the others. He let them shout until he saw Castorice slowly move her hands to her ears and then he stomped his foot and barked once, “*Enough*!”

They quieted, still fuming as the room tried to be more polite in their discussions.

“Did we not just say that it is a betrayal to not obey Mydei’s wishes?” Krateros growled, “you who claim to love him as we do, would spit in the face of his sacrifice?”

“Phainon just told us that the coreflame is a *part* of Mydei,” Hephaestion tried to growl but he barely managed to get his sentence out before he started weakly coughing. Castorice reached to comfort him, resting her hand on his forehead.

“But he *knew* that it belonged to him when he told Phainon to exchange it for his pardon,” Perdikkas reminded them, “he knew, and he still wanted this.”

“I agree,” Ptolemy added onto Perdikkas’ statement, “we should honor our Prince’s wishes and do as he said. He wanted his people to be safe, what is safer than the protection of the Dawn Device and the end of our peoples’ war?”

“Miss Castorice,” Peucesta called gently, “you described once before what it was like to bear a coreflame, that need to feel whole when you realized a part of you is missing.” The bard had a captive audience, and he knew it, pausing to gather his thoughts while he rolled the coreflame in his hands to see the symbol of Strife as it flashed inside. “When we return for our Prince, he will be needing this piece of his heart.”

I don’t need the coreflame to feel whole, because I have you.

Phainon swallowed around his secret.

"*If*," Leonnius said harshly, "*if* we return."

Perdikkas rose to his feet, knocking over his chair. Behind him, Phainon felt the sheet shift as Hephaestion squirmed in his uselessness.

"How can you say that?!" Perdikkas snarled.

"You think I *want* to say it?!" the runner motioned quickly to himself, to Phainon, and then Hephaestion, "Does this look like a crew that can repeat what we just did? Now that the Tide is stronger? Faster? Have you looked at the talismans, Perdikkas?"

The doctor winced and looked down, fists clenched at his sides. Anaxa's charms had saved them from corruption, but *barely*. Even with the increased capacity, they had filled too quickly once Nikador had perished and the Tide had been unleashed in full force. Phainon had learned that the only reason they had survived was because Peucesta had noticed them breaking and sounded the retreat early.

Phainon closed his eyes and replayed his final moments with Mydei again, all the way up to that desperate, hasty kiss.

I don't need the coreflame to feel whole, because I have you.

"We will evacuate the settlement to the mainland," he finally said, "it is a long route, but Okhema can be reached by land, and the Dawn Device reaches over the plateaus and fields between. It will not take long to ferry the people and supplies and get them moving."

"Phainon that will take months…" Ptolemy mumbled.

"It gets them moving on a predictable, *safe* path with plenty of options to stop and rest maybe even settle, and we will sail ahead to Okhema," he took a breath and let it out before saying, "where I will exchange the coreflame for the pardon of all Kremnoans and end the war between our peoples." In the corner of Phainon's eye he saw Krateros shaking, angry, but respecting the decision with reluctance by holding his tongue. "And I will petition for reinforcements to go back for Mydei."

The quiet was shattered by Anaxa's laugh. "A single coreflame to end a generations long war, buy the forgiveness for an entire crew of pirates, *and* access to Okhema's golden fleet? A tall order and too small of a purse."

"That's why you will come with me, professor."

Anaxa frowned and then schooled his expression once more as he quickly realized Phainon's intentions. "Ah, you would offer two coreflames and abuse my relationship with *that* woman to appease the Council of Elders." He laughed again and all the Kremnoans shuffled uncomfortably. "If I decline your request?"

"We are practiced rescuers," Phainon said simply, and three different people snorted in lieu of laughter.

“Fine, I will acquiesce under the condition that you do not present me as your primary offering. A skilled barterer does not empty their pockets at the beginning of negotiations, and I would rather not be presented to those peacocks except as a last resort.”

“Do you think that little of me, Professor Anaxa?”

“It’s *Anaxagoras*, and you have given me reason to be worried in the past,” he admitted, “prove to me that you are worthy of this faith that so many others have entrusted to you.”

Phainon nodded humbly and held a hand to his chest, “I will do everything in my power to secure the means to save Mydei from his eternal battle. He deserves nothing less than our very best.”

“I abhor the idea of allying with Okhema,” Krateros admitted, “…but what they lack in military might they make up for in other ways. The Goldweaver alone could turn the Tide.”

“Aglaea, Cipher, and Tribbie, are all powerful Demigods,” Castorice reminded them, “so long as Lord Mydei continues to fight, we are not without hope.”

“Even if I have to go alone,” Phainon told the room with resolve reverberating in his declaration, “I will return to Castrum Kremnos and bring Mydei home.”

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Phainon stood at the rail watching over the deck from Mydei’s favorite spot. The wind played with his hair and tugged at his clothes, nearly knocking Fig Stew off the railing with one gusty burst. The chimera huffed and jumped to a barrel instead for a more secure foundation. He rolled onto his side and Phainon willingly obliged, giving that soft belly gentle scratches.

“How often did Mydei take your advice?” he asked without turning around.

Krateros stepped forward, one hand resting idly on the hilt of his sword, the other relaxed at his side.

“Less frequently than I wish,” the old man admitted, “but he is wise beyond his years. Mydeimos will be the greatest of Kremnoan kings, a worthy successor of Gorgo.”

Phainon had to give the old man credit for his quiet positivity. The Kremnoans had absolute faith in their Prince, in Mydei’s resolve, endurance, and his immortal body.

“Did he ever reject your words and regret it?”

“I cautioned him once as a child not to eat jellyfish,” Krateros recalled and Phainon heard the fondness of revisiting a pleasant memory in that gruff voice.

“He didn’t…”

“Stubborn to a fault.”

Phainon chuckled at the image that came to mind of a young Mydeimos determined to find a recipe that called for stinging jellyfish.

“It was ever my purpose to guide not control,” Krateros said. He stepped forward to pet Fig’s belly. That old hand, covered in scars and rough skin long damaged by years in the sun knew all the right places to scratch and Fig Stew happily wiggled away from Phainon into that more experienced touch. “I had promised his mother as such.”

“What was she like?” Phainon asked, quieter now that they were closer.

“Radiant and strong,” he said simply, “just as the young Prince is.”

“I know that you have reservations about me, Krateros, but I appreciate your guidance.”

The old man snorted and pulled his hand away from Fig Stew’s belly. “Okheman sentimentality has no place on this ship.” Phainon smiled behind Krateros’ back as the old man turned to leave. “For all his questionable judgements, and his unwillingness to listen when I have spoken reason, I am glad that he did not heed me when I advised him about you.”

Phainon chuckled and twisted his head to look over his shoulder. “Oh, so *Kremnoan* sentimentality is allowed?”

Krateros huffed, loudly, indignant, and hurried away to manage the crew without another word.

“I’m glad too,” Phainon whispered to the chimera.

“*Awoo!*”

Chapter End Notes

> Just so every knows, I have had a list in my notes of every character that is doomed to die and WHEN they will die from the very beginning. I KNEW that Hephaestion would be fiiiine but it was so endearing all the same at how many of you all commented in horror begging for him to be okay. It's funny because he's probably the only one disappointed that he didn't get to perish in glorious combat befitting a Kremnoan warrior.

Chapter 30: Evacuation

Chapter Summary

No new tags? I personally find losing a home to be traumatic but it's already been mentioned in this fic so I'm not going to tag it

The evacuation doesn't go as smoothly as they hoped and Phainon finds someone who was almost left behind

Chapter Notes

TWO LOVELY PEOPLE HAVE BLESSED ME AND THIS FIC WITH FANART NOW. This is a literal dream come true so now I am going to share:
Link - Lissain
Link - Yanli1ruu
My Pirate agenda is spreading :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Convincing the Kremnoan Settlement that evacuation was the only option in the face of impending danger came with a sobering revelation. Phainon had already anticipated the language barrier. His Kremnoan was still laughably atrocious, even with extra help from Ptolemy and Peucesta, practicing exactly what he needed to say to the Kremnoan people. But when he finally stood before those who gathered at the dock, Phainon remembered that "captain" did not mean "Prince", nor did he want it to. Mydei entrusted the ship and his people to him, but the farmer's son was not of noble birth, nor did the settlement see him the way the crew did: Kremnoan in spirit.

As he stumbled over his words, speaking to Empousa and Daidalos, trying to remember every syllable with confidence, it slowly sunk in just how out of his depth Phainon really was. A crowd had gathered, eager for news of the battle, and met him with resounding disappointment and thinly veiled disgust.

Who was this Okheman that stood in the place of their Crown Prince, stumbling over words in a language he barely understood to demand they leave their home? Even when he tried to go off script, begging and pleading with more heartfelt words, they struggled to accept the shock of the crew's bitter return. He could not tell them about the Coreflame of Strife, lest they tear themselves apart to get to it, to try and become its master out of fear of the impending Tide. He could not tell them Mydei's final words in full, knowing they would not

believe him. And Phainon struggled to admit to them that *he was wrong*, the Tide was not pushed back as they believed, and for that hubris, their people would suffer.

Krateros, dutiful, grumpy, highly respected, Krateros, was the one that rallied the people. He stood beside Phainon and spoke to them loudly in Kremnoan in words simple enough for Phainon to understand.

He stood at Phainon's shoulder on the dock, vouched for him as a man who was Kremnoan at heart, hand chosen by Mydeimos the Undying. He reminded them of Phainon's strength in the arena, spoke to his courage and tenacity serving the ship, and then he repeated the order: the settlement must evacuate or perish. There could be no valorous death against a foe that tears from them their identity, not yet. The old veteran did not mince words, he did not hide from them the danger, nor their limited timeframe, and urged them to spread the message to the city. If there were any doubts, he invited them to settle the grievance with their spears, a challenge that none dared rise to meet.

With the crew's help, word spread like wildfire through wheat and packing began in earnest. The Kremnoans had two ships, the Chryseus Leo, and a merchant ship that they used to trade in faraway markets. The latter was a large trireme, commandeered a few years prior but with limited capacity for defense. She was not built for speed despite her oars and was wider and longer than the Leo, with fewer decks and sails.

Her primary cargo was left in the shipyard; stolen goods were no longer the priority over people and necessities. Even as half the city debated the validity of the threat, Perdikkas and Ptolemy worked with Empousa to send supplies across the sound to the mainland via their merchant ship, sailing back and forth at all hours.

Phainon personally helped everywhere he could, something that got easier when he was finally free of the sling. He couldn't lift heavy things but there were plenty of ways to help, especially when Krateros took over the coordinating. The people listened to the leader of the former Godshield Brigade, they recognized him as a local hero, but not once did he ever try to assume command, deferring to Phainon at every opportunity to show the people that the Okheman was worthy of the same respect. It was during this time, meeting with local leaders, veterans, and helping pillars of the community, that Phainon realized how adaptable the Kremnoan people were and how prepared they already were for this outcome.

A lifetime of *hope* and experience had left them without permanent roots. Phainon saw with every passing Entry Hour of preparation that the Kremnoans had been *waiting* for the chance to leave. For many adults it was simply a habit formed after years of military campaigns to not put down roots, to be ready to follow their King or Titan on long excursions across the ocean at a moment's notice. But overall, they as a people had never seen this island as the final destination for the sons and daughters of Kremnos, especially with their Crown Prince returned to them. There had always been an eagerness lurking under the streets for Mydeimos to take up the crown and lead them back to their homeland. To send them instead to shelter under the protection of a foreign god, they viewed as a temporary step on a long road home.

That preparation and willingness to work together as a people saved most of them when the Black Tide arrived ahead of schedule. The fog engulfed the northern half of the island in the dead of night, spreading rapidly like a tsunami, turning all those who had stayed to keep

watch. The speed at which the Tide poured over the Kremnoans was unprecedented, slowing only as the fog broke against the inland hills, and even then, still it crawled with hungry purpose. Phainon and the rest of the city were awoken in the night to a light from the North as fire licked at the forest and illuminated the mountainside, bearing down on the city as those poor souls that had been claimed by this eldritch enemy stormed the streets to meet their ends on their former comrade's spears.

The last of the evacuation began in earnest. Phainon could hear distant battle cries as Kremnoans fought monsters in the streets and made use of the city planning to seal off routes, creating bottlenecks that funneled the Black Tide creatures into kill zones. A city of warriors was well prepared for combat against flesh, but the creeping Tide still flowed, driving them back to the ships even as they slew the Tide's vanguard.

The smoke stung Phainon's lungs as his boots clicked on the stone road. Aside from the crack and pop of the fire slowly taking this street, it was quiet. Not a soul in sight as he hurried into burning buildings, calling for any who may have been trapped in the urgency. A few he found dead in their beds, crushed by falling debris, but no one answered his call until he fell back a couple streets and then his combing paid off.

Further from the quick moving fires Phainon heard a muffled peep. It was so soft and intermittent that Phainon wasn't sure he had heard it at first and very nearly moved on but when he closed his eyes and systematically took in each sound, filtering through the noises of destruction he heard a tiny whimper.

"Is there someone there?" he called, sticking to Kremnoan.

A gasp. His head whipped around in the direction of the sound.

The alleyway was a tight squeeze, even without his armor, Phainon's broad shoulders had to twist sideways to fit and his chest and back scraped against opposing walls as he crept between the two buildings. The glow of the fires was only just beginning to spill over the top of the opposing home, raining tiny embers and ash into a small, open clearing between several homes. Children had built a little fort here, old flags and thrown away sheets were stretched over lopsided sticks for cover and a collection of toy swords leaned against one wall.

Phainon squatted down and peeled back the fabric of the tent to peer inside and very nearly lost an eye.

"Whoa!" he yelped as he leaned away from the wooden sword. The point of it chased him backwards, swinging wildly at his outstretched hands, slapping his forearms, his fingers, and wrists when Phainon's back hit the wall. He snatched the swinging weapon, holding it by the dull 'blade' while the child fought to free it from his grasp.

"Hey, hey, it's okay!" They didn't understand and let go of the sword to throw themselves at Phainon instead. Little fists punched at his thighs and groin until he managed to catch a wrist and gently pulled the child away before any real damage could be done. Still, they struggled in his firm grip.

In the dim light, it was hard to tell if the child was a boy or a girl. They had chin length, mousy brown hair that was matted with ash, dark eyes, and were dressed like most other children Phainon had seen around town in a rough, sleeveless tunic. Mud and dust were smeared on every inch of exposed skin aside from two tear tracks down each cheek, already long dried.

Furious, they babbled in Kremnoan, presumably demanding that Phainon let them go while they whined, but the words were too slurred and Phainon was too new to the language to have any hope of understanding.

“Hey, it’s okay,” he tried again, dimly aware of the fire above, steadily reaching down the walls. The smoke was starting to settle in the cramped space, so he lowered himself to sit on the ground to buy some time.

The kid was still yelling at him, slapping him with stress in that small voice. Phainon could hear the rasp of a dry throat under the babbles and feel blunt nails trying to tear at the skin above his bracers. When the little kid managed to cut him, he winced but held on. The gold startled the child who ceased fighting to admire the new distraction when it glittered on their fingertips in the orange light.

Phainon gently let go when the kid stopped fighting. He let the toy fall to the ground and they seemed to recognize the truce in the action, taking the opportunity to retreat and keep a safe distance from this stranger.

“Come with me?” he asked.

The child looked up at him and then back to their fort. They crouched down to get their wooden sword from the ground but didn’t use it to hit him this time. Instead, the kid flinched and pointed it at one of the alleyways when part of a roof collapsed into the gap, sealing off one of the fort’s escape routes.

Sweat dripped down the back of Phainon’s neck and beaded on his brow. This narrow side yard was heating up fast and the ceiling of smoke was getting lower. Distantly, Phainon heard a warning horn, the first of two from Peucesta.

“What’s your name?”

The child babbled back in Kremnoan and Phainon gave up. He would need a translator for sure, his own sentences were missing the proper words, so he tried to keep it simple.

“Help me?” Phainon asked. He pretended to be scared of the fire, leaning away from it and covering his eyes, and the child reached out to put a hand on his arm.

They babbled again and then grabbed his hand to pull him towards another alley. It was wider than the one he had come from and full of heavy, black smoke that left him at the mercy of this child until they were on the street and the rest of the roof slid into the gap behind them.

Phainon didn’t wait for permission this time. He scooped the kid up in his arms and started running, lungs complaining with every step. At first the child protested, yelling at him and

trying to slap his face. That wooden sword smacked the side of his head repeatedly while he tried to orient himself downhill towards the ship.

He slid around a corner, and a massive paw swatted him out of the road. Phainon and the kid were sent flying and fortunately landed in a fabric stall with Phainon taking the brunt of the blow. The child was holding tightly to his chest now, stunned by the very sudden appearance of a monster.

Kremnoan children were trained from birth to be warriors, it was a cultural thing to shrug off fear and pain even at this age, but Dark Sun Gryphons were a league of their own. The monster's screech made the kid yell and bury their face in Phainon's shirt and while they didn't cry, their grip was white knuckled.

He wrapped an arm under the kid to hold them close while he staggered back to standing, no easy feat with the slip of silks underfoot, the soreness of his recently healed wound, and the ragged ache of his burning lungs. The gryphon was already advancing, swooping in at them wings wide and mane sharp. Phainon dodged at the last second and the Tide monster slammed into the stall, quickly becoming tangled and buying them precious time.

"I need to put you down," Phainon said in Okheman, knowing the child probably didn't understand his words but hopefully understood the action when he bent down and loosened his grip. The child scrambled to hold on tighter, wrapping their arms around his neck and their legs around his waist. The wooden sword smacked against the back of Phainon's head when he tried to dislodge them and by then the monster was lunging again.

Phainon instinctually called for his sword, but nothing happened. The broken hilt was still in Castrum Kremnos, pieces of the blade scattered across the crater under the Blade of Fury. His thoughts drifted to Mydei as he sprang sideways away from the gryphon. It slammed into the building behind them, showering the street with plaster and debris. Phainon covered the child's head as they screamed, more from the shock than fear.

What would Mydei do right now? Phainon tried to picture the Kremnoan standing here in the street alongside him, ready to fight. He could picture those broad shoulders and the flex of his biceps. Mydei would curl his fingers, halfway to a fist, and widen his stance with a pointed taunt.

Let me show you how it's done, Deliverer.

When the gryphon shrugged off the stone and turned again, Phainon stood his ground. The child turned enough to watch, wide-eyed as the monster ran at them, swiping with a massive paw. Phainon dodged in and to the side, narrowly avoiding those sharp claws to get in close enough to slam his fist directly into the gryphon's flat face with an angry shout.

There was a moment when time seemed to stop, the smack to what Phainon hoped was the monster's nose had the creature stumbling while it processed what happened. Mydei surely would have done the same… but Mydei wore gauntlets and had more experience fighting with his fists. The skin on Phainon's knuckles split with the blow and he felt the vibrations all the way through his arm to his shoulder with a tickle that made his teeth grind together.

It was the child that started the clock again. With one arm still wrapped around Phainon's neck they leaned back and slapped the gryphon with the wooden sword with a brave *thunk*. The gryphon reared, and the child swiped again but Phainon was already moving. He put his hand on the child's back to support them and raced away.

The gryphon pursued, swiping at his heels and occasionally leaping over Phainon's head to cut off any retreat. Every time, Phainon found a way to evade, dodging down side streets and once, he successfully ran along the wall around the gryphon, something he wished Mydei could've seen.

The horn of Peucesta's second warning reverberated through the air, comfortingly close. Phainon dipped between two buildings to run along the shore. It was more open along the wharf, no more hiding from the gryphon, but more importantly it brought the beast and himself into eyeshot of the crew. Phainon took the turn onto the dock just a tiny bit too fast and nearly threw himself and the child into the water, narrowly keeping on track as they surged towards the ship. He could see the crew ready to pull the ramp up behind them and then the dock shook.

The gryphon failed on the turn, claws tearing into the wooden dock and ripping it free from the shore. The monster flailed, tearing out planks as it dragged itself after them while its back half splashed helplessly in the water below. A younger Phainon would've surely faltered on that listing dock, but compared to a ship during a storm…

He leaped onto the ramp taking it in two strides to roll onto the deck, removing himself from the line of fire as a volley of arrows and one bright gunshot whistled on their way to the depths with the sinking, dying gryphon.

Phainon curled around the kid. They were shaking, holding tightly to him with a racing heartbeat, but not crying or yelling. Krateros was already shouting for the ship to get underway, and the sails above fluttered as they unfurled and caught the wind. The deck was already packed with people and Phainon knew that the hold wasn't any better. The last of the city was on board, ready for the ferry to the mainland where the others were waiting, already organizing the caravan for the upcoming exodus.

"Phainon!" Ptolemy dropped to one knee beside Phainon and immediately got his hand whacked by a toy sword.

The child babbled at him and Ptolemy's brow wrinkled.

"Can you understand… her?" Phainon asked. He had to lean back a little to see her face better but in the lights hanging around the ship, it was easier to tell that this fierce, courageous child of Strife was a girl.

"She has baby voice but yeah." Ptolemy got swatted again and this time he grabbed the sword and scolded her in her native tongue, "stop that! I am not your enemy!"

She fought to get her weapon back and he let her have it which calmed her down a little bit, enough to look around and stress. Phainon sat up with her and she squirmed to get comfortable in his lap, propping herself up on her knees on his thighs to look around with

increasing concern. She mumbled to herself while she carefully took in the chaos of the deck, still clinging tightly to Phainon's shirt with her good hand. A couple of very small babies were crying and there was a general buzz of people, to an overstimulated child it was probably a lot but then again, this was a Kremnoan child. She was probably desensitized to loud noises as an infant, in preparation for the cacophony of combat.

"Do you see your parents?" Ptolemy asked her and she shook her head and settled back down, retreating from Ptolemy to lean against Phainon's chest with her toy sword still swinging wildly around while she got comfortable.

"She was near the Tide line," Phainon reported, "in a residential district."

"What's your name?"

She shook her head and leaned into Phainon.

"Phainon, will you ask her?"

He struggled with the pronunciation but repeated the question and she reluctantly babbled something.

"Ask her about her parents and her age." Ptolemy helped him get the syllables right, while the girl was warming up to the bookworm. She still didn't answer when Ptolemy asked but she was starting to smile mischievously waiting for Phainon to repeat the words she already recognized from her kinsman's lips.

Phainon stumbled over the words, but she still answered, and Ptolemy understood. He rubbed his eyes. "Her name is Chironome, she's five. Give me a bit to track down her parents."

"Is there someone that can take care of her until we find them?" Phainon asked and they both looked down at where this little girl fiddled with her sword. She didn't understand them when they spoke Okheman, but Phainon got the feeling she wouldn't listen to the Kremnoan either.

"Maybe when we meet up with the others."

Chironome waved at Ptolemy to get his attention and started talking to him again. Her little voice was still strained from the smoke, and she kept pausing to cough, but she motioned eagerly to Phainon and tried to sound authoritative while she told a story.

"Did you understand what she said?" Ptolemy asked.

Phainon shook his head. "It's hard to understand when she doesn't enunciate."

"She says that you were very brave but that you still need a lot of help but it's okay because she's going to take care of you since you asked so nicely before and that's what heroes do. She also says that you need to get a sword because your punch wasn't good." Her little voice suddenly got louder as she added very quickly another string of words. "…you can't have her sword because it's her favorite. You need your own sword."

She had twisted in his lap so she could rub Phainon's arm, offering comfort, he realized. He smiled at her reassuringly and she smiled and patted his cheek like one would pet a dog, proud of her ability to make him feel better.

"I can keep an eye on her until we get across the sound," he offered.

"Maybe get out of the way while you do," suggested Ptolemy. He turned to the little girl to say, "this is Phainon, you did a good job saving him, but he needs more help, can you keep helping him?" Chironome nodded. "Good, can you take him down there to the doctor?" Ptolemy pointed to the stairs that led below and after a very short nervous gasp she found her courage and nodded again.

Determined, she got up and brandished her sword in one hand, narrowly avoiding smacking Ptolemy in the head, and with the other she grabbed Phainon's hand.

"This way, Fine!" she ordered with a solid tug, still slurring a bit but she was getting easier to understand the more he focused on her particular brand of little kid accent.

"Tell Hephaestion I said hi." Ptolemy patted Phainon on the back and then hurried to help the others with the sails.

Chironome was short for a five-year-old, or so Phainon assumed, while he loved children and had on occasion helped babysit back in Okhema, his grasp on child raising was notably limited. He just loved the whimsy of kids, their wild ideas, the silly things they said, the sort of imagination they still retained. They were joy and curiosity with infinite potential, and this little girl had the added bonus of being fearless.

She took her job very seriously, pulling Phainon along and swinging her sword around to clear the way. When Chironome wasn't sure where to go she looked up at him expectantly until he pointed and then she was back to pulling him along and yelling at everyone that dared cross her path.

"Move! Fine needs help! Move!" she shouted in Kremnoan.

Phainon mumbled soft apologies any time someone got slapped by the sword, but the crew were mostly amused, shook their heads, and got back to work after letting them pass until she finally found the infirmary door. It wasn't locked but it was guarded by Leonnius who was sitting on a barrel just outside. He saw them coming and was trying so hard not to laugh.

The runner was healing nicely but his ankle was still tightly wrapped to keep it stiff. With his limited mobility, guard duty was the best Leonnius could hope for until the sprain healed. He raised a hand in greeting and very nearly lost it to the swing of the toy.

"Fine, needs to see the doctor," she announced.

"*Fine?*" Leonnius bit his lip to hold back the laugh.

"It's a long story," Phainon said cheerfully, albeit a little raspy from the smoke inhalation.

“Okay, okay, little warrior,” Leonnius told her in Kremnoan, “you can go inside.” He reached up to grab the latch so he could push the door open for her.

She started to walk in, stopped so suddenly that Phainon very nearly tripped over her, and turned to say, “thank you.”

The second they stepped inside the infirmary, Chironome forgot that she had a job. She gasped so loudly that Phainon thought she might have been hurt and then followed up with a high-pitched squeal, startling the locals as she rushed to Hephaestion’s bedside to croon over Fig Stew. Alarmed by the sudden assault and the reaching hand, the chimera hissed and fluffed himself up, turning sideways to look bigger and hide the coreflame behind him. Hephaestion’s quick reflexes saved the little girl from a nasty bite when he caught her hand enroute to those fluffy cheeks.

Phainon was a second behind, grabbing her by the back of her tunic to hoist her aloft. Rather than being indignant or upset, Chironome squealed happily at that too and laughed while he bounced her up and down to keep her distracted.

“What in Nikador’s name is going on?” Perdikkas asked from one of the cabinets.

“Lord Phainon?” Castorice inquired with a tilt of her head. She blinked from her chair where she was peeling an apple. Two more waited in her lap but she had almost forgotten the small knife and half prepared fruit now that this new hellion was loose in the infirmary.

“I’m sorry, I didn’t know she would react like that,” he managed. He swapped back to Kremnoan to ask, “Will you be good if I put you down?”

She tilted her head in confusion and Perdikkas sighed. “Phainon, you got the pronunciation… hold on.” The doctor put the bandages he had in his hands back in the basket in the cabinet and closed the door before he wandered over to repeat Phainon’s question. It sounded *notably* different from how Phainon was saying it.

She nodded and started excitedly talking to the doctor, talking too fast and too slurred for Phainon to follow but Hephaestion chuckled and Perdikkas nodded politely. Very slowly, while she still rambled, Phainon set her back down on her feet. She was so engrossed in her storytelling that she didn’t even notice.

“You can’t pet him if you are holding the sword,” Perdikkas told her firmly.

She stomped her foot and started scolding Perdikkas, trying to explain something to him in earnest while Phainon crept around her to go to Hephaestion’s side. The man was well enough to be propped up on a gentle recline, sitting up to eat simple foods. His breathing was still very rough and wet but that was to be expected.

Hephaestion’s chest injury would’ve been fatal if Hyacine had not been standing next to him at the time. Both doctors had given Phainon the list of medical issues that the man had to overcome but it mostly boiled down to damaged lungs, ribs, and a few smaller organs. Little Ica had tended to him day and night after they still almost lost him in recovery, but the man was a fighter and refused to perish in such a shameful way.

“Ptolemy says hi,” he reported while he gently pet Fig Stew. The chimera was still fluffed up and unhappy but when Phainon’s hand gently patted the raised fur back down, it at least didn’t stand back up.

Hephaestion snorted. “What’s with the kid?”

“I was doing a last pass, looking for survivors and found her near the Tide line,” he explained, “Ptolemy is going to track down her parents when we get across the sound.”

Phainon gave Fig Stew one last pat and then reached over the little body to place his palm on the coreflame. It was snug between Hephaestion’s side and the chimera, safe and warm.

“Earlier tonight it went dark,” Hephaestion reported in a hushed voice, “it flared back to life quickly, but…”

Phainon’s eyes grew wide, and he snapped his head to look over at Castorice. Her eyes were a little darker than usual as she met his with a slow swallow.

“Lord Mydei is fighting very hard,” she said and Phainon’s heart sunk into his belly. The Tide’s surge, the coreflame losing its light… How many lives had Mydei already lost to buy them time? How many did he have left?

“Phainon, can she pet Fig Stew?” Perdikkas asked from behind them and Phainon scooted over to make space.

Chironome was much quieter now, she had surrendered her weapon and was trying to be more respectful of the chimera’s personal wants.

“Let him sniff you,” Hephaestion ordered, and she held her hand out.

Fig Stew leaned forward to sniff and when she stayed quiet, he gave her fingers an accepting lick. Chironome reached out to pat his head. Encouraged by the purrs, Phainon let out his held breath and went to sit down on a chair beside Castorice. Compared to the fight at Castrum Kremnos this hadn’t been as physically taxing but Phainon was emotionally spent. He had avoided any traumatic responses, but his heart still ached at the familiarity of a burning home, of Black Tide creatures tearing through streets. And knowing the high cost of every passing quint.

Castorice gently put her hand on his arm to get his attention and when he turned his tired expression to her, she held an apple slice to his lips. He happily took the sweet fruit, chewing slowly as he sank into his chair far enough to rest his head against the back of it to close his eyes and just rest for a moment.

The ship swayed underfoot, he could feel it in his wide stance as he braced himself to stay seated. An ache was starting in his hand, cool air stinging his knuckles where they had split. Sweetness on tongue lingered from the apple slice and even seated apart he could feel the warmth of Mydei’s presence in the room.

Phainon may have fallen asleep if it wasn't for tiny hands on his thigh. He kept his eyes closed as Chironome climbed into his lap again, her knees dug into the meat of his legs enough to make him wince, but he kept his hands folded on his chest to resist the instinct to remove her. She settled with a quiet oof and babbled at him.

"Fine, Fine," she demanded and he hummed in response, only opening his eyes when he felt that sweetness against his lips again.

She had seen Castorice feeding him and decided that her charge still needed help, hopeless as he was. One of her hands was on his chest so she could lean up enough to reach, the other holding the apple slice so tightly that juice dripped over her fingers to drop onto his chin. Phainon obediently parted his lips, and she alternated between shoving apples into his mouth and politely asking Castorice for more as they tag teamed his care.

"Do you understand her?" he asked Castorice right before a hand on his cheek demanded his attention again.

"Not in words," she admitted. The knife made a soft, crisp sound as it glided through the fruit's flesh. Cas handed the slice over, but this one went into Chironome's mouth, now that Phainon had been fed, she was realizing her own hunger. "Children of this age can be surprisingly generous. They long for connection and are keenly aware of what is happening around them. She saw me give you a bite of the apple and wanted to be the one to take care of you." Castorice offered a slice to Hephaestion, but he politely declined with a raised hand.

"Do you need me to look at that?" Perdikkas asked over his shoulder and Phainon followed where he was pointing to his knuckles.

"Oh, no, it'll be alright."

"Mydei makes it look easy," the doctor teased and Phainon's smile turned sad, at least until Chironome gently took his face in both of her hands, scooting up his chest to reach.

"You are okay," she said in her baby voice. His heart lurched a little at her tenderness and he really believed it even when she added, very seriously, "but you won't be if you don't get a sword."

Hephaestion started coughing when a laugh got stuck in his damaged chest and Perdikkas hurried to check on him while he mouthed 'I'll tell you later' to Castorice.

Oblivious to the chaos around them, Chironome wiggled off Phainon, crashed her way back to her feet and fetched her wooden sword from where Perdikkas had put it on the desk. She brought it back to him and put it in his lap with reverence. "You can share mine," she offered and then seriously again, "for now."

Phainon put his hand over hers and smiled. "Thank you," he said, and it sounded correct.

"I'll get her cleaned up, Lord Phainon," Castorice offered, "if you would like to rest."

"I can translate for you, Cas," Perdikkas added.

“I can do it,” Phainon insisted.

Perdikkas roughly shoved Phainon back down when he tried to get up and Chironome punched Perdikkas for it.

“He needs to go down for a nap! Or else he won’t be able to fight anymore!” the doctor huffed at her. The child contemplated that and then she also pushed against Phainon until he finally relented with a wave of his hand.

“Alright, alright, just a quick nap.”

Perdikkas scooped up Chironome who looked very displeased to be in someone else’s arms. “We’ll wake you when we make it across the channel,” he promised.

The chair wasn’t comfortable, but he was planning on only closing eyes for a few minutes. Phainon nodded and leaned back again. “Okay… thanks.”

The last thing he heard was the quiet click of the infirmary door closing and the soft purr of a content chimera.

Chapter End Notes

Note: This chapter is so late because I ended up playing phone tag with my niece, my father, my mother, my sister-in-law, and my brother doing research for this chapter cause I could not remember what five-year-old kids were like. Her name is from a readable in game. Super, super side character but I did try to give her the same personality as the NPC so fun easter egg.

Chapter 31: Legacy

Chapter Summary

No new tags

Phainon and Krateros get a chance to bond

Chapter Notes

Notes: Don't mind me trying to very sneakily adjust the chapter count. I think this is the last time I will have to do it, I say hopefully knowing I have a lot of plot left ;w;

Phainon dreamed of Mydei. Like most dreams it was hazy around the edges, fluid and non-descript. The environment around them didn't matter, the context of the company ceased to be, but Mydei was *there* beside him. They didn't talk, didn't touch, they just sat beside each other, smelling the sea breeze and the warmth of the distant sun.

Peace.

"Phainon," Mydei said, as gently as he could with that natural purr in his voice. He turned to see him, but Mydei was blurry and fading away at the edges.

"Phainon…" Mydei repeated and then Phainon was gasping awake. He blinked a few times and started to sit up, the immediate ache in his back and neck reminding him of how stupid it was to fall asleep in a chair.

"Phainon," Perdikkas repeated as he put a hand on his shoulder to stop him from rising, holding a finger to his lips before pointing at Phainon's chest. Chironome was curled up there, sound asleep around the coreflame of Strife. Someone had covered them both with a blanket at some point while they were sleeping.

He slowly reached up to wrap his arms around her and the coreflame so he could reposition for the sake of his aching back without dumping this precious cargo onto the floor.

"The ship is already unloaded," the doctor reported with a whisper and Phainon tried not to jump with alarm.

"Why didn't you wake me?"

"You needed the rest. So did she."

Phainon looked down at the little girl. They had found her clean clothes, an oversized old shirt that went just past her knees and tied at the waist with a bit of extra cord, and wiped the grime from her arms, legs, and face. Without the ash in her hair, the hue was less brunette than Phainon had originally thought, rather walking the fine line between a light brown and a dusty blonde.

He gently pulled the blanket up over her shoulder after it slipped, hiding her from the dangers of the world. Not that he needed to. Her toy sword was on the chair beside him, ready to be pointed at any monsters with the courage of a child that had not yet learned to fear those things that go bump in the night. Or perhaps her parents had already quelled those fears in a way that only a father or mother could.

“When we came back,” Perdikkas whispered, “she saw you getting restless in your sleep. Hephaestion told her to bring you the coreflame to ease your nightmares and she insisted on supervising until you were at peace.”

“I don’t remember any nightmares,” Phainon admitted, but this was probably why.

Mydei’s coreflame flickered warmly in her arms and Phainon wondered what he would think if he knew that little hands were holding this part of his heart. Did Mydei like children?

“Perdikkas, does Mydei like kids?” he asked softly.

“I think so,” the doctor admitted, “we don’t get a lot of chances to meet them when they’re this age but he’s very good with the infants.”

“Infants?”

“As the Crown Prince, many Kremnoans seek his blessing for their children. Even if he has never placed much value in such traditions, I’ve never seen Mydei decline, and he always holds them with such care. Someone who does not like children wouldn’t hold them with such soft hands and eyes.”

The tender image of that wild lion cradling a tiny person in his gauntlets made Phainon smile.

“I need to get her to the caravan,” Phainon murmured after a quiet moment, “will you grab the coreflame?”

Perdikkas’ steady hands surgically removed the coreflame from Chironome and she stayed sleeping, fussing only long enough to turn more into Phainon’s chest to drool on his shirt with her head tilted back. The doctor gently squeezed her wooden toy sword in between them to take its place and Phainon mouthed, ‘thank you.’ He wrapped the blanket around her nice and tight, even pulling it up over her head like a hood to keep out the early morning chill, and stood up with her cradled carefully in his arms.

Beside him the doctor was tucking Mydei’s coreflame back in beside Hephaestion who was out cold, sleeping heavily. If not for the very slow rise and fall of his chest, Phainon may have assumed the worst.

He carried the little girl past the working crew. It was still very late; dawn had not yet begun to paint the sky. Black smoke would've hidden the rosy and lavender hues anyway. Across the sound their island still burned and glowed but the sea beneath them had yet to turn murky. The Tide would take some time to chew through the settlement before it came to crash against the mainland. It gave them time to rest.

Half the crew were sleeping, the other half were loading the Chryseus Leo for the journey to Okhema, moving quietly so as not to disturb the others. Down the ramp it was a similar story. The Kremnoans were trying to organize, letting as many people sleep as could be spared while others packed carts, packs, and struggled to take inventory. The heaviest items were loaded into two different trains of carts to be pulled by two of four dromas. The long-necked gentle giants were dozing in their harnesses, grumbling softly as they awaited the morn.

Phainon scanned through piles of supplies, sleeping people, and hurried runners in the dark trying to find someone he recognized when he heard his name.

"Deliverer," Krateros greeted once more as he approached.

"Krateros."

"We are very nearly finished here and should depart with haste."

Phainon pulled the blanket back to show Krateros Chironome, and the old man's harsh gaze immediately melted. He leaned in to put his hand on her forehead; to pet the child ever so gently the way a doting grandfather might fawn over their first grandchild.

"And who have you brought to me today?" he asked in a slightly higher pitch and Phainon tilted his head in confusion at the question. Krateros made it sound like this was a habit of his to scoop up small children or other critters to present to the man for approval.

"Her name is Chironome," Phainon whispered, "Ptolemy was supposed to find her parents amongst the evacuated. Have you seen him?"

"He was speaking to Daidolos when last I saw him." Krateros' brows pinched and his tone turned serious once more. He scratched absentmindedly as his beard before saying, "I recall one of the crew mentioning a newborn daughter named Chironome. This was many years ago when we left Castrum Kremnos after Eurypon's death."

"Five years ago," Phainon observed, "she told us she was five years old."

"Pray that I am wrong," Krateros lamented, "He was one of those that gave their lives a week ago when we retrieved the coreflame."

Phainon winced. "A mother then?"

Krateros contemplated that and then motioned for Phainon to follow without answering. He must not have known. Despite Phainon's best efforts to bond with every crewmate there were a sizeable number of them that kept their port lives private, something that the others respected without judgement.

They walked swiftly over uneven ground. The beach gave way quickly to jagged rocks and then to uneven plains, where many were resting. That was where they found Ptolemy, still talking to Daidolos. He greeted them with a wave and then they quieted when they saw Chironome.

“Ptolemy did you-?”

“Yes, and it’s not good news.”

Phainon rubbed the little girl’s arm with his thumb, a gentle back and forth to offer comfort that she was too asleep to realize she needed.

“Her father was Militiades,” he reported and Phainon recognized the name from the list of those they lost in their return to Castrum Kremnos. “And her mother was on duty tonight in the northern guard towers, she didn’t make it.”

His heart dropped at the news. This little girl was going to wake an orphan.

“She was left alone? Does she have any other family? A neighbor?” he asked.

Ptolemy shook his head. “Her mother was working short shifts, leaving after her child was put to bed and returning before she woke.”

“My lords, with respect, I can take her for now,” Daidolos offered, “I know this child. Chironome has been attending classes at the arena for over a year now. She will recognize me as her teacher, and I can care of her until we find a family or unit that will take her.”

“A unit? She’s so young to already be learning to fight,” Phainon wondered aloud before remembering how different Kremnoans were. Ptolemy was the one that told him Kremnoans began learning how to fight from the moment they could hold a spear.

“This is no strange thing,” Krateros confirmed what he had already recalled, “Kremnoan children are stronger than most, it is important to begin training them as early as possible to refine that strength and courage.”

Chironome stirred in his arms, blinking her eyes and squirming to get closer to Phainon. He bounced her a little, swaying gently before holding her out to Daidolos who stepped forward to take her in his strong arms.

The change was immediate. She whimpered once and then shouted at Daidolos, something in sleepy nonsense speech. Chironome fussed and fought to get free, reaching for Phainon again. Her toy sword fell on the ground as she kicked and protested. Phainon bent down to fetch it while she finished waking up enough to realize she recognized the man holding her now and settled into an irritable stew while she babbled sleepily.

“You cannot go with him,” Daidolos said firmly, switching to Kremnoan.

More mumbles, urgent, stressed, and insistent.

“He does not need your help.”

Chironome didn't cry but her bottom lip stuck out and her whole body started to shake like she wanted to weep and simply couldn't. When the pouting didn't work, she tried to hit Daidolos who caught her wrist and held it tightly the entire way to the cart nearby. He set her inside and scolded her, more like a drill sergeant than a father. It had Phainon second guessing his decision, but Krateros and Ptolemy didn't seem bothered and it wasn't his place to try and change their culture.

Phainon walked up to the cart and peered over the edge to where Chironome was sitting with her knees pulled up to her chest and her arms wrapped around her legs. The shirt looked even bigger with her curled up so tightly, head down, hair splayed wildly over her knees while she sulked. The blanket pooled around her, bunched up around her back where it fell.

"Chironome," he called gently, and she looked up with a tiny gasp and hurried to her feet so she could wrap her arms around his neck, hugging him so tightly he was sure that she would hang from him above the ground if he pulled away now.

She baby talked at him, something like, "I don't want to go, Fine."

He gently reached up and pried one of her hands away so he could hand her the sword. "You have to protect them," he tried to say, and it was hard to tell if he said it correctly because she smacked him in the head lightly with the sword and then leaned forward to press her forehead to his.

Phainon wasn't sure if she really understood the Kremnoan farewell or if she was mimicking what she had seen adults do. Chironome could have simply been tired and wanted that physical connection. With one of her hands holding the sword, there was only one left to cling to the high collar of his shirt.

The last time he had done this was with Mydeimos. There were things he didn't say back then, things he wanted to say, needed to say, and just didn't have the time.

He very carefully pried the other little hand away and stepped back before she could grab him again. She reached, leaning over the side of the cart and called for him with increasing panic that hurt to hear. Daidolos reached out a massive hand to block her from Phainon, before she could leap from the cart and potentially hurt herself.

Upset, she threw her sword, and it clipped Phainon's shoulder hard enough to bruise before it clattered to the ground, sticking in a patch of sand before the weight of the hilt flattened it in the grass.

"Chironome…" Phainon sighed. He again crouched down to retrieve the weapon but when he stepped forward she had already turned away to pout, yelling between her fingers.

Phainon looked at Ptolemy who politely relayed, "she says she doesn't want it anymore."

"Okay," he said softly, turning to look at the top of her head. The rest of her had sunk back into the cart to be angry on her own. "Then I'll keep it until she's ready again."

“’The blade itself incites to deeds of violence,’” Ptolemy quoted as he watched Phainon tuck the toy into his belt as though it was a holy weapon. “I am sure she will find another when the time comes, but this is a time for tools of rebuilding rather than conquest, I suppose.”

There was a solemn silence between the men for a breath at that thought and then Phainon turned to Daidolos with last minute reminders. “Keep moving inland, as far from the coastline as you can get until everyone is inside the range of the Dawn Device. Don’t go all the way to Okhema. I will send a messenger when it’s safe to send representation to the city.”

“All will be well, Lord Phainon. We have Ptolemy’s maps to guide us.” They clasped arms and nodded to each other, not quite a formal farewell.

With Chironome’s dry sobs and the soft chirp of a nymph in his ears, Phainon turned and led the way back to the ship.

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Phainon stood in Mydei’s spot with his torn armor in hand, still damaged from the fight with Nikador. The break in the metal pauldron would need a smith to repair, a very skilled one too. These pieces had been crafted by Chartonus, Okhema’s Master Smith. His skill could only be rivaled by the Kremnoan masters and what few of them remained were lost in the wilderness, several days of sailing behind them. The coat, also torn was thrown over the railing, leaving Phainon in his favorite shirt while he pondered the best way to fix what was broken. And no, he wasn’t just considering his clothing.

When confronted, Phainon was cheerful, albeit a little short. He was sleeping alright and still putting his best foot forward, but his thoughts drifted regularly to Mydei, still fighting, still dying, and, on occasion, to a little girl with no parents who had been the essence of courage and care in the face of overwhelming loss.

“Captain,” Krateros said behind him and Phainon glanced over his shoulder.

“Is something the matter, Krateros?”

“Ever since we left the young Prince behind you have seemed less yourself.”

Phainon tilted his head and turned more fully to the man. “…are you worried about me?”

“Do not misunderstand, I prefer this version of you to the carefree puppy that once wreaked havoc on this ship,” the old man admitted.

“Then why the concern?”

“Is it not my duty to tend to the needs of my captain? Perhaps you would prefer another first mate?” he huffed.

Phainon waved a hand back and forth in front of himself and put the pauldron on a crate beside the railing to give the old mentor more of the attention he deserved. “Of course not, Krateros, I value your input. What would you like me to do?”

“When Mydeimos became stagnant his mood would be diminished. I have not seen you practice your spear work since before we retrieved the Coreflame of Strife.”

“…you want me to practice my spear forms?” Phainon asked for clarification and Krateros sighed so deeply and so loudly with such a slump of his shoulders that Phainon immediately felt bad for whatever transgression he had committed in misunderstanding.

“I am inviting you to spar.”

He really didn’t mean to laugh but the words were so surprising that Phainon let out two soft barks before he realized Krateros was serious. “With *you*?”

The old man crossed his arms and turned his nose up to hide his wounded pride. His armor creaked as he did so, his sword was in the armory, but the decorative straps at his belt still swayed and light glinted off the clasp of his chlamys.

“Is it so difficult to believe that I am an accomplished warrior? For all your battle prowess, captain, my experience is many times that of your own.”

“I do not doubt that Krateros,” Phainon insisted, trying not to be condescending, “but I have only seen you command the others. I had assumed that your combat days were behind you.”

Krateros snorted. “My combat days will be behind me when my corpse is cooling on the battlefield.”

Phainon wanted to vocalize a wish otherwise, but the Kremnoan would probably take it as an insult and this peace between them had been nice. He didn’t want to shatter it by saying something so insensitive, which also meant the only right answer to the challenge was ‘yes.’ Anything less could be deeply offensive.

“Alright, Krateros, show me the right way to wield a spear,” Phainon ordered, and the man seemed pleased. The exercise would do him good. Even if it was just simple forms or a relaxed spar. Phainon had every intention of going easy on the old man, using the fight as a chance to practice his restraint, something that had felt a little harder to hold onto since losing Mydei.

The old man was prepared and walked only a short distance away to fetch two spears and two shields from where they rested against the railing. The upper deck was as good of a place as any for them to face each other. It was where Phainon and Mydei had spared most frequently and in the early days of Phainon’s stay, was where he had seen Mydei train with Hephaestion.

He caught the spear as it was tossed to him and twirled it experimentally to get a firm grasp of how the weight was balanced and what the weapon felt like when it moved. Daidolos’ lessons of the basics started to zoom through the forefront of Phainon’s memories as he adjusted his grip and opted to forego stretching. It was unlikely he would need it.

Krateros started to toss him a shield too but stopped at the beginning of his swing when Phainon held up a hand.

“I won’t need it,” he said confidently and Krateros raised one eyebrow.

“The spear is only one half of the weapon, the other is the shield,” he scolded, offering it again.

Still Phainon declined. “I will not need it to focus on my form.”

Krateros set the disc aside and put his own shield on his arm, tightening the straps with practiced ease. It fit perfectly, round and small and very old. The same way the younger crew had favored weapons, arms crafted for them that they had come to learn as an extension of themselves, the older crew had favored shields. The old guard had *broken* more weapons than Phainon had ever handled in his entire lifetime and through experience had come to appreciate the symbolism and reliability of defense. This was the same shield that Krateros had carried in Eurypon’s campaigns, when the old man had overseen the line against Okhema. Phainon distinctly remembered it from when he lost the fishing bet and had to shine all the shields in the armory. The task had become infinitely more pleasant when his appraiser’s eye realized the age, value, and craftsmanship of the shields of the old guard.

To stand across from it now…

Phainon felt the familiar tingle of excitement that preceded a fight. It would be both an honor and a horrible shame to be the one to break the relic.

“Very well,” Krateros replied calmly. When he was ready, he stood in front of Phainon with the shield held lightly in front of his belly and his spear pointed down. “Whenever you are ready, captain.”

Phainon started to pace around Krateros, surprised when the old man did not also begin pacing. Where Mydeimos would have mimicked his footwork to find an opening, Krateros did not. Instead, the veteran held still, tracking Phainon with his eyes, even when Phainon paced to Krateros’ left where his eyesight was the weakest.

It was then that Phainon experimentally lunged, jabbing at the space above the shield. The weak attack was effortlessly blocked and a very sharp point dragged across Phainon’s side, tearing his shirt and ghosting lightly over his skin, enough to be felt, but not enough to draw blood.

He bounced back and patted at the tear, looking for gold and finding only that shallow scratch. At first Phainon snorted to himself, praising his luck, but then he realized how little of a role luck had played at all. Krateros had struck with surgical precision and *chosen* not to punish his arrogance.

“I expected more from Mydeimos’ chosen,” Krateros lamented.

The corner of Phainon’s mouth twitched and he rushed in a little faster, swiping up as though the spear were his greatsword. The shaft clashed against the man’s own weapon and then Krateros’ spear dipped, spinning around his own in a way that forced a painful twist of his grip until the weapon pulled free entirely. It clattered on the deck and Phainon dove to retrieve it, but a heavy boot kept it pinned and sharp bronze tapped the side of his neck.

Frozen in his crouch, Phainon looked up into disappointed eyes. Krateros had the bearing of a demanding but patient father trying to coax greatness from a failing son. It made fury and fear rise in Phainon's belly and chest. Fury at being looked down upon when he had already accumulated noble feats, not the least of which was the conquer of Nikador, and fear that perhaps Krateros was right.

"Do you think me fragile, Deliverer?" Krateros taunted. He pulled the spear away from the flutter under Phainon's collar and moved his foot. Slowly Phainon stood back up with his own spear in hand. "Have you forgotten who trained the Crown Prince? Who trained the crew? I can feel in your pathetic attack the hubris of a foolish youth who judges only the surface of a man."

Those two feelings combined in Phainon's throat into humility, and he nodded. Taking those words to heart. This time when he lunged it was with the respect that Krateros deserved and a feint to Krateros' left, to force the man to move his shield and create an opening. The veteran called Phainon's bluff, and the shield deflected the blow meant for Krateros' shoulder.

Still Phainon pushed, utilizing the momentum to follow the swing, treating the spear more as a lance, a style closer to the sword he was more familiar with. Krateros followed the momentum too, finally moving from his rooted stance to chase the spear rather than breaking upon it when the arc carried the blade around again. Exposed, Phainon got a close look at that legendary shield when it slammed into his face and sent him staggering.

Krateros did not allow Phainon to recover and a swipe at the Okheman's legs had Phainon jumping right into that shield once more. To his credit, he did not fall when he stumbled, and when Krateros pushed again, he dodged every pointed jab in his retreat. The shield came around again and Phainon leaped backwards, he rolled towards the rail to give himself some space and to retrieve the shield he had originally declined.

"Better," Krateros praised. The old man was smiling now too and Phainon caught a glimpse of the past in those aging bones. A lion does not lose his regality in his old age. When his ribs begin to show and his mane clings to him in patches, he still carries himself with the grace of majesty and a survivor's heart. He is as deserving of admiration as the young lion that rises to take his place.

Properly armed, their clashes no longer felt quite as one-sided, but Phainon still failed to draw blood and the longer they fought under the harsh sun the more Phainon felt like the mouse trapped between paws. Every advantage he thought he had was met by experience until he found himself thinking more than relying on instinct.

Where fighting against and beside Mydeimos was a dance that Phainon felt in his soul and heart, Krateros was a puzzle to be solved. The veteran not only knew how to move with the flow of battle, but he also knew how to direct and command it. Phainon found himself needing to think multiple steps ahead to find openings that Krateros was deliberately leaving him, subtly encouraging learning until every other clouding thought fell away into nothing.

There was no room for Phainon to worry over things in the future or the past, all that mattered was solving this pattern that Krateros was weaving for him in the moment and processing the subtle corrections. Somehow, Krateros was able to defend, attack, and still

find the time to use the butt of his spear to correct Phainon's form, leaving little bruises on his ankles and wrists, even through his boots and bracers.

But for every humiliating strike, Phainon was also blessed with praise whenever he did something noteworthy from a particularly powerful, well executed jab to a rolling block, to even the use of his surroundings when he made use of the railing during a vigorous part of their bout. In this way Krateros was cultivating the good while removing the bad and doing so amid practical application. Where Daidolos would have had Phainon stop to discuss his form, Krateros simply let the man make mistakes and see the results of those mistakes as they happened to give feedback in real time.

It was exactly what Phainon had imagined training in Castrum Kremnos would be like when he read of the warrior city in his books as a child. The surge of excitement when he realized how true this was, that not only was he standing in the presence of a master, but Krateros was training him in a way that only future Kings would have been trained. This was the same way Mydei had learned, had become the warrior that made Phainon's heart sing. It was arguably the highest honor that Phainon had received from Krateros, more so even than the veteran's deference the day he had become the interim captain. So, when the Okheman finally dropped to one knee, exhausted, it was under the weight of that humility and gratitude.

Krateros spun his spear and tapped the butt of the weapon against the deck twice, a signal that Phainon did not yet know but from context concluded it meant the end of their training. The old man had a shine to his skin, but sweat did not bead along his brow, nor did he collapse with exhaustion. He simply moved his spear and shield to one hand so he could offer the other to Phainon.

Sweat dripped off Phainon's nose and onto the deck when he took that hand and let himself accept the help to stand once more. The old man roughly smacked Phainon's arm and laughed, the first *real* laugh that Phainon had ever heard from him.

"There may be hope for you yet, Okheman," he praised, the title feeling affectionate, and then he walked to the railing to set his weapons aside for the time being.

Phainon followed him on shaky legs, somewhat bewildered by the man's endurance. As soon as he set his own spear and shield beside the others, he collapsed to sit on the heavy lid of the bins that held their fishing supplies.

"How…?" he managed to squeak out around heavy breaths.

"I learned in my second tour the value of conserving energy and stamina," Krateros explained, "no movement in combat should be wasted."

The old man sat beside Phainon and held out his hand palm facing them so Phainon could see the subtle quiver there. It was in his knees as well, proof of exertion that Phainon took as a compliment even if it did not match his own notably worse state.

"You are on the heels of emotional exhaustion and injury as well," Krateros reminded him.

"I didn't just lose my home again," Phainon said gently. There was a question there.

Krateros frowned and leaned back, he patted along the bench until he found a waterskin and after a short drink he offered it to Phainon as well. “I am not unaffected by emotional duress,” he admitted, “as I am sure you know from past experience.”

Phainon recalled the moment he returned without Mydei, how ready Krateros was to lash out and take his life in his grief. He remembered too the haste at which Krateros moved to act on his distrust and anger many times in that month of sailing before they found mutual acceptance.

“I admit that I am prone to emotional outbursts,” Krateros continued, “and I too miss Mydeimos with my entire being. To see what Kremnos has become, after witnessing her glory with my own eyes in days long past…” he trailed off but aside from a distant look, there was no sign of grieving. “Resilience comes with age and experience. It takes time to build and may falter in those moments of intense and unexpected duress, but it holds truest in the service of my brothers and sisters.”

“…that’s why you won’t take command,” Phainon realized aloud.

“I am at my very best in the service of the crown to which I have sworn the greatest of oaths, when I have left behind my own wishes in the ship’s wake.”

Phainon thought about that and then he started to laugh. It was a weak thing, exhaustion still weighing on him after an excellent fight. He stopped when Krateros’ annoyance had turned into a face of deep concern lest the veteran believe him to be a mad man.

“I’m sorry, Krateros, I just think it’s funny,” Phainon explained, “of all the people on this ship that I thought I would never be able to please, never be able to understand… Aside from Mydeimos, how is it that you are the one with whom I am the most alike?”

Krateros’ concern fell, turning more contemplative.

Phainon offered the waterskin to him and he took it, taking another drink. They passed it back and forth until it was empty and then they simply enjoyed the sounds of the sea in comfortable silence with their heads resting back against the smooth railing.

“Krateros,” Phainon said and was met with a gentle hum. “These new railings need stories to tell.”

“So they do, captain.”

“Will you teach me?”

“To tell stories?”

“To carve them,” Phainon specified.

Krateros paused, surprised that Phainon remembered from a passing comment that the old man was familiar with woodworking and carving. After a moment of consideration he grunted and said, “it would be easier to teach you to use a carving knife than a spear, hopeless as you are.”

Phainon chuckled, “I hope so, Lord Krateros. There are too many stories that need to be told.”

Chapter 32: An Aria to Kephale

Chapter Summary

No new tags

Phainon tells Okhema a story

Chapter Notes

My cat made every effort to keep this chapter from happening. After that week long vacation she has been unbearably clingy

Happy FFXIV patch day to all who celebrate~ And heck that floor 99 boss~

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon wore every piece of his armor, even with the metal torn and the fine stitching in his cape ripped. The wear of a well-traveled journey was the only part of him that went unpolished and it was by far the most honest. Castorice and Hyacine helped him with his hair and washing his face, Anaxa went over talking points, and Peucesta helped him wash the salt and grime from his clothing to make him more presentable. When Phainon approached the gates of Okhema from the dromas road to the Path of Parting, unarmed and alone, it was with the bearing of one who had walked the world and found therein a glorious and heavy purpose.

“Are you sure you don’t want us to go with you?” Hyacine asked for the fourth time.

“Not until I know it’s safe.”

Ptolemy waved his hand dismissively. “We told that lion we were kidnapping the Heirs, they have no reason to be suspect.”

“Caenis is smarter than that,” Phainon reminded them, “if it were true, what’s to stop Castorice from freeing herself with the Hand of Death?”

The coreflame was wrapped in fine fabric and tucked in a messenger bag over Phainon’s shoulder. He walked with one hand resting on top of it to keep that precious cargo from jostling. It still didn’t feel right carrying Mydei’s heart to the Holy City and away from its proper keeper.

The irony of this lonely march was not lost on Phainon, who had dreamed of this moment ever since Aglaea had begun training him to live it. How many times had he imagined himself walking along the golden road, clad in the garments of a noble hero with a shining sword on his back and an air of undeniable righteousness? He had pictured the blood of Titans on his boots and the light-headed joy of victory as he presented the fruits of his labor to Aglaea. Her lips would've curled in a genuine smile, and she would whisper words of praise, bringing honor to his vow to the Flame-Chase journey. And then he would bathe in the golden waters of the Marmoreal Palace, under the watchful gaze of Kephale and the comfort of a peace hard won to wash away the aches while feasting on figs and fine meats.

"If I don't return by Curtain-Fall Hour," Phainon told Krateros and the barely standing Hephaestion, "then flee."

"And leave you?"

"Yes," he ordered, "If that happens, Hephaestion, you'll be the captain."

Krateros' eyebrows raised and they shared a knowing look. He nodded politely in gratitude, and they clasped arms in farewell. "May triumph always be yours, Phainon."

How different this walk was from Phainon's dream. He was not a golden hero from storybooks, just a tired pirate, worn from the sun and salty sea spray. He did not return in glory, but pleading on his knees for a people that were now his own. The grand battle against the Titan had not been fought in picturesque temples with perfect results but paid for with the blood of good men in a place of sorrowful ruin. This coreflame was not to be given willingly, but with incredible pain and humility at the sacrifice and promise of the one who had surrendered it for love. Any bath he may be allowed would be to wash the stink of hard work, loss, and Tide from his skin, not the glitter of Titan blood. And this coreflame may serve Aglaea's Flame-Chase, but it was not Phainon's vow that bore it to her, but dire necessity for a proud people who were strong enough to endure when profound evil sought to devour their pride.

Phainon was still the Deliverer, but no longer Okhema's alone.

They saw him from a distance, as he made no attempt to hide and as recognizable as he was, Phainon was swiftly surrounded by a half dozen of Okhema's finest men in shining armor. He recognized several of them from his time in service to the guard. They had trained together, dreaming of epic battles and earned accolades. The messenger bag was taken from him at sword point, slung over the shoulder of one of the soldiers and Phainon had to fight the urge to forcibly reclaim it. But they did not open the bag, nor treat it with roughness and there was pain in their eyes as they reached for his offered wrists and bound them with manacles and chains. Phainon could see and feel the shaking in their hands as they carried out the justice they were sworn to uphold.

They muttered apologies and asked for answers as they paraded him through the streets to the wide eyes and whispered buzz of a troubled crowd. He offered them nothing aside from idle pleasantries and soft reassurances, a gentle smile still on his face to put the populace and his anxious friends at ease. A deal had not yet been struck and until his pardon was secured he was a pirate, a criminal that needed to be brought to justice. But that did not erase their

history, their respect, and confusion. Even in chains between them, Phainon knew these guards were deserving of kindness.

With nothing left to say, he kept his peace when they brought him through Marmoreal Palace to stand before the Goldweaver. They retreated then with soft and pleading expressions, putting his bag on the floor between himself and his fellow Chrysos Heir. For the first time since Phainon started his journey, he was alone with Aglaea. He did not fight his restraints or cow under the tickle of her threads as they reached for him. Phainon could feel them at his neck, his wrists, and his legs.

Aglaea was as unchanging and beautiful as the sky. Her office was still neat and tidy, organized without fault. Breakfast waited on her desk, barely touched aside from a suspicious, chimera sized bite from one of the cakes. The letter he had written for her was beside the plate and open to the world as though she had just been reading it. She was standing on her balcony with her back to him, looking over the waking city with a cup of tea in one hand and a little saucer in the other.

“To your credit,” she said, voice slow and sharp, “you did not lie to me in your letter.”

The smile he wore for the guards faded into something neutral and guarded. He swallowed stiffly and reassured her, “I have never lied to you, Lady Aglaea.”

“Because you never wanted to?” she challenged, “or because you couldn’t?”

Phainon said nothing, watching her at attention, head held high. She didn’t turn around, and he felt a little sad. After all this time, and she was so disappointed, Aglaea couldn’t bear to look at him.

“You said in your letter that when you returned it would be at the side of a man you had come to admire,” she said.

Phainon’s eyes flicked downward, and he clenched his fists to keep from shaking. The chains between his wrists clinked like heavy windchimes.

She let him stew in the thick silence for a moment and then turned to walk to her desk. Her dress flowed around her like morning mist, as light as her every step. The teacup settled on the saucer when she set it down, soundless when the fine ceramic met its match. Beside him a garmentmaker moved, floating in close to pick up the messenger bag to hand it to Aglaea directly and she in turn set it on her desk. With a sort of sad appreciation, she pulled the flap back and pushed away the suffocating wrap to free the Coreflame of Strife from its careful packaging.

“This was not the manner in which you intended to do so,” she observed and Phainon realized she *knew* that the Coreflame had already met its bearer.

“How long have you known?” he asked sourly.

“I was not sure until you entered the city,” she admitted. Her eyes settled on him, hazy and somehow piercing all the same. The yellow of them glowed through the emerald. “Did he

give it to you willingly?"

Another painful swallow. Another fight to hold his composure. "Yes."

Her long and perfect fingers hovered over the coreflame, appreciating its warmth before she gently covered it again.

"The coreflame is not a gift," Phainon told her firmly, "nor is it a fulfillment of my vow to you. It was given to me with purpose, and I will only surrender it if those needs are met."

"If it is within my power alone to give, you shall want for nothing," she promised.

Hopeful, he said, "the Coreflame of Strife is a peace offering from the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos, to be a physical manifestation of a permanent truce between nations." She didn't react so Phainon continued, "And with this peace, our new allies in Okhema will see fit to issue pardons, absolving the Kremnoan people, especially the crew of the Chryseus Leo, of their crimes under Okheman law."

"A clean slate for a crew of pirates," she stated.

"Yes."

"And the end of a centuries long war."

"Yes," Phainon insisted firmly.

"*Our* new allies in Okhema," Aglaea noted gently, "spoken like one who is outside of her beauty."

"Yes." He said it without hesitation, without faltering or looking away. He needed her to see how much he had changed since they had last met, that he was a better man in every way for his experiences, even if it may hurt her to see how far away from her side he now stood.

She raised a hand to her chest, pressing a delicate finger to the space below her throat, and closed her eyes. Aglaea was statuesque, elegant and crafted from fine marble by a master's hand to be the image of cold beauty. It was his hope, when she finally moved again, that it would be to grant his wish on behalf of the Kremnoan people, his people, but when she opened her eyes it was with predictable disappointment.

"You know such a wish is beyond my power alone to grant. For all my authority, I am not a monarch and Kephale's will is not mine alone to interpret."

Phainon sighed with the tiniest chuckle in the exhale. The Council of Elders would need to be swayed. "I expected as much."

"You must have quite the tale to tell, Phainon," she mused.

"It is an epic for the ages," he confirmed, "but there are many heroes in this story, and I am not one of them." Phainon lifted his bound hands just to let them fall again. The metal

complained with loud clanks when it was jostled. “I am the messenger who speaks on their behalf.”

The shadow of a smile passed over Aglaea’s features, so fleeting that Phainon worried he had imagined it. She put her hand over the messenger bag again and the Coreflame at rest there.

“How are Castorice and Hyacine?” she asked.

Phainon’s eyes narrowed just a hair. “They are well. This success belongs to them as well.”

“And you?” She asked with a tenderness that very nearly spoke of emotions that the Goldweaver may have once had, that remained in minute amounts buried deep within her.

“I am well,” he said with equal softness and the golden threads between them trembled.

“If you could do it again,” Aglaea wondered aloud, but she changed her mind before finishing the question and instead shook her head and asked, “Was it worth it?”

Phainon thought of a burning island, a displaced people, of countless injuries, and a surging Tide. He remembered the crew of the Sol and the sobs of a widow living in this very city, of his divisive presence tearing apart a crew that sailed as a family. His mind wandered to thoughts of a naval outpost, looted, with the bodies set aside unburied, of a Crown Prince left behind in desolation with the dead he had once sailed beside.

And then he thought of warm nights with good food and a happy crew listening to Peucesta’s tales whiles they taught Phainon the language of another world beside his tiny corner of existence. Good men told him stories, competed with him, filled him with courage and curiosity, sharing their culture with him and inviting him to explore alongside them as a part of their family. He thought of the blood shed between comrades fighting the Tide, trust built during a storm, a child’s compassion in a time of loss, and a hurried kiss. Phainon thought of Mydei, the crew, and the hopes that they had entrusted to him, a hope for peace that they had never considered possible before now. A peace that he would secure with a story, the kind that bards would immortalize in song beside those of the Titans. As they should, because if any people deserved to have their story told it was the Kremnoan Detachment and the Chryseos Leo.

“Yes. Without question.”

Her nod was subtle, but the bounce of her perfect curls was not. “Though they move with glacial stillness on the best of days, the Council of Elders wishes to convene this afternoon to try you. Political theater at its finest. They are eager to use your arrest to sway the people against the Flame-Chase and have already begun to invite the entirety of Okhema to witness.”

“Will I be given the chance to speak?” he asked her.

“Yes.” The smile was back, this time with a glimmer of mischief. “Will you tell your story to the people?”

“With pleasure.”

-

Phainon was taken by the Council’s guard shortly thereafter. Aglaea kept the Coreflame despite their insistence it be taken to the Council, but she refused to part with it until such time as it could be presented during Phainon’s trial. Even on opposing sides, Phainon was grateful for her intervention. If the guards had taken it he wasn’t sure he’d ever see it again.

They took him directly to Dawncloud from the Marmoreal Palace, marching him through the Sacred Path with noisy stomps and a mountain dweller escort to draw attention from the elders and scholars that studied there. The guards at each arm pulled and pushed at Phainon to keep him off balance to instill in him a sense of shame but every time he stumbled, the pirate rose again with a gentle smile and his head held high. When the citizenry stared, he pleasantly waved back, treating this parade as an opportunity to instill in everyone a sense of curiosity.

Come! He said with his smile and gentle nods. Come and listen to a tale that will shake the foundation of Okhema! Come and hear the words of the Deliverer turned pirate as he faces judgement under Kephale! Come and see the beloved Chrysos Heir of Aglaea, the man of the people, the hero of epics, beg on his knees for forgiveness!

He was kept in a small enclosure to wait, just barely tall enough for him to stand and wide enough for him to sit with his legs fully extended no matter which wall Phainon leaned against. The cell on the Chryseus Leo was only a pace larger and when he considered his first bed on the ship, Phainon didn’t feel so cramped, rather he smiled at the fond memories of meeting Fig Stew, making a deal with Mydei, and even that cold morning when Leonnius dragged him from the safety of the bars to fish.

He ignored the taunts of the Council’s men, and the curious looks of passing people that could see him from the hallway. Phainon was not *hidden* by any means, no, Caenis wouldn’t miss the chance to humiliate him before they could put the man on Trial. At least his cage was not in the center of the walkway where he could be openly mocked but Phainon was quite alright with the opportunity to watch the populace as they went about their day.

Okhema was truly a beacon of light, clean and beautiful, the city itself a temple to Kephale. Dawncloud especially, was the district closest to the Titan, built underneath the god where they bent under the weight of the Dawn Device. Dawncloud extended to the mountains at Kephale’s feet reaching the peaks where the Worldbearing Altar rested beneath their giant, silent face. It encompassed this place of learning where Phainon was now kept and it was the home of the Demigod Council, an amphitheater laid out like an arena not for combat but for words. It lay perched on a giant basin, a lake surrounded by giant torches where facsimiles of the coreflames glowed.

It was there that the guards brought Phainon, two quints past the Action Hour to face the Council of Elders and the whole of Okhema under Kephale. In the forecourt, across the wide bridge to the center of the arena, they removed his chains and gave him a moment to collect himself.

“Snowy!” called a playful voice and Phainon’s day immediately brightened.

“Lady Tribbie,” he greeted cheerfully while he rubbed his wrists, “what are you doing here?”

“Agy asked us to bring the coreflame,” she explained from a few steps above him on the stairs. He didn’t see the bag with her.

“Trianne and Trinnon are here as well?”

“Yes, we are waiting but we wanted to see you before,” she explained, “because we missed you and we worry about you.”

His heart softened and he held a hand to his chest. “I have missed you too, Tribbie, but I am also excited to share a story with Okhema and with you.”

“They are ready for you, Snowy,” she said after a slight pause.

“Well then, I better not keep the world waiting.” His voice was light and confident, buoyed by the strength of many others.

She reached out her hand for his and held it the entire way up the stairs, floating along so he wouldn’t have to crouch while they walked. Tribbie left him at the edge of the arena to fly away to the stands, presumably to meet up with her sisters and Aglaea.

“…proof that Lady Goldweaver’s Flame-Chase experiment has failed,” Caenis was saying to the crowd, “if her chosen hero, the *Deliverer* of Okhema as she calls him, could stoop so low as to ally with pirates and engage in piracy against his own people! Today justice will be done against this heretic that dares raise his blade against the Holy City!”

Oh, this was more than an indictment, he realized. Aglaea hadn’t been kidding, Caenis intended to deal with him now entirely.

“You finally deign to grace us with your presence, *Deliverer*,” she taunted as though she hadn’t been the one who ordered him caged since the Entry Hour.

“Elder Caenis,” he greeted politely and stepped forward with a slight bow of his head. His opinion of Caenis was not positive, but if she wanted political theater, then she would get political theater.

“Behold the traitor,” she told the people with a flourished gesture his direction and stepped back to be more in line with the other Elders on the Council where they sat on the front row of the curved bench.

Phainon humbly moved more into the center so all could see him.

“Elder Caenis there is no need for grandstanding,” Elder Callictis cautioned before continuing, “Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, you have been arrested and brought to stand before this Council to be indicted and tried in compliance with an arrest warrant that was issued on the order of this Council after evidence of your wrongdoing was presented and reviewed. It is

the wish of this Council that we proceed directly to trial while this Council is convened today. Have you any objections or statements you would like to make at this time?"

"I have no objections but would make a humble request," he said, loud enough for people to hear him. "I will willingly submit to the judgement of this Council but only after I am given the opportunity to speak at length regarding my time away from Okhema and of the noble task which was entrusted to me."

Caenis narrowed her eyes suspiciously while the Council leaned in to discuss among themselves. After a short moment they leaned away and turned their attention back to him.

"This is permissible as part of your testimony. We will henceforth commence the Trial of Phainon of Aedes Elysiae. Elder Caenis, if you would," Elder Diogena invited.

Caenis raised her voice to announce, "Phainon you stand accused of depredation, acts of violence against Okhema and her people, destruction of property, kidnapping, and treason against the Holy City. Do you deny these accusations?"

"I do not."

The crowd did not expect that, and whispered confusion rippled through the crowd, a low buzz of many voices that kept clear phrases from coming through. Phainon paid them no mind.

"Then you confess?" Caenis prodded with a widening smile.

"Not to every accusation," he specified, "I am not a traitor to Okhema, but yes, I am a pirate, and it is because of that allegiance that I am able to bring this Holy City that I love mixed tidings."

"Settle down!" Elder Callictis called to the crowd. He waited for the din to quiet before he addressed Phainon, "confessing to being a pirate *is* treason in the eyes of Kephale. Would you like to retract your statement?"

"No," he said firmly, "but I plead with the Council, not for my sake, but for the sake of Okhema to allow me the opportunity to explain what I have seen in my capacity as a pirate on distant seas."

Caenis opened her mouth to say something, but Elder Diogena spoke instead, "Make your case, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae."

"Then allow me noble brothers and sisters to tell you a story worthy of Kephale." Phainon took a breath, then he began to reveal to them the truth, beginning with his commission from Agalea and as he spoke he walked in a slow circle so that it was clear he spoke to the people, not the Council. He told them about his own trepidation when he received the call and the horrors of pursuing pirates across the sea. Phainon spoke highly of the crew, who were invaluable in tracking the pirate ship across the ocean beyond the reach of the Dawn Device and their courage in the face of the destruction they had witnessed.

“When I first laid eyes on that ship with red sails I knew we had found our mark. It was before the Entry Hour and Aquila’s eyes were closed beyond the Dawn Device. These pirates were turning to flee when we approached at speed, leaving behind a merchant ship, recently plundered. Hopeful to aid any survivors, I ordered my men to approach the burning ship and jumped across to search for any who survived this brutal attack.” He held a hand to his chest and paused. “It was the last time I saw my crew alive.”

He spoke from his heart as he described how helpless he felt in the hold, listening to the tearing of the ship’s hull, the screams from above as ink slowly swallowed the merchant ship and the Sol. He relayed how he was the only survivor pulled from the water by the pirates who had sent these two vessels to the depths, where he fought for his freedom and for vengeance only to be stopped by a man of incredible strength and nobility.

“The truth of what transpired that night came during the Entry Hour when I spoke at last to the Captain of this pirate crew. He was a man of harsh words and harsher means but honest and honorable. Perhaps you, my fellow Okhemans, would consider it strange to hear me refer to a pirate in such a way, but I choose my words because they are true and to speak otherwise would diminish the character of one who I now call my friend.”

The crowd murmured but Phainon paid them little mind.

“He told me of what I did not know and opened my eyes to a truth that Okhema has learned and then denied, that there is a *need* for pirates on the sea, for such men are the first line of defense against the greatest antagonistic force to poison Amphoreus, the Black Tide.”

Shouting and angry words were thrown in his direction, the crowd refused to believe him.

“I know! For I too struggled to believe that the Tide had reached so far and that *pirates* were hunting those monsters! But if I had known, if I had not willingly forgotten the Tide as a distant enemy, then my crew would still be alive, for when they fell to the blades of the pirate crew, they were no longer themselves but beasts, howling in pain.

“Thus began my time aboard a pirate ship, captive in name only for they accepted me and taught me and through them I learned not only of the threat that ever creeps through the seas but truths that have been denied the people of Okhema, truths of an enemy that haunts our recent history, Castrum Kremnos.”

The mumbling began in earnest and the crowd shuffled fearfully, still he raised his voice and spoke through their fear.

“The pirates that we have been taught to abhor are no brigands, they are Kremnoan, and they care nothing for our ongoing war, but act as protectors of their own people and the innocent alike. While they do not shy from bloodshed, every action is with purpose in defense of a greater good that Okhema has not been able to see, beginning five years ago, when, by the hand of their Captain, Crown Prince Mydeimos the Undying, Inheritor of Strife, that King Eurypon was slain.”

Phainon looked Caenis in the eye as he said it and saw the truth of it there. They knew. The Council knew and kept the truth hidden for mysterious, unknown ends.

“Lies!” someone yelled, and the chant began until the Council called for order once more.

“If it pleases the Council,” Aglaea offered smoothly behind them, loud enough for others to hear, “I may attest to the truthfulness of his story thus far.”

“There is no need, Lady Aglaea,” Caenis insisted, but the crowd’s chants grew in earnest, demanding that she use her threads to prove his words until the Council relented under the pressure.

The golden threads shimmered, visible to the crowd as Aglaea gave them form. They wrapped around Phainon’s hand when he offered it, palm up, and then bound him to the ground in a wide, circular array in the center of the Demigod Council.

“If he lies,” Aglaea told them, “then the threads will vibrate. Phainon, please repeat what you have said clearly and concisely.”

Emboldened, firm, and with his head held high he announced, “Crown Prince Mydeimos slew his father, King Eurypon of Castrum Kremnos five years ago. He sails as the Captain of the Chryseus Leo, a pirate ship, in defense of his people and all peoples of Amphoreus. He is not the enemy of Okhema.”

The string held firm and unmoving, and chaos erupted once more. This time the Council could not calm them as the implications of what Phainon had said passed through the shock.

So, he raised his voice instead and the arena slowly quieted to listen. “If you would lend me your ears once more, great people of this Holy City, I would tell you more of this story so you may know more of the allies that wait for you.”

And then he told them more. He told them nearly everything, laying his heart to bear as he recalled those gentle moments with each member of the crew. He told the people of Okhema about each of them in turn and how every interaction had shattered his preconceptions of them and what he had been taught to believe about their former enemies.

He told them about Ptolemy, a Kremnoan scholar who embodied the reason that so many of them believed their foe to be without. Kremnoan words spilled from his mouth as he demonstrated his learning and the patience of the bookworm, who treasured his history with such care that he chronicled the journeys of his people with his own hand with indifferent acknowledgement. This man who pursued knowledge and history with the fervor of any Grove Sage had been forbidden from visiting the Grove itself because he surely would’ve sunk the ship with the knowledge he longed to recover.

Phainon described for them Perdikkas and the honor that the doctor demonstrated in his every action. This man who could have let him die, an Okheman that was his enemy, but treated him fairly as one of his own at every turn. He told them about Perdikkas’ organization of his infirmary, the patience with which he kept his space clean, and the eagerness to learn what Phainon knew of medicine, as limited as it may be in the hopes it could improve his life-saving care. These were not men of needless violence, Perdikkas had taught, they were men of passion who had found their reason to live and to die.

From Leonnius, Phainon learned tenacity, not only in the face of physical trial, but in the face of grief and loss. He told the people of their fishing competition and the daily challenge that pushed him to improve and grow beyond his limitations. He told them of Leonnius as a voice of humor and honesty, pushing them through difficult times. Phainon recalled aloud the darkest moments of his voyage when he realized he was their captive and later when he learned of his warrant. He spoke to Leonnius' tenacious logic and humor to carry them forward always, never stagnant, always moving.

Phainon spoke to them of Peucesta's grace and quiet strength, the embodiment of courage during dark days. He told them how the man had once become tainted by the Tide, how he had recovered and found in himself new purpose, the courage to be kind. In a pale comparison to Peucesta's voice, Phainon sang to them the melody of the Tide, something that was only known because of his willingness to test a means to save them all at the risk of his own painful death. He emphasized that because of Peucesta, the Tide could now be survived and therein was a method to resist. Because of Peucesta and the hard work of others, Okheman sailors could brave polluted waters without fear.

He told them of Hephaestion, the last of the tenants of Strife, the embodiment of sacrifice. Not the sacrifice of the flesh that Kremnoans chased in their bloodthirsty pursuit, but the sacrifice of one's time and love. Phainon shared his first day working with Hephaestion, when he learned through example the value of respect for the ship. He recalled for them the conflict in the wake of his duel with Mydei, when Hephaestion stood between Phainon and Krateros to defend his enemy with Kremnoan blood. He told them of the assault on Castrum Kremnos, where Hephaestion almost lost his life and how willing he was to lay it again on the line to see his people safe from the Tide.

Phainon told them about Krateros. About how long it took the prickly old man to accept Phainon. How it took the approval of a chimera to finally win him over. He spoke of Krateros' stubbornness of his rigid belief that there could be no peace between Kremnos and Okhema. And then he told them how even that man's icy heart was melted by hope when Phainon, an enemy, and Krateros, emblematic of the old might of Castrum Kremnos, crossed spears not as bitter foes but as an old warrior and the rising generation.

Finally, he told them about Mydei. Phainon spoke about Mydei more than all the others because he was the perfect embodiment of Strife, Kremnoan in his entirety, not as their people were described to Okhemans, not as the old soldiers of the Holy City remembered from warring days, but as they were meant to be. He spoke at length about his time training with Mydei, sparring with him, learning of him, coming to understand his story, and all the while Phainon's prejudices were shattered on distant shoals. Mydei was no King, he refused to wear the crown, but still he led his dwindling people with fairness, kindness, and honorable strength.

He told the people of their conquests against the Tide as partners, as a crew. And he told them of the Settlement, of a people that had long abandoned their war with Okhema. Phainon's voice stayed loud and true so all could hear him as he told them of that fateful meeting in Mydei's house where they agreed to chase the Coreflame of Strife into a land unreachable. He expressed with earnest the way they longed to accomplish this task not because they wanted power, but because they cared and loved in a way that Okhema had not seen since

Kephale's sacrifice. And then he told them in detail about the Battle at Castrum Kremnos and the fall of a Titan, speaking to Mydei's composure in the face of Strife and then again, his resolute calm when the truth of Nikador's mission came to light.

Phainon held up his unbound hand and called Tribbie who flew to his side at his humble request with the messenger bag in hand.

"Lady Tribbie, if you would?" he asked gently, and she smiled at him and removed the Coreflame of Strife from the bag so everyone could see it. The collective gasp gave Phainon pause so everyone could appreciate what they were seeing.

"This Coreflame belongs to Crown Prince Mydeimos. He is its chosen bearer, the true Inheritor of Strife, and still he has parted with it and remains even now in the heart of Castrum Kremnos holding back the Tide," Phainon explained, his voice breaking for only a moment before he steeled his resolve. "This is the sacrifice of Castrum Kremnos! A man that could have power unrivaled, the means to claim victory for his people, chose instead to reject that power in favor of peace."

The threads held true, they did not waver once.

"This Coreflame of Strife is here to facilitate an exchange," Phainon said, "The end of a centuries long war between our peoples, the promise of peace and an alliance against the greater threat posed by the Black Tide, in exchange for the absolution of the Kremnoan people, including the charges of piracy."

The Council was watching with varying degrees of interest and Caenis scoffed. The people's responses seemed mixed. Many seemed undecided still trying to process earlier revelations, others were angry and yelled that Phainon demanded too much, others shouted that pardons were a small price to pay for peace.

"These golden threads are proof of the truth of my words!" Phainon reminded them all, but Caenis was not swayed.

"Is that all?" she mocked.

"No, I also would plead for the use of Okhema's Navy," Phainon said, "As newly realized allies, I beg for the strength to return to Castrum Kremnos, to rescue Mydeimos from his cruel Fate endlessly fighting the Tide. I would gladly submit myself to any punishment, pay for all my crimes as this Council deems fit, if this one wish would be granted."

Her laugh was a mixture of bark and cackle, loud enough to make the crowd uncomfortable and push them to silence. "And why would you agree to something like that?"

Phainon answered immediately, "Because I love him."

The golden threads held still.

Chapter End Notes

By now I'm sure some people have noticed but at the very beginning of the story I chose a tenant of Strife and assigned them to each of the Kremnoan 5. They have been embodiments of those traits from the very beginning~ :D

Chapter 33: The Trial of Phainon the Pirate

Chapter Summary

No new tags but mind the ones that are there. This was a heavy chapter

Phainon faces judgement at the hands of the Council of Elders

Chapter Notes

This fic is now in the top ten longest fics for this pairing in any language. I did not intend to do that. :')

I've seen an uptick of kudos and idk if people are just finding this fic by accident or if people are recommending it but if you are, thank you! It is a massive honor to have written something worthy of sharing.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Because I love him.

It wasn't what Phainon had intended to say but he made no effort to retract his statement, nor did he break into flustered giggles at the confession. This was the truth that Phainon had carried into this meeting, the answer to all things: love. What better place to announce it aside from shouting from the rooftops?

Beside him Tribbie held the Coreflame in both hands, looking up at him with the biggest smile. She held that precious piece of Mydei with the care he deserved and Phainon was all the more grateful for her presence by his side.

Caenis scoffed again and then laughed, "For you to have stooped so low. These are the words of a captive, brain washed by time and the exertions of his captors. The threads do not quiver because it is *his* truth, a truth that will not apply to Okhema."

Phainon's gentle demeanor shifted just a little towards anger. "Perhaps if the Lady Caenis had experienced love in her lifetime she would understand."

The crowd laughed and Caenis' scowl deepened.

"*If* the Kremnoans wanted peace, why did they not send a Kremnoan to barter for it? Why did they sneak into the Holy City and steal away the Chrysos Heirs?" she asked.

“Do you think so little of Castorice and Hyacine?” Phainon turned it around, “could the Hand of Death not choose to escape on her own?”

“Then the Heirs were complicit, traitors to the Holy City as you are.”

Phainon could tell from her voice that Caenis was planning on leveraging this against Aglaea. Maybe not today, but the Flame-Chase was on the chopping block on bad days, and he had given Caenis an edge. One step at a time.

“Again, I must insist that the acts of piracy that we have committed are not treason,” Phainon said, “and I *know* how that sounds, but please remember my story. Treason is malicious intent to destroy, to undermine, and we have done nothing to that end.”

“I heard your words, Lord Phainon,” Caenis said smoothly, “and the many confessions you have made therein.”

“And I *have* confessed,” he agreed, “to fighting to protect Okhema and people who needed me.”

“Kremnoans, enemies of Okhema.”

“*Good* people!”

“What you have done is illegal!”

“What I have done is *right!”*

“People of Okhema and my fellow Councilmembers,” Caenis continued, turning her back to Phainon, “Phainon pleads for forgiveness for crimes that he admits to committing and offers in exchange a trap for Okhema. What use do we have for a Coreflame? The already claimed Coreflame of *Strife* no less! Such a trinket matters only to Aglaea’s Flame-Chase which has consumed resources and lives for an idle collection while Okhema has enjoyed peace and prosperity without their influence. Even the Kremnoans have not dared to raise their blades against Okhema proper in *five year*s because of our strength. They can only manage these cowardly pirates that intercept our merchant ships, slaughter good Navy men, and raid our forts in distant waters. ‘The Black Tide did it,’ Phainon claims to justify his evil actions.”

He shook, annoyed. Even with the thread to prove his honesty, she refused to believe. Or perhaps she did and chose to sow these seeds of doubt. What Phainon brought in his truth was the means to shatter this illusion of perfection that the Council of Elders fought to preserve.

“Yet, there is good news in his story,” she teased, “The Kremnoan people are without leadership and weakened, no longer a threat. We have no need to call an end to this war in exchange for your pardon, because it has already ceased now that the warring brutes have cannibalized their own culture and people.”

“For the sake of *Okhema*, you cannot abandon them!” Phainon insisted.

“For *Okhema?*” she taunted.

“Yes! The threat of the Black Tide will not stop at the Dawn Device, not for long,” he passionately insisted, “I have heard its song and seen its face. The steady creeping that has claimed so many city-states before will come for Okhema and we need every ally, *especially* those with the strength and willingness to form an alliance to repel it.”

“How dare you speak such blasphemies against Kephale? To doubt the power of the Dawn Device, to doubt the strength of the Dawn Father…” she shook her head and tsked like she was scolding an animal.

“Kephale gives strength to those who seek strength,” Phainon said, fighting the growl. She wanted this rise out of him, to make him angry enough to appear rabid and frightening. “They never meant for us to become lazy and self-centered. Does their love not extend to every person that walks Amphoreus? Do you, Elder Caenis, dare to claim that they care only for Okhemans when nearly half this city is loved by refugees that have made her into the shining beacon on the hill? I have *witnessed* the strength of the Tide; it will break upon the Dawn Device and seep into the light if it is not stopped.”

Caenis didn’t falter, still on the attack, even mimicking his style of debate. “Did you not admit yourself to strengthening the Tide with your own actions? When you retrieved this Coreflame, did you not unleash a stronger Tide per your own admission? This rescue that you demand, trading Okheman lives to save a single man, the *Crown Prince* of our enemy, would that not increase the flow of this primordial force? Is it not better to leave the man as the dam? Okhema will be saved from the Black Tide, and our centuries long conflict will end if we simply do nothing but enjoy this peace we have built!”

“Mydei’s sacrifice slows the Tide, it does not stop it,” Phainon cautioned.

“Then he has bought Okhema another hundred years to contemplate a distant and minor threat.”

Caenis wasn’t going to budge. He knew that she would be the biggest obstacle coming into this, but the other members of the Council were more agreeable, and they had yet to offer their opinions. They very likely wouldn’t vocally weigh in as Caenis liked the sound of her own voice and would speak on their behalf, but she did not hold unilateral power, and the others could be convinced.

“I have come to you to offer peace, valuable allies, and an answer to a threat, and you respond with disdain, ignorant accusations, and closed-mindedness,” he huffed, “the people of Okhema will see the wisdom in my words and choose to step off this path of complacent destruction that you would have them follow.”

The Council leaned close to each other to whisper amongst themselves while the crowd grew restless where they were sitting. Phainon had already taken the better part of the hour to tell his story, a one man show for their entertainment while Caenis sowed seeds of doubt disguised as reason. The Coreflame of Strife wasn’t the only thing in his pocket he could offer but if Caenis rejected the first coreflame, there was little chance she would care for two. Anaxa was, thankfully, safe for now. He shifted his weight to ease the pain in his foot from standing still for so long.

“Order please,” Elder Etro demanded, and the crowd settled for the second act. “We have decided that the trial will continue. This discussion of your proposal is entwined with the charges brought against you; thus, we will announce our decision on both counts at the conclusion of these proceedings. Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, if you have finished your opening remarks, do you yield your time?”

“Yes, sir.”

“Then we will proceed to analyze the charges and give you the opportunity to defend yourself. Is this acceptable?”

“It is more than fair,” he agreed politely, though internally he seethed. It felt like they were deflecting, like they had already come to a decision about the Coreflame of Strife and this critical exchange. The people of Okhema and Kremnos needed this deal, accusations of piracy aside, pardons aside, they needed this guarantee of peace to move forward.

The threads around his palm warmed, comforting, and he felt them take away that emotional disturbance, filling him with peace to continue with clear-headed confidence.

“The kidnapping charges will be dropped,” Elder Callictis announced, “in light of recent confessions regarding the missing Chrysos Heirs. On the charges of depredation, acts of violence against Okhema and her people, destruction of property, and all other acts encompassed under the pirate flag, we will proceed to the indicting incident: the destruction of the Okheman Naval Base on the Pyrian Isles.”

Phainon remembered it. That was the first time he had seen the Chryseus Leo crew hide their identities as Kremnoan, the night where Phainon had stood at the crossroad and made the decision to stay with the crew to honor his agreement with Mydei. It was the first time he had been forced to confront the reality of what his capture entailed for both himself and the Kremnoan people. The first time he had to raise his blade against both sides to save them.

“Were you present when pirates attacked the fort?” the Elder asked.

“Yes.”

“Were you allied with the pirates?”

“No.” The thread stayed still and he continued, “At the time I was still a hostage. Mydeimos forbade me from leaving the ship.”

“Were you imprisoned?”

“No. I was ordered to stay behind but I was not confined,” Phainon explained.

“Then you willingly chose to engage in piracy?” Elder Caenis prodded.

“…yes,” he admitted, “but-“

“A confession!” she announced cutting him off, “he willingly chose to join the pirates in the sacking of an Okheman fort.”

Phainon took a deep breath to keep his composure, “I joined the fight on behalf of the Okheman troops. I did not personally engage in any destruction of property nor theft, but I did raise my sword to save lives. When Mydeimos and the crew attacked the fort they did so with the intent to chase the Navy from the island, to save them from the encroaching Black Tide.”

“The Black Tide again-“ Caenis huffed dramatically.

“It’s the truth. Mydei and the Kremnoans have been tracking its progress, studying it, to find a way to stop it.”

“Elders of the Council, if I may,” called a vaguely familiar voice from the populace. Phainon turned his head with the rest of the arena to see an older gentleman stand and step through the crowd. He waited patiently at the edge of the innermost bench to be acknowledged. The man looked different in the light, with dark brown short hair and matching eyes, clean and without the stress of combat but he looked familiar wearing the Okheman Navy uniform and a rich, bright blue chlamys to mark his rank. He raised a hand to his chest and the knotted scar through his palm gave him away before his words could.

For the sake of the crowd, the man raised his voice and announced, “I am Commander Hapries, though at the time I was Vice-Commander. It was my testimony of this attack that led to Lord Phainon’s indictment.”

Phainon’s eyes widened just a hair, and he barely kept his mouth from falling open. He had never expected to see this man again after that night. Mostly, he was relieved that the man had made it safely to Okhema after their parting.

“This Council recognizes Commander Hapries,” Caenis invited, “your report was invaluable.”

“And it was woefully misinformed,” Hapries declared. He stepped a pace closer, to be a part of the trial rather than left on the fringes. “When I gave my report to this Council it was from a narrow lens.” The man turned towards Phainon with sad eyes. “I am sorry Lord Phainon, it wasn’t until many weeks after I told them of your betrayal that I learned what you had done for us.”

Phainon smiled at him gently, trying to be reassuring, but kept his silence.

“What you *saw* was this man fighting against your own soldiers, *killing* them, and then choosing to follow the pirates when given the chance to flee!” Caenis reminded the officer, but he did not balk under her biting words.

“Not once did I say that Lord Phainon had killed any of my men,” he said firmly, “and I have brought with me soldiers that can testify to that truth, who were there at the battle until the last of us had fled.” Hapries turned and gestured behind him where three others stood to indicate their readiness to speak on Phainon’s behalf. “I did plead with Lord Phainon to run with us when we escaped, and I was confused and angry when the Deliverer of Okhema chose pirates that had killed our people over his own kin. But in the weeks that followed my testimony I have learned that the fort where we were stationed had been swallowed by the

Black Tide shortly after the fort was lost." Gasps rippled through the crowds. "Now that I have heard Lord Phainon's story, and the trials he underwent I believe I have a greater grasp on what transpired that night."

He looked to Phainon when he spoke next, searching for forgiveness, understanding, or both Phainon couldn't say but he gave this man his full attention as he told his story.

"I was a young soldier when Okhema last clashed with Kremnos, I know the strength and ferocity of Kremnoan warriors. They are disciplined, expert fighters. The man that drove a spear through my hand could have just as easily driven it through my chest, but he let me live to sound the retreat. At the time I believed him to be a cruel man, enjoying the pain he caused but as I have had time to reflect I know now that these Kremnoan pirates were willingly *restrained*.

"'Sound the retreat and my men will let you go,' he had said to me, and he spoke only truth. They only killed those brave soldiers that were determined to fight to their last and gave each of them every chance to flee. As a warrior, I know the desire to die on my own terms with a sword in my hand and if Phainon had not been there, I may have perished willingly with my men that night just as Commander Mityphon did. Those that died did so with honor and those that fled, their lives were *saved*. If these pirates, these Kremnoans, had not come to our station, we would not be here to speak on Lord Phainon's behalf."

Hapries paused to look at Phainon for some kind of confirmation that he was right. Phainon smiled and gave him a subtle nod, and the soldier returned the gesture. He turned on the Council with new confidence.

"That act of piracy saved our lives from the worst of fates," the soldier said firmly, and the crowd buzzed again at the implication.

"These *pirates* still stole Okheman property!" Caenis accused and Hapries waved his hand.

"Those goods would have been lost to the Tide with the noble men who were ordered to guard them."

"If this is true, if these Kremnoans targeted the fort to *save* men, then why did they attack without warning?" Caenis insisted, looking for holes in the argument.

"Commander Hapries," Phainon said, and attention shifted back to him, "I am sorry your promotion came under such heavy circumstances. I knew Mityphon, he was an honorable man and died a warrior's death."

Caenis rolled her eyes, but Hapries pressed his fingers to his chest and bowed his head in respectful gratitude for the sentiment.

"If a ship bearing the mark of Strife approached the fort, would you listen to them speak?" Phainon asked.

Hapries contemplated that for a moment and then shook his head. "No. I would not wait to hear the words of Castrum Kremnos, they are not known to treat with their enemies, and I

would be hard pressed to believe they come in peace."

"If you had and they told you that the fort needed to be abandoned to save all the lives therein, would you leave?"

"No, I would believe it a ploy to secure a military victory, and perhaps request reinforcements in response," he admitted.

"Elder Caenis, the prejudices of Okhema would've cost her many fine soldiers. There was no other way for them to save the people than to disguise themselves as brigands and chase them to safety," Phainon insisted.

Caenis' mouth curled into a foul smile, and she asked, "Commander, if the *Deliverer* had approached your gates and relayed to you the dire nature of your situation and ordered a retreat, would you obey?"

"…I would," Hapries admitted.

"And we did!" a young voice added. One of the three men that had come with their Commander shuffled past his companions to walk down the stairs to stand beside his commanding officer. The young man bowed politely to the Council and then as a second thought bowed to Phainon too. He had light brown, short hair and energy that came only from inexperienced youth.

"My name is Amorphis, my lords and ladies," he said, "forgive me for speaking out of turn, but I was also there that night. I am an archer, and my life was saved by the Deliverer when I-I shot him. My arrow was meant for one of the pirates, er, Kremnoans, but the Deliverer got between us, he took the arrow instead-" he motioned to the place on his own body, too vague to be specific but Phainon remembered where that arrow had stuck in his back, "-when he used his sword to break my bow, I thought for sure he was a man possessed and that I would die, but he pushed me back and ordered me to run, saving my life."

"Your testimony does not add-" Caenis started but the young man waved both of his hands frantically and talked over her.

"My lady please! To your question, I had the fortune and misfortune of fleeing from the same pirates twice."

Caenis blinked. Phainon blinked. The Commander was the only one that wasn't surprised.

"And the second time, it *was* as you said," Amorphis confirmed, "after we fled the first, many of us were left at the nearest fort while Commander Hapries returned to Okhema to report and receive instruction from the Admiral. While we were there, the pirates came again, but this time it was during Action Hour and the Deliverer came before them. He told us that there was no need for bloodshed, that our lives were in danger if we stayed. The Deliverer said that pirates were here to take the fort and many of the men laughed, but I and the others told them of the night our fort was lost and convinced them to flee. Not a single soul was lost to Thanatos that day. It wasn't until later that I learned that fort too had been consumed by the Black Tide."

The young man looked between the Commander, Caenis, and Phainon before Hapries patted his back reassuringly and gave him a nudge to return to his seat.

“Elder Caenis, I will take no more of this Council’s time except to say that this man’s illegal actions served Okhema in ways that few could ever hope to understand, if it were up to me, I would retract my initial testimony and see these charges dropped,” Hapries said clearly and firmly for everyone to hear.

“Noted,” she said shortly and after an awkward shuffle to realize he had been dismissed, the man returned to his seat amongst the chatter of the audience. They conversed at every level, too muddled to hear anything but isolated and meaningless phrases.

Oblivious to the buzz of the crowd, Elder Oenone consulted her notes, unrolling the scroll farther to read, “Beginning with your indictment and the issuing of your warrant, Okhema has lost two naval warships, the wreckage of which washed up on friendly shores with evidence of battle. While bound by the golden threads, can you assert that you, Phainon, and the pirate crew with which you sailed had no part in those ships’ destruction?”

“I cannot. I know those two ships, and we did destroy them,” he admitted, “the crew and ships had become corrupted by the Black Tide and would’ve caused unspeakable damage to innocent people had we not raised our weapons against them.”

The threads stayed still. Phainon could see the Council members looking between each other, trading quiet looks while Oenone rolled the scroll up tight. Caenis was scanning the immediate crowd, judging their reactions carefully. While any decision would be up to the Council alone, they frequently weighed the public’s opinion and nearly all Okhema had come today to see what would become of their Deliverer.

Eventually her eyes settled on Aglaea. With a sneer, Caenis invited, “You are quiet today, Lady Goldweaver. Will you not say something on behalf of your favorite Chrysos Heir?”

The crowd murmured excitedly as Aglaea stood and stepped away from her place in the front row to be more easily seen. She shimmered in the light of the Dawn Device. “There is nothing I can say to sway the people to Phainon’s defense. They already know by his own works that he is a man who chooses good regardless of the law.”

“Good intentions should not absolve a man of guilt!” a woman called. She was pushing through the crowd; face twisted in anger.

Phainon took a deep breath through his nose and then mumbled under his breath, “Xenia.”

Her short blue hair had been combed but only just and her gold eyes were dulled to bronze. Phainon’s words to her had not brought her peace, rather they left her feeling hollow and angry. He could see the exhaustion in how she moved and the way her eyes shook. Depression had rooted deeply in her heart and driven her to become a shell of the woman she had once been.

“I was resolved to hold my tongue, certain that justice would be done as *this man*’s crimes became evident, but I hear the crowd contemplate forgiveness and not once has this Council

addressed his greatest sin," she explained, curling in on herself. Her chiton shifted as she spread her stance for balance, arms held to her chest as if to hold her heart back while she struggled to contain her angry tears.

Caenis moved to her side and put a hand on her back for comfort. The Councilmember gently guided her forward and offered a hand for her to hold while she found her quivering voice again.

"It does not matter how many people he may have saved by breaking the law," Xenia managed, "more have been lost to his neglect! My husband, Marcus, was this man's first mate aboard the Speeding Sol and was lost to the sea when his captain's reckless behavior drove them to their deaths. Pirates? The Black Tide? It doesn't matter!" She glared at Phainon with so much pain and anger that his own face fell into grief with his aching heart. He wanted to hold her, to comfort her, but she needed more than he could hope to provide as tears spilled over, and she had to take a second to sob. "I am one of many women and men who have lost their loved ones, not only on the Sol but on the two ships sent to retrieve this criminal to bring him to justice. Far more have died for his adventure, for his *epic*, than have been saved."

She turned to everyone in the crowd, now silent with the weight of her pain. "When my Marcus held me the night before his departure, he told me with pride what an honor it was to serve the Lady Aglaea at the command of the *Deliverer*. He admired this man more than any in the city as the hero that we had been taught to believe in, that many of us have seen him embody… but good deeds from a young man do not make him qualified to lead men to their deaths!"

Xenia held more tightly to Caenis' hand. Her knuckles were white, but the Elder didn't wince or flinch. "His arrogance, his recklessness has denied my son his father, and then he has the gall to stand here and blame *the Black Tide*? He stands here and tells a story of a lone survivor choosing to honor the sacrifice of his men, men that *trusted and loved him,* by joining *pirates*. Phainon may not have killed any Okhemans, but he supports and loves the men who did while he ignores the blood on his own hands!"

On stumbling feet with tears flowing freely she turned again to Phainon. "They trusted you completely! Believed in you! Did you even mourn them? Did you honor them with funeral rites as we did here? While we were praying to Thanatos to bear them safely through the Sea of Souls, you were falling in love with the very same pirates you were hunting, that my Marcus longed to bring to justice." She turned her head back and forth to plead with the crowd to understand. "Had this monster died with the Sol, how many *more Okhemans* would yet live? Even if there was no hope for my husband there would have been hope for Captain Theophis and his crew. The pirates would have still chased away and saved Commander Hapries, and this fool would not have unleashed the Tide in a manner that may threaten Okhema. I don't care if the Council dismisses the charges of piracy, I don't care if they choose to end the war with Castrum Kremnos, none of that matters to me as much as seeing the Scales of Talanton balanced for the sake of the crew you abandoned!"

She stumbled in close to Phainon so he could see the hatred in her eyes, her desperate longing as she told him, just him, "a *good* captain would have gone down with her ship."

The crowd mulled over this new information while Xenia eyed him with such vitriol that Phainon was starting to get weak knees. Shame filled his consciousness with an uncomfortable itch that settled around his heart and neck to strangle him, and he knew she could see into him just as Phainon could see into her. Hatred and anger were easy emotions. Grief was infinitely harder to grasp with grace. How many times had Marcus reassured her before they departed, that he would come home to her and their son in glory? How many times had he kissed her and his boy and told them what an honor it was to serve his city? When he praised Phainon as a captain he was excited to serve, did he do so with absolute faith, convincing his beloved wife and son that the Deliverer would protect him as they did what they believed was right?

When she looked at Phainon she saw a vicious pirate that stole from her the man she treasured above all else. She saw a thief that took away a father and a future. And most of all, she felt betrayed, because a part of her that could not look past the truth of circumstance felt as though Phainon's failure made her husband a liar. How many dreams had they shared as a couple? What hopes did they have for her son? These angry tears that spilled down her cheeks and dripped from her jaw and chin were not shed for Phainon, they were meant for the man she wanted to see most in the world.

This weight of loss was crushing her completely and he longed to make it right.

"Thank you for your testimony, Xenia," Caenis praised with shallow compassion. She gently pulled the mourning woman away from Phainon to face the crowd again. "If this were your decision, how would you balance the scales?"

"His life is all that I would accept," she said firmly, "He was the captain, those men and that ship were his responsibility. He failed them and should have perished with his ship. It is justice to demand he pay for this sin now."

Phainon's hands tightened into fists and the golden thread pulled in response. He felt horrible and for a moment he agreed with Xenia, that perhaps he should have perished but her sentiment came from a place of malicious grief. She was searching for revenge, not justice, and while Phainon had made mistakes, he had also played that fateful night in his head many times since. There was no action that he would have taken differently with the information that was available to him at the time. Information that was severely limited, even with Aglaea's threads.

If Okhema was not so focused on complacency, on hiding from the world at large and pretending that there is no conflict in Amphoreus, then perhaps Marcus and the others would still be alive. For as eager as Aglaea was to accept refugees, to send the Heirs and her Navy to save people from the Tide, he had not once seen the Council approve the means to track the Tide nor research it. Phainon wanted to say as much, to shift the blame where it belonged, on the Council that insisted on keeping secrets and fueling prejudice to ensure that Okhema stays picturesque and perfect without struggle. He *should* out the Council and tell the people that if they would simply look beyond the Dawn Device perhaps he would've known the extent of the Tide as an immediate threat and not an enemy of distant city-states.

But he couldn't because that's not what Xenia needed right now. That's not what any of them needed right now. Pointed fingers would not move the city forward out of stagnation.

“Xenia,” he gently said, and she turned on him with heartbroken malice, “I will not plead for my life for my sake, but for yours. My death will not bring you peace.”

“It’s a start,” she hissed.

Before Phainon could say anything else Caenis pulled her away, guiding Xenia to sit beside the Council in the front row. Then the Elder turned back to the crowd to ask, “Are there others in agreement? That for his crimes, incompetence, and neglect, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae should offer up his life?”

The response was an overwhelming disagreement in the form of boos and angry shouts. For as torn as the people were, they still held Phainon in high regard.

“What think you, Lady Aglaea?” Caenis taunted, “Will you exercise your influence to save his life?”

“I will not.”

The crowd and Caenis paused, stunned by that total disregard for the life of one of her own. Phainon could not bring himself to look at Aglaea when she said that, but he felt in one tiny thread around his finger a tiny tremble when she added, “I have no love for a traitorous hero. Do with him as you please.”

While her words stung, rife with indifference, Phainon clung to that thread like a lifeline. It quivered on every word, soft enough to be felt but subtle enough to not be witnessed by the others. There was reassurance in her lie as Aglaea distanced herself from him and he saw in Caenis’ face revealing disappointment. Caenis’ hatred of the Flame-Chase would ever dominate her desire for fairness and justice. If Caenis could find in Phainon’s trial a chance to punish Aglaea, she would do it. It was kindness to push Phainon away.

Still the crowd boiled with discomfort at the implication. They expressed confusion and worry with many more beginning to shout and yell for Phainon to be freed. Despite Xenia’s emotional plea that pushed many of the crowd to indecision, too many Okhemans weighed this heavy mistake against the rest of Phainon’s testimony and what he had said about the Black Tide. He had recounted for them the story of the Sol’s demise, and while the thread had not borne witness to the truth of that part of his tale, they had no reason to believe he lied about the futility of the crew’s end and did not believe he should be held responsible for the tragedy.

Caenis turned and walked back to the other Elders, and they gathered together to deliberate. All the while the crowd roared, eager to have their opinions known until they were silenced by Elder Callictis rising to his feet to address the people.

“This Council has decided on the topic of Phainon of Aedes Elysiae’s proposal, to reject it in its entirety. Castrum Kremnos has crumbled to dust, there is no need to ally ourselves with her people, what remains of their military might pales compared to Okhema’s Navy. Okhema has no reason to send men to die to rescue the leader of our enemies. Okhema is protected by the Dawn Device and has no need to concern ourselves with the Black Tide. As to the matter

of the Coreflame of Strife, it will be seized and taken into the care of the Lady Goldweaver to prevent this power from returning to our generational enemy."

Phainon pulled at the threads. They felt more binding than reassuring now.

Elder Callictis continued, "In the trial of Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, this Council has decided on a guilty verdict. Regardless of any noble intentions, the accused broke the law and facilitated the breaking of the law leading to the deaths of Okhemans. He willingly conspired with the enemies of the Holy City and for this act of treason we sentence him to death by beheading. The execution will be held one quint past Entry Hour at the Worldbearing Altar with this Council serving as witnesses. There will be no public access."

The crowd erupted into chaos.

Chapter End Notes

I apologize for how uniform everyone sounds. I try to give each character distinct speaking patterns to distinguish them from each other and Phainon even has two patterns, one for debate and one for his everyday life, but unfortunately the NPCs I grabbed from the game don't have enough to go off of and I didn't care if Caenis' syntax was unique as long as she was a bitch soooo yeah :')

Chapter 34: The Dangerous/Miraculous Power of Truth

Chapter Summary

New Character Tag: Tribbie
New tag: Temporary Imprisonment

Phainon, the hero, gets the chance to play the damsel in distress. Too bad his prince is off slaying dragons.

Chapter Notes

I'm genuinely happy that some people are able to predict some parts of the fic. I know some people don't like predictability but it means I'm writing my characters well and managing my foreshadowing! Ready to see if you guessed correctly? :3c

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The shock of the announcement hit Phainon with a crushing sense of failure, not for his own life, which he cared little about, but for the people who had been relying on him to secure this victory. As soon as his sentence was read, Phainon hurriedly looked at Aglaea, an instinctual response, he was sure. Phainon didn't know what he expected to see. Comfort? Anger? Disappointment?

She had her eyes closed and her head bowed, face guarded and neutral, like she didn't care. It made him feel hollow to see her like that until Phainon realized Caenis was studying Aglaea as well, searching for a reaction that the Goldweaver refused to give. When the golden threads tightened around Phainon's wrists and ankles, visibly restraining him so he couldn't run from his fate, Phainon realized that Aglaea had to play a long game, even if it meant sacrificing him for a greater good. More than anything, he trusted her.

The assembly was erupting around them, worsened by the Dawncloud guards that rushed to secure the safety of the Council and surrounded him with weapons drawn. The crowd was furious with the decision and as the shock settled, more joined the chorus of voices that demanded a retrial or simply shouted for him to be freed. A scuffle was breaking out in distant seating as the populace disagreed with the sentencing, but Phainon never got to see the outcome.

He was swiftly placed in the Council's chains to replace the glimmering comfort of Aglaea's threads as he moved from her care to their confinement, and the Council took no chances with the Deliverer. As they locked the manacles around his wrists, ankles, and neck, Phainon

really did consider fighting back. These men stood little chance against his strength, even unarmed, he doubted they could best him if he tried to escape, but there were too many people there and Phainon would never risk the collateral damage against an innocent populace if he had the choice.

As the golden threads gave way to steel, he held his tongue, held his peace, waiting for an opportunity that didn't come. A guard pulled roughly on the chain attached to his neck and Phainon stumbled forward with a shout and growl. They gave him little time to recover, and he was half dragged, half led from the agora to the shores of Dawncloud.

Only the assembly was perched over the lake, the rest of Dawncloud stretched over the plateau beneath Kephale at the far side of the water, and along the beach where sprawling buildings connected to Marmoreal Palace. It was there that they took him, back through the places of study, past administrative offices, through the maze of stairs, balconies, and courtyards up high to the Council's prison.

Okhema had two jails. The other was in the city proper and was more what one would expect from a prison meant for the rare long-term inmate. This one was smaller, set high above a cliff overlooking the lake, run by the Dawncloud guards directly under command of the Council rather than the police that answered to Aglaea. There were only two cells here, meant for temporary holding. There was no bed, no place to relieve himself and nothing that could offer comfort. A small, barred window was set high in the wall opposite the door to let in daylight and a restrictive view of Kephale, but otherwise it was a plain, dark box carved out of stone.

Phainon resisted going in. He dug in his heels and held his breath as five men wrestled him into the small space. He managed to elbow one of them in the face, breaking a nose and his boot cracked the rib of another before the new collar at this throat dug too deep and he saw stars. Cold stone slammed against his face as he was pressed against the wall by an arm across the back of his neck and a fist in his hair. Another man had a shoulder against Phainon's back, digging hard enough to bruise between his shoulder blades. The chains rattled as these men locked the links in place and then they finally let him go to cough and rub his sore throat.

If he had been anyone else, this would have been overkill. The door was heavy wood, locked tight, the stone walls would not easily fall, and the chain around his neck was firmly connected to a ring on the wall. Even if Phainon had the strength to barrel through the door, the chain around his neck was too short to reach it. The length was barely enough to let him sit on the ground.

He pulled at the chains still holding his wrists together, testing the strength of the metal at the locked clasps and hissed when the cold steel bit into his skin. Every time he shuffled his weight the chain between his ankles dragged across the ground, too loud in the confined space. Phainon shouted in frustration and tried to pull the chain free from the wall, but it didn't budge, and the thick collar settled heavily on his collarbones.

Slowly he sank to his knees and the short chain tugged at his neck. Phainon's feet still hurt from standing in the agora for so long. The Trial had eaten up the entire afternoon, and Curtain-Fall Hour was fast approaching, not that he'd be able to see the thief star from here…

How did it all go so wrong? He really thought that the people of Okhema were on his side. They *were* on his side! They were ready to start a fight when he was dragged away from his people and family. Phainon thought *for sure* that at least part of what he had advocated for would have passed the Council's shrewd judgement. Even if they didn't let him go, still held him accountable for the crimes he had committed at sea, he had thought for sure that ending the war on paper would be an easy victory for everyone. What governing body would decline the opportunity to take credit for lasting peace, claiming victory over a generational enemy?

He slammed his fist into the wall. Then again. Phainon punched the solid foundation until his knuckles cracked, and golden blood spattered on the wall in tiny droplets and dripped down his fingers. Then he tried grabbing the chain and pulling and tossing like a wild, desperate animal until warmth seeped down his neck from where the harsh metal cut into the soft skin under the hinge of his jaw. Still, he fought, clawing at the manacles and kicking at the walls and locks with snarling shouts and pained, frustrated cries until his voice cracked and his strength was spent.

Phainon sank again to his knees and leaned forward until his forehead pressed against the cold wall. He panted helplessly and whispered soft apologies inside his head. The Kremnoan people were walking to Okhema for help, unaware that they were walking into waiting spears. Okhema would see their approach as an army come to invade their homeland, without the official peace that Phainon had asked for.

There was morbid poeticism in knowing that Phainon would die beneath the visage of his Titan, just as Mydei would under his. While Mydei fought the Black Tide at the peak of Castrum Kremnos, Phainon had fought beneath Kephale for the same lasting peace of which they together dreamed. He prayed in soft, rough mumbles that the crew would find a way to save their Prince. Phainon wasn't afraid to die, but how could he go to the next life while Mydeimos struggled endlessly, not knowing how he really felt? At least the crew would be safe, he reasoned, but the thought of never seeing them again squeezed his heart with such agony that tears rolled free.

Phainon didn't know how long he knelt there with the Dawn Device illuminating his cell with bright sunbeams. No food was wasted on a man doomed to die. No guards came to taunt him. He was simply alone.

"Woooow, they must really be afraid of you, brat."

Phainon's eyes widened and he stumbled back to his feet, looking for Cipher.

"Ew, I don't like the new jewelry though. It's so not your style," the cat crooned from the window. Her face was blocking half of the light as she peered through the bars. She was holding tightly to the metal rods for balance.

He stepped back as far as the chain would let him go so he could see her better.

"Oh, Zagreus' oversized purple balls," she huffed, "if you're *crying* I'll just come back later."

"Wait! Cipher, stop!" he called to her, "I'm not anymore."

“Maybe you should be since you feel so badly about-“

“Ciphy, he doesn’t need that right now…” scolded Trinnon. Her soft, tired voice preceded her little head popping into the remaining space in the window, blocking the rest of the light aside from the halo around each of their heads. It was oddly fitting considering the angelic comfort they were bringing him with their presence. He could never tell Cipher that. She would be so offended.

“Trinnon!” he greeted cheerfully.

“Snowy, are you okay?” she asked.

“I-I am.”

Cipher rolled her eyes so hard she almost fell and scrambled to hold onto the bars. She leaned back enough to look straight down at something he couldn’t see. “Damn it, Bartholos stop squirming so much!”

“Your tail is in my face, Boss!” Phainon couldn’t see Cipher’s best friend and sidekick, but his high-pitched, whiny voice came through the window just fine. That explained how she was up so high. Cipher was good at climbing, but she couldn’t fly like Trinnon and Bartholos could.

“It’s okay if you aren’t okay,” Trinnon reassured him.

Phainon looked down, hanging his head in shame. “I just… I don’t know what went wrong.”

“What did you expect for telling the truth like that?” Cipher said casually and Phainon looked back up at her with a confused tilt of his head that rattled the chains. “Oh, come on, brat, isn’t it obvious?”

“Ciphy…”

“You *told the truth*,” Cipher repeated, “*You* told the truth that the Council didn’t want anyone to know.”

And he did it in a public space, more than that, he was the *Deliverer,* people listened to him. Xenia had said it herself, they trust him and believe in him, so when he came home and broke the news about the world beyond the Dawn Device, he became the biggest threat to the Council’s carefully tailored society built on ignorance and complacency. As long as he was alive, he held the ears and faith of the people. There was no other way to silence him than to demand his head. It all clicked so hard that his eyes got wide and his shoulders slumped. Cipher tapped her nose when she saw the light turn on in his head and smiled her cat-like smile.

“Now you’re getting it.” She yelped as she dropped a couple feet from the window, leaving thin, long claw marks on the stone as she scrambled to hold on, and bright light shined directly in his eyes. He flinched away with a turn of his head and blinked until he could safely squint again.

“Snowy,” Trinnon said, unbothered by Cipher wrestling with her ride, “you still did the right thing. We loved your story and Okhema loves it too, even if some of them are scared.”

He looked down again, still contemplating the futility of the situation but Trinnon didn’t let the guilt settle in his heart.

“It wasn’t your fault,” she reassured in that soothing voice, “we know you took Xenia’s words deep inside you, but you have to know *it wasn’t your fault.”*

The tears beaded at his eyes again. He didn’t realize how badly he needed to hear those words. No matter how many times he tried and failed to forgive himself for what happened, knowing that someone else was there with answer, helped so much. He clung to her sentiment; let it dampen the guilt that lingered so he wouldn’t fall into crippling despair.

“UGH,” Cipher complained, she was finally back in the window, eyeing his tears, “stop that, you have more important things to worry about.”

Phainon tugged on the chains again. “Can you get me out?”

Trinnon raised a hand to her mouth to think. “Snowy, Agy told us not to take sides, and we agree with her. We cannot help you.”

“*I’m* not part of that we,” Cipher reminded Phainon, “but I’m not sure I want to help you after what you did.”

Phainon was again confused. It was all over his puppy dog face as he puzzled over what she said. He hadn’t even been around to *do* anything that might have upset her.

“Fucking Titans, *you don’t even remember?*” Cipher complained.

“He doesn’t remember??” Bartholos echoed in squeaks, “so much for the score of a lifetime.”

“Use that brain of yours for a second brat,” she commanded, still scowling down at him, “what did you *forget* to do, when you went to Castrum Kremnos?”

His immediate thought was Mydei, and his heart hurt again but after a long minute of trying to remember what Cipher had to do with Castrum Kremnos he remembered their original deal, the one this money-loving cat had made with them both.

“…we didn’t unlock the treasury door,” he groaned.

“Imagine my surprise when I made that long run with a big bag to fill with beautiful treasure and *those big doors were still locked*!” she complained.

“Tell him about the Tide!” Bartholos chimed and Cipher smacked her head on the top of the window with a yowl when he jumped.

She let go of a bar to presumably slap at him and she jostled about back and forth with flailing arms to keep her balance. “I would if you’d stop moving around you swollen grape!”

“Hehehe.”

It took her a second to settle again. “Whatever beasty you woke up on that island has the Tide all kinds of messed up,” she reported.

“Wait… you were there while Mydei-“ Phainon started to say.

“Yeah, I saw him,” she confirmed. Her voice had dropped in pitch to her more serious voice. “The lion was still fighting when we got there. Not sure how much of his humanity is left the way he was throwing himself at that thing.”

“And a good thing too,” Bartholos added. Phainon still couldn’t see the spirit creature, but Cipher’s involuntary bouncing and annoyed facial expression gave him away. “That kraken could eat whole islands if it wasn’t for that crazy guy keeping it busy.”

Phainon felt his body double in weight and his breath stuck like sludge in his chest. Suddenly his own skin was uncomfortable and itchy, the steel on his neck was too tight. He reached up and slipped his fingers under the collar to pull it down and move it from side to side as though that would alleviate some of the discomfort, but sticky warm blood trickled down his throat and made things so much worse.

Did Bartholos say a *kraken?* Is that the form the Black Tide had taken to fight Mydei? How could he hope to compete with that? With Mydei’s history in the Sea of Souls, fighting monsters… this was a horror meant to break him at every level.

“I need to get back to him,” Phainon mumbled.

“…what did he say?” Bartholos called.

“He says he needs to go back,” Cipher reported.

Trinnon’s face twisted into deeper concern. It didn’t look right on her child-like face, even with the flower veil she wore to cover her eyes, the crease of her brow was visible between her ruby bangs.

“Can’t he just open the treasury when he goes back?” Bartholos suggested.

“I am… deeply sorry that we forgot, Cipher,” Phainon said, genuine and with a small voice, “we had other things on our minds.”

Her cat ears twitched and they sat in silence for a while until Cipher sighed, “Well, you can’t exactly make good on your promise if the Council puts that pretty face of yours in a box, can you?” Another exasperated sigh, like this was the worst inconvenience of her life. “Let me see if I can get you out.”

“Can you just pick the lock?”

“*Just-Just pick the lock?!”*

“Did he tell you to pick the lock?!”

“No appreciation for the art of the heist! I thought I taught you better than that, brat,” she lamented.

Phainon was starting to get impatient, but he pushed it back down.

“Ciphy…” Trinnon whined, and Cipher softened.

“Give me some time to figure it out,” she said, “I know I make everything look *effortlessly* easy, but you don’t exactly fit in my pocket, do you?”

“…thank you, Cipher, truly.”

“Ew, sentimentality, I liked you better when you were on the other side of the world,” she complained, already leaving. Her voice faded as she finished the sentence, not giving him a chance to retort. The teasing was nice, comforting in an otherwise bleak situation. Even if she couldn’t save him, it meant everything that she was trying.

Trinnon rested her chin on both of her hands on the windowsill. “We can stay with you, Snowy, if you need us.”

He smiled warmly at her. “Thank you teacher, but I don’t want you to get in trouble too. I’m sure Aglaea has a plan and will need you.”

“Agy is very smart,” Trinnon agreed, “we will keep watch over you from a distance then, as we always have.”

As we always have. Phainon remembered the fair winds on his journey when the skies were clear, always exactly what they needed, when they needed it.

“Thank you, Trinnon,” Phainon said with all the heart he could muster, and then she was gone.

He waited in silence, looking at the window until the light hurt his eyes and then Phainon slowly sat back down with his back against the wall. The loose links of the chains settled on his shoulder and lap, but he gave them no concern.

Phainon’s mind and heart were across the ocean, with a blonde-haired Prince who needed him at his very best.

-

Hephaestion had been explicitly told not to sit out on deck for too long, but he was too happy to have some semblance of freedom back to obey Perdikkas and the anxious discomfort of experienced battle instinct was making that infirmary feel cramped. The compromise was the little fat pegasus had to keep him company, providing a steady stream of healing the entire time that gave him the energy to feel normal again. Hyacine’s healing magic couldn’t replace the pieces of his lungs and stomach that had been destroyed when he got hurt, but it could let him pretend that he was back to at least 50% of his strength and maybe, maybe with time, he could fight at everyone’s side again.

He tapped his fingers on the railing while Krateros paced. Fig Stew was prancing behind him, jumping into every imaginary footprint in turn. It was the nature of Kremnoans to leave all grudges on the battlefield and Hephaestion was no exception, despite their frequent fighting and fundamental disagreements, they both worried about Phainon. It was impossible to know if he was doing well in whatever meeting, debate, or engagement they were holding for him.

Anaxagoras had insisted that Phainon was charming to a fault and had a rapport with the people of the city that would garner him some protection. Then the scholar had muttered about *that woman* being a big support in a pinch too and that Phainon was probably going to be fine. But when Curtain-Fall Hour arrived, and the thief star flew overhead, Krateros was still pacing, and Hephaestion was still sitting by the railing tapping his fingers. Peucesta was playing something generic and quiet in the background while everyone waited in uneasy silence like the night before a battle.

There was still no word from Phainon.

“So, are we weighing anchor, captain?” Leonnius asked. He was lying in the shrouds with his legs dangling just barely out of reach of Hephaestion’s head. The title lingered, unsure, between all of them.

Hephaestion grunted, non-committal.

“Phainon told us to run,” Perdikkas reminded them but there was no command or urging in his vocalized recollection.

Another grunt. What would Mydei do? Would he put the crew at risk for something that was probably nothing? For all they knew, Phainon was giving a victory toast at an Okheman feast and lost track of time. Or he was in prison, and this Council or even the Goldweaver refused to listen to him at all. They didn’t know enough about Okhema to make an informed decision.

“I could go ask someone, Lord Hephaestion,” Castorice offered.

“We still don’t know if they consider you a hostage or a runaway,” Hephaestion said gently, “we don’t want to lose you too.”

He scanned the horizon. From their sheltered cove there wasn’t a lot to watch aside from the path up to the road. Hephaestion saw a distant glimmer and squinted. Something was sparkling just above the ground, a glimmer of gold at first but now a red dot was flying rapidly towards the ship.

He stood up and snapped at the others to get their attention and held his hand out for Peucesta’s bow but Perdikkas snatched it before Hephaestion could and drew it himself. If they weren’t potentially in danger, he’d be more annoyed by the doctor’s interference. Even if his wounded chest took priority over his wounded pride.

The others were slowly wandering over to the rail to look at the approaching… something. Leonnius had twisted in the shrouds to watch, even Fig Stew jumped up onto the railing, too curious to resist.

“What *is* that?” the runner wondered under his breath.

Perdikkas drew the bowstring back, and pointed with his finger beside the arrowhead, tracing a path at the oncoming… something… was that person? A tiny person?

Little Ica made a trilling sound and Hyacine hurried to Perdikkas’ side with a gentle but firm, “Wait! Wait!”

Castorice too gasped when she realized who it was. “Lord Hephaestion, that is not an enemy!” she insisted and then a breath later Tribbie was landing in Castorice’s arms for a happy greeting hug.

They spun on the deck, squealing like schoolgirls that hadn’t seen each other all summer while the Kremnoans still tried to process what was going on. Perdikkas slowly relaxed the bow until he could safely put the arrow back in the quiver and handed the weapon back to Peucesta. The bard tucked it away while he balanced the lyre on his leg so he could keep playing one-handed. The tune changed from something ominous and troubled to a curious brightness.

“Lady Tribbie!” Castorice greeted her, finally setting the girl down.

“Lady Tribbie!” Hyacine echoed while Fig Stew and little Ica hurried over to investigate with sniffs and happy chirps.

“Little Cas! Little Cinny!” she cheerfully greeted and Hephaestion decided he was just going to be lost and he accepted that. This person was half the height of the other two, a child, so the honorifics were confusing at best.

Bright, short red hair framed big blue eyes that rivaled Phainon’s for depth of color, made brighter by an adorable and stylish knee-length dress that matched her winged boots, flower themed headband, and black gloves. The accents and patterns were the same hue as her tiny golden wings that hovered over her shoulder blades behind her back. This Tribbie person had all the hallmarks of a well-kept child, with a tiny ponytail that only held back a very small portion of her hair, an inconsistent, half-forgotten braid in her bangs, and so many matching flower accessories pinned to her dress that there couldn’t be any left behind in the box. But she was clean, happy, and very respected by the two women on board.

“Tribbie? As in Tribios?” Krateros asked beside Hephaestion, and the new captain was genuinely surprised to see recognition and shock on the old man’s face.

“You know her, Krateros?” he asked.

“It has been decades,” the veteran admitted, “but she has not changed.”

“We age differently than humanity,” Tribbie confirmed as she, no, they, finally stopped playing with Hyacine and Castorice to turn to them, “but we remember you, Krateros of the Godshield Brigade and when you came to us for advice.”

The old man’s eyes widened.

“Uh, okay, that’s creepy, what’s going on?” Leonnius interjected.

Ptolemy’s gasp was a partial answer, and he finished the rest with excitement, “wait, wait, Tribios, the Holy Maiden of Janus? Demigod of Passages, the first Chrysos Heir?”

“How in Nikador’s balls do you know that??” At least Leonnius had the courtesy to swear in Kremnoan when he was in gentler company.

“Because I know how to read you cock-shaking nincompoop!” Ptolemy too swapped to Kremnoan to be polite.

Peucesta strummed a few notes and sang in his gentle, attention-grabbing tenor, “Sing to me muse of she who stepped through the first crossroads, who defied the gods to speak for humanity the will of fate. Sing of the first heroine who became many voices to reach every corner with a message of lasting hope.”

“Please, there is no need to sing our praises,” Tribbie insisted with a humble blush, “we are simply Tribbie, messenger of the Chrysos Heirs.”

“Have you brought us a message, Lady Tribbie?” Hyacine asked and the child, the Holy Maiden, wilted. Their wings drooped and their shoulders dropped even as they raised a hand to their chest and turned to face them all.

“Yes. It is about Snowy…”

“Snowy?” Perdikkas asked.

“Snowy is what Lady Tribbie calls Lord Phainon,” Castorice explained, “is he okay?”

“For now, but the Council of Elders has passed judgement on him,” Tribbie said gently, “they put him on Trial and have sentenced him to die at the Entry Hour.”

Peucesta’s lyre twanged an ugly note when his hand slipped, Castorice gasped, and then it was silent on deck while the news sank in. There was a long story there but right now those details didn’t matter.

“Lady Tribbie,” Castorice asked in a quiet, worried voice, “do you know where he is? Can you use your gate to save him?”

Sadly, Tribbie bowed their head. “We are only here as a messenger. It is our duty to share news, but we must remain neutral to the will of the Council, or things will be harder for Agy. We want to help,” they admitted, voice wavering, “but we know more than most that losses are a constant on the Flame-Chase journey.”

Something about that didn’t sit right with Hephaestion and he frowned deeply.

“Heh,” Ptolemy chuckled, and everyone looked at him with frustrated confusion, even Tribbie who seemed hurt, until he added, “then it is well that we are not on any Flame-Chase journey. We get to *rescue* Phainon for real this time.”

Perdikkas snorted through this nose and Leonnius snickered. Tribbie's eyes glittered with knowing mischief that briefly had Hephaestion wondering if this was what she had hoped for from the beginning.

"Even this legitimate rescue is breaking who knows how many laws," the doctor lamented.

"I will look up every last one when we are sailing away from this place," Ptolemy promised.

"It is a good day to be a pirate," Peucesta mused softly with a few accompanying notes.

"Gear up," Hephaestion ordered, "we don't have a lot of time."

"*Awoo!"*

-

The last time the crew had visited Okhema only a small group had taken to the streets but when Hephaestion called the entirety of the Chryseus Leo to the deck to tell them that Phainon was in danger and needed saving, the outpouring of volunteers turned a quiet rescue mission into a 'fuck it, we do it our way' kind of affair, long-term consequences be damned.

The two groups sort of formed on their own. Originally Hephaestion only wanted one group, but when word got around, Anaxagoras had insisted on going into the city himself for an errand unrelated to the rescue. The scholar had been mostly isolated, keeping himself in the galley, pouring over his research as he worked on improving the Black Tide talisman. It had become an obsession of his, so it was surprising to see him on deck at all.

When Ptolemy had tried to argue with the guy against a separate mission, Anaxa had cracked his knuckles, opened his mouth, and Hephaestion still wasn't sure how in the Netherealm he had convinced every Kremnoan onboard that he needed an escort to raid the Dawncloud Institute. He vaguely remembered big words describing Black Tide research and something about proper alchemical supplies. Krateros was a willing volunteer for that side quest. The old man recruited a few willing veterans, and they eagerly set out to approach the city from another route, to more easily visit hot spots around town that Anaxa thought 'had promise'.

Hephaestion's group was comprised of all the people that he couldn't say no to. Ptolemy, Peucesta, Perdikkas, and Leonnius, of course, insisted on coming along, fully armed, fully geared with even their plumed helmets on their heads. They were imposing Kremnoans ready to storm the streets, but the two remaining Chrysos Heirs after Tribbie had departed had insisted on coming as well. Hyacine refused to let her recovering patient out of her sight for any strenuous activities and Castorice believed she could keep Aglaea off their tail in the event the golden threads made an appearance. Even Fig Stew, wearing his own little helmet, ran beside them as they hurried to the city in full regalia, bright red and gold colors on display.

The first sign that something had changed was at the gate, where the road turned from dirt to carefully cared for tile, when their group crossed into Okhema and ran into the city guard. Hephaestion had ordered their men to avoid killing anyone, they had a mission to do, and

restraint would go a long way for future relations (if those could be salvaged at all), but it wouldn't do to allow an alarm to be raised at the start.

There were four men waiting there armed with swords at their hips and shields on their backs. Hephaestion and Leonnius hurried to disarm their foes, but all four guards looked directly at the group, then turned around to face their backs to them. Confused, the two Kremnoans stumbled to a stop a pace away, spears pointed at the ground, but ready in case this was a trap.

"You heard then about the Deliverer?" one of the Okhemans said loudly to his friends, wanting to be overheard.

"Oh, the trial earlier," his friend said back equally loud, "ridiculous if you ask me!"

"My brother is a guard at the Marmoreal Palace, he says those cowards of the Dawncloud Guard are keeping the Deliverer near the Council's Administration District high in that gaudy tower."

Hephaestion and Leonnius exchanged looks while the rest of their group caught up. Leonnius shrugged when Hephaestion tilted his head in confusion far enough for his long hair to spill over his shoulder. When the guards refused to acknowledge them any further, he waved to the group to keep moving. They slowly passed the Okhemans who kept turning in place as they passed to keep their backs facing the Kremnoans.

A third Okheman guard weighed in after quickly checking that this invading force was still nearby, "those arrogant Dawncloud soldiers are traitors if you ask me, all one hundred of them walking fixed patrols on duty tonight."

"*Incompetent* traitors," the last guard agreed, raising his voice and shuffling backwards to stay in earshot of the Kremnoans, "They don't even bother to check the service routes for the Dawncloud staff!"

Hephaestion and Leonnius lingered to listen while the others hurried down the street. Briefly, Hephaestion's eyes met with one of the guards. They nodded to each other with mutual respect and then the Okhemans quieted again, resuming their posts and leaving the two of them to catch up.

"Did you hear them?" Hephaestion asked the others as they rejoined the group, and everyone picked up speed.

"What's Dawncloud?" Leonnius asked.

"It's the district under Kephale," Hyacine explained, "up on the plateau, where all the priests live."

"The route to get there is through Marmoreal Palace," Castorice added.

A guard on the road ahead spotted them and jumped in surprise. It would be impossible not to be startled by a sizeable unit of shining Kremnoan warriors shaking the road as they ran

through the Holy City. The man pulled the horn from his belt. Peucesta reached for an arrow at his side but had barely strung the bow when the guard dropped the horn on the ground and smashed it with his foot. He pointed towards an alley as they approached, guiding them, and not a single person in their group slowed down when Leonnius turned on his heel and raced in the direction the man was pointing.

“Why are they helping us?” Perdikkas asked as they ran.

“Lord Phainon is very beloved in Okhema,” Castorice told them.

“What in Nikador’s name did he say to the city?” Ptolemy wondered aloud.

“The truth,” Peucesta guessed, “what else could he have said that could win the hearts of so many men, to look past what we are for what they know we are here to do?”

“Then let’s not let them down,” Hephaestion ordered as they surged between buildings, heading uphill, “let us do what they cannot and save the Deliverer.”

They broke free of the narrow alley and ended up in a wider street. If they were trying to be sneaky, the best option was to take the indirect route through more narrow side streets, but Fig Stew was done wasting time and the chimera booked it up the main road ahead of them. Peucesta followed next and then their crew were racing in the open.

He didn’t expect traffic this late at night, even with the glow of the Dawn Device making night feel like day, surely Okhemans still slept, but even trying to be quiet they made noise as they ran and there were people that peeked through their curtains. Every time he saw a shuffle on a balcony, those curious eyes watched not with fear but with relief and those few that did not hide reacted favorably.

One man, up late, raised his glass to them as they passed. Another clapped, briefly, but definitively. Every guard turned away and pretended not to see. And still they climbed unhindered.

“Lord Hephaestion,” Hyacine called, “don’t push yourself too hard. If you start to feel short of breath, tell me, and we can catch up to the others when it is safe for you to do so.”

He didn’t answer her to conserve strength. Now that they knew the city guard wouldn’t try to stop them, it was a reasonable request. Hephaestion had every intention of pushing himself beyond his limits if need be to save their brother, but it was nice to know he wouldn’t have to sacrifice his health for victory. His lungs were already fighting to keep up, every breath burned, and they were never quite deep enough, but there would be time to rest when Phainon was safe.

Chapter End Notes

I wrote two versions of this chapter. In the other one, Cipher is the one that tells the Kremnoans what happens and she jump scares them into long strings of robust and clever profanity that I couldn't censor with "they swore in Kremnoan that Phainon didn't understand" cause this is Hephaestion's pov AND HE DEFINITELY UNDERSTANDS. Ptolemy reads lots of things. He has a very colorful vocabulary.

There are two types of people:
Cipher - The heist must be elegant and clever and sneaky~
Kremnoans - What if we just break everything? :D

Chapter 35: Not the Worst Ideas

Chapter Summary

No new tags but I think this is the last time I'll have to adjust the chapter count now that I've finished pulling apart what's left of my original outline's carcass.

The crew brainstorms on how to get Phainon free...

Chapter Notes

I said it on Twitter, so I'll say it here too. If this fic breaks 1k kudos before I finish the main plot, I'll let readers request/vote on additional chapters/one-shots that can be anything from post-plot fluff, five years later, in-character Q&A chapter with questions from my readers, adventures of Fig Stew, prior chapters from other povs, etc. I would retain veto power of course and I won't write anything that would change the rating, but it seems like a fun way to celebrate if that happens to happen.
This is already my most successful fic by a longshot, and I am eternally grateful to all of you who made it this far! I am so content with the love that has already been shared so this would be entirely a bonus for you all as I am already as happy as I can possibly be~! :D

Waiting can be hard. Waiting *patiently* when you're hoping to be rescued the night before your scheduled beheading is impossible. Phainon tried napping, he tried pacing, he sang songs under his breath, he crafted his afterlife apology to Mydeimos, tossed a pebble he found up in the air until he dropped it and it bounced out of reach, and all of that took him less than a quint. The misery of waiting to die was compounded by the anxiety of Cipher's pending rescue attempt.

It was not for lack of hope. Phainon had absolute faith in Cipher! But he didn't have absolute faith in her punctuality and without any knowledge of her fledgling plan the stress was eating him alive. This was a "better late than never" kind of cat, a sentiment that was notably not applicable to his current situation.

Eventually he sat back down with his back to the wall, legs outstretched, and his head tilted to stare at the ceiling while he dozed. Even if a good night's sleep *was* an option he didn't want to wake up to Bartholos' giant black eyes and ghost claws in his face, or worse, Cipher's teasing grin. But as the hour ticked by Phainon found his consciousness drifting along that top layer of sleep, the thin membrane that separates the waking world from the

depths of deep dreams. It was the kind of snoozing that lasted for only a few minutes before the dip of the head jerked Phainon back to reality, only to nod off mere seconds later.

It went like that until Phainon lost all sense of time and zoned out watching the dust slowly float by in the beams of light through his window. They glittered as they caught the warmth of Kephale's light, stars that he could see during the day. He watched the sparkling little dots drift back and forth and started to get frustrated when tiny vibrations disturbed them. He was so annoyed with the disrupted flow of dust that Phainon barely registered the shaking floor as heavy footsteps until he also heard muffled voices and the clank of steel on stone.

Still sitting against the wall with his head tilted back, Phainon's eyes drifted to the door and narrowed suspiciously. Was it time? Surely Cipher would be lighter than that on her feet and smart enough to not banter with her sidekick the entire way? But the voices mumbling outside his door were too soft to make out and too animated to belong to only a pair of thieves.

The room jumped when something crashed nearby. It wasn't a distant sound but not in Phainon's immediate vicinity either. They were the sort of clunks and dinks that one might hear when a neighbor was working on their house next door with invasive construction sounds that felt closer than they were. There was more mumbling, the clang of metal on metal, and the dull hum of noise shifted closer.

Something slammed against his door this time, not particularly hard but with definite purpose. The voices picked up, talking over each other as the latch on his door jiggled experimentally, then a little more insistently, and finally the whole cell shook when it was assaulted a second time.

The heavy wood didn't budge but Phainon did. He slowly pulled himself to his feet and adjusted the chain around his neck to be more comfortable where he stood against the wall while he watched the door with cautious optimism.

There was quiet on the other side, a few more mumbles, something that sounded rhythmic, and Phainon pieced together what was happening with the instinctual unease of his reliable battle instincts. He retreated towards the corner as far as the chain would allow him to go and pressed himself against the wall in the second before the door was ripped violently from its hinges and thrown across the room to slam into the space that Phainon had been sitting in. It shuddered and clattered down at an angle, eliciting a gasp when it caught the chain on one of its corners as it fell, ripping him forward by his throat while he clutched at the metal to keep his neck from breaking with the impact.

"Pay up," Ptolemy ordered and Peucesta and Perdikkas passed over a few coins each while Leonnius proudly rolled his shoulder and slapped the dust from his hands in the now open doorway. Splinters were still rolling across the stone floor and one pathetic hinge squeaked as it swung back and forth where it was still hanging onto the wall by one last, bent nail.

They were all shining armor and hope with those glorious red plumes on their helmets waving and cheerful expressions partially visible around the curve of the cheek guards. Phainon held tightly to the chain to keep from choking but through the struggle he smiled at his friends come to save him.

“Phainon/Lord Phainon!” Leonnius and Castorice shouted simultaneously. They both hurried to his side but were promptly cut off and shooed away by Perdikkas. The doctor took note of Phainon’s discomfort on his knees immediately and pointed at the door.

“Make yourselves useful!” he huffed and Leonnius and Ptolemy hurried to lift the door so it would stop pulling on the chain. They put it unceremoniously against the wall it used to be attached to with a *thunk.*

The relief was instant and Phainon let go of the cold steel to put his hands on the floor while he caught his breath. The doctor was already brushing his hair away from his neck to look at the damage and inspect the locked clasp. Dried blood cracked under the prod of his fingers and Phainon winced at the tickle of a bead of warm gold slowly creeping into the hollow at the base of his throat.

Hephaestion came to him next. The man was the epitome of exhaustion quivering on his feet as he crouched in front of Phainon and put a hand on his shoulder. He took his helmet off and set it on the ground when Phainon looked up at him and they exchanged crooked smiles. It was so nice to see him out of bed. This wonderful man, too thin and lean in his Kremnoan armor, pale as new snow, lightly shining under a sheen of sweat with bandages still clearly visible under the fabric that stretched across his chest between his polished pauldron and shiny belt. He clearly needed to lay down for another week.

“Absolutely useless without us,” Hephaestion said softly, “must be a pre-requisite for a Captain.” He was oblivious to his own condition or firmly in denial, Phainon couldn’t tell either way.

“I told you to run,” Phainon said firmly.

“Pffft,” the first mate laughed, “we didn’t listen to Mydei either. You’re not special.”

Phainon leaned back to sit on his heels and everyone but him glanced down with thinly veiled rage at the clinking chains when they dragged across the stone.

“How did you even find me?” he asked as Castorice slipped into the tiny cell again while Perdikkas was distracted so she could get to him for a reassuring hug. Phainon reached up to gently touch her arms that were wrapped around his shoulders from the side opposite where the doctor was still assessing the damage. The extra bodies were not helping the claustrophobic nature of the prison, but he was grateful for the contact all the same. Yes, even when Hyacine and Peucesta appeared in the doorway to push the cell further past capacity.

“It’s a funny story,” Perdikkas said. The doctor was scooting over to make space for Hyacine who smiled at him, squeezed his arm by way of greeting, and then gently took his hand in hers so she could see how badly he had injured his knuckles. She hummed something under her breath, a lullaby perhaps, too soft to be for the room like a shared secret between doctor and patient while she rubbed his hand reassuringly and dabbed at the bloody tears with a cloth.

“If I may?” Peucesta cleared his throat from the hallway. There wasn’t enough space left for him to feel comfortable crammed between everyone else, but he could be easily heard from

where he stood in the doorway even with his soft voice. Phainon expected a lyre and an already composed song about their adventure through Okhema, but Peucesta was shockingly very concise and unaccompanied with few parts waxing poetic.

He started with the crew on deck, eagerly waiting for news as the time of departure came and went. Hephaestion had taken command as ordered but bid them wait. It was well that he had because a heavenly messenger, Tribios, came to share the news of Phainon's pending execution and the crew needed no other details to mobilize in a moment. When Peucesta's story moved to the Holy City, Phainon listened with obvious awe when he heard about the guards and populace who stood by in blatant opposition to their upbringing.

"They let you pass?" he asked for clarification.

"Phainon, *they told us where you were*," Hephaestion confirmed with so much love in his voice that Phainon worried he might burst.

"More than that," Leonnius added, "every guard we passed pointed us the right direction, the first group even told us how many Swancloud troops were on patrol."

"Dawncloud," Ptolemy corrected.

"That's what I said."

"*That is not what you said*!"

"I think I would know what I said!" Leonnius insisted as he stepped into Ptolemy's space.

Hephaestion sighed and stood up straight so he could get between them before it came to blows, but Kephale above, Phainon was just so happy to hear them banter. He was so, so grateful and humbled that as bleak as this situation had been, they loved him enough to come for him and they were acting like this was just another adventure, another epic tale to share over fine wine. It filled him with relief and the purest joy that could not be dampened even with the heavy chains keeping him trapped in this horrible place.

"But Dawncloud is run by the Council's men," Phainon wondered aloud, "it's a maze, how did you…?"

Perdikkas smiled. Castorice's hug turned into a back rub with one hand, the other resting gently on his forearm as she answered meekly, "Aglaea."

"We made it through Marmoreal Palace much the same way that we did getting through Okhema," Hephaestion explained when Phainon's face tilted in confusion. He had a hand on Ptolemy and Leonnius each to keep them apart while they continued to glare at each other, itchy to fight. "But beyond the palace we noticed the guards wearing different colors and assumed we found the right place." The first mate paused for a deep, struggling breath and let go of his companions to press both of his hands to his chest. Hyacine let go of Phainon to move to Hephaestion's side, gently urging him to sit with Leonnius' help.

When Phainon started to get up, worried, Perdikkas and Castorice both tightened their grips on his arms to keep him from making a fuss and he settled back down on his heels. He watched Hyacine check Hephaestion's pulse and listen to his breathing while Perdikkas picked up the story in his stead.

"The guards at the gate, the first guards we saw, mentioned something about unguarded service tunnels, but we didn't know where those were until Fig Stew led us to another chimera, a little gray and white thing with horns and a spade tail. It was holding the end of a very fine golden thread in its mouth. We thought if it was a trap at least there's a chance they'd take us to the same cell block as you and save us the trouble of looking."

Vigethos... "You followed the thread," Phainon summarized.

"Led us right here," the doctor confirmed, "I'm not sure where Fig Stew went, he and that other chimera had a very intense conversation barking and chirping at each other and then they both ran off when we started following the thread." He gave the cuff around Phainon's neck an experimental tug and Phainon winced. "And they think *we're* barbaric…"

Ptolemy leaned over to inspect where the chain was connected to the wall. He gave it an experimental tug and tapped at the stone around the baseplate with a calculating expression and even held his finger to a spot just above where the padlock connected with the confidence of a navigator marking a spot on a map. "Hand me one of the shields?"

Peucesta leaned around the doorframe to grab one of the round shields that had been left in the hallway. They really had stormed the city prepared for war.

He passed it over and Ptolemy held it in both hands nice and tight to bring the edge of it down on the heavy padlock with zero ceremony and a whole lot of yelling and unbridled rage. The clang was loud enough to wake the entire tower but none of the Kremnoans seemed to care about that half as much as how ineffective the blow was. Only the Okhemans even flinched at the loud noise.

"You didn't hit it hard enough," Leonnius critiqued, and Ptolemy scowled.

"'With the same strength that I had when I killed the bravest of our foes,'" Ptolemy quoted out of context, "This is going to be a brain over brawn puzzle, I fear."

"Just not strong enough," the runner coughed. "The dust in here is just wow," he explained when Ptolemy turned on him with a glare.

"Let me try," Hephaestion offered, and four different people said 'NO.' He pouted, dejected, from where he was sitting in his own corner like a child that was enduring a punishment for breaking a rule. Little Ica landed on his head and trilled to offer comfort.

Phainon empathized. He knew what it felt like to not be of use, to be too injured to participate. Hephaestion's frustration was almost palpable, especially remembering the days after the storm when Phainon was confined to a bed and only wanted to help. Oh… so this is how Mydei felt when he was upset with Phainon for risking further injury for the sake of service.

“Do you have your spears?” Phainon asked.

Ptolemy snapped his fingers as he guessed where Phainon was going with this. “Proper leverage may suffice.”

Peucesta passed a spear from the doorway and Phainon slowly got to his feet. Castorice and Perdikkas helped him up. He didn’t need it, but the moral support was worth keeping his silence and he knew what it meant to them to feel like they were helping.

Ptolemy contemplated how to get the spear through the links with little nods and shakes of his head that were easy to track with the way the plume on his helmet wiggled back and forth, up and down with every contemplative movement. Unfortunately, the weapon was a hair too wide to fit through everything aside from the ring on the wall and that was firmly bolted down. He stabbed it through anyway and put both hands on one side to hold it tight while the butt end of the spear pressed into the wall.

“Wait, wait,” Perdikkas waved his hand and left Phainon’s side to take the spear from Ptolemy so he could swap the end they were pulling on so the very sharp blade was against the wall and not flailing around where it could hit someone.

“So much for brains,” Leonnius coughed again, and Ptolemy let go to jump on him with an annoyed shout. They both went down scuffling and wrestling and they kept it up even when Peucesta firmly dragged them out by their ankles into the hallway to get it out of their systems. A crew of tense Kremnoans storming a city looking for a fight were going to find one *somewhere* even if it meant with each other. They’d be fine.

Phainon took Ptolemy’s place next to Perdikkas, and they both grabbed onto the spear with both hands to pull. The weapon bowed as they leaned back, slowly bending. Steel and wood creaked at the fulcrum when they hit that point of resistance, their strength versus that of the craftsmanship. For a second it felt like the piece would give. One of the bolts started to wiggle and then the spear snapped and both men fell backwards in a shower of splinters and the pathetic ding of the spearhead clattering against the floor.

Perdikkas looked at the end of the spear in his hand then back at the base of the chain and tsked. “Let it never be said that Okheman smiths are incompetent.”

“Mountain dwellers,” Phainon explained.

“That would do it.”

Hyacine tapped her staff in her hand while she brainstormed aloud. “Cassy, do you think Pollux could pull this free?”

Castorice tilted her head at the thought and then nodded. “Yes, I think they could.”

“We should have led with that,” Hephaestion mused from his time out corner. He was looking a little bit better under Ica’s ministrations.

The room got colder as Castorice closed her eyes and pressed her hands together as though in prayer. An energy gathered around her while they waited for Pollux to respond and then it occurred to Phainon how bad an idea this was.

“Castorice, wait-“ he started to say as she waved her hand in a broad stroke. A thin purple line stretched through the empty space from the floor to the ceiling and three seconds later everyone was shoved into Hephaestion’s timeout corner on top of him. Phainon’s chain tugged painfully against his throat at the end of its reach, and he made a gurgling sound against Pollux’s scaly side. Someone’s arm was in his belly; his foot was in someone’s thigh. Castorice was somehow across his shoulders, and he could hear Hephaestion’s groan turn into a squeak… or maybe that was Little Ica. The pegasus did have the appearance of a squeaking dog toy.

“Oh…” Castorice wheezed.

Pollux whined, only a small part of them made it out of the rip in space and the rumble made the whole building shake. The dragon was trying to cram more of itself into the extremely limited space, clawing at the floor and threatening to bring down the whole building while they puzzled out what was happening.

“I forgot they have to – oof! – squeeze in *beside* you!” Hyacine lamented, muffled under someone.

“Please stop squirming,” Perdikkas begged with his voice a few octaves higher, “someone’s boot is in in my groin.”

“Sorry, Perdikkas,” Hephaestion gasped from the bottom of the pile.

“Sorry, Pollux, you can go back now,” the Hand of Shadow peeped mildly, and perhaps a little embarrassed.

The dragon hummed and Phainon felt his whole body vibrate with the sound until the purr fully retreated inside the tear and the gate to the void winked out of existence once more. The whole crew peeled themselves off the wall in turn. It was amazing how much bigger the room felt when there wasn’t an oversized death dragon in there with them.

Perdikkas whimpered and limped away from poor Hephaestion who let out a breath with a squeaky moan. Hyacine had somehow ended up on top of him, and she was apologizing profusely and checking for any further damage from where she was kneeling over his lap, but aside from poor Perdikkas everyone seemed okay. Phainon rubbed at his neck and twisted his head back and forth uncomfortably while he glanced at everyone to double check their statuses.

“I think,” Leonnius said from the doorway, having witnessed it from a safe distance, “we might be stupid.”

Ptolemy scoffed and stomped back into the room. He had lost his helmet in the scuffle and just left the thing in the hallway, trading it for a sword. “Proper leverage *will* work,” he insisted. With the sword still sheathed he wedged it against the ring where the spear had been

earlier and tugged. When the metal didn't budge, he put a foot on the wall and pushed, straining with angry growls and constipated noises that got even more gross and undignified when he added a second foot. The combination of pushing with his feet and pulling with both hands left him parallel with the ground in an impressive defiance of gravity until the sword gave up and bent, dropping the bookworm on the floor.

"And how is that working out for you?" Perdikkas asked, snarky, with his knees still held tightly together to protect his recently bruised manhood.

Ptolemy rolled over and got to his feet again. He held up the sword now bent in the middle at a 45-degree angle to inspect the damage. "Relax, it's only Leonnius' sword."

Leonnius gasped and there was some noise in the hallway as Peucesta tackled the man aside before the rising tensions could cause any real trouble. They had a personal limit to how many fights the men could get into with each other on a mission.

Phainon ran his fingers over the clasps at his wrists and then over the one at his neck. He could feel the little keyhole under his fingertips and the joint opposite it. Those would be the more fragile part of the chain.

"Can someone break the hinge?" he asked. Ptolemy and Perdikkas both leaned over to look at the ones on his wrists. "Right here." Phainon pointed to where the cuffs would have to bend to open.

"That does look like a weaker part of the ensemble," Ptolemy mused.

"Stomp on it hard enough and it might break," Leonnius offered from over Peucesta's shoulder.

"We're not going to stomp on him!" Hephaestion growled and then started coughing.

Hyacine scowled at him and started scolding in her firm doctor voice that made everyone feel guilty for being disobedient, "Lord Hephaestion, what did I say earlier?" He stuck out his bottom lip and pouted.

"If we're really careful with the flat of a knife I bet we can get the little pin out of this hinge," Perdikkas suggested.

"Yeah I can see it," agreed the Kremnoan.

Ptolemy reached behind himself and drew a knife from his belt and Phainon leaned forward to watch. A hair's breadth away from the knife touching anything, Perdikkas sensibly thought of something important. "Phainon maybe you should sit down."

"Oh."

"Yes, that would help," Ptolemy agreed.

The three of them sat down and Castorice scooted in close to watch. Phainon held onto his wrist to keep it steady in his lap while Ptolemy tried to get the blade of his knife in the non-

existent spot between the pin and the hinge. He slipped and narrowly missed cutting Phainon and all four of them drew in sharp breaths through their teeth.

“What? What?” Leonnius asked urgently from the doorway. Peucesta’s frown deepened as they watched from relative safety.

“Lord Ptolemy if you hurt Lord Phainon…” Hyacine started.

“He’s fine!”

Maybe this was a bad idea, Phainon considered very briefly. “Let me try,” was what he said instead.

Ptolemy handed him the knife, and the chains clinked together as Phainon tried to get the right angle on the joint. He had a decently steady hand, but the pin was smaller than he realized and after scratching the metal thrice and slipping twice, Phainon slapped at it uselessly with the hilt to achieve the same results.

While he was working on that Leonnius had crept around the others to keep inspecting the collar at Phainon’s neck. Phainon could feel the runner’s fingers gently prodding around the soft flesh and slipping under the collar to gauge the space between the metal and skin.

“Y’know, I think we could squeeze a spear in here.”

“*Against my neck?”*

“The ring on the wall is too heavily bolted down but this collar is hammered thin, and the lock isn’t very strong. Ptolemy’s leverage idea might work better on this.”

“…”

Hyacine slapped her own face like she couldn’t believe what they were suggesting and Castorice asked, “Is that really the best idea, Lord Leonnius?”

“If it’s that weak we could just pull it apart,” Hephaestion suggested with another wet wheeze. He wilted a little when Hyacine turned on him with a disapproving look.

“I tried that,” Phainon admitted with a shake of his head.

Perdikkas shoved his fingers under the collar too, and Phainon resisted the urge to gag when the pressure on his throat increased and black spots peppered his vision. “We wouldn’t be putting anything *sharp* in there…”

“As long as we break the chain on his neck, we can deal with his wrists and ankles on the ship,” Peucesta reminded them. His gentle tone did not match the eagerness with which he handed over another spear.

“Okay, okay,” Phainon relented.

The crew was halfway through tag teaming awkwardly shoving the butt of the spear through Phainon's collar while his eyes were bugging out from the tight squeeze when an exasperated awoo from the doorway stopped them in their tracks. The whole room froze in the middle of what they were doing to look wide-eyed at the chimera in the doorway.

Fig Stew looked horribly unimpressed with those bright red eyes half lidded under his helmet. He studied them all, making a judgmental show of looking at the claw marks on the floor, the broken spear, dented shield, time out Hephaestion, bent sword, and their current weirdness of too many people dog piling Phainon with the worst idea they had yet. The chimera sighed and turned his head to chirp over his shoulder and Vigethos walked up to sit next to him.

"Aglaea…" Phainon mumbled under his breath. He hadn't expected to see her chimera here. Even when he was mentioned earlier, Phainon never would've thought the rotund critter would come to see him.

"Huh," Leonnius managed, still mostly frozen like the others in their confusion, "I gotta be honest, I really pictured her as a woman."

Ptolemy snorted but didn't get a chance to say anything before the chimeras stole the spotlight again.

Fig Stew motioned with a paw towards the group. "*Awoo! Aoo, awoo!"*

"*Awoo."*

"*Aoo. Awawaoo."*

Beagle nodded when Fig Stew sighed and they chirped between themselves while everyone else watched with confused silence, unwilling to interrupt even though no one had any idea of what was happening.

The gray chimera pointed at Phainon with a paw and turned to chirp at Fig Stew again who sighed with a short, "Awoo." Beagle patted Fig Stew on the back in a gesture of comfort.

"*Awoo?"* he asked.

Fig Stew slapped Beagle for whatever was said and Beagle cackled.

"Awoo! *Awoooo! AoAwo!"* Fig Stew insisted with a purr.

Beagle shrugged and relented with a soft chirp and reassuring, "Awoo."

Fig Stew half mounted the other chimera to nose his way into Vigethos' ruff, pawing at his collar, while the other held perfectly still beneath him. The gray chimera looked entirely too pleased to have Fig Stew necking him like that and Phainon was incredibly close to yelling at them to save such inappropriate behavior until after a date and *definitely* not in front of *people*. But well before he could fully process what was happening and the blush in his cheeks, Fig Stew pulled away with a golden thread between his teeth.

The two chimeras leaned away from each other, tugging to stretch the thread between them until it broke and the key that was tied to it dropped to the floor, bouncing with high-pitched clinks until Beagle pounced on it like he was catching a particularly slow fly. He slapped it twice to be sure it wasn't gonna bounce away anymore and then gently batted it towards Fig Stew.

"Awoo?" Fig Stew asked, surprised, perhaps a bit honored as he pressed a paw to his chest just under his ruff.

"Awoo!" Beagle confirmed politely with his paw outstretched towards Fig Stew and his head bowed.

Fig Stew proudly leaned down to pick up the key in his mouth, nearly slapping Beagle in the face with the plume on his chimera helmet as he did so but Beagle didn't seem to mind. He just leaned away until Fig Stew was upright again and then he took a seat with an audible flop to watch the orange chimera trot regally up to the awkward crew to slap the stupid spear that was clearly a bad idea and drop the key into Phainon's lap.

They all blinked at it.

"Key," Phainon said aloud as he picked it up, "none of us thought of trying to find a key…"

Perdikkas and Hephaestion both slapped their own faces, Leonnius chuckled, Hyacine sighed, Peucesta had crouched down to give Beagle an appreciative pet, and Ptolemy grumbled to himself in ancient Kremnoan so no one would know the specifics of his personal scolding.

"That does remind me, Lord Phainon," Castorice said shyly, "I had forgotten, Lady Cipher taught me how to pick locks with a hairpin." The whole room slowly turned to look at her, and she blushed, embarrassed, with both hands held up to her face to hide.

It was Fig Stew that broke the ice in the room with a huff as he walked back to Beagle, gestured broadly at the room with a paw, and chirp-trilled in what could only be interpreted as: do you see what I have to deal with?

Something about that was just so funny to Phainon. Still in chains, still in a tiny cold box, exhausted, emotionally spent, and filthy with blood, sweat, and lingering failure, he started to laugh. It was a genuine thing, a little rough on his sore throat and the way his friends looked at him, he must have seemed like he had gone mad in all the stress.

"Lord Phainon?" Castorice asked. She was peeking at him through the gaps in her fingers.

"I'm sorry, it's just," he started to say but his need to recover his breath got in the way. Phainon took a second to find his voice while he bounced the key in his hand. There was so much he could say about how awful this day had been, how seeing them come to his aid didn't fix everything but it was enough to give him the strength to hold out hope. He wanted to take each of them in turn and tell them what they meant to him, how much he treasured these bonds between them. He wanted to laugh at how silly they all were, struggling to find a solution and in their exhaustion forgot about the most obvious answers. They tried to cram a

dragon in this tiny prison cell before they considered picking the lock, a suggestion he had even brought up with *Cipher* earlier that Curtain-Fall Hour!

Here he was, the failure, surrounded by his new family, supported by his old family, and all he could feel was love. How do you even begin to tell people all of that? Where were the words for that?

Don't be so sentimental, Deliverer.

He smiled at the memory of Mydei and closed his hand around the key to hold it to his chest and simplified everything he was feeling into one, single statement, "I am so happy to know you all."

Chapter 36: The Heart of the Solution

Chapter Summary

Heh, chapter title is a pun, heh.
New tag: Beagle Coconut

Now free, Phainon has one more thing he wants to do before leaving Okhema.

Chapter Notes

Some of you saw this coming :3c

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon kicked the last chain across the floor into a pile with the other links and took in a deep, full-bodied breath to release in a satisfied sigh. He rubbed his wrists in turn and dried blood flaked off and flittered to the floor. Ugh, he wanted a bath. There was gold and black under his fingernails and a layer of dusty sweat that made his clothes stick to him uncomfortably.

“We should go before someone comes to check on you,” Ptolemy said while he put his helmet back on. Fig Stew agreed with a chirp and a wag of his tail. He turned to Beagle, and they met noses, staring at each other with their tails vibrating and noses wiggling like they were having their own conversation.

“If they didn’t come running when they heard the noises, I’m not sure they will,” Hyacine observed. She was helping Hephaestion to his feet, a task that Phainon hurried to help her accomplish. The first mate felt so much lighter than before with an arm slung over Phainon’s shoulders, and Phainon not-so-secretly worried about him as he slipped a hand around the man’s waist to hold him up so he could find his footing.

“The Dawncloud Guard are lazy,” Phainon said simply, “they have the most the important job in Okhema and have never once had to exercise their power of protection.”

“Ugh, big men with no experience who like throwing their power around,” Ptolemy grumbled sarcastically, “my favorite.”

Castorice delicately picked up Hephaestion’s helmet for him, but he shook his head at the thought. He was supporting the bulk of his weight just fine, but every inhale was labored, and

shallow and each exhale had a wet, sourness to it. The restrictiveness of a helmet felt like yet another bad idea on a night of lesser quality brainstorming.

“Hephaestion, do you have any attachment to that helmet?” Phainon asked.

He shook his head and Phainon gently shifted his friend’s weight to Hyacine so he could take the helmet from Castorice and leave the shining piece of armor upright on top of the chains. Peucesta whistled and Phainon knew he appreciated the implied message of a Kremnoan helmet resting on top of loose chains and an empty cell.

“I was under the impression you didn’t want to be in here any longer than you had to be,” Leonnius teased when Phainon lingered to inspect his work.

“I don’t. Let’s go.”

Phainon was pleasantly surprised and wildly disappointed with how easy it was to escape the Dawncloud Administration District. As was advertised, the service tunnels and narrow hallways that weaved through the ancient architecture were mostly unguarded and those few courtyards, rooms, bridges, and walkways that were entertaining late-night traffic were predictable. The guards that paced did so on strict timers or had given up entirely and were napping at their posts.

This wasn’t the first time Phainon had been through here. As Aglaea’s envoy, Phainon had spent a lot of time in Dawncloud and while he wasn’t familiar with *every* route he did know that guards were supposed to be few and far between, stationed only in public areas. To see so many, incompetent or not, was a surprise and he reasoned that perhaps the Council had expected something like this.

It made sense of course, Phainon turned himself in, naturally that meant his pirate allies were nearby. The Council were corrupt and self-centered, but they weren’t stupid, increasing patrols was the correct response. Too bad the people they commanded were so inexperienced.

They took it hurried but not sprinting. Hephaestion was doing alright and insisted he was okay, but Phainon could see the struggle in the way he moved even without his spear and shield. The others had opted to carry his equipment for him as they were now down a spear, sword, and shield after their repeated failed attempts to free Phainon with weaponized stupidity. Phainon almost, *almost* offered to carry the *man* but he didn’t dare threaten Hephaestion’s pride like that when the man was doing his very best and was focused.

The humidity of the baths was a definite indicator that they had left Dawncloud and returned to the Marmoreal Palace. If what the crew had said was true, and they had no reason to lie, their escape was all but guaranteed, it was only a matter of getting back to the ship but…

Phainon slowed from a jog to a stop and the others passed by him, turning a corner before they realized he was no longer keeping up and then they were back tracking. Heads popped back around the wall in turn, giving him puzzled looks.

“Lord Phainon?” Castorice asked. She hurried to his side and took his hand to pull him along, but he stayed rooted with their arms stretched between them.

“We can’t leave yet,” he insisted, and Cas let go.

“Phainon, this isn’t a good time to be homesick,” Perdikkas cautioned.

The whole group was slowly meandering back to where he was standing to stop a few paces ahead of him, beckoning.

“Mydei,” he said, “they took the Coreflame of Strife from me during the Trial.”

Ptolemy cursed under his breath. “Even if you did not get your pardon, did it at least buy peace?”

“No.”

Leonnius cursed under his breath.

“Even so, I don’t think Mydei would be happy if we all got caught and killed trying to retrieve something that he willingly gave away,” Perdikkas reasoned.

“The coreflames are a part of a Demigod,” Castorice reminded them, “to know that a piece of you is somewhere else… it is an emptiness that is hard to describe.”

Mydei’s final words to Phainon played in his head, the same loop that had given him comfort and grief in tandem since they were spoken at Castrum Kremnos. Perhaps it was a little selfish then, to want that Coreflame back enough to reject Mydei’s insistence that he didn’t need it …because Phainon did. Phainon wanted it. And as horrible as it felt to *want* for himself, as much as he rejected that impulse, abhorred it so much that the bile rose in his throat and his gut twisted in discomfort, he still did.

That heart was entrusted to him with purpose, and it was his duty to protect it and the wants and wishes of the man to whom it belonged. If it couldn’t be traded for peace and pardons, then Phainon wanted the damned thing back. And if Mydei *still* rejected it, then it was going in Phainon’s pocket for the rest of their lives.

“I’m not leaving without it,” Phainon insisted. He turned around and started walking swiftly down the hallway and footsteps followed, hurrying to catch up.

“Phainon, wait,” Hyacine begged and he paused, twisting in place just enough to look back over his shoulder.

Hephaestion was leaning heavily against a pillar with Hyacine’s hand on his back. His long hair had fallen over his shoulders and was hiding his face like a partial veil the way he was hunched forward but Phainon could see the tremor in his shoulders and the heaving way he panted. He coughed twice and dark red clots speckled the floor in fine beads. When he rubbed his mouth with the back of his hand it came away dark with wide streaks of blood.

Phainon took a step towards him, but Perdikkas cut him off and gently guided Hyacine away from their patient. “I’ll take him,” he insisted, “we’ll go straight back to the ship.”

Hephaestion waved a hand as though insisting he was alright, but he couldn't find the words and eventually gave up with a begrudging nod.

"Leonnius, try to find Krateros and tell him we saved Phainon and are returning to the Leo," the doctor ordered, "Ptolemy and Peucesta, help me get Hephaestion back to the ship. We'll let the Heirs find the coreflame and return to us. Anyone opposed?"

Ptolemy raised his hand, but he was ignored when Hephaestion flashed a tired thumbs up.

"Great then let's do it."

"Wait, none of you are staying?" Phainon asked. It wasn't that he was unhappy to be with his college study group again, it was just weird to not have any Kremnoans around.

"Don't worry, Lord Phainon," Hyacine teased, "they will be fine without us."

"I think Fig Stew wants to accompany us," Castorice observed.

The chimera roared his agreement, a soft, growling sound that was echoed by Beagle Coconut.

"Vigethos wants to come too?" Hyacine bent down to scratch under his chin, and he purred.

"*That's* its name??"

"Titan's, Leonnius," Ptolemy sighed, "you didn't think this was *actually* Aglaea did you??"

The runner huffed and grumbled, "well, I know now."

Phainon smiled at their antics. Peucesta was getting underneath one of Hephaestion's arms to support his weight while Perdikkas did the same on the other side. A part of him felt like he should be more worried splitting up, but even as Ptolemy and Leonnius bickered the whole way down the hall and his friends disappeared around a corner, he didn't feel that shadow of doubt. Absolute faith left no room for fear.

"Let's go."

He turned again and started running towards Aglaea's office. It wasn't far from where they had separated, and the door was unlocked when they got there. He stepped inside, slowly looking for the woman herself but she was absent.

"It's clear," he whispered and they piled in.

"Lord Phainon, do you know where she keeps them?" Castorice asked.

He shook his head. "She must have a hidden vault in here somewhere…"

Beagle chirped insistently and ran to the shelf, jumping on his hind legs and slapping his front paws together. He was staring at the amphorae on the top shelf that held his treats.

When Fig Stew trotted over to ask his new friend what he was doing, Beagle awoo'd back and then they both were jumping and begging.

Hyacine sighed and pulled over Aglaea's chair to stand on so she could reach the jar but moments before her fingers brushed the clay it was snatched away by cat claws. The healer yelped and jumped backwards, falling off the chair, but Phainon dove to catch her, and she landed safely in his arms.

"Of all the nerve, brat," Cipher hissed, "I promise to break you out of your cell in an elegant heist for the ages and when I got there all you left for me was a *mess*."

She fell off the top of the shelf like a liquid, elegantly twisting in the air to land perfectly on her feet with the jar in her hands and two eager chimeras sitting in front of her licking their lips.

Phainon put Hyacine down when she mumbled a polite thank you and then all his focus was on his apology. "Cipher, it just kind of *happened*…"

"Save it. You have no *idea* what kind of a night I have had," she whined, "I came up with the *best* plan to get you out, flashy but not overly so, the kind of heist that would have honored dolos… and when I went to that gaudy ship of yours to recruit sidekicks *they were already all gone.*" Beagle pawed at her leg. The two animals were sitting still with waning patience; mouths open like baby birds waiting to be fed. Without looking down, Cipher pulled off the lid and held it in her palm to free up two fingers to toss a single treat between them.

"So, I ran alllll the way back to town," she continued with her tail swishing. The fur was puffed up so Phainon knew she was at least a little bit mad for real. "And I asked every guard I saw if they had seen any Kremnoans and *every single one of them* lied to my face!" Her voice deepened in a mocking recreation to say, "'Of course not Lady Cipher! Kremnoans haven't been in Okhema in *year*s! I think we would have noticed any Kremnoans!' But ohoho, I *knew* that they tore through town! Even that guy at the antique place you like with all those ugly amphorae lied to me when it was obvious he had *just* been robbed! Who loses their entire stock to pirates and then *lies* about it? And the defaced Aglaea mural? The facial hair was a nice touch but please, *signing* something so uninspired?"

Phainon tilted his head in confusion and then opened his mouth to refute something that didn't sound like his friends, but she was very suddenly in front of him with a finger on his mouth to shut him up. "*I'm not done*. Those Kremnoans were so damn unpredictable that I gave up and decided to just save my baby brother who was hopelessly rotting in a cell *waiting for me* and *guess who wasn't there?"*

He shyly pointed at himself, and she patted his cheek with her free hand. The cookies in the jar she was holding rattled as she shifted from side to side. "*That's right."*

"Awoo!" called Beagle and Cipher paused her ranting to look down at where he was gently poking her leg. The single cookie she had dropped to them before had not been wildly devoured like Phainon would've expected, instead it was at Fig Stew's feet where the chimera was waiting patiently to share.

Cipher took a second cookie from the jaw and dropped it for Beagle and he awoo'd a thank you, picked the treat up, and brought it over to Fig Stew so his buddy could have two cookies. All four Demigods watched them with mild amusement, the tension in the room defused by their adorable antics.

"Lady Cipher," Castorice cleared her throat with a soft cough, and they were dialed in again, "I deeply apologize. We had no idea that you were on your way to save Lord Phainon."

"Lady Tribbie told us that he was going to be executed," Hyacine explained, "and we didn't really think past our desire to save him."

"Little red, huh?" Cipher purred. She put the lid back on the jar and passed it to her tail to hold so both paws were free to cross her arms. "Maybe the old seamstress is up to more than I gave her credit for. If you are trying to escape, why did you come here?"

"The Coreflame of Strife," Phainon answered. He stepped past Cipher to continue his search, reaching for Aglaea's desk drawers.

"She doesn't keep those in *here*," Cipher crooned.

Phainon froze. "Cipher, you know where Aglaea stores the coreflames?"

"Of course I do~ How do you think I got mine?"

"Will you tell us, Lady Cipher?" Castorice asked, "it's very urgent."

Cipher laughed, "really embracing this piracy thing, aren't you?"

"Please," Phainon insisted a little more softly, "it's for Mydei."

His earnestness caught her off guard and after a wide-eyed twitch of both ears, Cipher relaxed again. She put the chimera cookies on the desk and sighed. "Geez, you can stop with the puppy eyes, brat. Fine, I'll help you if you just stop looking so damn pathetic." He brightened immediately and she scowled. "That's worse. Turn around so I don't have to look at your face."

Phainon immediately complied and Hyacine slapped her own forehead. There was a lot of that going around tonight.

"Lady Cipher? The coreflame?"

"Follow me~"

Cipher was polite enough not to leave them in the dust as they ran through Marmoreal Palace. Late at night the baths were empty or being cleaned by the sparse few attendants on duty, but a pro thief already knew how to avoid them and not a single soul witnessed the four Demigods and two chimeras. Which meant there was no one to yell at them for running through hallways between the pools and sliding around corners in the variable humidity.

Marmoreal Palace was more than just a bath house, but the crown jewel of the complex was still the Overflowing Bath, the largest and most open of the public baths. The pool was massive with tables and fountains interspersed in the water and stretching almost the entire length of the hall. The ceiling so far above them that it was impossible to appreciate the detail in the artwork was held up by pillars wider than several trees each that lined the length of the pool. At the far side, to where they were running, the wall had long since been removed so bathers could look out across the plateau and the harbor. Had it faced Kephale, the baths may have been too warm in the direct light from the Dawn Device but angled away the bath took advantage of the indirect light to fill the space with a warm glow that rippled in the water without harming the eyes.

There was a path there past the balcony, lined with small fruit trees, carefully manicured flowers, and a small stream that wrapped around the Marmoreal Palace to a separate pavilion that was always guarded. The Chrysos Heir's bath was not open to the public and carefully removed to prevent anyone from straying in by accident. Even drunken guests would be hard pressed to get in there by mistake whether by the main path that snaked through the garden, or by any of the service entrances for approved bath attendants.

"The Heirs' bath house?" Phainon asked.

"You'll see~"

Cipher led them to one of the services entrances and the others followed her very closely. They crouched in the bushes, listening for any movement but there was nothing but the sound of insects chirping and the gentle trickle of tamed water. They still stayed low as they crossed the open yard where clean towels were drying in the light overnight and tried the door. Locked.

Cipher's tail was already swishing back and forth, the tip twitching happily as she produced a lockpick from her sleeve and expertly opened the door as though she had the key and not an illegal facsimile. "Someday I'll find something challenging to steal again."

"Like the Castrum Kremnos treasure vault?" Phainon asked.

The cat went rigid and slowly turned her head to glare at him. "*Too soon."* He offered her an apologetic smile, but she was already slipping inside.

They were standing in a neatly organized laundry room that Phainon recognized. He liked to get his towels directly from here rather than from the bins beside the bath. They were always so warm coming off the drying line outside.

"There shouldn't be any guards *inside* the bath right?" Hyacine whispered.

"Nah."

"There shouldn't be any attendants left either," Castorice reasoned.

"Not unless Aglaea is bathing," Phainon grimaced.

Hyacine winced at the thought, “that might be possible considering what happened to you.”

“She didn’t seem all that upset at the trial.”

“Lord Phainon, with respect, you of all people should know that the Lady Goldweaver does not *show* the Council how she is feeling.”

Yeah… he did know. Phainon considered instead how Aglaea had been that morning, before the Council even took him into custody. She had been very professional, very focused… but her office was still devoid of projects and her words had that hint of second guessing herself. Those were sure signs that she was having a hard time and her favorite way to relax was with a bath.

“Would she stop us if she was?” Hyacine asked.

They all considered that for a moment before Phainon confidently answered, “Yes. She’d have to.”

“I’m not so sure about that,” Cipher mumbled to herself in a sing-song cadence. Phainon shot her a suspicious look but let it slide.

“It is possible that she has already laid traps inside the vault,” Castorice cautioned, “to prevent any Chrysos Heirs from turning on her.”

“Or from retrieving coreflames they aren’t ready for,” Phainon added sadly. Hyacine also looked down, and he steeled himself at her downtrodden expression. It was so rare to see her slip out of her perfect bedside manner. “But we aren’t here for us, we’re here for Mydei.”

Fig Stew agreed with a chirp.

“If you’re done speculating,” Cipher said from where she was sitting cross-legged on a spare kline, “then we can go get your candle flame. Seamstress isn’t here. I saw her earlier in Dawncloud when I was looking for the Kremnoans.”

There weren’t a lot of reasons for her to be there this late at night. Phainon frowned at the thought, but the girls were already moving on at the good news.

The hallway was still brightly lit like it always was with Kephale’s light filtering in from the skylights above. It was pleasantly warm with a humidity that one could feel and taste but not dense enough to see. It clung to Phainon’s clothing and made him feel sticky. He couldn’t imagine how uncomfortable Cipher was with her fur. She looked like she was holding back complaints as they passed the changing rooms to get to the baths.

The water here was visibly different from the water meant for the general populace. It glittered and swirled with gold, Mnestia’s divine power, Phainon had always assumed, though Aglaea had never confirmed his suspicions she didn’t deny them either. It flowed from a spout above the centermost pool and spread to the others in tiers until all five of the circular baths nearly glowed as the light caught on the water and made it sparkle. The baths

curved around the room in a half circle surrounded by tiled walkways and in the very center of them all was a fountain.

The fountain itself was not particularly fancy. It was multi-tiered with smooth and even edges so the water would pour in quiet sheets so consistently that Phainon could almost see himself reflected in the sheen as though it were glass. Set into the floor without a raised edge or bench, the piece stood taller than Castorice but shorter than Phainon and was remarkably easy to run into. His first day, he had stepped into the shallow basin around its base and expected a firm correction, but Aglaea had smiled at his accident and waded into the fountain herself, beckoning him to feel the silk of the falling water as it splashed onto their feet.

It was that fountain that Cipher stood beside with a cheery, "Here we are~!"

She was met with blank faces.

"Oh please, you can't tell me she never brought you all here before to ask cryptic questions."

"I'm sorry, Aglaea," Phainon said, relaxed after his bath. His voice was light and happy even if she was frowning beside the fountain. "I'm not sure what I'm supposed to be feeling."

She made a harumph sound under her breath and mumbled, "it will come in time."

Phainon frowned at the memory and stepped in closer. There was a definite tug that he hadn't felt before, a sort of urgency that was hard to describe. He waded into the water and felt it immediately start soaking into his boots. They were water resistant, not water*proof,* so he expected the sudden discomfort of soggy socks and lukewarm water, but his focus was not on his own well-being right now. The driving desire to retrieve this coreflame was starting to burn inside his chest, becoming a creeping obsession, a desperate urge to get into the vault that he now knew was nearby.

Aglaea stood at the top of the spiral staircase and watched Phainon carefully with a finger pressed to her lips.

"You are certain?" she asked him.

A young Phainon nodded, weary, tired, feeling almost nothing at all and she sighed and turned away. The stairs rose as she walked towards the changing rooms, becoming one with the floor around the fountain once more.

"There's a staircase here," he said aloud as he remembered. Phainon followed the footsteps of the memory, walking over the giant, wedged tiles that circled the fountain. These were stairs, he knew they were. He stepped on each one in turn until he stood where the Aglaea in his memory once had at what should be the top of them.

"There you go," Cipher teased.

He twisted his body to match how she had stood but nothing happened at least not on the outside. The longer he stood there, the more urgent Phainon felt. It was an antsy nagging

feeling in the back of his mind, not quite a *longing* but something bordering on hunger, on a *need*.

Hyacine shifted uncomfortably and started to pace, eyes narrowed at the water. She too splashed into the fountain and dark spots appeared on her stockings where she got wet. It barely registered for her, and she didn't hesitate to feel along the edges of the layered basins, letting even more water flow along her arm to soak her sleeves and dress.

"There must be a way to open it then," she reasoned, voice strained, "Lady Aglaea must have sealed it with her threads. There must be a way to tell the threads to open!"

"Two for two!" Cipher announced.

"Lady Cipher perhaps now is not the time…" Castorice tried to say as she watched her friends with a measure of concern.

"You know how to open it, Cipher," Phainon breathed, it came out more accusatory than he intended but urgent nagging was turning into aching loneliness and a paranoia like he was forgetting something very important, something that he needed to live. There was something missing from him and it was waiting just behind this obstacle.

She sauntered over to him and snatched his hand, pulling him closer to the edge of the fountain so she wouldn't have to get wet. Cipher turned his palm up and then pushed back his sleeve to see where the chains had rubbed his wrists raw. She pressed where the skin was the thinnest, where it had already bled that night until the gold flowed anew and he hissed at her in annoyance.

"Cipher!" Hyacine scolded, voice tight.

"You wanted me to help, right?" the cat purred. She let go when Phainon recoiled, splashing in the shallow water as he retreated. Beads of blood dripped from his wrist into the water, the same color as the gold that swirled in the pools already, visually unnoticed, but something recognized it, recognized *him*. He didn't care if it was golden threads, the fountain, or Kephale themself what mattered was the shift in the tiles around the fountain as they slowly started to drop into the ground.

Phainon reached for Hyacine's hand as the tiles moved behind her and the water in the fountain spilled over the edge. She held onto him tightly and splashed her way closer to Phainon and the top of the spiral staircase.

"After you," Cipher purred.

Phainon barely heard her, his heart was already racing into the dark below. It pounded in his ears, demanding a hasty descent but reverence tempered his movements as he led the way down.

The space beneath the bath house felt primordial. It was the best way for Phainon to describe it in a single word. It was a cave first and room second with a tiled floor much the same as Okhema above, but the walls and ceiling remained natural stone, smoothed by the flow of

water many years ago that still filled the space around the circular platform and the lake beside which it was built.

Light from the open staircase refracted through the water that flowed from the fountain above, filling the room with a pale glow to rival the blue that glimmered from the depths of the small, underground lake. Bioluminescent moss grew in water so clear and still that it was hard to perceive that it was there until the ripples of the water above disturbed the surface and invited the light within to dance on the ceiling in mesmerizing patterns.

But for Phainon these observations were secondary to the singular item in the room: a deep basin resting on a pillar, filled with water to the brim, and glowing like trapped sunlight.

He paused at the bottom of the stairs and Hyacine robotically came up beside him with a whispered, “do you feel it too?”

And he knew exactly what she was talking about.

Phainon approached the basin as though it were a wild beast, something unpredictable with teeth, even as his heart screamed at him to embrace it, to dive into this bowl headfirst to willingly, happily drown. And when he peered inside and saw the coreflames resting inside, he understood why.

He slowly put both hands on the side of the basin, letting his thumbs dip into the water to feel the familiar warmth. It was sunshine on wheat fields, warm stew after a cold day, it was Mydei’s subtle smile, and the feeling of his body hovering above Phainon’s own while they sparred on a distant shore. It was the wholeness of belonging, the good ache of knowing what it means to love and be loved. It was responsibility and expectations with the support and courage to meet them all.

Tears flowed freely, something he only noticed when they dripped from his jaw to disturb the water below. It startled him and he reached to touch them with surprise, rubbing one between his thumb and forefinger as he looked back at his fellow heirs.

Hyacine was weeping too, her face full of shock and something purer, happier, like she was recalling a memory so sweet that her body couldn’t hope to contain the emotions that had built up inside her. She was shakily walking towards the basin to stand beside him to peer inside with a soft gasp that brought her hand shakily to her lips.

Phainon watched Hyacine with total understanding as he realized this shared experience was not for him alone. When he turned again to look at Castorice, she was smiling at them, standing apart with a hand held to her chest to allow them this moment that she had already experienced years ago. Cipher too was uncharacteristically quiet, sitting on the stairs to watch them with a sort of pride that only comes from one who led the way.

Aglaea’s Flame-Chase Journey had been ongoing for nearly a thousand years; its history shrouded in mysterious origins long lost to everyone aside from those that had experienced it for themselves and that was history that they treasured just the two of them. In that time, five coreflames had been discovered and given to their new bearers, three were missing, one remained with their Titan, an ally of humanity, and three were here, waiting.

The Coreflames of Strife, Sky, and Worldbearing flickered with greeting, as though they had a will of their own, as though they too could not contain their joy.

“I always thought Strife would be mine,” Phainon whispered. The shining sun symbol of Worldbearing glowed brighter at his voice. “When it chose Mydei I didn’t think… I never thought…”

“I know what you mean, Lord Phainon,” Hyacine whispered. Her voice was cracking. “It’s like a reunion… but with someone I’ve never met. How is that possible?”

Phainon’s heart reached for his coreflame and in that moment he realized what Mydei had felt in Castrum Kremnos when Phainon had tried to hand him a heartbeat, a drop of weighty power and completeness.

I don’t need the coreflame to feel whole, because I have you.

The tears dripped again as Phainon fully appreciated that statement in a way he couldn’t before, now that he knew what it felt like to be this close to his heart, and what it felt like to reject it.

When Phainon reached into the basin with both hands, spilling the water over the sides in smooth, splashing sheets, it wasn’t to get *his* coreflame, it was to get the one he came here for first, the one that belonged to the only person that made him feel whole. He cradled the Coreflame of Strife in both hands and stepped away from the basin to check it, to watch the light of it dim and glow like it was breathing. A part of him ached for his own heart still submerged, but looking at this one in his hands, Phainon realized Mydei still held a piece of him across the ocean, and the Coreflame of Worldbearing could only hope to fill that space.

I don’t need the coreflame to feel whole, because I have you. Oh, how true that was.

“You know,” Cipher called, and her voice felt too loud in the echo, “you can take all of them.”

“Aglaea…”

“Would have stopped us long ago if this was not her intent,” Castorice reminded him. When he still hesitated she added, “Lord Phainon, are we not pirates?”

Phainon looked between his fellow heirs and then back down at the Coreflame of Worldbearing. It glowed brighter under his gaze, a promise of power, a promise of deliverance. He let out a breath on the tail end of a gentle chuckle as all the puzzle pieces clicked at once.

“Of course we’ll take them,” he said gently, looking at Hyacine’s shiny wide eyes and full smile.

She hiccupped a little bit and wiped away her own tears before she reached up to catch his with a gentle touch and the voice to what he just realized himself, “Lord Phainon, I’m sure of it now. This is how we’re going to save Lord Mydei.”

Chapter End Notes

For folks worried about Hephaestion. He's gonna be okay, coughing clots is very, very different from coughing bright blood.

Chapter 37: Freely Given

Chapter Summary

New tags: Cutting
It's a reference to cutting but I know from personal experience that can be very upsetting to some readers. It's very brief and is NOT from a suicide attempt, but it IS still there as Anaxa tends to be a little cavalier with his own life. If folks read this and think I should throw up any other tags, please, please tell me. I can't predict all of my reader's discomforts but I definitely try my best!

Chapter Notes

I know I said I wouldn't pov swap outside of Phainon and Mydei very much, but I think you all will forgive me for this one. :3c

When Anaxa and Krateros entered Okhema it had been with express intent but only a fool was narrow-minded enough to resist choice opportunities as they presented themselves. With the help of a dozen men at his command and a surprisingly docile Okhema, those opportunities were too bounteous to ignore and Anaxa was eager to indulge. They had zig-zagged through town, filling sacks and bags with lots of things he *needed* and some things that he *wanted* from alchemical ingredients and curiosities to various containers, piled high on the backs of willing Kremnoans who were too enchanted by the piracy to question what he ordered them to grab.

Not that the citizens weren't willing to relinquish their goods after only a brief exchange. It *barely* counted as piracy at all when they were *giving* stuff away. Phainon's rescue was so easy to exploit. All it took was mentioning the Kremnoans and shopkeepers tripped over themselves to provide whatever Anaxa requested if it would save the Deliverer. It was so easy that he genuinely considered leveraging this newfound cheat to secure the dromas egg that he had always wanted… Alas, not the time nor place. It would be unfair to the perfect hatchling if they emerged at sea far from solid earth to eat. Besides, he had more urgent concerns, like planning three steps ahead while everyone else got them back to net zero rescuing Phainon.

Krateros was a professional and willing participant which came as no surprise. The man had no love of Aglaea, nor the Holy City and even indulged when Anaxa took the time to deface any mural or statue of her with charcoal as they passed. Nothing so violent as destroying

them of course, but he didn't mind taking the time to tease that arrogant woman as they made their way with purpose to Dawncloud.

In truth, aside from those moments where he was looking at her visage, Anaxa thought about Aglaea very little until he was finished with his primary goal and was confronted on the path to the Dawn Father by the woman herself as they were leaving the Worldbearing Altar.

What an image they made, Anaxa standing in front of a unit of Kremnoan pirates, recently stolen amphorae filled to the brim with blasphemy strapped to their backs. Even pious Krateros looked faint after what they had just done and Anaxa couldn't blame him for his anxiety, not everyone had the courage to do whatever it takes in pursuit of the unknown. The professor himself was drenched in sticky gold standing a few paces from the Goldweaver, still dripping onto the road.

"Let me guess," she crooned, her voice like a scalpel, "it's not what it looks like."

Anaxa scoffed and crossed his arms across his chest, a smirk slowly pulled one corner of his lips up into a curl as he responded with equal sharpness, "It's *exactly* what it looks like."

Her face stayed statuesque, emotionless, unchanging, but her words dripped with venom that made the Kremnoans behind him shuffle uncomfortably and tighten their grips on their spears. "You have gone too far, Anaxagoras."

"Please," he purred, "can I really be the Great Blasphemer as you so *affectionately* called me once, if I do not take action to reassert the title?"

"Defacing murals of me I can tolerate as behavior befitting a child throwing a tantrum, but cutting into the flesh of the Dawn Father? Inexcusable."

"Lord Anaxagoras," Krateros said with his voice low, quiet beside Anaxa, "if it comes to blows, it is unlikely we will be able to hold her for long."

"Relax, Krateros," he reassured the old man, "she will let us pass unhindered."

"Cocky," Aglaea accused.

"Confident," he corrected with a demeaning tut, "so much so that you can take your men and go on ahead, Krateros." The old vet seemed unsure, but Anaxa calmly extended a hand to the side to direct them around her. "She won't stop you."

Aglaea stayed quiet. Gold threads shimmered in the air, but the Kremnoans were able to cautiously pass by her with their precious cargo.

"Lord Anaxagoras," Krateros called from behind the Goldweaver.

"I will be along," the professor promised, "tell the others to wait at the ship for me."

The veteran lingered, perhaps contemplating the theme of the night: *opportunity,* as he studied the Goldweaver's back and drummed his fingertips on his sword. But that thought

lasted only for a moment before he gestured to his men and they jogged away, eventually disappearing down the road.

“I have not missed your sharp tongue and foolish arrogance, *professor*,” Aglaea enunciated sharply when they were finally alone.

“Nor I you, Aglaea. So where does that leave us? Will you bind me in your threads, execute me beside your prized Deliverer?” Her eyes moved, just a hair to the side when he mentioned Phainon and Anaxa’s half smirk spread into a full smile. “So, they already freed him. Curious how foreigners found his cell so quickly.”

“I couldn’t possibly know what you mean,” she said, dismissive, harsh, “and I don’t appreciate the accusation.”

“Oh Aglaea, Aglaea, don’t insult me.” He made a tsk, tsk sound to drive home his point.

The shadow of a smile crossed her features and then faded just as quickly when she crossed her arms. “What do you want with the blood, heretic?”

“You haven’t figured it out?” he teased, and she immediately turned it around, unphased.

“Have you?”

His smile faltered only a little bit and his arm twitched.

“Oh…” she said, the edge of her voice softened by a thread, the very same thread that Anaxa felt around his arm like the ghost of a stray hair. “You have.”

He tsked and plucked it from his sleeve, tossing it aside with a roll of his thumb and forefinger, disgusted by the intrusive nature of it. Beneath the fabric the bandages itched around his wrist.

“It’s a versatile substance,” he admitted, unwilling to give her specifics.

“Still willing to defile your own body. How much of your blood have you spilled to use for your experiments?” Aglaea prodded.

“Enough to be sure that my pinnacle creation in this ridiculous journey has been perfected. Enough to know that I am right,” he snapped, tightening his crossed arms around his chest and squeezing them tight to stop the itch, “enough to know that you have let Phainon believe a lie.”

“I have never lied to him.”

“Lies of omission are still lies,” Anaxa scolded, “he told me that it is Mnestia’s divine power, *your* power, that cleanses the Tide in the Chrysos Heirs’ bath, but it is Kephale’s blood, is it not?”

She stayed silent. A confirmation.

“And you call me a blasphemer.”

“What I use is freely given-“

“Only for the use of you and yours, eh, Aglaea? How is this any different?” he asked.

“I have never taken a blade to the holy body,” she hissed, and the edge was back to her voice.

“Add this sin to my tab,” he laughed, “these accusations are pointless. You already intend to let me go.”

She hummed, “then tell me how I came to this decision.”

“Because you know that this is the best way to see your Flame-Chase Journey come to an end,” he reasoned.

“Go on.”

For a second he considered telling her no, but when would he get the chance again to call her out and perhaps confirm a few of his theories?

“Piracy has always plagued the free peoples of Amphoreus, but you sent Phainon to investigate the Chryseus Leo, *knowing* they were Kremnoans. You knew that the young Prince of Kremnos was a Chrysos Heir and an inheritor of one of your missing coreflames,” he paused to judge her reaction, to see if he was right but she didn’t move at all, not even a twitch. “You knew that *Phainon* could convince them to retrieve Strife for you, perhaps even find a weakness in the Tide.”

She let out a soft laugh, short on a single quick exhale. It felt a little too fake, a little too scripted and lacking any authenticity. “It’s not like you to give me so much credit. You really believe I predicted this outcome? Predicted Phainon and Mydeimos’ partnership?”

“As loathe as I am to admit it, yes. I believe you saw all of this.”

“I am no seer.”

“But you *have* been watching,” he accused, “and you understand *desires,* Demigod of *Romance*. The same way you knew that I would eventually relent and take up the Coreflame of Reason and thus chose to leave it unclaimed in the Grove when the Tide swallowed the isle.” Her smile returned but she kept silent. “And there is no one else that you have so carefully watched and cared for than Phainon of Aedes Elysiae. You intend for him to take up the Coreflame of Worldbearing, do you not?”

“I do,” she purred, “and he has.”

Anaxa’s eyes narrowed a little at the declaration and then he laughed, long and loud, “I see. I am not the only opportunist in Okhema this Curtain-Fall Hour.”

Aglaea started walking, giving him plenty of space to step around him as she walked towards the Worldbearing Altar and out of his way, no longer blocking his escape.

“Aglaea,” Anaxa said sharply. He turned sideways to look at her, and she stopped walking, back still facing him. “Would you send these young Heirs to solve the riddle of the Tide on their own?”

“With someone as clever as you, have they need of me at all?” she posited, turning just enough to ensure he heard her. He huffed to himself, resisting the urge to gag at the two-faced praise.

“You know what the Tide is, don’t you?” he asked, pointed, accusing. The threads in the air gave her away, they trembled, glittering from invisible to shining gold when they caught the light.

“I… have my suspicions,” she admitted.

Anaxa studied her with a narrowed eye. “Is it related to the missing coreflames?” he asked.

Something about her changed from perfect composure to the shadow of an emotion.

“Yes,” she said, and her voice was soft and quiet, like someone about to cry. Aglaea turned more fully to him, dry-eyed and stoic her tone of voice back to emotionless and biting. “Tell me this, Grand Performer, are your motivations purely selfish?”

“Of course, I cannot pursue the topic of my personal interest until the Tide is completely removed from this world,” he confessed freely, she would be able to tell if he lied anyway.

“Because until such time your experiments on yourself are *tainted*,” she said as a matter of fact and Anaxa schooled his expression, meeting stone with stone, knowing with knowing. She was peering deep into his heart, sensing what he had kept from the others.

“I will not discuss an ongoing experiment with you.”

“Your willingness to save Mydeimos is not altruistic, you need to see what has become of him after his time fighting the Tide and what happens when he accepts his coreflame.”

“Leaving him to fight the Tide without its protection for an extended time was an unintended but ideal experiment. But he is not the only source of valuable information waiting in Castrum Kremnos,” he admitted.

“Eurypon,” she said, low and deep.

“The Mad King kept detailed descriptions of his experiments on the Strife Titan’s corruption and his observations fighting the Black Tide. It’s possible he found the answer years ago and lost himself before he could act upon it.”

“A great number of his works are not stored in Castrum Kremnos but at a library that once belonged to Gorgo,” Aglaea thought aloud and Anaxa contemplated that hint in silence.

They watched each other for a long moment while the breeze played with their hair and clothes. Kephale above bearing witness to their standoff as Anaxa confidently waited for

Aglaea to find what she was looking for and drop her threads. She must have found it because she closed her foggy eyes and turned away.

“I have nothing but faith in Phainon and the other Demigods,” she said, “make good use of what you have stolen today, heretic, you will not get more from Kephale. Hopefully you do not bleed yourself dry before you discover the truth of the Tide.”

“Would that really be such a loss?” he laughed.

“I suspect you will be more troublesome when you die,” she bit but her footsteps were light as she walked away and left him standing alone in the road.

Anaxa looked down at his hand, still bright with Kephale’s blood and his own seeping through his sleeve where the wound had opened beneath the bandages. He must have squeezed a little too hard. Oops.

“Thoughts?” he asked the air and a voice whispered beside him.

“I have to hand it to you, your theory about the Black Tide may be correct.”

“Just a little more proof, Cerces. The answer and corresponding solution are within reach.”

The Titan of Reason hummed in his ear. She had long since stopped appearing beside him, a specter only he could see and hear, but Anaxa had found in her companionship a wealth of information. She was proof that the coreflames retained limited sentience, that they were alive in a sense as a symbiotic part of their chosen Demigod, or perhaps this was simply the power of his particular coreflame, his ‘wish.’ That was the more likely explanation, but he had a few different theories, nothing to carve in stone just yet.

“Will you go the library as she suggested?”

Anaxa thought about that as he started to walk through Okhema, leaving behind squelching footprints as he passed the Dawncloud guards that had already been rendered unconscious the first time they had passed. “Why not? I’m sure it would not be difficult to convince the captain to make a detour after we rescue the Crown Prince.”

“If there’s anything left to rescue…”

“I would invite you to have faith, but the irony would make me sick,” Anaxa laughed, mumbling to his coreflame, “from a *logical* standpoint we have no reason to believe he is lost. We’ve already proven between the two of us that the River of Souls has a cleansing effect on the dead. An immortal Kremnoan Prince has the best chance of surviving without succumbing to the Tide song.”

“And what of his humanity? Enduring such repeated agony?”

“Ah, yes, I suppose how much of *that* remains we will have to witness for ourselves.”

-

The temptation to take the coreflame into himself was not as powerful as Phainon had thought. Simply carrying the Coreflame of Worldbearing was enough to feel a measure of comfort and completeness but whether it was because he carried his own heart or Mydei's it was impossible to tell, and he honestly didn't care. What mattered was that both coreflames were tucked carefully into a laundry bag slung over his shoulder and held tightly to his chest.

Hyacine was loathe to part with the Coreflame of Sky and carried it herself while Little Ica kept trying to sniff at it. She too wanted to contemplate the implications of this power calling them before she took it into herself.

Phainon had expected Cipher and Castorice to be pushy about their ascensions but neither of them teased or insisted either way. Cipher especially was shockingly reserved when she was facing a very serious topic, and it gave Phainon reassurance that he was making the right decision to wait.

But hadn't he waited enough?

As they hurried through the familiar city streets and back alleys, faster than a walk, slower than a run, Phainon slowed down to consider that heartbeat in his hands. The glow of the two coreflames was clearly visible through the weave of the canvas sack, happy to be along for the journey, but he couldn't stop thinking of the many times where Aglaea had asked him if he felt anything and he hadn't. He bathed in those shimmering pools daily, sometimes twice a day if he felt particularly sticky after a workout and until *today* he had never felt the pull of a piece of him literally under his feet.

"Why now?" he wondered aloud and the three girls ahead of him paused to give him their attention. He caught up in a few long strides and stopped beside them.

"Why what now?" Cipher asked.

"If the coreflames choose their bearers through time and it has always been mine, why now?" He looked up at Cipher for the answer, and she seemed contemplative, like she was worried she might say the wrong thing if she spoke too soon. Something in the way she searched his face, her eyes darting back and forth before settling on the coreflame in his arms, worried him. She was rarely this serious, this thoughtful. He'd take a joke at this point.

"Because you need it now," she said simply.

"And I didn't need it before?" he asked, genuine, pleading, "if I had already been a Demigod when Mydei and I-"

"Then what?" Cipher growled, "what *exactly* would be different? And don't give me any of this 'oh he'd be safe!' nonsense, because you don't know that." She got in close when he looked down, arching her back and leaning in so she could stay in his line of sight. "Would you have been able to bond as equals?" she asked and Phainon's mouth fell open to answer before it shut again when words failed him. "That adventure that you told the whole city about, yes, don't seem so surprised, I heard *every* word, do you really believe any of that would have happened if you had that light in your chest? Do you really believe you could *appreciate* this power, this *responsibility* if you hadn't struggled to be worthy of it? Trust me,

timing matters and the *truth* is that you *don't know for sure* what would have been different, and it doesn't really matter does it? You have it *now*, it sees you *now.*"

"Well said, Little Ciphy!"

All four of them almost jumped out of their skins.

"Hehe, surprised you didn't I?" Trianne greeted them as she settled both feet on Phainon's shoulders and her hands on top of his currently dusty, silver hair.

"Hello, Lady Trianne," Castorice and Hyacine said in tandem.

At their feet Fig Stew started to growl until Beagle pulled his tail and after a brief exchange of awoos and paw waving, Fig Stew was okay with this new friend and chirped a greeting.

"Snowy, are you worried about your coreflame?" she asked. She stood on his shoulders and leaned over his head to look at him upside down.

"Uh… It's not that teacher," he stammered, "I was just wondering why it waited so long to choose me, if it already knew."

"You weren't ready yet silly!"

"Surely it is not that simple, Trianne…" Phainon tried to argue.

She tilted her head, and it was a miracle her flower ornaments stayed attached to her hair upside down like that. "Why not? Aren't some things that simple?"

Maybe it was the way she said it in her little kid voice or that she was the *first* Demigod and was misleadingly ancient, but something about that statement just clicked. *Maybe it was just that simple.* Phainon *simply* hadn't been ready until now.

"Coreflames are really cool," she told him. Trianne flew over his head to sit on his arm instead and he held it out for her to be comfortable facing him like the weirdest bird ever. "They give you special powers and make your wishes come true so it's really important that the people who get coreflames have good wishes!"

"I've always had good wishes…" he pouted.

She put her gloved hands on each cheek and pushed them together to squish his lips and then she tugged on them to stretch them out. "Yeah, but Agy still had to teach you important things first. And you had to learn some important things for yourself first!"

"A-Am I the same way, Lady Trianne?" Hyacine asked, nervous.

"Yup!" she answered cheerfully, "think of all the things you learned Little Cinny that you can put to even *better* use now! There's joy in the journey!"

Aglaea had said once that she had known about her coreflame and wasn't ready for a while to receive it, that it took her some time to learn what it meant to be the Inheritor of Romance.

She had genuinely believed that knowing there was a coreflame waiting for her had made her miserable and probably delayed her ascension as a Demigod.

He thought about how easy it would be for Aglaea to use her powers to shortcut her dressmaking but still chose to do everything by hand. He could picture an impatient and frustrated young Aglaea pricking her fingers on needles, swearing at stiff fabric, stressing over colors, wanting her coreflame for the shortcut and learning instead to love the process.

Phainon was looking at this coreflame as a shortcut, as an answer, and it was, but if he had it before this journey had started… it was like Cipher had said, he never would've bonded with the crew, never would've fallen in love. It would have been a very different story, one lacking in personal growth. The person he was when he left Okhema was not the same person that held the coreflame now, that was ready to appreciate it as a comforting tool and not the end all, be all fix.

"If someone with good wishes gets a coreflame before they're ready, bad things happen…" Trianne insisted. She stopped playing with Phainon's cheeks and instead fussed over his hair and the dirty streaks on his face.

"What kind of bad things?" Hyacine asked.

Trianne held a finger to her lips and frowned, eyes squinting as she struggled to retrieve a particularly distant memory. "I don't remember…"

Had it happened before? Was that why Aglaea had been so careful with him and Hyacine? Castorice had taken her coreflame almost immediately after they had retrieved it together, but she was also considerably older than Phainon. Cipher had stolen her coreflame but as the Demigod of Trickery perhaps that was all the coreflame really wanted to see from her to decide she was worthy. Every coreflame was different, with different powers and unique manifestations for their bearers.

"But that's enough about that!" Trianne insisted, already happily moving on, "you're ready now and the coreflames chose both of you! More importantly, I'm here with a special delivery!"

Cipher's tail swished back and forth excitedly. "Oh? Why didn't you lead with that Little Red?"

"It's not for you, Ciphy!"

The cat was notably less interested now. "Oh. Boring."

Trianne hopped off Phainon's arm and landed right in the middle of their haphazard circle of Chrysos Heirs. She searched her pockets with little hands and then pulled out a way too big of a box from the left side of her dress. If the Flame-Chase didn't work out, the Demigod of Passages could do very well working birthday parties. The box was almost the size of her head, wrapped in bright red paper with a big yellow bow holding it closed. She set it down in front of Phainon.

“Agy said that you needed this,” Trianne said cheerfully, “sorry, Little Cas, Little Cinny, Little Ciphy, if you break your things then maybe we will have something for you next time too!”

Castorice held her hands up to her mouth to hide her unladylike snort when she held in a laugh.

“Break something?” Phainon asked with a pout.

Trianne was already opening the box, letting the yellow ribbon fall across Beagle and Fig Stew who happily chased and batted at it, oblivious to the rest of the happenings there in the middle of a tiny, sleepy alleyway courtyard in Okhema. She pulled the lid off with a cheerful, “ta da!”

Just like her pockets, the box was much bigger on the inside, making use of their powers, their wishes, to bring to Phainon a replacement set of clothes. He pulled the pauldron out and held it up to the torn one on his shoulder with a sigh.

“I looked ridiculous up there today didn’t I?” he asked.

“Yes,” Cipher said immediately.

“Little Ciphy!”

Cipher stuck out her tongue.

“You look like you’ve been on a long journey, Lord Phainon,” Castorice reassured him, completely glossing over how tidy the girls looked. They had been on the same ship and looked just fine.

He crouched down to run his fingers over the neatly folded fabric, identical to what he was wearing aside from the character. This pair of pants didn’t have lopsided hand stitching from where a piece of wood had torn through it and into his leg during a storm. This new coat didn’t have a tiny hole from an arrow that went into his back defending Krateros. The cape was whole and shiny, not torn at the bottom where a Black Tide monster had ripped it. The leather straps and buckles were shiny and perfect having not had to endure the salty sea spray. It just wasn’t *him*, without those memories.

It wasn’t that Phainon liked looking a little worn, but the pauldron was the only thing he kept, tucking that into his bag. It was the only piece of his armor that was detrimental to its effectiveness when torn and he would be wise to replace it but the rest…

“Thank you, Trianne, but this outfit I’m wearing was given to me by someone I respect,” he said with a warm smile, “and I’m quite fond of it.” He thought he sounded sweet with just the right amount of heroic sentimentality and that signature wide smile.

“Agy said you broke your sword,” she said blandly in response, and he turned red.

“Well, I, yeah…”

Trianne pushed him back to his feet and shooed him away from the box so she could dig around inside, shoving clothes out of the way to grab the hilt of a sword that was buried towards the bottom of the magical gift. She had to fly to pull it all the way out.

Phainon recognized it immediately. Well, sort of, it looked like a better version of the idea he had sketched when he was working for Chartonus, the master smith in town. This was the sword that he had been trying to earn enough cash to commission!

It was a greatsword nearly as tall as he was with a wide blade and balanced grip. The fuller had been dyed the same blue as his cape, like the sky above Kephale. The treatment of the blade had left it in various stages of gradient from the shining silver tip to a dark gray around the golden hilt and stylized guard, designed to look like a sun curving over the full length of the black leather grip to the gold pommel.

Cipher whistled.

“Trianne,” Phainon whispered, it was hard to breathe looking at it, “I barely managed the first payment, I can’t afford this…”

“Please take it from, Trianne at least!” she whined. Her little wings were straining to hold it up and he hurried to take it from her. It was the perfect weight, the exact right balance, and it just felt *right.* He studied it in awe and couldn’t help giving it a few experimental spins.

“This is how Lord Phainon looks at Lord Mydei,” Hyacine observed with a giggle as she stepped backwards to give him space to play with his new toy. He immediately felt self-conscious.

“Chartonus said to tell you that it’s called Dawnmaker,” Trianne instructed, “and that it’s already been paid for.”

“But I didn’t,” he started to say but Trianne cut him off by shoving a note against his lips.

“Please take it, Snowy,” she insisted with a pleading whine.

He pulled the note away and opened it with his thumb to read it. It was short and simple, and it played the strings of his heart with expert precision. The warmth in his chest spread to his fingers and toes and his throat clenched tight when he tried to swallow around the new light-headedness. He tucked the small strip of paper inside his coat pocket with reverence.

“Alright, Trianne, I will. Thank you for delivering it to me,” he said genuinely. The sword vanished in a shower of blue, tucked away and waiting to be summoned when he called for it again.

“Aaaany other crises waiting in the wings?” Cipher grumbled.

“Nope!” the red head announced.

“Not you, Little Red, I’m asking the pirates.” Castorice shook her head. Hyacine checked with Little Ica and then they both shook theirs in unpracticed tandem. “Well, Deliverer? Anything else you’d like to second guess before skipping town?”

Phainon looked down at Fig Stew and Beagle Coconut. They both awoo'd at him in encouragement.

He put his hand over the coreflames and said resolutely, "No. Let's get back to the ship."

-

Phainon wasn't surprised to see that he and the girls were the last ones to make it to the Chryseus Leo. Entry Hour was fast approaching, and the ship was already getting ready to leave, just waiting for their wayward captain and friends. What *was* surprising was the suspicious collection of new cargo sitting on the deck. It was the first thing Phainon noticed when he stepped on the deck and bid the girls goodnight.

Anaxa was standing next to many various antique and replica amphorae that were sealed tight but still had gold around the seal and splashed over the sides. There were fingerprints everywhere and the whole situation just looked *bad.* Collecting whatever that was, it *looked* like blood, oh Kephale that is so much blood, please do not be blood, must have been a messy hassle.

"Professor?" Phainon asked as he beelined over.

"Oh, good, you're safe," Anaxa greeted, monotone, bored, covered in yep, that's blood.

"What in Kephale's name is this?" he asked, gesturing to the jars and to Anaxa.

"Don't ask questions you don't want the answer to."

"Where did you get these jars? Did you steal these?"

"I'm not repeating myself."

Dumbfounded, Phainon had no idea where to even begin addressing this, but his first mate came to his rescue. Phainon turned when Krateros coughed twice into a closed fist to get his attention and directed his questioning gaze to the old man instead, but Krateros just shook his head and hurried to change the subject by physically leading Phainon away by the arm.

"It's good to have you back, captain," he said, "your orders?"

Phainon shook his head to clear the lingering fog, the exhaustion of the day was quickly catching up but he very clearly told Krateros, "get us going towards Castrum Kremnos. Where is Hephaestion?"

"In the infirmary, Perdikkas said to tell you that Hephaestion is fine but needs his rest."

"We all could use some of that," Phainon said with a laugh.

Krateros at least cracked a small smile and nodded once in agreement and then he was stepping away to bark orders. The wind was favorable; they'd all be able to sleep when Okhema was in their wake.

Phainon walked up the stairs to the top deck with the coreflames so he could watch the city get smaller behind them. As tired as he was, there was still a longing to look back both literally and figuratively. There was a haunting sort of feeling now looking at Kephale and the Dawn Device, a sort of kinship that Phainon would never have considered before he was holding the Coreflame of Worldbearing. It was a heart of a past being, given to Phainon to share. Talk about big shoes to fill.

“Well, I wish I could say it’s been fun, but you did leave me hanging,” Cipher said. She was in the shrouds, hanging upside down to be nose to nose with Phainon as he stood near the railing.

“You’re leaving already?” he teased.

“Uh, yeah, duh, I’d much rather be somewhere *dry*,” she hummed.

“Cipher, if you’re leaving, I actually need a favor,” Phainon said sheepishly.

“After *standing me up*?”

Cipher feigned annoyance but he saw the way her tail swished, content, excited at the prospect of something interesting to do.

“It’s important.”

“Alright, alright, let’s hear it.”

“The Kremnoan people are marching to Okhema,” he told her, “at my insistence.”

She whistled through her teeth and slipped through the gaps in the shroud to be upright, hanging above the deck from her hands for a moment before dropping to the deck without a sound. “You were counting on that coreflame to end the war,” she supplied, “so the city would take them as refugees.”

He nodded and rested his hand over Strife. It was colder than the other coreflame, flickering faintly, desperate to keep burning while its owner struggled on his own so far away.

“The Black Tide has taken their home twice and now they’re heading towards a city that will assume the worst.” Phainon could hear the grief in his own voice, feel the exhaustion as he thought of Chironome and the others.

“You need someone with quick feet to keep the world from burning down before you have a chance to fix it.”

“I’m really counting on you, Cipher.”

“Of course you are,” she teased, still playful, still purring. “Some things never change. Don’t worry about them, go save the man who gave you his heart and when you do, don’t forget to *unlock that damned door*.”

He winced and then promised, “I will. Cipher, take care of yourself.”

“I’m supposed to be saying that to you, brat. Try not to have *too* much fun when you finally eat that coreflame,” she teased and then she was gone.

Phainon sighed and looked over at Fig Stew. The chimera had followed him up to the top deck and jumped on top of his favorite crate to show Beagle Coconut the best sunning spot on the ship. The gray chimera had a harder time climbing up there but he made it after a couple of leaps.

“She never did like long goodbyes,” Phainon sighed, “I’m sure she got it from you.”

He reached over and scratched Vigethos’ chin, around his horns and then down to his scruff to pull the golden thread out from behind the chimera’s collar.

“She did, didn’t she, Aglaea?” he told the thread. Phainon pinched it between his two fingers as he leaned over the railing and watched the city shrink. The coreflames pulsed brightly through the bag over his shoulder and he patted them gently with his free hand before retrieving the note from his coat pocket to read it again.

He read it a third time, then once more, committing it to memory before folding the tiny piece of paper up and wrapping the golden thread around it. He pressed the bundle to his lips.

“From the moment you took me in, until now, thank you, for everything,” he whispered and then he held his hand out and let go. The same wind that pushed them forward into deeper waters snatched up the note and dropped it into the sea.

They were pirates after all. He couldn’t let the Goldweaver see what happened next.

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I am, and always have been, proud of you, Phainon. You were always worthy of the title. -A

Chapter 38: Again

Chapter Summary

No new tags but please mind the ones that are already there

Welcome back, Mydeimos

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There were a lot of things that didn't matter anymore when Mydei threw Phainon to safety and blocked the man from returning.

The passing of time was a big one. With the sky above Castrum Kremnos permanently full of black clouds and rolling thunder, each Entry Hour passed by without acknowledgement nor fanfare. He had no concept of mealtimes, no time to rest or sleep, there was no reason to count the passing of weeks or years, because he had no idea how long he had been fighting, and it simply didn't matter.

How many times he had died was another silly nonissue to forget. The first time the Tide gutted him, he considered starting a count, but something about the thought filled him with anxiety more than humor and he didn't need that weight on his chest. Unnecessary baggage like that would ruin the fun of an otherwise good fight.

It was getting easier to ignore the constant hum of the Tide Song in the back of his mind, the volume adjusted on its own with every death. If Mydei paused to listen to it, he could sing the lyrics by heart. He didn't understand them, but he could feel the underlying message: *give up, join us, so you won't be lonely again.* But even that too was something that simply didn't matter anymore.

What an absurd request. Giving up was never on the table, it wasn't even a temptation because of the only thing that *did* matter, and that was Phainon. Of course, Mydei wanted to protect his people and crew too, but Phainon was at the forefront of every second of this struggle that would surely last through the eternities.

However long it takes.

Every time he died it was with Phainon's name on his lips. Every time he sucked in air again he was calling for his Deliverer. Every long swim upstream through the River of Souls was spent picturing Phainon's goofy grin until he couldn't quite remember the details of his smile anymore. But even *that* didn't matter as long as he held tightly to what it felt like to be side by side with the person he loved most in this world and any world after.

It was the heart of those memories that tried desperately to fill the void inside his chest, that eternal ache that hurt worse than every broken bone, every gasp for air, and stabbing wound. Phainon had been right about the coreflame. It was truly a missing part of him, a near literal removal of a part of his chest. It was a pain that he felt like he could speak to, especially after the second time sharp claws ripped his still beating heart from him and threw his body aside to break on the dilapidated remains of his homeland.

But Mydei had also been right when he pushed it away and made the lofty and perhaps naïve claim that the coreflame couldn't compare to Phainon and the feeling of completeness that he had around the man, like a piece of him that he had never known was missing had come home. Which was why the pain was so immense now, fighting the Tide, because not only was his coreflame gone, but so was Phainon.

When his throat was slit and his body grew cold Mydei could imagine the feeling of Phainon's warm frame wrapped around him, trying to protect what was left of that life before it faded away with his capable arms.

The first time the Tide had pinned him to the ground and choked him to death, he had felt phantom tears on his cheeks and a tight squeezing in his chest as though someone were mourning him and holding Mydei tightly to keep him together.

When his legs had been severed and tossed to the side, leaving him to bleed out yet again, he thought he heard music, not the Tide song, but the soft tenor of Peucesta's lullabies. A memory he was sure, but he had felt the melody deep in the void that had once been his heart.

When he was choking on the ash of monsters he had defeated, buried under the severed limbs of the Tide's kraken, panting, exhausted, he could feel the fears of the people he loved, their worry for him carried over the waters, and Mydei fought harder to reassure them and himself that this was nothing. Their worries were wasted on him. How could they forget so easily the joy that Mydei felt in battle? His only regret was not sharing it with the person he loved!

He prayed that those silly sentiments would carry across the waters, that Phainon would be the smart, strong, noble Deliverer that he had seen every day of their journey together. He knew that the man would be okay, that Perdikkas and Hyacine would see him well again and that he would step up to this request that Mydei had made of him. There was no one better to take care of his people while Mydei corrected their mistake.

It was his idea to retrieve the Coreflame of Strife. Had he known that Nikador was the last line of defense, would he have taken a different path for Phainon's redemption? No. Nikador was not themself at the end.

Even if it was not the Tide's corruption, Nikador was not the Titan of eld from stories anymore. Whether it was Eurypon's influence or something else entirely, Nikador had still become something rabid that needed to be put down. If the Tide had not kept the Titan's attention for such a long time, that spear would undoubtedly have torn across Amphoreus. That same spear that ripped through Mydei's belly and left him dying, again and again as the Tide played with its new toys.

I swear on my own golden blood that I will give a thousand of my own lives to celebrate this triumph beside you all.

He meant every word. Mydei's arms and legs were shaking as he revived. The Tide still clung to his spirit, he felt so heavy. Each death purged much of the corruption, but he could still hear the song when he stood again. His boots were caked in the blood of past partings, turned into a paste when the gold met ash. They weighed him down more than the flashing memories of a traumatic childhood.

Whether the Tide knew of his history fighting tentacled creatures in his youth or not he did not know but it gleefully took this form, enjoying every fight as he lost more and more of himself to his personal demon.

All weakness, grief, and grudges will be settled on the battlefield.

They were his mother's words that he had repeated over the years, but every time he threw crystal at that monster's beak and ripped into squishy flesh with his claws it was hard to let that weakness go. He was a kid again, flailing wildly, little more than a monster himself, a beast in the water, drowning, drowning and then it grabbed his ankle and threw him against the Sword of Strife, snapping his neck.

He was dead, again, before he hit the ground.

Get up, my son!

Mydei spat at the monster as it roared at him, getting frustrated. His wounds were knitting back together. It itched but he paid the process no mind, such little pains meant nothing to the lion of Kremnos. The kraken roared and squealed, a sound that was grating and unnatural above the ocean surface like a spear scraping against smooth marble. The kind of noise that you felt in your teeth. Sometimes it would retreat and send monsters to entertain Mydei in its stead, but it always came back, reaching for him eventually.

He stomped on the tentacle that slithered towards his foot and crystal erupted around it, spearing up the arm and holding the beast tight while he grabbed for another wriggling limb to rip it free in a gush of ink and song.

On and on they fought and Mydei left more and more of himself behind, freeing himself of the past to embrace that excitement that flowed in the veins of every Kremnoan when they look their end in the eye and greet it with glee.

Fight for that future, and when fate's inescapable grasp comes for you, resist it with the strength of your mighty will.

He laughed as he grabbed a piece of Phainon's broken blade from the ground. It cut into his hand, but he couldn't feel it through the bloodlust, through the excited high of an eternal battle and when the kraken came for him again he met it eagerly.

Mydei didn't know how long he had been fighting this time when the sky above rent in two. He was too focused on fighting his monster to notice the change until the kraken was

recoiling from the light. The clouds above ripped open as though they had been cut with fine shears and multi-colored light poured across Castrum Kremnos, illuminating the city of warriors in a way that it had not seen since Eurypon's fall.

The light was blinding but rejuvenating and Mydei threw himself at the Tide with renewed vigor, ripping and tearing like a rabid animal even when another beast joined him at his side. He could see the flash of gold and blue in the corner of his eye, an angelic creature of grace and destruction with beautiful wings, a long pair of tails, and a golden halo. Mydei could feel its heat when he dashed in close and with it came explicit joy and a surge of competitive elation. Bruised, bleeding, and broken, he launched himself at the kraken's face to tear at its eyes while it screamed until a massive sword ripped across its body and its form frayed at the edges, slowly turning to ash.

It thrashed, throwing Mydei to the ground beneath the Blade of Fury where he felt his body break further, but he still stumbled to his feet with wild eyes and a toothy grin to spit blood and watch the kraken in its death throes. And as it faded so did he. The relief of a battle well fought, the end of a struggle paid for with many lives was often followed by exhaustion. It was not unexpected.

"Mydei!" a familiar voice shouted, and with one word he was himself again.

The Prince chuckled as his knees buckled, and he collapsed onto a strong and warm arm, a presence that flooded his dull senses with familiarity, comfort, and wholeness.

"I was prepared to fight til the end of time," he rasped around his broken throat as those arms gently lowered his body and rolled him to face the sky. They held him close, supporting his head and shoulders, not letting him touch the ground. Phainon was hard to see through his blurred vision, he looked different, but he *felt* the same.

Mydei reached up with a shaking hand to press his palm to Phainon's cheek and felt soft lips on his fingers. Someone else was shouting far away but black was creeping in along his vision and nothing else really mattered than what was here in front of him.

"What took you so long, Deliverer?" he sighed with the breath he had left.

And then, he died.

-

Mydei stood on the shore of the River of Souls. He needed to get back, to defy death once more but… he was tired.

He didn't dare sit, lest he decide to stay, but knowing that the battle was over for now, that his body was in Phainon's arms, brought a measure of peace. As eager as he was to return his spirit to that man's side, Mydei was also exhausted and needed a moment to himself, to pick up the pieces that had been torn from his body and scattered across the battlefield. He needed this silence to put aside cohesive thought and simply *be* before the weight of who he was fell upon his shoulders again.

The air was cold here, quiet. Sometimes the spirits of the dead whispered to him as they haunted the fields of flowers that lined the shore. He had long surmised that this was where he visited in his dreams. Where he had talked to his mother in his youth.

Perhaps if he lingered here long enough she would appear, and he could tell her about their adventure, the things he had learned, and even the things he had yet to consider the weight of. Would she be upset with him for giving away the Coreflame of Strife? Would she be proud to know he did it for Phainon?

“Valorous death before glorious return. My son, you refused to fall in combat and insist on returning to the mortal world. Do you still dare call yourself a Kremnoan?”

The voice was muddled, more of a lingering thought than a true phantom. Mydei didn’t turn around. He recognized Eurypon’s words, this was not the first time he had heard them.

“Think you still have the right to sit upon the throne of the great kingdom you destroyed? I don’t think so.”

“…shut up,” Mydei mumbled. It was hard to talk down here; it took too much of his strength to fight the pull of abyss.

“Since when did the Kremnoans grow so weak as to become someone else’s quiet support? After all, you and I both thrive on strife and fear…”

For a moment, Mydei considered entertaining his father, asking why he did what he did. What drove a great King to sacrifice his only son? Maybe he would answer this time. Or maybe that too didn’t matter anymore.

“Get lost.”

Mydei gathered himself then and waded into the water, starting the journey upstream back to the world of the living, shrugging aside his father’s taunting, that madness that followed him even unto death. He needed to get back to Phainon, to the crew. Mydei still didn’t know how many, if any, survived their assault on the city. How long had it even been?

Don’t stop moving forward. I don’t remember ever teaching you to be “weak.”

The cold pulled at his muscles, stung at every cut, but still he swam until the cold of the afterlife gave way and Mydei felt warm again.

He kept his eyes closed. Mydei didn’t have the energy to open them. He couldn’t move his arms or legs, trapped in the limbo of someone not quite ready to wake up, so he didn’t. There was a voice, Phainon’s voice, he couldn’t understand it from this far away, but it was all-encompassing comfort. He could feel the rock of the ship and fur under his hand, both hands… that was curious… and smell sweet things. It was enough to feel safe, so he slept.

When Mydei finally felt the exhaustion fade away and wakefulness gave him the strength to open his eyes he focused first on the familiar. The ceiling above was that of his home at the Kremnoan Settlement, at least what he could see of it in the gaps between pinions and the

limited light. He was surrounded by dark blue and bronze-gold feathers belonging to a pair of wings that had encompassed him and the person he was lying against as though they alone could keep out the world.

There was a heartbeat that was not Mydei's own, beating strong and solid against his back inside a broad chest that rose and fell rhythmically with each deep breath between whispers. Phainon was spooning Mydei, keeping him close, letting him rest on his back across Phainon's belly and chest while he read aloud in Kremnoan from their favorite book by candlelight. Mydei could follow along with where he was at with his eyes as Phainon used Mydei's blanket covered chest to rest his arm holding up the book so he could keep the man secure while passing the time. One of his arms was wrapped in clean bandages, all the way from the wrist to the middle of his forearm, but it didn't seem to bother him as he turned the page.

Mydei's own arms were at his sides, bent slightly at the elbows where two chimeras, Fig Stew, and one he had never seen before had curled up with him on either side. Why they preferred his hard musculature over the plush of the cushions surrounding them he'd never know. Phainon had created a sort of nest out of bedding, far more than Mydei usually kept in the big room, but this was more enjoyable than the bedroom he supposed as he listened to Phainon's horrible pronunciations butchering his favorite parts and smelled the light breeze as it passed over the balcony and into the open room. If he closed his eyes to listen, he could hear others snoring softly and knew that despite Phainon's efforts to create a private bubble for them, his other friends were nearby as well.

He tilted his head back and looked up at the underside of Phainon's chin. The man was wearing sleepwear, a light chiton and clasp-less chlamys over his shoulders like a shawl. His hair was clean and still damp from a recent bath, glowing in the candlelight. He could see it fanning over his ears like misplaced fine down. It made Mydei realize his own hair was damp too, cool against his scalp.

Mydei reached up with a hand to gently brush his knuckles along Phainon's jaw, and the man finished his sentence, he *actually* finished the sentence before he closed the book with one hand and looked down at Mydei.

There it was, the smile that Mydei had fallen in love with. The one that carried him so many times from death to life. He ghosted the rough pads of his fingertips against Phainon's temple and cheek. He looked so tired, how long had they been apart?

Mydei wordlessly sat up, letting the still sleeping chimeras roll away to snore on the pillows, and the wings fluttered around them, Phainon's wings. They loosened around the pair to give Mydei space but only just enough to not feel claustrophobic as he turned around. Phainon was unwilling to remove the feathers entirely, leaving them curled in a way that was selfish, to keep Mydei to himself. He twisted to rest on his knees between Phainon's legs, and the blanket fell off his shoulders, leaving his chest and shoulders bare.

Phainon pulled a leg up, bending at the knee so he could nudge Mydei's side, perhaps a little playful, definitely grounding, possessive even, and he felt warmth in his cheeks that spread to his ears and chest. He set aside the book, leaving it on the blanket with a hand still resting

over its aging pages. The other reached up to catch a lock of Mydei's hair, giving it a gentle tug.

Mydei very slowly reached for Phainon's face with both hands and coaxed him into sitting up and away from the pillows he was propped up against, eager to meet him on equal ground where they belonged together. He sat back on his heels and gently traced Phainon's lips, under his eyes, and along his jawline with his fingertips until Phainon melted into one palm, leaning into where Mydei cradled him with his fingers wound in silken strands and his thumb resting on the soft space beside Phainon's blushing ear and cheek. The other hand brushed the bangs away from Phainon's eyes so he could see them better, to ponder how much Phainon had changed since he had seen him last.

The blue of them flashed gold and Mydei blinked and tensed in surprise, a movement that made Phainon look down. His wings fluttered and drooped to lay flat against the blankets and cold floor and he raised a hand to tenderly grab Mydei's wrist to pull away as though ashamed, but Mydei held tighter, firmly tilting his head back with the press of fingertips against the underside of his chin until their eyes met again.

"It's still you," Mydei whispered, so softly he thought his voice might break, "I can tell, it's still you."

Phainon's eyes turned shiny, and the threat of tears started to bead at the corner of his eyes and Mydei couldn't wait anymore. He tilted forward at the same time as Phainon and their lips met, softly testing the waters, but building in confidence with every racing heartbeat. Phainon's hands moved to Mydei's shoulders sliding up his neck to hold him at the hinges of his jaw, keeping him close even when they parted for breath, their foreheads pressed tight and noses still touching.

Mydei's fingers tingled, and his chest felt tight, no, *full.* There was a bubbling warmth in his stomach that rivaled the heat between them and made him want to wiggle in place, run around the building, or hit something, at this point it was a toss up which one he wanted more. All he knew was that he was full to bursting with love and adoration and couldn't keep the little gasping chuckles from escaping between breaths. The smile on his face was hurting his cheeks but he couldn't stop drinking Phainon in.

He memorized every blink, every stray hair that got in his face, the little breathy giggles that tumbled from his lips, the way Phainon looked at him with those eyes that couldn't decide if they wanted to be blue or shine like golden sunlight. They could talk about that later, when Mydei returned to the earth from this heaven he had found himself in, this heaven he never believed he'd get to hold again. He had resigned himself to fighting forever, to be alone, oh how happy he was to be proven wrong.

"Mydeimos," Phainon mumbled with Kremnoan pronunciation and Mydei couldn't help but kiss him again. One of his hands drifted deeper into Phainon's hair to gently hold him by the roots, to keep this man where he wanted him, as their lips parted and closed with inexperienced but eager kisses. He tightened his grip, just enough to pull a gasp from that pretty mouth and was rewarded with Phainon's soft tongue licking across his lips with a shy, boyish expression that made Mydei's heart race.

“My disobedient, ridiculous puppy,” Mydei mumbled in his native language as he let go of Phainon’s hair to press his thumb to his Deliverer’s lips, “I told you to leave me, could you not obey me even the once?”

Phainon reached up to take Mydei’s wrist, pulling it away to reverently kiss his palm. “Not even once.”

Mydei leaned in again to kiss him, but Phainon put a hand on his chest and pushed him back. Those wings fluttered up again, encompassing, not wanting Mydei to leave but keeping him at arms-length for some reason and Mydei tilted his head, confused at the response.

“I’m still mad at you,” Phainon explained.

“Mad enough to kiss me?”

“*That* was because I missed you.”

Mydei sighed and let his hands fall away from Phainon to rub his own face. He was still sore, he felt clean, but the ache of fighting still lingered. “You are angry because I did not let you stay and fight…”

“I’m angry because you didn’t give me the chance to say it back.”

He looked up at Phainon with unwarranted surprise. The man had kissed him, they had *just* kissed, surely that was enough for him to know that Phainon shared these feelings with him. But Phainon looked genuinely upset, like there was more than just this single thing on his mind.

“Phainon…” He brushed his knuckles against Phainon’s cheek. To his relief, Phainon did not recoil.

“I wanted to say it first,” he grumbled, “and you didn’t give me the chance to say it all.”

“I’m sorry,” Mydei said gently, “would you like to say it now?”

“No,” Phainon pouted.

“Then I will say it again.”

Phainon’s hand slapped over Mydei’s mouth, and he chuckled before kissing it as Phainon had done for him.

“When I can do it right,” Phainon promised, “I’ll say it out loud.”

He took his hand back and Mydei chased it with his own to clasp his rough fingers in their laps between them with his own. “Deliverer-“

“Not now, Mydei. It’s late, there will be time to answer all your questions in the morning.”

“Allow me a few?” the Prince asked, “so that I can rest more easily.”

Phainon visibly contemplated that and then nodded.

“How many did we lose?” Mydei asked softly, and they both crashed back to reality. It took Phainon a moment of puzzling. The candlelight over his shoulder made his hair glow along the fringes like a halo as he struggled to answer and Mydei got the sense that more time had passed than he realized, enough at least for Phainon to have to distinguish between events to understand the context of the question.

“Seven,” he answered sadly, “we lost seven the day we slew Nikador.”

Mydei’s gut twisted in knots as he asked, “and since that day?”

“None.”

He sighed, relieved it was not worse, and then shakily asked, “who?”

Mydei listened carefully as Phainon told him the names of his crewmates that gave their lives in combat, who undoubtedly joined that great blade in the sky that Nikador would never again wield. Names that Phainon had memorized, taking his role as captain very seriously in Mydei’s absence. His heart swelled with pride knowing that he had picked well and while he silently wished his fallen crewmates glory in their passing, he knew they would not tolerate mourning, especially from their Prince.

“How long has it been?” he asked next.

Phainon swallowed, the bob of his throat distracting as he said, “Twenty-seven Entry Hours, give or take a couple. Ptolemy kept better track than I did.”

Mydei slumped forward, his forehead resting on Phainon’s shoulder as the relief washed over him and took the tension with it. He shook very briefly with a soft laugh.

“Mydei?” Phainon asked, concerned. He felt strong hands on his back, massaging their way up to squeeze lightly at the back of his neck before they curiously played with his hair.

“I thought it had been years,” he confessed, “that perhaps you had forgotten about me.”

“Forget you? Like I’d ever.”

Mydei leaned back again to study the look in his best friend’s eyes. “Then why do you look like you carry the weight of a century?”

Phainon looked away, his voice shaky when he whispered, “You died in my arms, Mydei…”

“HKS, is that what this is about?” he teased.

The glare that came Mydei’s way was full of hurt. Phainon didn’t appreciate Mydei being dismissive of his feelings, but this was a nonissue and there was no way Mydei was going to let the love of his life stress over something so ridiculous.

“I *held* you while you *died*.”

“Deliverer, death cannot keep me for long,” Mydei reminded him. He gently took Phainon’s hand and held it to his bare chest so the man could feel his heart beating. When he let go, Phainon’s palm stayed flat against that firm muscle to feel and be reassured but the look in his eyes was still haunted.

“You have even now witnessed for yourself that I will always come back,” he pushed, “and if you have any idea how exhausting it is return from a protracted battle, then you should know that pointless arguments are the last thing I want to get into now.”

Phainon kept his mouth shut. He nodded and then it was his turn to lean forward to rest his forehead against Mydei’s chest, right over where his hand still counted heartbeats. Those wings shifted when he did, curling in tighter, wanting to keep Mydei safe and secure. The Kremnoan wrapped his arms around Phainon and felt the other warrior do the same, pulling him in as close as he could manage without pulling Mydei down on top of him.

“…you’re still upset,” Mydei observed.

“I know it is nothing to you,” Phainon murmured, “but it was everything to me. Even knowing that you would come back, to see you there, covered in blood, with no shine to your eyes or beating of your heart… You took a piece of me with you.”

The ache in Phainon’s voice had Mydei second guessing his casualness. His lives always felt cheap, even to his family and crew that had seen him perish and return several times it was almost like an inside joke, something to tease him about when a foolish idea snatched away a life. Perhaps it was a result of their cultural upbringing, to disregard death as simply something that happened, something to be desired under the right circumstances. But Mydei was one of very few Kremnoans to reject the idea of valorous death over glorious return. He wanted a future wherein his people valued every breath and fought to protect each other rather than to mindlessly march to their deaths like insects.

Who was he to devalue his own? Especially when someone dear to him was hurting.

“You’re right,” he relented, “and if it is everything to you, then it will be to me.”

Phainon’s arms around his shoulders and back tightened in a reassuring squeeze and then he let go when Mydei pulled away. Again, Mydei pressed his palm to Phainon’s cheek as though it would hurt him to not keep in contact.

“I can’t promise I will never die again,” he said firmly and Phainon’s expression turned sour, that guarded expression that he wore to mask his grief, but Mydei saw through him. “I would cross the River of Souls over and over again if it meant you could be safe.”

“That’s not fair,” Phainon hissed and Mydei let his hand drop, “you are my equal in everything Mydei. You don’t get to be the only protector here.”

“…fair enough.”

“We can talk about it more in the morning,” Phainon said after a minute of heavy silence, “a lot happened while you were holding back the Tide.”

“So, I see,” Mydei reached out and brushed his fingers against Phainon’s wings. They shivered under his touch, and Phainon gently brought them in closer for Mydei to feel. They weren’t like a bird’s wings with many interlocking feathers. Rather they were wholly unique, branched like a tree with only a few large pinions per branch. One entire wing was dark blue, almost black in the candlelight, and the other was golden bronze. There was an edge to them, but they weren’t sharp nor cold. Each feather had its own heat like laundry that had been left out in the sun to dry and warm. When Phainon wrapped them around Mydei it was as though he was surrounded by the memory of harvest days, of long naps in the shade of tree with the smell of warmed grass tickling his nose. It made him smile.

Mydei offered that smile to Phainon but the one he got in return was tired, happy and relieved, but still haunted.

“We should sleep, Mydei,” Phainon suggested. He was already falling away, laying back against the pillows but Mydei followed him, leaning over Phainon with his hands on the cushions to either side. His hair fell around his face to cage them in more intimately than Phainon’s wings had before.

“One more kiss,” he demanded, “one more kiss and one more secret.”

Phainon thought about that for a moment and then reached up to touch Mydei’s cheek. He lifted his head from the pillows to chastely press their lips together and they held it until Mydei’s shaky arms demanded he quit.

Regrettably, Mydei rolled off Phainon to lay beside him and Phainon turned to his side with a curious expression.

“You are right, we are equals, and I do trust you, Deliverer,” Mydei began. He paused, trying to find the right words to share this secret with the person he loved most. “And it isn’t fair if I don’t let you protect me too.” He reached out to futilely brush hair from Phainon’s tired eyes. Those bangs fell right back into place but still he tried. “My tenth thoracic vertebrae. That’s my weak spot, and the only way to kill me.”

Phainon’s eyes widened then narrowed, and his mouth opened but he didn’t say anything, not right away. As usual, the Deliverer had to process what he had just been told and his face cycled through a series of emotions in rapid succession until, in true Phainon fashion, he started to laugh.

“I share with you my greatest secret and you *laugh*?” he hissed around his whisper.

“I’m sorry, Mydei,” Phainon managed as he calmed down, “I just remembered something. Before I followed you into Castrum Kremnos you asked me something.”

“I did.”

“Do you remember what I said?”

“…I do.”

“And I meant it,” Phainon promised. The pain behind those beautiful blue eyes alleviated somewhat in the comfort of responsibility and trust. Mydei worried he might regret sharing something so intimate out loud, but it was worth it to see Phainon at ease. It was worth it to hear Phainon fall into a deep and restful sleep.

“Deliverer, do you have my back?”

“Always, Mydeimos.”

Chapter End Notes

I worry a TINY bit about what this jump will do to the pacing. I'm HOPING that after a couple more chapters folks will see the vision. Hopefully. I'm experimenting. Yay growth!
Basically, if it feels like there's a chapter missing, that's intentional. I want it to feel that way because MYDEI feels that way.

Chapter 39: The Tales We Tell

Chapter Summary

New tags: Implied/Referenced Self-Harm (changed from Cutting), Eye Trauma, Body Horror
All very minor but please protect yourselves if you are sensitive to even references of these things

Phainon tells Mydei what happened

Chapter Notes

Shoutout to my beta reader, Bane. She's my co-author on my other long-fic and I made her read this one so she could read over my shoulders and help me find the things I missed. She doesn't even go here and already had to help me fix something I realized in a panic at like 11 pm :')

Writing is hard sometimes guys. Especially when your original outline is crying in a ditch somewhere.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon woke up before Mydei but after everyone else and was relieved to have the room to himself. Everyone knew how he felt about Mydei now, word got around fast, and no one was surprised when many of the crew heard Phainon confessing to Mydei's corpse over and over between sobs. He had rocked back and forth on his knees with Mydei held tightly to his chest apologizing and telling him how much he loved him in both languages as if that would wake him up faster. It didn't.

He gently brushed bed head hair out of Mydei's eyes as he slept and smiled at the memory of their kisses late last night. It was so very tempting to wake the man with another, but Perdikkas had warned Phainon that Mydei would probably need more rest than he usually did after coming back from the dead. It was hard to know how many lives he lost and couldn't recover from before they came to his rescue and his body and spirit could finally, finally let their guard down to sleep.

Mydei's hair was still a little sticky between Phainon's fingers. They had tried to bathe him when they got to port yesterday but he'd need another. Side by side like this Phainon could still feel the corruption lingering on his spirit, another perk of his coreflame perhaps. He wanted to burn it away from Mydei, to take it upon himself. It wouldn't be so bad, he

thought, to hear the song one last time, something that may never happen again now that he was a Demigod.

He ran his fingers over Mydei's shoulder and down his back, tracing tattoos as he went. The man had ended up sleeping on his stomach, a position that Phainon now recognized as a gesture of trust. Starting at one, Phainon counted the bumps of Mydei's spine until he got to ten, brushing over that sensitive spot that made Mydeimos shiver in his sleep, little more than a reflexive twitch. He pressed a little harder with two fingers, circling that bump on his back with firm rubs.

I share with you my greatest secret and you laugh?

Phainon hadn't known how else to react, he was so overwhelmed at the time. Happy to hear Mydei's voice again and still angry with him for his callousness, but now that it was quiet, that he was rested, that Mydei was okay, the weight of that secret could properly settle. He didn't like thinking of it as the only way to kill Mydei, this was the best way to *protect* Mydei and Phainon was humbled and honored to be trusted with such an important job.

"Awoo?"

Phainon grunted when Beagle pounced on him and knocked the wind from his belly. His tail was straight and his whole body was on alert. Those big blue eyes peered out from under Phainon's arm as he rubbed his head and horns on the sore bicep.

"I'll feed you in a minute."

Fig Stew chirped at that sentiment but stayed put beside Mydei. The orange chimera was stretched out happily in the little spoon spot against Mydei's side and Phainon suspected any attempts to move him would result in violent protest. Beagle purred and made biscuits on Phainon's abs and then stotted over to his chimera boyfriend to lightly headbutt Beagle's side and then sprawled on top of him. Fig's peep was anything but distressed and Phainon took the hint to leave. They were making him jealous.

Breakfast was easy, bread, figs, and cheese had already been set aside and Phainon sliced up some of the cured meat they had on hand. Beagle was teaching Fig Stew how to have an appetite so Phainon piled the plate a lot higher than he normally would. When he considered how long it had been since Mydei had tasted food, Phainon added even more until the plate was an accident waiting to happen. The chimeras had their own water dish in the other room, so he grabbed the pitcher of juice for himself and meandered back, pausing in the doorway when he saw the empty pile of bedding.

Mydei was standing on the balcony petting Beagle Coconut and Fig Stew in turn. They were sitting politely on the railing, not demanding attention but eagerly accepting it when given. The chiton they had dressed him in was still tied around his waist, leaving his back and shoulders bare. Phainon watched him for a minute, studying the way he looked at the city with a tired slump and ran his fingers through his hair like he usually did when he was stressed.

“Mydeimos,” he whispered, just loud enough to be heard and Mydei turned those beautiful amber eyes to watch Phainon walk across the room where he set the plate and pitcher on the railing.

Mydei looked at the food with obvious want and then turned those hungry eyes on Phainon. He saw Mydei look for wings, which were put away for now, then to his eyes, and finally they dropped to Phainon’s lips.

“Was it a dream?” Mydei asked, his voice gravelly and hoarse from disuse.

Phainon leaned forward and pressed his lips to Mydei’s giving him every opportunity to step away but Mydei closed his eyes and pushed into it, even reaching a hand up to take a handful of Phainon’s chlamys to keep him from pulling away before he was ready to let go. He only stopped when Phainon’s smile broke the kiss.

“…not a dream,” the Kremnoan mumbled to himself.

“No, it wasn’t.”

“Good, I didn’t want it to be.” He turned back to facing the ruins of the settlement and reached for the food, curling his lip back to show his teeth when Beagle tried to snatch a piece of meat from him. The chimera pouted and took a step back, but Phainon stepped in to prevent a fight. He handed each of the chimeras bites of food when they waited patiently, acting as the intermediary between them and the plate so Mydei could eagerly take what he wanted, what he *needed* after going so long without.

“Was it the Tide?” Mydei asked.

“Yes.”

“The silence here is stifling… The city feels so unfamiliar now.”

“You’ve exchanged thousands of blows with the Black Tide…your ears are probably just not used to this peace and quiet,” Phainon tried to be light-hearted about it, but it didn’t feel right, “we would have lost everyone, Mydei, if it wasn’t for you.”

Mydei’s hands on the railing slowly curled into loose fists.

“I can call the others,” Phainon offered, “we can tell you what happened since Castrum Kremnos.”

“I want to hear it from you.”

“Mydei, there are parts of the story I don’t have…”

“Then tell me the parts you do.”

Phainon started with a shameful admission, beginning the story from the very moment the crystal blocked his way back to Mydei’s side. Fig Stew purred at the mention of his heroism and the well-deserved credit that the chimera had earned when he pulled Phainon away from

crippling grief. The chimera puffed out his chest and rolled onto his back so Phainon could scratch his belly when Phainon described the tension on deck when he returned without Mydei. He ran his fingers through that plush fur as he recalled the first time Fig Stew had allowed such affection in detail.

“He accepted you,” Mydei repeated softly as he watched with a guarded expression. He reached over to pet Fig’s belly as well and their fingers met.

“Yeah, convinced the whole crew too.”

“Krateros.” It wasn’t a question.

“Yeah.”

Beagle very firmly put his paw on their hands and chirped, annoyed. He slapped them both across the knuckles when they lingered a little too long and then he set about grooming the tummy of a purring Fig Stew with more focus than Phainon had seen from the monster in his whole life.

Phainon moved on to talk about the crew’s injuries, how hurt he had been, how hurt Hephaestion had been. Mydei reached for Phainon’s chlamys and pushed it aside to trace the scar with his fingertips while Phainon described the lingering pain. He had been there when Nikador’s spear ripped open his flesh, but it was different, seeing it now when there was time to process how serious the injury had been. When Phainon started elaborating on the first mate…

“Mydei? Where are you going?”

“Where is Hephaestion now?” he asked while he pulled on his sandals.

“Perdikkas is staying with him in a home near the bathhouse.” Phainon’s own sandals hit his chest and fell into his arms. He saw where this was going, slipped the footwear on and reached to grab his bag beside their messy pile of cushions. Phainon added his book from last night and a couple of easy snacks, then secured it over his shoulder and rested his hand over the bag while Mydei finished getting dressed. The red chlamys only covered his shoulders and part of his chest. Phainon didn’t mind. He liked the flash of tattoos as Mydei moved.

“Tell me more as we walk.”

The roads were solemn and quiet. They took it slow so Mydei could take in the devastation as Phainon recalled the evacuation. He described for Mydei the Black Tide as it raced the ship in unpredictable bursts, how it stalled for a time, allowing them to ferry supplies and people to the mainland across the sound. The fires and monsters had blanketed the last of them to escape in the night with heavy ash. He almost told Mydei about Chironome, that sweet orphan child with a heart of a lion, but he paused and decided in that moment to keep the memory of her to himself for now.

Mydei reached up and squeezed Phainon’s arm, stopping in the road next to a collapsed stall. The city felt gray, even with the bright blue sky above them and the rising sun trying its best

to splash color against the remains, but the ash still clung to every surface, dampening the brightness that had once been.

“That must have been hard for you,” Mydei observed when Phainon did not continue right away. There was worry in his leonine eyes, he must have thought the hesitation was Phainon recalling a particularly difficult memory.

“It’s your home that was lost,” he chuckled sadly, “and you’re worried about how I feel?”

“This was never home,” Mydei said simply as he started walking again, and Phainon vaguely remembered him saying as much once before.

Phainon matched his pace and told Mydei about the journey to Okhema. He had to tell his story about Krateros twice when Mydei didn’t believe him the first time. Even though the Kremnoan insisted he wouldn’t believe it until he saw it, Mydei still smiled when Phainon listed his positive interactions with the man. He especially emphasized to Mydei that Krateros made an excellent first mate but still dramatically complained about the veteran, describing Krateros as a terrifying taskmaster at every lesson whether it be sparring or woodcraft and Mydei laughed in mutual understanding.

The sounds of the crew got louder as they approached the bathhouse and surrounding buildings. Several of the structures had collapsed but a few still stood proud. Mydei and Phainon walked in silence when they heard the crew. The sound carried in the empty city, but the mumbling of distant voices made it easier to remember that there were more than ghosts here, that the Kremnoan people still lived despite the Tide’s best efforts.

“-I mean we could *ask* but there’s still some from Okhema,” Perdikkas’ voice carried. They rounded the corner in time to see the doctor talking to Peucesta. The two of them brightened immediately when they saw Mydei and Phainon.

“It’s good to see you on your feet, captain,” Perdikkas greeted and Phainon had to close his mouth before he responded. There would probably be some muscle memory there for a while as he readjusted to his role as crewmate, but Mydei still looked at him expectantly, as though he wasn’t sure anymore to whom the title belonged.

“It *is* good to see you on your feet,” Phainon agreed, silencing the debate before it could start.

Mydei turned back to their friends and nodded which was all the permission his men needed. Perdikkas and Peucesta scooped him up in a hug between them and Mydei’s eyes widened in shock.

“HKS! You fools! What is this? Has the Deliverer taken from you your pride?” he scolded but they didn’t let go of him.

“You were missed, Mydei! Let us love on you!”

“Nikador’s glory, he *has*! Phainon of Aedes Elysiae! Your sentimental foolishness has corrupted my crew!”

“It won’t happen again!” Phainon promised with a playful chuckle and then he joined the group hug while Mydei cussed at them more creatively in Kremnoan until they let him go.

“You need another bath,” Peucesta observed when they pulled away and let Mydei straighten his clothes to try and recover some of his dignity.

“Not now,” Mydei huffed, “where is Hephaestion?”

Perdikkas nodded and then gestured with a wave for them to follow and he led Mydei to one of the intact houses. The home did not belong to them, it didn’t belong to anyone anymore, but there were warm blankets and basic amenities that Hephaestion needed.

The first mate was sitting up on the kline when Mydei pushed aside the curtain to see him. Hyacine was tending to a long, wide scar across his chest while Ptolemy cracked jokes. There was a book in Ptolemy’s lap with his thumb between the pages to keep their spot but judging by the company that story had long been abandoned in favor of good conversation. The room brightened further when they saw their Prince.

“Mydeimos…” Hephaestion greeted, and the captain immediately stepped up to his side.

“Lord Mydei,” Hyacine acknowledged politely.

“Hephaestion, are you…?”

“I am not in danger, Mydei, don’t look so distraught.”

“Phainon told me you had been severely injured…”

Ptolemy huffed and shot Phainon a glare. “Storytelling without us?”

“You are welcome to repeat the tale,” Phainon invited with a flourish.

“’Why cover the same ground again? It goes against my grain to repeat a tale told once, and told so clearly,’” Ptolemy quoted with a shrug.

“If it helps, I haven’t finished telling him everything.”

Mydei took a seat on the kline near Hephaestion’s feet and gestured to Hyacine and Perdikkas, “tell me of Hephaestion’s condition, then I would hear more of what happened in my absence.”

The doctors told Mydei about the details of Hephaestion’s injuries and what it could mean long term. Phainon had heard it all before and it still hurt to know, but Hephaestion reassured Mydei with a soft, if tired smile, and even light-heartedly complained about not being allowed to help more with the all the new chores on the ship.

“What chores?” Mydei asked.

“Replacing all that wax, painting the ship, cleaning up all that blood from the talismans,” Ptolemy listed and Mydei frowned. “…Phainon is not as far in the story as I thought.”

Phainon pulled up a dusty stool and sat down to begin again, continuing where he left off on their arrival in Okhema. This was where the story diverged so Phainon focused only on his side. He glossed over his encounter with Aglaea and then described the Trial. Some details he kept to himself, as Phainon had the first time he recounted what happened to the others. They didn't need to know about his confession to the city, not when he still wanted to say those words to Mydei himself when the moment felt right.

Mydei kept his reactions muted as Phainon talked until the story reached the Council's decision and then his knuckles turned white where they squeezed his crossed arms. There was fury in his eyes as Phainon described how he felt when Caenis rejected the Coreflame of Strife and with it any desire for peace between their nations. He saw Mydei's body tremble with anger when he revealed the Council's judgement and had sentenced him to death.

That's when Phainon took the bag off his shoulder and opened it in his lap to show Mydei the Coreflame of Strife. It was bright and strong in his hands, the gold almost overpowering the purple crystal in the presence of its keeper. He held onto it still when Mydei didn't reach for it, keeping it close like the gift it was. He told Mydei about the rescue and how they used the chance to not only recover Strife but to seize the coreflames that belonged to Hyacine and himself.

"Worldbearing," Mydei repeated thoughtfully, "it suits you."

Phainon blushed and looked away.

"It does, doesn't it?" Hyacine teased.

"Then you are both demigods," Mydei confirmed aloud.

"Yes." Phainon put his hand to his chest. "I wanted… I wanted to wait, to take that step *with* you, to do what you did for me and offer my coreflame to you, but…"

Phainon looked up when Mydei's hand gently brushed his knee. "You came for me, Phainon. That is everything. But your pardon-"

"I don't need it. I'm not sure I even *want* it anymore. The people that mattered most to me still believe in me, are still *here* with me. I meant it when I told Okhema that I am a pirate."

"And my people?" Mydei asked.

"I sent Cipher with a message. They no longer march towards Okhema for safety."

"They're strong Mydei," Hephaestion reminded him, "they'll make a place on the plains and wait until we return to them with glad tidings."

"You said the Tide took over the Settlement," Mydei recalled.

"We cleared it after we saved you," Perdikkas filled in, answering the question hidden in the statement, "well, Phainon did."

“After we left Okhema we went straight to Castrum Kremnos,” Phainon continued, “Hyacine and I-“ he looked over at her when he said her name and she smiled warmly, making the whole room feel sunny, “-we talked to Castorice a lot about becoming Demigods before we accepted them.”

Phainon remembered what it felt like to take that burning fire inside his chest. The comfort of candlelight had felt like wildfire when he accepted it, burning him alive until he couldn’t bear it. On the deck of the Leo, he had taken his new sword to his own body, clawing at his chest and belly, trying to rip the coreflame free while the crew backed away in terror. That first transformation had been made so much worse by his confused panic, by the blood thrown across the sails as it crystalized and ripped him apart, filling him with power too great to contain.

He remembered worrying that he wasn’t ready after all, that this was the end of him and then the breeze had caught his feathers, colors had felt all the brighter, the deck was far below him and everything had felt *right.* Castorice had compared him to a butterfly, finally achieving a form he was meant to be after the painful process of breaking apart inside a chrysalis. And then he had willed himself back to his prior appearance and she retracted her metaphor with an annoyed grumble.

Hyacine’s hadn’t been much better though she handled it with more grace than Phainon had. Where he had panicked, she calmly waited for the Coreflame of Sky to settle inside her. She had fallen to her knees on the deck, talking with soft reassurances to those who gathered around with concern while she cried purest, glittering blood. Her eyes had rolled wildly until she shakily removed them herself, speaking softly as though comforting a patient and not enduring this horror herself. The wild, multicolored eyes of Aquila had taken the place of her own, pulsating wildly, moving independently until Hyacine found herself, blinked, and it was as though nothing had happened.

Perdikkas had fussed over her more than he had Phainon, wiping her bloody tears away with his own handkerchief while Castorice apologized profusely for not predicting something so ghastly. But Hyacine waved them both away and tended to Phainon who was still whimpering like a child with his new wings and embarrassing, self-inflicted wounds.

“It was a lot,” he summed up and everyone in the room silently agreed that no more needed to be said right now on that topic. “Hyacine used her authority as the Sky to part the clouds for us and I hurried to meet you. The Professor was able to improve on the talismans. They *did* work the first time but after Nikador…”

“The Tide was strengthened,” Mydei remembered.

“Yes. Anaxa dipped each protective charm in Kephale’s blood-“ Mydei’s eyes narrowed but he didn’t interrupt to ask where they got that, “-and then sealed them in wax to give them another layer of protection. It was enough, and the crew were able to follow us into the acropolis.”

“Good thing too with the number of trips we needed,” Ptolemy grumbled, “no one is allowed to give me grief for my love of preservation again. That Professor is many times worse.”

Mydei tilted his head and Hephaestion laughed a little before saying, “Anaxagoras wanted as much of Eurypon’s writings as possible. Most of the crew were combing through records for anything with his handwriting on it and hauling it back to the ship.”

“There is nothing to be gained from the ramblings of a madman,” the Prince huffed.

“That… might not be entirely true, Mydei,” Phainon admitted, “Anaxa believes King Eurypon had learned things about the Black Tide and the coreflames that no one else had discovered during his campaign. He believes there is information there that can confirm his theory.”

“His theory?”

“That aggravating man will not discuss it yet,” Ptolemy huffed.

“He’s always been like that,” Hyacine said but it wasn’t reassuring.

“After we loaded the ship and unlocked the treasury we came here,” Phainon explained, “the Tide had retreated after our battle, farther back than before and we agreed this was the safest place for you until you came back to us.”

Hyacine scooted over closer to Mydei so she could press the back of her hand to his forehead, and he obediently held still. “You still look a little pale… the Tide still clings to you. Do you hear its song?”

“Yes,” Mydei admitted, “if I listen for it, it is there.”

“That settles it then, I’m prescribing you a bath,” she instructed.

“You better go with him, Phainon,” Perdikkas added, “doctor’s orders. There will be time to talk more later.”

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The sturdy bathhouse had escaped the Tide’s assault but in the absence of a regular attendant the complex still suffered. It had taken a fair number of them to get a few of the pools cleaned enough to be worth bathing in and there was no hope for a boiling bath like the one that had nearly broken Phainon the first time they had brought him here. The memory made Mydei smile and blush at the same time, a foreign combo that made it hard to recognize himself in the mirror as he changed.

It took time to bounce back from death, Mydei knew that, but looking at himself now… He looked and felt frazzled, burdened, and still very, very tired. His eyes darted to watch Phainon in the mirror. The Deliverer still looked the same, but he felt warmer, more confident with that coreflame inside him. He kept his back to Mydei as he shrugged out of his clothing and set each piece aside in a cubby, reverently working around the Coreflame of Strife that he kept close. It wasn’t something Mydei had expected to ever see again, and it wasn’t something he wanted to think about just yet, but Phainon insisted on its presence, prepared to even bring it into the baths with them.

“Phainon,” he called, and the man looked up at him with bright, expectant eyes as blue as the sea that crashes against the shore. “Leave the Coreflame in here.”

“Do you not want it?”

“Not yet,” Mydei said softly and when Phainon’s expression morphed into one of longing, Mydei turned and pressed his palm to Phainon’s cheek to remind him, “must you hold it instead of me? Am I not enough?”

“Okay, okay,” Phainon chuckled, and he pulled away to tuck the coreflame in the cubby with his clothes, choosing the book instead. There was a tiny tug in Mydei’s chest when he did so, like a pull on a string around his heart, but it faded when Phainon smiled and Mydei was again so sure that the coreflame meant nothing compared to Phainon’s fire.

Mydei was patient and obedient when Phainon led him to the bath, passing other crewmates that were in a similar state of relaxation, towards a smaller, warm pool of water that shimmered brighter than the others. He paused at the edge and studied it with confusion while Phainon set towels, soap, and his book on a stool beside it. The Deliverer waded in when he was ready, but Mydei rejected Phainon’s offered hand when the man stepped inside first and reached for him.

“Mydei?” Phainon followed where Mydei was looking and then waded closer. “It’s okay. This is how we bathe in Okhema to cleanse the Tide.”

“HKS, my caution is not fear,” he huffed, defensively.

“I know, Mydeimos.”

Mydei waded into the water after Phainon and followed his lead to sit beside him, letting the water soak to his bones and ease the aches and pains that still lingered. Phainon snatched the soap first to wash himself and Mydei tried not to stare. Neither of them had bothered with towels or bath wear but Phainon still had that damn collar on. Maybe it was the coreflame inside him, but the sun mark on his neck glittered brighter than he remembered.

“You mentioned Kephale’s blood,” Mydei said after a moment and Phainon shook water from his face and hair, “is that what you added to the bath?”

“Yeah.”

Mydei caught Phainon’s arm below the elbow, holding him tight to see the fabric bandage that was wrapped around his wrist. He remembered seeing it last night too. “…*only* Kephale’s blood?”

Phainon pulled his arm free and immediately started to soap up Mydei’s hair to change the subject, making him growl. “Oh, don’t act like you don’t enjoy the attention,” he scolded and Mydei huffed, settling down with his back to Phainon.

The once Okheman hummed while he worked and Mydei listened in silence, letting him massage the grime and oils from his hair. Mydei could do it himself, but something about

being doted on was nice and he was content to doze and soak while the floral smell of the soap added another layer to what was left of the Tide song that lingered in the back of his mind.

“I don’t want the coreflame,” Mydei said after what felt like a long time. Phainon’s fingers paused in Mydei’s hair. “I meant what I said, it’s not a power that I want for myself and my people.” He raised a hand to look at it, not sure what to expect and finding nothing out of the ordinary when he did. “There is an expectation there, akin to the crown.”

“The future you don’t want for them,” Phainon supplied.

“Yes.” Once again Mydei entertained the thought of crushing the crown underfoot, of leading his people the rest of the way to Okhema, to demand the end of the war so his people could find a life of plenty and peace safe from the Black Tide.

“And what if it was the best way to secure their futures?” Phainon wondered aloud. Mydei twisted his head to look over his shoulder and up at Phainon. “Okhema, Kremnos, all people’s of Amphoreus, there is no future for *anyone* if the Tide cannot be defeated. Aglaea always believed the coreflames were the secret to destroying the Tide, that’s why she pursued them so relentlessly. Now that I have one and have wielded it against that evil... I won’t make you take it Mydei but consider instead what good you could do as the Demigod of Strife, not as Strife became, but as what it was meant to be, the Titan that I have learned so much about on this ship.” Phainon chuckled a little to himself and teasingly tugged at Mydei’s hair. “We could be as Nikador and Kephale of old, the ones carved on the Leo, who were friends and comrades. Maybe Peucesta will write songs about us.”

“He already does,” Mydei grumbled and turned back around. He let Phainon resume washing his hair. Soapy water trickled from his temple down his cheek, a tickling sensation that made him curl his toes.

No man or woman born, coward or brave, can shun his destiny.

Phainon was right. Mydei had been looking for an answer, a way to protect his people, what better way to inspire change than to tear down the old Dynasty and show them what Strife needed to be, not what they wanted it to be.

“Then we will go after the Tide,” Mydei said firmly.

“Isn’t that my decision now?” Phainon teased and Mydei’s shoulders tightened. He slowly turned around to fix Phainon with what he hoped was a commanding glare but the man booped his nose and left behind a little cloud of suds that undermined his entire air of authority. “You *did* make me captain.”

“A temporary measure,” Mydei growled, “but if you would like to fight me for it, I will oblige.”

Phainon chuckled, “No, no, *sir*, the Leo is yours, of course. I was never more than a passenger after all.”

His frown deepened and Mydei wiped the soap from his nose and stood in the bath to look down at Phainon. The man leaned away, rightfully intimidated and doing a shockingly good job at keeping his eyes up as Mydei leaned over him to slip a finger under that collar. “A passenger? No, you are my *prisoner*, if I recall.”

Phainon smiled, cheeky and teasing with a tilt of his head that bordered on coy. “Oh, captain, you have died too many times. The Chryseus Leo doesn’t take prisoners, remember?”

Mydei snorted and rubbed his thumb over that sun marking on his neck. “Join my crew, Phainon of Castrum Kremnos,” he demanded, diving to the heart of the matter.

Phainon’s breath caught when Mydei spoke, he felt it under his fingertips and the subtle bob of his throat when he swallowed and finally said, “With all my heart, Mydeimos.”

“What did I say about sentimentality, Deliverer?”

“That you love it and want more of it in your life?”

“HKS. What a ridiculous puppy I have on my crew.” Mydei let him go, turned around and dropped heavily into the water up to his nose. Phainon’s hands followed, once again scrubbing at his hair. A few soapy bubbles floated by and they fell into a comfortable and quiet rhythm, relying on gentle taps and gestures to finish washing Mydei’s hair and face.

“Any better?” Phainon asked when Mydei resurfaced again after another rinse.

Mydei brushed the dripping hair from his eyes running his fingers through that mane to shake away the glittering water and any residual soap and then he paused to close his eyes and listen. The song was still there, faint but relentless. He sat along the edge of the pool in answer and settled in to soak a little longer.

Phainon flashed him a sympathetic look and climbed out of the bath. “Would it be alright if I practiced reading to you?” he asked as he wrapped a towel around his waist.

“I welcome it,” Mydei invited, “I can correct your horrible pronunciations.”

“Have mercy, Mydei,” Phainon whined, “I am improving!”

It was still Mydei’s favorite story, the same one that he had almost ruined with his notes in the margins, the same one that Phainon had clung to since the day Ptolemy had handed it to him in the library on the Chryseus Leo with its faded pages and missing corners. It was the story that Krateros would read to Mydei when he was sick, the one that Mydei would read after bad days. To know that Phainon loved it too was another special thing they shared.

Mydei closed his eyes and listened to Phainon struggle to tell of the hero as he began his voyage home and the trials he would have to face. He listened to the soundtrack of the Tide song as it blended with Phainon’s words as he read of the hero preparing for a particularly dangerous part of the journey with daring curiosity. In the story, the clever hero asks his men to tie him to the mast and fill their ears with wax as they sailed past a notorious stretch of ocean so he could listen to the…

Mydei's eyes snapped open, and he turned in the bath with wide eyes to look at Phainon who immediately tripped over the rest of the sentence before he gave up and tilted his head in concern. "Mydei?"

With the notes of the next refrain playing in his ears, he firmly declared, "I know what the Tide is."

Chapter End Notes

Im staying up all night to watch the livestream. Im not ready. The stress is so bad guys

Chapter 40: Ascension

Chapter Summary

No new tags

Alternative chapter title: The Lion does not Concern Himself with Footwear

Mydei has a theory, Anaxa has opinions about that theory (like he does about everything), and there's some déjà vu.

Chapter Notes

Sorry for the delay on this one. The 3.7 livestream had me so stressed all weekend there was no chance of me writing.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Mydei, think about it for more than a second!” Phainon insisted as he followed his captain down the road. The Kremnoan hadn’t appreciated Phainon’s skepticism and was now stomping through the city looking for Anaxa, still soaked from the bath, barefoot, with his hair unbraided and dripping. Thank Kephale that Mydei had at least wrapped his chiton around his waist on the way out of the bathhouse, but he was still mostly naked. Well, more naked than usual.

“I’m not saying you’re *wrong*, I just think maybe you should think it through before telling anyone else!”

Mydei continued to ignore him as Phainon pursued with one sandal untied on his foot and the other under his arm. He was still trying to get his bag in order after the hasty exit and constantly flexing his foot to keep the one piece of footwear doing its job without being left behind. Phainon had at least used a towel before throwing his clothes on in his hasty pursuit. Mydei’s chiton was so soaked it was almost see-through, and it clung to his ass and thighs, leaving nothing to the imagination. The man didn’t seem to care that everyone who stumbled on them could see the perfect curve of his muscles and how that fabric hung low enough to see where the bathwater still dripped down the small of his back…

Phainon slapped his own face and hurried to catch up with a series of awkward hops and hobbles.

“Look out!” someone shouted and Mydei bounced backward, narrowly avoiding an accident and crashing into Phainon who was now out of breath for two reasons.

A child-sized stone sphere crashed down the crossing road in front of them bouncing along with a happy dragon in pursuit. The whole ground shook when Pollux ran by and then it shook again when they returned with the ball in their mouth, delicately held between sharp teeth and that beak-like snoot. They paused to sniff in Mydei and Phainon’s direction and then wagged their tail and fluttered the long petals in their ruff when the recognition clicked behind those bright white eyes.

“Pollux!” Leonnius shouted and the runner came sliding down the road a second later. “What’s the hold up? Come on, buddy. Mydei, you’re awake! Phainon! …why are you wet?”

Phainon and Mydei leaned forward enough to peer around the buildings to look uphill where Castorice and Peucesta were waiting beside an unloaded catapult. Castorice waved when she saw them.

“Fetch?” Phainon asked and Pollux wiggled at the word and whined around the ball in their mouth.

“Yeah we were taking a break from assessing the state of the armory-”

“Anaxagoras.” Mydei demanded urgently.

Leonnius reached up to scratch at the scar over his brow while he thought aloud, “still on the Chryseus Leo, I think. I saw him head down there with Ptolemy earlier.”

Mydei didn’t wait, he ducked under Pollux’s belly and kept going in the straightest possible line towards the docks while the others watched. The dragon craned that long neck to watch Mydei upside down along the path he walked between Pollux’s legs.

“…Phainon?”

Phainon sighed and started after Mydei again, going around Pollux like a polite person should and still trying to get his bag situated while he hopped on one foot to put the remaining sandal on. “Mydei thinks he’s solved the riddle of the Tide,” he called over his shoulder in answer and then he was hopping away before elaborating.

“Damn it, Mydei, slow down!”

Mydei picked up speed, very nearly crashing into Perdikkas when he took a turn down another street. The doctor’s hands were full of little sealed packets inside a basket that barely fit under one arm.

“Mydeimos?” The doctor reached out to grab Mydei with his free hand on instinct but the Prince expertly dodged around and kept powerwalking away. “I guess he’s feeling better… Phainon?”

“Perdikkas,” Phainon greeted with a smile and a panting breath as he caught up to the second almost incident. He hopped in place and finished tying the second sandal, eager to pursue

Mydei but trapped by good manners. “Raiding the storehouses?”

“Yeah, most of what we had we sent with the others… Are you chasing Mydei?”

“Yeah, Mydeimos is convinced he’s figured out what the Black Tide is,” Phainon sighed, “I really need to…” He gestured vaguely in the direction Mydei had run and then hurried after him. The truth was as good of a reason to end the conversation as any.

Any response was left behind in dust as Phainon ran to catch up. At least barefoot Mydei didn’t dare try to sprint or even run with all the debris, so it was easy to catch up.

“I’m serious, you can’t just storm in there half prepared! Anaxa will eat you alive!” Phainon insisted as they jogged along the pier to the shoddily repaired dock, functional was more important than pretty and it was not pretty. It was still partly in shambles from when Phainon had run away from the Black Tide Gryphon, but Mydei didn’t slow down at all.

“Let me at least help you draft a proper argument!”

Mydei stormed up the ramp onto the deck of the Chryseus Leo and finally paused his powerwalking to look around, searching for any sign of the professor. There were half a dozen crewmates at work washing the deck, checking the sails, and moving cargo under the diligent eye of Krateros. Those who noticed him looked up in shock at the prince, who was clearly on a mission, his chiton hanging low and tight around his hips, scanning over them with curious urgency.

“Maybe I can get you a shirt?” Phainon offered cheekily instead when he saw Krateros’ confused expression. He was predictably ignored.

That’s when everyone else caught up. He had been so focused on Mydei that Phainon hadn’t noticed the procession of people that were curious enough to tag along too until Perdikkas, Leonnius, Castorice, and Peucesta were bunched up on the ramp behind him with an upset Pollux trying to figure out how to get down the flimsy dock without breaking it. The dragon kept putting a paw down on the wood and then pulling back to whine when it creaked, leaving the excluded beast stranded on the shore.

“What are you all-” Phainon started but he didn’t finish.

“Anaxagoras!” Mydei called and something crashed in the galley. He immediately turned and resumed storming in that direction with a curious pack of people on his heels.

Phainon was not prepared for Mydei to see the state of his beloved kitchen just yet. Anaxa had a month to make it his own lab and any semblance of what it used to be was limited to the things Anaxa *couldn’t* move like the ovens and firepit. The pantry had been reorganized to make space for alchemical ingredients, the cubbies were full of jars of things that Phainon didn’t want to know about, and Mydei’s pots, pans, tools, and even his apron were hidden in the captain’s quarters to protect them from the purge.

He scrambled to get in front of Mydei at the top of the stairs. “Mydei, listen, you just woke up, it’s been a long morning already-”

Mydei physically picked up Phainon under the arms and set him to the side but before he could walk past, Phainon grabbed his arm and twisted it behind Mydei's back to steer him the other way. Angry gold eyes peered over Mydei's shoulder, fixing Phainon nervously in place.

"Do you really want to do this, Deliverer?" he asked, low and threatening.

"Come now, Mydeimos," he chuckled, "you're still recovering, it wouldn't be much of a fight."

Behind them Perdikkas leaned in close to Peucesta to whisper in his ear. The bard whispered back and then they were suddenly much more invested.

"Is this really the time?" Castorice asked.

"Is something wrong with the prince?" Krateros asked, still playing catch up.

"I'll break them up," Leonnius offered but Perdikkas was on him in an instant with an arm over his shoulder to stop him and Phainon couldn't take the second to consider that or answer Krateros before Mydei's elbow slammed into his temple.

He stumbled, dazed, and shook his head to clear the stars behind his eyes but Mydei gave him no opportunity to recover. The Kremnoan looped two fingers through Phainon's collar and started pulling him along down the stairs by the neck and all Phainon's remaining coordination belonged to the nearly impossible task of staying upright and not being strangled. He was still wheezing when Mydei half-led, half-dragged him into the galley proper, where he finally paused to take in the results of Anaxa's labor.

The professor and Ptolemy had covered every surface of the kitchen with reading material from Eurypon's study. Scrolls were shoved into the cold oven, maps were blanketing piles of tablets, and books were stacked haphazardly on the floor. Half of the preparation table was covered in glass bottles, vials, and flasks all shoved together to make space for more reading material. Loose sheets of paper of various ages were being held down by hoarded trinkets including a series of prototypes of the protective charms now reduced to paperweights.

Phainon watched Mydei like a hawk, anticipating the inevitable murder attempt but the man was handling himself suspiciously well. Any irritation that he harbored was neatly tucked away and didn't show in his body language or on his face.

Ptolemy raked over the whole party piling in with his eyes. His hands were full of shards of a broken jar that he unceremoniously tossed in a waste bucket. "How was your bath?" he asked.

Mydei let go of Phainon's collar and gave him a small shove, enough to get Phainon out of the way so he could state clearly and confidently to Anaxa's back, "Siren. The Black Tide is a siren."

Phainon slapped his own face. Ptolemy's eyes narrowed. Behind them Peucesta gasped, the others stewed in puzzled silence.

Anaxa didn't react right away. He was leaning over a pair of books and making notes in the margins with one hand while the other fidgeted with one of the improved, blood-soaked talismans. The red crystal inside kept making clunking noises as he pushed it around with a finger. It was the only sound for what felt like an unbearably long time as Mydei waited patiently, arms crossed across his chest, for Anaxa to say something.

Phainon hid his face in his hands, expecting the worst.

"I concur."

"…what?" Phainon mumbled, breathy and shocked. Mydei flashed him a smug smirk. Perdikkas swore under his breath and passed Peucesta a couple coins.

Anaxa stood up straight and twisted in place so he could look at Mydei without straining his neck. His powder blue eye glanced briefly over Mydei's state and took in the accumulated audience without a single change in facial expression.

"I'm with Phainon on this," Leonnius chimed in, "sirens aren't real."

"The world is vast and much of it remains unknown," Anaxa reasoned, "common truths told through stories and songs become sensationalized, eventually becoming legends but the truth does not stop existing as truth because humanity chose to treat it as a children's tale."

"'If any one unwarily draws in too close and hears the singing of the Sirens, his wife and children will never welcome him home again, for they sit in a green field and warble him to death with the sweetness of their song,'" Ptolemy quoted softly, mostly to himself. He had a look of concentration on his face like he was putting pieces together and wasn't very happy about it.

"This is why I generally refrain from sharing my hypothesis until after I have enough proof to draw a satisfying conclusion," Anaxa grumbled when he looked over everyone's telling faces, "The Tide *itself* is not a siren, but there is an argument to be made that it is a siren's *song*."

"It is a desirable thing," Peucesta mumbled, overwhelmed by the revelation, "even unto death."

"I had plenty of time to listen to it," Mydei explained, "I understand now the pull of it."

Phainon frowned. He wanted to refute this theory but didn't he just that morning wish he could pull the corruption from Mydei to take it for himself? He had wanted to hear the song again, however briefly. Peucesta had risked his life as a test subject when there was a chance of hearing it again and no one who had heard it and lived would argue against its sweetness.

"Do you still hear it?" Anaxa asked Mydei and the Kremnoan bowed his head and closed his eyes.

He waited a moment, listening, then confirmed, "I do, though it is faint."

"Have you claimed your coreflame?"

“No.”

Anaxa hummed to himself and raised his hand to press the palm against his eyepatch, a gesture that Phainon remembered seeing a lot during his days at the Grove. “But you have bathed in the golden blood?”

“I have.”

“Twice,” Phainon added.

“Was I talking to you, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae?” Anaxa snapped, “*rule number two!”*

He peeped and involuntarily took a step back behind Mydei with a mumbled apology and Leonnius snickered until that discerning eye turned on him next and then Leonnius was also cowering behind Mydei to hide from the academic.

Perdikkas raised his hand and Anaxa, pleased, invited him to speak. “I thought that siren song was supposed to beckon men with personalized temptation. Everyone who has discussed the song with me have described the same thing.”

“The song that Peucesta plays is indeed the same song I heard when I entertained corruption in my self-imposed exile at the Grove,” Anaxa confirms, “it does not vary, but our understanding of sirens comes entirely from a myth that does not explicitly state that the sirens sing of personal wants, only that the song is beautiful, enchanting, and drives men to their deaths.”

Ptolemy cleared his throat to get Anaxa’s attention and waited for the Professor to acknowledge him before he added somewhat skeptically, “*if* we treat the story of the returning hero as *fact*, then the sirens of eld were confined to a single island, one that was easily passed with wax in one’s ears. That is nothing like the Tide.”

“I agree,” Anaxa said, “therein is one of the questions that needs to be answered. If this is the work of a Siren, then why is their song manifesting as the Black Tide? By what power could a song become a transformative, persistent horror?”

There was no power in this world that could do that, Phainon considered. It came crashing down at once and he hurriedly raised his hand and waited to be called on when he realized the only thing that could even come close was, “A coreflame.”

“A reasonable hypothesis,” Anaxa praised and Phainon preened under the praise. “But this is still rampant speculation, and a theory needs supporting evidence before a conclusion can be drawn.”

Mydei stepped around the walking hazards that waited in every corner and reasonable walkway in the room to get to the table where he peered over at what Anaxa was studying.

“…you’re looking at my father’s research into the corruption of Nikador,” he observed.

“I am. The answer to this riddle is not *only* in a bedtime story. It is also in the study of the most ancient powers on Amphoreus. Unfortunately, Eurypon’s hoarded works alone are not

enough which is why our next stop is the Library of Garbaniphoro."

The Kremnoans in the room winced and Phainon tilted his head. "The Kremnoan royal library? Isn't that a part of Castrum Kremnos."

"It used to be," Mydei grimaced.

"Part of the building still is," Ptolemy corrected, "a very, very small part of the royal collection that we may have picked clean when we visited five years ago."

Mydei started scanning over the mess while he elaborated, "the library has always belonged to Kremnoans but was maintained by a conquered nation after the island separated." He waded through the mess when he found what he was looking for: a map of the northern seas.

Phainon hadn't forgotten about that piece of trivia from his youth. Castrum Kremnos, the fortress island, was famed in ancient days for being impossible to lay siege to because it *moved*. The island was not attached to the earth beneath dark waters after Nikador carved it from one of the northern continents after Georios rampaged across Amphoreus, sinking whole landmasses. The Castrum remained untethered for nearly a thousand years until half a millennia ago when a Kremnoan king used giant chains to bind the city to another, rooted island, where it remains today, the same chains Phainon had seen with his own eyes.

"The library didn't sink into the ocean?" Phainon asked, "When Georios sank the mainlands during the War of the Titans?"

Mydei shook his head. "Krateros has been there."

They all turned to look at the veteran who had been listening quietly as he tended to do during serious discussions.

"I have," he confirmed, "but even before the Black Tide claimed the ruins, only one wing was left. Part of the library burned to the ground after an accident and what remains has not been tended to for nearly fifty years."

"Aside from the Grove it is the oldest repository of knowledge in Amphoreus," Anaxa said with crossed arms, "and the only one that may still hold records of the Northern Kingdom of Hyperborea." When everyone blinked at him in confusion the professor sighed. "The Kremnoan Dynasty once divided the Kingdoms of the north and those of the south. The Grove, allied with Okhema, primarily hoarded knowledge that pertained to the southern sphere of influence, while information and studies of the north gathered in the Library of Garbaniphoro. As the Tide stems from the north, it is to our benefit to study the Kingdoms that once existed there."

"Hyperborea fell roughly a thousand years ago," Phainon thought aloud, "I can't imagine much will have survived that long."

Mydei tilted his head. "A thousand years ago? How did it fall?"

"Scholars have debated that topic for centuries," Anaxa lamented.

Mydei shook the map out and laid it on top of the flattest surface he could find and checked the date twice before he started searching for the tiny island that housed the library. The map showed the advance of the Tide Line, but the captured island wasn't the only thing Mydei was looking at.

"The Black Tide came from the north," he observed and somehow pointing out the obvious was revelatory to everyone there except Anaxa, who mumbled about having just said that very same thing.

"Y'know," Leonnius mused, "these maps are very outdated."

"If for no other reason than to update them…" Ptolemy agreed.

"Captain?" Perdikkas asked. He was looking at Mydei, but Phainon still had to resist the urge to answer.

Mydei traced his finger along the northernmost edge of the map. It was mostly blank, colored in dark as lost territory, forever inaccessible due to the Tide. Phainon watched the man slowly form a fist with that same hand to lightly press his knuckles to a tiny island, very far away, surrounded by black. "We will go to the library when the crew are rested and the Chryseus Leo is restocked for a long journey."

"Finally," Anaxa purred, "some hope for answers."

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It felt like it was only yesterday the last time Mydei had participated in a send-off celebration, and for him it almost was. The feasting before they had left for Castrum Kremnos to retrieve the coreflame nearly drained the city's stores. This one was far more humble and intimate, reminiscent of days spent relaxing in the evenings at sea, only instead of the deck of the Leo, they feasted in Mydei's open home on the hill, drank what wines they could find, and told stories, dressed in their familiar finery once more.

Surrounded by the crew he cherished, Mydei listened to them regale him with tales of the moments he missed, not to make him feel poor for his absence, but to eagerly include him. Everything from the name of the new chimera that had stolen Fig Stew's affections, the details of their daring debacle of a rescue, of Captain Hephaestion and First Mate Krateros, and the many complaints about the food they had been made to endure the last month. They even let Phainon show off his new sword with a tacky name.

They relentlessly teased Phainon, especially when rosy cheeks from too much drink fueled rough-housing and the former interim captain was thrown over the balcony railing to cheers and toasts when Mydei announced the most excellent news of Phainon the Pirate's official debut as crew. He had rejoined Mydei's side with leaves in his hair, a scratch on his face, and the biggest grin.

"Shall I make him my first mate?" Mydei had teased when he took a moment away from the festivities to share a break with Hephaestion.

“That was only if I died, Mydeimos,” he laughed.

“If I should be so lucky.”

“Alas, I had orders not to.”

Mydei bumped Hephaestion with his knee. “I will not make that mistake twice.”

“Titans above you better not.” They laughed and then Hephaestion leaned forward over the balcony railing, breathing deep of the cool air of Curtain-Fall Hour before saying, “Phainon told me to leave him in Okhema, I’m sure he told you.”

Mydei grunted in confirmation.

“After we saved him, Phainon asked me if he made the right choice leaving you, since in my limited time as captain I chose to disobey him when he gave me the same order you gave to him.”

“Circumstances were different. You made the right choice, so did he.”

Hephaestion laughed softly and put a hand on Mydei’s shoulder. The man felt so much frailer and older now. The chlamys over his shoulder barely covered the scar on his chest but even with these shallow breaths, Hephaestion was full of mirth when he responded, relieved, “that is exactly what I told him. Come, we must toast to victory, the one we have achieved and the one yet to come.”

“We must,” Mydei agreed, and they both went back inside.

As promised in Mydei’s remarks before they went to battle, every crewmate toasted their victory over the Coreflame of Strife while it flickered on bold display in the middle of the table, glowing brightly in the presence of its master and practitioners. They toasted the Chrysos Heirs, honorary crewmates on the eve of another voyage, who raised their own glasses with equal fervor. They toasted those that had gone to that great blade in the sky, and to those that remained on distant shores.

They danced and laughed until the hour was late and those noble men and women departed to bathe, rest, and prepare themselves for the morrow until it was quiet aside from the strum of Peucesta’s lyre, revisiting the Tide song on the balcony and Phainon, who listened in quiet contemplation.

Mydei listened and watched them with a pleasant sense of déjà vu and quiet resolve.

He quietly set down his cup on the table between now empty plates and listened to Peucesta play in time with the song that still lingered in the back of his mind. A siren’s song. He was sure of it. Mydei had listened to that song the entire time he had been dying, a month of listening to sad sentiments, the longing of something deeply, profoundly *alone* and desperate. And he sympathized even as his muscles twitched and ached at the memory of death with such familiar honey in his ears.

Mydei let the world settle until the song began to repeat and then he accepted that it was time for action. He stood up and cracked his neck and stretched his arms. It just felt *right* to be back in his familiar clothes, armor, and jewelry, like he was himself again, the regal lion that his people considered him to be.

With the time for hesitation behind him, Mydei reached for the Coreflame of Strife. A cornered Leonnius had spilled the details of Phainon and Hyacine's ascensions and Mydei expected such brutality from Strife. He had no desire to take this thing into himself here surrounded by sleeping crew. Instead, he tucked it back inside its bag and slung it over his shoulder.

"Phainon," he whispered as he approached, and the man moved as though the word had roused him from sleep. He dreamily turned to Mydei with those sparkling eyes, blue as day against the moonlight glow of his hair in the dark. Phainon's smile wavered when he saw the bag over Mydei's shoulder.

"Mydei?"

"Come with me."

When they ran through the jungle paths, behind the waterfall, along the cliff, and under trees the same size as they were for the second time it was the spirit of competition. Phainon now knew the way and raced Mydei at every step, pushing him to be faster and stronger, to consider the boundary that he once reached for and to push through it entirely.

They broke through the tree line and this time it was Phainon who walked ahead across the smooth stone where they had once fought. He walked with confident strides and broad shoulders and Mydei looked at that man's back with adoration.

"Are you ready then?" Phainon asked over the crash of waves that showered them in fine mist.

Mydei walked closer, stopping several paces away to take the bag from his shoulder and reach for the coreflame within.

"I stand by what I said, Deliverer," Mydei told him as he tossed the bag to the side and held the coreflame aloft. It shone in the night like a bonfire, bright and desirable. "You are enough to fill the space that this power left." Phainon's head tilted ever so slightly, and he put a hand on his hip. Mydei's heart lurched at that smile. "But it fills me with indescribable anticipation when I think of meeting you in our full glory as Demigods."

Phainon's eyes flashed gold, the symbol of a sun inside the blue until none was left except the bright of burning flares and when he spoke it was strained with barely contained excitement. "I can think of no better way, Mydeimos, for two warriors to share in this moment, than to clash with all our power."

The shiver that raced through Mydei forced his toothy grin. It lit his blood on fire before the coreflame had even touched his skin and he felt in his bones the same eagerness that Phainon was struggling to hide. There were beasts inside them thrashing at their cages, desperate for

release to *run,* not to flee, but because they were *free*. That bloodlust that boiled in Mydei was not a desire to kill it was a desperate *need* for this man before him, to feel as they had the first day they stood across from each other, to feel as they had again here on this very shore. He wanted that thrill of meeting his match, of fighting until he collapsed, spent, and content knowing that his partner felt the same way after giving their all in return.

Mydeimos was ready to stand as equals beside this fellow Chrysos Heir to confront all the Black Tides of this world, unstoppable, indefatigable, and infinite. Strife and Worldbearing once again standing as allies, as friends, as lovers to be the envy of all other gods.

With Phainon watching, waiting, he made his choice to wield the fury of man to seize the authority of Titans.

Mydei pressed the Coreflame of Strife to his chest.

The agony was *instant* and unlike anything he had felt before. This was the pain of a thousand deaths compounded into a full body torture that dropped Mydei to his knees, fingers curled into claws as he fought the urge to rip the coreflame free as his insides twisted and burned. Something was crawling inside him, crushing his bones like kindling and remaking him from within. Crystal grew in his muscles and sinew, cutting through his body as they pushed through his skin.

Mydei's teeth clenched tight, he had stopped breathing, and his voice broke when his pained grunts and groans gave way to a scream that he could not contain. He threw his head back as facets sprouted across his whole body, keeping his hands from closing into fists, tearing though his flesh to add gold to the salty sea spray.

Growling around each ragged, desperate swallow, Mydei tried to flex and felt the crystals respond, power surged through his blood. Light rippled through his tattoos, and he heard the voice of Strife roaring inside him like an uncaged lion. Those claws tore at the inside of his ribs and bit his heart until he just… let go.

Mydei stopped fighting it and instead he listened, embracing those calls of conflict that screamed over the lingering Tide song, and let the lion loose. He roared himself and shattered the crystals in his palms so he could close his fists and toss an arm to the side to guide those shards where *he* commanded, letting them erupt around him and not from within him. Still the beast inside fought until more than just the familiar red was bursting forth. Something long and horrible was ripping from his back, he had no hope of standing with the crunch coming from his legs, and still that lion ate his insides.

He didn't know how long it took for that first transformation to run its course, nor could Mydei point to the moment when the pain turned into something more pleasurable, becoming instead a buoying power that made him sing. But he came to himself again with Phainon's hand on his shoulder and those familiar wings curled around them.

Phainon's Titan form was simply himself with a breaking, burned body, golden eyes, hair dyed blonde by the purity of his power. He had a long train from skintight robes, like twin battlefield banners frayed and torn at the ends, the same dark blue color as his left wing. A sun shaped halo floated behind his head, and shards of golden bismuth broke through the

flesh of his right shoulder. He was radiance incarnate on his knees to comfort Mydei who was still struggling to even process what he was feeling.

He had expected the pain of taking his coreflame, especially as the Inheritor of Strife, suffering was simply a part of the package. What he didn't expect was for his divine form to differ from that of the former Titan.

"Trianne said that coreflames grant wishes," Phainon said gently as though he could read Mydei's thoughts, "maybe Strife knew, that you wanted to be different than Nikador."

His body was still *mostly* the same from the waist up. Mydei was still himself, tattoos and all, though his hair was longer, wilder, untamed, and his ears had changed, round and fuzzy. They twisted to hang on Phainon's every word.

It was the waist down that was so different. Mydei's bottom half had been replaced with a lion's body like the centaurs of old myths and heroic stories but with paws instead of hooves and blood-red fur streaked with golden marks akin to his tattoos instead of the sorrel of horses. Golden armor adorned the lion's back and front paws, glimmering gold fabric blanketed his flank with the shining symbol of strife, and behind him hovered metallic wings with feathers like blades, waiting, detached from his shoulders.

Phainon gently cradled Mydei's face in his burning hands and Mydei realized how hard he was panting in the silence left behind by the silenced song. One of Phainon's thumbs brushed under Mydei's eye, tracing a shape so deliberately that it must be a new marking on his skin. Phainon followed it with the pad of his thumb under Mydei's left eye from his nose to his temple and then back again along his cheekbone. The other thumb pressed between his lips to feel the fangs there with genuine curiosity.

Mydei licked Phainon's thumb until it retreated and then he took a few deep breaths. The coreflame inside his heart stirred, excited, filling him with an unexpected fullness, of knowing that here, in this moment he was complete.

"Take your time," Phainon said as he pulled back to give Mydei space, but the Kremnoan reached for him and caught his hand, holding tightly until Phainon pulled Mydei to his feet, all four of them.

The sensation was insane, not only was he feeling his new limbs, but Mydei's senses had expanded. He could almost *smell* Phainon's impatience, his longing to fight, even if it didn't show on the worldbearer's face. He could sense the sharks in the water looking for food, *feel* the predators of the forest as they hunted by moonlight in the purest form of violence. Mydei's awareness and understanding of the world around him was accompanied with a newfound clarity that was too much to unpack right now.

He shifted on his paws, flicking water from one of them as the fur soaked up the moisture. There was a glow about him, the red of his fur, the bright gold of his claws, even his tattoos on his arms and chest glowed red and shimmered like sunlight. He twisted at the waist to inspect himself, to feel along the back of the lion body and shudder as he felt it. Another shiver traveled from his tail to his head when Phainon teasingly grabbed onto his wing. Even

detached he felt the touch that made his fur stand on end and he growled a proper growl before swiping at Phainon.

Crystal erupted from the ground to chase the arc of his swipe, but Phainon hovered out of range to dodge the attack and slowly floated down to sit on the peak of those facets with one knee pulled up so he could rest his elbow upon it. His cheek rested in his hand as he peered down at Mydei, as casually as though it were any other day on the ship and Phainon were teasing him from the shrouds. That cute smile and squished cheek, and the mirth in gold eyes were a comfort, a reminder that they were still the same inside, no matter what may have changed with their newfound divinity.

“You know I’ve been meaning to ask,” Phainon crooned, “where did your crystal powers come from?”

“Not every question has an answer,” Mydei responded. His voice was raw and hoarse with a permanent growl.

“Don’t let Professor Anaxa hear you say that.”

Mydei walked forward, relieved to find that he was not as helpless as a newborn, that the coreflame came with the instinct to know his new form as though he were always this way, as though this familiarity was a reunion and not a first meeting. His front paws climbed the crystal to raise him up to eye level with Phainon who kept smiling and watching until they were nose to nose and Mydei was reaching for him.

Phainon waited patiently while Mydei’s fingertips felt the cracks in his ashen skin, the sharp points of the collar that rested heavily against his collarbone. He traced the open gashes across Phainon’s chest, and his fingers came away gold with blood that didn’t spill naturally from those wounds that would never heal. He left bloody fingerprints on Phainon’s cheek as he gently pressed that tender flesh, feeling the heat of him like a burning sun, a seraph trapped between the giant paws of a predator.

“How do you feel?” Phainon asked, light, teasing.

“My bones have turned into steel, and my blood is seething and ablaze. There is a tempest within me, like I could fight a thousand years and not fall.”

Phainon’s wings vibrated when he shuddered at the thought. “How about we start with just tonight, Strife?”

“At your ready, Worldbearer.”

Chapter End Notes

I am a huge fan of biblically accurate Mydei with Nikador's body and arms but I am also a fan of lion-taur Mydei and for the context of the fic it made more sense to go that route. I apologize if that is not the image of Strife some of you were expecting.

Did Mydei have his crystal attacks in the game BEFORE the Trial of Strife? I can't believe it just occurred to me that his crystals are not an inherent ability.

Chapter 41: The Actions Louder than Our Words

Chapter Summary

New tag: Implied Sexual Content

The boys have a "talk" and the crew arrives at the Library of Garbaniphoro

Chapter Notes

It's not writer's block, it's writer's perfectionism I swear.
I'm taking these last chapters a bit slower because I want to be so careful to not miss any of the loose ends that I have left as we're now working towards the culmination of the plot. Also all the 3.7 stuff has me laying facedown in a ditch sobbing. They better be okay I swear to Kephale.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon had expected Mydei's transformation to be magnificent but what his crush became exceeded all his wildest expectations. Mydei's presence was weighted. Light bent around him like the shimmer of a mirage on a hot day carrying that call to arms and surge of adrenaline that Phainon had felt from Nikador. He was so different and yet wholly familiar, like this was just what Mydei had always been on the inside and finally everyone who beheld his glory could see what he was meant to be.

But the pure honesty of what they were, Phainon felt most when they clashed. When Mydei's summoned lance met Phainon's transformed Dawnmaker, the shockwaves tore the leaves from the trees along the beach and pushed back the ocean. When Phainon retreated to the skies and Mydei followed with those beautiful wings spread wide, the clouds parted.

Where Phainon had two wings, Mydei had six. They unfolded like a Titankin construct when Mydei had leaped into the sky. Each wing was stiff and metallic, detached from the sphere that centralized them. The sphere itself hovered behind the small of Mydei's back, in the curve of where the lion and man met. On the ground they crossed over the lion body, folded neatly aside from the topmost pair that had extended above him like a crown. Now as Mydei climbed into the sky to meet Phainon in the air they lined up along his body at intervals, reaching out like sunbeams in different directions to effortlessly carry his weight.

Every clash of claws on steel, every time their wings collided in a shower of sparks, light erupted and rippled through the vibrations. They chased each other as high as the clouds and then back to the island to shatter stone while the ocean churned and rolled. They were a

maelstrom in motion, every wingbeat stirring distant tsunamis, and every meeting of blades shook the firmament with thunder.

Phainon barely noticed the effect of their divinity on lesser things. Nature meant nothing to them like this, locked in glorious combat not for rage but for joy. The grin on Mydei's face no doubt mirrored Phainon's own, minus those sharp, elongated canines. Every time they clashed and leaned in close, Phainon could see the shimmer of the new gold tattoos alongside the familiar red ones, feel his breath and the rumbling purr in his chest, and be mesmerized by the eager ferality in his unchanged eyes.

He'd be happy to fight like this forever. He'd also be happy resting on top of that soft fur, playing with Mydei's fuzzy ears, and massaging those adorable and dangerous paws. Or even just holding Mydei in his arms as they used to be, changed back to human, Phainon didn't care as long it was Mydei, *his* Mydeimos.

They were so engrossed in their sparring that Phainon was genuinely angry when Pollux pounced on Mydei to drag him back to earth. The dragon was like one of Anaxa's projectiles hurtling through the sky to knock them out of it and Mydei was no less pleased. He shouted at Pollux the whole way down, paws flailing and kicking at the dragon's side. Phainon hurried to help, caught up in the excitement of a foe they could fight together but a tornado erupted around him, catching his wings like sails in a storm and throwing him out over the ocean.

He dashed back, skimming the surface of the water to leave a rising wake. Little Ica swirled at him again, but Phainon grinned at the challenge and rolled out of the way, testing the limits of his agility in the air, until he was able to jump on Pollux's back to pull at the dragon's ruff. The night sky turned to day above them, a spotlight that made the three warring divinities freeze when the light turned scorchingly bright. It defused the tension enough to allow rational thought to creep along the edges of Phainon's war-addled mind.

"Are you done now?" Hyacine asked with a sleepy huff.

Phainon held a hand up against his brow to block the light and he still had to squint to see Hyacine's glowing Eye of Twilight watching them from the dark beyond this pocket of daytime she had so casually opened. She and Castorice were still in their sleepwear. They both looked annoyed.

"Thank you, Miss Hyacine, Miss Castorice," Leonnius grumbled behind them.

Pollux bucked beneath Phainon, sending him bouncing along the beach where he lay face up for a second to let the bloodlust settle around his racing heart. The spotlight turned off and Mydei shoved Pollux away with both his hands and front paws so he could get up and stretch. His wings folded up behind him.

"Y'know, I think I would appreciate how cool you look *way* more Mydei if you didn't just almost sink the island," Leonnius complained.

"Stretching new muscles, Lord Mydei?" Castorice asked.

Mydei's lion rump sat down with a *whump* and he expertly spun his spear around his body until it settled on his shoulders with his wrists draped across the shaft. "Yeah."

Phainon slowly floated back over, hovering beside Mydei *just* enough to be taller. He really did try to smile apologetically but it must not have been very convincing.

Hyacine closed her eyes, pressed her hands together as though in prayer, and took a very deep breath. She held it until Little Ica sat on top of her head and then she fixed Mydei and Phainon in a stare that sent chills through their veins. Both of her eyes were wide with neon ripples, hypnotic and very disappointed.

"I know you're excited but you both should be more aware of the damage you have caused," she scolded. Mydei scoffed but when he unsummoned his lance in a flash of light, crossed his arms, and looked down, it was with a modicum of genuine shame.

Phainon let go of his sword and it too dissolved in light. He scratched at his cheek, embarrassed, and looked around at the ruined beach. The now naked tree line was leaning away from the ocean instead of reaching for it, sand had been blasted away into new dunes, and the stone shore was cracked and broken. The landscape had been changed at a fundamental level in that short spar.

"Is everyone okay?" he asked sheepishly.

"No one is hurt," Leonnius reassured them, "but everyone is definitely *awake* now."

Phainon wilted under those accusatory gazes.

Mydei sighed. "We will personally apologize to all those who were left awestruck by our formidable presence."

"Maybe don't word it like that to them when you do, Lord Mydei," Castorice advised.

Pollux barked in agreement.

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The Chryseus Leo departed with the receding tide, leaving behind the bones of the settlement and packed full of supplies for a long voyage. The crew had started grumpy and stayed grumpy after Mydei's apology but after a few Entry Hours of sailing, the familiarity of hard work aboard the ship they loved put everyone back into good moods.

Mydei was captain again, Phainon was just one of the guys, Anaxa had begrudgingly given up the kitchen at mealtimes, and things were 'normal.' Or at least as normal as possible with five Demigods on board a ship sailing north to places untouched by man in twenty plus years.

There were subtle changes too, nothing *bad*, just different. Mydei could see them from his favorite spot at the railing. Fig Stew was with his new chimera best friend, showing Beagle how to work off that lavish lifestyle he had left behind. Vigethos' belly was all but gone with hard work and Mydei's Kremnoan discipline.

Hyacine and Perdikkas were assessing bandages in the warm sunlight and ocean breeze. Every once in a while they'd laugh, and the sound would carry to Mydei's ears. Anaxa was discussing something with Hephaestion near the entrance to the galley. The other day Mydei had seen Castorice in the shrouds helping Leonnius. He had barely recognized her wearing pants and not her favorite lavender dress.

But mostly he watched Phainon. The man was standing at the railing port-side near the bow with Krateros, sketching their ideas for new carvings with charcoal, dressed for hard work. Mydei liked Phainon's regal coat, armor, and cape, but he liked this version of Phainon too. The version that was simple, focused only on the task ahead of him with his whole heart, humble and pure, unchanged by the divine weight of his holy authority. This version was stripped down to just his boots, pants, and his favorite shirt that cut low down his chest and barely hid the black choker he always wore. He had insisted it was part of his "signature look" and Mydei was forced to agree when Phainon took it off for a day and it threw off the whole crew.

Ptolemy slapped him with a rolled-up scroll. "Mydeimos, are you listening at all?"

"Hm," he grunted and leaned more of his weight on his arms on the rail.

"What did I just say?"

"You were requesting stew for dinner."

"I was trying to show you the change in the Tide Line," Ptolemy whined.

Mydei sighed. It had become harder to focus during peaceful days like this. Even in his human form, Mydei could feel the lion inside him getting drowsy in the warm sunlight and the peace of being surrounded by friends. Strife longed for combat, but combat with purpose meant enjoying the moments worth fighting for in the first place, especially the simple things like naps. Something to live for as Perdikkas would say.

"Show me," he ordered, and Ptolemy unfurled the scroll again.

"We saw the Tide retreat after we saved you, but this is… Hyacine says it's possible the library is no longer in Tide territory," Ptolemy was saying, "the victory at Castrum Kremnos might have set the Tide back almost a hundred years, she won't be able to see for sure until we're a little closer… Mydeimos."

"Hm?"

"Stop looking at your boyfriend for more than a minute please, *captain*."

Mydei's eyes snapped back to Ptolemy. "He is not my boyfriend."

"You haven't talked about it yet?" The bookworm looked unimpressed.

"It has not come up."

“’No god could make a finer looking fellow than you are, but you are a fool,’” Ptolemy deadpanned, “have you at least fu-hmph!”

Mydei slapped his hand over Ptolemy’s mouth roughly. “No, and it is not any of your business should we choose to! I don’t care how much money you have put on the topic of my love life.”

Ptolemy bonked Mydei on the head again with the rolled-up scroll and then pulled away with the toss of his head. “We just want you to be happy, Mydei.”

“I am and he already knows that I love him. I am… waiting for him to say it.”

Mydei turned back to the railing to rest his elbows on the polished wood and leaned over. A hand settled roughly on his back with a light slap and then Ptolemy asked gently, “would you like me to kill him for you?”

Mydei snorted, a quick and simple laugh, “there is no need. If he takes too long, I will wring the words from him myself.”

“And how long is too long, Mydeimos?”

He didn’t respond right away. “I am sure I will know.”

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“Have you told the young prince how you feel?” Krateros asked and Phainon’s knife hand slipped, very nearly ruining the scene he had been working on all Entry Hour. Fortunately, the curl of carved wood that fell to the deck was thin and the cut shallow.

“W-Where did that come from?” Phainon stammered.

“You have done nothing but recommend stories from Prince Mydeimos’ life for these reliefs,” the old man accused.

“That’s not true.” He pointed to where Krateros had sketched out Fig Stew and then Krateros put his finger above Phainon’s to point to the Mydei sketch holding that very same charcoal chimera.

“It is no secret that you two have grown close,” Krateros reminded him.

“…yeah,” Phainon relented. He turned around and went back to carving, digging firmly and confidently against the wood so the strokes would cut cleanly. Every swipe was slowly outlining Mydei’s Titan form.

“Is it something you have discussed with him?”

“Not really.”

Not since the night Mydei woke up again and kissed Phainon like he was life itself. Fighting on the beach had *felt* like a discussion… They hadn’t found the time to revisit that passion

since setting sail. Between their duties and the threat of the Tide, Phainon wasn't sure if it was still on Mydei's mind at all and there certainly hadn't been a 'right time' to confess his love for Mydei. The captain already knew that Phainon loved him, he didn't need to say it out loud yet.

Krateros grumbled, disapproving. "Cowardice does not befit a son of Kremnos nor a god."

His knife slipped again, nearly cutting off Mydei's tail. "I am no coward! …I just want the moment to feel right."

Phainon waited for Krateros to scold him, but it didn't come. Worried the old man had simply left him entirely, Phainon looked up and over his shoulder to see Krateros still standing there, already back to work.

"…Aren't you going to yell at me?"

He didn't even look over. "I know a lost cause when I hear it."

"You're not going to give me advice?"

"Do I look like your parent?"

Phainon bit back the urge to call Krateros his *grandparent* and said instead, "I expected you to say something like 'the battlefield is dangerous, and you never know when the last chance you have to say it has passed!'" Phainon's old man voice was comically horrible, an unintended mockery. "Or 'Mydeimos doesn't care if it's romantic or perfect he just wants to be with you so stop delaying your own happiness especially before the most important battle of our lifetimes!'"

Phainon paused to listen to his own words for a second and then he stood up and handed the carving knife to Krateros. "Thank you, Krateros."

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Mydei was just starting to send Ptolemy on his way when Phainon came up the stairs, white hair bouncing on every step except for where sticky sweat held it to his forehead. He smelled like hard work and wood shavings.

"Captain Mydeimos?" Phainon asked, "Do you have a minute?"

"What is it, Deliverer?"

Phainon smiled from ear to ear, his eyes flashed gold and then back to sapphire, and he said firmly and happily, "I love you."

Mydei was so startled by the earnest and beloved declaration that he almost transformed. The coreflame and his heart were dancing and high-fiving and whatever else was causing that ridiculous overflowing feeling while he stood there with his arms crossed blinking at that beautiful smile that rivaled the brightness of the sun. His jaw dropped, ready to say it back, to say anything.

“*Get fucked, Perdikkas!*” Ptolemy shouted over the railing in Kremnoan, down to the main deck with a loud, celebratory *whoop!* “*You and that string strummer owe me 20 each!”*

The blood rushed to Mydei’s cheeks and colored his ears and chest. Endearing. His crew were endearing, really, but holy fuck they could not read the room sometimes.

Mydei threw Ptolemy over the rail to the deck below with a yelp and a crash, fuming for all of a second before he was turning back to Phainon to grab the front of that handsome man’s clothes, pulling him in tight to kiss him. He didn’t care that the crew’s attention was on them now, he really didn’t. The rest of the world faded away for that kiss, especially when Phainon held onto his wrists and pressed back with equal passion.

“I love you too, Phainon of the Chryseus Leo,” Mydei said when they pulled away and then he gave the man a playful shove. “Now get back to work before the ship falls apart without you.”

“Aye, captain,” Phainon teased with a salute, “permission to call you my boyfriend, captain?”

Mydei crossed his arms to hold his racing heart back. They’d have to talk about this later for sure…no, no more later, they had enough later. “Permission granted… would you like to speak more of it? Perhaps tonight over food?”

Phainon was almost wiggling he was so happy, Mydei could see it in the way his hand trembled and in his adorably awkward fidgeting when he reached up to scratch his face and then his hair like he did when he was particularly nervous or apologetic. “Would you like me to cook?” he asked.

Mydei’s smile immediately dropped. “No.”

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Phainon spent the rest of his day in a state of eager bliss. He finished his chores, finished Hephaestion’s chores, and then he worked on the railings until the smell of good food called the crew to eat on the heels of two very happy, full-bellied chimeras. He wiped the oil from his hands and wandered towards the galley, but Mydeimos called him from the upper deck and Phainon answered without question.

Finally, alone in their room to discuss the culmination of yearning, the food was left forgotten on the table. There were so many better uses for their mouths right now. As Ptolemy and Hephaestion had once said, they were men of action, not words, though a few managed to slip out between heavy breaths and pants. Each one was a desperate prayer, a whispered name, a song on swollen lips longing for each other.

Mydei smelled like fresh bread and olive oil. The scent clung to his soft skin and Phainon could taste it when he dragged his tongue over hardened muscle. It lingered on his lips when they kissed and was all encompassing when they embraced.

He was soft skin and taut muscle, the kind of sculpture that the gods had made to tempt lesser men. Mydeimos was perfection incarnate in every heated touch, every soft gasp, and eager

growl, a beauty that men longed for, that Phainon was humbled to even know, nevermind be given permission to touch with such intimacy.

They reached for each other with unbridled urgency that broke the first hammock in a matter of minutes and the second followed not long after. Neither of them could be bothered to care, the world had shrunk to only them, no other name on their lips, no other thought than the realization of desperation.

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Mydei had spent the Action Hour remembering what it was like to live in a kitchen again. He happily did his job cooking for the crew and then he spent his time making a proper meal for himself and his *boyfriend*. Something with love and care that ultimately didn't matter because when they met in their room that night, alone, to discuss this budding relationship, the food was left forgotten on the table.

Phainon smelled like carpentry, resin, and sweat, warm like a sunbeam. He tasted like salt and was rough along the edges like a man tempered by a hard work, but Mydei didn't want him any other way. He was honest in a way that Mydei admired, humility honed into something boyishly handsome. Phainon was proof of overcoming adversity, of humble origins ascended to something angelic and selfless.

Every touch, every kiss, pulled sweet hymns from Phainon's lips, even when their antics chased them to the rough ground it felt fitting in a way. They didn't need a palace, though Mydei would give him the world if he could. They didn't need any pomp and circumstance; there was nothing proper about this moment between warriors.

This was honest and true and entirely them. Even if he hadn't expected this when he set those plates down on the table, still waiting, undoubtedly cold, now that Mydei rested with Phainon wrapped around him, he couldn't imagine how a conversation would have even gone.

Phainon's heart was still racing against Mydei's chest. His own was pressed up close against his ribs to reach for its other half. He could still hear it when Phainon pulled away to lean over Mydei for another gentle, and chaste kiss.

Ever the wordsmith, Phainon said softly, "I love you."

"I love you," Mydei repeated, and that was all the conversation they needed.

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With fair winds and suspiciously clear waters, the Chryseus Leo's voyage to the Library of Garbaniphoro was almost a pleasure cruise with plenty of free time for the crew to weaponize their boredom into ridiculous schemes and competitions. Many of Phainon's prior commitments were still ongoing but he made a point to participate in every proposal and contributed his own ideas at every opportunity.

He was still meeting with Perdikkas weekly and was surprised and relieved to see that Mydei was too, taking his own private sessions with the doctor to work through difficult memories.

Phainon still practiced his Kremnoan and was now passably able to speak to every crewmate in his heavy Okheman accent. He knew the story of the wandering hero by heart and was on his fifth readthrough, this time out loud with Mydeimos before bed. They had given up trying to repair the hammocks and concluded they simply were too heavy combined to share one and had rearranged the room to use the originally designed bed space as an actual bed and not shelving.

Phainon still sparred with Mydei in the Entry Hour and trained with Krateros in Parting Hour. He still fished with Leonnius once a week and helped Peucesta and Hephaestion polish and care for the ship. The only thing he ended up dropping from his schedule was lyre lessons from Peucesta and after he found the bard teaching Castorice and Hyacine how to play and harmonize, he didn't feel particularly bad about that.

The other Demigods had already felt like part of the crew before they left but if there was any doubt remaining, that was gone now. Hyacine and Perdikkas now had hidden code words between them to complain politely about their patients. Peucesta and Castorice were harmonizing old Styxian folk lullabies in their sleep much to the chagrin of the rest of the crew. Anaxa and Krateros kept getting into stubborn yelling matches that they repeatedly insisted was all in good fun and held more structured debates with Ptolemy when the Kremnoan scholar wasn't beta reading Castorice's latest works or recording the Leo's history.

It was the family that Phainon wanted to take on the world beside and that chance was literally on the horizon.

The Library of Garbaniphoro was a relic of ancient times, more so than Castrum Kremnos had been. From the ship it looked mostly intact perched high on the cliffs, but then the wind pushed the Leo around her side, and the collapsed wing of the library was a more accurate advertisement of her state of disrepair. Phainon did not care in the slightest. The main building was still standing strong and besides, the older and more rundown the better. He loved old things, old ruins, old artifacts, there was a history that spoke from the dust when open-minded explorers sought out those voices.

Centuries had not taken from her the elegance of ancient Kremnoan architecture, the strength to withstand, even as whole buildings crumbled around her down the cliffside, her façade still stood resolute. The cliff itself was as described in legend, as straight as though it had been cut and as steep as though that cut had come at the hand of the master. The most ancient parts of Castrum Kremnos still rested in the water, the tops and bottoms of buildings long worn into facsimiles of their former glory stuck on the shoals. Time had not been kind but tall pillars, covered in moss, barnacles, and other sea life still stood like spires protecting the knowledge of eons.

"…because you need me to navigate the shelves!" Ptolemy insisted as he followed Mydei across the deck. The captain stopped next to Phainon to study the distant library himself.

"We have Anaxagoras for that," Mydei argued without turning around.

"Anaxagoras does not read ancient Kremnoan!"

“It’s possible that the tomes we are looking for are in another language entirely,” Anaxa mused, and Ptolemy fixed him with a glare.

“If there are writings in Styxian, I may be able to help,” Castorice offered.
Hyacine raised her hand to say, “I was helping translate the runes of the Skyfolk back at the Grove. It was one of my secondary degrees.”

“Of course, you both will be of excellent service,” Anaxa invited.

“Mydei pleeeeease!” Ptolemy begged.

“Where’s the harm, Mydeimos?” Hephaestion reasoned. The first mate looked so much better. He had handed off the docking procedure to Krateros who was shouting to the rest of the crew behind them.

“Hmph.”

“Oh, come on, Mydei,” Phainon teased. He reached out and squeezed Mydei’s bicep, just under the decorative clasp there. “It ended up being worse for our collection when we didn’t let Ptolemy into the Grove.”

Mydei’s stubbornness cracked under Phainon’s gentleness, and he grumbled, “Fine, you may be on the landing party.”

Ptolemy mouthed, ‘thank you’ to Phainon and he responded with a thumbs up behind Mydei’s back.

“Hyacine,” Mydei called, “can you see any evidence of the Tide?”

She put a hand up over one eye and closed the other for a few seconds. When she spread her fingers to peer out from behind them the wild eye of Aquila darted about, seeing things beyond any of them. It was a clear day with clear seas, sunny and humid so Phainon doubted any lingering Tide would have the strength to put up a real fight if there were any left.

“I don’t see any monsters, Lord Mydei,” she reported.

“Be on guard all the same,” he ordered and Phainon nodded his agreement. They were dressed for combat in their usual armor, just in case, and each of them had a backpack with minimal supplies and plenty of space to take what they needed in reading material. Phainon and Mydei’s bags were full of food in case they had to stay the night up there, a reasonable assumption considering the size of the library and how deep they were into Action Hour already.

The landing party was chosen from volunteers and was thus notably small. The scholars of the Grove were all, of course, far too excited to be excluded and carried critical experience at ancient sites. But the Kremnoans were harder to convince aside from Mydei, Ptolemy, and Peucesta whose love of stories made this trip a sort of pilgrimage, but Phainon was surprised to find that Krateros and the entire Old Guard refused to set foot on shore. The old veteran had muttered something about holy ground meant only for Kings and attendants but refused

to elaborate further and instead wished them well. It was an odd sentiment coming from someone who had attended the late King Eurypon and Queen Gorgo and had browsed the shelves here before.

Old dock gave way to even older stonework only a few strides away from where the ship was tied, worn smooth by the sea. There was no port here and only the one dock that had gone through thousands of repairs. The farther they walked along it the more Phainon could see the style change as though they were literally walking backwards through time to the small platform that connected the walkway to a steep path that wormed its way up to the jewel of the northern seas.

Phainon was losing his mind he was so happy. He was one more comment away from being kicked off the side of the cliff as punishment for the way he loudly noted the remnants of the old city along the cliff, the scarring in the stone from Nikador's blade, even the bowed nature of the *stone* steps worn by centuries of footsteps.

"The Kadirans used to worship Aquila," Ptolemy told Phainon as they walked. He pointed out some of the circular symbols carved on some of the steps. "Even after Kremnos conquered them and they became caretakers of the library, some of their traditions survived for many generations."

Phainon traced the eye carving with his fingers as they passed, holding up the line to do so. "Have you heard of them, Hyacine?" he asked.

"No," she admitted, "there were a great many city-states that worshipped Aquila, my primary focus of study was the Sky-folk, but it does not surprise me to see the Eye of Twilight is a surviving symbol."

"Symbols that are believed to ward evil and poor intentions are fitting for a library," Anaxa commented, "there is no other symbol on Amphoreus as widely recognized as the Eye of Twilight than perhaps the Dawn Device."

Phainon had to pause while Mydei leaped across a small gap. The walkway ahead had washed out, whether from a storm or age it was impossible to know. The prince waited on the other side, hand extended to catch the others. Phainon stayed behind to help the girls with their jumps, giving them a little toss over the gap and into the safety of Mydei's arms. He tossed Anaxa too with mumbled apologies but Ptolemy and Peucesta had no issues making the leap, nor did Phainon, but he appreciated Mydei's firm grip on his arm when he landed.

"Ptolemy, do you know why Krateros wouldn't want to come here?" Phainon asked as they started the last stretch of the ascent.

"I do not. What did he say?"

"Only that it was holy ground meant only for royalty and their attendants."

"There are several tales about the library that may give superstitious men and women pause," Peucesta said lightly. He was towards the back of the caravan. "Some believe that Nikador severed the library from Castrum Kremnos to leave behind their wisdom in pursuit of more

violent glory. Others say that the library is cursed, as not even Georios wanted it when they sank half the world into the ocean. Or perhaps it is as simple as a man unwilling to see a beloved landmark in ruins."

That was a humbling thought, but Phainon was undeterred and when they finally reached the top and stood beside the pillars that marked the once gates of the Library of Garbaniphoro, he was almost moved to tears. The statues that may have once adorned the tops of those pillars were long gone, leaving broken tops and vine covered carvings but they still dutifully marked the narrow path that opened beyond them to a modest sized courtyard. Leaves and sand filled the dry fountain, debris piled up along the edges and filled cold braziers, and a soft sort of peaceful quiet muted all but the sounds of their footsteps.

"The doors are intact," Anaxa observed with his arms crossed.

"So is the surrounding frame," Ptolemy mumbled.

The façade of the library was a massive thing, built for kings and gods two stories high in a manner reminiscent of the Kremnos Arena. The doorway was framed by pillars and sloping walls that reached as far as the cliff to guide guests into that gateway marked by arches. The double doors were twice as tall as they were wide and covered by an extended cornice. Scenes of Nikador were carved into the pediment above, faded into shadows of their former glory.

The bookworm was the first to approach the gilded door. The bronze fixtures that held the handles were shaped like lion heads, holding the rings in their teeth, but when Ptolemy gave it an experimental tug nothing budged. He tried to push. Nothing. Peucesta joined him and they tugged in tandem, but nothing moved.

"Is there a password?" Phainon asked.

"Magic was not a Kremnoan specialty," Anaxa huffed, "nor was it one of Ancient Kadir."

"I'm sure it's just stuck," Ptolemy grunted as he slammed his shoulder into the heavy door repeatedly. "It hasn't been opened in a very long time."

Phainon started stepping up to help, but Mydei held a handout to stop him. There was a puzzled look on his face as he studied the door.

"Ptolemy. Peucesta. Come away from there," he ordered. Ptolemy pouted but he followed the bard down the pair of steps that led to the threshold and waited impatiently to the side.

"Mydei?" Phainon prodded.

Mydeimos stepped to the side and tilted his head, looking at the door from a new angle. Then he paced past Phainon, parallel to the façade to crouch and tilted his head again. It was like watching Beagle try to figure out a food puzzle. Back and forth to watch how the dusty bronze plating caught the light until he finally, finally stepped up and approached the door with reverence. He placed his hand on the door, pushing with his gauntlet only briefly before he crouched again, studying every inch of the door's seam.

“Deliverer,” he called and Phainon and the other’s started forward. “*Only* Phainon,” Mydei corrected when he heard more than one set of footsteps. Phainon crept forward with excited trepidation, searching for whatever Mydei may have noticed until they were side by side beside this mighty threshold.

“Did you see something?”

Mydei nodded. “How old is the Goldweaver?”

Phainon frowned. “Old. At least a thousand years old.”

Mydei pressed his gauntlet to the door again and curled his fingers to drag the tips of his claws gently across the surface until they caught on to something nearly invisible until it was tugged: a golden thread.

Phainon blinked and reached to pluck it, but it held tight, no weak thing like those they had pulled from cargo in the past. Instead, he felt further down the seam of the door counting those subtle changes of texture when his fingertips brushed another thread. There were more than a dozen at least.

“Aglaea sealed the door?” he mumbled curiously to himself.

“Okhema has been at war with Kremnos for hundreds of years and Krateros was here no more than twenty years past… when could she have done this?” Mydei wondered.

“Would you like to share with the class?” Anaxa shouted from the courtyard.

“No!” they both shouted back at the same time.

“They must have been here for centuries,” Phainon guessed, “waiting to seal the doors in case of an emergency.”

“An emergency such as the Tide.” Mydei plucked at a thread again and it shimmered gold before it vanished again, too thin to be perceived without catching the light.

“But the Tide has receded, why are they still binding the doors?” Phainon wondered aloud.

Mydei’s eyes were narrow, deep in thought. Phainon could see the wheels turning in time with his own. What was Aglaea trying to protect here? Were these threads still attached to her? What value did this library have? How could she have known so far in advance to leave these threads here with this explicit purpose? Aglaea was clever and ageless, but she couldn’t see the future. Only one Demigod had the gift of Prophecy and that was…!

“Mydei,” Phainon mumbled, breathless, “I think I know what it’s waiting for.”

The Kremnoan looked up at him expectantly with a curious tilt of his head, but Phainon was focused on this lock. He made a fist with his left hand and held it to his chest and put his right hand, palm flat on the door. It took some effort, but Phainon closed his eyes and gently tapped the power of his coreflame, letting it feed into his fingertips so the golden thread could feel it, could recognize him.

The threads across the door glowed bright gold and the others waiting behind them gasped as they revealed themselves but even though they saw him, it wasn't *Phainon* they wanted.

"Mydei," he said, excited and trying to articulate, "I think they're waiting for *you.* I think they're keeping *Nikador's* wisdom for the Inheritor of Strife to come and reclaim it."

The recognition hit halfway through Phainon's sentence and Mydei reached out with confidence. The power of Strife surged through him. Phainon felt it like a heat wave with the whispers of conflict in his ears, filling his heart with excited bloodlust and then it was gone, shattered with the threads.

With a heavy groan and long creak, the doors slowly opened outwards like a gaping maw finally letting go of a long-held breath. It smelled of papyrus and stone, dust and ink, of promise.

"Alright, Aglaea," Phainon mumbled under his breath, "What were you hiding from the Tide?"

Chapter End Notes

I'm not able to write out all the shenanigans but please know that for like a week, every time someone called for the captain, Phainon responded at the same time as Mydei, and he always had the stupid expression: :3c
After the 20th time, Mydei threw Phainon off the ship and Peucesta won five coins each from Ptolemy and Perdikkas.

Chapter 42: The Library of Garbaniphoro

Chapter Summary

No new tags

They're at the library! But someone got there first...

Chapter Notes

So 3.7 killed me for a few days and then Currency Wars owned my soul for the rest of the week. :')
I am so sorry for the delay, I promise I'm still alive just taking care of irl things and farming jades for Mydei's rerun coming up. I feel like Phainon would forgive me for that so you guys can too.

3.7 gave us the ACTUAL name of the library and it's not the Library of Garbanphoro but I'm gonna commit so before people in the comments say something, I know and I am lazy ;w;
That's future me's problem when the perfectionism kicks in and I've already finished the fic. That's when I'll fix the little things. :')

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Old things smelled old and new things smelled new. It’s one of those things that is inherently recognizable and equally indescribable. Even if there are other scents involved that are easier to put a name to, the core of the scent is ‘new’ or ‘newness’. This library mostly smelled *old*, and it was divine. Phainon loved when history tickled his nose. He loved new scents too; the metallic bite of armor unworn, ink freshly applied to white paper, and the woody pine tar of a ship before her maiden voyage. But there was something so special about old smells.

Especially when those old scents were coming from a massive, legendary atrium fit for kings. The library opened immediately into a massive grand hall with arched ceilings held up by two rows of marble pillars. It was deeper than wide, maybe three, no, four times as long lit by filtered sunlight through dirty glass panes and marble shaved so thin that the sunlight made the ceiling glow brightly. Cold braziers hung from hooks on every pillar, a promise that study didn’t have to stop at sundown.

A massive statue of Nikador waited for them near the entry way, protected by curved desks that would have belonged to dutiful record keepers. Smaller statues, painted amphorae, carved plates, and tapestries lined the walls and filled display shelves. The space down the

center of the hall was reserved for large statues, depictions of Gorgo slaying the Lion of Tretos, of former kings on dromas back, and Nikador fighting Aquila. Even from here Phainon could see their spears raised high, nearly piercing the ceiling.

“Curious that the way was blocked by golden threads,” Anaxa said as he stepped up beside Phainon and the hall caught his voice, amplifying it. The group was approaching the threshold with appropriate caution. They had all seen the glow of those fine threads and Aglaea was no stranger to traps. “You wouldn’t happen to know anything about that, would you, Phainon?”

“I have my suspicions, Professor, but nothing more than outlandish theories.”

Anaxa’s grunt was unconvinced but respectful.

He didn’t turn to acknowledge his teacher. It was taking every ounce of Phainon’s strength to not skip wildly into the atrium to inspect every article he could find. Nothing in here needed appraisal but he certainly wanted to give each piece the attention they deserved as though they did.

“Regardless of her motivations, she has protected a treasure of my people and possibly the answer we need,” Mydei announced as he took a single step into the library. The fine layer of dust curled around the metal of his greaves in tight curls when it was disturbed. “I owe her a great debt.”

Ptolemy shook his head and reached for Mydei’s arm, holding him back from walking any further. “Hold on, Mydeimos. It would be unwise to move on from this so quickly. Krateros was just here something like twenty years ago, and it was still open. *When* could she have left threads like that?”

“Lady Aglaea is over a thousand years old,” Castorice informed them, “she may have been here many lifetimes ago.”

“She must have left them here a long time ago in case the Black Tide came for the library,” Hyacine theorized out loud.

“I had the same idea,” Phainon admitted.

Mydei raised a hand to look at his fingers, there were still crumbling pieces of thread there, finer than hair, only visible in the glow of sunlight bouncing off the pillars to brighten the threshold. “And left them at a time when Kephale and Nikador were still allies.”

Anaxa didn’t bother theorizing with them. He was the one that finally had enough speculating and walked into the library as though it were his own back at the Grove. Confident steps kicked up dust as he immediately headed for the front desk to start digging around at the scrolls and tomes tucked onto the short shelf behind it. Ptolemy followed next, starting at the opposite end of the shelf.

Phainon eagerly started after them, but Mydei’s hesitation caught his attention and gave him pause as well. The prince was looking around with increasing confusion.

“Is something wrong, Lord Mydei?” Castorice asked as she gently reached for him, stopping just before touching his shoulder.

“Where are the books?” he asked genuinely.

“It is a failing on our part that you have not been to a proper library,” Peucesta lamented.

“It’s a fair question, Lord Peucesta,” Hyacine posited, “the library at the Grove had plenty of shelves in their atrium.”

“The Library of Garbaniphoro is a fortress or a vault as much as a place of study,” Phainon explained. He didn’t bother trying to hide his excitement as he rapidly recalled what he had read of the place in his school days. “Libraries that house rare and important tomes store them away from public areas and send librarians to fetch them on behalf of the scholar requesting access.”

“I imagine many of the wings are open for perusal,” Anaxa hypothesized from across the foyer. He found the tome he was looking for and dropped the heavy thing on the desk, unceremoniously wiping the dust from its spine and the edges of its pages. It was as thick as Anaxa’s hand was wide. “The oldest works will be sealed away for preservation.”

“What should we be looking for?” Hyacine asked aloud as she slowly meandered into the open space and towards the front desk. She leaned over the desk to look at the book upside down as Anaxa slowly pulled it open and started running his fingers over the delicate lines, pretending he could read the Kremnoan.

“For now, gather everything you can about the Titans, Coreflames, and the Black Tide,” Phainon told her.

“And anything about the northern Kingdoms,” Castorice remembered aloud.

“We are primarily here for the rest of Eurypon’s research,” Anaxa firmly reminded them. “But grab anything that may be even tangentially relevant,” he added with an air of condescension, as though it was frustrating that he felt like they needed the instruction to do so.

Ptolemy was also leaning over Anaxa now as Peucesta came up on the other side. Pinched between the two Kremnoans the professor looked particularly diminutive and annoyed, but they were flipping through the pages with better understanding and pointed purpose.

“Looks like we want collections beta, eta, iota, pi, rho,” Ptolemy noted.

Peucesta pointed at something on the opposite page. “West wing nu and chi too.”

“Mydei and I can take the west wing,” Phainon volunteered. The captain flashed him a look, but Phainon was already speed-walking into the depths of the hall, skipping ahead to admire each piece in passing as he searched for the best stuff.

While the center of the hall was dedicated to the kings and gods of the past the spaces between the pillars and the outside walls belonged to desks and tables for study. They were

closely packed in the gaps between the different doors that lined each wall. Each gateway led to their own pocket of collections with labels carved into the frame above them.

Phainon had read about this library several times over his school years. It was famous for a lot of reasons, but it was affectionately described as labyrinthian by scholars of all ages and histories. The library may have started simple and small, but over time, as it expanded, construction had to embrace some creativity to find space to grow. Many of these pockets were still single rooms adhering to like topics, but Phainon was learning with every curious peek that some of them stretched into other floors. Most featured stairs that led towards dark expansions above and others reached into the depths, where they made use of the space beneath the ground.

“We may have benefitted from a map,” Mydei mused as he caught up to Phainon again. The prince was holding steady, walking slowly to take in the atmosphere but not pausing, whereas Phainon kept hurrying to stop in front of every relic. He would race past Mydei, get distracted and stop to study a piece of interest (and they were all of interest), and Mydei would slowly pass him again.

“Where’s the fun in that?” Phainon asked cheerfully. He skipped ahead to where there was no door, only a brightly lit opening that led to the west wing. Across the hallway the east wing had long since collapsed, filling the doorway with rubble, and leaving them with only the one remaining option.

“It’s here, Mydei,” Phainon called but his energy was firmly reined in when he saw Mydeimos pause for the first time in their steady journey towards the truth.

The captain had stopped beside a hanging tapestry, looking at it with a guarded expression, hiding how it made him feel, if it elicited feelings at all. Curious, Phainon joined him to study a window into Mydei’s own history. The image depicted a king standing on a cliff, holding an infant over the edge above a hungry sea. At his feet a woman was on her knees, hands raised palms up. She was dressed as a warrior, a true Kremnoan with long, wild hair, blonde with strawberry red tips and a sword at her side. Men stood at attention along the cliff behind them, watching.

“…if you could go back,” Phainon started to say.

“Stop.”

“Mydei-”

“No.” He didn’t say it harshly; there was no pain in his voice. “It is because of my past that I am here now. How can I not look back on this tragic moment as anything less than a blessing?”

Phainon blinked in surprise at the sentiment and then again when Mydei grabbed the leather armor strap across Phainon’s chest to pull him in for a quick kiss. Too quick for him to reciprocate. The shock had barely passed when Mydei let him go and walked past him towards the west wing. He disappeared around the corner, but Phainon stayed rooted for a moment more to study King Eurypon and Queen Gorgo.

It is because of my past that I am here now. How did that man do it? How did he always find the simplest and most profound ways to describe the storms in Phainon's heart? Distant past, near past, it didn't matter.

Phainon put a hand over his heart and bowed his head in respect to Queen Gorgo's sacrifice and contemplated the flicker of grief that he still carried from Aedes Elysiae. They were both haunted by the weight of their past, but Mydei had never seemed *heavy* with it. What mattered was the now and the future, the future they were now empowered to save.

"Deliverer!" Mydei called and Phainon hurried to catch up.

The west wing was a maze, but they were finally getting into the readables. There were still shelves of relics, which made sense, Amphoreans were creative when it came to record keeping, but Mydei and Phainon were finally surrounded by seemingly endless rows of long shelves. The ceilings away from the atrium were low, supported by thinner pillars with fewer sources of natural light. The walls were still composed of marble but the thin sheets that allowed light to pass through were fewer and farther between. Phainon and Mydei found themselves lighting braziers as they went, where it was safe to do so. The efficient fuel in each little hanging basin was less than full but would last a few days at least without tending.

Phainon paused frequently to pull scrolls and steles from the shelves to check their contents. The labels on each shelf were faded and those they could read were not helpful. Each shelf had numerical codes that undoubtedly corresponded to a catalog at the front desk, a system that was useful to the keepers of these treasures but of little use to them now.

He was delighted to find that his studies in Kremnoan were coming in handy. While they were surprised to find some works in Okheman, the vast majority of what they found was predictably written in Mydei's native tongue. Phainon found himself easily distracted with every book he picked up. Things written on paper, whether scrolls or tomes, were more recent additions or less important than those things written on steles or even thin sheets of brass. Some pieces were copied into multiple formats in the name of preservation, heavy when stored on metallic mediums but far more likely to last.

It was *fascinating* to Phainon to see what the library's keepers considered worthy of long-term preservation. A few sheets of brass had meticulously been imprinted with the Kremnoan recipe for stewed lamb. Another set recorded the bloodline of the royal chimeras, keeping records of their pedigrees for hundreds of generations, beginning with the esteemed Absentee Master.

Everything about this place carried an air of permanence and for Phainon it also harbored an inherent romanticism. They had not said a word to each other in many quints but Mydei's soft breathing, his heartbeat just one shelf over was a comforting background sound as Phainon read about ancient ship building techniques from a scroll.

He started to put it back but paused as Mydei removed a tome from the other side and their eyes met through the shelf. Phainon smiled at him warmly and was met with soft eyes and a gentle grunt.

"Anything?" Mydei asked.

“Not yet.”

“Hm.”

Phainon put the scroll back and then wandered around the end of the shelf so he could press in close behind Mydei to wrap his arms around the man’s waist and breathe him in. The library was cold. Mydei was warm. He rested his forehead on a strong shoulder and closed his eyes to just be, to exist in this moment, surrounded by the history that led to this single moment in time.

The Kremnoan mostly ignored Phainon, his focus was on the book in his hands before he sighed and put it back on the shelf to instead reach up to tug on Phainon’s hair. It was brief, light, and immediately followed by the firm press of fingertips on Phainon’s scalp.

“The Professor said that the oldest works may be sealed away,” Mydei whispered. To speak any louder when they were side by side would have felt blasphemous in this quiet place.

Phainon lifted his head and rested his chin on Mydei’s shoulder instead. “I wouldn’t know where to start looking for any sealed rooms.”

“Perhaps along the wall would be best,” Mydei teased.

Reluctantly, Phainon let his hands fall back to his sides, letting his boyfriend go, but Mydei turned and caught his hand before he could walk away to pull him into a proper kiss. This time Phainon was ready, and he reached up to cradle Mydei’s face, holding him tightly with his fingers entwined in those silken locks. His pinky rested over Mydei’s braid, and his thumbs gently cradled the hinge of his jaw. Mydei’s own hand settled over Phainon’s collarbone, slipping up as they kissed to loop a finger under Phainon’s collar just in case he considered trying to escape, a thought that made Phainon inwardly laugh.

They pulled away, breathlessly caught up in the moment, and Phainon leaned in again to steal with his lips the breath that Mydei had just found in their moment of reprieve but a gauntlet on his chest gave Phainon pause. While Phainon studied Mydei’s lips, his long lashes, the crimson tattoo beside his eye… Mydei was looking past Phainon with a puzzled expression.

“It makes sense,” Mydei mumbled and Phainon curiously followed his line of sight to the shelf behind him. “If she left them on the door, why would she not leave more for other purposes?”

Clinging to shelf behind them was a golden thread. It glimmered brightly, happy at their display of public affection and Phainon felt the blood rush to his cheeks and ears at the prospect of having been caught kissing in an abandoned, but still public, library. Mydei was far less concerned with that part. He pushed Phainon away so he could reach for the thread, giving it a tug to pull it free from the shelf and it brightened, shining into the depths of the library until it turned a corner.

“I didn’t see it before,” Mydei grumbled with a frown.

“The threads belong to the Titan of Romance,” Phainon mused aloud, “perhaps they reacted to our ki-“

“HKS!” Mydei snapped as he punched Phainon in the shoulder to stop him from talking. Perhaps Mydei was shy after all. He crossed his arms with a hmph and turned away but Phainon was already moving on.

Even if the thread was activated by something simple and somewhat silly, it was still *here* and that meant something important. Aglaea sealed the library to protect it from the Tide, something she must have known would happen via prophecy or an experienced hunch, it didn’t matter. In any case, something in this library had value and this thread might lead them to it.

Phainon took one end of the thread and started following it between the shelves. Mydei’s footsteps stayed close behind.

She led them into the depths of the west wing, lighting lamps as they went, past several walls before slipping into the impossible space under a door in a dark corner at the end of the longest stretch of bookcases yet.

“Sealed away,” Phainon whispered, musing mostly to himself but Mydei agreed with a staccato grunt. The captain was already feeling along the thin edges of the door, barely visible against the wall while Phainon fumbled to light the dark brazier hanging above the label. He almost dropped the flint twice as the two pieces clacked together over the fuel until a spark caught on the aged oil and a flickering flame finally decided to catch hold with a yawn.

Phainon held the brazier up by the chain, bringing the light up and over their arms to dispel the shadows around a tiny keyhole. Mydei picked at it with a claw, but it wasn’t big enough for more than just the sharp point. Phainon gently pushed Mydei aside so he could crouch down to look at it himself. This door and lock were not particularly heavy. It was not likely meant to be a vault so much as just inaccessible to the public which meant…

Mydei came to a similar conclusion and Phainon was calmly but firmly pushed away from the door before a Kremnoan shoulder barreled through the thing, snapping the thin lock and forcing those stiff hinges to bend. With a sleepy creak the heavy door came to stop moments before it could slam into the wall behind it.

The room beyond had two bookshelves that were half empty and a flight of stairs that led to a basement floor, but Phainon’s heart was still at the door. He ignored the pleas of the thread to follow its brightness into those dark depths and instead shuffled forward with a horrified expression to gently wiggle the door on its hinges to check that it was okay.

“…must you mourn a broken lock?” Mydei grumbled, “it had to be done.”

“Brutish Kremnoan,” Phainon huffed in mourning. “To assault a piece of history like this is abhorrent!”

“Would you have *truly* preferred to have searched for the key?” Phainon stuck out his lower lip in lieu of a response and Mydei stepped forward to pinch it lightly with his claws and take the light from him. “Come along, Deliverer, the answers will be worth the price.”

The stairs took a single turn on the way down, turning into a short, narrow hallway when they reached the bottom. There were two rooms on each side, no doors, just wide openings into matching small square rooms.

Phainon followed Mydei and the light into the first one. A small but sturdy square table centered the room, surrounded by short, thickly built shelves along all four walls to support the shining brass collection. There were no scrolls here, only thin stone steles and books with pages of thinly hammered brass, guaranteed to last for thousands of years without copying. The gold threads glowed around three books in this room, wrapped around each of them in loose coils before continuing to the other rooms.

The first tome that Phainon set on the table to check was thankfully written in Kremnoan. Though the foreword from the Scribe who penned this piece was quick to list the original source, a record from the lost Hyperborean ----. Phainon puzzled over the word for a moment, not sure he was reading this correctly.

“Mydei, is there more than one word for ‘kingdom’ in the Kremnoan language?”

“Not that I know of.” Mydei leaned over Phainon’s shoulder to look at the word himself and his brows wrinkled. “It does not say kingdom, it says empire.”

“I thought Hyperborea was a kingdom.”

“That was my understanding too.”

Phainon shook his head and turned the page, scanning the contents for a moment while Mydei read beside him. It was definitely *close* to what they were looking for, a record of the old northern kingdoms, but this was written like a fairytale, a romance between a tyrant and her loyal knight. Whether it held any historical truth was hard to determine, but folklore from the country they were looking into was at least a start.

A second book confirmed they had the right the section, but Aglaea’s threads stopped being useful beyond that. Every piece they wrapped around was a love story, tales of romance that attracted the wayward threads. Too far from their master, they must have simply defaulted to what they knew, seeking love where they could find it.

Phainon had started building a collection of works to bring back to the others for further investigation, choosing those that spoke about the political environment more than the emotional one, so he was surprised when he set another brass book on the table and realized Mydei was still reading the first book they had picked up.

“I don’t think a fairy tale will help very much, Mydeimos,” Phainon teased.

“Was it not a fairy tale that led us here?” Phainon opened his mouth to retort and for once, words failed him. He frowned, an expression that deepened when Mydei’s lips curled in a

victorious smug smirk. “This tale is embellished but the figures were real. The scribe refers to scholarly works in the footnotes.”

Phainon tilted his head. “Which ones?”

Mydei went back a page, leaning back so the metal sheet wouldn’t smack his face as he scanned the margins and footnotes before reading aloud, “Rise and Fall of the Hyperborea Empire, Vol 3.” He turned a couple more pages. “Daughter of the Sea: A Study of Oceanic Peoples.” Another page flip. “Dukes of the Imperator.”

Phainon sorted through the books he had pulled to see if any of them matched. A few of them were here already and the others he found within the quint. Every time Mydei found a new reference, he told Phainon and as silly it seemed at first, the fairy tale was saving them a lot of time narrowing down potentially useful information. It was especially so when Mydei found the word ‘siren,’ proving that they were not just a storybook monster created to scare children.

From there Phainon found more proof of sea sirens as a people, creatures that lived in the depths of the ocean in a time all but forgotten, the most well-known of which came onto land to hide among humans.

That was when Phainon and Mydei closed their books and began packing them exactly evenly into their bags, determined to make a single trip of this treasure trove of information. While the temptation to curl up where they were to keep reading remained, Phainon also knew that the others would likely want a turn with this material. Anaxa especially would be eager to have every puzzle piece in front of him before he started assembly of the bigger picture. More than that, the longer they waited here the more these four rooms were beginning to feel like a tomb and Phainon was eager to taste fresher air.

Finding their way back took a quint and by the time Phainon and Mydei returned to the atrium the others had already claimed and pushed together two long tables and a pair of desks. Someone had cracked open one of the boxes on the tables to access the loose paper and ink inside and tossed out any inkwells that were improperly sealed and no longer usable. The tables were piled high with everyone’s discoveries including a rolled-up tapestry and set of decorative plates.

“Um,” Phainon started as he searched for a spot to set down their finds. His arms were starting to ache, and his shoulders were numb.

“Set it anywhere,” Anaxa ordered, distracted. He was pacing back and forth along the longest edge of the table, picking up books, scanning through them, setting them down, and scooping up another on the next pass. Back and forth, mumbling to himself, while the others snacked on food they brought and watched the Professor at work.

“Has he been like this the whole time?” Phainon asked. Castorice was the closest to them, sitting on the end of the bench. She looked up and nodded with a mouthful of figs and then hurried to help when she realized how many heavy things they had brought back. Every work thudded on the table when they set them down and pushed them into the pile to join the others within Anaxa’s reach.

The professor cut himself off mid-sentence when he spotted a thinner book that Mydei was setting down and snatched it before it could properly settle on the table.

Mydei frowned irritably. “It is written in Kremnoan,” he warned, but Anaxa was already pouring over the pages and pacing away again, mumbling in a manner that sounded like only half a conversation.

“Your man is actually insane,” Ptolemy told Phainon like it was a new discovery and not something Phainon learned on his first day of class. He was sitting on the other side of Hyacine between her and Peucesta. There were three books open on the table in front of him, but his primary focus was on their snacks. Peucesta too had set the lyre away to pick at one of two bunches of grapes while he read.

“Would you like some, Lord Phainon, Lord Mydei?” Hyacine offered. She held up the bag they brought with the bread and meats wrapped up nicely inside and Mydei gratefully took it from her. He squeezed between Hyacine and Ptolemy to be within better reach of the snacky fruits, leaving Phainon to find another spot for himself.

A part of him really considered squeezing in after Mydei anyway, to make room for everyone on the bench even if it was a very tight fit, but Phainon’s hunger for food was outmatched by his curiosity. He instead leaned over the table to see what else the others had found. Time had passed more quickly in the dark bowels of the library than he realized. The light from outside had faded to barely a glow and the others had efficiently made use of every minute to build a pile that towered dangerously up to Phainon’s eye level.

They had found the rest of Eurypon’s research notes, stories about the flame-chase, detailed, dry records tracking the Black Tide, collections of lyrics from bard songs, genealogical records, military records, on and on in what was probably only the surface of a very, very deep ocean of knowledge. Phainon watched Anaxa pace and then he watched the other five as their heads followed the professor back and forth as they ate in relative silence. Even away from the shelves in this more open place there was a reverence that hung heavy in the air and a numbness of tired minds.

Phainon leaned over to grab one of the hard rolls to chew on while he read about… what *did* he pick up? He put the bread in his mouth to hold it while he thumbed through paper pages. It was a collection of essays written in Okheman from a scholar that had moved from the Holy City, then to the Grove before they finally traveled here to study at this library maybe sixty years ago. They were researching coreflames, but the margins were full of notes, someone rambling about corruption in Kremnoan.

He put his thumb against the spine to hold the book open in the middle so he could take the roll from his mouth to ask, “how did you guys find so much in so little time?”

“We had help,” Hyacine beamed.

That sounded familiar. “Threads?” he asked.

“Nymphs,” Ptolemy corrected, “…did you find more threads?”

Anaxa stopped pacing and everyone stopped talking to look at him in alarm, but the professor mumbled to himself about distracting voices and instead grabbed an armful of books and stomped off to a farther corner of the hall to study.

“Don’t mind him, Lord Phainon,” Castorice reassured. She patted his arm from where she was sitting. “He is upset that everything he wants to read was found by a nymph.”

Phainon snorted, a half-chuckle in disguise, “then he will be particularly displeased when he learns how Mydei and I found our books.”

“A golden thread?” Peucesta asked. He was looking up from his book with gentle curiosity.

“Yeah, Mydei and I found it after we-” Phainon cut himself off when Mydei’s head whipped around to glare at him.

“After you?” Ptolemy prodded as he put an arm around the captain’s shoulder. Phainon could see the coy grin spread across Ptolemy’s face as he noted Mydei’s blush and rapidly came to horrible conclusions fueled by his favorite genre of literature.

“We kissed! *Only* kissed!” Phainon hurried to say before that imagination could get too far ahead to stop. Castorice and Ptolemy both looked disappointed.

“And the Titan of Romance revealed a golden thread to you?” Hyacine mused. There was a lightness to her tone like she was biting back a laugh.

“Mhm,” Phainon hummed as he took two long exaggerated steps to stand behind Mydei. “I wonder what else we could find if we-”

Today was just a day for unfinished sentences. Mydei’s arm looped around Phainon’s neck and pulled him down flailing and scrambling to get free. “Do you *want* to finish that thought out loud, HKS?”

“Kinda, yeah—Ah! Mydei stop!” Mydei’s grip tightened until Phainon had to drop his book to tap out and only then did the Kremnoan let go so a flustered Demigod could fix his hair and remember how to breathe again.

“Does it have to be you two *specifically* making out?” Ptolemy mused, mischievously looking down the bench at the two girls.

Peucesta came to their rescue. “I would be willing to try with you, Ptolemy.”

“You know I have nothing but love for you, Peucesta, but what would *Perdikkas* say?”

“Pay up.”

“That’s right and do we *really* want him to win?”

Peucesta sighed and picked up his lyre, answering with a sad tune that may have once been a love song.

“Don’t worry, Lord Ptolemy,” Hyacine said brightly, “even if we didn’t find any threads, the nymphs were more than helpful.”

“It is curious that the Goldweaver has played a role on this voyage,” Mydei thought aloud. He popped a grape into his mouth and then dug around in the bag for one of the meat wraps he had made before they left.

“Is it though?” Phainon asked and the others turned to look at him. “Aglaea has been leading the flame-chase for almost a thousand years, she’s been a Demigod for longer. Half the stuff here she could probably recount from memory.”

They sat in silence to consider that before Castorice asked, “so why didn’t she?”

“More questions,” Ptolemy sighed, “we have a long night ahead of us.” Mydei twisted in his seat to say something, but Ptolemy beat him to it. “We already sent a note to the Chryseus Leo. Little Ica took it down to them. They know we are well, safe, and staying the night.”

Mydei gave him a single pat on the back and reached for a book from the pile while Phainon recovered his from the floor.

“Let’s get started,” the captain ordered and Phainon eagerly obeyed.

Chapter End Notes

> Phainon being a fucking nerd and taking his time in this damn library ruined my outline again. I'm not changing the chapter count yet but it might be 51 chapters, I swear to Kephale

Chapter 43: Regaled Vow

Chapter Summary

No new tags

The pieces are on the table and the puzzle is coming together

Chapter Notes

I would have finished this yesterday but I got distracted reading other fics. Hot damn there are amazing writers out there.

This is mostly exposition. I'm hoping it's not too boring ;w;

By the time they had settled down to sleep, Phainon had gravitated back to the love story that the threads had first led them to. Even if the shimmering gold had only been attracted to the romance of it, Phainon felt like there was something here that wanted to be uncovered. This story wanted to be told, not buried in an ancient crypt.

He read by firelight and every time he got to an unfamiliar word he gently poked Mydei and the Kremnoan would sleepily translate. If it was a word that he didn't recognize, Mydei would pass the book down the line to poke at Ptolemy who decided that if he had to be woken up every hour, so did Peucesta. The two would sleepily determine the most accurate translation and then pass the book back down the line until finally the patience snapped and Ptolemy yelled with sleepy tears that he wanted to be left alone until morning. The shouting summoned Anaxa, still very awake, enjoying the quiet time to study, to send all four of them back to sleep like unruly toddlers.

But good stories had a knack for finding good readers the strength to keep healthy choices at bay and Phainon was engrossed in this tale of the siren knight. When Anaxa walked away and Mydei's breathing slowed with sleep, Phainon pulled the book from his pack once more to read.

In many ways he felt like he could relate to her, in others not so much, but his heart resonated with the themes of being lost and found. The story didn't say how the sea siren lost her home, only that she swam from the depths alone and took on a human form to find companionship and purpose. She found joy in serving the woman she loved, her commander, the Imperator, and this love was returned in subtle ways. The Imperator threw feasts for her and their friends

with roaring fires, good food, and fine wines at every reasonable opportunity, and they would dance together, unperceived in front of the bards.

That was the part that puzzled Phainon the most. On several occasions the story would describe a great battle, a grand celebration, and a dance between these two lovers, but ever conscientious of appearances, the Imperator would insist they dance in secret. How in Kephale's name was it possible to *secretly* dance in the middle of a party?

He made a note of every page that mentioned the contradiction and resolved to ask his friends in the morning if it was a translation error on his part. Still trying to figure out what the author could have meant, he fell asleep on brass pages.

Phainon woke up a few quints into Entry Hour. Knowing how late he had stayed up, the others had let him sleep in but Perdikkas' happy greeting and everyone hurrying to meet him brought Phainon back to life with a sleepy blink. He was barely sitting up and still trying to process that the doctor had joined them in the library at all when Mydei dropped a whole pomegranate in his lap and then sat down, cross-legged beside Phainon with his own.

"Perdikkas?" Phainon slurred and Mydei tilted his head. The confusion turned to recognition when Mydei's eyes darted between Phainon and the doctor.

"He brought breakfast and another pair of eyes," Mydei explained. The Kremnoan reached out to run his thumb over Phainon's cheek with an amused twinkle in his eye. It was a funny sensation that left behind an uneven tingle until Phainon reached up to rub his cheek too and felt half a page imprinted there. "For a moment it seemed you confused me for him. Perhaps tonight you should join us in sleep sooner and rest on something softer than brass."

Mydei let Phainon go to cut open their breakfast with a small knife. He made sure Phainon was eating first before he cracked open his own fruit and they picked at the seeds while they watched the others laugh around the table. Hyacine was excitedly talking to Perdikkas about some of the books they had found, Castorice and Peucesta were helping hand out food, and Ptolemy had distanced himself to read some more while he ate. Phainon couldn't see Anaxa but that wasn't any cause for alarm. It wouldn't be a worry unless he went missing for more than an Entry Hour.

"I wish we could stay here longer," Phainon mused. He popped a couple of the tart seeds in his mouth, savoring the juice on his tongue while he watched the light of Entry Hour filter in from above, leaving trails in the dust before settling on the big statue of the Lion of Tretos. A butterfly nymph was perched on the lion's nose, sunning itself in the light.

"Spoken like one that has already solved the mystery of the Tide," Mydei countered. Their knees bumped into each other as he turned to better face Phainon.

"No, I mean, *a lot* longer," he tried to explain, "beyond any study of the Tide. I want to explore every wing, study every tapestry…" Phainon trailed off when he saw how Mydei was looking at him. "I know it's stupid."

"It's not," Mydei corrected quickly, "and there is no reason we cannot return once the matter of the Tide is settled. It *is* my library after all… and what's mine is yours." He looked away at

that last part, glaring intently at the pomegranate rind that he was slowly tearing apart with the claws of his gauntlets.

Phainon's heart warmed at the thought, and he reached out to put his hand on top of Mydei's. "Does that apply to everything?" he asked, light-hearted and teasing.

"HKS, I meant what I said as I always do. Do not abuse my generosity."

"I wouldn't dream of it, Mydeimos."

Mydei still refused to look at Phainon but any moment they may have had was chased away by the sound of staccato footfalls and the fluttering buzz of tiny wings. Anaxa was storming down the center of the hall on as straight of a path as possible with his hands full of a massive stack of papers. Trailing behind him were a pair of nymphs, one of the beetle varieties, pale blue in color, and the other was a bright pink butterfly. Anaxa paused twice to turn around and swat at them, but they just fluttered out of reach and then followed him again all the way back to the main table.

"Class is in session!" he announced loudly as he slammed that massive stack of papers down onto an open spot. The whole table jumped and while the books settled quickly there was a short scramble to keep the food from rolling away.

Phainon knew better than to keep the professor waiting. He grunted to himself as he got to his feet and held a hand out to help Mydei up. The two of them gathered close behind the others, standing to give the others space to sit on the bench. Castorice slid over to make room for Ptolemy, and he rejoined them with his own notes and breakfast in hand.

The professor scanned them all, did a double take when he realized there was an extra Kremnoan, and then decided he didn't care. The bag under his eye was heavy with indifference.

"I can confidently announce that I know the source of the Black Tide," Anaxa said firmly.

"Oh, is that all?" Ptolemy said sarcastically. He was still unhappy about the late night. Phainon was fighting a yawn himself.

Anaxa's eyes snapped to Ptolemy. "Would you like to present to the class first?"

The bookworm frowned and said, "I didn't realize you wanted to copy my answers, Professor."

At the far end of the table, Peucesta excitedly leaned over to whisper something in Perdikkas' ear, but the doctor lightly smacked his chest and shook his head.

"If you would fight, please do it outside," Mydei sighed.

"There is no need, Captain Mydeimos," Anaxa purred, "it would be faster for me to teach than test after all."

Anaxa leaned over to shoo the two nymphs that had happily settled on his stack of papers and took the top inch in hand to thumb through them. He smiled to himself, building suspense and some annoyance before he announced, “the Black Tide is the song of Dux Gladiorum Hysilens, the Demigod of Ocean, a sea siren from Hyperborea.”

The silence hung in the air for a long breath as the information settled on the group. No one seemed wildly surprised, but no one hurried to agree either. They were all taking a second to chew on that conclusion while weighing it against what they had studied themselves. Phainon definitely felt like some explanation was *missing*, but nothing he had read contradicted that statement.

Anaxa’s eye traveled over all of them in turn before settling on Ptolemy, taunting the Kremnoan, and Ptolemy was trying very hard not to rise to the bait. Instead, he politely invited through gritted teeth, “would you please *enlighten* us on how you got to that conclusion, *professor?”*

“I would. Before I begin, I would remind the class of rule number two: do not interrupt me. Silence is golden. If you have something to add, raise your hand and wait to be called upon.” Anaxa waited to see if any of them would disobey at the start, but everyone held their peace and, satisfied, the professor continued, “I will begin by laying down foundational knowledge to support my conclusion. After consulting with the rest of Eurypon’s study into Nikador and corroborating with my personal experiments in the Grove on the Coreflame of Reason I can definitively conclude that the Black Tide is unable to corrupt coreflames.”

Ptolemy was already raising his hand and Anaxa sighed but went ahead and pointed at him. “A coreflame is the only power in this world strong enough to create the Tide and Titan’s *do* experience corruption. There are plenty of notes here and stories that describe the Titan’s descent into madness *before* Eurypon began experimenting on the divine body. Mydei and Phainon both said there was no speaking to the Titan and that’s to say nothing of the other gods.”

“The *Titan* is not the same as the *Coreflame*,” Anaxa reminded him, “every Demigod here can attest that any corruption from the *Black Tide* was cured by their ascensions, taking the Coreflames into their bodies.”

Phainon nodded, so did the girls, Mydei crossed his arms and bowed his head, agreeing.

“So, you’re suggesting that Nikador was what? Experiencing corruption that *wasn’t* from the Black Tide?” Ptolemy prodded and Anaxa grinned.

The professor started taking sheets of paper off the top of his stack, his mint-green ponytail bounced against his shoulder as he slapped them down in turn, while listing, “Georios, a Titan corrupted, driven mad they sank continent after continent into the sea. Aquila, a Titan corrupted, closed their eyes and brought about the eternal night until Seliose slew the god and claimed the coreflame. Janus, citing the end of their ‘immortal’ life willingly surrendered the coreflame to the first Demigod of the new era.” He dropped two chunks in quick succession. “Talanton and Mnestia, Titans on the verge of corruption, they surrendered their coreflames.” A much larger pinch of papers dropped onto the others. “Nikador, famously gone mad with bloodlust, lost their reason and became a Titan corrupted.”

The professor gave them a minute to consider before he spelled it out for them, saying, “the coreflame is not the source of the corruption, it *amplifies* the corruption of its bearer and that corruption may come in many forms.”

Phainon took a sharp breath through his teeth and bit his lip. Anaxa’s eye darted to him.

“Something to add, Phainon?” the professor invited.

“I just remembered something that Lady Trianne said to me is all.” When Anaxa waved to him, Phainon recalled aloud, “she told me that coreflames grant wishes, and it’s very important for their new bearers to be ready for them… that the new Demigod needs to have good wishes.”

“*Exactly*,” Anaxa crooned, “the Black Tide is the work of a coreflame’s power, amplifying the corrupted wish of a siren.”

“…well, damn,” Ptolemy breathed in the silence.

“The sea siren connection makes sense,” Peucesta finally weighed in with his usual soft-spoken demeanor, “the Tide song is alluring, intoxicating, and addictive as the songs of sirens are meant to be in myth… why the Coreflame of Ocean? Could she not have had the Coreflame of Law?”

“The Coreflame of Law was claimed at the beginning of the flame-chase journey by the leader of the dominate Empire on Amphoreus at the time,” Phainon explained, “Imperator Cerydra.”

“There are three coreflames that cannot be accounted for,” Anaxa said as he thumbed through his notes again, “Earth, which was claimed by the Demigod Terravox in the early days of the Imperator’s flame-chase and disappeared with him. Then there were Law and Ocean, which were last seen together in the hearts of their Demigods nearly one thousand years ago during the height of the Hyperborean Empire.”

“Cerydra famously started the flame-chase journey after becoming the Inheritor of Law,” Castorice recalled. She didn’t raise her hand, but Anaxa let it slide in favor of the discussion.

“Lady Tribbie brought her the prophecy, and she began hunting the coreflames soon after,” Hyacine remembered. The healer started sorting through her own books, looking for her source in case she was called upon to cite it.

“That same prophecy that motivated the Goldweaver to assume command of the flame-chase after the Imperator’s death. The same one that she keeps close, away from all except those she has roped onto the path beside her,” Anaxa mused.

The eyes in the room immediately turned towards Phainon who blinked in surprise and tried to rein in his fluster. “W-Why me? Castorice and Hyacine are Chrysos Heirs too.”

“Lady Aglaea never told me the prophecy,” Hyacine said.

Phainon frowned. “Castorice?” he asked, and she shook her head.

“She never told me either, Lord Phainon.”

That was admittedly very puzzling. Why would she only tell him? It was no secret that Aglaea had slowly been grooming Phainon to one day take her place in Okhema at the head of the flame-chase, but why keep the prophecy a secret? It was little more than a vague poem, a list of coreflames and generic one line well wishes.

“Did Aglaea tell you the prophecy that drives the flame-chase?” Anaxa prodded.

“Yeah, she made me memorize the core part of it,” he admitted, “but it’s not insight into the future, so much as a shopping list of generic instructions.”

“Instructions?”

Phainon nodded. “It’s stuff like-” he gestured to Mydei, “*Fight to know the inspiration of Strife, that the world may know peace.”* Phainon gestured to Castorice next. “*Embrace the inevitability of Death, that the world may know life.* Stuff like that.”

“A mandate from a distant prophecy to make use of the coreflames…” Anaxa mused.

“It starts: *Red is the hand that seeks to assume the fire of the gods, the flame is discerning and knows their heart. Flow golden blood, flow. Reach for your missing pieces to quell the unease of corruption,”* Phainon quoted slowly, frowning, “*Losses are a constant on the flame-chase journey. Therein is the power to doom the world or save it.”*

Next to him Mydei shifted his weight, his hands holding his elbows in a crossed position gripped a little tighter.

“In all these readings, has anyone come across an explicitly stated reason why the flame-chase journey began?” Anaxa asked.

Mydei raised his hand. When attention turned his direction he spoke, saying, “I found a short passage that was supposed to be an excerpt from the journal of the Imperator of the Hyperborean Empire. She consulted regularly with ‘one who could see the future’ and believed that the coreflames would destroy the world if they and their bearers were not carefully controlled.”

Hyacine slouched where she was sitting and Little Ica dropped into her lap to provide something comforting to squeeze. “Many of these books described the Imperator as a tyrant bent on conquest… if someone like that got a coreflame…” The Imperator’s ‘wish’ was not hard to deduce. She would have happily ruled all Amphoreus.

Phainon’s grip tightened on the plates in his hand, the story that painted Cerydra in a more positive light with her Dux Gladiorum, with Hysilens. He hefted it up to look at it a little more closely.

When Aglaea first took Phainon under her wing she had him study history with Lady Tribbie. They talked about Cerydra on several occasions, but it was all surface knowledge, the kind of thing that was written about here in a somewhat plain manner: dates and lists of conquests.

The Imperator had taken great pains not to be the primary subject matter of historical records despite her prominence at the time. Most of those books focused on specific events, victories, and the establishment of the flame-chase. Events that Tribbie and Aglaea never expanded on past what was written in his textbook.

At the time, Phainon thought nothing of it but now it seemed strange that Tribbie and Aglaea would keep the more personal parts to themselves, after all, they were *there*. Aglaea and Tribbie even made appearances in *this* book, however brief. They were comrades.

“Was this Cerydra a siren?” Mydei asked, “could it be her song?”

“No, there was a single siren in her army at the time,” Anaxa explained.

“The Dux Gladiorum, Hysilens,” Phainon mused aloud.

“*What did I say about interrupting?”*

“S-Sorry, Professor!”

Anaxa sighed and continued, “Imperator Cerydra’s Dux Gladiorum, her most loyal general, was a siren.” He held up another pinch of paper and slapped it down on top of the spent stack. “And the Inheritor of Ocean after the Imperator led her armies against Phagousa, the Ocean Titan.”

Perdikkas shook his head a little bit. “I’m sorry, I know I’m late to this study session, but I’m already lost. How does this tie back to the Black Tide?”

Rather than be annoyed, Anaxa was surprisingly patient when he said, “perhaps a timeline of events would help?” He didn’t wait for Perdikkas to agree and instead rifled through his notes until he found the page he wanted.

“Over a thousand years ago, sea sirens lived in the depths of the ocean, but an unknown catastrophe drove at least one of them to the surface where she shed her fins to walk among men. Around the same time the Kingdom of Hyperborea lost their royal bloodline and went in search of any lost heirs.” Anaxa waved his hand in circles and then took the top sheet of his notes off to set it down on the spent pile. “How Cerydra came to be the Imperator is of no consequence, what matters is that she rose to power, found the siren, and gave her a home serving as a general of her armies.”

Perdikkas slowly nodded, following so far.

“The Titans had already begun to pass their coreflames to the next era of Demigods around this time,” Anaxa explained. He paused when Perdikkas’ face wrinkled with confusion. “Has something puzzled you?”

“Maybe. Is this because they were becoming corrupted?” Perdikkas asked.

“Yes. A long life will eventually succumb to madness, even with divine power to prolong the inevitable. Many of the Titans surrendered their coreflames before this happened,” Anaxa explained, “the first of which was Janus, who left the next Demigod with the prophecy of the

coreflames, which Phainon has so graciously enlightened us about. It is a warning as much as a mandate that the coreflames would need to find their next keepers to ensure their power was properly harnessed according to their purpose without succumbing to the corruption of their bearers.

“It was likely this prophecy that drove the Imperator to begin the flame-chase, but I have yet to find any works that confirm this hypothesis, not that it matters for our purposes. Regardless of motive, Cerydra began to march across Amphoreus, slowly expanding her Empire and waging war against the gods. There are detailed records of each earthly and divine conquest and mention of this Hysilens claiming the Coreflame of Ocean before she killed the Imperator and left the Empire in shambles.”

Mydei, Perdikkas, and Peucesta both started at the statement. Ptolemy was the only Kremnoan that seemed to have gotten that far in the reading. Phainon unfortunately knew that’s how Cerydra met her end. He knew when he was reading the love story too. It made everything a little bittersweet, despite the author’s best efforts to emphasize the romance of their relationship.

“Why would she do that?” Perdikkas asked.

“No one knows for sure,” Phainon admitted aloud, “Aglaea might but she never talked about it.”

Ptolemy rubbed his temples and then let his hand fall to slap on a stele. “Sometimes I forget that the Goldweaver was *there*. Why didn’t we just kidnap her too and bring her along?”

“Why *didn’t* Lady Aglaea tell us more?” Castorice wondered in a small, hurt voice.

It was a question that Phainon wanted to ask her. He was sure she had her reasons. Aglaea always had her reasons, but why lead them to books and tomes about all of this and not just tell them, tell *him*, herself?

His thumb brushed across the indents on the brass over the author’s name. It was a pen name for sure, Regaled Vow. This author that wrote so eloquently about these two women sounded familiar… Phainon took long steps around the bench to Anaxa’s side of the table so he could reach the pile of tomes without crawling over anyone in the process. He sorted through them quickly while everyone watched him like he had gone mad.

At least a dozen of the books that the nymphs had led them to were written by, or co-written by, the same person. The same author writing pieces that were hundreds of years apart? This one was about Cerydra and Hysilens, another was about the flame-chase, here was one about the nature of corruption in Titans, this was a collection of essays about the nature of prophecy. All of them written with similar prose, under the same name listed beside dozens of different translators.

“Lord Phainon?” Hyacine asked and he looked up.

Everyone was looking at him with a combination of confusion and curiosity. “…sorry, I just. I think Aglaea *has* been telling us. Look at the author names.”

Anaxa huffed irritably and Phainon realized he figured it out. “Of course,” the professor grumbled, “Regaled Vow is an anagram.”

“Goldweaver,” Phainon agreed, “that’s why she sealed the library and sent nymphs to guide us to these books, because these are her works, *her* recollection of events.”

“Okay,” Ptolemy grumbled, “let’s assume that the Goldweaver knew all of this, knew the Black Tide was the result of what, her friend, her coworker becoming corrupted? Why didn’t she stop it herself?”

“Maybe she couldn’t,” Phainon hypothesized, “maybe one coreflame isn’t strong enough.”

“Or we’re missing something,” Anaxa huffed. He slammed the rest of his notes down and turned around to drop heavily onto the bench, facing away from everyone to think.

Ptolemy rubbed his face with both hands, Mydei leaned against one of the pillars and scratched his chin, and Peucesta started playing his lyre. It was something contemplative and quiet.

“The conclusion is still sound,” Hyacine offered cheerfully and Little Ica chirped agreement. “We have no reason to believe the Professor is wrong about the source of the Black Tide and as long as we know what it is, we can find a way to stop it, right?”

Phainon agreed, “It *has* to be the Coreflame of Ocean enhancing the song of Hysilens. Somehow it’s turning the song into the Black Tide to grant her wish.”

“Why?” Mydei asked very suddenly and everyone except Anaxa turned in their seats to look at him. “Why would this Dux Gladiorum kill the woman she loved and make a wish that could create the Black Tide?”

Silence. Even the lyre stopped. The beetle nymph that had followed Anaxa chirped unhelpfully from the pillar.

“The ‘why’ might be the key to stopping it,” Hyacine reasoned.

“And none of us have found that,” Ptolemy grumbled.

“Yet,” Phainon added, trying to keep the room feeling positive, “we haven’t found it *yet*. There are still plenty of resources here. Has anyone found out anything about how a siren’s song works?”

“Oh, Lord Phainon, I found a few references to the Imperator making use of the song,” Castorice offered. She ran her fingers over bookmarks until she found the page she wanted and passed it over. “She used it somehow to spy on enemies.”

Phainon tilted his head and opened his own book, passing it to Ptolemy. “Ptolemy, there are several spots in this book where the auth- where Aglaea talks about the Imperator and the Dux Gladiorum dancing in secret before the bards. Will you check my translation?”

The Kremnoan raised an eyebrow skeptically and then his eyes scanned through the pages, slowly narrowing as he read more. He flipped to another bookmark and repeated the same back and forth dash with his eyes before he looked up again. “That *is* what it says.”

“A siren’s song weaves illusions,” Anaxa finally said. He was leaning back against the table now, slouching with his legs spread to keep from sliding off the bench entirely while he studied the pillar in front of them like it had all the answers. “A fantasia,” he added, “the coreflame likely enhanced the illusion, making it so the illusion becomes real instead of a temporary state of mind.”

“You came up with that quick,” Ptolemy grumbled and Anaxa threw a stele at him. Ptolemy barely caught it before it broke his nose and looked like he might throw it back, but the text caught his eye, and he sighed and set it down instead. “A description of a siren’s fantasia as written by Regaled Vow.”

“But why is that her wish?” Mydei asked again and Phainon was starting to feel the frustration in the room rising again.

“Aglaea took over the flame-chase journey when the Imperator was killed, right?” Perdikkas asked.

“Yeah… did you think of something?” Phainon asked.

“No, just trying to get my head around the timeline. I am only familiar with Kremnoan history,” the doctor admitted, “it is curious though. If the flame-chase was so important to preserve, why didn’t Aglaea take the Coreflame of Law?”

“Maybe someone else took it first?” Hyacine wondered aloud.

“Could a Demigod take two coreflames’ power?” Perdikkas asked.

“No, if someone could claim a coreflame that did not belong to them, Eurypon would have done so,” Mydei pointed out.

Phainon remembered how desperately they clung to Mydei’s coreflame when they had to leave him behind, how important it was to them to keep that part of his heart safe. He tried to imagine what it would be like if he were in Hysilens’ place, if Mydei were Cerydra. It wasn’t difficult to empathize with the love story that led to the tragedy.

She lost her home, traveled somewhere distant and new, fell in love… and lost that love. If they lost Mydei again Phainon wasn’t sure what form his grief and rage would take. The hatred that bubbled deep inside him from the loss of his childhood home would be impossible to contain if he lost this new, beloved family. He sure as hell would keep the Coreflame of Strife close, unwilling to part with it for even a second.

“I’m sure the Demigod of Ocean has it,” he said, mostly to himself, loud enough so the others could hear. Phainon looked down at the book again, sure of what he said, and then the book was snatched from his hands.

Professor Anaxa turned quickly so it couldn't be snatched back, not that Phainon would hurry to reclaim it, he was more surprised that Anaxa was interested in a book written by the Goldweaver about the love between two ancient Demigods.

"I said I'm looking!" Anaxa snapped to the side. There was no one there, but everyone knew better than to point it out when he was clearly in a mood. He flipped through the pages quickly, lingering on the sheets that Phainon had marked.

"Professor…?" Hyacine tried and he ignored her for a few more page flips.

He slapped the book closed with a heavy clank and then turned around to hand it back to Phainon with a muttered, "one problem at a time."

Ptolemy groaned and leaned forward with his hands pressed together and his thumbs on his eyes, rubbing them gently. Beside him Peucesta started playing again and it seemed to help because Ptolemy let his hands fall and focused again.

"No matter what, we're not leaving this library until we have plan right?" he asked, "we don't want a repeat of what happened at Castrum Kremnos." The room collectively agreed in a series of nods and mumbled sentiments. "Then we don't need all the answers, just the right ones."

Phainon nodded firmly and set the book down on the table. "We all agree the source of the Black Tide is Hysilens. The Black Tide is a siren song but between the coreflames and the talismans we're all immune so that doesn't really matter."

"It might," Anaxa grumbled and Phainon paused to look at the professor.

The man had both his hands on the table and was leaning forward, head bowed. His hair was hiding his face and he didn't look up when he gestured to the love story in front of Phainon. "They hid themselves from all the attendees of these celebrations. Attendees that consisted of their closest comrades and the Imperator's advisors." When no one else seemed to piece it together, Anaxa sighed and spelled it out. "The Imperator surrounded herself with Chrysos Heirs and Demigods."

"So, the talismans only protect us from the Black Tide itself, not the song," Ptolemy concluded.

"The coreflames, the golden blood, they will protect from the song that is filtered through the coreflame, this we have proven to be true, but I cannot confidently say that they will spare us from the song itself, not up close," Anaxa concluded.

"So, we put wax in our ears," Mydei suggested, "as the hero's crew did."

"Sometimes the simplest solution is the right one," Castorice agreed.

"And if you're wrong?" Perdikkas asked, genuine.

"Well, there must be a way," Phainon pointed out, "Cerydra was not under the effects of the song. If she used this as a way to spy on her allies, then there must be a way for her to exempt

herself from the fantasia."

"Okay, I'll work on that," Ptolemy offered. He stood up to lean over the pile of books to start digging, shoving aside piles of documents and a couple of scrolls that promptly started to unroll. The tapestry that had been shoved in there rolled off the table where it too partially unwound.

"Lord Ptolemy, let me help!" Castorice insisted firmly as food was shoved dangerously close to the edge of the table. Phainon hurried to catch the scrolls and saw Mydei reach to recover the tapestry.

"Someone will need the answer to the question *where*, as well," Anaxa mumbled to himself.

"I found a few old maps, Professor Anaxa," Hyacine offered. She was also making a mess reaching for a few of the scrolls from the bottom of the pile. "They show the early spread of the Black Tide; she must be near the epicenter right?"

"It's *Anaxagoras*," the professor wheezed but his class had long since dissolved into unmanageable chaos and he was giving up.

Phainon was taking over instead. "Ptolemy, you're looking for a way to dispel the effects of the siren song. Hyacine, you keep trying to find out where she might be hiding."

"Lord Phainon, the rest of us should still try to find out why Lady Hysilens would wish for the Black Tide," Castorice suggested, "maybe there is a way to convince her to stop singing without fighting."

"Would the Imperator know?" Mydei asked suddenly.

Phainon glanced up at his boyfriend. The captain was holding the unfurled tapestry with a curious expression.

"You were the one reading her journal last night," Ptolemy huffed, still busy picking out study material.

"Then I'll just ask her."

The room froze and all sound stopped except for that damn nymph. Anaxa drew his firearm on the fourth chirp and whipped around to search for it, but the nymph took the hint and fell silent too. Everyone slowly turned to look at Mydei who had a mischievous smirk barely curling the corner of his lip.

He turned the tapestry around to show everyone the depiction of a short woman with pale blue hair and a fiery crown. She was sitting on the back of a massive dromas with sharp, dark brown and orange scales, pointing ahead with a chess piece in her hand. At her side were three figures, Tribbie and Aglaea were immediately recognizable, the other, a pale woman with dark purple clothing, long black hair, adorned with pearls and shells must have been the siren. The background was faded but divided into four sections, each featuring a coreflame being claimed in a brief, contextless scene.

“Is this her?” Mydei asked, pointing to the woman in blue.

“It is,” Anaxa confirmed, and Mydei’s half smirk turned into a toothy grin.

“I know this woman,” he stated firmly.

Phainon felt his heart sink. *Please don’t say it.*

“I have seen her every time I have died,” Mydei explained, “waiting on the shore of the River of Souls.”

We’ll find another way, Mydei, please. Phainon’s heart dropped the rest of the way into his stomach.

“It would not be hard to find her again. I will get the answers we need.”

Chapter 44: Absolute Trust

Chapter Summary

New tag: Assisted Suicide

▶ Spoilers - CW details

Mydei and Phainon fight about the plan

Chapter Notes

Damn, we really are close to 1k kudos! Thank you all so much for the support! ;w;

"Absolutely not," Phainon said quickly and firmly.

"Phainon, it's a good idea," Ptolemy started to say but he flinched back when Phainon shot him a glare. Everyone was leaning away from him. Everyone except Mydei.

"She has the answers we need," Mydei said simply, like this was as simple as going to the market for eggs.

"So do these," Phainon insisted, gesturing at the pile of books with a sharp wave of his arm.

"Deliverer-"

"No!" he snapped, "you don't get to *Deliverer* me! Not about *this*."

Everyone else at the table was holding perfectly still, unwilling to draw attention to themselves as Phainon shook. He could feel his Titan form trying to break free under the frustration, the worry, but he held it back as best he could.

"My lives are cheap," Mydei insisted with his arms crossed and a tilt of his head.

"Really?" Phainon hissed, "you're going to say that to *me* after what we talked about the night you woke up?"

"Um, maybe we should take a break," Hyacine suggested. The others agreed through their actions, even Anaxa, excused themselves slowly from the table, leaving Mydei and Phainon behind to argue. They waited until they were both alone to even move again.

“We have *time!*” Phainon pleaded, “what we need is right here in this library.”

“And how long will that take, Phainon?” Mydei snapped back, “how long will it take to scour these shelves? How much ground will the Black Tide recover while we pour over ancient words on the *chance* that the Goldweaver recorded a method to defeat the Black Tide? The same Goldweaver that would not share these things with you in person! None of us know for certain that the answer is written here at all! It is possible she does not even know!”

“Better for us to try than for you to die!”

Mydei scoffed. “This is not up for debate, master wordsmith. I am the captain, and it is my decision, my life to use as I deem fit.”

“That’s not true anymore! What’s mine is yours, *you* said that!” Phainon stomped his foot down hard enough to feel pain in his leg. “And that includes your life too!”

Mydei was shaking now, a subtle shiver. Phainon could see the air starting to warp around him as his Titan also threatened to break free.

“You took a piece of me with you when you died, Mydei,” he reminded a little softer, just as insistent, “why do you want to do that to me again?”

“Because this is about more than *us,”* Mydei said firmly.

Phainon’s heart dropped again, and his hands clenched into fists at his side. He wanted to storm away to be angry somewhere else but if he walked away and came back to see Mydei on the floor… He shook his head violently to clear that thought.

“This is the *answer*, Deliverer,” the prince insisted. His boots clicked on the marble floor as he walked around the table to reach for Phainon’s hand, but Phainon recoiled before they could touch.

“You told me that you would take your deaths more seriously,” Phainon accused. He could feel angry tears welling up in his eyes, but they would not spill.

“I said, that if it is everything to you, then it will be to me,” Mydei agreed. When he reached for Phainon’s wrist again, it was swift, denying him any chance of escape to hold on tightly with no hope of a retreat. “I always mean what I say, so you understand how serious I am proposing this course of action.”

Phainon tried to rip his hand free, but Mydei held tightly to his wrist, pulling Phainon close to hug him. They struggled for a moment. The Kremnoan held on tight and Phainon pushed against him until Mydei stubbornly pulled Phainon’s wrist behind his own back trying to force the man to reach for that weak spot. The one that no one else knew, the only way to kill Mydei for good. Phainon stopped fighting when he realized Mydei’s intention and he tentatively reached for it, counting vertebrae down the line until he was pressing against that horrible weakness.

“This isn’t the end of me,” Mydei reassured, “it’s not the end of *us*. This is the *best* heading we can choose; the straightest path with the truest winds.”

Phainon’s grip on Mydei tightened. One hand moved to Mydei’s hair, coaxing the man’s face to his shoulder, the other pressed more firmly against his back.

He was still not okay with this. How could he *possibly* be okay with this? Images of Mydei’s bloody corpse came back in waves. There was the moment he had come to Mydei’s rescue, when this lion of a man had collapsed and the light had left his eyes. He remembered the ache of shouldering Mydei’s heavy weight when he personally carried his body back to the Chryseus Leo. Phainon had been too distraught to shed his godly form and had curled around him in their cabin refusing to let anyone see him. He had worn Mydei’s blood for days, had soaked his feathers in it while he cradled him, mourned him, begged him to return around broken sobs. It was Phainon’s blood beside Kephale’s in that bath that healed his wounds and cleansed the worst of the Tide’s corruption. Even with Perdikkas’ reassurances it had taken Mydei so long to breathe again, even longer until he had opened his eyes and spoken.

Mydei pulled away enough to take Phainon’s face in both hands, sliding them from his cheeks to the hinge of his jaw, to hold his head and neck with firm reassurance. “I know I am asking the world of you,” he said softly. Those amber eyes were taking Phainon in, searching for a measure of understanding that Phainon was not yet sure he was willing to give. For once, he wanted to be selfish, damn the world …but that wasn’t who he was, and Mydei knew it.

“You are my equal in everything, Phainon,” Mydei said gently, “you don’t get to be the only protector here.”

“Don’t,” Phainon hissed, “don’t use my own words against me.”

“I must, because I need you to be with me on this. I need you to be completely okay with this plan.”

Angry, Phainon let his hands fall to his side and tried to look away but Mydei held on, firm enough to keep him from retreating, gentle enough to not hurt him. He used his thumbs on Phainon’s jaw to tilt his head back to look him in the eyes. The press of those warm hands was everything, they stirred feelings of longing and hope from the depths of his bones to rival the anger he felt. How could he refuse that gentle request to *see* each other when he wanted to look away, to be angry?

“I can do this, Phainon, my heart,” he begged in Kremnoan, “this strength of mine comes from you after all. Have I not earned your faith? Do you really believe I would leave you so soon with no hope of coming back to you?”

“You weren’t there, Mydei,” Phainon growled in a pained whisper. His Kremnoan was awkward and poor, but the emotions were there, “when I held your body on the ship, not knowing when you would come back to me. I didn’t know if I’d ever get a chance to tell you how I felt.”

“Phainon, that piece of you that I took with me… how do you think I found my way home again?”

Phainon blinked away a tear before it could spill over and reached up to lightly grab Mydei’s wrists, grounding himself. “It feels as though you are choosing the world over me.”

“I am choosing the world *because* of you,” Mydei corrected, “because my Deliverer showed me how, because you are here with me, the man who looked beyond the borders of his home to fall in love with a pirate. I will return swiftly with the means to save everyone, *especially* you, and I will wake to your smiling face just as I did before.”

He shook but Mydei smiled so softly that Phainon’s trepidation was crushed under that quiet confidence. The angry heat in his belly tamed and he gently nodded. It was a subtle agreement, something so small he knew Mydei felt it more than saw it.

“Good, then I have a request of you, Deliverer,” Mydei said with a shaky waver to his voice, a slip of that resolute confidence. It made Phainon look up with suspicion, searching the fine lines of his face, the tremor in his warm embrace. “I want you to be the one to kill me.”

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Mydei saw it in Phainon’s eyes the moment he made the request. Those shiny blue baubles like gemstones turned gold with barely concealed horror and he was burning under Mydei’s palms. He couldn’t blame Phainon for such a response, it was a big request, especially with how nervous Phainon was for this plan to begin with. So, when Phainon pulled away, he let him go.

“*How can you ask that of me?”* Phainon hissed after taking a few steps back. He had switched back to his native tongue and raised a hand, not quite reaching his mouth to cover it. “It’s not enough to convince me to hold your body you want me to *kill you?!”*

Phainon sounded frantic and Mydei tried to balance it with his own calmness, responding gently in Kremnoan, “Yes. I would have it no other way.”

“*Why? Why the fuck do you think I would agree to that?!”*

“Because we are equals in all things,” Mydei insisted, “because in this way it will not just be me alone enduring this pain but something we share beyond this life. Because I trust you implicitly. Because this would bind us so completely that it would be impossible for me to lose my way back to you. *Because you need this too.*”

Phainon was shaking and for a moment looked like he would throw up. He didn’t understand. The very thought of doing this was crushing the man under that heavy weight of responsibility but Mydei didn’t back down. He didn’t retract his demand. As hard as this would be for Phainon he genuinely believed it would help him in the long run.

Mydei did not take his lives lightly, not since he woke in Phainon’s arms. He had made a vow to Phainon that night and sealed it with his secret. To suggest this, to want to die at the hands of his beloved for the purpose of saving the world? Phainon needed to understand that this

was a temporary state for Mydei. He needed to be a part of the entire process from death to rebirth to understand that every life held weight yes, but that Mydei would not leave him so easily. Phainon needed this to see that not even death could keep them apart for long.

And Mydei needed this too. As frivolous as his deaths had been, Mydei had never once taken his own life. It was a line he had never been able to cross, never *wanted* to cross. Reckless behavior, sure, throwing himself in the way of attacks meant for his men, of course, but he had never taken a weapon to his own body. Perhaps it was his way of appreciating his lives before Phainon had come along and given a name to that innate sense of self-preservation.

Phainon was still trying to grapple with the request and predictably, needed more time. The bright gold of his eyes shook as he glared at Mydei, anger and resentment trying to hide the immense pain that lurked in the depths of that raging spirit. When he finally blinked, Phainon turned and stomped away.

Mydei didn't watch him go. He looked at the floor, listening instead as those stomps echoed in the atrium until they faded away entirely.

"Mydeimos?" Perdikkas asked as he approached, passing the storm that was Phainon on his way. "Is everything alright?"

"No. But it will be."

"…you don't have to do this, Mydei."

Mydei sighed, crossed his arms, and looked sideways at his crewmate, one of his oldest friends. "When have I ever shied away from death, Perdikkas?"

"It's different now."

"Because I have ascended to divinity?"

"Because you have Phainon," Perdikkas told him, "Because it's not just about how you feel anymore. It's about how he feels too."

Mydei sighed and admitted, "I know, Perdikkas, and that is why it must be him. Give him time. We'll have our answers soon enough."

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Phainon had stormed all the way outside the library and that's when he let himself turn. His wings sprouted and uncurled, his body itched as it transformed and then he threw himself from the cliff and flew out over the sea. If Mydei hadn't insisted on such a horrible condition, on requiring Phainon's participation, he wouldn't have left at all, but now Phainon just wanted space. He needed the moment to remember how to breathe, needed this space to just *process* this impossible thing that Mydei had requested of him.

Phainon circled the island on an updraft climbing higher and higher with intent to reach the sun that hung high in the sky, so high that the air felt like broken glass in his lungs, so thin that the black crept along the edges of his vision and the curve of the world made him feel

small. The island was a speck below, the sea and the sky felt like one and it still didn't feel far enough from this horrible responsibility.

Phainon slowly started to glide back down, letting himself fall rather than rise in a steady descent, safe and controlled. And as he fell, he thought.

Mydei was right, this wouldn't be the end of them. The answers they needed were guaranteed if he went to the River of Souls to confront the long dead Imperator. The Kremnoan, unfortunately, knew that River well enough to get in and get out and Phainon would be the last face he saw before he took the dive and the first when he climbed back out.

It was a cruel thing to ask of Phainon, but he understood the request. The more he tried to imagine this morbid task from Mydei's point of view, the more he realized he would want Mydei to do the same for him. He wouldn't want the shaky struggle of having to take his own life while his friends watched. He would want a quick and painless death, held tight in Mydei's arms, comforted in his mission as the black crept in. Perhaps Perdikkas could mix a poison, Hyacine could stop his heart, or Castorice could embrace him as Death itself, but would that be the same? Would it feel as *anchoring* any of those other ways?

If Mydei held him, smiling and muttering reassurances as he dove into the underworld on a mission that would save the world, would guarantee the freedom of their peoples and family, Phainon felt like he would have the strength to endure anything. That solemn responsibility would feel like a casual chore as easy as swabbing the deck or raising the sails.

As always, Mydei was right, perhaps Aglaea didn't have all the answers, couldn't record the solution they needed. This was, after all, something that only Mydei could do and he had come to Phainon with vulnerability, wanting Phainon to be a part of it so that he wouldn't have to do this mournful thing alone. Maybe this was what the thread was waiting for all along, why it had to be the Inheritor of Strife that opened the door.

Phainon sighed as he glided down, still high enough to see the edges of distant islands, high enough to see the dark horizon where the Black Tide crept forward, trying to reclaim the ground it had lost when they took back Castrum Kremnos.

The clock was ticking. This wasn't just the best way; it was possibly the only way.

Rather than return to the library immediately, Phainon glided down to the Chryseus Leo, to perch on the railing. The crew greeted him as they walked past, doing chores as though a god didn't just land amongst them. He would always be Phainon first, their once interim captain second, and the Worldbearer third, as it should be.

"Phainon?" Leonnius asked as he paused. There was a coil of rope over his shoulder. "Did something happen?"

Not yet.

"No, I just needed to grab a couple things." Despite his vocalized intentions, Phainon made no attempts to move. He just stood there, looking down at his friend and wondering if maybe he should ask for advice. If he pulled Krateros or Hephaestion aside and told them about

Mydei's plan, would they hurry to the library to stop him? Could they slap some sense into their prince? Or worse, would they agree?

"Would you like me to get them for you?" the runner asked. His head was tilted, face alight with worry. Phainon smiled, a warm and sunny thing that he hoped would put their friend at ease, but Leonnius' worry turned to skepticism.

"That would be great. Trying to get my wings through doorways, y'know?" he joked.

Leonnius set the rope on a barrel and slapped his hands together. "What am I lookin' for, captain?" he asked with a wink.

"There are two blankets on the bed in my room. I need them both."

"Staying another night?"

"Not sure yet, we're just playing it safe," Phainon reassured.

Leonnius didn't press, but Phainon still felt bad for keeping things from him. The runner left and Phainon slowly sat down on the railing. His wings fluttered in the wind, sails he could intimately feel. He closed his eyes to let the breeze soothe the pit of anxiety that still lingered in his heart, beating around the coreflame, nothing but the sounds of a lazy ship at rest, creaking under every footstep until a purr broke the spell.

A curious Fig Stew had trotted over to check on Phainon, balancing precariously on the railing to bump his head against his warm side. He pet the chimera absentmindedly, listening to those questioning, persistent awoos rumbling low in the animal's chest. It eased some of his surface worries, even if he still felt distant.

The blankets, neatly folded, slapped onto the barrel with a *whump*. "You know something like this we could have just brought to you if you had sent the little horse with a note," Leonnius said. He scooped Fig Stew up and set the hissing chimera down on the deck before the critter could fall off the railing. The chimera was less than pleased and batted irritably at Leonnius' ankles, but the runner wasn't paying him any mind.

"Oh Nikador, no, I couldn't ask anyone to make that trip. Those stairs are horrible," Phainon tried to chuckle as he reached for the bedding. It came out dry and humorless.

"Phainon."

"Hm?"

Leonnius put his hand on the blankets to keep him from grabbing them right away. "Are you *sure* everything is alright?"

The smile didn't falter, "it will be, I'm just… discouraged. It's been difficult trying to find the information we need."

"Damn… well, hold out hope, yeah? You know we're all here for you, Worldbearer or not." Leonnius gave Phainon a gentle pat and then retrieved his rope, getting back to work with a

whistle. Simple, but comforting words.

Phainon scooped up the bedding and flew back to the library.

He still took his time flying back up the cliffs, using the gentle ascent on a warm updraft to gather himself, to set aside that rage born of fear and love to replace it instead with steady trust. When Phainon's boots touched the courtyard once more he was returning to himself. His wings and halo vanished into embers, his hair turned white once more and everything became again as it was before he took that time for himself.

The others looked up at him as he passed them by. Everyone had separated to study, searching for answers in the hope they could provide a solution that spared Mydei and by extension, Phainon. It warmed his heart that they were trying and for him that was enough. He smiled at them as he passed, genuine, reassuring, until he was walking confidently up to Mydei.

The captain's eyes darted between Phainon and the blankets with suspicion, but he didn't say anything, just crossed his arms and let the silence weigh heavily.

Phainon cleared his throat and finally broke the silence himself with a quiet Kremnoan, "I'm sorry. That was not like me."

"You needed to think," Mydei acknowledged, as close to forgiveness as Phainon was going to get.

"I did."

"And?"

"I trust you." Phainon held the blankets up. "I'm not leaving your body on the floor."

Mydei blinked a few times and then smiled, just a little bit, that subtle, gentle, genuine smile that Phainon loved so much.

"Am I too heavy to hold, Deliverer?" Mydei teased.

"With that body of yours, Mydei? Absolutely," Phainon threw back.

He set the blankets down on the bench and his smile wavered, but Mydei stepped up to kiss him and brought it back. "Thank you, Phainon. This journey will be all the smoother because of you."

"Can we not talk about it too much?" Phainon whined as he dropped his forehead to Mydei's shoulder. "I might change my mind."

"No, you won't."

"…no, I won't."

The others returned when Mydei called to them and Phainon stood apart while Anaxa, Castorice, and Mydei talked. For as wild and crazy of an idea as this was, Mydei was diligent and careful. If he was going to make use of this blessed curse of immortality, he wanted to do it right.

Anaxa reviewed with Mydei all the questions he needed to ask, the things they didn't know and the things they needed confirmed. They talked a bit about what the Imperator might be like and discussed possible means to convince her to answer his questions. Phainon could hear them talking, could hear Ptolemy weighing in, catching the things that might have been missed.

He couldn't hear Mydei talking with Castorice and Perdikkas. That discussion was quiet, more personal. The kind of thing that Phainon probably wouldn't understand anyway. Their relationship with Death extended beyond what Phainon had experienced, as hard as that was to believe considering his history. Curiosity itched at him while they talked but by the time it had grown too great to bear, they were pulling apart and Mydei was reaching for him.

"The others will give us space," Mydei told him softly, pulling Phainon in close with a hand on his waist as though they were about to dance. They deviated to get the blankets and a few other things, then Mydei was leading Phainon by the hand to a quieter corner of the hall.

"This is a good spot," Mydei hummed. He was trying to be casual about this and Phainon wondered if it was a show or not. Perhaps for Mydei, this really was nothing.

In silence they folded one of the blankets and laid it down to soften the marble beside the big statue of the Lion of Tretos. The statue was raised on a dais, just a single step that they settled beside, using the raised lip as a shelf for their supplies. Mydei set out paper and a pen, his water, and a hunting knife, then he gently guided Phainon into sitting.

He felt out of his depth here, just responding to Mydei's confidence as he sat on the blanket and leaned against the step. Mydei took off his pauldron and set it aside, letting his chiton and half cape fall to tie them around his waist. He took off his necklace and his earring too, leaving them beside the paper. Bare chested, he sat down with his back to Phainon and lay against his boyfriend's chest. It was exactly how Phainon had held him the night he woke up, after they had rescued him from Castrum Kremnos.

"Mydei… how…?" Phainon started to ask. His eyes followed where Mydei was reaching to grab the knife. He held it in his open palm for Phainon to take but there was hesitation, and it sat there gleaming while Mydei patiently waited.

"Not like this," Phainon whispered.

"You have the strength for it, Deliverer, I know it," Mydei reassured. His tone was light.

"Castorice can-"

"Her touch may send me to the end of the river not the start."

"Perdikkas can work up a medicine-"

“It will take my body longer to reject any poison than it will take to heal a familiar wound,” Mydei interrupted gently, “this will be quick and spare you from this accursed body’s reflexive struggles.”

Phainon shakily took the knife from him and held it to the side while Mydei got comfortable. He wrapped his left arm around Mydei’s shoulders to hold him firmly against his chest and took deep breaths. Mydei’s hair tickled his nose when he buried his face in blonde locks and tried to find the courage he had a quint ago. The doubt was rising until he felt Mydei’s hand on his arm.

“Phainon,” he whispered, twisting enough to look up at him, “all will be well. Trust me above all else.”

“…I promise you; the pain will pass in an instant.”

Phainon kissed Mydei’s temple and nodded, a subtle thing that made his bangs fall forward into his eyes. He twisted the knife in his hand to free up a finger to press against Mydei’s chest, noting the gap between his ribs and the angle he would need, but when he aimed the tip of the blade above its mark it quivered, tremoring in time with his doubts. What if he missed? What if he caused Mydei more pain than necessary?

Mydei’s hand curled around his own on the handle as he pressed the point against his skin where it needed to go. The sharp point barely poked his flesh and a stubborn bead of gold welled beneath the steel.

“I’ll be right back, Phainon, it’s okay to let me go,” Mydei whispered.

Phainon’s shaky grip steadied, and the knife pierced deep, as though Phainon were trying to reach beyond his love, to stab himself too. But the blade stopped short in Mydei’s heart with a pained grunt and a resolved sigh.

“Smile for me,” he ordered in a pained whisper and Phainon obeyed the best he could. Mydei’s tattoos shimmered red as his body shuddered and slowly, smiling softly in return, he stilled.

Phainon held his breath, fighting the tears that threatened to run over. There was no need for them, he knew that. Mydei would tease him relentlessly if he woke up and saw red eyes and tear stains but when Mydei’s hand slipped and his body relaxed, quiet and lifeless, he almost couldn’t help it.

“Phainon,” Perdikkas said gently as he knelt beside him. The doctor put a hand over Phainon’s, helping him pull the knife out to set it aside. Blood trickled from the wound, but Perdikkas hurried to cover it with gauze. “Just hold him, I’ve got this part.” His steady voice was calm and experienced.

“How many times have you done this?” Phainon whispered around a shuddered breath, “waited for him to come back?”

“Too many to count,” Perdikkas admitted, “what matters is that he *does* come back. Always.”

Phainon tightened his grip around Mydei's shoulders and buried his face in that golden mane mumbling gentle words of affection that Mydei couldn't hear, determined to bear him, his whole world, until the moment he returned.

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Waking up on the shore of the River of Souls was never the same as waking up in the living world. It was more disconnected than that, like suddenly coming to awareness inside a dream. The moment of arrival is too hazy and unimportant to remember. All focus is entirely on the now, the suddenness of standing on black sand beside dark waters. Behind him stretched endless hills of faintly glowing blue flowers punctuated by ruins of kingdoms so old they no longer had names. Isolated pillars, crumbling walls, doors to nowhere… they stood as snapshots filtered through purple light that broke up the landscape and gave lingering souls something to cower around.

Mydei recognized them as landmarks from his many trips upriver and the sight of them filled him with the comfort of knowing that their plan had worked. His soul had washed ashore precisely where he had expected it to be. Even better the lingering exhaustion of the Netherealm felt quieter this time. There was always an alluring call to give up, to wash away in the river, to surrender all memories as payment to move on to the next life, but that voice was drowned by Mydei's purpose and connection.

"More so this time than others," he mumbled to himself when he looked down. Attached to his hand was a golden thread. It was tied in a delicate bow around his pinky finger on his right hand, fine as spider silk, the kind of thing that was easy to miss, easy to forget, utterly invisible until someone went looking for it.

He gently took hold of the manifestation, this glimmering thing, and knew in a heartbeat what it was: a blessing from the Titan of Romance. Despite its seeming fragility, this string was as strong as the finest steel, crafted by the love between Titans to bind them through actions and affections even beyond the veil of death. The longer end stretched upriver, too far for Mydei to see, vanishing in the blackness, but when he closed his eyes and gathered the thread in both hands, he could feel Phainon's heartbeat, could hear his soft whispers. They were bound in spirit and Mydei would have it no other way.

The wayward captain let the thread go and it happily quivered behind him, a lifeline to guide the pirate home when he was ready. The unexpected comfort made his steps lighter as he started to wander, searching his memories for the woman he saw on the banks.

Time was impossible to measure here. Mydei wasn't sure if it even flowed at the same pace. The thought crawled under his skin like a distant itch as he wandered past faded souls and crystalized memories. The river flowed beside him so smoothly it looked like glass, but he knew from experience there was a racing current hiding beneath that steady surface. He was considering wading into those depths, a shortcut to hurry this journey along when the shine of spun gold caught his eye once more.

For a moment Mydei thought it was his thread to Phainon, waving at him, unspooled enough to tangle but when he gathered their string of fate in hand there was very little slack, not enough to explain this loose string on the breeze. His heart twisted as he considered the

possibility that Phainon had somehow joined him in the Netherealm, but he discarded the thought just as quickly. Phainon was no fool and the Worldbearer would not surrender his life so casually when he held Mydei's trust so tightly.

Mydei reached for this extra string and found it taut, stretched enough that it sang a low and mournful note when plucked. One end reached back towards life like Mydei's did, the other flowed downriver, binding two souls through a weave of romance that extended beyond the veil of death, a love so pure that it manifested as an eternal string.

He must have swam past this thread dozens of times, unaware that it existed until now. Mydei chuckled to himself. Now that he knew what it was like to be deeply in love; to *be* loved so completely in return… it was hard not to see it. He took this new thread in hand and with understanding in his heart he held it close and listened.

His eyes snapped open, but he held the thread tighter. Just as he could hear Phainon's heartbeat in his own thread there were heartbeats here too, but underneath their gentle rhythm was a song. The same song that had clung to Mydei's spirit like muck, that turned men into monsters and poisoned the sea. A song of conquest and destruction, of longing and grief …of devotion.

Mydei chuckled to himself and started following the thread, now confident of who was on the other end.

The story of the siren knight had always been one of love.

Chapter 45: The Imperator

Chapter Summary

New Character Tag: Cerydra, Hysilens
New tag: Minor or Background Relationships, Cerydra/Hysilens

Mydei meets with the Imperator

Chapter Notes

Shout out to Bane who continues to be my beta reader catching my most egregious typos before my shame can be publicly posted.

Sorry this one took an extra couple days. I deliberately picked at it slowly because I wanted to get Cerydra right and make sure I didn't miss any information. The hazard of posting chapter by chapter means I have to be REALLY careful to avoid the dreaded retcon.
Fingers crossed that I didn't miss something and have to frantically edit this later. @.@

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei's walk through the Netherealm was accompanied by the soundtrack of the Black Tide song and steady heartbeats. It was a strange feeling as his footsteps crunched in the sand in time with Phainon's steady heart, listening to the song without corruption through his gentle hold on the shimmering string. The coreflame burning in his chest kept him safe from the corrosion so it was puzzling that he could hear the song at all. But the deeper Mydei got the more he realized this was the song in its purest form, without the effects of the Tide. It was a simple longing, a song sung at someone's grave in the hopes that they would hear it through that thin veil.

For as long as she had been here, Mydei was surprised that the Imperator was not further down river. She kept to the same familiar stretch of the shore, waiting patiently in different poses beside a broken stone tower. He saw the tower first and the diminutive woman second, exactly as he remembered her.

She was sitting on a stool, sideways to a stone table with her legs crossed at the knees. One hand rested in her lap; the other was propped up at the elbow on the table so she could lean her weight into a bored expression with her knuckles pressed against her cheek. Mydei would have thought her a pouty child, but her presence carried a regal formality that demanded nothing but the finest of royal manners in her presence.

It wasn't a feeling Mydei expected and when he finally stopped and stood a few paces away, he found himself at a loss. All his practiced approaches with Anaxa just didn't feel right in the moment. Despite being of royal blood himself, he felt a very powerful urge to bow, to lower himself beneath the weight of her presence.

"Don't," she said before he could and he blinked, tense and surprised he could understand her. Even with Castorice's reassurances that the land of dead had its own language, it was still a jarring experience. She turned her head to face him. "It's only natural to long to prostrate yourself before me, but there is no need. Come, sit, very few spirits have the courage to even consider approaching me." Her voice was smooth and confident with a lilt of arrogance that Mydei found mildly annoying, but it was hard to resist her allure.

Her eyes were teal and glittered with sharp edges like a diamond cut by a master craftsman. They matched the ends of her hair, the blue blended so seamlessly into the silver it was as though she had dipped the ends in a blue lagoon and let it bleed. Her bangs were uneven creating layers that framed her face like the fins of a tropical fish, elegant, and desirable with the rest of her hair pulled back into two braids. They met in a ponytail that reached just past her waist, bound by a black ribbon tied in a perfect bow at her nape.

Perfect was probably the best way to describe her appearance. The tapestry had failed to do her justice, from her tall and narrow crown that flickered with blue fire, to her belled sleeves, exposed shoulders, and short dress in blue and black. Long coat tails, hung from her waist in thick ribbons, weighted by golden accents to lay gently on the sand, swept back to avoid being stepped on by her high heeled boots.

Mydei found himself unwilling to disobey and when she gestured with a hand adorned by gold and silver rings he followed where she led until he was sitting across from her at this small stone table.

"How strange," she murmured to herself, "I feel as though I have seen you before."

"I am no stranger to this river, Imperator," Mydei admitted.

"'Flamecrowned,' 'Tyrant,' 'Empress,' 'Supreme Commander,' 'Imperator' …the world has given me countless titles. Those are names for the living. You may simply call me Cerydra."

"Cerydra," Mydei said with a gentle nod. He rolled the name around on his tongue. Something about the way she had said it with such weight and glory, it suddenly felt foreign on his lips, like he was somehow saying it *wrong*. "I am Crown Prince Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos, Inheritor of Strife."

"Oh?" she shifted in her seat, suddenly much more interested than before, "Nikador's nation was the only one aside from Okhema that rivaled my own. It's curious, I would not have expected a dynasty of war to treat with Hyperborea."

Mydei tilted his head. "Did my people treat with yours in the past?" he asked.

She pointed to his finger where the thread shimmered and then delicately held up her own to show him where she was also tied with golden string. "A gift from Dux Goldweaver, one of

my most loyal generals. She designed this raiment for me as well. If you bear her mark then you must have swayed her with proof of undying love towards another. Surely you must be allies for her to witness something worthy of her blessing?"

"Imper- Cerydra, do you know what has happened to the world since your passing?"

The young woman frowned. "Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos," she said firmly, as though announcing him to the table, "you are not here on your final voyage, are you?"

He shook his head. "No. I am not."

"As time has marched on in this bitter place it has become harder for me to peer into the lives of the living." She pondered her own words and Mydei's answer before ordering, "Speak. Tell me of the world as it is now, what has become of my legacy."

For a moment, Mydei considered declining. He wasn't here to tell her stories, he was here to retrieve her own, but there was a longing buried deep underneath her authority. This was not the demand of a ruling Empress; it was the genuine curiosity of someone who *needed* to know.

So, he told her everything.

Time passed differently in the Netherealm. Mydei wasn't sure how long it took him to tell her about the state of Amphoreus, even keeping it concise and clinical, it took time to tell her what became of her Empire. She had studied him with a guarded expression, impossible to read, stopping him only to ask clarifying questions when his descriptions were inadequate.

She was pleased when he told her about the continuing flame-chase journey, how it had produced heroes like Phainon and powerful figures like Aglaea, and didn't seem to mind how little of her was remembered. While his initial impression of her had come across as egotistical, the more Mydei measured her reactions and input the more he realized she didn't equate her *legacy* with *herself* and cared more about the advancement of her intentions in life than how she was perceived by history.

Perhaps it would have been better if she had been. When he told her about the Black Tide and their theory about Hysilens as the cause, Cerydra had not responded with horror or revulsion, she seemed… happy.

"The prophecy spoke true," she mumbled, mostly to herself. "Not that I am surprised, with or without Dux Fatorum's words this outcome was inevitable."

"Will you tell me of your life?" Mydei asked.

"You want to know my secrets so you and the other Demigods may put a stop to the Black Tide." She spoke with such confidence and knowing that Mydei almost missed the question under the statement.

"I do."

"I have no desire to help you stop the Black Tide."

“Someone very dear to me helped me embrace this death so that I could travel here to speak with you. I am not leaving until you answer all my questions. When I return to my loved ones it will be with the answer to save the world,” Mydei told her firmly. The threat was thinly veiled but she was not intimidated.

“Save the world,” she mused. Her youthful voice pitched a little higher as she purred those words. “And what do you think the Black Tide is trying to do?”

His blood chilled as she spoke.

“You have described to me a world still at war. Your own people have been trapped in conflict since the beginning of the Kremnoan Dynasty, a conflict that continues with Okhema to this day, as you have said. The Black Tide unifies the world when humanity cannot, is this not a desirable outcome? To unite all Amphoreus under a single banner? To create a world of peace?”

“The Black Tide is anything but peace, it is death and corruption, fire and ash. Those who fall to it are stripped of their humanity and become mindless monsters… That is not peace,” Mydei argued.

“And your approach to the world is any different, *Strife*? Kremnoans thrive on conflict, long for combat. Can you truly claim to strive for peace when bloodlust fills your veins with pleasure?” She smiled, a cruel thing that belonged to the tyrant Mydei had read about. Her gaze was half-lidded and her cheeks uneven where her hand smooshed the one up to crinkle one of her eyes. Cerydra was watching him expectantly, like a cat with a mouse. This was a *game,* and she was waiting patiently for Mydei to make his move so she could take another one of hers.

He contemplated carefully, trying to consider what he could say that might sway her. Phainon would have already had the right words. That master wordsmith would have loved a debate like this. All Mydei had was his honesty; sometimes that was enough.

“Imperator Cerydra,” he finally said, using the title despite her earlier disregard for it as a show of respect, “now that I have accepted my coreflame and ascended to divinity I better understand the meaning and purpose of Strife. What you have said sings true, my heart glories in combat. It was combat and conflict that made me who I am, and it was where I fell in love. It is because of strife that I have come to value the things in my life that I want to protect and seen those relationships grow strong.” He paused to look at the thread around his finger. “My relationship with Phainon is one example. We were enemies and our allyship was forged in fire and tested in strife. I cannot say if we would have found each other if our peoples were not at war… The world needs conflict, it is how humanity grows and comes to understanding in pursuit of a lasting peace, one worthy of defending.”

Mydei moved his hand to join the other in his lap, resting over his knees in loosely closed fists. “The Black Tide does not allow for growth or understanding. There is no reconciliation, no choice, no life worth living. I know from stories that your life’s ambition was to conquer all Amphoreus, to unite her people beneath one banner, but I also know that you value the rule of law and are fair above all else. As the Inheritor of Law, surely you see the injustice of this campaign.”

Cerydra's smile never wavered, she never seemed to lose the upper hand. Even when Mydei felt like he had made the right move, said the right thing, she looked like she had expected it. "An injustice?" she crooned. "And what injustice is there in my legacy?"

"Hysilens," Mydei said simply and Cerydra's smile cracked. "The song that furthers your ambition is one of grief and loss. She is described as the dutiful knight, how is it fair that she must shrug aside her own desires to bear yours alone? Is it not a joy of being in love that one may shoulder the burdens of their lover beside them? I am Kremnoan, we weigh the scales differently than the Northern Kingdoms. If I am wrong, then please, educate me."

The Imperator leaned back to sit straighter, her hand falling into her lap where she looked down, playing with the string that was tied around her pinky.

When she was slow to respond, Mydei gently asked, "Can you hear it?"

"Yes," she said softly, for the first time, Mydei thought she may show a fleeting vulnerability. It passed quickly and she tilted her head back again, carrying herself with that same regality. "Very well, Crown Prince of Kremnos, I will tell you whatever you would like to know."

"You will help us defeat the Tide?"

"I care not about the Black Tide," Cerydra reiterated, "…but my Dux Gladiorum has served me endlessly for a thousand years and not once has she come to give me her report. I don't like to be kept waiting."

Mydei took a deep breath through his nose to tame his excitement as he tried to remember what he was supposed to ask about.

"The siren song," he invited, "how does it work?"

"Simple, the fantasia is an illusion."

"Does it work on Chrysos Heirs?"

"Of course it does."

That tracked with what they had hypothesized. "It didn't work on you."

Cerydra's smug smile was back. "It works on *all* Chrysos Heirs."

"How were you able to spy on your allies without being seen? Or dance in front of the bards in secret?"

"A sea siren's fantasia is one of temptation, but it is still only an illusion. Anyone can break free of the dream if they have the will to navigate its labyrinthian charm. A true leader always knows what they want and how to gain an advantage with the tools they have available to them. The answer will vary for everyone but simply knowing you are under the spell is the first step towards gaining an advantage."

Cerydra talked with her hands. Mydei's eyes kept darting down to follow them when she slowly waved on long sentences. The way she was speaking each movement felt deliberate, hypnotic, and his battle instincts had him on edge.

His eyes flitted back to hers and he tried to match her bored expression, hiding from her his every reaction. "Why did you start the flame-chase journey?"

"Because it was my duty," she told him simply, "do you believe in the importance of bloodlines, Crown Prince?"

Mydei shook his head firmly. "I have seen great leaders, wise men, and noble spirits come from humble backgrounds. The Inheritor of Worldbearing is the son of farmers, whereas I am the son of Kings, we stand happily on equal ground, as it should be."

"The Kingdom of Hyperborea did," Cerydra told him, "the chaos that surrounded the death of their childless monarch led the people to hunt for any willing puppet that could play the role of a lost heir. It was the steward that plucked me from the people. My hair and golden blood matched that of the late royal family, and he saw in me a puppet through which he could retain power." She reached up to play with a long strand of hair that fell over her shoulder, entwining it around her pointer finger. It didn't feel like nervous tick when she did it, the way Mydei sometimes fussed with his braid when he was anxious. Everything Cerydra did was calculated and deliberate.

"The fool could not have known when he brought me to the palace that the treasure of the late King would choose me."

"The Coreflame of Law," Mydei filled in when she paused for dramatic effect.

"As the Demigod of Law, it was easy to see where the scales were imbalanced. Executing the steward and his family was my first decree as newly ascended divinity."

Kremnoans came from a culture steeped in blood but something about the way she said it didn't sit right with him. She spoke of them so casually but there was an underlying glee hidden in her voice. To her, lives were just there to be measured, to be *weighed*. Each victory was celebrated and pocketed, every question to her authority removed swiftly and without mercy.

"You have inherited a coreflame as well, Crown Prince," she noted, sounding a little lighter but then her voice subtly dropped again, weighty when she added, "you know the responsibility we carry."

He grunted and crossed his arms across his chest, maintaining eye contact the whole time. It was his subtle attempt to stay on equal ground with her, to meet her as a fellow monarch, but Mydei knew they were not the same. He was a runaway king, contemplating the elimination of his Dynasty and she was an Empress, the greatest conqueror in recorded history.

"When I became the Demigod of Law and began my campaign to unite the Northen Kingdoms the Demigod of Janus came to me bearing the weight of prophecy. My new Dux Fatorum, bearing that divine edict told me exactly what needed to be done. As the prophecy

says, *rewrite the fabric of Law, that the world may know order.* As the only one that could accomplish such a feat, duty compelled me and as I contemplated those words I realized, corruption of the Titans was inevitable. Every catastrophe that has befallen the world has come from a Titan surrendering to their inner desires over the mandate given them by their coreflame. It is only a matter of time before they lose themselves and must be stopped. The prophecy warns as much, the power of the coreflames is *to doom the world or save it.* Only united and safely controlled under one rule could such power be used responsibly for the greater good."

Mydei's brows crinkled, enough that even this stranger noticed. Cerydra tilted her head at his reaction.

"Do you disagree?" she prodded, genuinely curious.

"I do not, you are proof of your own words, Imperator Cerydra," Mydei pointed out, "the catastrophe of the flame-chase journey came about because you surrendered to your inner desires."

Cerydra's smile remained but her gaze hardened.

"As I have already said, the flame-chase has changed in these one thousand years," Mydei told her, "The Lady Goldweaver still seeks the coreflames, hiding them away until their bearers are ready. Many consider her a hoarder of power but this voyage with Phainon has taught me much about the nature of divinity."

He paused to study Cerydra, wondering if this was all he'd be allowed for his turn, but she did not respond and he continued.

"'Coreflames grant wishes,'" Mydei quoted, "Phainon told us these were the words of the Lady Trianne, one of the Holy Maidens of Janus, who further emphasized that while coreflames choose their bearers, those bearers must be ready before they ascend. Now that I have spoken with you, I see why the Goldweaver and Holy Maiden keep those gathered coreflames from their Demigods until they are pure-hearted and good."

"Pure-hearted and good," Cerydra repeated, mildly surprised. She was mulling over his implications, that she had not been ready to ascend and had come to the Coreflame of Law already corrupted. Perhaps it was more subtle than the rolling Black Tide, perhaps some good still came of her conquests. In a time of turmoil, Cerydra had been what her people needed, but it didn't change that weighted truth.

"Imperator… Cerydra," Mydei continued with a firm voice, "do you love her?"

The question came as a shock and a flicker of annoyance passed across her gaze like a shadow before she huffed. "A foolish question, as Imperator I love all my loyal subjects." The thread around her finger glimmered, giving her away but Mydei didn't call her on her deflection.

"Then surely it grieves you that Hysilens has spent the last thousand years alone in mourning."

Cerydra raised her hand to look at the thread. Mydei couldn't hear the song from where he was sitting but he knew she could. He pressed his advantage.

"How did you die?" he asked. "History says that it was your Dux Gladiorum that killed you."

"History speaks true," Cerydra confirmed, somewhat distracted. Her voice was softer around the edges, but the confidence remained. "It was my final order to her."

Mydei's heart started to race. "Why?"

Cerydra stood up with the soft sound of crunching sand and Mydei blinked away his surprise. She wasn't much taller standing as she had been sitting. With both hands on the stone table and her spine as straight as a mast, Cerydra was still shorter than Mydei while he was sitting.

His grip on his elbows loosened, Mydei's body coiled like a spring, ready to strike if she went on the attack but the feeling passed when this young woman turned away entirely. She stepped away from the table to face the river, searching for something there that Mydei realized she had been looking for all along. The water lapped near her shoes, but she stood just out of reach.

"Because I genuinely believed once that it was the right thing to do," she admitted, and this no longer felt like a match between royals.

Cerydra bowed her head, an action that felt unnatural to Mydei as an observer. For the first time since their meeting, Cerydra seemed genuinely vulnerable. He considered moving to her side to comfort her, but Mydei didn't want to insult her pride. So instead, he waited patiently for the moment to pass, letting her return to this moment in her own time, determined instead to simply listen.

"My court held five Demigods," she told him when she straightened, "myself, Dux Fatorum, Dux Goldweaver, the great dromas king, Terravox, and Dux Gladiorum. I turned my armies towards Oronyx, the Titan of Time and led the march myself to demand the coreflame. They refused and instead offered council in the form of a prophecy that shook me to my very bones. We returned to Hyperborea without the Coreflame of Time, only the weight of those words."

Cerydra turned in place to face him from the beach. There was a shine to her eyes that he didn't expect, that felt unnatural and misplaced.

"*The world may bow to a single banner, but you cannot live to see it,"* she quoted and Mydei thought that end of it until she added the second path presented to the monarch by Oronyx, "*abandon this conquest and know a life of love."*

"You chose the former," he realized aloud.

"Of course," Cerydra said, casual, "it was my duty and lifelong ambition. The life of a single Demigod weighed against the peace of all the world; what worthy ruler would not make that same decision? To sacrifice themselves for the ones they love?"

Mydei understood without hesitation. After all, he had done the same.

“I confided in my most trusted knight, the woman I loved, Helektra, my intentions. She pleaded with me to find another way, but the prophecy left no room for debate. If the flame-chase journey was to continue, if Amphoreus was to be united at last, then the scales needed to be balanced. I entrusted my duty to her and ordered her to carve the Coreflame of Law from my chest. She held me while I died, her blade in my heart.”

The stone seat beneath him felt a little too cold but Mydei dared not move. He could feel between them eerie parallels, with notable differences. Had he not just died in Phainon’s arms with a blade in his chest? But they were in this together, Cerydra and her love were not. Cerydra had the choice to live with her love and decided against it. True to both prophecies, the world would be doomed, united under one banner.

“That was her name,” Cerydra continued, rambling with her same confident enunciation as though addressing a mass of people, but that soft remained along the edges of her tone. “Hysilens was the moniker given to her when she walked from the sea but as a siren, among her own people, her name was Helektra. She was the perfect choice for the Coreflame of Ocean. Phagousa was the Titan of banquets, feasts, and celebrations, the creator of honey brew. Helektra understood and loved the Law, perhaps in a more brutal and instinctual way than I ever could, even as its bearer, but she also loved fire and music, good wine and good company.”

“The Coreflame of Ocean is no longer about celebration,” Mydei told her harshly, “how can it be? She has assumed your duty, as you requested, and her love for you has turned into a vicious wave that denies humanity any chance of a joyous tomorrow.”

“*Command the tides of the Ocean, that the world may revel in song,”* Cerydra quoted, “she is living the mandate of the prophecy… but it is not the song she wants to sing.”

“Her corruption will destroy the world,” Mydei agreed, “and herself.”

“It already has,” Cerydra admitted, “the moment I gave her the burden of my duty.”

“Imperator, your legacy lives on in other ways. The Goldweaver’s flame-chase has already begun uniting the world, not by erasure of identity, but by bonds much stronger than any mandate.”

Mydei stood and walked to her, holding his hand low to offer her the string that tied him to Phainon. She crossed her arms at first, refusing to budge as he approached and declining to take him up on his offer. The commanding aura was back, her feelings tucked neatly away once more as he waited patiently for her to reach out to pinch the golden thread between her pointer and middle fingers.

“The heart that beats in this thread is from a little town that was destroyed by the Black Tide. Phainon of Aedes Elysiae was taken in by the Goldweaver and became the Deliverer of Okhema, their golden son, destined to be the Worldbearer. He should be the natural enemy of Castrum Kremnos and for a time we were, but now we are bound even beyond the veil of death. It was your legacy that brought us together, your flame-chase journey, helmed by the

woman who picked up your greater legacy. The rest of our people deserve the chance to learn what we have found between the two of us, to celebrate our differences as allies with song, dance, good wine, and good company."

Cerydra closed her eyes to listen to that heartbeat while he talked, and they sparkled when she opened them again. "I suppose the continuance of the flame-chase is legacy enough."

"When I return, I will sing your praises myself," Mydei promised.

She scoffed and let go to cross her arms again. "I would rather be forgotten than defined... For better or worse, my legacy has already borne fruit. My flame-chase journey is working as intended, uniting the world. There is no need to assign credit."

Cerydra let go of the string and crossed her arms again. "You have found a way to counter the effects of the Black Tide itself, have you not? Because it is the result of a coreflame's power I assume you have used golden blood or fight exclusively alongside Chrysos Heirs to spare your men from the corruption? You said it transforms?"

Mydei blinked. Perhaps he shouldn't have been so surprised that she put the pieces together so quickly. This was the woman that started the war against the gods, and the woman most familiar with the siren song.

"Yes, Professor Anaxagoras, the Inheritor of Reason, believes that the Coreflame of Ocean is turning the fantasia into reality."

"This is why you asked me about the song," she pieced together.

"Yes."

"Then the answer is simple, is it not?" Her hand moved from her chin into a dismissive wave. "She is as any other corrupted Titan, take her coreflame and the Black Tide will cease to be."

"You make it seem so simple," Mydei deadpanned.

Cerydra's smug smirk was back, "as a fellow monarch and leader of armies, you understand as well as I that sometimes the answer *is* that simple."

"A simple answer does not mean a simple resolution."

"No, and my Dux Gladiorum is an army unto herself, loyal to her final breath. She will defend my will with the force of the ocean she commands," Cerydra cautioned, "but you are many Demigods, surely this fight will be a challenge, but it is not impossible to secure victory."

Mydei recalled the fight with the kraken, that extension of the Tide that kept him isolated and engaged for nearly a month. Phainon and Hyacine had startled it into a retreat but how much more powerful was this Demigod up close?

"What if we had no need to fight?" Mydei wondered aloud. Cerydra studied him, visibly bored but he could feel the hum of anticipation around her as close as they were. "Could she

be convinced to surrender her coreflame?"

"Dux Gladiorum answers to no one but herself."

"She would answer her Imperator," Mydei countered.

"Her Imperator is dead."

"Then tell me what to say."

Cerydra paused then, mulling that over in her head. He could see it in the subtle twitch of her finger, the way her eyes would flick from side to side as she took the idea and ran it through calculations in her head.

"If she is herself," Cerydra reasoned, "then that may work."

The possibility that Hysilens had lost her sanity, her ability to hear reason, lingered in the air between them.

"For a time after my death, I could see the world through our bond, but that connection has faded over time," the Imperator admitted, "I have long wondered if it is because our love had dwindled, or if something else had happened to her. Sirens live long lives and Helektra was a Demigod, the Inheritor of Ocean on top of her increased lifespan. To sing for so long…"

"You're worried about her," Mydei observed.

Cerydra paused to consider her words carefully before saying, "she has been alone for a very long time."

"So have you, but the thread still binds you." He pointed to the thread, and she twisted her hand in the air, back and forth in a slow arc to see the thread glimmer. It was just as bright as the one around his own pinky. "I have heard her song. It is meant for you."

Cerydra hummed. "Tell her that this song bores me. I would much prefer something lighter, befitting a joyous reunion over a drink of Divine Dew."

"Divine Dew?" Mydei asked, worried that her message might not be specific enough.

"As a King, I must bear the weight of every move on the board. Indulging myself in honey brew would only lead to a total defeat. As such, I couldn't drink with her in celebration after each conquest. After we retrieved the Coreflame of Ocean, I offered her a single wish, anything that was within my power to grant. She wished to share with me a drink of Divine Dew, a once-in-a-millennium vintage when we had laid aside our conquest and could finally rest in the new age that we created."

Mydei considered that thoughtfully and then nodded with a soft smile. "I will tell her when we find her and let her know that you are waiting for her."

"Have you found her?" Cerydra asked very suddenly and Mydei's smile dropped, answering her question. "You have not…"

“It is only recently that we have even determined the source of the Tide is a Demigod and the Black Tide makes it difficult to search for her.”

Cerydra tapped her fingers and then announced, “then you must go to the heart of my fallen Kingdom. When our connection was stronger, I could feel the cold of the ocean as if it were ice. She will have retreated to those depths where her song is strongest.”

“Will she not have gone home? To where her kin may be?” Mydei asked.

“Home is not always where one was born. From your tale, you must know this better than I, Monarch of Kremnos,” she scolded, “can you not say with absolute certainty that your home is not beside your beloved? She will be near the place that meant the most to *us*, the beach where we first met on the shores of Hyperborea.”

That was a long voyage, one full of complications, but it was a start.

“Thank you,” Mydei said genuinely, “this victory will belong to you as much as it will to us.”

“Of course it will,” she huffed, letting her arms fall so she could put a hand on her hip. “I have never known loss, even in death I am not about to start.”

“Respectfully, I don’t think that’s true, Cerydra,” Mydei said gently, with a bow of his head, “to love is to lose and you wear proof of your love eternally on your hand.”

However, she felt about that, Cerydra wouldn’t say. She turned away with a huff. “Do you not have a task to complete, Crown Prince? Once one has spoken their peace, one should leave decisively.”

“You will not be alone much longer, Cerydra, I promise.”

“A leader is always alone; there is no room for anyone else at the top.”

Cerydra spoke with such finality that Mydei didn’t have the heart to respond. He left without further words but in his heart he disagreed. With a little bit of work and a little bit of love, Mydei was sure there was room enough for two.

-

His boots crunched in the sand as Mydei walked upriver, away from the waiting monarch, content to hurry back to Phainon while he mulled over what he had learned. His boyfriend’s heartbeat was slow and steady, relaxed through the thread, sending him strength and stability with every step.

“Awoo!”

Mydei’s head shot up, puzzled when he heard the little howl, eyes scanning the horizon. Perhaps he had imagined it. Not once had he seen a chimera in the land of the dead. Castorice had spoken of them as messengers, he assumed that such special creatures were kept apart from humanity to serve a greater calling.

So, when Mydei heard a happy and familiar chirp once more, he stopped and turned to look again. Orange and white fur bounded through the antila flowers that lined the sandy beach, disturbing them to race towards Mydei. He paused briefly, easily distracted, to sniff at a rock with his ears pert and his tail wiggling, before he remembered his master. Bright red eyes blinked at Mydei eagerly as he trotted through the black sand to plant himself happily at the captain's feet.

"Fig?"

"*Awoo!*"

Chapter End Notes

"Is that a cat? …Is that MY cat???" - Bane

Chapter 46: The Son of Gorgo

Chapter Summary

No new tags

Mydei meets a familiar face in the Netherealm

Chapter Notes

I completely forgot, we hit 1k kudos before the last chapter! As a thanks for all the support I am willing to take post-fic requests for additional content!

▶ A few rules:

When Fig Stew planted his little butt in the sand and looked up at Mydei expectantly, the Kremnoan wasn't immediately sure how to react. Several feelings tumbled through him on a loop, none of them sticking and none of them showing on his face as he studied the chimera.

His scaled tail was wagging, eyes bright, ears forward, no signs of distress. Mydei could feel Phainon's heartbeat through the thread and it was still calm, too fast to be sleeping but still at rest. Of course, Fig Stew was on the *ship* last he checked and Phainon was at the library. Did the Chryseus Leo come under attack?

"Are you dead?" he asked very pointedly.

Fig Stew shook his head.

Well, that was a relief. Chimeras in general were very intelligent creatures, and Fig was one of the smartest. Mydei had no reason to assume the creature didn't understand the question and he had every reason to believe the response. It quieted a little bit of the inner turbulence that was nibbling on his insides.

"Is everyone okay?" Mydei asked next.

Fig Stew nodded.

That was good but it also explained absolutely nothing. The chimera couldn't speak in a language that Mydei would understand so his inquiries would be limited. Asking why Fig was there wasn't going to do any good but standing around asking dozens of questions was

wasting time. Then again, the Netherealm was supposed to equalize all languages... did that include chimera speak?

“Why did you come here?”

Fig Stew stood up with a purr. He gave himself a full body shake to free himself of sand and started trotting up the hill into the sea of flowers. Mydei followed without further questioning.

Antila flowers softened every one of Mydei’s footsteps, turning the volume down on the already muted sounds of the Netherealm. It made Mydei feel exposed. Swimming upriver after every death came with an inherent turmoil. With the flow of disturbed water racing against his skin and ears, the fight back to life had always felt *loud* with the pound of blood and urgency. Standing on the shore was peaceful, a stillness that could only be described as quiet but not *silent*.

The flowers demanded *silence*. The babble of a River, however still, was *sound* that these blooms devoured. Mydei’s creaking armor and Fig Stew’s purrs, felt like unwelcome disturbances and his battle instincts loathed the implication. Souls took notice, turning to watch them pass by in various states of decay. Some were no more than shadows, others, like Cerydra had been, were still holding to their stagnation tightly enough to still look solid and whole.

Fig Stew was either oblivious to the way they turned to watch or didn’t care. He trudged along with his tail held high, the tip of it bouncing above the flowers just like his fluffy ears. The chimera didn’t detour at all on this sacred task but even traveling in a straight line it felt like they were taking time to reach wherever this creature longed to go.

If Mydei stayed down here too long, would his death be made permanent? The thread around his finger thrummed, reassuring, but Mydei still wondered if there was a timer on his immortality, one that he could not see. The realization that he could make that choice revolted him, there were people who needed him, people *he* needed, but from a practical curiosity about his cursed body… Was his weak spot, *truly* the only way to kill Mydeimos the Undying? Or could he be undone by exhaustion, a failing of stubbornness, or grief?

The thought dashed against the shore of his love and splintered into nothing at the same time Fig Stew mewled. He glanced down at those wide, slow-blinking eyes and then followed them up to another ruin of a bygone age.

It may have been the base of a watchtower at one point, Mydei recognized the structure of early Kremnoan architecture, but the bulk of the walls had long since collapsed and failed to make the journey. All that remained of them was a partial curve, too crumbled to rise to any noble height, but enough to allow for some privacy within the circle of stone floor and scraps of furniture.

There were two people there, sitting on giant stone bricks that had fallen from the wall in an age long past. One was a man that Mydei had never seen before with very short dark brown hair and stubble along his jawline and chin. He had dark eyes that softened when Mydei approached above a gentle, albeit very tired smile. Light armor adorned his lean frame, the

standard tunic and bronze of the Okheman Navy, but he wore the gold cuffs and rich blue and gold chlamys of an officer.

Fig Stew bounded in leaps to the second person, throwing himself into her arms so hard that she almost fell over with a booming laugh that cut through Mydei with nostalgia sharp enough to leave his eyes wet with budding tears. He knew that laugh, that bright smile, and especially those amber, leonine eyes.

Mother? He was afraid to say it aloud lest she vanish like a mirage on water. His feet very suddenly felt heavy, rooted among the antilas, afraid to take that final step up onto the stonework.

Gorgo was ethereal and beautiful, a true Queen of Kremnos and daughter of Strife. Strength coiled in her arms and legs, muscles lean but defined. It radiated from her in the way she carried herself, head high, back straight, armor gleaming bronze under red and black fabric. And her face… the way her hair framed her face, wild and chopped, uneven and somehow so natural was a mane that settled on her shoulders. Some of it had been braided over her right shoulder, careful, even, and locked in place by a bronze aglet. It was a look that Mydei saw every time he saw his reflection in a mirror, in the water, and now here. The same chin, narrow, leonine eyes, long lashes, curved nose, and her voice rumbled with a deep purr straight from his memories.

“What keeps you, Mydeimos?” she teased. Her voice was confident, deep compared to the other women in his life, like a war drum, stirring the blood to action with every syllable. “Have you no words for your mother?”

Still stunned, Mydei slowly closed his mouth. He hadn’t realized his lips had parted in the first place and when he opened them again, no sound came out. His whole body was trying to process the surge of emotions that had piled up behind the dam.

She held Fig Stew up above her head with both hands under his little arms and he purred so loudly the flowers could not hope to dampen the reverberation. His paws reached for her, making biscuits in the air while his tail wagged like one of Peucesta’s metronomes.

“I should be proud,” she told Fig Stew, “that my son, like all great warriors, has outgrown me!”

“Awoo!”

“Mother, I-”

“BUT ALAS, MY HEART ACHES FOR MY SON. IT IS THE CURSE OF ALL MOTHERS TO LONG FOR THEIR WAYWARD CHILDREN,” she said loudly over him.

“Awoo!” Fig agreed and she laughed and bounced the chimera once before cradling him like a baby on his back to rub his tummy while he purred and made biscuits in the air.

Mydei could feel the dam inside him crack and when he finally took a step, it broke. The weight that had chained him to the ground snapped and he rushed to her. She barely had time

to set aside Fig Stew and stand before Mydei's arms were tight around her shoulders and he was racked with tearless sobs. Her arms wrapped around his torso, tight around him, grounding while he pressed his cheek to the side of her head, surprised to find such warmth from her spirit.

It was Gorgo who pulled away first and Mydei had to force himself with great difficulty to let go.

"You have grown," she observed with pride. She put her hand on his cheek, her eyes darting back and forth as she took him in. Gorgo was not a small woman, but she still had to tilt her head to meet his eye.

A soft sound cut through the moment, the man had cleared his throat and was watching them with a sympathetic, albeit somewhat awkward smile. The sort of expression one saves for reluctant gestures.

Mydei shot this *stranger* a glare, but Gorgo was unbothered. She let her hand slip from Mydei's cheek to his shoulder, then to his bicep to give him a reassuring squeeze. "I have not forgotten about you, Marcus," she told the man without looking at him.

Gorgo pulled away from Mydei and took his hand, pulling him towards the Okheman even as her eyes drank him in with the discerning eye of a parent checking that their adult child was eating well. "As overjoyed as I am to see you, my son, I did not send for you just so you could wile away precious time with your mother."

Fig Stew had jumped onto Gorgo's seat, waiting patiently in a sit to be acknowledged by the Queen. Mydei noted the chimera as he was led. "Then Fig Stew led me here to-"

"Mydeimos," she said. It was a command from a matriarch and Mydei's eyes snapped to her before he could think any further along that line of thought. "This is Marcus and he *must* speak to you."

The Okheman had a hand extended in greeting, waiting patiently while Mydei considered it. He was still so overwhelmed it took him a moment to reciprocate, clasping the man's arm in a mutual shake.

"It is an honor, Marcus," Mydei hummed politely, perhaps a little shallow.

"The honor is mine, Prince Mydeimos," the man said lightly. He had a friendly air about him that reminded Mydei of Phainon. The kind of friendly that held onto a handshake for far longer than one should. "For a long time, I lamented that I would not be able to thank you."

"Thank me?" The confusion was impossible to hide.

"For killing me."

Mydei recoiled as though burned, taking a shuffled step backwards and letting go of Marcus with suspicion in every movement. It was the *sincerity* with which he said it that made the

shock so much worse. Marcus was *smiling* as he said it and now Mydei was searching his brain for this man he simply did not remember.

Gorgo's eyes glittered and she patted Mydei's shoulder. "I will leave you two to talk. Peace, my son, I will not go far."

Mydei relaxed with her reassurances but the spring in his gut was still wound tight and when she stepped away that coiled tension spread to his arms and legs, leaving him standing stiff and wary. "I'm sorry," he told Marcus, "I don't remember you."

The man laughed, a short awkward thing, "Haha, that's fine, Prince, I didn't expect you to. When we fought I was newly changed."

The coil turned to dread as it wrapped Mydei's heart in chilling ice. "Changed?"

"By the Black Tide." Perhaps it was in response to the look on Mydei's face, but Marcus pressed a hand to his chest, the same way Phainon did when he was nervous, and tucked his head. "Ah, I'm sorry, I know this is a lot and not at all why you came here. Queen Gorgo said that you may not have been able to come at all so to stand before you with this opportunity… it's easy to forget that you do not know me as well as I know you."

"You know me?"

"From the stories your mother has told. Her connection to the world of the living is much stronger than mine you see. She has been comforting me with tales," he explained. "Um, please sit, and I will do my best to better explain why it was so important that I thank you."

It took Mydei a second to take a seat, settling where his mother had been before. She was in the flowers now, chasing Fig Stew with a child-like demeanor. Frolicking in the flowers with a chimera was not something he expected from his mother, but she somehow managed it without compromising her disciplined and regal demeanor. It set Mydei at ease to see her smile.

"She is a remarkable woman," Marcus said gently and Mydei realized he had been staring.

"She is," he agreed, pleasantly warm with the realization that Marcus said *is* and not *was*. He turned to Marcus then to give the Okheman his full attention and the man smiled, taking the body language as the invitation that it was.

"I was the First Mate of the Speeding Sol," Marcus explained, "serving under Captain Phainon."

Mydei's eyes widened a hair and again that tightness in his chest returned. "You were on the ship the night we rescued Phainon from the water."

A subtle nod. "I followed my Captain onto the corrupted ship and succumbed to the Black Tide." Marcus's hands were on his knees, slowly closing into tight fists. "It happened so fast. It's hard to remember images but the *feelings* are branded onto my soul. The determination that I had to follow my captain into combat meant nothing in the face of the Tide's

overwhelming grief and despair. There was a moment before the change when the song burrowed deep, permeating my bones with absolute loss and grief so painful that my legs trembled until I fell. It was a longing that I have not felt since the day I kissed my wife and son goodbye to embark on the voyage that led to my death. You have heard the song too, right?"

Mydei nodded but said nothing, letting the man continue.

"I wept when I heard it and then screamed when it took over my body. The song is loud and all-encompassing, so I hope it makes sense when I tell you I *felt* the sound of my bones breaking and my head bursting, more than I heard it." Marcus shook his head. "I am sure you have seen the change before… what I need you to know, most of all, is that the transformation is not death. What is left behind is not mindless. We become ghosts trapped in a shell that is no longer our own, but the *person* is still there, buried under the agony."

Mydei resisted the urge to shudder, steeling himself to listen.

"We are driven to madness by the song that preys on our grief, filling us with a desperate loneliness that drives every movement with a frantic need to spread so we will not be alone any longer," he paused and shame crept into the tremor of his voice. "When I turned, I saw my Captain disappear below deck and after thrashing through the transformation I set out in pursuit of him, with every intention of killing the Deliverer, because the song told me that was the only way I could obey my oath to him. A part of me knew that was wrong, screamed from behind the bars of this new prison that I did not want to do that, but my body moved without me. It was your claws in my throat, breaking through the deck of that burning ship, that freed my spirit from those chains."

Mydei vaguely remembered that. There had been an elite Black Tide monster on the deck of that merchant vessel when the Chryseus Leo turned around and rammed Phainon's ship. The corruption had spread so quickly… It had been unprecedented even in the detachment's experience. He remembered the urgency with which they moved cargo from the merchant ship as the Black Tide swelled in the water below. And how surprised they all were to find a survivor in the wreckage.

"It is because of this experience that my thanks comes with a hopeful request," Marcus pleaded. "The other Black Tide monsters… they are in pain. Even if there was a way to return them to humanity, their madness would surely persist. All that is left for them is a half-life of agony. Please, Inheritor of Strife, save them from this horror they are forced to endure."

Marcus' request was accompanied by a bowed head and hands pressed together as though praying. He was a devout pilgrim, sitting beside the divine, humble and with nothing to offer in sacrifice aside from his hope and faith.

"I am not your god, Okheman," Mydei said, he tried to sound fierce and commanding, but it came out with too much awe and worry.

"No, you are not," Marcus admitted, "but I place my faith in Strife all the same… Strife and the Deliverer."

This wasn't the kind of request that Mydei was comfortable accepting implicitly, not when there were already so many unknowns. They still had to stop the Black Tide from spreading before they could consider the clean-up, but perhaps there was some comfort in thinking ahead. Only hopeful people looked past the trials of tomorrow, planning beyond the frightful horizon to something brighter.

"If not I," Mydei promised with a hand over his chest, "then the other Demigods. I will tell them what you have told me."

"Thank you," Marcus looked back up at Mydei with a grateful smile and then opened his mouth to speak again, but he hesitated.

"Have you more to say?" Mydei invited.

"It's my captain," Marcus explained.

"Phainon?"

"Yes. I have admired him for some time, and I worry that he may be harboring some guilt for what happened to the Sol and her crew," he explained. "Will you tell him that we forgive him?"

Mydei's heart twisted again at the thought of Phainon. "…that does sound like him," he agreed.

"And will you ask him to…" More hesitation as Marcus swallowed, "ask him to forgive Xenia."

"Xenia?" Mydei asked with a tilt of his head.

"She is my wife," he explained. "And she has treated him terribly since my passing."

This was news to Mydei, but it wasn't a surprise. Phainon *had* gone off on his own the night they went to Okhema, and Mydei couldn't possibly know every detail of when they had returned to the Holy City without him. The Deliverer was the kind of person that would seek to comfort the families of his fallen crew, to take responsibility no matter the circumstances.

Mydei nodded and then asked, "Would you like me to take a message to your wife?"

Marcus shook his head. "I love her and have been keeping my eye on her as best I can but… any message I send with you she will either reject or cling to with such fervor that she will never heal. For the sake of our son, she needs to let me go."

"You are afraid that if you give her sign, she will never stop searching for them," Mydei concluded.

"Yes," Marcus whispered.

"I understand."

“Thank you for hearing me, Prince Mydeimos. I will not keep you any longer.” He stood and offered his hand again, clasping Mydei’s arm with firm recognition when Mydei got to his feet and met the gesture. “She shrugs you away and speaks of wiling away the time, but I know she wants to speak to you too.” Marcus’ smile was warm when he gestured with a nod towards Queen Gorgo sitting among the flowers while Fig Stew headbutted under her chin to cuddle. She leaned in and whispered something into the chimera’s ear and they laughed together at whatever secret they shared.

“It was an honor, Marcus,” Mydei said genuinely.

Another nod and Marcus let go. “I will give you some privacy,” he half-mumbled. Before Mydei could say anything further, he turned and walked away, already fading. Perhaps he would linger for a time like these other spirits, Mydei couldn’t say for sure, but it was not his place to judge so he respectfully turned away.

It was then that Gorgo turned her eyes to him again, smiling a toothy grin. She sat among the flowers as Mydei walked to her, trying not to shake as he relished this moment. Every little tilt of her head, the way her fingers brushed over Fig Stew’s sides, the sound of her hum as he very slowly walked to her… Mydei wanted to sear it into his memory.

“He is a good man,” she said, nodding to where Marcus had been. “I am glad you spoke with him.”

Mydei gently lowered himself to his knees beside her and she reached out to yank him down to sit so that their shoulders were touching. It startled him into silence and she laughed.

“If I did not know better I would worry at your timidness! Is this really *my* son?”

“Forgive me mother, I did not expect to see you again,” he admitted.

“Mydeimos,” Gorgo tsked. She took his hand to hold in both of hers. “I have never left you.”

Fig Stew barked once and then wiggled into the space between them.

“Castorice said that someone was watching over me, that those who have died who harbor strong wills may use mediums to reach out. All this time, Fig Stew was-”

“My messenger, yes,” she told him cheerfully, “through him, I have had the honor of watching you grow into a man that I am proud to call my son.”

Mydei chuckled and scratched between Fig’s ears. “Krateros has been trusting him as though he were you. How right the old man was.”

“Krateros is a good man,” she agreed.

“Mother,” Mydei swallowed, the weight of his curiosity made his chest tight, “how are you here?”

“I have always been here Mydeimos. Do you not remember? I suppose those memories must feel as dreams to you now. You were so very young.”

He shook his head. “I remember my youth and I am grateful to have had you to raise me while I grew in the Sea of Souls along this river, but Nikador’s blade…?”

“Eurypon’s treachery,” she said darkly, “neither of us were worthy upon our deaths to fight by Nikador’s side.”

“Have you not considered moving on?” Mydei asked, mildly afraid of the answer.

“I have, but I wanted to see what became of my son. You were a little thing when you were born, Mydeimos. Your cry was so fragile and ethereal. Eurypon and I could never have imagined that such a feeble cry would come from our child. But Nikador’s own battle cry resonated with yours, and suddenly your newborn mewlings were as crystal-clear resonant as the roar off the Tretos lion. There was no denying it: you are of pure Kremnoan blood, the son of Gorgo born to take the crown!”

Mydei felt bile in his throat, the guilt of his own considerations as of late, eating through his belly. Nervous, with a voice that wavered, he asked, “Mother, I… would you love me less if I cast that crown away?”

Her hand came up to his cheek, catching his face as he tried to turn away. “Mydeimos… what needless worry hides in your heart? Even if my dreams for you were lofty the day you were born, at the core of everything you are simply my son, the ordinary child of a Kremnoan mother. You have developed yourself with determination and I am pleased here in the afterlife.

“My love for you never needed a crown. If you have doubts about this so-called glory, this inheritance of regicide, then live as you please! Gorgo, the founder of Kremnos, per their will and their yearning, summoned Nikador and earned the glory of Strife. And you, my child, can also return home with true glory under the radiance of the Lance of Fury, not as its ruler, but simply as yourself.”

Her thumb brushed across his cheek and when she pulled her hand away there was wetness there. Mydei had not even realized he was crying.

“You *are* the rightful heir, Mydeimos, not just of Kremnos, but of Strife itself. In you is the power to command change for our people, to become something *more* than what your father left behind.”

“Should I crush our legacy underfoot? This legacy of Strife that betrayed you?” he half-whispered, “is that what you would do in my place?”

“I am not you,” she scolded, “and I cannot make that decision for you. Once I believed in the spirit of Kremnos without question, and then your father threw you into the Sea of Souls. It was at that moment I realized how everything I believed in was utterly hollow. Perhaps the spirit of Kremnos had once existed, but as greed bloomed in the hearts of humanity over the years, such spirit has long faded alongside our glory. I no longer put my faith in any oath or doctrine. Now I have just one role… That of your mother, Mydeimos. Your guardian.”

You don’t get to be the only protector here.

His own words, no, Phainon's words echoed as he studied his mother's radiant smile. She would have loved him.

"So, Mydeimos, have you found something deserving of your protection?"

He held up his hand to her, the one with the golden thread, to reverently show her the strength of his bond. "I have, mother."

And then he held nothing back. Mydei told her everything about his family, about Krateros as a mentor, about his closest friends in the Detachment. He told her about the moment he achieved vengeance in her name, putting an end to Eurypon for good. He described for her the Chryseus Leo and his favorite parts of sailing. But he spoke the most about Phainon. This beautiful, ethereal, perfect man, who had swooped in and stolen his very spirit with his strength and heart.

Mydei let her hold the string while he talked and Gorgo's eyes glittered with gentle knowing as they listened to Phainon's heartbeat and unintelligible murmurs. They were rhythmic now, consistent. He was talking. That perfect wonderful man was *reading* to his body, taking care of him with diligent love.

"I am sorry," Mydei said sheepishly when his throat started to feel dry.

"For what, Mydeimos?"

"For recalling what you must already know. Fig Stew has been with me for every step of this long voyage."

"Yes, but I like hearing it from you, while I can."

"I can visit you again," he said swiftly.

With equal swiftness she slapped him across the back of the head. It was so surprising and so *Kremnoan* that Mydei leaned away and pouted at his mother like a child.

"No, for the sake of that wonderful and patient man, no."

"We sail to dangerous waters soon," Mydei reasoned, "I may fall in battle."

"No," she said simply and with resolute firmness.

Her reaction left him flabbergasted, mouth agape, eyes wide, fumbling for what felt like an obvious explanation but she silenced him with a finger to his lips.

"You are going to treasure each life the way he does, Mydeimos," she instructed firmly, "I saw him you know. When you stayed to fight the Black Tide, he broke beneath the Lance of Fury. It was this one's courage and his promise to you that saved our people." Fig Stew purred when she rubbed under his chin.

A knot was forming in Mydei's throat at that thought, the image of a bleeding, broken Phainon pleading with a crystal wall.

“And when they retrieved your body, he did not sleep. Fig Stew and I tried to coax him to rest, but he was fire and fury turned inwards, Mydeimos. I have never seen such hatred in my life.”

“…hatred?”

“Hatred for himself,” she explained, “for not getting to you faster. He could not hold his human form his grief was so great. Not I, nor Fig, nor even Perdikkas could get to your body the way he held you. Until you started to breathe again, he was as dead to the world as you were.” Gorgo sighed and looped the golden thread around Mydei’s hand a few times and then she placed both of her hands over his. “I know, my son, that sacrifice is a tenant of Strife, and you must do everything to protect him, so I will not accept an impossible vow from a Kremnoan warrior, promise me instead that you will *try*.”

“I will, mother.”

“I like him, Mydeimos,” she said with a toothy grin, “it took Fig Stew some time to be sure, but I have loved him from the start. His men love him too. That Marcus had nothing but good words to say about the Deliverer of Amphoreus.”

Fig Stew made a low chirping grumble deep in his belly.

“Oh shush, Fig,” she scolded, “you could not have known that Eurypon would change so.”

“Not making that mistake twice,” the chimera grumbled.

Mydei’s eyes darted in shock to Fig Stew, accusatory, and the chimera’s face slowly turned into a half-lidded smug smile. So, he *could* be understood down here. Before Mydei could scold the beloved pet, Gorgo patted his thigh.

“You will need to return to him soon,” she said, still cheerful but softer now.

A part of Mydei’s heart leaped into the back of his throat as he remembered he could not stay here forever. There was a deep and painful longing coating his throat with fluff, stealing his breath to keep him from speaking, to prevent this inevitable goodbye.

“Mydeimos,” she whispered when she saw him struggling. Her palm pressed against his cheek, and he raised a hand to cover hers, to keep her there, afraid to close his eyes. “You do not need to speak to me again to know that I am beside you, but if it helps, I have a gift for you. You left behind Eurypon’s ring when you killed him, but won’t you take mine?”

He blinked and reluctantly let her go when she took her hand back to take the ring from her finger. It was a signet ring bearing the crest of Strife and cast in bronze. Where Eurypon’s ring had been encrusted with jewels, this one was simple, humble, a reminder that Strife did not bask in riches, it was practical and purposeful.

Queen Gorgo placed it in his palm and guided his fingers to close around it. “Hold it tightly, Mydeimos, and it will surely go with you.”

“I will treasure it, mother,” he promised.

She let go and rose to her feet, offering a strong hand to pull Mydei up beside her for a firm embrace that made his ribs creak. “See that you do, my son, not because I gave it to you, but for whom you will give it.”

“You are giving this to me so that I will give it away?” Mydei whined into her shoulder.

“Allow a mother to give her son this final test. I will know that you have finally broken free of our blood-soaked past, when you surrender this ring to your future.”

His arms tightened around her. “I love you, mother.”

“And I you, Mydeimos, my beloved son. I am, and always will be, proud of you.”

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Mydei and Fig Stew walked the river together, heading upstream in bittersweet silence until the quiet darkness turned into the soft ache of a body lying still on a folded blanket. The chill of the marble floor still crept through the layers to nip at his legs but a warm chimera body, laying by his side and the rise and fall of a strong heartbeat at his back promised warmth.

Phainon’s voice cut through the stillness, getting louder as Mydei came to himself. This perfect, wonderful man was reading from their favorite book, and as promised, when he looked down into Mydei’s blinking eyes, it was with a gentle and loving smile.

“Welcome home, Mydei,” Phainon whispered.

“I told you I wouldn’t be gone long,” Mydei teased light-heartedly.

Phainon’s gentle touch rubbed along his cheeks, warm and gentle, bringing Mydei back to life with the realization that there were tears spilling from his eyes and a small, but very important weight in his palm.

Chapter 47: Nothing Left Unsaid

Chapter Summary

Mydei and Phainon talk

Chapter Notes

I THINK I CAN STILL DO THIS IN FIFTY CHAPTERS. Everyone pray that I don't have to move the chapter goal posts again.

Mydei was exhausted. The revival process *always* hurt. He had described it to Perdikkas once, fumbling to find the right words for something he didn't fully understand. The sensation was like realigning a broken bone in the middle of combat, when fear and pain have forced the muscles to contract. The nerves and bloody break scrape and grind, nerves roaring as they're forced together and bound.

The realignment of the soul and body was just a shade worse. The wound had closed, the flesh mended. There was no knife in his chest, but his soul remembered the blade in his heart, and it still needed time to heal. That persistent ache, like a migraine stabbing low at the nape, couldn't be described as bone deep. It was stitched on his soul, fraying on the edges until it could be mended, preferably by napping somewhere warm and soft.

But as the Kremnoan saying goes, there would be time to rest when he was dead.

Mydei tucked aside all the pain when he woke in Phainon's arms. No more tears, no more attention given to those pins and needles in every joint, no time or energy to process the emotional weight of his journey that wrapped like a wire around his intestines and lungs.

The moment Anaxa realized Mydei was awake, the Professor was on his knees by the captain's side to record his testimony of events. Everything Mydei learned from Cerydra poured from his lips like honey brew, free-flowing and slurred, while the others listened carefully. Fig Stew purred in his lap, Phainon offered him water, and the others did their best to not crowd while also satisfying their curiosity.

He described the Imperator in detail, everything that stood out about her and everything she had said about Helektra, the sea siren that hid in the ocean beside Hyperborea. Missing history was penned in the gaps, and her knowledge of the siren song was rapidly transcribed alongside the previously forgotten prophecy that had led to her eager death on the siren's blade.

Mydei could feel the slump of his shoulders and the tremor in his hands as his body creaked. But it wasn't the ache that held his tongue when he finished recounting his time with Cerydra. He needed to tell them about Marcus, what he had said about the Black Tide monsters and their cruel state of purgatory, but when Mydei turned enough to look at Phainon, at the bags under his eyes, the soft smile that barely hid his worry and hurt, he just couldn't do it. Not yet. His fist stayed closed around the ring, still hidden, a secret between himself and the sleepy Fig Stew.

The pause had saved him from his monologue. Anaxa had already moved on with these new findings and taken command in Mydei's moment of weakness. They packed books and notes while Mydei held still beside Phainon and the chimera, waiting for the foggy mush behind his eyes to clear.

Mydei moved through the motions like a ghost as they returned to the ship and disembarked from the great library, pointing north towards the fallen kingdoms. The decision was made carefully after pouring over maps, taking stock of their supplies, and consulting with Krateros and Hephaestion. He fell back into the rhythm of being the captain, of barking out orders, cooking their meals, and running his war council, but at the back of his mind he was looking for a chance to talk to Phainon about Marcus.

He knew the stress was getting to him when he woke one morning to Phainon's frantic tapping. Mydei was partially transformed on the bed. His lion back half was on the floor, drooped like a towel over the back of a chair and his front paws were wrapped so tightly around Phainon that the man was suffocating in plush fur.

"It's not a bad way to go, really!" Phainon had insisted with a reassuring smile and when Mydei couldn't transform back due to stress, Phainon had stayed up with him, running a brush through his fur and humming soft lullabies.

That should have been the moment. What better time did he have to talk to this patient man who *deserved* to know how his crew felt in the afterlife? Phainon who was so good, so perfect, and so very haunted. Phainon who had horrible nightmares that woke Mydei from time to time, that took restraining hands and a chimera's soft tongue to coax back into a restful sleep.

But Mydei couldn't do it, because he wasn't ready to admit that he saw more than Cerydra down there. Because he knew that Phainon would listen to everything, even the parts that Mydei wanted to keep to himself, and he wasn't sure he'd be able to hold back, once those emotions were free.

As Phainon massaged his paws and crept up his Titan body to comb and braid Mydei's hair, he thought about the ring, tucked away in a locked drawer while he slept. When Phainon's hand gently rubbed the fading scar over Mydei's heart, easing another ache until his eyelids fluttered with encroaching sleep, he realized he wanted to share every emotion with him, as soon as he found the words. No more beating around the bush, he wanted to be straight-forward with blunt and brutal honesty, good *and* bad, as Mydei had been his whole life!

So why was this so hard?

Mydei stood at the bow beside the silent head of the great lion a few Entry Hours later, eating his breakfast and watching the sea ahead. The horizon in every direction was black, it had been since Descent Hour the prior day but the roiling clouds above them split like a wound, letting in the light and guiding them north through the oily ocean. The Eye of Twilight's power was an unprecedented advantage in this endeavor.

One of his fuzzy ears flicked at the sound of soft footsteps. Despite Mydei's best efforts to hold his human form, his ears were slow to receive the message. Vibrant red and horribly obvious to anyone who knew that Mydei wasn't doing it on purpose. Like this even his clothes felt itchy, and he had settled for simpler attire. His armor was left behind in the room, pending a good polish, leaving him in a short tunic, chlamys, loose pants, and knee-high boots, enough to stay warm.

He didn't turn when Phainon stepped up beside him to lean both of his forearms on the railing. But his eyes did flick down when his boyfriend leaned forward enough for that white mop to be visible, sticking out as far as he could safely lean to look at the ocean breaking against the rostrum. It was laundry day for Phainon and a few others. He was wearing that old exomis, the one they had provided him with when he was still a prisoner. It left most of his back and chest exposed but Phainon didn't seem to mind.

They stayed that way for a while, enjoying the breeze, however cold, in comfortable silence. Well, *mostly* comfortable silence. Mydei traced every scar on Phainon's back with his eyes thrice, resisting the urge to run the length of them with his fingers. He could feel the ring in his pocket searing his skin through the fabric of his pants and his courage swayed back and forth on a pendulum. He took a breath when he felt it swing around again and opened his mouth to speak but Phainon beat him to it.

"What do you think of kids?" Phainon asked without turning and the question caught Mydei so off guard that all his bunched-up emotions unraveled into a garden-variety pile of confusion.

"…what?"

"Kids," Phainon repeated, "do you like them?" The Deliverer shifted his weight, twisting in place to look up at Mydei from where he was leaning over the railing.

"…were you planning on having them?" Mydei asked, cautiously.

"Unless your Titan form came with more changes, no. At least not of my own." He sounded cheerful, relaxed, but there was tiredness in his eyes, a dull to the blue.

"I like them well enough," the captain answered after taking a moment to consider it, "why?"

"Because there are some things I didn't tell you about… stuff that happened when you were gone," Phainon said as he heavily rolled back onto both forearms to face the ocean again, hiding his eyes from Mydei's slowly souring expression. There wasn't enough guilt on Phainon's shoulders for him to have done something egregious, but Mydei still felt like he was holding his breath.

“When we evacuated the settlement, I found a little girl hiding in the ruins of her home,” Phainon explained and then he told Mydei everything about the five-year-old orphaned daughter of Militiades, Chironome. He spoke highly of this little girl that took a swing at a Black Tide Gryphon with a toy sword, who squealed with joy at Fig Stew, and fed Phainon food to keep his strength up. Phainon’s voice was tender as he recalled the way she took her tasks seriously, protecting “Fine” all the way to the infirmary, the way she curled up against his chest to sleep, and how crushed and angry she was when Phainon left her in the care of a temporary guardian.

“I didn’t tell you before because it didn’t feel important at the time,” Phainon explained, “but I’ve been thinking about her more lately, and this world we’re trying to save so that she can grow up. This fight we’re sailing to… it didn’t feel serious enough until I considered her and now I can’t stop feeling like this isn’t just another fight. This voyage is so much bigger than all of us and I think I’m afraid.” The vulnerability in his voice was raw and gritty, and very much only for Mydei. This was not the Worldbearer wearing his reassuring smile to please the masses, this was Phainon, the farmers’ son who lost everything and never wanted to lose again. “I trust you, Mydei, I wanted you to know what’s on my mind.”

A little bud of guilt started to nibble at Mydei’s gut as he thought about the secrets he was holding onto himself.

Phainon stood up straight, pushing away from the railing and turned to face Mydei with a reassuring squeeze above the elbow. “You don’t need to tell me what secret you’re keeping, just promise me, when you’re ready, you will?”

Mydei followed that firm grip up those strong arms to Phainon’s face. His lips were lightly curled at the corners, but his smile wavered below tired but trusting eyes.

“How did you know?” Mydei sighed around his own shame. He looked down at Phainon’s chest, avoiding his gaze by studying the knotted scar in his shoulder, the one left behind by Nikador.

“Because I know you now. I remember what you were like when you were trying to find the words to tell me about my status on the ship,” Phainon remembered aloud. “I thought you hated me the way you wouldn’t look at me.” Mydei’s eyes darted up to Phainon’s in defiance of the observation. “And later when you found the warrant from Aglaea, I remember how quiet you were.” Phainon let go of Mydei’s arm to instead gently take his cheek in hand, pressing his warm and calloused palm against the wind-bitten cold that lingered there. “Whatever is haunting you, it involves me, doesn’t it?”

Mydei carefully reached up to wrap his fingers loosely around Phainon’s wrist. “It does,” he whispered, “and it is not my place to keep it from you.”

“If you’re not ready-”
“No. There is no room for sulking on my ship,” Mydei said, just as he had the day they met, “nor cowardice.” Just knowing that Phainon would wait if asked, it was a comfort that Mydei hadn’t realized he needed.

“You just needed to know how you felt first, right?” Phainon asked and Mydei remembered holding Aglaea’s written words, the ones that condemned Phainon and set them on this impossible and wonderful path. That was his reasoning then. It held true now.

“And where to start,” Mydei confirmed, “I too, have had a lot on my mind.”

“…how much did you hold back when you told Professor Anaxa about the Netherealm?” Phainon asked carefully, giving him a starting point.

“Nothing that did not apply to his studies, but enough.” Mydei pulled Phainon’s hand away from his face so he could turn back to the railing, to set his hands on the new wood. Phainon and Krateros had already carved the moment Mydei had stayed to fight Nikador there by the bow. Only the most noble of stories were worthy of framing the great lion of Tretos they had said, both cheerfully ignoring his embarrassment. The raised edges felt smooth under Mydei’s bare hands.

“Meeting Cerydra was like seeing my reflection in disturbed water,” Mydei admitted, “we are not the same, but… there were similarities.”

“You are no tyrant, Mydei.”

“No, but I *have* asked horrible things of you,” he took a breath to say, “I am sorry I asked you to kill me.”

Phainon shook his head and went back to resting on his forearms, close enough to lean his shoulder against Mydei’s arm. “I’m sorry I ran away at first, instead of trusting you.”

“Did you not hear me, HKS? I am saying I should not have asked.”

“You’re comparing what I did to you, with what Cerydra asked of Hysilens, aren’t you?” Phainon accused and Mydei’s mouth shut. “It’s different, Mydei. It’s different, and yeah, it was hard, and yeah, it hurt to hold your body, but you were right too. Being a part of that process, beginning to end, it didn’t *fix* everything, but it helped. I had a lot of time while you were dead to think about it, and I realized how much I valued your trust in me.”

Mydei grunted, neutral, non-committal.

“How about I forgive you for asking and we agree to not do it again?” Phainon offered with a playful lilt in his voice.

“This is acceptable.”

“…Cerydra loved Hysilens when she asked too,” Phainon remembered aloud, “but she put her dreams of saving the world first.”

“I did the same.”

“But I get to see you again and you were thinking of me when you asked, that’s the difference.”

Mydei drummed his fingers on the railing and then turned his hand over to look at his palm. "When I was dead," he recalled, "I was bound to you by a golden thread."

Phainon seemed genuinely surprised by that. "Like one of Aglaea's threads?"

"Yes, the Imperator was similarly bound to Hysilens. She mentioned that Romance must have seen a reason to bless us to bind our souls so completely."

"I like that." Phainon's voice was soft and gentle. He turned enough to smile sideways at Mydei. "A monarch who fell in love with an outcast."

"Two Demigods that believed they were saving the world."

"We *are* saving the world."

"They thought so too," Mydei reminded him.

Phainon ran a hand through his hair. "For all we have in common, there are differences too. We aren't clinging to prophecy."

"I have rejected my crown," he added.

"Their story *is* beautiful," Phainon said after a moment, "tragic, but beautiful. Hysilens' loyalty to her love is worthy of immortalization by song. Still…" His voice dropped to nearly a whisper. "She must be terribly, terribly lonely."

"Would you do as she has?" Mydei asked, "if I perished and with my dying breath insisted you go on, to accomplish my dreams in my stead?"

Phainon thought about that, hard enough that the ends of his hair started to turn blonde, leaving them tipped in honey. A manifestation of the duress such a query stirred inside him. "I don't know," he confessed, "I'm not sure I want to think about it."

The air felt heavy when Mydei took a breath. Not all conversation topics were appropriate for breakfast, depending on the morning, no conversation at all was the universal preference.

"I suppose I would," Phainon decided after another moment, "because they would be *our* dreams, no?"

Mydei's heart jumped when he heard that.

I like him, Mydeimos… I have loved him from the start.

Longing bubbled up in his belly, disagreeing with the bread and olives he had finished earlier as his insides started throwing a party, doing celebratory squats. His heart was full to bursting, singing Phainon's name and forgetting his own.

When Mydei looked down at Phainon again, the man was smiling up at him, his cheek smooshed against his knuckles. "When did you know you were in love with me?" Phainon asked.

Mydei crossed his arms and tucked his head to think. His ears flattened as he searched through their time together. “It did not happen in a single moment,” he realized, “there was no grand gesture, no moment of revelation, I simply realized that I had been, as though there were never a time that I was not.”

He opened his eyes again to Phainon’s boyish adoration. The expression of a man so deeply in love that just a glance made Mydei feel warm and safe.

Mydei cleared his throat. “And what of you?”

“When did I know I was in love with you?”

“Yes.”

Phainon’s smile faltered. He couldn’t beam as widely when his eyebrows pinched in deep concentration. It was so cute. Mydei loved that expression.

“I wish I could say it was before Castrum Kremnos,” Phainon finally said, “and maybe I was, but I knew without any shadow of a doubt when I was on Trial in Okhema, when I told the whole city that I loved you.”

Mydei tilted his head. “You told Okhema that you loved me?”

“Mhm,” Phainon’s relaxed adoration was back, “even without Aglaea’s threads holding me accountable, the moment the words were out, I knew I meant them.”

Mydei shook his head and frowned. “You told the whole of the Holy City, but you could not tell me the moment I rose from the dead in your arms?”

Phainon scoffed and let his hand fall away from his face to slap against the railing, still leaning his weight onto his elbow. “You hadn’t been dead for a week.”

“I had yet to wake, it counts.”

“You were *breathing*! You had a *heartbeat!*”

“Do not argue semantics to avoid the accusation, silver-tongued hyena,” huffed Mydei.

Phainon groaned and bent his knees, hiding below the railing with only his fingers holding on to keep him upright. He looked like he was going to be sick if Mydei didn’t know any better. This HKS had long found his sea legs during their spars.

“Yes!” Phainon relented, “yes, I told Okhema and then hesitated to tell you. I just…I wanted it to be special. It took me awhile to realize the circumstances of a confession like that aren’t what makes it special, it’s the person I’m confessing to.”

Mydei’s cheeks and ears felt warm, his insides fuzzy and happy. With an exaggerated huff, he held his crossed arms a little tighter and turned his nose up, eyes closed. “What have I said about sentimentality on this ship, Deliverer?”

“That you love it and want more of it in your life?”

Mydei cracked one eye to peek at Phainon’s silly grin as the man stood back up and leaned in close.

“HKS,” Mydei huffed.

“Krateros said that *Kremnoan* sentimentality is allowed, and as I recall, you introduced us to Nikador as sons of Kremnos.” Phainon’s voice was too cheerful, too sing-song. He was stepping in closer and Mydei refused to budge, even when the man was completely inside Mydei’s personal space.

“As the Inheritor of Strife, I disown you,” Mydei announced, deadpan.

“Mm, I’ll just have to earn my way back into your good graces, captain,” Phainon hummed. He kissed Mydei’s cheek, barely grazing the heated flesh with his lips.

A part of Mydei wanted to indulge, the part of him that caved and smiled at the playful advances, but he still had more to say.

“Cerydra was not the only person I spoke to in the Netherealm,” Mydei admitted, “my mother was waiting to speak to me.”

Phainon paused and then leaned back to beam at Mydei with a shaky smile as he tried to restrain his excitement. Mydei could see the shimmer of gold flash in his eyes like it did when he was trying to keep his emotions in check. His hands came up to take Mydei by the arms, holding him lightly above the elbows.

“Mydei, that’s wonderful! …unless, it’s not?”

“It was… bittersweet.”

“Do you want to talk about it?”

No, Mydei thought.

“She likes you,” he said.

“You get the chance to talk to your mother, and you talk about *me?*” Phainon laughed, perhaps a little too proud of himself. Mydei punched him in the shoulder, firm enough to make a point, to shove him back, and Phainon chuckled a little harder.

“She has been watching the crew through Fig Stew,” he revealed.

“All this time Krateros was right?”

“Yes.”

“Damn… but that means she’s been with you,” Phainon said happily. He rested his hand on the rail again and stepped in close to stand beside him, ready to support Mydei as needed.

That attentiveness, that thoughtfulness and selflessness were so damn cute, it made Mydei's heart stand at attention and filled him with the courage to share.

"Even earlier than I realized," Mydei confessed, "she raised me in the Sea of Souls as well. I thought they were old dreams from my youth, but I know now they were memories."

Phainon lightly punched Mydei's arm, flirting, "Mydei, that's amazing!"

It did warm his heart thinking about his mother's laugh, her face, and her council, enough to make him smile and lean into Phainon. His mind drifted back to the ring in his pocket.

I will know that you have finally broken free of our blood-soaked past, when you surrender this ring to your future.

More than ever, Mydei wanted Phainon to be that future, or at the very least a greater part of it. He genuinely could not picture a life that did not include Phainon. It was hard to even remember a time without him there by his side at all. How had this crew managed before? How had they lived without this smile, this energy, this loving, selfless soul? A soul that needed them too.

I have never seen such hatred in my life. Hatred for himself.

Mydei gently reached for Phainon's hand, giving it a firm and reassuring squeeze. This fight they were sailing to could very well be the end of them. Waiting at the end of this voyage to the edge of the map was a thousand-year-old Demigod driven by grief and love warped into madness. The only thing Hysilens had *left* was the duty entrusted to her by the woman she treasured, and it had become a monster that ate, ate, ate. Phainon's parents, his childhood home… Deep in those cerulean eyes flecked with gold was a buried rage and hate, an eagerness for revenge born in the trauma and fear of an eldritch horror. Did Phainon even know how deep that well within him was?

It was time. Phainon needed to hear this.

"Mother spoke with me but she initially sought me out so I would speak with a new friend she made in the last few months, an Okheman sailor named Marcus."

Phainon stilled. That hand on the railing tightened, clinging for support, and Mydei could see the mask going up, the careful gathering of his emotions to tuck them in a box. He hated it, he hated feeling like Phainon was trying to hide from him.

"Phainon, it's not bad," Mydei reassured. He reached out to grab Phainon's shoulder, to keep him close while he told Phainon everything he remembered about the conversation with Marcus, beginning with the revelation about the Black Tide. Phainon's trembling worsened with every word, a combination of distress and the effort of trying to hide it. Even now, Phainon was trying to hold himself together, falling back on years of impossible expectations.

"Mydei," Phainon mumbled with a shake of his head, "why didn't you bring this up at the library? This is about the nature of the Black Tide…"

“It changes nothing about what we must do. This task matters not if we cannot stop the siren and nothing about this knowledge helps the crew.”

Mydei reached out to brush the bangs from Phainon’s eyes, a losing battle against the breeze that gathered those silver locks again and put them right back.

“He left other messages with me, Deliverer, for you specifically. He wanted you to forgive Xenia, his wife. It would seem she has been cruel to you…?”

Phainon nodded and pain filled his expression, too great to bury. His shoulders drooped and his knees shook. “I have already forgiven her,” he admitted, “love and loss… I can’t blame her for hating me.”

You hate yourself too, don’t you? For failing them, for losing them the same way you lost your family. How long have you been holding onto this? How long have you been fighting yourself, alone?

Mydei studied him, torn between punching the self-hatred out of his boyfriend or hugging it out of him. “He also wanted you to know, on behalf of your crew, that they forgive you.”

Phainon’s head bowed and he turned away to leave, hiding again, but Mydei didn’t let him escape. His fingers wrapped around Phainon’s wrist, tight enough to hold, light enough to put him at ease. Phainon could have easily broken free if he tried but he didn’t, instead stepping away until their arms were fully extended, straining, as though Mydei were the only anchor keeping him from blowing away entirely in a raging whirlwind.

They waited like that until Phainon relaxed and the tightness of the hold loosened. His head was still bowed, hiding behind the curtain of his hair but Mydei stepped in front of him and reached out to again brush those bangs aside, this time holding them back with his hand over Phainon’s temple. Tears like diamonds peppered those long lashes, fighting the urge to fall.

“Look at me,” Mydei ordered in a soft voice and Phainon shook his head, half-heartedly trying to pull away, “Phainon of the Chryseus Leo, look at me.”

He looked so fragile like this, ethereal, divine, when he finally obeyed.

“It is time to forgive yourself,” Mydei whispered and Phainon couldn’t hold the emotions back anymore. They spilled from him in waves with broken sobs and Mydei wrapped his arms around this man’s shoulders, pulling him in and holding him tightly, letting those emotions run their course.

Phainon’s forehead slowly fell onto Mydei’s chest. He held tightly to Mydei’s chlamys as he mumbled, soft and vulnerable, “Mydei, I don’t know how.”

Mydei’s hug tightened around Phainon’s shoulders, and he rocked them in a subtle sway. “Then I will start, and you may trust my words until such time as you can trust your own.” He pressed a kiss to Phainon’s hair and leaned his cheek against his temple, whispering gently, “I forgive you, Phainon.”

The wind rushed around them as Phainon's wings appeared, unable to hold them back as the emotions surged through him. The blue and gold pinions fluttered, indecisively moving to cocoon them both and then back to furling behind his shoulders. His whole body was shaking as he sobbed, fighting the need to do so despite Mydei's gentle, encouraging touch.

Mydei ran his fingers through Phainon's hair, rubbing his scalp, his neck, his shoulders, and down his back with one hand while the other held him close, keeping him anchored, safe in this sheltered harbor of his companionship. These were old tears, Mydei could tell. The kind that were pushed down every time they threatened to fall, the kind that needed to spill and were denied by a string of excuses. The kind that may have come with shame in another time, another place, if they were shed alone.

Mydei pulled back enough to take Phainon's face in both hands, to hold Phainon still while he kissed every tear. His lips gently claimed every single one from his chin, his cheeks, and finally he kissed both eyes in turn, stealing away that sorrow until all he saw in those sunny eyes was *relief.*

"Here I am," Mydei mused, trying to sound playful, "once again asking so much of you, but if anyone can accomplish this mountainous task, it is the Deliverer of Amphoreus."

Phainon's scoff came out awkward, trying for a chuckle, but ending up as a broken whine. His wings drooped to lay flat across the deck, too heavy, too burdened to hold. "Mydei, I told you not to call me that…"

"And I remember pinning you to a rocky beach and accepting your surrender. I told you then, you do not get to choose what we call you, *Deliverer."*

"I should fight you again," Phainon huffed, "to take that right back."

"You would lose, but even if the heavens fell and you secured a pretty victory against me, I would never obey your winning demand," he confessed, "because it is the truth." Mydei's thumb brushed under Phainon's eye, gently rubbing a small circle there. "Not for Okhema, but for this ship, for *me*. You delivered us to a life we could have never known without you, and now we sail to stop the Black Tide, to save all people. Is that not the calling of a Deliverer?"

"You make it sound as though I alone am the hero here…" Phainon mumbled, still doubting.

"Every good hero in every epic has his companions, Phainon of the Chryseus Leo. It does not make him any less of a hero himself."

Those pretty lips parted to argue some more and Mydei silenced him with his own. They pressed together, gently, sweetly and without demand, only a gentle invitation to share their burdens, and Phainon accepted it without hesitation.

They were lost in that moment, coming down from the height of emotional acceptance when the cacophony came over the forecastle deck. Phainon's wings closed tightly behind him and Mydei's ears flattened. He turned to glare at the offenders, but the new arrivals were completely unbothered.

“I don’t *care* if we’ve had favorable winds the entire way,” Hephaestion was arguing, “it is not physically possible.” The first mate was leading the small group, head on a swivel until he spotted the captain and then he was picking up the pace, walking straighter than he ever had in his life.

“You asked me to chart the stars as we sailed, Lord Hephaestion!” Hyacine argued. She was using her doctor’s voice, the one that said, ‘you will listen to me and that’s final’ while her eye of twilight darted about in its socket. “I have been watching them every waking moment and I am telling you, we are *already here*.”

“Hyacinthia,” Anaxa started to say but was promptly interrupted when she spun on him.

“I *am* the sky, Professor! I assure you; I am not reading the stars improperly!”

Neither the professor nor Krateros behind him knew how to react to her brazen behavior. Frankly, Mydei didn’t either. He had never seen the young healer raise her voice. Something about it felt *wrong* somehow and it left a heavy pit in his stomach. Her agitation was flooding them all with urgency.

“Mydeimos!” Hephaestion called, “will you *please* speak sense to her?”

Mydei crossed his arms. “Lady Hyacine?”

“I am not crazy, Lord Mydei,” she insisted. That eye of hers was extremely distracting. He was trying so hard not to stare at it. “I studied the star charts above Hyperborea, even taking into account how they may have changed over the course of one thousand years! We should already be there!”

Hephaestion sighed and slapped her on the head with the rolled-up map in his hand, a Kremnoan gesture that she did *not* appreciate. She swatted at it, but he pulled it out of reach and unrolled it to show Mydei, pointing at the Northern Continent and the stretch of ocean between the library and the landmass.

“Perfect seas, perfect winds, and not a *single* sign of land. Hyperborea was built on the shore between the ocean and a steep mountain range that protected it from the North winds. Mountains like that can be seen from a ship *leagues* away,” Hephaestion pointed out, “we must have at *least* seven more Entry Hours.”

Mydei consulted the map and then looked over the top at where Hyacine was fuming. She had no reason to lie… but there had been no sign of land, and this journey *was* expected to take quite a long time.

“Krateros, is it *possible* that we have traveled at a speed that would put us at our destination ahead of schedule?” Mydei asked.

Krateros shuffled uncomfortably. “The winds have been more than favorable, captain,” he admitted, “truthfully, I had expected to see signs of land by now, the outer isles, if not the Northern Continent itself. The chill in the wind alone is proof that we have crossed into colder waters.”

Phainon walked past Mydei and climbed up onto the railing, standing at the bowsprit and holding onto a line for balance as though he would be able to see something that no one else had caught. His fluttering wings showered them with downy feathers as they adjusted for the breeze.

“Lady Tribbie surely has given us the Blessing of Passages,” Hyacine insisted, “she has hastened our journey.”

“Be that as it may,” Anaxa snapped, still irritated at having been interrupted before, “we would have *seen* more than just a *rock.”*

Mydei’s eyes snapped up. “A *rock?”*

“It was nothing, Mydeimos,” Hephaestion insisted, “It looked like an isolated boulder, a few white caps where the waves were breaking, a sandbar at best. We gave it a wide berth at the start of the Entry Hour while you were making breakfast.”

Phainon dropped back down and leaned over Mydei’s shoulder to look at the map again. “We need to turn around.”

“*Phainon*, there is nothing there!” Hephaestion insisted.

He pointed on the map to the southern edge of the Northern Continent where the mountain range had been marked. Just as Hephaestion said, there was the city, nestled in the shadow of the tallest peak.

“The Imperator said Hysilens would go home, right? To the place that she shared with the woman she loved,” Phainon reminded them.

“To Hyperborea,” Mydei confirmed.

“The ocean around Hyperborea,” Anaxa corrected. He had poured over Mydei’s notes, he surely had them printed on the back of his eyelids by now.

“Why not both?” Phainon asked.

Hephaestion shook his head. “Phainon that’s-”

“Turn the ship around,” Mydei ordered, “your rock, Hephaestion, isn’t guarding a sandbar.”

Phainon patted the first mate on the shoulder and said, “It’s the top of a mountain.”

Chapter 48: Altered Horizons

Chapter Summary

Hyacine has a plan, but Mydei worries they may have rushed into this a little too fast

Chapter Notes

With the holidays breathing down my neck and the new FFXIV patch coming out soon these chapters are gonna slow down a bit. I really, really want to finish this by Christmas but unfortunately a fic for fun is a little low on the priority list. I hope you guys can forgive me ;w;

Phainon wanted to believe that the moment of revelation would be enough to force the lid back down on the void that held all his emotions, but even as Krateros and Hephaestion turned and hurried to bark orders to the crew, to mobilize, feathers still fluttered in the cold wind. His wings still hung from his shoulders and when Mydei stopped on the stairs and looked back at where Phainon had been left alone, it was written on his face. Phainon could see in those amber eyes the worry of someone who could peer right through him.

He needed to *move*, needed to get to his gear. Hysilens would surely know that they were there, and it would take little more than a firm slap from a kraken arm to send the crew to a watery grave.

An emotional exhaustion was settling on his insides, leaving him feeling scrubbed, raw, and exposed. The relief that Mydei had given him had helped but with no time to let those feelings rest… it was just a lot, and he could feel his body wanting to shut down to escape it.

“Deliverer?” Mydei called and Phainon gave him a reassuring wave.

“I’m fine, Mydeimos. I’ll be along.”

It still took Mydei a long minute to move. The captain kept looking between Phainon and up the stairs towards where the others were scrambling in an organized chaos. When he finally went on ahead it was with a trusting look, not soft, not pitying, but with a hardness in the way his brow was set, as though ready to hurl a challenge.

Don’t keep me waiting for long, it said.

Phainon took a breath when he was alone and stepped back to lean against the great lion. His wings were pressed against that stone mane, and he leaned on the noble muzzle for support.

It wasn't a lie when he told Mydei that he was afraid. He wished he could say that this was the fear of the fight, something easy like a child afraid of monsters, the kind of fear that could be overcome with a parent's reassurances and a toy sword. No, this was the fear that had haunted him forever, the fear that had defined Phainon into what he was now. The fear that he hated so completely that he had come to hate himself.

He was afraid of failing, of disappointing the people he loved, of not being enough.

It was the same fear that crushed him when he read the warrant for his arrest. The same fear that drove him to rage against the inside of a Dawncloud cell. The same fear that was born when a young man buried his village in ash with a broken shovel. That terror that warped and twisted and ate at itself with violence until it could no longer be accepted, only buried under something stronger.

Hatred and vengeance burned hotter than fear.

I forgive you, Phainon.

He tried to say the words in his head with his *own* voice, but it was Mydei's pleasant growl that he heard instead.

I forgive you, he tried to say out loud, but the words were stuck in his chest.

He angrily slammed his fist against the lion's muzzle, realized what he did, and then hurried to soothe the silent stone.

"I'm sorry," he mumbled, "I just didn't think this would be so hard."

Phainon sighed and leaned forward to rest his forehead on the statue, listening to the way the breeze whistled and breathed around the lion's carved ears and open maw. Mydei gave him the first step, ending the Black Tide would be the second. His forgiveness would just have to hinge on their success, on his vengeance fulfilled.

The bubble of hate overtook the lingering fear and Phainon steeled himself again. His feathers melted away, and he found that easy smile once more. This was the fight he had been waiting for after all! There was no time to waste on trivial things.

Phainon admired his Kremnoan crewmates for a lot of reasons, not the least of which was their ability to mobilize immediately on command. Even when the crew were relaxing, making food, even *sleeping,* a part of them were always on alert and ready to spring into battle ready positions.

The crew's scrambles were chaos to an untrained eye and precise execution to anyone else. In just the time that Phainon had paused to gather himself, the crew had turned the ship around, furled half the sails, were donning their gear, and the armory was opened. They had been in

enemy territory since the first Descent Hour after they left the library, but it was very different realizing they had sailed over the enemy's stronghold entirely.

Phainon passed Mydei in their room. The captain was dressing comfortably, wearing his regal and familiar red and black. He pulled the strap tight on his gauntlets with his teeth and then beckoned for Phainon with the bend of a golden claw.

"Are you well?" Mydei asked when Phainon stepped close enough to grab. Mydei's grip was light above his elbow.

"I will be," Phainon promised.

"Good, I need you to watch my back." Mydei leaned forward to kiss Phainon's cheek, holding him still with a hand against the side of his neck. His hair tickled Phainon's nose, making him squirm, but Mydei held tight until he was satisfied.

"The war council will be on the top deck, when you are dressed."

"Aye, captain."

Mydei gave him one more longing look and then let him go to leave.

Phainon's gear was technically dry. It was a good thing he had gotten up early to do his laundry. There were creases that felt cold but not wet, teetering on the edge of dry and damp, enough to eat up precious time while Phainon debated uselessly if he should wear something else. As though he *had* something else to wear to the battle of the millennium.

By the time Phainon had changed and left his room, the crew had prepared enough to let the initial confusion bubble back up over the urgency of following orders. They wanted to know why they were mobilizing.

Phainon saw Leonnius waiting by the rail. He caught Phainon's gaze and fell into step beside him.

"What's going on?" the runner asked urgently.

"Did Hephaestion not tell you?"

"Only that the enemy may be upon us soon."

"We still don't know how," Phainon told him, "but we're already at Hyperborea."
Leonnius tilted his head, puzzled.

"It's underwater."

"*Nikador's taint,*" Leonnius mumbled in Kremnoan before swapping back to Okheman, "how are we supposed to get there?"

Phainon stopped at the bottom of the stairs to the top deck. "That's something we're going to have to figure out," he grumbled, "once we have a plan I'll let you know."

“Of course.” Leonnius still looked worried, but he stepped back and let Phainon go to meet with the others.

Mydei had pulled together anyone that might be able to help solve their current, unexpected dilemma, so the usual suspects were there. Hephaestion, Ptolemy, and the Demigods were all discussing the situation around the navigation table. A couple of very old maps were carefully stretched open by heavy, rectangular brass rods at the curling edges.

“The mountain is the only place where anchoring would be possible,” Hephaestion was explaining.

“Are we sure it’s wise to anchor?” Ptolemy asked, “we may need to strategically retreat… Does *no one* else think it strange that the Black Tide has not tried to attack us?”

“Give praise to Nikador that it has not,” the first mate grumbled.

“There are no records of the Black Tide attacking with aquatic or amphibious monsters,” Professor Anaxa reasoned, “though lack of recent records does not definitively prove that they do not exist at all. She could be alone and simply have chosen not to reveal herself.”

“She doesn’t have to, so long as she is underwater, none of us can get to her,” Mydei grumbled.

“Are the talismans waterproof?” Hephaestion asked.

“You think we’re going to *swim* there?” Ptolemy huffed.

The first mate was already at the end of his patience, a rarity for Hephaestion. “*In case someone is knocked overboard,”* he all but hissed.

“My charms are waterproof, but swimming was never an option. The weight of the ocean would crush anyone who ventured too deep,” Anaxa reminded them, completely glossing over the *breathing* problem. His arms were half crossed, one hand cradling the opposite elbow while the other rolled a pair of crystal shards around in his palm. The sound was mildly annoying, but Phainon recognized his old teacher’s fidgeting quirks from his university days. If it helped the genius think, then he wasn’t going to complain.

“Professor, everyone, I may have a solution,” Hyacine offered, “I cannot raise Hyperborea from the depths, but I believe I can lower the sky.”

The table was quiet as everyone looked at her. Phainon hadn’t even *considered* that as a possibility but as the Eye of Twilight…

“If I lower the horizon,” she continued when no one answered her, “it will be as though the continent never sank. I can do it in a pocket, here.” Hyacine leaned forward and drew a circle on the map with the pencil, big enough to uncover the entire city, the mountain behind it, and a sizeable part of the bay.

“Hyacine, that’s amazing.” Phainon finally broke the frozen shock around the table. The realization that their options were not as limited as they had been in prior campaigns opened

whole new doors.

“Amazing and potentially very reckless,” Professor Anaxa huffed. He had his head tilted to the side, eye closed, holding still like he was listening very intently to his own thought processes.

“Wouldn’t that displace a massive amount of water?” Ptolemy asked.

“’A massive amount of water’ is relative,” Anaxa explained, “if we were filling a fish tank, then yes, but compared to the ocean as a whole, no. The *force* of the displacement is more dangerous than the change in water level.” He tightened his fist and the little stones in his hand ground together and then stilled. “Hyacinthia, I will work together with you to ensure the execution of your plan doesn’t create any unexpected natural disasters.”

“I would appreciate that, Professor,” she accepted with a smile, “the change will not be permanent. I will need to hold the pocket to keep the ocean from rushing back in.”

“How long can you give us?” Mydei asked.

“I don’t know, I haven’t tried this before,” she admitted, “several hours?”

If Hyacine got them down there before Action Hour… that would give them until sundown. Phainon rested his hand on the table and leaned over the map, trying to judge how much ground they had to cover. Too much.

“If something happens to her while she’s holding the air-” Hephaestion started.

“I will protect Lady Hyacine,” Castorice offered. She raised her hand politely and then stepped in close to wrap her arm around Hyacine’s. The two of them locked together at the elbows smiling broadly at each other. “Pollux and I will keep her safe while she holds the sky.”

“There’s too much of the city to search,” Phainon observed, “and with the song…”

Mydei uncrossed his arms and leaned over the map. “Only the Deliverer and I will go looking for the siren.”

“Are you sure?” Hephaestion asked.

“We will be able to cover more ground in our titan forms.”

“And you won’t have to be as cautious with your powers,” Ptolemy pointed out, “’For a god is not easily caught – not by a mortal man.’ We will only be in your way.”

“And I need the men here,” Mydei instructed, pointing at the docks. “We have not seen aquatic Tide monsters because we have never fought beneath the ocean, but we would be fools to not consider the possibility that there is an army waiting between us and the Demigod.”

Even if there wasn't, another line of defense between Hyacine and Hysilens would go a long way. Hyacine was creating the best opportunity for them but would also become their greatest weak spot.

"Give us a quint to make calculations," Anaxa requested.

"That gives us time to brief the crew," Hephaestion agreed.

"Gather the unit leaders," Mydei ordered. He leaned over the map and marked a spot with the pencil. "This is where we need the ship to be. We will need men on the oars, treading water until we are able to drop anchor."

"I'll take care of that positioning, captain," the first mate confirmed, "professor, will you check my math when I have it."

"Of course."

"There will be no time for goodbyes," Mydei said firmly, "the siren may rise from the depths at any moment."

The group scattered to do their tasks without waiting for a formal dismissal. Mydei was right, they didn't have the time to waste.

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Mydei had lived his whole life preparing for combat, moving from one fight to the next. Sometimes that fight was a playful bout with Hephaestion, training with Krateros, or tug of war with Fig Stew. They included exchanges with the Okheman Navy, surprise attacks from the Black Tide, and scripted piracy when raiding for supplies.

This was different. Everything about this felt different.

Standing at the bow of the Chryseus Leo beside Phainon, watching Hyacine raise her hands was not something Mydei could have ever prepared for. It took a single gesture to instantly rip open the clouds to flood the world with golden sunlight and infinite, clear sky. They shared golden blood but watching this tiny woman with wild eyes command such power made him feel entirely outclassed.

One quint. It had taken one quint for Anaxa and Hyacine to determine the best way to perform a miracle. One quint to reshape the surface of Amphoreus. One quint to gather his best friends, tell them the plan, hand out the improved talismans, and get the men in position. The water splashed against the hull as the crew rowed, twisting the Chryseus Leo in a slow circle to keep her from drifting too far on the ocean waves.
This felt like too big of a fight, too high of stakes, to leave to the chaos of unknown variables, of a half-formed plan, crutching on their divinities as the easy answer to all things. As though they weren't about to fight another Demigod, a creature of power and age and wisdom, who had a thousand years to perfect her lethality.

How long did they really have for this operation? Was the city even still intact? Could they be wrong and Hysilens was not here at all, leaving behind instead an army to intercept any trespassers?

What the hell were they thinking?

A hand grabbed his and Mydei blinked away his unease to turn his head to Phainon. He was smiling like this was just another day, as though they hadn't spilled their hearts to each other within the Hour… as though his shining eyes weren't still rimmed pink at the corners with old tears.

A gentle squeeze, reassuring, loving, and Mydei felt the courage inside him surge. He felt invincible. *This was possible!* They could save the world!

And then the weight slammed down on them, and they were ripped apart.

It punched the air from Mydei's lungs and drove Phainon to his knees. Mydei followed a second after as his knees buckled, nearly breaking as they fought to keep upright before the deck rose to meet him. He could see Phainon struggling to breathe, his cheek pressed against the wood, just as his was. The world around them warped and tore. Beneath them the ship creaked and cracked, groaning with strain. The lines were popping, beginning to tear under the pressure.

Instinct told him to fight but Phainon's hand found him again, looping his pinky around Mydei's forefinger. He was still smiling, a little wobbly now, unsure, but trusting and comforting all the same.

Against the will of Strife in his heart, Mydei forced himself to relax as the weight of the Sky settled on the ship, on their shoulders. Every breath felt like choking, every tiny movement was pushing a mountain, he couldn't hear anything now except the roar of the ocean as it rose in the corner of his eye.

A wall of water was slowly rising in the near distance. He could see the edge of it above the railing, too far away to feel the ocean spray that misted from the falling water, but close enough to filter the sunlight to create swaying patterns across their faces. They sank deeper and the weight of the world remained, until there was no longer a blue and cloudless sky, but a dark and imposing ocean, full of ink and song.

Phainon's one-fingered grip loosened. The man's eyes were rolling back as he struggled to breathe. Mydei tried to call to him, but his voice was buried in the roar, and it left him in a similar state of suffocation.

The black was creeping into his vision, and he thought perhaps they would perish before the battle began, but then salty, cool air flooded his lungs, the pressure abated, and the churn of the sea settled into the distant roar of waterfalls with a sudden lurch. The natural sway of the ship stopped, leaving behind an eerie stillness.

Mydei took a couple of test breaths. It was cold down here at the bottom of the ocean but as he slowly put his palms flat on the deck to push himself up, the air started to feel… normal.

Beside him Phainon did the same, pushing himself up on steady arms while he took deep full breaths through his nose and mouth. They looked at each other and slowly smiled with shared relief.

The moment was short-lived, coming to an end when Hyacine shrieked and dropped to the deck. She was covering her eyes with both hands, shoulders shaking.

“Hyacine!” Phainon called and he was up in a flash, hurrying towards her.

Castorice cut him off, wobbling on her own two feet. “Please, Lord Phainon, you haven’t the time for sympathy.”

She was right. Mydei could see from where he was stumbling to stand that their time may be shorter than anticipated. Gold blood was trickling over Hyacine’s fingers where they covered her face. Holding back the weight of the water like this was far more taxing than they anticipated and his worry for her grew to include the rest of the crew.

“We will care for her,” Anaxa insisted. He was physically pushing them away while Castorice gently placed a lavender cloak over the Sky Demigod’s shoulders.

“Deliverer,” Mydei snapped as he turned, and Phainon reluctantly and stiffly followed.

The ship had caught on the ocean floor, as they fell to meet it. Hyacine had pushed the sky lower than intended and the Leo’s belly was resting gently in the silt that settled below the harbor. A quick look over the side confirmed it.

The water they rested in was as black as the heart of an evil man, but Mydei could tell from where it rose against the hull that they were resting in no more than a puddle, less than knee deep. The beach beyond looked like low tide during a drought, exposed, while the waiting docks of the marina reached into the open air, too far away to be of use.

“*Damn,”* Phainon whispered beside him. The rest of the crew had abandoned oars to hurry to the deck to join them with weapons ready. Mydei caught Leonnius and Peucesta out of the corner of his eye slamming into the rail at his side to stare at the marvel before them.

Hyperborea would have been an incredible sight *without* the wall of water. Hyacine had carved for them a miracle: a cylindrical air bubble exactly as she had said, leaving the ocean to frame the bay, the city, and the mountain. Seawater trickled down the sheer peak face in streams and the ocean churned against the invisible walls that Hyacine had erected. Loose spray fell from them as escaped mist, scattering the sunlight above into cascades of color.

The ruins of the capital city were a whalefall, white and gleaming where the reef had yet to claim it. Silver moss and dead coral clung tightly to the stone but there were no fish, no crabs, nor creeping things. It was a tomb. A tomb that did not take kindly to the air that sapped away the comforting weight of a crushing ocean.

In the depths of the city a familiar mass churned and boiled, slimy and amorphic. Black as a night that swallowed the moon and stars, and resonating with the distant sounds of a

mournful song. It bubbled taller than the palace spires and slowly started to spread. Long tentacles reached from its core as it pulled itself over the buildings and towards the shore.

“Looks like you’ll need us after all,” Leonnius huffed to Mydei. The runner pointed with his chin, a sharp nod at the beach where monsters gathered. They were different than the Black Tide monsters they had seen before.
“The books never said what happened to the other sirens,” Phainon mumbled at Mydei’s side.

These creatures were fish on better days, but little was left of them but a rotting core and long, flowing fins. They were gray and sickly colored, pale at the joints and dark around reddened faceless flesh. Many of them had tears in their fins and all of them featured shimmering sharp horns.

They hovered over the sand, agitated but not hindered by the air. Like a nocturnal animal forced to scavenge in the daylight for food, they were irritable but not helpless.

For a moment both sides studied each other, trying to decide what to make of the other, trying to determine what the heck happened to create this impossible staging ground. And then the creatures shrieked and even Mydei hurried to cover his ears from that horrible sound. The war cry rallied the monsters, and they flowed towards the ship like serpents, fast and fluid, spilling over each other in a frenzy.

Krateros moved first. He was already shouting orders, calling Peucesta who relayed the commands by horn as the old vet moved down the line, tapping the helmet of each crewmate in turn before they jumped over the railing to land in the soft silt. Their talismans glowed faintly as the Tide called to them from the water, but they held and the corruption was stayed.

Rope ladders clattered down the side of the ship. Weapons splashed as spears and shields were thrown to the men that were forming the first line. They moved with deliberate, practiced haste.

Mydei counted them as they leaped, searching for the friends he didn’t have time to say goodbye to, but two of them were already missing and the battle had barely begun.

“Mydeimos,” Krateros called when he got to the prince. The old man grabbed Mydei by the forearm and Mydei returned it, holding tightly and leaning in to better hear. “These creatures are beneath you, leave them.”

“Hephaestion and Perdikkas?” Mydei questioned with a tilt of his head.

“Will complain over the victory feast that they were late to this most legendary battle,” Krateros said, “May victory be yours, Mydeimos.”

He let go and gave Mydei a firm shove before moving on to Phainon. The old man opened his mouth to speak, shook his head, and instead pulled Phainon forward by the coat to slam their foreheads together. He held it for a second and then shoved the Deliverer away before moving on to the next man.

Mydei smiled and snorted at Phainon's bewilderment. Even a hasty and awkward Kremnoan farewell counted for something.

A roar brought them back to the present. The air vibrated with it, a melodic sound that should not have come from such an ugly mass. It shook the mountain, the city, and made waves at their feet, nearly breaking the Kremnoan line as the first of the fish monsters threw themselves with reckless abandon on the line of shields and spears where they burst into pointed shrapnel.

The distant kraken wrapped an arm around a building and wrenched it free with a thunderous crack. It crumbled as it was thrown, a launched barrage of scattered, inconsistent projectiles.

Mydei and Phainon moved in sync, leaping from the ship to take flight. The crack of the Lance of Fury shattered the largest fragments into gravel rain and a swipe of Phainon's sword burst the rest into harmless dust. They were radiance and fury, power and pride incarnate hovering over the ship and their family at war.

The Black Tide was unimpressed.

The kraken reached for another monument to weaponize, but Mydei and Phainon had already had enough of that game. Phainon dashed ahead, blazing like the Ascent Hour sun, sword swept back beside the tail of his robes and his wings spread wide.

Mydei looked down where the Kremnoans were surging forward against a swarm, drastically outnumbered, knee deep in sludge, fighting their way up the shore. He remembered then what Marcus had said, about men and women trapped in bodies with hijacked wills. It would be so *easy* to trample these tiny things under foot, to save them and his crew.

The lance in his hand was heavy, the claws on his paws long and flashing with every flex, but then he saw the flash of Krateros' sword, heard Hyacine's pained shout, and remembered what it meant to trust, to never have to fight alone again.

Light flashed deep in the city. Phainon was dashing around the kraken, leaving long and oozing cuts. A tentacle chased him, another swiped. Gold wings flashed and one of the tentacles was severed. The beast screamed and the limb slowly melted into a runny goo.

It was bigger than last time. Even from this far away Mydei could tell that this was not the same kraken that had tormented him at Castrum Kremnos. That beast had been a shadow of this one, a puppet on a string far from home with waning power.

Mydei's tail swished as he hefted the lance over his shoulder and extended his arm, aiming the massive bolt. He fought this thing for a month, this beast that did the siren's bidding, a monster of the deep that she had created with her longing. And it had made a mockery of him.

Never again.

The Lance of Fury was lightning and when it pierced between the kraken's tiny eyes with a flash of crackling red light, thunder echoed off the mountain and bounced off the walls.

Crystal erupted from its body, ripping it nearly in half. It writhed and melted as though dying but as Mydei flew to Phainon's side it was already bubbling again, reforming.

"How amusing," Mydei huffed, "is this to be a battle of immortals then?"

"Mydeimos, are you asking me to leave this to you?" Phainon asked, deep and annoyed. There was a wild flash in his eyes akin to offense and Mydei was almost angry that those words even crossed the man's mind.

"How do you expect me to put an end to this creature without my other half by my side?" Crystal shards formed slowly from red glitter in the air, reforming another lance. Mydei snatched it as it finished and held it at his side with the point angled down and the shaft resting along his forearm.

"Your other half?" Phainon teased with a soft chuckle. The light lilt in his voice was back. Whatever had made Phainon quick to anger had hopefully passed. "Is this really the best time for romance?"

"HKS, perhaps I do not need you after all!"

"No, no, Mydei, I would be honored to share this victory with you."

"Yes, you will be," he agreed with a happy growl. Mydei's tattoos rippled with light as crystalline dust swirled around him again. Phainon's halo and wings shimmered, a faint glow matching the bright yellow of his eyes. Their red and gold was taunting, baiting, and those beady eyes shook with rage.

The kraken screeched as it reformed and wriggled after them, reaching as they darted through the air in opposite directions. Agile dashes brought them close to swipe at oily flesh, but every wound was repaired and Mydei felt the futility in their actions. It reminded him too much of a month of listening to the Tide song, of dying to this creature again and again.

The fear of failure bloomed in his belly like a wound that would not heal. He could hear matching frustration in every one of Phainon's shouts as they collected severed limbs to no avail. The burning of his Coreflame's power filled him with exhilaration and adrenaline and the joy of combat but it was sour in his mouth when he thought of his friends and family fighting on the beach. Every sound of Peucesta's distant horn was a reminder that they were the only thing between this beast and the end of their world.

Phainon brushed past him, flying under Mydei's paws as he was pursued by a reaching tentacle. Mydei dodged to the side and swiped his lance along its side, intercepting it moments before the ink could envelop Phainon. The rubbery flesh burst in a spray of black that peppered across them. Droplets landed on Mydei's lips, and he raised a hand to wipe them away, tasting the bitter salt of seawater as he did.

The Worldbearer was beyond words now. Mydei could hear it in Phainon's guttural growl, in the reckless way he swung his sword. It was on his face as he bore his teeth in a twisted grin speckled in the same black that dripped down his cheeks. Phainon had stopped caring about

dodging and Mydei was spending more time watching his boyfriend's back and staying out of the way than fighting the monster.

Their synergy was waning. He was dancing a waltz with a man that was trying to step on his toes. The flow that he had come to love standing side by side with Phainon was stilted, jarring, and awkward, until the fight stopped feeling like dance and warped instead into disjointed snapshots.

Maybe Phainon *should* have left this fight to Mydei… or maybe he shouldn't have come at all. The longer they fought the more Mydei could see and *feel* it: the sour and corrupting rage of revenge. But who was Mydei to deny a man his chance at vengeance, when Mydei had personally exacted his own revenge on the man that killed his mother.

Oh. He left the ring in his pocket…

A tentacle came flying out of Mydei's blind spot and he was thrown down into the city, barreling through walls as his wings spun to protect him from the worst of the impact. His body skipped across a city square before sliding across sharp coral to stop against a crumbling wall. Debris rained on him, leaving him feeling more annoyed than pained.

Gold spread across his fur and ran over his armor in rivulets, Mydei's vision was blurry, but he could see the shine of it when he tried to move. He hit his head when he fell and there was a worrisome warmth spilling over his cheek. Paws kicked aimlessly, stretching, testing his limbs and finding them sore. Nothing felt broken, but when Mydei tried to stand again, his knees buckled and the world spun. He leaned heavily on his lance and took a couple deep breaths.

He could hear Phainon fighting still and wondered if the man had even noticed Mydei go down with his tunnel-vision as narrow as it seemed to be. That fear of failure that had made a home in Mydei's belly started to grow, wrapping around his throat like vines.

This fight was different.

He knew the moment they committed to the plan and the truth of it pumped through his veins even now. This was the battle that would determine the fate of the world, but more than that, it was the monster under the bed. This was the creature that killed Phainon's parents, the one that corrupted Eurypon, the one that took their homes from them.

…and the one that was taking Mydei's partner from him before his very eyes.

Mydei forced himself to take a step forward, shook his head to clear the blood from his brow, and then the weight of a tidal wave slammed down on him again. He clawed and fought at the tentacle that wrapped around him, dragging him back across the cracked and broken ground. The Lance was pinned to his side, crystal erupted from his body, but the kraken would not let him go.

Gold flashed in the corner of his eye where Phainon was still fighting, oblivious.

That wild, crazed, *gleeful* look on Phainon's face faltered when he finally noticed Mydei in the monster's clutches. Realization spread across his features and then the beak slammed closed, and Mydei was surrounded by darkness.

Perhaps he should have been more concerned about having been consumed by a monster of the deep. A dark part of him chuckled that finally, after all these years, something in the water finally got him. But as water filled his lungs, and blackness stole his vision, the thing Mydei noticed the most was the quiet.

Chapter 49: The Worldbearer Eclipsed

Chapter Summary

No new CW, please note the ones that are already there. There's some graphic imagery in this chapter.

Phainon and Mydei fight the Black Tide Kraken.

Chapter Notes

I am deeply, deeply sorry this chapter was so delayed. The Ao3 curse came for me in a good way and I found out last December that I am pregnant! It's something I've wanted for a long time so I'm very excited but, unfortunately, that came at the cost of my physical ability to write the way I'm used to. I've spent the last few months resting and sort of retraining myself to write differently but just as effectively while also honing my craft, learning new punctuation, and just growing as a writer overall with the help of the Fanfic Writer's Group on Discord. I'm even hoping to clean this fic up and improve on earlier chapters as well! Some chapters have already been edited for grammar and I'm working on expanding some earlier scenes to make the story that much more seamless!

If you are also a hobby writer and seeking ways to improve, get feedback, offer feedback, and grow in a critical but friendly environment, I can't recommend this group enough: Link
It is because of them and their support that this story can continue at a quality worthy of my wonderful readers!
(Please be advised this is a multi-fandom, multi-ship, 18+ only environment for collaborative writers looking to workshop. If you are particularly sensitive to some themes/ships/etc, please take into account your own comfort before joining!)

I'm genuinely so excited to share the rest of this story with you all, even if it's just going to take a little longer between updates while I go through this relearning process!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Every time the kraken screamed, Phainon let the shiver of satisfaction gild the raw hatred that burned in his soul. It was the only other thing he let himself feel as he tore at the gelatinous mass with his sword and wings. Every haunting memory, every buried emotion from before this singular moment was an afterthought, waiting for the wildfire to run its course to be heard once more.

He didn't want to feel those things. Phainon didn't want the weight of grief, he didn't *want* that fear, that desperation, that loss… hatred burned brighter than all of it.

Laid upon the pyre one by one, those feelings cracked and melted until his blood was boiling and his bones were smelting into steel. The biting cold of the ocean floor was little more than morning frost cowering in the sunlight of his ardor. And he eagerly fed the flame with wild glee.

Phainon was a predator turned loose upon his captor, a monster unleashed and adorned with broken chains – wholly divine. The coreflame in his chest burned with such immense radiance it filled Phainon to the brim with invincible confidence. So, when the kraken screamed and its limbs burst to pelt its inky blood across his face, Phainon *bathed* in it as an offering from a lesser being.

How dare this creature look upon his glory? How *dare* it consider itself on equal footing with his godhood? His was the power to command the heavens! To cradle the world with the sole responsibility of seeing it thrive, or should he decide, to see it ended with little more than a whimsical thought.

Such was Phainon's elation as he laughed and basked in combat with this creature of the deep; as he teased and tortured the monster of his nightmares. He ripped off its limbs and left lacerations in its sides for every time the Tide had made him feel *weak*. When it howled in pain and rage he danced in place and drank in the sounds as sweet music; a symphony of agony that was finally giving voice to the void that had hidden inside his heart to rot since the fall of Aedes Elysiae.

That joy danced with his hatred, intrinsically intertwined with perfect rhythm, in perfect time with every cry, screech, and laugh. Until a flash of red at the corner of Phainon's eye gave him pause and left those twirling emotions knotted in a mess of misplaced steps and broken toes.

A recent, already frayed memory of thunder at the edge of his awareness, pleaded with Phainon to remember that his cacophonous solo of eager destruction was supposed to be a duet. There was a voice in the wind, drowned out by the crack of boiling marrow in burning bones. A wild and worried face at Phainon's back was barely clinging to his recent recollection, all but obscured by smoke.

The harmony dutifully trying to be heard under Phainon's roaring, suffocating melody was tossed aside in a spray of ocean crashing upon a rocky shore and flash of red and gold.

Phainon spun in the air as the kraken ceased its pursuit of him, turning instead to the one who was left behind in this deadly refrain. It splashed and crashed its way to where Strife struggled to free himself from the dust and rubble.

And when Phainon could finally see beyond himself again, the Inheritor of Strife was already trapped and thrashing in the tight seal of the monster's grip. The length of the limb was wrapped so tightly around the divine body that he could not get free, even with all the strength of a god.

And before Phainon's eyes, that noble creature, his only companion in this struggle at the end of the world, was gone. The kraken's beak slammed closed and the warmth of Strife's presence vanished with a *crunch,* dragging with it what remained of Phainon's restraint.

The terror and loss that he had laid upon the fire stirred in the coals. Phainon's breaths were labored, choking gasps. His lungs were struggling to keep up and tears flowed freely, already falling in anticipation of his realization.

All this power was *not enough*.

He was alone again.

And it was all his fault.

"Why did you…?" he breathed, the words ripping from his throat in a rasp. *Not again.*

The kraken beneath him was squirming, rippling happily, *celebrating*.

Why did you take them all away from me? The thought played In Phainon's head on a loop, screaming from the ashes of his burning heart with accusation in every syllable.

He was trembling in the sky, barely aloft as though on thin strings.

Hatred burned hotter than guilt.

The strings snapped.

The air around Phainon warped with the heat. His tears evaporated, leaving behind dried tracks that stretched and cracked when he curled his lip back and shook with unbridled rage. The destructive power of the sun burned inside him with reckless abandon.

The ocean that still dribbled down the mountainside in happy rivulets turned to steam to hang in the air leaving it heavy with a midsummer's humidity. Faceless statues perched on towers cracked and burst as the permeating cold was snatched away from them with brutality. Coral crumbled in the heatwave, seaweed turned as autumn leaves before simmering away into nothing, and grains of sand clung to each other until they could no longer be parted – turned to shining glass.

"Fine then," he growled, uncaring if the kraken could hear or understand him.

It shied away from his heat, from the fire that once burned within now burning without. One limb hurried to shield its eyes, two others pawed at its own flesh, pressing with purpose at its being. The rest reached desperately for the ruins, clinging to a past long lost to the ocean, and the secrets she kept. The kraken fought for distance even as it struggled against a swelling in its body.

At last, it understands what vengeance it has wrought, Phainon considered, however briefly, before the fire became too great. His own flesh was burning, a sickly smell of ash and rot.

The edges of his feathers were alight with the creeping red of a steady flame. They glowed with the orange of a sunset when he surged in pursuit of this embodiment of corruption. Every attempt to stave off his dive met searing winds and burning swipes of his blade, cleaving through every limb until the tip of his sword plunged deep between the kraken's eyes.

The flesh beneath his feet boiled as he clung to the blade, pressing it deeper between angry snarls until only the hilt remained unburied; until Phainon wondered if he might go deaf from the screeching cries; until Phainon was certain he could not be removed no matter how hard the beast threw itself against crumbling buildings.

Salty steam burned away his feathers and seared his skin but still Phainon held tightly.

This is the end. This was always going to be the end for you and me.

"Come then, monster of the deep," he crooned, low and angry. "Let us burn together."

The inside of the kraken greeted Mydei with violent turmoil and a cold shock that sent needles rippling down his body. An ache that stuck to his soul as the beak locked shut with a tooth-aching grind and the undertow dragged him deep into the monster's abyssal belly, thrashing and fighting the whole way.

Is this really happening?

He felt so small; tossed about like a doll in a hurricane. How long had it been since he last drowned?

What do I do? Mydei's own voice inside his head sounded so young.

The panic tightened around his heart as past memories collided with present panic.

I need to get out!

He desperately fought to reach above his head, searching for the surface as he was dragged through the dark and away from all sense of direction. Mydei's chest tightened around that final breath. Tears joined the salt of the sea. He closed his eyes tight to hide from the familiarity that sobbed in a toddler's voice.

Not again… please not again...

The maelstrom stilled then, leaving him adrift in nothingness, at the mercy of the frigidity of the Northern seas and his own instinctual panic. Freed from the undertow, he curled up tight and covered his mouth and nose with both hands. He was afraid to open his eyes. He was afraid of losing his breath even more.

I spent my childhood drowning.

The weight of the ocean was bearing down on him from all sides. His paws – spread wide in the water – scooped helplessly in the black, searching for an equilibrium that no longer seemed to exist. Mydei was keenly aware of the seizing in his muscles as crippling cold seeped deep, reaching for the marrow in his bones.

The nightmares still linger and there are times when I feel fear looking into the heart of the black ocean.

Every joint stiffened; there was burning in his lungs, bitterness on his tongue, and new wounds stung as they tore further at the seams. Every movement exaggerated, every desperate pull in slow motion as these precious few seconds stretched into a painful perception of infinity replete with remembered words and sorrows.

None of it compared to the terror consuming his insides.

I have embraced that part of me and learned how to let it go.

Was that another lie he had told Phainon? Images of him flashed behind Mydei's eyes at the thought.

Not this *Worldbearer* that Phainon had embraced, living only to rejoice in violence against the Tide. The creature that was now face to face with his demons had become a living sun, wrathfully burning and infinitely distant.

He considered instead the man from this morning: the Phainon that held such faith and love for him, who was patient, kind, and so very strong. Mydei remembered his Deliverer's lips on his own, of strong hands on his waist, his back, and his chest. For a moment he could imagine their warmth chasing away the biting cold.

It wasn't a lie when Mydei called Phainon his strength, his equal in everything.

He was fire and fury turned inwards, Mydeimos.

Phainon needed him. This could not be the end.

Mydei's final breath held tight. His lungs were remembering what it was like to make the most of every second, to recover quickly in the water, to maybe reach the surface this time. The moment trapped in eternity passed and less than a minute since Mydei was swallowed, he had been lost and found himself again.

With newfound resolve he slowly opened his eyes, squinting around the salty, icy bite. Every blink brought about more clarity in the dark as he searched for the absent horizon.

He had expected a proper belly and discovered only ocean, as open and seemingly endless as the sky. And perhaps no less beautiful. The dark that had been all-consuming when first he chanced a look was not so complete on a second inspection. There were stars in the water: glimmers that caught a dim and distant light and scattered it into every color.

The glow of his tattoos flashed as he reached for crystal and the stars reflected red, lighting the water enough to see the gold of his blood swirl and dilute around him before gently

drifting by on a gentle current. The brightness in the gloomy tomb overpowered what light already lived here, and it took another few blinks in the dark to see it again after his own brilliance faded. It was gentle and warm, reaching across the distance like sunbeams through layered silk.

A burn was nibbling at the edges of Mydei's lungs in solemn reminder of his looming demise, but the memory of a twice-made promise steeled his nerves. Even with his experience, there was no more time to waste on despair and even less to spend on further hesitation.

His paws scooped at the water as he swam, wings pressed tightly against his back to minimize the drag. The hint of warmth that drifted through the silence clung to the current to beckon Mydei upstream into warmer waters.

Aside from the occasional sway in the sea and the steadily increasing burn in his lungs, Mydei's swim was shockingly peaceful. The cold fled with every stroke, the bright flecks in the black still twinkled invitingly, and it was quiet.

The storybook spoke of voices projected over the water to reach beyond the reefs and shoals that surrounded rocky lairs. Mydei had thought for sure that this close to Hysilens the siren's song would have carried unfiltered from her own lips. But here in the black of the belly, he couldn't hear any melody at all. Not the alluring dirge of a grieving Demigod nor the screams and raucous percussion of war song.

The edges of his vision were starting to blur alongside the warning churn of that held breath as Mydei finally pushed closer to the light. These waters more akin to a tropical clime – warm like the comforting kindle of a heartbeat. That glow in the darkness was a horizon at sunset, the coals of a well-loved oven, filling the water with a pleasant tingle that reminded Mydei of a passionate, desperate kiss.

Filtered through a protective mesh of Tide fog was the source of the light: the heart of the monster. Gold as blood, the light seeped through gaps in the ink that swirled around the silhouette of a woman. She was curled like a troubled infant around the brightness of a coreflame, selfishly close, knees and elbows pulled in tight to her chest to keep out the world.

Mydei called to hand the Lance of Fury and with it tore at the inky membrane that kept her apart. The Tide retreated. The water stirred. Her hair, as long as she was tall, swirled around her as she tilted her chin to glare beyond him with narrow, pale eyes. They were darting back and forth in rapid twitches, focused on something outside his own senses. Her delicate fingers tipped with sharp claws clasped the Coreflame tightly, the sigil of Law bright and taunting at its core.

He treaded closer and when she still failed to notice him he reached for it.

Bubbles escaped Mydei's lips as his lungs seized, out of time, begging for breath, and urgency turned his surgical maneuver into a frantic scramble. The Coreflame flared brighter when his fingertips brushed its surface and then the siren came back to herself.

Claws dragged through the flesh of his arm and blood clouded the water between them. It tasted of iron and salt when he gasped, losing what was left of his air as water surged through his throat and chest. The ache of it spurred Mydei to reckless action, an instinct screaming at him to find another breath, and if he could not, to die quickly and spare himself further agony.

She had the advantage in the water, but the reach of Mydei's lance still cleaved through her flesh when he swiped in a broad arc. Her golden blood joined his to stream in elegant, glittering ribbons from their bodies that danced in the Coreflame's light.

Imperator Cerydra's heart, knocked free, waited between them. It didn't try to float away. It didn't sink. It simply waited to be reclaimed by whomever was bold enough, strong enough to reach out and take it.

For a moment they looked at each other – a furious, lonely siren, and a drowning lion, two gods recognizing each other's power in the dark. And then she screamed and the sound ripped through the water with such violence that Mydei scrambled to cover his ears. He felt the vibrations through the choking in his chest, in every nerve and reflex. It was paralyzing and exhilarating all at once and he thought, yes, this was a worthy first death, one that he would repay in kind soon, when he revived.

But before his soul could slip away, still begging for a breath, the ocean boiled.

Mydei wished he had perished sooner.

He thrashed in the sudden violence of the bubbling water. Every nerve was alight and all was white-hot pain. The wounds on Mydei's arm, his lungs full to bursting, nothing else mattered in the moment than this all-consuming torture. In his blurring vision he *watched* the skin on his hand and arm starting to scald before blinding sunlight and a surging torrent ripped him away from any remaining sense of reality. He was a leaf in a storm, a grain of sand in a whirlpool, utterly at the mercy of divine intervention that exceeded his own.

Mydei wrapped himself in crystal, fighting the pain of his bubbling skin and melting wings as the kraken evaporated at the feet of an immense and horrible power. Hot and dry air coursed over him and dimly he considered the good fortune of having found a chance to breathe. But that thought was shattered against the reef alongside his body as he fell unceremoniously into the broken city.

The eruption of the kraken was loud, brutal, and short. Its body ruptured with an explosive sound that rippled through the city's bones and could be seen racing up the surrounding ocean walls like a wave. For a moment the air shook and the tumultuous ocean around them quivered like it may collapse but Phainon found he didn't care. He could barely remember how he got to the ocean floor in the first place.

The steam seared his skin and wings. Pieces of him were crumbling into dust as the kraken's body ceased to be, leaving behind two bodies to crash into the earth below. Covered in pale

white steam it was impossible to tell which one was the siren and as Phainon considered his gentle descent the bright light of a Coreflame made the decision for him.

It glittered brightly. A bright coal in the ash of a once roaring flame, it bounced into the middle of the massive square and came to rest in the basin of a now dry fountain.

Phainon's divinity was spent for the time being when he touched lightly on the ground, fatigued for the first time since the fight began. Sweat dripped off his nose, and he had to lean on his sword like a cane for support while shaky legs found their footing and lungs found oxygen in the humidity. His wings were gone. They crumbled away as ash after delivering him to safety on uneven ground. The Coreflame still beat in his chest, but it was quieter, resting in a gentle smolder after returning him to humanity, healed and whole.

Once glorious tile crunched underfoot. He didn't care. The coreflame was a star in the dark and as surely as it reached for him, it would undoubtedly reach for that damned siren.

On either side, at opposing ends of the square, the dust was starting to settle where the core of the kraken had fallen. One of the falling bodies had ripped through a building, tearing off the façade in the process. The other had punched a hole in a thick curtain wall lining one side of the plaza.

Phainon's eyes darted between each smoking impact as he started stalking towards the coreflame. He let Dawnmaker drag across the ground at his side with a sparking, screeching grind. One of those shadows would surely lunge for his throat once she recovered.

Let her come.

But the moment that stole his breath wasn't the image of a raging siren come to reclaim a heart, it was part of his own, laying still on the stone in a mangled mess. Ice poured over Phainon in that moment. All else forgotten before he could reach his original destination.

The dust had settled, the steam dissipated, and all that was left behind was a very human Mydeimos, crumpled over a pile of shattered bricks to rest in part in a puddle of his own muddy blood. If not for his hair and clothes he may not have been recognizable at all as brutalized and twisted as his body was.

"Mydei?" Phainon mumbled in a pained whisper, rife with denial.

Mydei was going to get up.

He had to get up…

Why wasn't he moving? They promised each other he'd take his lives more seriously!

The other body stirred in the corner of Phainon's eye, struggling weakly behind a curtain of lingering haze to get to its feet but Phainon couldn't look away from Mydei.

He almost tripped in the first few stumbling steps in Mydei's direction over broken stone. The body was shiny and glittering. Blood was dripping from Mydei's fingertips. His legs were twisted and elevated against the crumpled wall he had landed on.

A little closer, still no movement. “Mydeimos? This isn’t funny anymore!”

Mydei was facing the sky, his shoulders and head on flat ground, and one arm trapped in debris and twisted unnaturally to reach for something beyond himself. The other lay across the same ground beneath Phainon’s feet. An earring gleamed in the gore.

A little more recognition and understanding. And so much more panic.

“*Mydei!*” The call echoed through the plaza, playing back the urgency – the fear – in a voice that Phainon didn’t recognize immediately as his own. It was a horrible rasp, a broken cry for a broken place. “No no nononono…”

Tears pricked the corner of his wide eyes as Phainon dropped Dawnmaker with a clatter that could wake the dead. The echo covered the sound of Phainon’s heavy footsteps as he hurried to Mydei’s side.

Exhaustion pleaded with Phainon to stop. The adrenaline was wearing away without that inner fire to fuel it, but he still reached for Mydei’s shoulders and took him under the arms to drag him from the rocks.

Mydei’s corpse was little more than a finely dressed amalgamation of lacerations and burns. The smell of cooked flesh made Phainon’s stomach turn and when he pulled his hands away from Mydei’s body and found sticky skin clinging to his trembling palms he had to turn away to collapse, sob, and retch over the crumbled debris.

Blood turned bronze by dust and sand spattered his sleeves and pants when Phainon wiped the sick from his mouth. Bitterness still stuck to his tongue when he crawled on hands and knees back to Mydei’s side to shakily reach for his love’s face. There was no life in those amber eyes. He wasn’t breathing. Neither of them were now.

This was so much worse than finding Mydei bruised and broken at Castrum Kremnos, and Phainon’s seizing heart tightened at the memory. Salt burned his cheeks as tears flowed freely to drip from his chin to fall on Mydei’s neck and chest. Already the body was repairing itself. New, clean skin was visibly spreading, hastened by the Coreflame of Strife. But Phainon had already seared this horror to memory.

“Come back to me,” he whispered in a raw voice while tracing the lines of Mydei’s cheek and jaw.

With reverent caution, Phainon reached for Mydei again to pull the body into his lap, to cradle Mydei’s head on his arm like a babe while the flesh knit back together. His bones crunched as they realigned and Phainon winced at the sound and held him tighter.

He wanted to mumble words of encouragement, to ease Mydei’s return, but Phainon was still quivering. There was a knot in his throat and an emotional exhaustion caught between mournful grief and that smoldering, still burning hatred. They stole his words and left him with nothing else but hot tears, raspy sobs, and shallow breaths.

These were *burns*. Mydei had *burned to death*. His broken bones from the fall were healing faster than the regrowth of new skin, the damage was so severe. Strife's immortality had to consider the new map of Mydei's body carefully, stretching over exposed, red and gold musculature.

These were burns.

Phainon felt an anxious realization bubble low in his chest – a half-formed worry. Did he…?

The thought evaporated when Mydei gasped and coughed, spewing seawater across the stonework as he came back to life. For a second Mydei struggled against Phainon's hold but a moment of recognition turned resistance into relief and both of those strong arms wrapped tightly around whatever of Phainon they could reach. They held him close with tentative strength while he buried his face in Phainon's belly.

"*Titans*," Mydei wheezed, "you're alright."

He smiled and hiccupped in response.

Phainon's hands pulled at renewed flesh, grasped at Mydei's clothes, changing every other second. It wasn't enough. Phainon needed to hold all of him at once!

Mydei's hand on his chest put an end to that thought. Even shaky and weakened, he pushed Phainon back and reclaimed his autonomy to sit up with some help. Unwilling to let him go entirely just yet, Phainon kept a hand on his back, possessively covering Mydei's weak spot with his palm.

Mydei looked so tired still. Red patches on his body were still healing; the smell of burning flesh still lingered in the air beside the tart metallic bite of blood. He shook under Phainon's hand, a not-so-subtle quiver that betrayed his exhaustion. Not that Phainon couldn't see it in his eyes as Mydei studied his own hand for a few seconds before rubbing his face.

It was a relief to see, to remember Mydei's immortality, but still… Phainon didn't want to forget what Mydei looked like with saltwater trickling from his lips, skin melted down to bone, flesh bubbled and red. The longer Phainon studied the healing horrors still marring Mydei's body the more the tug in his chest pushed and pulled between a guilt he didn't quite understand and a vengeance he knew more intimately.

Hatred burned hotter than guilt.

Rage that had been sated was already rising again and the shadow of fearful grief was waning under the rekindled hatred in Phainon's heart. It beat along his veins, eager to *consume*, to be *bestial,* as Mydei had once invited him to be.

Give in to that primal desire, the purest form of Strife and fight with intent to kill.

Phainon pulled his hand away from Mydei to dig his fingers into his own thigh instead and shot a glance across the square.

She was hurt, even from a distance, that much was obvious. The way she half-limped, half-dragged herself. The way she reached across her body to hold tightly to her arm. The way she slouched and stumbled and sparkled gold in the dimming light. All of it spoke to her state of being.

Phainon's insides were coiling tight as he watched her scramble for the fountain and throw herself at the basin wall. She lingered there, slouched against the stonework, and slowly lifted her eyes to look at them with thinly veiled fury. How misleadingly frail she looked – this monster from under the bed – slumped with a long, bloody line carved down the length of her chest.

Here was the source of the creeping evil in this world. It was *her* song that stole from him a homeland, a *family*, and a future. *Her* will that destroyed the Grove and countless other city-states. *This creature's* borrowed ambition that destroyed the Sol and his comrades, that corrupted Eurypon and sent an infant Mydei to the Sea of Souls. The destruction of the Kremnoan people, the orphaning of Chironome, countless losses that haunted Phainon…

It was *her* fault that Mydei had died again with such abhorrent brutality.

"Deliverer?" Mydei called but that voice was so distant already.

The breath that Phainon sucked through his teeth tasted of salt and blood. He held it tightly for a long moment before letting it go. His heart still pounded in his ears and red was creeping into the corners of his vision.

"She did this to you," Phainon whispered low, dripping with vitriol and hate. Phainon's heart hardened and a growl caught in his throat.

Finally, he could see the true face of his demons.

Finally, he could end it.

He could be *free.*

Mydei grabbed his coat as Phainon got to his feet. He could feel the tug holding him back but his eyes were locked on the siren.

"Phainon!"

Phainon wasn't listening. All he could see was this perfectly presented opportunity.

Hysilens was beautiful and surreal. When she pulled herself over the fountain's edge it was with a sort of primordial grace that belonged only to ancient seas. Black hair as long as she was tall fell around her face and shoulders, contrasting with the paleness of her skin and the indigo of her scales. Her tattered dress with bits of shell and coral strung through the fabric flowed around her like fins when she rose again from the basin with the Coreflame of Law wrapped in her arms.

"Phainon, come back to me!" Mydei shouted. But before the echo of his call could fade away, Hysilens darted, and like a starving predator, Phainon launched himself after her.

The tearing of his coat slowed Phainon down when Mydei tried and failed to leash him. Off balance, Phainon stumbled and Hysilens took her lead, but he was quick to recover and the ache in his legs became a minor, ignorable inconvenience.

Even burdened by injury and the Coreflame held tightly to her chest, Hysilens moved with ethereal elegance more akin to swimming rather than running. She glided across the square with barely a pause, driven by the same inhuman endurance that pushed Phainon to ignore his own limitations.

He darted for his sword first and barely slowed down to retrieve it. The weight of the blade in his hand was a comfort in the same way Phainon imagined a wolf valued its teeth. And what better way to imagine himself as he hunted weakened prey with single-minded ferocity.

“Phainon, stop!”

How dare you ask that of me! Phainon thought in a snarl. *After everything she’s done to you!*

But he didn’t have the breath to waste on words. Mydei’s voice was already becoming an afterthought, an echo among the dead, no more than a ghost to shrug aside.

The tails of her dress were beaded, Phainon realized as he gained on her. The ornaments looked like bones crawling all the way up to where her dress stopped at her lower back. He could see the pale of sodden flesh when her hair swayed with a stumble on a fractured staircase at the far side of the square. She was hurrying into the city. Perhaps to hide. It wouldn’t matter. Blood still dripped from her body to spatter on the stones.

By the time Phainon had surged up the stairs himself, she had vanished from his sight. It bought her precious seconds as he paused to follow her bloody footprints with his eyes.

“Not like this!” Mydei snarled behind him, much closer now, and Phainon was suddenly very aware of the warrior at his back, keeping pace.

This voyage is so much bigger than all of us and I think I’m afra-

Phainon snarled away his own words in his head.

Hatred burned hotter than fear.

He surged forward, tracking the siren with urgent desperation. He needed this. They *all* needed this!

Mydei’s calls stayed on his tail, but they were easy to ignore as he raced between buildings and up a mountain path until he finally caught sight of her again on the mountainside. Hysilens stumbled on the paved road ahead. And then she disappeared through one of several archways into a dark, gaping maw in the cliffside.

Soon.

It was just below the turn in the path that Phainon, single-minded and itching to seize this victory, was brought low. A weight hurtled into his back and dragged him down the slope a

ways by a tight grip around his waist. He spun with Dawnmaker, but Mydei caught the blade with his gauntlet and held tightly.

Neither of them moved while they caught their breath, still bound in a tense clash while Phainon came back to himself. It took so much effort to will the tension in his arms to relax, to ease the pressure he was forcing through Dawnmaker's grip, and only then did Mydei let go to grab for him instead. The claws of shining gauntlets curled around the strap that crossed Phainon's chest, holding him still in conjunction with his wary gaze.

"Breathe," Mydei ordered and Phainon thought that was a ridiculous order at first. But then he shuddered and trembled through a breath too long held and every muscle in his body made itself known. Phainon was coiled so tightly he was visibly shaking. His jaw was clenched so tight his teeth hurt and the breath that stuck in his throat burned with salt and ash.

Mydei was struggling too. He panted softly with a subtle wheeze on every inhale. There were still patches of skin on his chest and arms that were red and raw. The image of Mydei broken and melting flashed fresh in Phainon's memory.

"She has to die," Phainon hissed and he did not recognize his own voice.

Mydei's brows were pinched with concern and Phainon felt like a bug pinned under glass, studied, analyzed, judged… but Mydei let go anyway. "For the right reasons, Phainon."

He laughed through a scoff, a single bark, and then turned his rage towards Mydei to snap, "*I have every reason."*

Phainon didn't wait for Mydei to respond; he stomped up the path, relieved that the pleas had stopped. And equally relieved that Mydei's footsteps still crunched behind him.

He'd understand later. Mydei would understand when this was all over, when Phainon was free of this darkness that chewed on his insides, had suffocated the fire that had been burning him from within. They could go back to being happy – a *real* happiness – when he was free.

When he could finally say those impossible words to himself.

Phainon stepped through the archway with more caution and control than before, sword at the ready, Mydei at his back. He blinked in the darkness until his eyes adjusted and the faint trickles of light that filtered from above and from the entry filled the shadows with definition.

The cave was not very deep, but it was surprisingly clean and well-kept. Circular in shape it was simple and refined with a tall ceiling and few features. Perhaps once an artist dreamed of filling the room with statues and accolades but the arches and pillars that lined the walls framed nothing at all. The only defining *anything* of note was a stone sarcophagus, plain, simple, and standing in the middle of the room with its lid askew.

Hysilens was there, surrounded by a neat pile of clean bones, immaculately arranged. She knelt among them with her back to the entryway and the glow of the coreflame held tightly to her chest. The light of it was a warm wash in a cold place, leaving streaks of gold on polished columns and catching on the blood soaked into the siren's dress.

Their shadows fell upon her, and she twisted in place enough to glare at them while tears streamed freely down her cheeks from pale blue and lavender eyes. Her claws tightened around the edges of the Coreflame of Law, held high enough to tuck under her chin; held tight enough to smear her blood across its holy surface.

Phainon's blood boiled at the display of desecration and his grip on Dawnmaker tightened until it hurt. He leaned forward to take a step but Mydei's hand on his shoulder stopped him. The light squeeze was grounding enough to clear some of the fog, enough to really *see* this woman waiting for them in a tomb.

Mydei stepped up beside him and Phainon heard him take a breath to speak but Hysilens' mouth curled in a knowing smile before the words could form. A golden glow was burning in her chest; rays of light filtered through translucent skin backlighting her ribs like a creature of the deep. The Coreflame of Ocean burned bright and Phainon's instincts howled.

He lunged past Mydei, raising Dawnmaker, but before he could finish his swing, the siren opened her mouth and began to sing.

Chapter End Notes

Yes, the chapter count went up again. I think it's the last time :')
I keep underestimating my ability to yap and I'd rather push that finish line back than deny you all a satisfying conclusion!

End Notes

Comments are how you water and feed your local ficwriters. If you enjoyed, please let me know!

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